

PINNACLE OF ELOQUENCE

A Commentary on *Nahj al-Balāghah*

Volume 2



Tahir Ridha Jaffer

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**Pinnacle of Eloquence – A Commentary on *Nahj al-Balāghah*
(Volume 2)**

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In the name of Allāh, the Omnibenevolent, the Merciful

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TRANSLITERATION TABLE

ء	ʾ	ط	ṭ
ا	a	ظ	ẓ
ب	b	ع	ʿ
ت	t	غ	gh
ث	th	ف	f
ج	j	ق	q
ح	ḥ	ك	k
خ	kh	ل	l
د	d	م	m
ذ	dh	ن	n
ر	r	و	w
ز	z	ي	y
س	s	ه	h
ش	sh	ة	h (or not transliterated)
ص	ṣ		
ض	ḍ		

Long Vowels

ا	ā
و	ū
ي	ī

Short Vowels

ـَ	a
ـُ	u
ـِ	i

(س) : ﷺ - Peace and blessings be upon him and his family

(ا) : ﷺ - Peace be upon him (or her, or them)

SERMON NUMBERING SEQUENCE

P	S	M	F	I
83	84	81	83	83
84	85	82	84	84
85	86	83	85	85
86	87	84	86	86
87	88	85	87	87
88	89	86	88	88
89	90	87	89	89
90	91	88	90	90
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94	95	92	94	94
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96	97	94	96	96
97	98	95	97	97
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100	101	98	100	100
101	102	99	101	101
102	103	100	102	102
103	104	101	103	103
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109	110	107	109	109
110	111	108	110	110

P	S	M	F	I
111	112	109	111	111
112	113	110	112	112
113	114	111	113	113
114	115	112	114	114
115	116	113	115	115
116	117	114	116	116
117	118	115	117	117
118	119	116	118	118
119	120	117	119	119
120	121	118	120	120
121	122	119	121	121
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123	123	120	123	123
124	124	120	124	124
125	125	121	125	125
126	126	122	126	126
127	127	123	127	127
128	128	124	128	128
129	129	125	129	129
130	130	126	130	130
131	131	127	131	131
132	132	128	132	132
133	133	129	133	133
134	134	130	134	134
135	135	131	135	135
136	136	132	136	136
137	137	133	137	137
138	138	134	138	138

P	S	M	F	I
139	139	135	139	139
140	140	136	140	140
141	141	137	141	141
142	142	138	142	142
143	143	139	143	143
144	144	140	144	144
145	145	141	145	145
146	146	142	146	146
147	147	143	147	147
148	148	144	148	148
149	149	145	149	149
150	150	146	150	150
151	151	147	151	151
152	152	148	152	152
153	153	149	152	153
154	154	150	153	154
155	155	151	154	155
156	156	152	155	156
157	157	153	156	158
158	158	154	157	159
159	159	155	158	160
160	160	156	159	161

P: Pinnacle of Eloquence (this work) **S:** Şubhī Şālīh edition **M:** Muḥammad ‘Abduh edition **F:** Fayḍ al-Islām edition **I:** Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd edition

COMMENTARY KEY

- R Quṭb al-Dīn Abū al-Ḥusayn Saʿīd ibn Hibatillāh al-Rāwandī (d. 573 AH), *Minhāj al-Barāʿah fī Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*
- I ʿIzz al-Dīn ʿAbd al-Ḥamīd ibn Hibatillāh ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd (d. 656 AH), *Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*
- M Kamāl al-Dīn Maytham ibn ʿAlī ibn Maytham al-Baḥrānī (d. 679/699 AH), *Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*
- MB Ḥabībullāh Muḥammad ibn Hāshim al-Mūsawī al-Khūʿī (d. 1324 AH), *Minhāj al-Barāʿah fī Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*
- Z Muḥammad Jawād ibn Maḥmūd Āl Mughniyah al-ʿĀmilī (d. 1400 AH), *Fī Ṣilāl Nahj al-Balāghah*
- T Muḥammad Taqī ibn Muḥammad Kāzīm al-Tustarī (d. 1415 AH), *Bahj al-Ṣabāgha fī Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*
- J Muḥammad Taqī Jaʿfarī al-Tabrizī (d. 1419 AH), *Tafsīr Nahj al-Balāghah*
- N Nāṣir ibn Muḥammad Karīm Makārim al-Shīrāzī (b. 1345 AH), *Nafaḥāt al-Wilāyah*
- S ʿAbdullāh Jawādī Āmulī (b. 1351 AH), *Salūnī Qabl an Tafqīdūnī*

REFERRING TO ‘AMR IBN AL-‘ĀS

- 1 How surprising that the son of the woman of disrepute has convinced the people of Syria that I am facetious and that I am a playful person, engaged in frolic and fun! He has uttered falsehood and spoke sinfully. Indeed, lying is the worst speech. When he speaks, he lies, when he promises, he reneges, when he is requested, he withholds stingily, and when he asks, he does so importunately. He betrays the pledge [he makes] and severs ties with his kin. When he participates in battle, what a bold chider and commander he is – [but only] as long as the swords have not taken action! Yet when that happens, his greatest ruse is to expose his private parts to the people! By Allāh, the remembrance of death prevents me from [idle] play, while forgetting the Hereafter prevents him from speaking the truth. He did not even swear allegiance to Mu‘āwiyah until he had stipulated that he should reward him for doing so, and grant him a paltry gift for forsaking the religion.

١ عَجَبًا لِابْنِ النَّابِغَةِ، يَزْعُمُ لِأَهْلِ
الشَّامِ أَنَّ فِيَّ دُعَابَةً، وَأَنِّي امْرُؤٌ
تَلْعَابَةٌ، أُعَافِسُ وَأُمَارِسُ! لَقَدْ
قَالَ بَاطِلًا وَنَطَقَ آثِمًا. أَمَا وَشَرُّ
الْقَوْلِ الْكَذِبُ؛ إِنَّهُ لَيَقُولُ
فَيَكْذِبُ، وَيَعِدُ فَيُخْلِفُ،
وَيَسْأَلُ فَيُخَلِّ، وَيَسْأَلُ فَيُلْحِفُ،
وَيُخُونُ الْعَهْدَ، وَيَقْطَعُ الْإِلَّ؛
فَإِذَا كَانَ عِنْدَ الْحَرْبِ فَأَيُّ
زَاجِرٍ وَآمِرٍ هُوَ، مَا لَمْ تَأْخُذِ
السُّيُوفُ مَا خَذَهَا! فَإِذَا كَانَ
ذَلِكَ، كَانَ أَكْبَرُ مَكِيدَتِهِ أَنَّ
يَمْنَحَ الْقَوْمَ سَبَبَةً! أَمَّا وَاللَّهِ إِنِّي
لَيَمْنَعُنِي مِنَ اللَّعِبِ ذِكْرُ
الْمَوْتِ، وَإِنَّهُ لَيَمْنَعُهُ مِنْ قَوْلِ
الْحَقِّ نَسْيَانُ الْآخِرَةِ؛ إِنَّهُ لَمْ
يُبَايِعْ مُعَاوِيَةَ حَتَّى شَرَطَ أَنْ
يُؤْتِيَهُ أُتِيَّةً، وَيَرْضَخَ لَهُ عَلَى
تَوَكُّلِ الدِّينِ رَضِيخَةً.

CONTEXT

In this oration, Imām ‘Alī speaks about the personality of ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ, the close companion and advisor of Mu‘āwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān. In fact, one might say that the only reason Mu‘āwiyah was able to come to power and keep his authority was the guile and cunning of this man. Even though this sermon comprises a short and summarized description of this character, the way in which the Imām describes him clearly shows that he was a dangerous man who was deluded, and misguided others. When we study history, we find that the nature of ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ has indeed been reflected completely and accurately in these words of the Imām. Amīr al-Mu‘minīn gave this sermon seemingly as a response to the claims made by ‘Amr that he was a foolish joker who lacked seriousness. This is what ‘Amr was telling the Syrians, in order to disparage the Imām and remove the awe and love for him that some had in their hearts. A number of scholars have narrated this sermon in their works before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, with slight variance. These include Ibn Qutaybah, Abū Ḥayyān, al-Bayhaqī, and others. Al-Shaykh al-Ṭūsī also narrates it from a different source in his *al-Amālī* (N). Based on some accounts, this oration was likely delivered in Kūfah.

COMMENTARY

1 The term ‘*Ibn al-Nābighah*’ literally means son of a woman of ill repute, or a woman who ‘shows’ herself. ‘Amr’s mother was called by this title because she was known for her loose morals and licentiousness, and was shamelessly open about it (M). It is said that in the month when ‘Amr was conceived, she had intercourse with five men: Abū Lahab ibn ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib, Umayyah ibn Khalaf, Hishām ibn al-Mughīrah, Abū Sufyān ibn Ḥarb, and al-‘Āṣ ibn Wā’il; and each of them claimed him as his son. She chose ‘Āṣ as the father because he supported her financially, although ‘Amr resembled Abū Sufyān more (I). The Imām addresses him by his mother’s title because it was the practice among Arabs to attribute one to his mother if she was known for being ignoble and vile, when they wanted to censure or rebuke that individual. They would also address them as their mothers’ sons when those women were known for nobility and virtue, in order to praise them (MB). The phrase ‘*yazūmu li Ahl al-Shām*’ literally means that he asserted to the Syrians. ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ had told the Syrians that Imām ‘Alī was a facetious and playful person, engaged in frolic and fun, after having thought long and hard for

something demeaning he could say about him that the people would believe. Since he was unable to come up with anything else, he made up this lie and claimed that ‘Alī (‘a) was not suited for the caliphate because he was always joking and making fun (Z). The terms ‘*du‘ābah*’ and ‘*til‘ābah*’ mean joking excessively and entertaining with vain talk, respectively (N). It is interesting to note that this criticism of the Imām was similar to one that was levelled against him many years earlier by ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb (I). Imām ‘Alī rejects this assertion as falsehood and outright lies. Then he proceeds to mention six vile qualities of this accursed individual: *when he speaks, he lies, when he promises, he reneges, when he is requested, he withholds stingily, and when he asks, he does so importunately. Furthermore, he betrays the pledge [he makes] and severs ties with his kin.* It is noteworthy that three of these traits are linked to dishonesty, namely lying, breaking promises, and betraying pledges. And indeed, when examining the life of ‘Amr ibn al-Āṣ, one finds him to be an entirely self-serving and deceitful character.

Interestingly, the Imām also highlights his selfishness and miserliness, as one who was persistent and importunate when he solicited something while being niggardly and tight-fisted when it came to giving others from his wealth. And these are qualities commonly found in people who have deep love for this material world (N). The phrase ‘*yaqta’ū al-ill*’ has been interpreted in two different ways. Some say that the term ‘*al-ill*’ refers to pacts or covenants, in which case it would mean *he cuts off his agreements*, and that is yet another attribute of dishonesty. However, it is more likely that the term refers to close relatives, and the phrase connotes severing ties with near of kin (MB). Imām ‘Alī then makes mention of ‘Amr’s cowardice, noting that he is only brave with his speech, in places where there is security and safety from any real danger. But once the actual battle starts and swords are struck, he would do anything to save his hide. The phrase ‘*mā lam ta’khudh al-suyūfu ma’ākhidhahā*’ means as long as the swords do not take their heads, or as long as they do not reap their harvest, and is a metaphor to describe the heat of battle wherein swords strike the necks and heads (I). Some have read the phrase passively and interpreted it to mean *as long as the swords are not unsheathed and raised by hands, ready to strike* (N). When this happens, the Imām says, then his only recourse is *to expose his private parts to the people*. This is a reference to how during the Battle of Ṣiffīn, at one point ‘Amr had come face to face with Imām ‘Alī, and just as the Imām was about to strike him, he denuded himself and exposed his private parts. As a result, Imām ‘Alī turned away and thus

‘Amr’s life was saved. The term ‘*sabbah*’ may refer specifically to the backside (I), or generally to the private parts (N). It is reported that one day ‘Amr came to Mu‘āwiyah and the latter saw him and started laughing. When he asked him what was funny, Mu‘āwiyah remarked, “I just recalled how you exposed yourself in battle when you came face to face with Ibn Abī Ṭālib. Lucky for you that he was a noble man, for if he wished he could still have killed you right there!” (T). In fact, poets later even composed verses describing the self-abasement and indignity of ‘Amr due to this action of his (Z).

Amīr al-Mu‘minīn then explains why he would never waste his time with idle play as alleged, and why ‘Amr made such a false claim: *remembrance of death prevents me from [idle] play, while forgetting the Hereafter prevents him from speaking the truth*. Finally, he again highlights ‘Amr’s love for this world by reminding his listeners how he had pledged to help Mu‘āwiyah rebel against the Imām and establish himself as the ruling authority in exchange for the governorship of Egypt, and in so doing, forsook his religion for *a paltry gift*. The term ‘*raḍīkhah*’ refers to a small gift or bestowal that is insignificant in value. Here it is meant metaphorically to show that what ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ had sought of this world was paltry in comparison to what he had given up of the Hereafter, both in terms of its short existence and its low worth (N).



DESCRIBING EIGHT ATTRIBUTES OF DIVINE MAJESTY

1 I bear witness that there is no god but Allāh, alone, without any partner. The First, with nothing before Him, and the Last, having no end. Thoughts cannot arrive at any of His attributes, and hearts cannot comprehend His nature. Dissection and division cannot apply to Him, and eyes and hearts cannot fathom Him.

١ وَأَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ وَحْدَهُ لَا شَرِيكَ لَهُ، الْأَوَّلُ لَا شَيْءَ قَبْلَهُ، وَالْآخِرُ لَا غَايَةَ لَهُ، لَا تَفْغُ الْأَوْهَامُ لَهُ عَلَى صِفَةٍ، وَلَا تُعْقِدُ الْقُلُوبُ مِنْهُ عَلَى كَيْفِيَّةٍ، وَلَا تَنَالُهُ التَّجَزِئَةُ وَالتَّبَعِيزُ، وَلَا تُحِيطُ بِهِ الْأَبْصَارُ وَالْقُلُوبُ.

AND FROM THE SAME SERMON

2 Pay heed, O servants of Allāh, to the beneficial lessons, and learn from the glaringly manifest signs. Be deterred by clear warnings and take advantage of reminders and counsels. Imagine that the claws of death have caught hold of you and the ties of hope have been severed from you. Hardships have suddenly descended crushingly upon you, and you are being driven towards the place where everyone is [eventually] led to. And every soul will come accompanied by a driver and a witness: a driver that leads it to the place of assembly [on the Day of Judgment], and a witness that testifies to its deeds.

ومنها

٢ فَاتَّعِظُوا، عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، بِالْعِبَرِ النَّوَافِعِ، وَاعْتَبِرُوا بِالْآيِ السَّوَاطِعِ، وَارْذَرُوا بِالنَّذْرِ الْبَوَالِغِ، وَاتَّقُوا بِالذِّكْرِ وَالْمَوَاعِظِ، فَكَأَنَّ قَدْ عَلَقَتْكُمْ مَخَالِبُ الْمَيِّتَةِ، وَانْقَطَعَتْ مِنْكُمْ عَلائِقُ الْأُمْنِيَّةِ، وَدَهَمَتْكُمْ مُفْطِعَاتُ الْأُمُورِ، وَالسَّيَاقَةُ إِلَى الْوَرْدِ الْمَوْزُودِ، فِي «كُلِّ نَفْسٍ مَعَهَا سَائِقٌ وَشَهِيدٌ»: سَائِقٌ يَسُوقُهَا إِلَى مَحْشَرِهَا، وَشَاهِدٌ يَشْهَدُ عَلَيْهَا بِعَمَلِهَا.

ON THE DESCRIPTION OF PARADISE

ومنها في صفة الجنة

- 3 Distinct levels, in terms of excellence, and diverse stations [exist in Paradise]. Its bounties never cease and its inhabitants never depart. The one who abides in it never grows old, and its residents are never in need.

٣ دَرَجَاتٌ مُتَفَاوِسَاتٌ، وَمَآزِلٌ مُتَّفَاوِسَاتٌ، لَا يَنْقَطِعُ نَعِيمُهَا، وَلَا يَظْعَنُ مُقِيمُهَا، وَلَا يَهْرَمُ خَالِدُهَا، وَلَا يَبْأَسُ سَاكِنُهَا.

CONTEXT

This sermon is an excerpt of a much longer oration, details of which are not available (MB). This is evinced from the usage of the term '*wa minhā*' (*and from it* i.e. from this sermon) which is employed by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Three main issues have been addressed in it. The first pertains to some of the Divine Attributes of Majesty and Beauty which the Imām has spoken of using short yet profound statements. The second aims to draw attention to the lesson-giving events in the lives of people, particularly the death which is witnessed by them. Finally, the third issue relates to the stations and stages of Paradise which will be enjoyed by the virtuous in the Hereafter (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes this oration as part of the sermon known as 'al-Gharrā' (no. 82), and if this is indeed the case, then the context of al-Khuṭbah al-Gharrā' would be the same as the context of this excerpt thereof.

COMMENTARY

1 As with numerous other orations, Amīr al-Mu'minīn starts this sermon by mentioning the beautiful qualities of Allāh. He mentions eight Divine Attributes beginning with His Oneness and lack of any compeer. Indeed, it is rationally impossible to have two infinitely omnipotent deities, and the Qur'ān itself also states this clearly when it says about the heavens and the earth: *Had there been [any] gods other than Allāh therein, they would surely both be ruined* (Q21:22). The repetition of this testimony has numerous benefits, and also carries rewards. A tradition from the Messenger of Allāh states, "Allāh the Almighty says: Whoever among you meets Me, testifying that there is no god but Me, and that Muḥammad

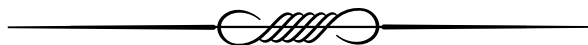
is My servant and Messenger, I will admit him into Paradise by My mercy," (T). The second attribute he mentions is that Allāh is *the First, with nothing before Him* meaning that He is pre-eternal and has no beginning, for if that were the case, He would have been preceded by non-being. This statement further proves His Oneness, because He is pre-eternal and infinite, and two beings cannot simultaneously have these qualities (N). Likewise, He is *the Last, having no end* which means there is no limit to His existence. These attributes have also been discussed in other sermons (such as no.s 95 and 100) as we shall see. The phrase *thoughts cannot arrive at any of His attributes* translates '*lā taqā'u al-awhāmu lahu 'alā ṣifāh*' which means that conjecture, imagination, and supposition cannot arrive at or settle upon any attribute of His. The reason for this inability is that the mind can only imagine form and matter, and can only fathom ideas that have delineable limits, whereas the attributes that are limitless are beyond human comprehension. Furthermore, Divine Attributes are not extra to Allāh's Essence such that they can be imagined or conjectured independently (MB). *Hearts cannot comprehend His nature* ('*kayfiyyah*') because He does not have any extrinsic quality constituting a 'nature' that might be ascribed to Him. Hence there is no '*kayfiyyah*', which is a limited and limiting concept, that can apply to Allāh and by which He may be known or comprehended (N). It is reported from Imām al-Ṣādiq that whoever tries to ponder upon the nature of Allāh is doomed (T). When the Imām says *dissection and division cannot apply to Him*, he is alluding to belief in Divine Simplicity and the fact that Allāh is not made up of parts, like other composite beings, and hence cannot be divided or dissected. Being divisible entails neediness since it makes the whole needy of its individual parts, and such a thing does not apply to Allāh (Z). Finally, the last two qualities he mentions are that Allāh can neither be fathomed by the eyes, nor the hearts. That is because *sights cannot encompass Him* (Q6:103), and the hearts are unable to grasp and comprehend His Essence (M). A question may arise here regarding the apparent contradiction between this statement and another statement of the Imām in sermon no. 178, wherein he said: *Eyes do not perceive Him by the witnessing of sight, but hearts perceive Him through the realities of faith*. We must keep in mind, however, that what is mentioned in this sermon pertains to the Divine Essence (*dhāt*), which can never be encompassed by the heart or mind of a human being. This is different from the general recognition of Allāh by the hearts through

conviction and faith, which is what the Imām speaks about in the other sermon. Hence there is no contradiction (N).

2 In the second section of this oration, Amīr al-Mu'minīn calls on the people to pay heed and take counsel from the valuable lessons, clear signs, manifest warnings, and reminders. The term '*al-ibar*', which is the plural of '*ibrah*', refers to admonitions or exhortations by which one takes warning or learns a lesson. It is thus named because through it one passes (*abara*) from ignorance to knowledge. Indeed, by studying history and examining past events one can derive some important lessons that may be beneficial in his own life. And the same is true for the *manifest signs* and *clear warnings* that can be witnessed around us in creation, and have been mentioned in the scriptures sent to humankind through divinely appointed Prophets. Numerous such warnings exist within the verses of the Glorious Qur'ān speaking of the fate of disbelieving nations whose obstinate defiance led to their ruin (N). The Imām then advises the people to *take advantage of reminders and counsels* which have reached them from the Noble Messenger as well as the reports of earlier Prophets (M), for the Qur'ān says: *Whatever We relate to you of the accounts of the Prophets are that by which We strengthen your heart, and in this there has come to you the truth and an advice and admonition for the faithful* (Q11:120). He then makes his listeners visualize a scene wherein they *imagine that the claws of death have caught hold of them and the ties of hope have been severed from them*. He likens death to a bird of prey in order to rouse their emotions and activate their imaginations, to evoke a stronger response and have a deeper impact on his audience (MB). The idea of hopes being severed by death is repeated often in the Imām's sermons, and simply reminds the people that when death comes, there will be no worldly ties that remain, and all their aspirations and ambitions will be cut short. He continues by telling them to imagine that *hardships have suddenly descended crushingly upon them and they are being driven towards the place where everyone is [eventually] led to*. The phrase '*al-wird al-mawrūd*', which is also mentioned in Q11:98, literally refers to a pathway to a waterhole for thirsty people and animals to access drinking water (N). The hardships being referred to here include the pangs of death that come suddenly upon one who is on the verge of dying, and the remorse and sadness of losing one's loved ones and possessions, which is very difficult to bear. Subsequently, after resurrection, everyone is driven to the place of assembly and accounting (Z). The Qur'ān states: *every soul will come accompanied by a driver and a witness* (Q50:21).

This will be the *driver that leads it to the place of assembly* on the Day of Judgment and a *witness that testifies to its deeds*. Some exegetes say that it does not necessarily mean there will be two beings; rather, it might be one angel who both drives the dead and acts as a witness to his actions (I). However, it is more likely from the apparent meaning that there will be two angels who will individually perform these respective tasks (N).

3 The final section of this sermon has a brief description of Paradise. The Imām says that Jannah has *distinct levels, in terms of excellence, and diverse stations*. Perhaps the reason he mentioned this was to motivate people to continue striving, for there is always room for improvement and progress. One must then continually strive to attain a higher degree of perfection and thereby deserve a loftier station in Paradise (N). This reality is reflected in a number of verses of the Qur’ān as well. For instance, we are told: *For each there are degrees according to what they have done, so that He may fully compensate them for their deeds, and they will not be wronged* (Q46:19). There are also many traditions which talk about the levels and stations of Paradise. One tradition states that there are a hundred levels in Jannah, with the distance between each level and the next being equivalent to the space between the sky and the earth. Its highest level is al-Firdaws... so if one seeks Paradise, he should seek al-Firdaws (MB). Imām ‘Alī then reminds the people that Paradise is a place where *bounties never cease*. Furthermore, *its inhabitants never depart* and are not compelled to leave it. So not only are its blessings perpetual, the residence of its inhabitants also continues forever (N). Since they do not age in Paradise, those who abide therein do not suffer from decrepitude that would cause them reduction in enjoyment of the bounties, as is witnessed in the life of this world. Some commentators say the phrase *never grows old* generally implies that they never face distress, and since old age is usually accompanied by difficulty, exhaustion, and distress, the inhabitants of Paradise never age (M). The phrase *its residents are never in need* translates ‘*lā yab’asu sākinuhā*’ which literally means that they never face wretchedness brought on by intense need and indigence (N).



ON DIVINE ATTRIBUTES AND ADMONITION TO THE PEOPLE

- 1 He knows all secrets and is aware of the innermost thoughts. He encompasses everything, subjugates all things, and has power over everything.
- ١ قَدْ عَلِمَ السَّرَائِرَ وَخَبَرَ الضَّمَائِرَ، لَهُ الْإِحَاطَةُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ، وَالْغَلَبَةُ لِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ، وَالْقُوَّةُ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ.

ADMONISHING THE PEOPLE

عظة الناس

- 2 Let he who would take action among you do so during his days of respite before death overtakes him, and in his spare time before he becomes pre-occupied, and while he can breathe easily before he gets suffocated. Let him prepare for his soul and his journey, and take provisions from the abode he will depart, for the abode of his [permanent] settlement.
- ٢ فَلْيَعْمَلِ الْعَامِلُ مِنْكُمْ فِي أَيَّامِ مَهْلِهِ قَبْلَ إِزْهَاقِ أَجَلِهِ، وَفِي فَرَغِهِ قَبْلَ أَوَانِ شُغْلِهِ، وَفِي مُتَنَفِّسِهِ قَبْلَ أَنْ يُؤْخَذَ بِكُظْمِهِ، وَلْيَمْتَهِدْ لِنَفْسِهِ وَقَدَمِهِ، وَلْيَتَرَوِّدْ مِنْ دَارِ طَعْنِهِ لِدَارِ إِقَامَتِهِ.

CONTEXT

This sermon begins with the mention of some Divine Attributes – specifically those attributes that would have a profound impact on the morals of any heedful individual. Subsequently, there is advice to the people regarding the transience of this world and the need to take provisions for the everlasting life of the Hereafter. It also contains advice regarding the importance of the Qur’ān as well as a warning to people against negligence and heedlessness. Finally, the Imām mentions some blameworthy traits that all believers should strive to eschew in their lives (N). The context of this sermon in terms of when or why it was delivered is not mentioned in the commentaries. However, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes its initial section as part of the sermon famously known as ‘al-Dībāj’ (no. 109), so the context mentioned for that sermon would apply to it as well. The later sections

are included by him as part of the sermon that Imām ‘Alī gave on the first Friday after he became the caliph (4:168).

COMMENTARY

1 This opening passage of the oration contains a reminder of some important attributes of Allāh. Imām ‘Alī reiterates what has been clearly stated in the Qur’ān (such as in Q6:3) when he says that Allāh *knows all secrets and is aware of the innermost thoughts* of His creatures. The term ‘*al-sarā’ir*’ is the plural of *sarīrah*, meaning a secret inner thought which is concealed from others (I). This is also the meaning of ‘*al-ḍamā’ir*’, which is considered to be its synonym (M), and likewise means hidden thoughts and feelings. The phrase ‘*ḵhabara al-ḍamā’ir*’ has been interpreted in two different ways. Either it refers to testing of the hearts by putting them through trials (I), or to the fact that He knows whatever is hidden in one’s innermost thoughts (MB). In fact, Allāh knows of what exists even before it comes into existence (Z), so He knows what we think even before we actually have that thought. *He encompasses everything* is actually a general statement after a specific one (*dhikr al-‘ām ba’d al-ḵhāṣ*), since it is preceded by mention of His all-encompassing knowledge (N). The term ‘*al-ghalabah*’ connotes something more than ‘*al-quwwah*’, and gives the meaning of overpowering and prevailing over the creation (M).

2 From the beginning of this pericope until the end of the oration, Imām ‘Alī offers advice to his listeners and admonishes them. It is said that this entire section of the oration is a restatement of one of the Noble Prophet’s famous sermons (I). He begins by reminding them of the limited time they have in this world, *before death overtakes* them. The word ‘*irhāq*’ literally means to cover up something, and it is used here because when death comes, it completely covers the existence of a person (N). Some commentators say that the term means making something difficult, and it is employed here because the arrival of death brings with it difficulty (T). So the opportunity to do good deeds is not to be missed, and one should act while he has time, *before he becomes preoccupied* with pressing matters or worldly hardships (MB). And he should do this *while he can breathe easily before he gets suffocated* by death and the distressing regret it brings (M). The Imām then advises the people to *take provisions from the abode one will depart for the abode of his permanent settlement*. The term ‘*qadamihī*’ which literally means his foot, and

3 Fear Allāh, O people, in what He has instructed you to preserve of His Book, and what He has entrusted to you of His rights. Verily Allāh, the Glorified, has not created you in vain, nor has He abandoned you to futility, nor has He left you to wander in ignorance and blindness. He has outlined what is expected of you and is aware of your actions. He has ordained your lifespans and sent down to you the Book as a clarification of all things. He made His Prophet live among you for a period of time, until He perfected for him and for you, through what He had revealed of His Book, the religion that He approved of, and clarified through him the loved and hated actions, and His prohibitions and commands. He left you no room for any excuse and completed His proof before you. He advanced His warning to you and cautioned you before [the befalling of] a severe punishment.

۳ قَالَ اللَّهُ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، فِيمَا اسْتَحْفَظَكُمْ مِنْ كِتَابِهِ وَاسْتَوْدَعَكُمْ مِنْ حُقُوقِهِ، فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سُبْحَانَهُ لَمْ يَخْلُقْكُمْ عَبَثًا، وَلَمْ يَتْرُكْكُمْ سُدىً، وَلَمْ يَدَعَكُمْ فِي جَهَالَةٍ وَلَا عَمَى، قَدْ سَمَى آثَارَكُمْ، وَعَلِمَ أَعْمَالَكُمْ، وَكَتَبَ أَجَالَكُمْ، وَأَنْزَلَ عَلَيْكُمْ الْكِتَابَ تِبْيَانًا لِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ، وَعَمَّرَ فِيكُمْ نَبِيَّهَ أَزْمَانًا، حَتَّى أَكْمَلَ لَهُ وَلَكُمْ فِيمَا أَنْزَلَ مِنْ كِتَابِهِ دِينَهُ الَّذِي رَضِيَ لِنَفْسِهِ، وَأَنْهَى إِلَيْكُمْ عَلَى لِسَانِهِ مَحَابَبَهُ مِنَ الْأَعْمَالِ، وَمَكَارِهِهَ وَنَوَاهِيهَ وَأَوَامِرَهُ، وَأَلْقَى إِلَيْكُمْ الْمُعْذِرَةَ، وَاتَّخَذَ عَلَيْكُمْ الْحُجَّةَ، وَقَدَّمَ إِلَيْكُمْ بِالْوَعِيدِ، وَأَنْذَرَكُمْ بَيْنَ يَدَيِ عَذَابٍ شَدِيدٍ.

has been translated here as *his journey*, could also refer to a place of honour one arrives at, or more generally one's future (N). Some versions read '*qudūmihi*' meaning his arrival (T), connoting one's arrival in his permanent abode in the Hereafter.

3 Imām 'Alī now seeks to warn his listeners by repeating *Allāh, Allāh* – meaning, fear Allāh, or be mindful of Allāh (N). Some commentators say the verb *ittaqū*, meaning *be mindful of*, has been elided, and that is why the noun *Allāh* has been repeated in lieu thereof (I). He cautions the people to be careful regarding the Book of Allāh, i.e. the Glorious Qur'an, which they have been instructed to preserve. Its preservation here refers to following its ordinances and acting upon

its teachings, not the mere memorization of its words (T). The rights (*huqūq*) being referred to are the prescriptions regarding what is permitted and forbidden (N). Alternatively, if the pronoun is understood as pointing to the Qurʾān itself, then it is the rights of the Qurʾān that is meant here (Z). As Allāh is All-wise, He does not do anything without a purpose. Thus His creation of human beings was not in vain; and since there is a specific purpose behind it, He neither abandons humankind without direction, nor leaves them *to wander in ignorance and blindness*. This reality is expressed clearly in the verses that state: *Did you think that We created you in vain, and that you would not be returned to Us?* (Q23:115), and: *Does the human being think he will be left without purpose?* (Q75:36).

The phrase *He has outlined what is expected of you* translates ‘*qad sammā āthāarakum*’, which has been interpreted in two different ways. The first is that He has clarified for you what actions are good and what are evil, and the second is He has elevated your stations through your obedience when you obey (I). The role of the Noble Prophet is then mentioned by Imām ‘Alī, when he reminds the people that Allāh allowed His Messenger to live among them *for a period of time*. He (ṣ) conveyed the message to the people and guided them for twenty-three years, in which time the Qurʾān was revealed and the prophetic *sunnah*, which contained many detailed rulings not expounded in the Qurʾān, was explicated (Z). This is what is meant when the Imām says that Allāh *clarified through him the loved and hated actions, and His prohibitions and commands*. The terms ‘*maḥābbahu*’ and ‘*makārihahu*’ respectively mean that which He loves and that which He dislikes (I). Thus, Allāh *completed His proof* for the people and perfected His religion, as stated in the verse: *This day have I perfected for you your religion, and completed My blessing on you, and approved Islam as your religion* (Q5:3). As such, no excuse was left for anyone to claim that they did not know the truth, or were unaware of right guidance (N). And because the Prophet had already warned them of the consequences of defiance and disbelief, they will have no justification by which they might save themselves from punishment in the Hereafter (MB). It is worthy of note that Allāh decreed His Prophet should remain alive and healthy until he was able to complete his mission and convey His message. This was despite numerous threats to his life from enemies, as well as the many battles he participated in – as many as three battles a year (J).

4 So make right the remainder of your days, and force your souls to be patient in that. For indeed, they are few when compared to the numerous days in which you would show negligence and disregard for admonition. Do not give your souls free rein as such allowances would lead you down the path of the oppressors, and do not flatter each other as such dishonesty will steer you towards sin.

٤ فَاسْتَدْرِكُوا بَقِيَّةَ أَيَّامِكُمْ، وَاصْبِرُوا
لَهَا أَنْفُسَكُمْ، فَإِنَّهَا قَلِيلٌ فِي كَثِيرِ
الْأَيَّامِ الَّتِي تَكُونُ مِنْكُمْ فِيهَا الْغَفْلَةُ
وَالْتَّشَاغُلُ عَنِ الْمَوْعِظَةِ؛ وَلَا
تُرْخَّصُوا لِأَنْفُسِكُمْ فَتَذْهَبَ بِكُمْ
الرُّخَصُ مَذَاهِبَ الظَّالِمَةِ، وَلَا
تُذَاهِنُوا فَيَهْجَمَ بِكُمْ الْإِذْهَانُ عَلَى
الْمَعْصِيَةِ.

5 O servants of Allāh, verily the foremost among the people in admonishing himself is most obedient to his Lord, while the one who deceives himself most is most disobedient to his Lord. Defrauded is he who cheats himself; enviable is he whose faith is secure; felicitous is he who takes lesson from [what befalls] others, and wretched is he who is beguiled by his desires and vanity. Know that even a little ostentation is [akin to] polytheism, and sitting in the company of those who follow their base desires leads to neglecting faith and bringing forth Satan.

٥ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، إِنَّ أَنْصَحَ النَّاسِ لِنَفْسِهِ
أَطْوَعُهُمْ لِرَبِّهِ، وَإِنَّ أَغْشَاهُمْ
لِنَفْسِهِ أَعْصَاهُمْ لِرَبِّهِ، وَالْمَغْبُوتُ
مَنْ غَبَنَ نَفْسَهُ، وَالْمَغْبُوتُ مَنْ
سَلِمَ لَهُ دِينُهُ، وَالسَّعِيدُ مَنْ وَعِظَ
بِغَيْرِهِ، وَالشَّقِيُّ مَنْ انْحَدَعَ لِهَوَاهُ
وَعُزُّورِهِ؛ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ يَسِيرَ
الرِّيَاءِ شِرْكٌ، وَمُجَالَسَةُ أَهْلِ
الْهَوَى مَسَاءَةٌ لِلْإِيمَانِ وَمَحْضَرَةٌ
لِلشَّيْطَانِ.

4 The meaning of his instruction *make right the remainder of your days* is that they should endeavour to rectify and make amends for their past misdeeds in the remaining time they have in this world, and they should force their souls to be patient and steadfast in doing so (MB). Imām ‘Alī then explains the reason for this, saying the days they have left *are few when compared to the numerous days in which they would show negligence and disregard for admonition*. Indeed, when one examines the hours and days of his life, and compares the time spent in negligence and heedlessness of one’s true goal and purpose with the time spent in awareness

and mindfulness, he would find the latter to be much less compared to the former. Furthermore, he uses the present continuous tense in the phrase '*takūnu minkun fihā al-ghaflah*', thereby alluding to the fact that their heedlessness is not restricted to the past, but is something that may continue in the future as well (N). Giving souls *free rein* (*tarakhīṣ*) means being soft or easy on oneself when it comes to doing what is forbidden. Disallowing such tolerance therefore signifies being cautious and exercising self-control in matters that are legally proscribed (MB). Not doing so, warns the Imām, will lead one to follow the *path of the oppressors* and to destruction, for one would be oppressing his own soul aside from wronging others. Some commentators have interpreted this phrase differently, perhaps due to the word '*madhāhib*'. They say that one is not permitted to follow any of the leaders of other creeds in their *ijtihād* when they have exercised leniency and tolerance in an aspect of the *sharī'ah* (I). However, this interpretation seems far-fetched here. Instead, it refers generally to the wrong paths that oppressors follow due to their giving in to base desires and allowing themselves to freely contravene the laws prescribed by Allāh (M). The concept of self-control is prominent in many teachings found within the ḥadīth corpus. One tradition from Imām Ja'far al-Ṣādiq states that whoever exercises self-control in the face of desire, fear, lust, anger, and elation, Allāh will make his body forbidden to the Fire (MB). Amīr al-Mu'minīn subsequently addresses the specific issue of flattery and sycophancy, saying that such acts of dishonesty *will steer you towards sin*. The phrase '*lā tudāhinū*' literally means do not deceitfully cajole people in order to get them to do what you want (T). Some commentators have interpreted flattery (*mudāhanah*) and insincere pretence (*riyā'*) to mean one and the same thing (Z). However, in this instance, it is more likely that the Imām is referring to being polite and kind with sinners, in an attempt to try and get along with them and remain in their good graces – such an action would inevitably lead one to sin. Alternatively, it may mean self-deception through excuses and false justifications, such as coming up with some convoluted legal validation for committing a sin. This kind of action eventually leads one towards sinning openly, and it is one of the means by which Satan misguides people (N).

5 The purpose of advice, when it is given sincerely, is to seek betterment or benefit for the one being counselled, and nothing can be better than the attainment of everlasting felicity. Yet this is something that cannot be attained save through obedience to Allāh. Hence, whoever is most obedient towards his

Lord advises and admonishes himself the most (M). Conversely, deception is the opposite of sincere advice as it entails displaying what is contrary to that which is hidden within, with the purpose of cause harm to the one being deceived. And since there is no harm greater than everlasting damnation and punishment, he who is most disobedient to his Lord is one who has deceived himself the most (MB). *Defrauded is he who cheats himself* means that when compared to being cheated by someone else, if a person actually cheats himself and causes loss to himself, then he is far worse off and more greatly defrauded (N). The Imām refers to one whose faith is secure as *enviable* (*‘al-maghbūt’*). The term *ghibṭah* means desiring a bounty or blessing that one sees in others, without wanting it to be taken away from them. It is a form of admiration mixed with envy, but without negative feelings. Indeed, the person who is able to adhere to his beliefs through the vicissitudes of life and the ups and downs he faces is praiseworthy and admired (N). He who takes lesson from what befalls others (*‘man wuīza bi ghayrihi’*) is felicitous. This means that one should learn from history and what transpired in the past. He should note the consequences of tyranny and thereby eschew it. He should reflect upon the outcome of piety and thereby seek it (M). Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī reminds his listeners that even the tiniest amount of showing off (*riyā’*) in religion is considered akin to polytheism. This is because one who shows off actually performs actions for the sake of people, seeking their acknowledgement and admiration, instead of doing it to please Allāh. Traditions tell us that on the Day of Judgment, the ostentatious one who did all his good deeds just to show people will be informed that all his deeds have been nullified and his reward has been cancelled; and he will be commanded to go and seek his reward from those for whom he had performed the actions (N). Finally, in this section, the Imām warns the people that keeping company with those who submit to their vain desires leads to *neglecting faith and bringing forth Satan*. The phrase *‘mansātun lil-īmān’* means that which causes faith to be forgotten and neglected, and the connotation of *faith*, here, is both belief and practice. *‘Maḥḍaratun lil-shayṭān’* means a place where Satan is present (I). This shows us how important it is to ensure that we keep good company and choose appropriate friends. Indeed, the Messenger of Allāh (ṣ) is reported to have said, “A man is upon the faith of his friend, so let each of you be careful about those whom he befriends,” (Z).

6 Shun dishonesty, for it is incongruous with faith. The truthful one is on the threshold of salvation and honour, while the liar is on the edge of an abyss and ignominy. Do not be jealous of each other because jealousy eats away faith just as fire consumes firewood. Do not bear malice towards each other because it shaves off blessings. And know that [false] aspiration diverts the mind and makes one forget the remembrance [of Allāh]. So give lie to [false] aspiration, for it is a deception, and he who holds it is deceived.

٦ جَانِبُوا الْكَذِبَ فَإِنَّهُ مُجَانِبٌ
لِلْإِيمَانِ، الصَّادِقُ عَلَى شَفَا مَنْجَاةٍ
وَكِرَامَةٍ، وَالْكَاذِبُ عَلَى شَرْفٍ
مَهْوَاةٍ وَمَهَانَةٍ؛ وَلَا تَحَاسَدُوا، فَإِنَّ
الْحَسَدَ يَأْكُلُ الْإِيمَانَ كَمَا تَأْكُلُ
النَّارُ الْحَطَبَ، وَلَا تَبَاغُضُوا فَإِنَّهَا
الْحَالِقَةُ؛ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ الْأَمَلَ يُسْهِي
الْعَقْلَ، وَيُنْسِي الذِّكْرَ، فَأَكْذِبُوا
الْأَمَلَ فَإِنَّهُ غُرُورٌ، وَصَاحِبُهُ مَغْرُورٌ.

6 Imām ‘Alī then turns his attention to some important ethical principles and teachings. He urges his audience to *shun dishonesty*, for it is far from and alien to faith. Not only is dishonesty and untruthfulness discordant with faith, it pushes one away from faith and thereby weakens his belief. That is because a liar usually utters falsehoods to obtain something he desires or for some personal benefit, whereas a true believer knows that everything is in the Hands of Allāh, and is aware that submission to base desires is actually a form of polytheism (N). Hence, *the truthful one is on the threshold of salvation and honour, while the liar is on the edge of an abyss and ignominy*. The honour brought about by honesty is experienced both in this world and the next (MB). The term ‘mahwāt’ refers to a place into which one falls, such as a pit or an abyss, whereas ‘mahānah’ means contemptibleness, vileness, and ignominy (I). Imām ‘Alī then warns the people of the negative effects of jealousy, noting that *jealousy eats away faith just as fire consumes firewood*. There are numerous traditions from the Noble Prophet (ﷺ) and the Imams of the Ahl al-Bayt that warn us about jealousy. In one report attributed to Imām Ja‘far al-Šādiq, he says that a jealous person harms himself first before he harms the one he is envious of, just like Iblīs who was cursed due to his jealousy of Ādam... (MB). His instruction *do not bear malice towards each other because it shaves off blessings* alludes to the fact that malice and hatred is usually mutual, since aversion is countered by aversion. The term ‘al-ḥāliqah’ is derived from ḥalq

which literally means to shave, and it is used here to show that malice removes blessings right from the roots, since the cornerstone of felicity is mutual understanding, compassion, and empathy among members of the society, and that cannot be attained without goodwill and affection (N). The final point he mentions pertains to aspirations and hopes, which, in and of themselves, are neither blameworthy nor praiseworthy. Rather, it must be seen what the consequences of those aspirations are on an individual in order to gauge whether they are positive or negative. So hoping for a long life with Godwariness and carrying out righteous actions is praiseworthy, while aspiring for a long life only to amass wealth and worldly gain is blameworthy. That is because the latter aspiration beguiles an individual and turns him away from thinking about his purpose in this world (Z). Hence the Imām tells us to *give lie to such false and worldly aspiration, for it is a deception, and he who holds it is deceived*. One of the ways by which these distracting aspirations can be countered is through frequent remembrance of death and contemplating what awaits one in the Hereafter. Countering aspirations in this manner is called *giving lie to it (takdhīb)* because when the mind seeks to attain what it aspires, it begins to imagine that it is within reach, but when one recognizes that death may come at any moment, that belies what was imagined by the mind (MB).



DESCRIBING THE QUALITIES OF THE GODWARY AND THE WICKED

1 Servants of Allāh, verily among the most beloved of Allāh's servants to Him is one whom Allāh has helped against his carnal soul, so he covers himself with inward sadness and outward fear. The lamp of guidance shines within his heart, and he has made generous preparations for the day that is to visit him. He regards for himself near what is distant and considers easy what is difficult. He sees and perceives, he remembers [Allāh] and increases [his good deeds]. He quenches his thirst with sweet, fresh water whose source has been made easy for him to reach, so he drinks to his satisfaction in the first draught and traverses the level path. He has divested himself of the garments of desires and abandoned all concerns except a single specific concern. He thus escapes from blindness and association with those who follow their base desires. [Instead,] he becomes one of the keys to the doors of guidance, and looks for the doors of perdition.

١ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، إِنَّ مِنْ أَحَبِّ عِبَادِ اللَّهِ إِلَيْهِ عَبْدًا أَعَانَهُ اللَّهُ عَلَى نَفْسِهِ، فَاسْتَشْعَرَ الْحُزْنَ وَتَجَلَّبَبَ الْخَوْفَ، فَزَهَرَ مِصْبَاحُ الْهُدَى فِي قَلْبِهِ، وَأَعَدَّ الْقِرَى لِيَوْمِهِ النَّازِلِ بِهِ، فَقَرَّبَ عَلَى نَفْسِهِ الْبَعِيدَ وَهَوَّنَ الشَّدِيدَ، نَظَرَ فَأَبْصَرَ، وَذَكَرَ فَاسْتَكْتَرَّ، وَارْتَوَى مِنْ عَذْبِ قُرَاتٍ سَهَّلَتْ لَهُ مَوَارِدَهُ، فَشَرِبَ نَهْلًا وَسَلَكَ سَبِيلًا جَدَدًا. قَدْ خَلَعَ سَرَابِيلَ الشَّهَوَاتِ، وَتَخَلَّى مِنَ الْهُمُومِ إِلَّا هَمًّا وَاحِدًا أَنْفَرَدَ بِهِ، فَخَرَجَ مِنْ صِفَّةِ الْعَمَى وَمُشَارَكَةِ أَهْلِ الْهَوَى، وَصَارَ مِنْ مَفَاتِيحِ أَبْوَابِ الْهُدَى، وَمَعَالِيقِ أَبْوَابِ الرَّدَى.

2 He has seen his way and is traversing his path. He has recognized his beacon and crossed his perilous seas. He has held fast to the firmest of handles and the strongest of ropes. He has thus attained conviction which is like the brightness of the sun. He has resolved to undertake, for Allāh, the Glorified, the most sublime of actions, including discharging all that comes upon him and tracing every branch to its root. [He is] a lamp in the darkness, a dispeller of dubieties, a key to matters obscure, an eliminator of problems, [and] a guide in the wilderness. When he speaks, he articulates clearly and when he remains silent, he stays safe [from error]. He is sincerely devoted to Allāh, so Allāh chooses him as His own. He thus becomes one of the repositories of His religion and the pegs of His earth. He has enjoined justice upon himself and the first stage in his justice is dismissing desires from his heart. He preaches the truth and acts according to it. There is no avenue for good that he has not strived for, and no place where it might be found that he has not gone towards. He has placed his reins in the hands of the Qurʾān, so it is his driver and leader. He halts wherever it unloads and settles wherever it encamps.

۲ قَدْ أَبْصَرَ طَرِيقَهُ وَسَلَكَ سَبِيلَهُ،
وَعَرَفَ مَنَارَهُ وَقَطَعَ غَمَارَهُ،
وَاسْتَمْسَكَ مِنَ الْعُرَى بِأَوْثَقِهَا،
وَمِنَ الْجِبَالِ بِأَمْتِنِهَا، فَهُوَ مِنَ
الْيَقِينِ عَلَى مِثْلِ ضَوْءِ الشَّمْسِ،
قَدْ نَصَبَ نَفْسَهُ لِلَّهِ سُجْدَانَةً فِي
أَرْفَعِ الْأُمُورِ، مِنْ إِضْدَارِ كُلِّ
وَارِدٍ عَلَيْهِ، وَتَضْيِيرِ كُلِّ فَرْعٍ
إِلَى أَضْلِهِ. مِصْبَاحٌ ظُلُمَاتٍ،
كَشَّافٌ عَشَوَاتٍ، مِفْتَاحٌ
مُبْهَمَاتٍ، دَفَّاعٌ مُعْضَلَاتٍ، ذَلِيلٌ
فَلَوَاتٍ، يَقُولُ فَيَنْفَعُهُمْ، وَيَسْكُتُ
فَيَسْلُمُ. قَدْ أَخْلَصَ لِلَّهِ
فَاشْتَخَلَصَهُ، فَهُوَ مِنْ مَعَادِنِ دِينِهِ
وَأَوْتَادِ أَرْضِهِ. قَدْ أَلَزَمَ نَفْسَهُ
الْعَدْلَ، فَكَانَ أَوَّلَ عَدْلِهِ نَفْيُ
الْهَوَى عَنْ نَفْسِهِ، يَصِفُ الْحَقَّ
وَيَعْمَلُ بِهِ، لَا يَدْعُ لِلْخَيْرِ غَايَةً
إِلَّا أَمَّهَا وَلَا مَظْنَّةً إِلَّا قَصَدَهَا،
قَدْ أَفَكَّنَ الْكِتَابَ مِنْ زِمَامِهِ
فَهُوَ قَائِدُهُ وَإِمَامُهُ، يُحُلُّ حَيْثُ
حَلَّ ثَقْلُهُ وَيَنْزِلُ حَيْثُ كَانَ
مَنْزِلُهُ.

CONTEXT

This sermon is one wherein Amīr al-Mu'minīn describes the qualities of pious, Godwary individuals, and those of wicked, immoral people. He also apprises his listeners of the status of the pure progeny of the Prophet and corrects some misconceptions. The last part of this sermon addresses a subject that is different from the rest of the oration. From this we can conclude that it was a much longer sermon and al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has left out portions thereof. Some later commentators attempted to locate and adduce some of these elided parts of the sermon in their works (I). The oration is found in other sources as well, and even some Sunnī scholars, like al-Zamakhsharī (in his *Rabīʿ al-Abrār*) have mentioned it, in part, with slight variance in wording. Such variance gives us an indication that his source for this sermon was different from *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes the first part of this oration as part of the sermon known as 'al-Gharrah' and the last section thereof as part of the sermon called 'al-Bayān'. This would mean that the above oration comprises parts of two distinct sermons that al-Sharīf al-Raḍī has brought together as a single oration. Some commentators note that what has been stated in this sermon forms the basis of many of the teachings co-opted by people who undertake spiritual wayfaring, since it mentions the traits and state of a perfect (*kāmil*) human (I). In fact, within this relatively short sermon, the Imām mentions about forty characteristics of such lofty individuals (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening section comprises the qualities of those individuals who are loved by Allāh. The first of these is the servant *whom Allāh has helped against his carnal soul, so he covers himself with inward sadness and outward fear*. This divine help comes in the form of an ability that is given to the mind of an individual by which he can overpower the base desires of his carnal soul (M). The term '*istash'ara*' literally means covering oneself with an inner garment (*shī'ār*), whereas '*tajalbaba*' means covering oneself with an outer garment (*jilbāb*). Hence, the derived meaning is that such a person, who is the beloved of Allāh, has sadness within his heart – a sadness that may be brought about by feelings of regret for his

lack of sufficient effort in the past in obeying or worshipping his Lord, and which now impels and motivates him to make up for those lost days. Likewise, his outward fear is what keeps him cautious and watchful of his actions, so he ensures he is not doing anything that might displease his Lord (N). Such a person has a *lamp of guidance* that *shines within his heart*, meaning that the divine teachings illuminate his heart, thereby guiding him and bringing him closer to Allāh (MB). He thus makes *generous preparations for the day that is to visit him*, preparing well by performing good deeds, for his death and his grave, just as one would prepare food for a visitor (Z). The term '*al-qirā*' refers to food that is prepared by a host for his guest. In the eyes of such a pious individual, what is deemed distant by most people is thought of as near, and what is considered difficult is taken as easy. That which is *distant* refers to the Day of Resurrection, as the Qur'ān states: *Indeed they see it to be [something] distant, but We see it near at hand* (Q70:6-7) (T). Some commentators have offered other possible interpretations, saying that it could refer to the mercy of Allāh, which is distant from the undeserving sinners but close to the pious and devout servants. Alternatively, it may be a reference to worldly aspirations, which are distant in terms of their lengthiness, but are shortened by the pious through remembrance of death (M).

As for the *difficult* which such a person considers easy, it could be the acts of worship that are difficult and require patience, but which are made easy to the devout as they have trained their souls and can taste the sweetness in such worship. Another possible meaning is that death, which is a difficult experience, is made easy for them through their numerous good deeds (MB). It could also mean that they face the hardships and travails of life with ease, because they consider them to be trivial and insignificant compared to the rewards they expect for their patience (M). The Godwary *sees and perceives, he remembers* Allāh and his own death, *and increases* his good deeds. His seeing with perception either refers to his ability to look at things deeply and arrive at the reality thereby (Z), or to his contemplation and reflection which leads him to gain insight (MB). The sweet, fresh water (*'adhbin furāt*) which is made accessible to such virtuous people, and with which they quench their thirst, is a metaphor for the religion of Islam and its *sharī'ah* (Z), or for the love of Allāh (I), or true knowledge that leads to a cognizance of realities (MB). It is this 'water' that *he drinks to his satisfaction in the first draught*, because its quality is such that a single draught thereof is sufficient to quench his thirst, and then he *traverses the level path* of moderation, knowledge,

and understanding (M). Having *divested himself of the garments of desires*, he abandons all concerns *except a single specific concern*, which is none other than Allāh, and how he can attain nearness to Him and gain His approval and pleasure.

The outcome of such sincere devotion is escape *from blindness* and from *association with those who follow their base desires*, since the knowledge one attains helps him exit the darkness of ignorance, and following the path of guidance keeps him away from those who are misguided by their vain desires (MB). As a result, he becomes one of *the keys to the doors of guidance, and locks for the doors of perdition*. Such individuals are the means by which others can be guided, and are thus deemed *keys* to the gateways of guidance, while at the same time acting as *locks* to the doorways of destruction and damnation. That is because they prevent people from transgression and sin, which would result in eternal punishment (M).

2 The Godway individual sees and recognizes the path that he has been instructed to follow, so he traverses it. The word '*manār*' was initially used to refer to a column or lamppost placed on the road as a sign to show the way, so that passers-by would not get lost. The *beacon* mentioned here, however, refers specifically to the leaders appointed by Allāh to guide people aright. So when a wayfarer recognizes them, and clings to them, he is protected from going astray (MB). The term '*ghimār*' is plural of *ghamrah*, which literally means a flood of people or water which causes congestion and is difficult to pass through (T). In this instance, the term refers to difficulties faced by an individual including calamities, sorrows, and disappointments that those who unsuccessfully seek this world endure. The pious one crosses those *perilous seas* unscathed since he has no inclination or attachment to this world (M). He has instead held fast to *the firmest of handles*, which the Qur'ān describes as complete submission to Allāh, and doing good (Q31:22), or repudiation of *tāghūt* and belief in Allāh (Q2:256). The *strongest of ropes* refers to the *thaqalayn*, i.e. the Qur'ān and the *'itrah* of the Noble Messenger (s) (T). As a result of following right guidance, such an individual attains a level of certitude and conviction which is as bright as the sun, since he knows the truth and acts upon it, so his actions are based on manifest proof which is as clear as day (Z). The result of this strong conviction then translates into deeds, and leads the Godway person to carry out the *most sublime of actions* for the sake of Allāh. *Discharging all that comes upon him* translates '*iṣḍāri kullī wāridin 'alayhi*' and refers to the ability to answer any question and tackle any issue that comes his way (N), or to guide any seeker of guidance who comes to him (I).

The act of *tracing every branch to its root* is a reference to *ijtihād* or striving to derive rulings of particulars from general precepts (MB). As such, the person becomes *a lamp in the darkness*, illuminating the way for others, *a dispeller of dubieties* through his removal of the veils of ignorance, *a key to matters obscure* as he clarifies ambiguities for the people, *an eliminator of problems* by doing away with that which hinders the proper understanding or implementation of religious rulings, and *a guide in the wilderness* which is so vast that many would lose their way therein were it not for his guidance. The Imām then continues describing this godly individual saying that his speech is articulate and clear, and his silence is a means of staying safe from error and sin. This means that both his speech and his silence have a purpose (N). His sincerity is accepted by Allāh, because all his actions were only for Him, without any inkling of ostentation. Consequently, Allāh gave him a special position among the people of the world. So he became *one of the repositories of His religion*, like a mine full of treasure that is excavated and from which precious gems are removed. He is likewise one of *the pegs of His earth*, like the vast mountains that keep the earth stable and prevent it from shaking, as he too prevents the believers from shaking in their conviction. That is the metaphorical meaning; however, if the Imām is describing his own noble self, and by extension his infallible progeny, then their being *pegs of His earth* could be understood literally, since were it not for their presence, the earth would not remain as it is (MB). Having *enjoined justice upon himself*, the first action that the God-fearing person undertakes is to dismiss desires from his heart. The fact that he focuses on his own soul first shows that justice must begin within oneself, through self-reformation (N). Some non-Shīʿī commentators note here that no human being, after the Messenger of Allāh (ṣ), had attained perfect justice except Imām ‘Alī (‘a) (I).

Since the individual who has *taqwā* adheres to justice, *he preaches the truth* but at the same time *acts according to it* himself. This is unlike many of the people who are quick to preach what is good even when they do not practice it themselves (T). Another quality of the Godwary is their love for virtue, which drives each of them forward, such that there is *no avenue for good that he has not strived for, and no place where it might be found that he has not gone towards*. The verb ‘*ammahā*’ means turns toward it and seeks it out, and ‘*mazannah*’ is a place where something one seeks is presumed to be (T). Some commentators have understood the above statement to mean that the Godwary person leaves no virtue incomplete, and does

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صفات الفساق

3 [On the other hand,] there is another who identifies himself as a scholar yet he is not one. He has garnered inanities from the ignorant and deviancies from the misguided. He has laid for the people snares made from the ropes of deception and false speech. He construes the Book according to his opinions and twists the truth according to his vain desires. He makes people feel safe from major sins and trivializes serious crimes. He says, "I stop when faced with doubts," yet he jumps into them, and he says, "I eschew innovations," yet he has made them his bedfellow. So his form is the form of a human, but his heart is that of a beast. He neither recognizes the door of guidance that he may follow, nor the door of misguidance to keep aloof from. Such an individual is but a corpse among the living.

٣ وَآخِرُ قَدْ تَسَمَّى عَالِمًا وَلَيْسَ بِهِ،
فَأَقْتَبَسَ جَهَائِلَ مِنْ جُهَالٍ وَأَصَالِيلَ
مِنْ ضَلَالٍ، وَنَصَبَ لِلنَّاسِ أَشْرَاكَ
مِنْ حَبَائِلِ عُرُورٍ وَقَوْلٍ زُورٍ، قَدْ
حَمَلَ الْكِتَابَ عَلَى آرَائِهِ وَعَظَفَ
الْحَقَّ عَلَى أَهْوَائِهِ، يُؤْمِنُ النَّاسُ مِنْ
الْعُظَائِمِ وَيَهْوُونَ كَبِيرَ الْجَرَائِمِ،
يَقُولُ: أَقِفْ عِنْدَ الشُّبُهَاتِ، وَفِيهَا
وَقَعٌ، وَيَقُولُ: أَعْتَزِلُ الْبِدْعَ، وَيَبْنِيهَا
اضْطَجَعَ؛ فَالضُّورَةُ صُورَةُ إِنْسَانٍ،
وَالْقَلْبُ قَلْبُ حَيَوَانٍ، لَا يَعْرِفُ بَابَ
الْهُدَى فَيَتَّبِعُهُ، وَلَا بَابَ الْعَمَى
فَيَصُدُّ عَنْهُ، وَذَلِكَ مَيِّتٌ الْأَحْيَاءِ.

not suffice with performing only part of it. Rather, he strives to continue doing the good until its completion, without leaving anything out. Even when it comes to something which is presumed to be virtuous, and wherein there is a chance of goodness, such a person turns his direction towards it and seeks to attain it (M). This pious individual places the reins of his life *in the hands of the Qur'an*, taking it to be his *driver and leader*. The statement *he halts wherever it unloads and settles wherever it encamps* emphasizes how closely he follows the teachings of the Qur'an. The analogy used here is that of a traveller who journeys and then disembarks and halts at certain points, which is quite apt given that the person follows the Qur'an on his journey towards Allāh, to the letter, without any

divergence (M). Some have suggested that the place where the Qurʾān *unloads* and *encamps* is the household of prophethood, at whose doorstep the Qurʾān was revealed. Therefore, it refers to the Messenger and his pure progeny (MB).

3 Having described the pious, Godfearing believer, the Imām now begins talking about the unrighteous, wicked individuals and their characteristics. Such people, says the Imām, are different from the Godwary. They include one who *identifies himself as a scholar yet he is not one*. This is similar to what was mentioned in sermon no. 17, where he (ʿa) said that those who only resemble people (‘*ashbāh al-nās*’) call such a person a scholar, even though he is not one. Indeed, from the earliest times certain unqualified people, who had not undergone the toil and training required, would embellish their achievements to present themselves as qualified scholars. Some commentators mention, as examples of such individuals, the likes of Mālik ibn Anas, Sufyān al-Thawrī, and Masrūq ibn al-Ajdaʿ (T). By employing the verb ‘*tasammā*’, in the active tense, the implication is that people who are aware do not deem such an individual to be learned; rather, he only makes this claim for himself and some lay, ignorant people parrot his claim and take him to be a scholar (N). The terms ‘*jahālīl*’ and ‘*aḍālīl*’ have been rendered *inaneities* and *deviances* respectively, with the former being a plural of *jahālah*, while the latter is a plural that has no singular form (I). Some commentators say that ‘*jahālīl*’ refers to compound ignorance, wherein the ignorant one is ignorant of his own ignorance. As such, the statement regarding his having *garnered inaneities*, or acquired ignorance, is figurative (M). The Imām then uses a beautiful analogy to depict how such a person misguides others, saying that he places for the people *snare made from the ropes of deception and false speech*. Like a hunter who lays traps to catch his quarry, placing grain on the ground to ensnare birds, or bait for other kinds of animals, and attracting them thereby, this kind of individual also uses various contrivances, such as *deception and false speech*, to attract and then misguide the people (N). *He construes the Book*, meaning the Glorious Qurʾān, *according to his opinions and twists the truth according to his vain desires*. There are many examples of this in history. One commentator mentions the example of the Ḥanafī scholar al-Karkhī who is reported to have said that the yardstick in matters of jurisprudence is the view of Abū Ḥanīfah, so if the text of the Qurʾān and Sunnah agrees with it, then it is fine, otherwise the text of the Qurʾān and Sunnah must be re-interpreted in light of the view of Abū Ḥanīfah! (Z). It is worth reminding ourselves here that the Noble Messenger (ṣ) said unequivocally, “Whoever

interprets the Qurʾān based on his own opinions should prepare [to find] his place in the Fire.” Yet it is notable how all the different sects in Islam, of which there are many, seek to prove the soundness of their views through the Qurʾān, which they interpret in line with their views (MB). The act of twisting the truth *according to his vain desires* means equating what is true to what is beneficial for him personally, and what he wishes and desires, instead of looking at it objectively to see what it truly signifies (Z). One of the ways in which he misguides others is by trivializing serious misdeeds and making people feel secure from major sins. In doing so, he attracts those who have a propensity to sin – and at times that constitutes the majority in a given society – since when they find that he supports their evil actions and opinions, they begin to follow and praise him (N).

This kind of corrupt individual tries to portray himself as rational and righteous, declaring that whenever he is faced with doubts, he halts and does not proceed. Yet in reality, he plunges into doubtful and dubious matters; for how can one who lacks knowledge even recognize doubtful matters (*‘shubuhāt’*) to begin with?! (I). *He says, “I eschew innovations,” yet he has made them his bedfellow.* It is the practice of fake scholars and phony sages to clutch at innovations and heresies in order to give their own agendas and desires a gown of religious sanction and even recommendation (N). The term *‘al-bida’* is plural of *bidʿah* which refers to innovation in religion, either by adding something extrinsic to it or by negating something that is part of it. The ignoramus claims to keep aloof from such innovation while he immerses himself in it (Z). Hence, in reality, such a corrupt individual has *the form of a human, but his heart is that of a beast*. Inasmuch as they cannot understand the reality of matters and can likewise not control their animalistic desires, they have been likened to beasts (M). Indeed, like animals, they neither recognize *the door of guidance* to follow, nor *the door of misguidance* to avoid. Some have glossed this as their inability to differentiate between the Ahl al-Bayt (ʿa) who are true guides, and those who oppose them; so they abandoned the Ahl al-Bayt and followed the path of their enemies (T). As a consequence, such a person is *but a corpse among the living*. Since the true meaning of being alive is a continuous state of seeking perfection and self-improvement, as well as the acquisition of merits that would lead one to eternal felicity, and because the ignorant one is bereft of this, his position is no different to that of a corpse (MB).

THE PROGENY OF THE PROPHET

عترة النبي

- 4 So *where* are you going? And *where* do you stray? The banners [of guidance] are raised, the signs are clear, and the lampposts have been erected, so to *where* are you being led astray? And how are you bewildered while your Prophet's progeny is among you? They are the torchbearers of right, the standards of faith, and the spokes-people of truth. So accord them the same good position that you accord to the Qur'ān, and come to them as thirsty camels approach the water hole.

٤ «فَإَيْنَ تَذْهَبُونَ؟ وَ«أَنْتَى تُؤْفَكُونَ»!
وَالْأَعْلَامُ قَائِمَةٌ، وَالْآيَاتُ وَاضِحَةٌ،
وَالْمَنَارُ مَنْصُوبَةٌ، فَإَيْنَ يَتَّاهِ بِكُمْ؟
وَكَيفَ تَعْمَهُونَ وَبَيْنَكُمْ عِترَةُ
نَبِيِّكُمْ؟ وَهُمْ أَرْزَاقُ الْحَقِّ، وَأَعْلَامُ
الدِّينِ، وَالسِّنَةُ الصَّدَقِ، فَأَنْزِلُوهُمْ
بِأَحْسَنِ مَنَازِلِ الْقُرْآنِ، وَرِدُّوهُمْ
وَرُودَ الْهَيْمِ الْعِطَاشِ.

4 In this section of the sermon, Amīr al-Mu'minīn instructs the people to follow those who are appointed to guide them towards the path of felicity. When he asks the question, quoting the verse of Sūrah al-Takwīr: *So where are you going?* (Q81:26), he means: which path can you follow that is clearer than the path of truth? According to a narration mentioned in *Tafsīr al-Qummī*, this question means: where are you going regarding 'Alī, meaning regarding his *wilāyah* – where do you flee to from it? (MB). For further emphasis, he also quotes the last part of a verse from Sūrah al-An'ām: *where do you stray?* (Q6:95), as a second rhetorical question. Indeed, there is no excuse for their straying since the *banners of guidance* have been raised, the signs have been made clear for all to see, and *the lampposts have been erected*. These three similitudes all signify the presence of Imāms in their midst, and since they are among the people and accessible by them, they have no excuse for not following their guidance (M). That is why the Imām again poses the question: *so to where are you being led astray?* The verb 'yutāh' comes from *tih* which means a wilderness in which one loses his way because there are no signs or landmarks by which he may be guided. The Imām is asking them why they are straying as though there is no means of guidance available, when it is clearly there before them, as bright as day (Z). Thus he says *how are you bewildered while your Prophet's progeny is among you?* By posing this question, Imām 'Alī is alluding to

the well-known statement of the Noble Prophet in which he said that he was leaving behind two weighty things (*thaqalayn*) that would act as the means of guidance for the people, as long as they held on to them together (M).

To further underscore the importance of the Ahl al-Bayt and remind the people of their status, he describes three of their qualities, namely that they are *the torchbearers of right, the standards of faith, and the spokespeople of truth*. The word ‘*azimmah*’ is plural of *zimām* which literally refers to a bridle or rope used to lead a mount, and it also connotes the means by which something subsists or is managed. In this instance, the phrase ‘*azimmat al-ḥaqq*’ means that they lead the truth and it follows wherever they go (N). ‘*Alsinat al-ṣidq*’ (lit. tongues of truth) has been rendered *spokespeople of truth*, and means that they are the truthful conveyors of what was revealed to the Messenger (ṣ), or that they speak only the truth and nothing else (M). After reminding the people of their status, the Imām tells them to accord the Ahl al-Bayt the same position of respect, honour, and obedience that they give to the Glorious Qurʾān (I). Some commentators have interpreted the phrase ‘*aḥsani manāzil*’ as the best of approaches, saying that the Qurʾān is approached differently by various people. Some take it to be a mere book, others only recite it orally, others recite and understand it, yet others recite, understand, and reflect deeply upon it, allowing its message to penetrate their hearts. It is this last approach which is the best approach. So what the Imām is saying here, according to this interpretation, is that they should likewise have the best approach when it comes to following the Ahl al-Bayt (M). He advises the people to *come to them as thirsty camels approach the water hole*, in order to take knowledge from them, since they are the wellspring of knowledge and wisdom (MB).

5 Imām ‘Alī then mentions a ḥadīth from the Noble Messenger (ṣ) which some commentators have deemed to be among the difficult traditions (*mushkilāt al-aḥādīth*) since it has some ambiguity surrounding its meaning (MB). The pronoun ‘it’ (*hā*) in the imperative *take this* (*‘khudhūhā*’), refers to the statement of the Prophet that follows (T), or to ‘the truth’ (N). Regarding the statement of the Prophet (ṣ) “*Verily when one from among us dies, he is not dead, and when his body disintegrates, he has not disintegrated*,” commentators have offered differing opinions. Some say that it could be interpreted in two possible ways. It could either mean that the Noble Messenger (ṣ), ‘Alī (‘a), and their pure progeny are alive with their bodies— the same bodies they had while they lived in the world, and Allāh

5 O people, take this [statement] from the Seal of the Prophets (ﷺ): “Verily when one from among us dies, he is not dead, and when his body disintegrates, he has not disintegrated.” So do not speak of what you know not, since most of the truth lies in what you deny. Absolve the one against whom you have no argument – and that is me. Did I not act among you upon the weightier guide, and will I not leave behind among you the lighter one? I raised the flag of faith among you and informed you of the limits of what is lawful and unlawful. I clothed you with security through my justice, spread out for you virtue with my speech and action, and demonstrated to you the most noble character traits from myself. So do not pass judgment about that which is beyond what the eye can see, and which the mind cannot fathom.

ه أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، خُذُوهَا عَنْ خَاتَمِ
النَّبِيِّينَ ﷺ: «إِنَّهُ يَمُوتُ مَنْ مَاتَ
مِنَّا وَلَيْسَ بِمَيِّتٍ، وَيَبْلَى مَنْ بَلِيَ مِنَّا
وَلَيْسَ بِبَالٍ»، فَلَا تَقُولُوا بِمَا لَا
تَعْرِفُونَ، فَإِنَّ أَكْثَرَ الْحَقِّ فِيمَا
تُنْكِرُونَ، وَاعْذِرُوا مَنْ لَا حُجَّةَ لَكُمْ
عَلَيْهِ - وَهُوَ أَنَا. أَلَمْ أَعْمَلْ فِيكُمْ
بِالْثَّقَلِ الْأَكْبَرِ وَأَثْرُكُ فِيكُمْ الثَّقَلِ
الْأَصْغَرِ؟ وَرَكَزْتُ فِيكُمْ رَايَةَ
الْإِيمَانِ، وَوَقَفْتُكُمْ عَلَى حُدُودِ
الْحَلَالِ وَالْحَرَامِ، وَأَلْبَسْتُكُمْ الْعَافِيَةَ
مِنْ عَذْلِي، وَفَرَشْتُكُمْ الْمَعْرُوفَ مِنْ
قَوْلِي وَفَعْلِي، وَأَرَيْتُكُمْ كَرَامَ
الْأَخْلَاقِ مِنْ نَفْسِي؛ فَلَا تَسْتَعْمِلُوا
الرَّأْيَ فِيمَا لَا يُدْرِكُ قَعْرَهُ الْبَصَرُ،
وَلَا تَتَغَلَّغُلْ إِلَيْهِ الْفِكْرُ.

has raised them to the heavens. If this were the meaning, it would entail the absence of their bodies from their graves. There is at least one tradition from the Prophet that alludes to this. However, the mention of disintegration makes this interpretation problematic, unless we say there is a word that has been elided here. If we take that word to be ‘shroud’, it would mean when the shroud covering his body disintegrates, it does not disintegrate. Since the shroud (*kafan*) which enwraps the dead body is considered to be like part of the corpse, it may be referred to in this manner. The second possible interpretation is that, as most theologians say, the living human being has a core which keeps him alive, and it is this core which constitutes the identity of the individual and makes him who he

is. So it is this core which is preserved and raised by Allāh; it is not the physical body which has been kept alive by Allāh. This is also the case when it comes to martyrs, about whom Allāh says: *Do not think that those who were slain in the way of Allāh are dead; rather they are living and provided for before their Lord* (Q3:169) (I). Other commentators interpret this statement metaphorically, saying that it means their teachings and legacy never dies, and lives on forever after them (N). As for disintegration of the body, there is plenty of evidence to suggest that some bodies remain fresh and undecayed in the grave, so for such a thing to happen to the chosen Infallibles is not hard to fathom. And this is also supported by a number of traditions in our ḥadīth corpus (MB). While there is a lot more that can be said on this subject, such a detailed discussion is, however, beyond the scope of this commentary.

Imām ‘Alī warns the people not to speak about what they do not know, *since most of the truth lies in what you deny*. This is an allusion to how human beings often reject that which they do not know or cannot comprehend. This has been seen throughout history, from the early days when people rejected the notion that the earth is a sphere, insisting it was flat, to more recent times when it was thought that man would never be able to set foot on the moon (Z). In the present context, mentioning this after saying that the friends (*awliyā’*) of Allāh are alive even after their death, means to remind the people that their knowledge is very limited and they should not deny that which they have no understanding of, for most of the truth lies beyond what they know (N). Since they had no valid proof or argument against him, the Imām tells them to consider him free of guilt, for he had carried out his responsibility towards them with justice, following the path laid down by the Noble Prophet. Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī goes on to explain how he had conducted himself to further clarify that he had done his duty. He says that he had acted *upon the weightier guide*, meaning the Qur’ān, and will leave behind among them *the lighter one*, meaning his two sons, al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn, for they were the remaining members of the blessed *‘itrah* of the Noble Prophet (I). He *raised the flag of faith* among the people – and the similitude of a flag is quite apt here since a raised flag helps to guide people on the path, thus did the Imām guide people in matters of religion, informing them of the details regarding *what is lawful and unlawful* (MB). When he says *I clothed you with security through my justice*, the Imām is referring to how he kept them secure from the harm of oppressors and tyrants. The term *‘al-āfiyah’* in the phrase *‘albastukum al-āfiyah’* refers to safety

ON MISCONCEPTION

ومنها: في الظن الخاطئ

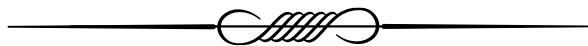
6 Until one would assume that the whole world is tied up in the hands of the Banī Umayyah, as it grants them its boons and leads them to its clear springs, and that their whip and sword will never be removed from this *ummah*. Whoever thinks this is mistaken. Rather, these are only a few drops from the pleasures of life which they will taste for a while before spitting it all out.

٦ حَتَّى يَظُنَّ الظَّانُّ أَنَّ الدُّنْيَا
مَعْقُولَةٌ عَلَى بَنِي أُمَيَّةَ، تَمْنَحُهُمْ
دَرَّهًا وَتُورِدُهُمْ صَفْوَهَا، وَلَا
يُزْفَعُ عَنْ هَذِهِ الْأُمَّةِ سَوْطُهَا وَلَا
سَيْفُهَا، وَكَذَبَ الظَّانُّ لِذَلِكَ؛
بَلْ هِيَ مَجَّةٌ مِنْ لَذِيذِ الْعَيْشِ
يَتَطَعَّمُونَهَا بُزْهَةً، ثُمَّ يَلْفِظُونَهَا
جُمْلَةً.

and security (M). Indeed, the justice of Imām ‘Alī is well-known, and many historical accounts depict how under his rule, everyone, including the weak, were given their rights (N). Furthermore, he *spread out for the people virtue, with his speech and action, and demonstrated to them the most noble character traits*, such as patience, without malice or hatred, and doing everything solely to please Allāh (Z). The term ‘*farashtukum*’ comes from *farasha* which means to spread out, lay the groundwork, and facilitate. Here it means that he facilitated and laid the groundwork for virtue through his words and deeds (I). In concluding this section, Amīr al-Mu’minīn once again advises the people not to pass judgment about *that which is beyond what the eye can see, and which the mind cannot fathom*, meaning about the lofty status of the Ahl al-Bayt, which is something decreed by Allāh through His wisdom (N).

6 Given that this section is unrelated to what precedes it, some commentators say that al-Sharīf al-Raḍī has left out a portion of this otherwise lengthy sermon, and they have adduced some of the removed portions thereof from other sources (I). The Imām describes how the rule of the Umayyads will extend, and their oppression will become pervasive, leaving people with nowhere to turn, until it will be assumed that the whole world is in their grasp (MB). The similitude he then uses is that of a camel which is tied up in its pen (‘*ma’qūlah*’), giving them its fresh milk (‘*darrahā*’), and leading them to the clear springs of water from which it

drinks (*‘safwahā’*) (M). One who saw how lavishly the Banī Umayyah were living, and how much opulence they enjoyed, would get a feeling that they controlled the whole world. At the same time, their continuous unhindered tyranny and oppression would lead the person to assume that *their whip and sword will never be removed from this ummah*. However, Imām ‘Alī states that this assumption is false, and *whoever thinks this is mistaken* (*‘kadhāba al-ẓānnu li-dhālik’*); this is a prophecy for the future based on the knowledge that had been shared with him by the Noble Messenger. Indeed, the Umayyads’ rule was ended by the ‘Abbāsids, and they were brutally overthrown (Z). This was only, according to the Imām, *a few drops from the pleasures of life which they will taste for a while before spitting it all out*. The term *‘majjah’* is derived from *majj*, which literally connotes spitting out saliva, and the related term *mujāj* refers to the spittle that is cast out of one’s mouth. Honey is sometimes called *mujāj al-naḥl* (lit. spittle of the bee), and the juice of a fruit, like grapes, is also called *mujāj* or *mujājah*. In this instance, use of this term signifies something short-lived, like someone who puts something delicious inside his mouth, but is unable to swallow it and has to spit it out (N). There are many examples of the extravagance of the Umayyads that have been reported. In one instance, we are told that ‘Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān had a garment woven for his daughter Fāṭimah, the wife of ‘Umar ibn ‘Abd al-‘Azīz, with pure gold thread and inlaid pearls and rubies, at the cost of a hundred thousand gold dīnārs. Yet despite their abundant wealth, the Umayyads ruled for no more than a thousand months before they were overthrown (T).



ON WHY PEOPLE ARE RUINED

1 Now then, verily Allāh never destroyed the tyrants of any generation except after respite and ease, and He did not mend the [broken] bone of any nation except after hardship and trial. In things lesser than the distress you have faced and the grave matters you have already encountered, there is a lesson [to be learnt]! Yet not every individual who possesses a heart is intelligent, nor does every person with ears listen, nor is every possessor of eyesight observant.

١ أَمَّا بَعْدُ، فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ لَمْ يَفْصَحْ
جَبَّارِي دَهْرٍ قَطُّ إِلَّا بَعْدَ تَمْهِيلٍ
وَرَحَاءٍ، وَلَمْ يَجْبُرْ عَظْمَ أَحَدٍ
مِنَ الْأُمَمِ إِلَّا بَعْدَ أَرْلٍ وَبَلَاءٍ،
وَفِي دُونِ مَا اسْتَقْبَلْتُمْ مِنْ عَذَابٍ
وَمَا اسْتَدْبَرْتُمْ مِنْ خَطْبٍ مُعْتَبِرٍ!
وَمَا كُلُّ ذِي قَلْبٍ بَلِيصٍ، وَلَا
كُلُّ ذِي سَمْعٍ بَسْمِيعٍ، وَلَا كُلُّ
ذِي نَاطِرٍ بَبَصِيرٍ.

CONTEXT

This sermon has been reported by al-Kulaynī in the last volume of *al-Kāfi*, and by al-Shaykh al-Mufid in his *Kitāb al-Irshād*, albeit with slight variation in wording. Some of its phrases have also been discussed by Ibn Athīr in his *al-Nihāyah fī Gharīb al-Ḥadīth wal-Athar*. Al-Kulaynī relates it through a chain from Imām al-Ṣādiq, who said that Amīr al-Mu'minīn gave this sermon in Madīnah (T). Of the two sections that make up this oration, the first addresses the nature of divine punishment, and how it does not come down immediately. Rather, Allāh gives time to the wrongdoers to mend their ways and repent for their sins. The second section talks about the misguided people who seek to solve their religious differences by resorting to their own opinions rather than turning to what has been revealed by Allāh through His Prophet (N). Some commentators say that the whole purpose of this speech was to censure the people for espousing different religious opinions and turning away from the guidance of the Imām (MB). The

author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this sermon as part of a longer oration known as ‘al-Ṭālūtiyyah’ (2:426).

COMMENTARY

1 From its opening phrases, we can deduce the goal behind this oration. Clearly, Imām ‘Alī spoke these words to rebuke the people for depending on their own flawed logic and judgement instead of referring to him. They did this because they were too proud to learn from him and benefit from his presence (M). The Imām begins by pointing out to them that it is the wont (*sunnah*) of Allāh not to crush tyrants of any era except after a long respite and an abundant share of fortune. This is clearly seen from what happened to the past generations and peoples (MB). The verb ‘*yaqṣim*’ is derived from *qaṣm*, which literally means to crush or smash with force, and here it is a metaphor for destruction and annihilation (N). The tyrants of any age or generation (‘*jabbārī dahrin*’) are those who wage campaigns against humanity and plot against any stance for freedom by the people (Z). Allāh grants them respite and ease (‘*tamhīl wa rakhā*’) before seizing them with punishment. The Qur’ān describes this beautifully when it states: *But when they neglected what they had been admonished, We opened for them the gates of all [good] things. When they rejoiced in what they were given, We seized them suddenly, whereat they were in utter despair* (Q6:44) (T). The Imām said this in order to warn his audience against becoming heedless in the comfort they enjoyed, so that they do not end up suffering the same fate as the evildoers before them (MB). Just as respite precedes divine punishment, divine aid also comes after a period of anguish and trial. The metaphor used for this is that of mending broken bones, which we know takes time. Some commentators say that the hardship and trial that people have to go through refers to the sacrifices they must make and the pain they must endure in order to attain freedom from the yoke of tyrants (Z).

Amīr al-Mu’minīn then tells the people that there is a lesson for them even in those things that are lesser than the distress they have faced and the grave matters they have already encountered. The phrase ‘*fi dūni ma...*’ has been interpreted as by some to mean ‘in the least of...’ (T), and by others to mean ‘in that which...’ (N). Our translation is based on the former interpretation, but if the latter is taken, then the translation would read: *in that which you have faced of distress, and the grave matters you have already encountered, there is a lesson*. The term ‘*atb*’ literally

2 How surprising! And why would I not be surprised by the error of these factions with their varying arguments in their religion! They neither follow the footsteps of a Prophet, nor do they emulate the actions of a Legatee. Neither do they believe in the unseen nor do they abstain from vices. They act upon the dubious and tread in vain desires. For them, good is whatever they consider admirable and evil is whatever they consider detestable. In difficulties, their recourse is to themselves and in obscure matters, they rely on their own opinions; as if each one of them is his own leader, having taken hold of what he considers, in his opinion, to be firm handles and strong cords.

فَيَا عَجَبًا! وَمَا لِي لَا أَعْجَبُ مِنْ
خَطَا هَذِهِ الْفِرَقِ عَلَى اخْتِلَافِ
حُجَجِهَا فِي دِينِهَا! لَا يَقْتَضُونَ أَثَرَ
نَبِيِّ وَلَا يَقْتَدُونَ بِعَمَلِ وَصِيِّ، وَلَا
يُؤْمِنُونَ بِغَيْبٍ، وَلَا يَعْقُونَ عَنْ
غَيْبٍ، يَعْمَلُونَ فِي الشُّبُهَاتِ،
وَيَسِيرُونَ فِي الشَّهَوَاتِ، الْمَعْرُوفُ
فِيهِمْ مَا عَرَفُوا، وَالْمُنْكَرُ عِنْدَهُمْ مَا
أَنْكَرُوا، مَفْرَعُهُمْ فِي الْمَعْضَلَاتِ
إِلَى أَنْفُسِهِمْ، وَتَعْوِيلُهُمْ فِي
الْمُبْهَمَاتِ عَلَى آرَائِهِمْ، كَأَنَّ كُلَّ
امْرِئٍ مِنْهُمْ إِمَامٌ نَفْسِهِ، قَدْ أَخَذَ
مِنْهَا فِيمَا يَرَى بِعُرَى ثِقَاتٍ
وَأَشْبَابٍ مُحْكَمَاتٍ.

refers to an internal feeling of distress and unease, and it is this meaning which is intended here (N). Some commentators say that if the word is read as “*atb*’ then it means censure and displeasure, and refers to the Imām’s reproof of them for their differing opinions and stances. However, if it is read as “*atab*’ (with a *fathah* on the *tā*’), then it refers to the difficulties and distress that befell them from their enemies (MB). In any case, the Imām is asking them to take a lesson from their past, for indeed they ought to learn from even the smaller things they underwent and faced. This instruction is universal and just as applicable today as it was at that time (Z). At the end of this section, the Imām encourages the people to employ their faculties of intellection, contemplation, and reflection, thereby alluding to how those factions who opposed him do not follow reason (R). That is because *not every individual who possesses a heart is intelligent, nor does every person with ears listen, nor is every possessor of eyesight observant*. The ears and eyes are particularly

mentioned after intelligence because it is through listening and observation that one can learn about what has transpired, and then he can use his intellect to derive lessons therefrom (MB).

2 This section begins by the Imām's expression of amazement at how different groups had deviated from the right path, and provided various arguments as proofs and justification for their erroneous beliefs. His statement *and why would I not be surprised* is meant to present his explanation regarding his amazement in the form of a response to a possible question one might pose about his dismay (M). It is evident that during the time of Amīr al-Mu'minīn, cracks had begun to show within the *ummah* in the form of different religious factions and sects. Their differences ranged from matters regarding theological principles to religious praxis. And because the Muslim empire had expanded greatly, these differences abounded in various locations (N). After criticizing them for differing in this way, Imām 'Alī mentions the causes of these differences, stating firstly that it is the result of not following the teachings of the Noble Prophet and his appointed vicegerent. The outcome of their abandoning these teachings was catastrophic for Muslims, as history attests (T). Indeed, if the Muslims had followed the guidance of Rasūlullāh, they would not differ among themselves thus, for the Prophet brought a single *sharī'ah*, and came with a single revelation. The legatee ('*waṣī*') of the Noble Messenger was the one whom he appointed to lead the people after him, namely Imām 'Alī ('*a*'). Had they followed him, they would have followed the way of the Prophet himself (MB). The second cause of their division was not believing in the unseen ('*ghayb*'). By *the unseen* all that cannot be perceived by the senses is meant, but in this context, it likely refers specifically to the resurrection, the Hereafter, and the rewards and punishments therein (T). The third cause of their splitting up into different religious sects, the Imām says, is that they do not *abstain from vices*. The word "*ayb*" literally means fault or defect, and the verb '*ya'uffūna*' comes from '*affa*' which refers to abstaining from something out of modesty and chastity. One who possesses the quality of '*iffah*' therefore abstains from any action that is deemed to be a fault, or is blameworthy. Those who keep aloof from vices in this manner are prevented from obstinately holding on to their wrong ideas and opinions, which would otherwise result in differences among the people (MB).

Others who lack this quality, however, *act upon the dubious* ('*al-shubuhāt*') and *tread in vain desires* and passions ('*al-shahawāt*'). This means that they neither halt when faced with any doubt, to search for the truth regarding it, nor do they eschew

sensual and base desires, opting instead to immerse themselves in them. Given that the verbs used for these actions have the present-continuous tense, the implication is that they continuously act on what is doubtful (in terms of its lawfulness), and engross themselves in vain desires (N). As a consequence, in their eyes *good is whatever they consider admirable and evil is whatever they consider detestable*. This means that they judge an action to be virtuous or evil in accordance with their personal inclinations and whims. Whatever they like is taken to be good, and whatever they dislike is taken to be evil (M). In difficult and obscure matters, they rely solely on their own understanding and opinion, since they deem that to be the yardstick of truth (Z). It is *as if each one of them is his own leader* ('*imām*'), so he needs no evidence other than his own opinion and judgment, which he falsely considers to be a firm handle and a strong cord to hold. This is the outcome of those who abandon the clear guidance of Allāh and resort instead to their own limited understanding of matters. Indeed, many a deviant sect has come about due to this (N).



REGARDING THE NOBLE PROPHET (S)

1 He sent him during the period after an interval in the sequence of Messengers and a lengthy slumber among the nations. [It was a time of] proliferation of vices, unsettling affairs, and fiery wars, as the world was devoid of light and filled with deceit. Its leaves had turned yellow and there was no expectation of its fruits, as its water had sunk into the earth. The beacons of guidance had been obliterated and signposts of destruction had appeared. Thus it glowered at its people and frowned in the face of its seeker. Its fruit was discord and its food was carrion; its inner garb was fear and outer covering was the sword.

١ أَرْسَلَهُ عَلَى حِينِ فِتْرَةٍ مِنَ الرُّسُلِ،
وَطُولِ هَجْعَةٍ مِنَ الْأُمَمِ، وَاعْتِرَافِ
مِنَ الْفِتَنِ، وَانْتِشَارِ مِنَ الْأُمُورِ،
وَتَلَطُّ مِنَ الْحُرُوبِ، وَالذُّنُوبِ كَاسِفَةً
النُّورِ ظَاهِرَةً الْغُرُورِ، عَلَى حِينِ
اصْفَرَارٍ مِنْ وَرَقِهَا، وَإِيَّاسٍ مِنْ
ثَمَرِهَا، وَاغْوَارٍ مِنْ مَائِهَا؛ قَدْ
دَرَسَتْ مَنَارُ الْهُدَى وَظَهَرَتْ أَغْلَامُ
الرَّدَى، فَهِيَ مُتَجَهِّمَةٌ لِأَهْلِهَا عَابِسَةٌ
فِي وَجْهِ طَالِيهَا، ثَمَرُهَا الْفِتْنَةُ،
وَطَعَامُهَا الْجِيفَةُ، وَشِعَارُهَا الْخَوْفُ،
وَدِثَارُهَا السَّيْفُ.

2 So take heed, O servants of Allāh, and recall those [beliefs and actions] by which your fathers and brothers are held hostage, and for which they have to account. By my life, not much time separates you from them, nor have lengthy periods or centuries lapsed between you and them; you are not so far today from the day when you were in their loins.

٢ فَاعْتَبِرُوا عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، وَادْكُرُوا تِيكَ
الَّتِي آبَاؤُكُمْ وَإِخْوَانُكُمْ بِهَا
مُرْتَهَنُونَ، وَعَلَيْهَا مُحَاسَبُونَ.
وَلَعُمْرِي مَا تَقَادَمَتْ بِكُمْ وَلَا بِهِمْ
الْعُمُودُ، وَلَا خَلَتْ فِيمَا بَيْنَكُمْ
وَبَيْنَهُمُ الْأَحْقَابُ وَالْقُرُونُ، وَمَا أَنْتُمْ
الْيَوْمَ مِنْ يَوْمٍ كُنْتُمْ فِي أَصْلَابِهِمْ
بَبَعِيدٍ.

3 By Allāh, there is nothing that the Prophet told them but that I am here telling you the very same thing, and the ears you hear with today are no less keen than the ears they heard with yesterday. Neither were eyes opened for them nor hearts made [percipient] for them during that period, but that you have been granted the same at this time. And by Allāh, you have not been shown anything after them that they knew not, and nothing was preferred for you of which they were deprived. Indeed, the affliction has befallen you with its bridle let loose and its girdle unfastened; so do not be deceived by the condition of the beguiled lot, for it is only an extended shade whose term is fixed.

۳ وَاللّٰهِ مَا أَشْمَعَهُمُ الرُّسُولُ شَيْئًا إِلَّا وَهَآ أَنَا ذَا مُسْمِعِكُمُوهُ، وَمَا أَسْمَاعُكُمْ الْيَوْمَ يَدُونُ أَسْمَاعِهِمْ بِالْأَمْسِ، وَلَا شَقَّتْ لَهُمُ الْأَبْصَارُ، وَلَا جُعِلَتْ لَهُمُ الْأَفْئِدَةُ فِي ذَلِكَ الْأَوَّانِ، إِلَّا وَقَدْ أُعْطِيتُمْ مِثْلَهَا فِي هَذَا الزَّمَانِ. وَاللّٰهِ مَا بُصِّرْتُمْ بَعْدَهُمْ شَيْئًا جَهْلِيَّوُهُ، وَلَا أَضْفَيْتُمْ بِهِ وَحُرْمُوهُ، وَلَقَدْ نَزَلَتْ بِكُمْ الْبَلِيَّةُ جَائِلًا خَطَائِمَهَا، رِخْوًا بِطَائِنَهَا، فَلَا يُغَرِّنْكُمْ مَا أَصْبَحَ فِيهِ أَهْلُ الْغُرُورِ، فَإِنَّمَا هُوَ ظِلٌّ مَّمدُودٌ إِلَى أَجَلٍ مَّعْدُودٍ.

CONTEXT

This oration, or a part thereof, has been narrated by a number of scholars before the time of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. For instance, ‘Alī ibn Ibrāhīm al-Qummī, who lived about one century earlier, mentions it and al-Kulaynī also narrates part of it in the first volume of *al-Kāfī*. Some commentators note that since Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd has discussed a number of variant wordings in this sermon, we can conclude that it existed in other sources besides that which was used by al-Sharīf al-Raḍī (N). Other commentators have quoted the earlier versions of this sermon mentioned in *al-Kāfī* and *Tafsīr al-Qummī*, noting the differences between them and the version recorded in *Nahj al-Balāghah* (T). The ultimate goal of this oration was to remind, admonish, and advise the people to wake up from their slumber of heedlessness, and warn them to be wary of deceit and dissent (MB). Of the three sections that make up this sermon, the first depicts the state of the Arabs during

the Age of Ignorance, before the Noble Prophet was sent to them. The second section contains a warning to those who were listening that they should take a lesson from the past so that they do not return to the same condition as those who preceded them. Finally, in the third section the Imām emphasizes that he is continuing in the path of the Messenger, and teaching them what the Prophet had taught the people, so they had no excuse to turn away (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām begins by reminding the people that Allāh sent the Noble Messenger *during the period after an interval in the sequence of Messengers*. The term *'fatrah'* refers to the period between the time of two divinely appointed Messengers, which was an interval wherein revelation had ceased, like the duration between the era of Prophet Īsā and the Noble Prophet Muḥammad (ṣ) (T). Some traditions say that the gap between these two Messengers was five to six hundred years. Imām 'Alī mentions this to accentuate the blessing of prophethood, since the value of a blessing increases in accordance with its increased benefit. And there is no doubt that the absence of a Messenger would result in proliferation of corruption and evil in the land, and the longer he remains absent, the more he is needed. Hence, his coming after this interval brought with it much blessing for the people (MB). Prior to that, the nations were in a *lengthy slumber*. The term *'haj'ah'* literally refers to sleep during the night, which is usually a deeper sleep than what one might experience during daytime. That is why it has been used as a metaphor for the ignorance and heedlessness of the people at this time (N). Imām 'Alī then goes on to describe this period as one with *proliferation of vices, unsettling affairs, and fiery wars*. The phrase *'itizāmin min al-fitān'* literally means resolving upon strife, and here it refers to the prevailing of evil over good, and vice over virtue (Z). Since the term *'itizām'* was also used to describe an unruly, wild and uncontrollable steed, some commentators have understood the phrase as depicting the evil and strife (*fitān*) of that era as a hostile animal which purposely attacks people, or a tyrant who deliberately oppresses the defenceless (N). A variant version of the phrase reads *'itirāḍin min al-fitān'* and connotes the manifestation of strife and its proliferation (R). Different interpretations have been suggested for the phrase *'intishārin min umūr'*, which we have rendered as *unsettling affairs*. One possible meaning thereof is that there was a lot of division

and deviation among the people, which took them away from the balanced state of equity and justice (M). It could also refer to the society being in turmoil due to lack of adherence to the most basic human ideals (Z). That in turn gave rise to a disorganized polity where there was no order, and the attitude of ‘anything goes’ was pervasive (N). Such a situation then saw numerous skirmishes, fights, and battles as tribes would become lifelong enemies for the smallest infractions. It was also a time when the world was dark and full of deceit, such that people could not trust each other.

Imām ‘Alī then compares it to a tree whose *leaves had turned yellow and there was no expectation of its fruits, as its water had sunk into the earth*. This is a beautiful analogy since it depicts the state of hopelessness among the people, compared to the expectation from a flourishing, fruit-bearing, green tree that was a pleasure to look at and gave hope of something good to come (MB). His statement *the beacons of guidance had been obliterated* means that the previously revealed scriptures and teachings of the earlier Messengers, which were a light of guidance like beacons and lampposts, all got effaced, forgotten, and abandoned. In their stead, *signposts of destruction had appeared* in the form of disbelief, hypocrisy, and corruption (N). In the end, the world *glowered at its people and frowned in the face of its seeker*, meaning that it rejected those who had become its slaves and rebuffed those who sought it (R). Or it could mean that this world faced them with what they detested, even when it showered wealth and status upon them; it gave with one hand and struck them down with the other (Z). Some suggest that the glowering and frowning of the world is a metaphor for how difficult and harsh life was at that time, due to the absence of social justice, brotherly love, and respect among the people (N). *Its fruit was discord* and deviance from the truth, since that is the only bitter fruit which the withered and yellowed tree of the world could produce. The statement *its food was carrion* can either be interpreted literally, since the Arabs in the Age of Ignorance would consume the flesh of carrion, or the term ‘*jūfah*’ here might have a more general connotation which encompasses all that has been forbidden to consume in the *sharī‘ah*, whether it be in the form of food that is eaten, or wealth that is usurped, etc. (MB). When Amīr al-Mu‘minīn says that *its inner garb was fear and outer covering was the sword*, he is alluding to how bloodshed and killing was rampant during that time, and it had caused the people to live in a state of fear for their lives. Each tribe was wary of the other, for they could carry out raids against them at any time, night or day, and the smallest

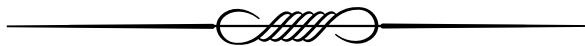
altercation could spark a war that lasted for years and claimed hundreds of lives (N).

2 Imām ‘Alī then calls on the people to take heed, and to remember the vile actions and pathetic state of the earlier generation. He does this as a warning to the people that if they are not careful, they may witness a resurgence of what occurred in the Age of Ignorance. Then they would be covered by all the same filth and misery that was prevalent in those days. *I’tibār* means moving (‘ubūr) from deficiency to completion. It is used to describe those who analyse the events which transpire and learn a practical lesson therefrom, by which they transfer from a state of ignorance to one of knowledge. This term therefore cannot be applied to those who only read historical reports or watch documentaries to gain information about what happened in the past, without bringing about any change in himself (S). The word ‘*tīka*’ has the same meaning as the more common term ‘*tilka*’, and both function as demonstrative pronouns or demonstrative adjectives. Here, it represents all the beliefs and actions by which their fathers and brothers used to be held hostage (N). The Imām is asking them to reflect on the qualities that had caused their forefathers to get confined and restrained, just as Allāh says in the Qur’ān: *Every soul is held hostage by what it has earned* (Q74:38) (R). This confinement was like one being shackled in chains and prevented from free movement, as a consequence of his own actions (M). Then, the Imām says *not much time separates you from them*, meaning that there is no excuse for negligence about the past when it was not that long ago (MB). Some commentators have interpreted the phrase ‘*mā taqādamat bikum wa lā bihim al-‘uhūd*’ to mean that no special covenant was made with them or those who preceded them. Based on this interpretation, the term ‘*uhūd*’ means covenants or pacts, as it does in the verse of the Qur’ān which states: *Say, “Have you made a covenant with Allah? For Allah will not fail to keep His covenant. Or do you ascribe to Allāh what you do not know?”* (Q2:80) (N). However, given the next line of the sermon, the first interpretation, where ‘*uhūd*’ is understood to mean eons or a length of time, seems more accurate. Indeed, the Imām subsequently states *nor have lengthy periods or centuries lapsed between you and them*. The word ‘*al-aḥqāb*’ connotes long periods of time, and ‘*al-qurūn*’ can either mean generations (I), or centuries (T). In either case, the general message is the same, and that is summed up in the last sentence of this section: *you are not so far today from the day when you were in their loins*. Since what had transpired was relatively a short while ago, and knowledge of it was still fresh in

the minds of the people, there was no excuse for them to neglect or ignore it. Rather they should have taken a lesson from it (MB).

3 Imām ‘Alī declares that whatever he is telling the people is exactly what the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ) told them when he was with them, without anything added or omitted (R). Some commentators have understood this declaration to mean that there was no argument left for them against the Imām, since he had conveyed to them the message, and made them hear it clearly (MB). By saying *the ears you hear with today are no less keen than the ears they heard with yesterday*, he is negating any excuse they may offer for not listening to his words, as they could hear clearly just as those before them could hear (M). It was not that earlier people had their *eyes opened for them*, or that their hearts were made percipient during their time (*‘al-awān’*). Rather, just as they were given eyes to see and hearts to comprehend, so too had the people of the current generation been given the same. So it is not possible for them to claim that they were ignorant of any of it, or were incapable of understanding it (MB). Furthermore, there is nothing that they did not know which the people had later been shown, nor had they been privileged with any knowledge which the earlier generation were deprived of, through which they could justify their change in attitude and behaviour. The phrase *‘usfītum bihi’* means being preferred and granted something which others are not. It is related to the term *al-ṣaḥfī*, which is the most valuable part of booty that is acquired and is reserved for the chief or leader himself, and is removed first before the rest of the booty is divided (I). What the Imām is saying here implies that during his time, due to the poor decisions of the previous caliphs, and the inflow of copious wealth from conquered lands, there was a re-emergence of another Age of Ignorance. This time, the idols being worshipped took the form of gold and silver coins (N). One commentator has suggested that the reason why people did not accept the same words from Imām ‘Alī that they, or their fathers, had accepted from the Noble Prophet (ﷺ) was because he had not been granted the same blessing of having his words accepted as did the Prophet (I). However, a more plausible reason for this is that during the time of the Messenger of Allāh, people listened to his words and followed him because they realized what he brought was the truth. At that time, most of the people were poor and possessed little worldly wealth. However, at the time of Imām ‘Alī, wealth had become abundant and love for it had hardened their hearts, so they rejected the same message (T). When he said that an affliction has befallen them *with its bridle let loose and its girdle unfastened*, he is talking about a

grave tribulation, because when the bridle of a mount becomes slack or the strap under its belly gets unfastened, the rider finds it difficult to control (R). Some commentators have suggested that the affliction being referred to here is the sedition of Mu'āwiyah and the Banī Umayyah (MB, N). In the final sentence of this sermon, Amīr al-Mu'minīn warns the people not to be deceived by the condition of the beguiled lot, and their ascendance, for it is only like *an extended shade whose term is fixed*. The similarity between a shadow and this world is that both can look long and protracted, but they have a fixed time after which they are no more (M). Moreover, like this world, the shadow seems stagnant and motionless to the onlooker, while in reality it is moving gradually (I).



ON THE PRE-ETERNAL CREATOR AND THE GREATNESS OF HIS CREATION

- 1 [All praise belongs to Allāh,] who is recognized without being seen, who creates without deliberation, who has eternally existed even when there was no sky with constellations, no curtains with portals, no pitch-dark night, no calm sea, no mountain with gorges, no winding ravines, no land with smooth plains, and no creature with supports. He is the Originator of all creation and its Inheritor. He is the God of all creation and its Sustainer. The sun and the moon are constant upon their courses, seeking His good pleasure. They make every new thing old and bring every distant thing near.
- ١ [الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ] الْمَعْرُوفِ مِنْ غَيْرِ رُؤْيَةٍ
وَالْخَالِقِ مِنْ غَيْرِ رَوِيَّةٍ، الَّذِي لَمْ
يَزَلْ قَائِمًا دَائِمًا إِذْ لَا سَمَاءَ ذَاتُ
أَبْرَاجٍ، وَلَا حُجُبٍ ذَاتُ أَرْتَاجٍ، وَلَا
لَيْلٍ دَاجٍ، وَلَا بَحْرٍ سَاجٍ، وَلَا جَبَلٍ
دُو فِجَاجٍ، وَلَا فَجٍّ دُو اغْوِجَاجٍ، وَلَا
أَرْضَ ذَاتِ مَهَادٍ، وَلَا خَلْقٍ دُو
اِعْتِمَادٍ؛ ذَلِكَ مُبْتَدِعُ الْخَلْقِ وَوَارِثُهُ،
وَإِلَهُ الْخَلْقِ وَرَازِقُهُ، وَالشَّمْسُ
وَالْقَمَرُ دَائِبَانِ فِي مَرْصَاتِهِ، يُبْلِيَانِ
كُلَّ جَدِيدٍ وَيَقْرَبَانِ كُلَّ بَعِيدٍ.

CONTEXT

Unfortunately, no information has reached us regarding the exact time and place when this sermon was delivered by Amīr al-Mu'minīn. However, due to its general purport, the message of the sermon is clear, regardless of its context. Parts of the sermon have been narrated in other sources, such as al-Wāsiṭī's *Uyūn al-Ḥikam wal-Mawā'iz* and al-Āmidī's *Ghurur al-Ḥikam*. However, the differences in wording show that the source used by the authors of these works was different from that of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Hence we can conclude that this sermon had been narrated through different chains of transmission and was present in a number of different source texts (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has noted that this oration is quite similar to sermon no. 184 in terms of its message, and in some cases, its wording as well. The three sections that make up this sermon address

different but related matters. In the first section, the Imām explains, in a very clear and profound way, the belief that Allāh is the pre-eternal Creator. The second section is a summary of the relationship between Allāh and His creation, and the third section is advice to the people regarding their behaviour and conduct.

COMMENTARY

1 Like with most of his sermons, Amīr al-Mu'minīn begins by praising Allāh. He states that Allāh is known and *recognized without being seen* by the eyes, or indeed any of the other senses (S), and He *creates without deliberation*, unlike all others who create things (T). Recognition of Him comes about through witnessing the signs that exist in the earth and the heavens, which clearly show His omnipotence. It is something known by the heart and its conviction, rather than what is visible or witnessed by sight. This has already been discussed in the commentary of sermon no. 49. The act of thinking and deliberation is carried out to arrive at an understanding of something unknown or unclear. However, there is nothing that Allāh is unaware of, so such an act does not apply to Him (MB). Some suggest the phrase '*al-khāliq min ghayri rawīyyah*' could also mean that He creates without any prior experience. This is contrary to the way in which human beings create, which is usually preceded by some experience in terms of what they have seen, heard, or tried (N). Imām 'Alī then states that Allāh is pre-eternal; He has always existed and will always exist ('*qā'imān dā'imān*'). He was there *even when there was no sky with constellations, no curtains with portals, no pitch-dark night, no calm sea, no mountain with gorges, no winding ravines, no land with smooth plains, and no creature with supports*. The general meaning of this passage is that Allāh existed when nothing else was in existence (Z). The phrase '*hujubun dhātu artāj*' refers to veils that have doorways or locks. The term '*artāj*' or '*irtāj*' (which some commentators insist is more correct (I, T)), is the plural of *rataj* which means a big door (R), and hence we have rendered it as *portals*. However, the term could also mean 'blocked' or 'inaccessible', given that the verb *rataja* means locked and barred, while *ratija* means impeded. If this latter meaning is taken, then the phrase would be translated: *no veils that block or are inaccessible*.

There are differing opinions among commentators regarding what these veils or curtains are referring to. Those who accept the second meaning say that it refers to the 'veils of light' that have been alluded to in some narrations. These veils are

said to be under the Divine Throne, and no creature (except those whom Allāh chooses) can even approach them. The intensity of their light prevents anyone from gazing at, or passing through, these veils (N). However, if the first meaning of doorways or portals is taken, it could still refer to heavenly veils, since according to the narrations about the Noble Prophet's ascension (*mi'rāj*), he passed through a number of these heavenly veils on his journey towards the Divine Throne (MB). Other meanings have also been suggested for this phrase, such as it being a metaphorical reference to the veils that cover the soul due to a human being's love for this world, or following his vain desires. They block the person from experiencing and being guided by the light of Allāh (M). One commentator states that the phrase is actually a negation of the notion of 'veils' from the Almighty in the first place, as they do not apply to Him in any way (*al-salb bi intifā' al-mawḍū'*), just as one would negate Him having offspring (Z). However, this interpretation does not match the rest of the examples, which are all phenomena that were later created and came to exist. Furthermore, the mention of such veils is found not only in narrations, but also in some supplications like the well-known *Munājāt al-Sha'bāniyyah*. Nevertheless, we have little understanding of the actual nature of these veils, since it is clearly something metaphysical (N). That is if we accept the interpretation as a reference to 'veils of light' (*ḥujub al-nūr*). If, on the other hand, we were to understand the phrase as a reference to the celestial phenomenon of Black Holes, then it would pertain to the physical realm. That would then fit in well with all the other examples mentioned by the Imām, which also pertain to the physical creation. Furthermore, Black Holes are both inaccessible and portal-like, so both possible meanings of the phrase would apply.

The term *'fjāj'* is plural of *fajj*, which can either mean a deep valley, or a mountain pass (T), and *'dhū i'timād'* refers to that upon which the creatures rely for support, such as their limbs or wings (I). Some commentators interpret the latter phrase as a reference to the strength and ability of the creatures (MB), by which they move and carry out the actions necessary for their survival. Aside from emphasizing that Allāh is eternal, these examples of natural phenomena that never used to exist but were later brought into existence also serve to remind the people of the great blessings of Allāh. The land which is smooth enough to allow human beings to settle, farm, and build is one of the great blessings of the Creator, just as the dark night in which people can rest, and the calm sea on which ships can sail are all divine blessings (N). Subsequently, Imām 'Alī states that it is Allāh

who originated all of creation and He is *its Inheritor*. This means that just as all of creation comes from Him, they all return back to Him since He is eternal and forever existent (M), and will remain after everything perishes (MB). He then describes the sun and moon as being *constant upon their courses, seeking His good pleasure*. The word '*dā'ibāni*' is the dual form of *dā'aba* which means to strive and toil, or to continue on one's way (T). It is taken from the verse which describes the sun and moon as '*dā'ibayn*' namely: *He made the sun and the moon subservient for you, constant in their courses...* (Q14:33). Therefore, what he means here is that both the sun and moon are continuously moving in their set courses, revolving in their orbits as per the natural laws laid down by Allāh, without diverging therefrom in the least (Z).

Some commentators have interpreted the phrase *seeking His good pleasure* as acting in accordance to His will (M). Others attribute their movement to angels who have been tasked with moving these celestial bodies in their orbits, and the angels do this seeking Allāh's pleasure (R). Perhaps this meaning is more apt, given that the sun and moon have been made subservient and cannot do anything against what they have been ordered (T). The fact that they *make every new thing old and bring every distant thing near* is a warning to the people that the passage of time, which is marked by the apparent movement of the sun and moon, causes everything to gradually wear away, become old and decrepit, and perish. Furthermore, that which seems far off to most people, such as old age, senility, and death, is actually brought closer day by day (N). By mentioning this fact, the Imām is admonishing the people against negligence and urging them to be alert and aware, for time waits for no man (M).

2 The Imām then continues to describe the Creator, and mentions His relationship with His creation. The phrase [*He*] *counts their works and deeds* is an allusion to His encompassing knowledge of the actions of His creatures. Some have said that *their works* ('*āthārahum*') may refer to their footprints on the earth, or their steps (MB), or the traces and legacy they leave behind (N), or even generally their actions and behaviour (I). The fact that Allāh counts *the number of breaths* of His creatures is reflected in a report wherein the verse: *...We only count down for them a number* (Q19:84) is said to refer to how Allāh counts the age of His servants by their breaths, not by how many years they have lived; for indeed, even human beings can count their age in years (T). The phrase '*khā'inata a'yunihim*' is rendered as *their perfidious glances* and refers to what they try to catch a glimpse

- 2 He apportions their sustenance, counts their works and deeds, and the number of breaths they take, as well as their perfidious glances and the innermost thoughts that their chests conceal. [He knows] their place of settlement and temporary lodging in the wombs and loins, until their final end. It is He whose wrath on His enemies is severe despite the vastness of His mercy, and whose compassion engulfs His friends despite the severity of His wrath. He subdues whoever challenges Him, destroys whoever defies Him, abases whoever opposes Him and overpowers whoever becomes His enemy. He is sufficient for the one who relies on Him, He gives the one who asks Him, He repays the one who lends to Him, and He rewards the one who thanks Him.

٢ قَسَمَ أَرْزَاقَهُمْ، وَأَخْصَى آثَارَهُمْ
وَأَعْمَالَهُمْ وَعَدَدَ أَنْفُسِهِمْ، وَخَائِنَةَ
أَعْيُنِهِمْ وَمَا تُخْفِي صُدُورُهُمْ مِنَ
الضَّمِيرِ، وَمُسْتَقَرَّهُمْ وَمُسْتَوْدَعَهُمْ
مِنَ الْأَرْحَامِ وَالظُّهُورِ، إِلَى أَنْ
تَنْتَاهِيَ بِهِمُ الْغَايَاتُ. هُوَ الَّذِي
اشْتَدَّتْ نِقْمَتُهُ عَلَى أَعْدَائِهِ فِي سَعَةِ
رَحْمَتِهِ، وَاتَّسَعَتْ رَحْمَتُهُ لِأَوْلِيَائِهِ
فِي شِدَّةِ نِقْمَتِهِ، قَاهِرٌ مَنْ عَارَاهُ
وَمُدْمِرٌ مَنْ شَاقَّاهُ، وَمُذِلٌّ مَنْ نَاوَاهُ
وَعَالِبٌ مَنْ عَادَاهُ؛ مَنْ تَوَكَّلَ عَلَيْهِ
كَفَاهُ، وَمَنْ سَأَلَهُ أَعْطَاهُ، وَمَنْ
أَقْرَضَهُ قَضَاهُ، وَمَنْ شَكَرَهُ جَزَاهُ.

- 3 Servants of Allāh, appraise yourselves before you are appraised and hold yourselves accountable before you are called to account. Breathe before the throats constrict, and submit willingly before being forcefully driven. Know that for one who is not helped against his own [base] self, such that he acts as his own adviser and admonisher, there is no one else to be an admonisher or an adviser for him.

٣ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، زِنُوا أَنْفُسَكُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ
تُوزَنُوا، وَحَاسِبُوا مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ
تُحَاسَبُوا، وَتَنْفَسُوا قَبْلَ ضَيْقِ
الْخَنَاقِ، وَأَنْقَادُوا قَبْلَ غُنْفِ السَّيَاقِ؛
وَأَعْلَمُوا أَنَّهُ مَنْ لَمْ يَعْزْ عَلَى نَفْسِهِ
حَتَّى يَكُونَ لَهُ مِنْهَا وَاعِظٌ وَرَاجِرٌ،
لَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُ مِنْ غَيْرِهَا لَا رَاجِرٌ وَلَا
وَاعِظٌ.

of or espy furtively (I), or to looking lustfully at what is forbidden, or insulting virtuous and innocent people with their gaze (N). This phrase, and the one following it, have been derived from the verse of the Qurʾān which states: *He knows the treachery of the eyes and what the chests conceal* (Q40:19) (MB). Commentators have interpreted the terms ‘*mustaqarrahum*’ and ‘*mustawdaʿahum*’ as the wombs of mothers wherein the fertilized embryo settles for a period of time, and the loins of fathers where the sperm was, briefly, before it was transferred to the womb, respectively (N). Alternatively, it could refer to their place of settlement on the earth, followed by their stay in the graves after death (I). The phrase *until their final end* could refer to the end of their development in the womb, or until they reach the end of their lives in this world (N). Some commentators say that it refers to the final end of humankind in the Hereafter, which is either felicity in Paradise, or wretchedness in Hell (Z). Imām ‘Alī then reminds the people that the wrath of Allāh on His enemies *is severe despite the vastness of His mercy*. One early commentator says this means that His punishment of His enemies is severe in the Hereafter, just as His mercy is all-encompassing for them in this world (R). However, this reading does not match the actual statement, which means that both His wrath and mercy are simultaneous, and one does not prevent or hinder the other (N).

The subsequent phrase about how His compassion *engulfs His friends despite the severity of His wrath* clarifies this same meaning. It is not like the case of kings, for example, since they cannot exhibit mercy and anger at the same time (M). The phrase ‘*qāhirun man ʿāzzahu*’ means that Allāh subjugates and subdues anyone who would dare to challenge Him. This was the case with individuals such as Firʾawn and others, who had openly challenged Allāh and were thus crushed and obliterated (MB). That is because Allāh *destroys whoever defies Him, abases whoever opposes Him, and overpowers whoever becomes His enemy*. In contrast, one who relies upon Him finds Him sufficient (‘*kafāhu*’), as the Qurʾān states: *And whoever trusts in Allāh, He suffices him* (Q65:3). Indeed, *He gives the one who asks Him, He repays the one who lends to Him, and He rewards the one who thanks Him*. Of course, there are certain conditions to be met on the part of the one who asks. For instance, he must strive himself and then ask, for seeking without any striving is of no avail (Z). Lending to Allāh means spending one’s wealth in His way and for His cause. The Qurʾān tells us: *Who is it that will lend Allāh a goodly loan, so that He may multiply it for him and he may [thereby] have a generous reward?* (Q57:11) (MB).

3 In the last section of the sermon, Amīr al-Mu'minīn advises the people to take stock of their deeds while they are still alive in this world, before the accounting of the Hereafter. The phrase '*zinū anfusakum min qabli an tūzanū*' literally means weigh yourselves before you are weighed. The instruction to hold oneself to account (*muḥāsabat al-naḥs*) has been mentioned in many traditions and there are entire treatises written on the subject, such as the one penned by 'Alī ibn Ṭāwūs (T). The reason for such emphasis on self-accounting is clearly because it enables the believer to make amends for any wrongdoing while he still has the opportunity to do so in this world, before death comes and it is too late (I). This is further reflected in the next statement: *Breathe before the throats constrict, and submit willingly before being forcefully driven*. The term '*khināq*' literally means the noose or cord that is tied around the neck, and by which one is strangled (T). Here it refers to the windpipe, and '*ḍiq al-khināq*' depicts suffocation that results when the windpipe is constricted (N). Submission here refers to following all the commandments of Allāh, and the one who 'forcefully drives' people is the Angel of Death, who takes away their souls while they are displeased and unwilling to leave this world (M). According to some commentators, this means that even the most headstrong disbelievers will, upon their death, submit to the truth due to the tremendous pressure they will experience at that moment; yet that submission will be of no avail (N).

Finally, the Imām warns that *for one who is not helped against his own [base] self, such that he acts as his own adviser and admonisher, there is no one else to be an admonisher or an adviser for him*. This means that one who is not helped by Allāh to combat the passions and urges of his base soul, through counselling and reproving himself, will not benefit from the advice and admonition of others (MB). True guidance is actualized from within oneself; so as long as one is not ready internally, no advice or counsel from outside will have any effect. Therefore, a person must begin by making a firm decision to reform himself, and then seek Allāh's assistance and help. It is only when one possesses an internal voice of conscience that admonishes him and restrains him from submitting to his vain desires that he would then be ready to accept guidance and advice from the divinely appointed guides and righteous believers (N). A narration attributed to Imām al-Sajjād (ʿa) states, "O Son of Ādam, you will remain in a goodly state as long as you have an adviser within yourself, and as long as you strive to appraise

yourself, and as long as fear is your inner garment and sorrow is your outer robe!"
(T).



THE SERMON OF AL-ASHBĀH

1 Mas'adah ibn Ṣadaqah related from [Imām] al-Ṣādiq, Ja'far ibn Muḥammad (ʿa), who said, “Amīr al-Mu'minīn (ʿa) delivered the following sermon from the pulpit of Kūfah, when a man approached him and said, ‘O Amīr al-Mu'minīn, describe our Lord for us in such a way that it is like we are seeing Him with our very eyes, so that we may increase our love and cognizance of Him.’ So he got angry and called out, ‘Gather together for prayer!’ So people congregated until the masjid was teeming with them. Then he ascended the pulpit while he was still angry, with a changed complexion. He praised Allāh and extolled Him, and invoked blessings upon the Prophet (ṣ). Then he said:

رَوَى مَسْعَدَةُ بْنُ صَدَقَةَ عَنِ الصَّادِقِ ١
جَعْفَرِ بْنِ مُحَمَّدٍ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ، أَنَّهُ قَالَ:
خَطَبَ أَمِيرُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ بِهَذِهِ
الْحُطْبَةِ عَلَى مِئْبَرِ الْكُوفَةِ، وَذَلِكَ
أَنَّ رَجُلًا أَتَاهُ فَقَالَ لَهُ: يَا أَمِيرَ
الْمُؤْمِنِينَ، صِفْ لَنَا رَبَّنَا مِثْلَ مَا نَرَاهُ
عَيْنًا لِنَزِدَّادَ لَهُ حُبًّا وَبِهِ مَعْرِفَةً.
فَغَضِبَ وَنَادَى: الصَّلَاةَ جَامِعَةً،
فَاجْتَمَعَ النَّاسُ حَتَّى غَصَّ الْمَسْجِدُ
بِأَهْلِهِ. فَصَعِدَ الْمِئْبَرِ وَهُوَ مُغْضَبٌ
مُتَغَيِّرُ اللَّوْنِ، فَحَمِدَ اللَّهَ وَأَثْنَى عَلَيْهِ
وَصَلَّى عَلَى النَّبِيِّ ﷺ ثُمَّ قَالَ:

CONTEXT

This is one of the few sermons about which the context has been provided within the text itself. Since the details are given within the text, most commentators have discussed the sermon's context before embarking on their commentaries of the oration itself. Some, however, have only mentioned the context in passing and started their commentaries from the sermon proper (Z, for example). There are two opinions regarding the naming of this sermon. A number of commentators hold that it was called al-Ashbāh (lit. 'ethereal forms' or 'apparitions'), meaning individuals (*ashkhāṣ*), and here the term refers to angels because there is mention of angels in this sermon (I, MB). Others, however, opine

that it is likely named thus because the original sermon contained mention of the term *ashbāḥ*, but that section was not included in *Nahj al-Balāghah* by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. The latter opinion is supported by the nomenclature generally employed in this work, where the sermon of al-Shiqshiqiyyah is named thus because the term *shiqshiqiyyah* is found therein, for example. Furthermore, angels have been mentioned in many other sermons, and the term *al-ashbāḥ* is not appropriate for describing angels (T). It has alternatively been suggested that the term refers to all those created beings, sentient and otherwise, that have been mentioned in the sermon, including angels, the sky, the earth, prophets, etc. (S).

The fact that al-Sayyid al-Raḍī mentions the narrator of this sermon as Mas'adah ibn Ṣadaqah suffices as a chain of transmission given that Mas'adah had authored many books, such as one titled *Khutab Amīr al-Mu'minīn* ('a), which was extant until the time of Sayyid Hāshim al-Baḥrānī (d. ~ 1107 AH). Additionally, this was one of the Imām's well-known (*mashhūr*) sermons, and a number of scholars have adduced it in their works both before and after al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Aḥmad ibn 'Abd Rabbih mentioned it in his *al-ʿIqd al-Farīd*, and al-Shaykh al-Ṣadūq has quoted it in his *al-Tawḥīd*, with slight variance in wording. Some like al-Zamakhsharī and Ibn Athīr later adduced parts of it in their works as well (N). Aside from being one of the few longer sermons in *Nahj al-Balāghah*, it is also considered to be among the most eloquent. Al-Raḍī describes it as one of the most marvellous (*'min al-jalāl'*) orations, and some commentators say that its eloquence compared to that of other speech is like gold in comparison to gravel (I).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening passage explains when and why Imām 'Alī gave this sermon. It was reported by Imām Ja'far al-Ṣādiq through his companion Mas'adah ibn Ṣadaqah, who said that Amīr al-Mu'minīn delivered this oration from the pulpit of Kūfah after someone approached him and said, "Describe our Lord for us in such a way that it is like we are seeing Him with our very eyes, so that we may increase our love and cognizance of Him." Upon hearing this, the Imām got so angry that the colour of his face changed. He called out loudly to the people, instructing them to gather for prayer. The reason for his outrage could have been because the questioner assumed that Allāh had attributes like those of the creatures, and hence wanted to hear a 'physical' description of Him. It may also be that Amīr al-

Mu'minīn was angry because after all this time, the Muslims still did not understand the attributes of their Lord (N). A further possibility is that his anger was due to the questioner implying that what has already been mentioned about the attributes of Allāh in the Qur'ān is insufficient, and he sought something more than that (S). His call "*al-ṣalāt jāmi'atan*" actually has the elided imperative *iḥḍarū*, meaning gather or present yourselves for the prayer (I). When the Imām made this call, they all came into the *masjid*, and it became full and was teeming (*'ghaṣṣa'*) with people. It was then that he ascended the pulpit, praised Allāh and extolled Him, invoked blessings upon the Prophet (ṣ), and proceeded to give the following sermon. It is noteworthy that the Imām was still visibly angry when he sat on the pulpit and started his oration, as the narration states.

2 The opening lines of this oration clarify an important point, namely that Allāh's treasures do not get depleted by giving, nor do they increase by reserving them for Himself, so there is no reason for Him to withhold His bounties (M). Hence, *every giver depletes his store save Him, and every withholder is blameworthy but Him*. Indeed, depletion and loss are experienced only by one who requires intermediary means in order to acquire something. However, they do not apply to the Creator of things from nothingness (Z). The verb *'yukdīhi'*, from *akdā*, means to impoverish or diminish. A land is described as *kādiyah* when its vegetation is slow to grow, and when this verb is used for a person, it means that his goodness is diminished. The Qur'ān states about such a person: *and [he] gave little and [then] held back* (Q53:34), meaning his goodness was cut off after giving only little (I). The reason for such behaviour in human beings is stinginess, and it is considered a blameworthy action. On the other hand, Allāh does not withhold out of fear of loss or poverty, nor does He save what He has for any future need (Z). Rather, His withholding is due to mercy and knowledge of what is good for His creatures. As such, it is also a bounty and blessing. The phrase *'fawā'id al-ni'am'* is general and encompasses both material and immaterial blessings. Some commentators suggest that it represents the necessities of life whereas the next phrase "*awā'id al-mazīd wal-qisam'*" refers to those bounties that bring about comfort and joy. Alternatively, the *wholesome bounties* refer to personal blessings whereas the *manifold gifts and shares* connotes communal blessings. Yet another possibility is that the first phrase is talking about those bounties that come to people without any effort on their part, such as water, air, sunlight, etc. whereas the second phrase

DESCRIBING ALLĀH, THE EXALTED

- 2 All praise belongs to Allāh, who gains naught by deprivation and parsimony, nor is He impoverished by munificence and generosity; for every giver depletes [his store] save Him, and every withholder is blameworthy but Him. He is the bestower of wholesome bounties and manifold gifts and shares. All of creation are His dependants. He has guaranteed their provisions and ordained their sustenance. He has paved the way for those who wish to turn to Him and those who seek what is with Him. And it is not that He is more generous when asked than when He is not asked.

وصف الله تعالى

٢ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي لَا يَفِرُّهُ الْمُنْعُ وَالْجُمُودُ، وَلَا يُكْدِيهِ الْإِعْطَاءُ وَالْجُودُ، إِذْ كُلُّ مُعْطٍ مُنْتَقِصٌ سِوَاهُ، وَكُلُّ مَانِعٍ مَذْمُومٌ مَا خَلَاهُ، وَهُوَ الْمَنَّانُ بِفَوَائِدِ النِّعَمِ، وَعَوَائِدِ الْمَزِيدِ وَالْقِسَمِ، عِيَالُهُ الْخَلَائِقُ، ضَمِنَ أَرْزَاقَهُمْ، وَقَدَّرَ أَقْوَاتَهُمْ، وَنَهَجَ سَبِيلَ الرَّاغِبِينَ إِلَيْهِ وَالطَّالِبِينَ مَا لَدَيْهِ، وَلَيْسَ بِمَا سُئِلَ بِأَجْوَدَ مِنْهُ بِمَا لَمْ يُسْأَلْ.

refers to the blessings that one needs to strive for (N). The term “*‘iyāl*’ is commonly understood to refer to one’s family, and if this meaning is intended, then it is obviously metaphorical (M). However, a more general meaning of the term is *dependants*, who rely on one for their sustenance, provisions, and betterment (MB). A similar statement is seen in Du‘ā’ Abū Ḥamzah al-Thumālī wherein we read, “And the creatures are all Your dependants (*‘iyāluka*), and in Your grasp (*qabḍatika*).” Some commentators say that the term “*‘iyāl*’ here also alludes to the compassion and love of Allāh for His servants (N). *He has guaranteed their provisions and ordained their sustenance*, as has been explicitly mentioned in the Glorious Qur’ān (Q11:6). Allāh has guaranteed the sustenance of all creatures, including animals, birds, insects, etc. and has apportioned for each creature that which is necessary for it in accordance to its requirements (T). The fact that He is not *more generous when asked than when He is not asked* means that unlike human beings who get affected by the pleas and petitions of those who ask them, thereby rendering them more generous towards those who seek from them, Allāh is not affected in the least and His generosity remains the same in every circumstance (I).

3 [He is] the First who had no 'prior' for there to be anything before Him, and the Last who has no 'subsequent' for there to be anything after Him. He prevents the pupils of the eyes from beholding or perceiving Him. Neither does time change for Him such that His condition would be altered, nor is He in any place such that He could transfer [to another]. If He bestowed all that is yielded by the mines in the mountains and displayed by the open oysters in the seas, including pure silver, gold nuggets, scattered pearls, and gleans of coral, it would neither affect His munificence nor decrease the vastness of what is with Him. With Him are such treasures of bounty that are not depleted by the petitions of the people, because He is the Most Generous who is neither diminished [in benevolence] by the pleading of beggars, nor made ungenerous by the importunity of petitioners.

٣ الْأَوَّلُ الَّذِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُ قَبْلُ فَيَكُونُ شَيْءٌ قَبْلَهُ، وَالْآخِرُ الَّذِي لَيْسَ لَهُ بَعْدُ فَيَكُونُ شَيْءٌ بَعْدَهُ، وَالرَّادُّ أَنْاسِيَّ الْأَبْصَارِ عَنْ أَنْ تَنَالَهُ أَوْ تُذَرِكَهُ، مَا اخْتَلَفَ عَلَيْهِ ذَهْرٌ فَيُخْتَلَفَ مِنْهُ الْحَالُ، وَلَا كَانَ فِي مَكَانٍ فَيُجَوَّرَ عَلَيْهِ الْإِنْتِقَالُ، وَلَوْ وَهَبَ مَا تَنَفَّسَتْ عَنْهُ مَعَادِنُ الْجِبَالِ، وَضَحِكَتْ عَنْهُ أَصْدَافُ الْبِحَارِ، مِنْ فِلِزِّ اللَّجَيْنِ وَالْعَقِيَّانِ، وَتُثَارَةِ الدُّرِّ، وَحَصِيدِ الْمَرْجَانِ، مَا أَثَّرَ ذَلِكَ فِي جُودِهِ وَلَا أَنْفَدَ سَعَةً مَا عِنْدَهُ، وَلَكَانَ عِنْدَهُ مِنْ ذَخَائِرِ الْأَنْعَامِ مَا لَا تُنْفِذُهُ مَطَالِبُ الْأَنْعَامِ، لِأَنَّهُ الْجَوَادُّ الَّذِي لَا يَغِيضُهُ سُؤَالُ السَّائِلِينَ، وَلَا يُبْخِلُهُ إِلْحَاحُ الْمُلْحِحِينَ.

3 Describing Allāh as *the First who had no 'prior' for there to be anything before Him, and the Last who has no 'subsequent' for there to be anything after Him* means that He has neither a beginning nor an end (Z). Allāh is not limited within time, so 'before' and 'after' do not apply to Him the way they do to everything that exists within the bounds of time (*al-zamāniyyāt*) (I). When he says *He prevents the pupils of the eyes from beholding or perceiving Him*, the Imām means that neither can the physical eye see Him, because He has no corporeal body or form, nor can the inner eyes perceive His Essence, because a limited being can never perceive an Infinite Being (N). The term '*anāsīy*' is plural of *insān*, and here it refers to *insān al-ʿayn*, meaning the pupil of the eye (T). Since Allāh is above time and not bound by it,

His condition never changes or gets altered, and since He is beyond space and its limitations, He is never in any place such that He could then transfer to another. It is known that all changes are rooted in time, and it is only with the passage of time that any kind of change or movement can take place. That is why the Almighty never changes (M). Imām ‘Alī then returns to the subject of Allāh’s munificence and bounty, saying that no matter how much He bestows, *it would neither affect His munificence nor decrease the vastness of what is with Him*. This is true even if He were to bestow *all that is yielded by the mines in the mountains*. The phrase ‘*mā tanaffasat ‘anhu ma’ādin al-jibāl*’ literally means what the mines of the mountains exhale, and has been used metaphorically like the verse that states: *and the morning as it breathes [anew]* (Q81:8). Here it connotes that which is broken off from it (T), or the minerals mined therefrom. Allāh’s bounty is similarly unaffected even if He bestowed what is *displayed by the open oysters in the seas*. Again, a metaphorical phrase ‘*mā ḍaḥikat ‘anhu aṣḍāf al-biḥār*’ has been employed, which literally means what the oysters of the sea laugh out, and refers to the opening of the mouth-like shell of the oysters thereby revealing the pearls contained therein (N). These mines and oysters could be full of *pure silver, gold nuggets, scattered pearls, and gleans of coral*, and it would still make no difference. The terms ‘*al-durr*’ and ‘*al-marjān*’ refer to large pearls and small ones respectively. Alternatively, ‘*al-marjān*’ could refer to a kind of red gem, called coral (MB). The treasures of Allāh are *not depleted by the petitions of the people*, and His generosity neither gets diminished *by the pleading of beggars*, nor *by the importunity of petitioners*. Human beings, on the other hand, often get angered by beggars who are importunate and continue insisting excessively even after being politely refused. That is because we have our own needs which we prioritize above that of others. However, Allāh is without need, and He provides for all the creatures without any hindrance (Z).

4 The Imām then turns to the subject of Divine Attributes. He addresses his questioner saying *follow whatever the Qur’ān shows you of His attributes and seek illumination from the light of its guidance*. Though he was addressing one man, his message was for all those who were listening (M). Since the man initially asked for a description of Allāh *like we are seeing Him with our very eyes*, the Imām explains an important principle to him, namely that we can only understand His attributes through what He tells us about Himself (N). Some commentators understand the phrase *whatever the Qur’ān shows you of His attributes* to mean that it is forbidden

HIS ATTRIBUTES IN THE QUR'ĀN

4 So look, O questioner: follow whatever the Qur'ān shows you of His attributes and seek illumination from the light of its guidance. As for what Satan directs you to learn, which is neither mandated upon you in the Book, nor is there any trace of it in the *sunnah* of the Prophet (ﷺ) and the Imāms of guidance, then leave its knowledge to Allāh, the Glorified, for indeed that is the ultimate right of Allāh upon you. Know that it is those who are firmly grounded in knowledge that have no need to break through the barricaded gates leading to the unseen, due to their acknowledgement of that which they are ignorant of pertaining to the details of the veiled and the unseen. Allāh, the Exalted, praises them for their admission that they are unable to access that which their knowledge does not encompass. He called their abstention from delving into things whose essence He has not enjoined upon them to investigate 'entrenchment [in knowledge]'. So limit yourself to this, and do not [try to] gauge the greatness of Allāh by the measure of your own intellect, lest you become one of those who perish.

صفاته تعالى في القرآن

٤ فَانْظُرْ أَتَيْهَا السَّائِلُ: فَمَا ذَلِكَ الْقُرْآنُ عَلَيْهِ مِنْ صِفَتِهِ فَأَتَتْ بِهِ وَاسْتَظْصَى بِنُورِ هِدَايَتِهِ، وَمَا كَلَّفَكَ الشَّيْطَانُ عِلْمَهُ مِمَّا لَيْسَ فِي الْكِتَابِ عَلَيْكَ فَرْضُهُ، وَلَا فِي سُنَّةِ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ وَأُئِمَّةِ الْهُدَى أَثَرُهُ، فَكُلُّ عِلْمِهِ إِلَى اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ، فَإِنَّ ذَلِكَ مُنْتَهَى حَقِّ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكَ. وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ الرَّاغِبِينَ فِي الْعِلْمِ هُمُ الَّذِينَ أَغْنَاهُمْ عَنِ افْتِحَامِ السُّدَدِ الْمَضْرُوبَةِ دُونَ الْغُيُوبِ، الْأَقْرَارِ بِجُمْلَةٍ مَا جَهِلُوا تَفْسِيرَهُ مِنَ الْغَيْبِ الْمَحْجُوبِ، فَمَدَحَ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى اعْتِرَافَهُمْ بِالْعَجْزِ عَنِ تَتَاوُلِ مَا لَمْ يُحِيطُوا بِهِ عِلْمًا، وَسَمَّى تَرْكَهُمُ التَّعَمُّقَ فِيمَا لَمْ يُكَلَّفْهُمْ الْبَحْثَ عَنْ كُنْهِهِ رُسُوخًا، فَأَقْتَصَرَ عَلَى ذَلِكَ، وَلَا تُقَدِّرْ عَظَمَةَ اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ عَلَى قَدْرِ عَقْلِكَ فَتَكُونَ مِنَ الْهَالِكِينَ.

to ascribe attributes to Him which are not befitting of His greatness (Z). The phrase *what Satan directs you to learn* could refer to delving into speculations about the

Essence of Allāh (T), or to all that which is not found in the Qur'ān or Sunnah about the Almighty, or what humankind is not required to know or inquire about since it is beyond their comprehension. Indeed the Messenger of Allāh is reported to have said, "Leave aside that which puts you into doubt for that which does not bring about doubt," and that about which there is no doubt is what has been revealed by Allāh (Z). Therefore, when something *is neither mandated upon you in the Book, nor is there any trace of it in the sunnah*, then its knowledge should be left to Allāh, for indeed *that is the ultimate right of Allāh upon you* ('*muntahā ḥaqqillāh 'alayk*'). Not doing so would open the door for doubt and unwarranted speculation and this, in turn, would result in divisions and schisms, which runs counter to the goal of religion that aim to unite the believers (M). Adhering only to what Allāh has revealed is deemed His right upon the creation because His command is to be obeyed, and His revelation contains all that the people would ever need for their guidance and felicity, with nothing left out. Trying to go beyond it is neither beneficial nor encouraged, and can actually lead to straying from the right path (MB). Indeed, *those who are firmly grounded in knowledge* see no need to *break through the barricaded gates* of the unseen, since they acknowledge what they are ignorant of regarding what is veiled from them. This could be termed 'intellectual humility', and Allāh praises them *for their admission that they are unable to access that which their knowledge does not encompass*. The identity of '*al-rāsikhīna fī al-'ilm*' has been discussed at length in exegetical works (in the *tafsīr* of Q3:7), but what we glean from this statement is that it refers to those who are able to distinguish between what is knowable and what is not, and when they face matters of the veiled unseen ('*al-ghayb al-mahjūb*'), they admit their ignorance and eschew speculation and conjecture (Z). And it is because of their abstention from *delving into things whose essence He has not enjoined upon them to investigate* that they have been described as firmly grounded or *entrenched* in knowledge. Indeed, many a scholar arrives at the loftiest peaks of knowledge only to realize the extent of his own ignorance. Then the Imām tells the questioner to restrict himself to this, and not try to *gauge the greatness of Allāh by the measure of your own intellect, lest you become one of those who perish*. Indeed, Imām Muḥammad al-Bāqir is reported to have said, "Verily a group spoke about Allāh, the Almighty, until they were confounded to such an extent that a man would be called from the front yet he would [turn back and] respond from behind, and he would be called out from

5 He is the All-Powerful, such that if imaginations leapt forward to discern the extent of His power, and thoughts that are free of vain ideas sought to fathom the depths of His unseen kingdom, and the hearts longed to grasp the nature of His attributes, and the ingresses of the intellects intricately scrutinized that which is beyond description so as to attain knowledge about His Essence, He would repel them all as they crossed the gorges of the dark unknown, focusing only on a way to Him, the Glorified. They would thus return defeated, admitting that the core of His gnosis cannot be attained through arbitrary efforts, nor can the extent of the majesty of His glory be conceived by the minds of thinkers.

هُوَ الْقَادِرُ الَّذِي إِذَا ارْتَمَتْ الْأَوْهَامُ
لِتُدْرِكَ مُنْقَطِعَ قُدْرَتِهِ، وَحَاوَلَ الْفِكْرُ
الْمُبَرِّأُ مِنْ خَطَرِ الْوَسَاوِسِ أَنْ يَقَعَ
عَلَيْهِ فِي عَمِيقَاتِ غُيُوبٍ مَلَكُوتِهِ،
وَتَوَلَّهَتْ الْقُلُوبُ إِلَيْهِ لِتَجْرِيَ فِي
كَيْفِيَّةِ صِفَاتِهِ، وَغَمَضَتْ مَدَاخِلُ
الْعُقُولِ فِي حَيْثُ لَا تَبْلُغُهُ الصَّفَاتُ
لِتَتَأَوَّلَ عِلْمَ ذَاتِهِ، رَدْعَهَا وَهِيَ
تَجُوبُ مَهَاوِي شَدَفِ الْغُيُوبِ،
مُتَخَلِّصَةً إِلَيْهِ سُبْحَانَهُ فَرَجَعَتْ إِذْ
جُهِتَتْ، مُعْتَرِفَةً بِأَنَّهَا لَا يَنَالُ بِجُورِ
الِاعْتِسَافِ كُنْهَ مَعْرِفَتِهِ، وَلَا تَحْطُرُ
بِنَالِ أُولِي الرُّوِيَّاتِ حَاطِرَةً مِنْ
تَقْدِيرِ جَلَالِ عِزَّتِهِ.

behind and reply in front!" That is why we are told that we must not discuss about the Essence of Allāh (T).

5 Emphasizing the inability of human beings to grasp the nature of the Divine Essence, and the limitlessness of Allāh's attributes, the Imām states that this holds true even *if imaginations leapt forward to discern the extent of His power*. The term '*irtamat*' literally means that which throws itself as a result of some other action (R), and its root verb is usually employed to connote throwing or shooting something at a target while hunting or fighting (T). Here, it has been used metaphorically to mean that even if the imaginations jump forward to attain an understanding of the extent of Allāh's power, they would never be able to do so (Z). The result is similar when *thoughts that are free of vain ideas seek to fathom the depths of His unseen kingdom*. The phrase '*khaṭar al-waswās*' (or in some

manuscripts '*khaṭarāt al-waswās*') refers to evil inner thoughts of the mind (R), and includes the whisperings of Satan as well as flawed assumptions (MB). Even when the mind is free from such thoughts and ideas, it would still be unable to fathom the depths of Allāh's kingdom. Any yearning of enthralled hearts that long *to grasp the nature of His attributes* are futile, so even when those with a deep love for Him seek to understand His Essence through the ways of the heart, they are incapable of doing so (N). Some commentators have understood the verb '*tawallahat*' to connote bewilderment and confusion (R), so the hearts that yearn to comprehend His attributes are perplexed. The phrase '*ghamaḍat madākhil al-ūqūl*' is rendered *the ingresses of the intellects intricately scrutinized* and refers to attempting a deep examination or study of something the reality and core of which cannot be understood or described due to its intricacy and complexity, in order to acquire knowledge about the Almighty (I). Alternatively, it could mean that the minds delve so deeply into the intricacies of such matters that it surpasses description, due to its complex nature (MB).

'*Rada'ahā*' is the response to all four conditional statements preceding it (M), and means that if a person uses these four means, he may attain knowledge of many realities but he will never know the Essence of Allāh, since that is beyond his capacity of comprehension (N). Hence the statement *He would repel them* means that Allāh would prevent them or stop them (R). And since this unknowable reality is out of reach for the human being, any attempt at fathoming it would make one *return defeated*. The verb '*jubihat*' connotes failure (Z), or being turned away and repelled (R). Having tried using all the means at their disposal to no avail, they realize that *arbitrary efforts* ('*jawr al-ī'tisāf*') cannot be used to attain *the core of His gnosis* ('*kunhu ma'rifatih*'). Commentators have offered various interpretations for the terms '*jawr*' and '*al-ī'tisāf*' with some saying that the former means deviating from the right path and the latter connotes traversing a thorny path that does not lead to anything good (Z). Other say '*jawr*' means abundance whereas '*al-ī'tisāf*' is following a wrong path (T, R). The latter term has also been interpreted as travelling on a road other than the known public highway (I). In any case, the meaning is that whatever human beings try, they will never be able to gain an understanding of the Divine Essence. Furthermore, the majesty of Allāh's glory and might cannot *be conceived by the minds of thinkers* through reflection, or any other means. That is because whatever can be conceived in the minds of people, no matter how glorious and great it is, is still merely the conception of

6 He originated the creation without any model, nor following any measured template by a creator worshipped prior to Him. He showed us the dominion of His might, and wonders articulated in the traces of His wisdom, and the acknowledgement by the creation of their need for His powerful grip to maintain them. In this was what guided us to the proof that compels us to know Him. In the marvels of His creation are manifested the traces of His handiwork and the signs of His wisdom, so all that He has created becomes a proof for His existence and a guide towards Him. And [even] if the creature is silent, its argument is voiced through its design, and its guidance towards the Originator is established.

٦ الَّذِي ابْتَدَعَ الْخَلْقَ عَلَى غَيْرِ مِثَالٍ
اِمْتَنَلَهُ، وَلَا مِقْدَارٍ احْتَدَى عَلَيْهِ، مِنْ
خَالِقٍ مَعْبُودٍ كَانَ قَبْلَهُ، وَأَرَانَا مِنْ
مَلَكُوتِ قُدْرَتِهِ، وَعَجَائِبِ مَا نَطَقَتْ
بِهِ آثَارُ حِكْمَتِهِ، وَاعْتِرَافِ الْحَاجَةِ
مِنَ الْخَلْقِ إِلَى أَنْ يُقِيمَهَا بِمَسَالِكِ
قُوَّتِهِ، مَا دَلَّنَا بِاضْطِرَارٍ قِيَامَ الْحُجَّةِ
لَهُ عَلَى مَعْرِفَتِهِ، وَظَهَرَتْ فِي الْبِدَائِعِ
الَّتِي أَحَدَتْهَا آثَارُ صَنْعَتِهِ وَأَعْلَامُ
حِكْمَتِهِ، فَصَارَ كُلُّ مَا خَلَقَ حُجَّةً لَهُ
وَدَلِيلًا عَلَيْهِ، وَإِنْ كَانَ خَلْقًا صَامِتًا،
فَحُجَّتُهُ بِالتَّذْيِيرِ نَاطِقَةً، وَدَلَالَتُهُ عَلَى
الْمُبْدِعِ قَائِمَةٌ.

creatures and not the true description of the Creator, who is far greater and more glorious (MB).

6 The way that Allāh creates cannot be compared to how the creatures make things, since *He originated the creation without any model*, and did not follow *any measured template by a creator worshipped prior to Him*. In contrast, whenever human beings make things, they have to envision them first, and plan out clearly how they will make what they want. And they can only do this by visualizing the measurements or template of something external that existed earlier, and then copying or following that in order to create something else (MB). This fact leads to the realization that human beings are not capable of true, original invention (*ibdā'*) since whatever they make is based, in one way or another, on something that already exists and was created before (N). *The dominion of His might*, which Allāh has shown us, refers to what He has created by His power and the knowledge with which He made this universe (Z). And *the traces of His wisdom* refer to Divine

actions and laws (M), which are all based on perfect wisdom and benefit (*maṣlahah*) for the creation (MB). As for *the acknowledgement by the creation of their need*, this may be a verbalized acknowledgement or, in most cases, a non-verbal acknowledgement based on the reality of their situation (*lisān al-ḥāl*) (MB). Indeed, it is through what He has shown us of these things that we are guided *to the proof that compels us to know Him*. And this constitutes clear evidence against any denier or opponent (Z). Some commentators say that compulsion here does not pertain to knowing the Almighty, but to establishing the evidence that would lead to knowing Him (I).

In the marvels of His creation are manifested the traces of His handiwork and the signs of His wisdom, for everything in creation, by its very existence, declares His power and wisdom (N). Hence, *all that He has created becomes a proof for His existence and a guide towards Him*. This refers to what is commonly known as the teleological proof of the existence of God, or the argument from design (since such a complex and perfect creation could not have come about without a Designer). It is further complemented by the cosmological argument which states that an endless chain of causes is impossible and there must be a Primary or First Cause which brings everything into existence (Z). Because every creature, even if it is unable to speak ('*khalqan ṣāmītan*'), voices its argument *through its design, its guidance towards the Originator is established*. Of course, those who traverse on the path of truth are at different levels and their ability to 'hear' these voices of the creation varies depending on their spiritual station (M). In short, it is as if by the perfect way in which it has been created, everything calls out, "Do you not see me and observe my form, composition, and qualities? Do you think I created myself or one like me created me?" And in so doing, it declares its createdness and the fact that it has a Creator (MB).

7 This passage further emphasizes the uniqueness of Divine Attributes, which can in no way be compared to the qualities of creatures. The Imām categorically states that whoever makes such a comparison *has not truly acquainted his inner self with knowledge of Allāh*, and such a person *has not made his heart attain conviction that Allāh has no peer*. He testifies to this and bears witness, as a means of emphasis, just as Prophet Hūd testified that he had disassociated himself from what the polytheists ascribed as partners to Allāh (Q11:54-55) (T).

7 So I bear witness that whoever likens You to the disparate limbs of Your creation, or to the joints that connect them together and are enclosed [with ligaments] by the wisdom of Your design, has not truly acquainted his inner self with knowledge of You, and has not made his heart attain conviction that You have no peer. It is as though he has not heard the disavowal by the followers of those [false gods] they followed when they said, “By Allāh, we had indeed been in manifest error when we equated you with the Lord of all the worlds.” Liars are they who equate anything with You, when they liken You to their idols, adorn You with ornaments of the creatures by their imagination, divide You into parts like those of physical bodies by their conjecture, and compare You to the creatures that have different abilities with their [deficient] faculties of intellection.

8 And I bear witness that whoever equates You to anything from Your creation has taken a peer for You, and whoever takes a peer for You is an unbeliever according to what is stated in Your unequivocal verses and indicated by the evidence of Your clear arguments. Verily You are Allāh, who can neither be confined in the intellects so as to be analysed by its musings, nor in the deliberations of the minds so as to be limited and inferred.

فَأَشْهَدُ أَنَّ مَنْ شَبَّهَكَ بِبَيِّنٍ
أَعْضَاءِ خَلْقِكَ، وَتَلَاحُجِّ حَقَاقِ
مَفَاصِلِهِمُ الْمُحْتَجِبَةِ لِتَذْيِيرِ
حِكْمَتِكَ، لَمْ يَعْقِدْ غَيْبَ
ضَمِيرِهِ عَلَى مَعْرِفَتِكَ، وَلَمْ
يُبَاشِرْ قَلْبُهُ الْيَقِينَ بِأَنَّهُ لَا نِدَّ لَكَ،
وَكَأَنَّهُ لَمْ يَسْمَعْ تَبَرُّؤَ التَّابِعِينَ
مِنَ الْمُتَّبِعِينَ إِذْ يَقُولُونَ:
«تَاللَّهِ إِنْ كُنَّا لَفِي ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ
إِذْ تُسَوِّيْكُمْ بِرَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ».
كَذَّبَ الْعَادِلُونَ بِكَ، إِذْ شَبَّهُوكَ
بِأَضْنَائِهِمْ، وَنَحَلُّوكَ حِلْيَةَ
الْمَخْلُوقِينَ بِأَوْهَامِهِمْ، وَجَرَّءُوكَ
تَجَرُّؤَةَ الْمَجَسَّمَاتِ بِخَوَاطِرِهِمْ،
وَقَدَّرُوكَ عَلَى الْخَلْقَةِ الْمُخْتَلِفَةِ
الْقُوَى بِفَرَاحِ عُقُولِهِمْ.

وَأَشْهَدُ أَنَّ مَنْ سَاوَاكَ بِشَيْءٍ مِنْ
خَلْقِكَ فَقَدْ عَدَلَ بِكَ، وَالْعَادِلُ بِكَ
كَافِرٌ بِمَا تَنَزَّلَتْ بِهِ مُحْكَمَاتُ
آيَاتِكَ، وَنَطَقَتْ عَنْهُ شَوَاهِدُ حُجَجِ
بَيِّنَاتِكَ، وَإِنَّكَ أَنْتَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي لَمْ
تَنْتَهِ فِي الْعُقُولِ، فَتَكُونُ فِي مَهَبِّ
فِكْرِهَا مُكَيِّفًا، وَلَا فِي رَوَايَاتِ
خَوَاطِرِهَا فَتَكُونُ مُحْدُودًا مُصَرِّفًا.

It is noteworthy that the Imām turns his address directly to the Almighty here, and this practice of changing from the third person to the second person, known as *iltifāt*, is a rhetorical device used to gain the attention of listeners among other things (MB). An example of such a change in address is seen in Sūrah al-Fātiḥah where we recite: *You alone do we worship, and You alone do we beseech for help* (Q1:5). By mentioning *disparate limbs and joints*, the Imām is refuting the false beliefs of the Mujassimah and the Mushabbihah, whose anthropomorphic ideas are close to polytheism and disbelief (N). The phrases *‘tabāyuni a’ḍā’* and *‘talāḥumi ḥiqāqi mafāṣil’* refer to the limbs and joints of human beings and animals, which are covered by flesh and held by ligaments. These are just examples of certain parts of the creation to which only an ignorant individual would liken the Creator, for verily nothing in creation is like Him (*laysa kamithlihi shay’*) (Z). The Imām then states that it is as though those who do this have not heard *the disavowal by the followers of those false gods they followed when they said*, as mentioned the Qur’ān: *“By Allāh, we were indeed in manifest error when we equated you with the Lord of all the worlds”* (Q26:97-8). Hence we see that Imām ‘Alī uses this verse as evidence to show that those who liken Allāh to the creatures are in error, and those in error do not have knowledge of Allāh (M).

The Imām then calls those who equate anything with the Almighty liars. It is clear how this is the case when they adorn Him *with ornaments of the creatures by their imagination*, divide Him *into parts like those of physical bodies by their conjecture*, and compare Him *to the creatures that have different abilities with their [deficient] faculties of intellection*, since all such comparisons are false. The word *‘qarā’ih’* is plural of *qarīḥah* which was a term used for the first water that is drawn forth from a well, and here it refers to the faculty of intellection (R). Considering Him to be a composite entity with parts, like the body parts of creatures, is false, yet there were certain groups, even among those who claimed to be monotheists, who held such beliefs. The Banī Isrā’īl believed in the corporeal nature of God, and even pressurized Prophet Mūsā to let them ‘see’ God with their own eyes. The trinitarians among the Christians also believe that Jesus is ‘God in the flesh’. It is likely that some of these ideas then crept into certain Muslim circles giving rise to groups such as the Mujassimah and the Mushabbihah (the former held that the Almighty has a body and the latter believed that He had some qualities similar to that of the creation). Yet the Qur’ān is explicitly clear that nothing can be compared to Allāh (Q42:11) (N).

8 A further clarification and underscoring of the point is made in this section, where the Imām once again testifies that *whoever equates Allāh to anything from His creation has taken a peer for Him, and whoever takes a peer for Him is an unbeliever*. This, he says, is something stated in *unequivocal verses* of the Qurʾān and indicated by the evidence of His *clear arguments*. Some of the verses that speak of this include: *Is there a god besides Allāh? No indeed! But they are people who deviate [by ascribing equals to Him] (Q27:60), ...and do not follow the desires of those who deny Our signs, and those who do not believe in the Hereafter and equate [others] with their Lord (Q6:150), and Yet those who disbelieve equate [others] with their Lord (Q6:1)*. The *clear arguments* mentioned by the Imām refer to rational proofs that demonstrate the impossibility of the Creator being like the created (T), or it could refer to the arguments presented in the Qurʾān itself (N). Hence, one who ascribes any of the qualities of the creatures to Allāh, or assigns to the creatures any of the Divine Attributes is considered an unbeliever, by consensus (*ijmāʿ*), and according to both the Qurʾān and Sunnah (Z).

Some commentators suggest that this testimony differs from the earlier one since it is an allusion to a different group. The earlier testimony of the Imām was pertaining to the idol worshippers who considered their idols to have a divine status, such that they would present their needs before them and seek what they desired from them. In this way, they worshipped the idols. In contrast, the testimony made here pertains to those who ascribe peers or partners to Allāh, such as the dualists who believe in a ‘god of good’ and ‘god of evil’, or the trinitarians who believe in three ‘gods’ as one. The Imām considers these groups as disbelievers, based on what is stated in the Qurʾān and *clear arguments* (N). The final statement of this section is considered by some commentators to be a third testimony, linked by conjunction to the second (MB). In it, the Imām testifies that the Almighty *can neither be confined in the intellects so as to be analysed by its musings, nor in the deliberations of the minds so as to be limited and inferred*. It could be said that this is a summary of the preceding two testimonies (M). The term ‘*mahab*’ literally means a place where wind blows, raising dust, and in the phrase ‘*mahabbi fikrihā*’, it has been used metaphorically to refer to musings of the mind, which commentators say is quite a beautiful metaphor (I). The first part of the statement above means that if the mind was capable of comprehending Him, He would have a particular ‘how-ness’ (*kayfiyyah*), but since He is above such a thing, the mind can never comprehend the core of His Essence and Attributes (N).

ALSO PART OF THE SAME SERMON

9 He proportioned what He created and made its dimensions precise; He designed it and made its arrangement intricate. He turned it towards its direction so it neither transgressed the limits of its station nor fell short of reaching the end of its goal. It was not refractory when commanded to proceed upon His will; and how could it, when all matters emanate from His will? He brings into existence diverse things without need for resorting to deliberation, engaging any inner impulse, drawing on any experience gained from the events that occur over time, or using the help of any partner who might assist Him in innovating wondrous things. So His creation was completed by His command, and it submitted in obedience to Him and responded to His call. Neither did the tarrying of any laggard nor the inertness of any procrastinator prevent it from doing so. He straightened the crookedness of all things and set their limits. With His power, He harmonized their incongruities and linked the means of their association. He separated them into various categories that differ in their parameters, proportions, dispositions and forms. [These were] a new creation that He perfected, and He initiated and fashioned them as He willed.

ومنها

٩ قَدَّرَ مَا خَلَقَ فَأَحْكَمَ تَقْدِيرَهُ، وَدَبَّرَهُ
فَأَلْطَفَ تَدْبِيرَهُ، وَوَجَّهَهُ لِرُوحِهِ فَلَمْ
يَتَعَدَّ حُدُودَ مَنْزِلَتِهِ، وَلَمْ يَقْصُرْ دُونَ
الْإِنْتِهَاءِ إِلَى غَايَتِهِ، وَلَمْ يَسْتَضِعْ
إِذَا أَمَرَ بِالْمُضِيِّ عَلَى إِرَادَتِهِ، فَكَيْفَ
وَأِنَّمَا صَدَرَتْ الْأُمُورُ عَنْ مَشِيئَتِهِ؟
الْمُنْشَأُ أَصْنَافَ الْأَشْيَاءِ بِلَا رَوِيَّةٍ
فِكْرٍ آلَ إِلَيْهَا، وَلَا قَرِيحَةٍ غَرِيِزَةٍ
أَضْمَرَ عَلَيْهَا، وَلَا تَجَرِبَةٍ أَفَادَهَا مِنْ
حَوَادِثِ الدُّهُورِ، وَلَا شَرِيكِ أَعَانَهُ
عَلَى ابْتِدَاعِ عَجَائِبِ الْأُمُورِ، فَتَمَّ
خَلْقُهُ بِأَمْرِهِ، وَأَدْعَنَ لِبَطَاعَتِهِ وَأَجَابَ
إِلَى دَعْوَتِهِ، لَمْ يَغْتَرِضْ دُونَهُ رَيْثُ
الْمُبْطِئِ وَلَا أَنَاةُ الْمُتَلَكِّي، فَأَقَامَ مِنَ
الْأَشْيَاءِ أَوْدَهَا وَنَهَجَ حُدُودَهَا،
وَلَاءَمَ بِقُدْرَتِهِ بَيْنَ مُتَضَادِّهَا، وَوَصَلَ
أَسْبَابَ قَرَائِنِهَا، وَفَرَّقَهَا أَجْنَاساً
مُخْتَلِفَاتٍ فِي الْحُدُودِ وَالْأَقْدَارِ،
وَالْغَرَائِزِ وَالْهَيْئَاتِ، بَدَايَا خَلَائِقَ
أَحْكَمَ صُنْعَهَا، وَفَطَرَهَا عَلَى مَا أَرَادَ
وَابْتَدَعَهَا.

The second part of the statement negates the idea of attaining knowledge of Him through rational deliberation and reflection. The term '*muṣarraḥan*' is rendered *inferred* and means that minds conjecture Him arbitrarily, with their preconceived notions and biases, and the limits of their intellection (Z), yet knowledge of Him can never be attained this way.

9 The Imām now turns to a description of how Allāh originated His creation. Out of His wisdom, *He proportioned what He created and made its dimensions precise; He designed it and made its arrangement intricate. Then He turned it towards its direction so it neither transgressed the limits of its station nor fell short of reaching the end of its goal.* These were the three 'phases' of creation: *taqdīr*, *tadbīr*, and *tawjīh* (N). Proportioning every dimension of the creation according to a precise measure is what we term *taqdīr*. As for *tadbīr*, the phrase '*wa dabbarahu fa alṭafa tadbīrahu*' has been interpreted as arranging and organizing the creation according to a wise plan (R), or designing and managing every intricate aspect of the creation with grace, and in accordance to laid out laws (Z). When it comes to *tawjīh*, it refers to facilitating the means of development and movement in the direction of the ultimate goal of creation (N). Some consider it to refer to the purpose for which a creature was created, so the '*wijhah*' for a raincloud is carrying and pouring down rain, and for a donkey it is carrying loads, and for bees it is producing wax and honey, etc. (MB). Nothing in creation *transgressed the limits of its station nor fell short of reaching the end of its goal*, and each created thing did exactly what was ordained by Allāh (M).

Nothing was *refractory* ('*yastaṣīb*') meaning none among the creatures obstinately disobeyed or went against what it was instructed *when commanded to proceed upon His will*, rather everything obeyed and submissively followed the command with ease (Z). Indeed, how could it be otherwise *when all matters emanate from His will*? That is, how could any creature go against the will of Allāh when everything is in His control and cannot exist without His will, and they are all governed by it! (M). Hence we see perfect order in creation, with celestial objects moving at determined speeds in their respective orbits, and other natural phenomena following the course set out for them. It should be noted that what has been mentioned in the statements above pertain to the ontological (*takwīnī*) command of Allāh, not His legislative (*tashrīʿī*) command. Hence, it does not impinge on human free will because firstly, free will has been given to human beings by Allāh's command to begin with, and secondly, it applies only to issues

that fall under the rubric of His legislative command (N). The Imām then mentions four things that the Almighty does not need in order to bring anything into existence. These are: deliberation ('*rawiyyah*'), inner impulse ('*gharīzah*'), experience ('*tajribah*'), or the assistance of another ('*sharīkin a'ānah*'). As for deliberation, it is only required by one who uses what is known to him in order to arrive at an understanding of what is unknown, and that could never apply to the All-Knowing. Inner impulse is likewise inapplicable to the Almighty as it signifies being influenced by something, while nothing can ever influence Allāh.

Experience is not required by Him since one who needs to resort to past experience is deficient and thus needs to enhance his ability by referring to what happened previously which is obviously not the case with the Omniscient Creator. Finally, a helpful partner is out of the question since firstly, He can have no partner, and secondly, only one who is incapable needs help, and Allāh is never incapable so as to require assistance (MB). Once He made the creation, *it submitted in obedience to Him and responded to His call*. It did so without sluggish delay ('*rayth al-mubṭī*') or laggardly languor ('*anāt al-mutakalli*'). Both these terms signify tarrying, inertness, and procrastination, and what this means is that everything in creation comes about at its precise time. So, for example, the teething of a suckling infant and the lactation of a breastfeeding mother happen at the exact moment when required, otherwise neither would a mother be able to nurse her baby, nor would the child be able to attain the nourishment needed (T). By saying *He straightened the crookedness of all things*, the Imām meant that He prepared everything in the perfect way, as per what it needed to perform its function, and *set their limits* thereby facilitating the easy achievement of their purpose (MB). Some manuscripts have the phrase '*nahaja judadahā*' instead of '*nahaja hudūdahā*' in which case the translation would be: *He prepared their paths [for them]* (I). *He harmonized their incongruities* such as the contrary characteristics they may have, like wetness and dryness or heat and cold, *and linked the means of their association*. This latter statement has been interpreted in different ways. Some say that it refers to binding the souls to their bodies, while others opine that it refers to giving to each the guidance that is most appropriate for its wellbeing and felicity (T). He separated the creation into various categories ('*ajnās*'), with differing *parameters, proportions, dispositions and forms*, such that some are tall while others short, some big and others small, some wild and other tame, some beautiful and other unseemly, and so on, in accordance with His wisdom (MB).

ON THE DESCRIPTION OF THE HEAVENS

10 He arranged, without any suspension, the elevations of its spaces. He joined the clefts of its fissures and attached them to their pairs. He made its difficult ascents easy for those [beings] that descend with His command and ascend with the deeds of His creatures. He summoned it while it was vapor, so its handles coalesced. Then He ripped open its sealed doors after they had been closed and placed blazing sentinels at its gateways. Holding it from quaking in the vastness of space with His hands, He ordered it to remain stationary in compliance with His command. He made its sun a lightsome sign of its day, and its moon an effacing sign of its night. He set them in motion within their orbits and regulated their movement in the passage of their courses so as to distinguish between night and day by them, and so that *the number of years and calculation [of time]* may be known by their fixed movement. Then He suspended in its expanse its firmament, placing therein its adornment of [stars, like] small gleaming pearls and brightly shining lamps. He shot the eavesdroppers with their piercing flames. He made them all follow their specific ways, from the constancy of those that are fixed, to the orbiting of those in motion, the descending and

ومنها في صفة السماء

١٠ وَنَظَّمَ بِلَا تَغْلِيْقٍ رَهَوَاتٍ فُرَجَهَا،
وَلَا حَمَّ صُدُوعَ انْفِرَاجِهَا، وَوَشَّجَ
بَيْنَهَا وَبَيْنَ أَرْوَاجِهَا، وَذَلَّلَ لِلْهَابِطِينَ
بِأَمْرِهِ، وَالصَّاعِدِينَ بِأَعْمَالِ خَلْقِهِ،
حُرُوزَتَهُ مَعْرَاجِهَا، وَنَادَاهَا بَعْدَ إِذْ هِيَ
دُخَانٌ، فَالْتَحَمَتْ غُرَى أَشْرَاجِهَا،
وَفَتَّقَ بَعْدَ الْإِرْتِنَاقِ صَوَامِتَ أَبْوَابِهَا،
وَأَقَامَ رَصْدًا مِنَ الشُّهُبِ النَّوَاقِبِ
عَلَى نِقَابِهَا، وَأَفْسَكَهَا مِنْ أَنْ تُثَوَّرَ
فِي حَرِّقِ الْهَوَاءِ بِأَيْدِهِ، وَأَمَرَهَا أَنْ
تَقِفَ مُسْتَسْلِمَةً لِأَمْرِهِ، وَجَعَلَ
شَمْسَهَا آيَةً مُبْصِرَةً لِنَهَارِهَا، وَقَمَرَهَا
آيَةً مُمَحِّوَةً مِنْ لَيْلِهَا، وَأَجْرَاهُمَا فِي
مَنَاقِلٍ مَجْرَاهُمَا، وَقَدَّرَ سَيْرَهُمَا فِي
مَدَارِجِ دَرَجَتِهِمَا، لِيُمَيِّزَ بَيْنَ اللَّيْلِ
وَالنَّهَارِ بِهِمَا، وَلِيُعْلَمَ عَدْدُ السِّنِينَ
وَالْحِسَابُ بِمَقَادِيرِهِمَا، ثُمَّ عَلَّقَ فِي
جَوْهَا فَلَكَهَا، وَنَاطَ بِهَا زِيَّتَهَا مِنْ
خَفِيَّاتِ دَرَارِيْهَا وَمَصَابِيحِ
كَوَاكِبِهَا، وَرَمَى مُسْتَرْقِي السَّمْعِ
بِنَوَاقِبِ شُهُبِهَا، وَأَجْرَاهَا عَلَى أَذْلالِ
تَسْخِيرِهَا، مِنْ تَبَاتٍ

the ascending, the ominous and the felicitous. ثَابِتَهَا وَمَسِيرَ سَائِرِهَا، وَهَبُوطَهَا
وَصُغُودَهَا، وَنُحُوسَهَا وَسُغُودَهَا.

Such was the beginning of His creation *that He perfected, and He initiated and fashioned them as He willed*. This final phrase is actually a clear conclusion that the Imām draws after all that he described. He says the creation that Allāh has made based on His knowledge and wisdom is indeed wondrous and perfect (N).

10 The Imām continues speaking about the amazing creation of Allāh, providing details and expounding in depth how the cosmos was created. The phrase *He arranged, without any suspension, the elevations of its spaces* echoes what the Qurʾān states: *It is Allāh who raised the heavens without any pillars that you see...* (Q13:2). Today, astronomers confirm that celestial bodies like planets maintain a distance from each other and retain their respective positions through invisible forces like gravity. Hence, no physical suspension or pillar has been used. The term ‘*rahawāt*’, which is the plural of *rahwah*, has different meanings. It could mean open space (N), or an elevated or lowly place – it could refer to either of these two opposites (R). Some commentators have understood this phrase to mean that the heavens were initially unorganized, with some parts thereof higher and others lower, so the Glorified Lord arranged them into a single expanse with His power, without employing any suspension (I). However, this explanation has been rejected by other commentators who say that firstly, the creation of Allāh is not like that of human beings so as to be unorganized at first and then put right. Secondly, this explanation would entail interpreting the term ‘*rahawāt*’ with two opposite meanings (high and low) at the same time, which is logically and linguistically incorrect (T).

He joined the clefts of its fissures, meaning he connected the parts of each body together, forming a whole, *and attached them to their pairs* by placing the forces of attraction and repulsion between similar celestial bodies, keeping their distance constant thereby (Z). One commentator suggested that the term ‘*azwāj*’ here refers to their spirits (*nufūs*), namely heavenly angels (M), but this interpretation was refuted by al-Majlisī who, quoting from al-Sayyid al-Murtadā, said that there is a consensus among Muslims that celestial bodies are non-sentient. However, he added, it is possible that it may refer to the angels who have been tasked with

overseeing the functions of celestial bodies (T). The Imām then states that the pathways of ascent and descent were opened up and made easy for the angels to traverse as they perform their functions of descending *with His command* and ascending *with the deeds of His creatures*. Are angels material beings so as to be described as descending and ascending from and to the heavens, or is this a metaphorical or spiritual descent and ascent? Commentators have offered different opinions regarding this. However, that which accords with the apparent meaning of the above statement, as well as numerous other narrations and even the verses of the Glorious Qurʾān, is that angels are subtle beings of light that also have a material aspect, though their subtlety prevents us from being able to see them. As such, it is possible to apply actions like ascension and descent, or coming and going, to them (N).

The cosmos was a smoky vapour (*‘dukhān’*) when the Almighty called out to it. This early state of creation is alluded to in the verse: *Then He turned to the heaven while it was smoke, and He said to it and to the earth, “Come, willingly or unwillingly!” They both said, “We come willingly”* (Q41:11). The phrase *“urā ash-rājiḥā”* literally means the handles of its crevices, and here it connotes the edges of the fissures and gaps in the cosmos that were coalesced and sealed as a result of its being compacted by a divine command. It is as though these crevices had something akin to handles of a box that are interlocked together so as to keep it closed shut (N). The verb *‘fataqa’* means to rip or rent open, and the sealed doors (*‘ṣawāmiṭa abwābiḥā’*) that were opened up in this way refer to heavenly gates, as the Qurʾān states regarding those who deny the signs of Allāh: *the gates of heaven will not be opened for them...* (Q7:40). The statement could thus be referring to the creation of doors by splitting up a single expanse, or to opening up the doors that were already created along with the initial creation. And it is through these gates or doors that the angels pass when descending or ascending with the deeds of the servants or their supplications and their souls (MB). Some commentators interpret it figuratively as the opening up of the doors of mercy upon creation (M).

Regarding the placement of *blazing sentinels* (*‘raṣadan min al-shuhub al-thawāqib’*) in its pathways (*‘niqābiḥā’*), commentators have differing views. Some consider it to be a reference to the verses of the Qurʾān that speak of this, such as the statement of the jinn: *Indeed we reached out for Heaven, but found it filled with fierce sentries and flaming stars. We used to sit in some [hiding] places thereof to eavesdrop, but whoever listens now finds a flaming star lying in wait for him* (Q72:8-

9) (I). Others understand it metaphorically and try and posit a scientific explanation of the phrase, saying that it refers to something different from what has been mentioned in the Qur'ān (Z). One commentator notes that the sentinels mentioned in the Qur'ān have been tasked with repelling the jinn, and that came into effect after the birth of the Noble Prophet (ṣ), as per what we find in the traditions. On the other hand, what the Imām is saying here pertains to the beginning of creation, so these sentinels were present right from the beginning. In order to resolve this apparent contradiction, he suggests it is possible that the sentinels would always repel the Shayāṭīn, but after the birth of the Messenger of Allāh, their repulsion became more intense (T). To prevent *it from quaking in the vastness of space*, He held the universe *with His hands* ('*bi aydih*'), ordering it to *remain stationary in compliance with His command*. Of course, the mention of His hands is meant allegorically, and in some commentaries the 'holding' of the universe in this manner is interpreted in scientific terms to refer to certain forces like that of gravity, which keep things stable and steady; and this is what the ending phrase '*His command*' refers to (N). Indeed, the Qur'ān also mentions this in the verse: *Verily Allāh upholds the heavens and the earth lest they fall apart; and were they to fall apart, none would [be able to] uphold them after Him; indeed He is Forbearing, Oft-Forgiving* (Q35:41).

The sun was made a *lightsome sign* ('*āyatan mubṣīratan*') of daytime while the moon, an *effacing sign* ('*āyatan mamḥūwwatan*') of the night. This statement is derived from the verse: *We made the night and the day two signs. Then We effaced the sign of the night and made the sign of the day [clearly] bright...* (Q17:12). The effacement of the moon could refer to how part of it becomes dark in some of its phases, or to the fact that it's light is generally dimmer than that of the sun (MB). The regulated movement of these two celestial bodies *within their orbits* enables people to refer to them to distinguish between night and day, and also to *know the numbering of years and the reckoning [of time]* (Q17:12). In their discussion on these lines of the sermon, some commentators recount the narration of Mufaḍḍal ibn 'Umar wherein Imām al-Ṣādiq describes to him the details about the functions of the sun and moon, and they also mention some traditions in which the Infallibles would address the sun or the moon directly (T). The statement *He suspended in its expanse its firmament* connotes the suspension of each celestial body in its specific orbit. Were one to ask: did the Imām not earlier state that these arrangements were *without any suspension*? The response is that the suspension negated by the

Imām refers to one celestial body being suspended through a link to another body above it, whereas here he is saying that the firmament is suspended by the will of Allāh in the expanse of space. Hence, there is no contradiction (M).

The verb '*nāṭa*' means to attach or hang something, and here it describes the positioning of an adornment of stars, like *small gleaming pearls and brightly shining lamps*. The phrase '*khafīyyāt darāriyyihā*' refers to small stars whereas the larger stars are described as luminously bright lamps (Z). These celestial bodies perform various functions, such as brightening the night sky and guiding travellers (Q6:97). Blazing meteors with piercing flames shoot at eavesdropping devils as mentioned earlier in this sermon, and repeated again here. Some have opined that this repetition is because at times meteors look like shooting stars to people on earth, hence the Imām mentioned it again along with his description of the stars (N). Finally in this section, the he speaks about the specific path that is submissively followed by these celestial objects, as they move in a particular orbit. This an allusion to the verse: [*He created*] *the sun, the moon, and the stars, [all of them] disposed by His command...* (Q7:54) (MB). The *descending and the ascending* of stars has been interpreted as their falling and rising, as per what is seen by the people on earth, not an actual descent or ascent. The *ominous* stars are those from which meteoroids break off and fall to earth, thereby causing some destruction, whereas the *felicitous* ones are those that afford some benefit like giving light, showing direction, etc. It is clear that these last terms do not connote foreboding through the stars, as the Imām had forbidden that explicitly elsewhere (Z).

11 In this part of the sermon, Imām 'Alī talks about angels. Speaking about the angels and jinn entails talking about the unseen (*al-ghayb*), and belief in the unseen stems from the heart, no empirical evidence can be provided therefor. As for the intellect, it does not reject the unseen as long as a rational possibility for it exists in essence. The Qur'ān underscores belief in the unseen as an essential component of faith, and it is evident that the Imām is addressing this sermon to those who believe in the unseen. As for those who deny it, he speaks to them using the logic of that which can be perceived by the senses, as noted in his other orations (Z). Observing the exquisite literary elegance and contents of this section, Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd remarks that this 'godly speech' (*al-kalām al-rabbānī*) voids all the eloquence of the Arabs (I). Some commentators quote the narration about the ascension (*mi'rāj*) of the Messenger of Allāh as a preamble to their commentaries

DESCRIBING THE ANGELS

11 Then, to inhabit His heavens and populate the higher strata of His dominion, He created a novel creation, that is, His angels. With them, He filled its vacuous gaps and occupied the vastness of its space. Between the voids of these vacuities resound the trills of the glorifiers among them, in the hallowed sanctums, [behind] the veiling curtains and the screens of glory. And beyond that reverberation by which the ears are deafened, there are beams of effulgent light that dazzle all sight from beholding it; so it stands, having been held back bewildered, at its boundary.

12 He created them in different forms and with varied characteristics, each having [pairs of] wings. They glorify the majesty of His grandeur. They neither arrogate to themselves what is manifested in the world of His creation, nor do they claim to create anything with Him that He alone made. Rather they are but honoured servants. They do not precede Him in speech, and they act [only] according to His command.

ومنها في صفة الملائكة

١١ ثُمَّ خَلَقَ شُبْحَانَهُ لِإِسْكَانِ سَمَآوَاتِهِ،
وَعِمَارَةِ الصَّافِيحِ الْأَعْلَى مِنْ
مَلَكَوْتِهِ، خَلَقًا بَدِيعًا مِنْ مَلَائِكَتِهِ،
وَمَلَأَ بِهِمْ فُرُوجَ فَجَاجِهَا، وَحَشَا
بِهِمْ قُتُوقَ أَجْوَانِهَا، وَبَيْنَ فَجَوَاتِ
تِلْكَ الْفُرُوجِ رَجُلُ الْمُسَبِّحِينَ
مِنْهُمْ، فِي حَظَائِرِ الْقُدُسِ، وَسُتُورَاتِ
الْحُجُبِ، وَسُرَادِقَاتِ الْمَجْدِ؛ وَوَرَاءَ
ذَلِكَ الرَّجِيجِ الَّذِي تَشْتَكُّ مِنْهُ
الْأَسْمَاعُ سُبْحَاتٍ تُورِ تَزْدَعُ الْأَبْصَارَ
عَنْ بُلُوغِهَا، فَتَقِفُ حَاسِيَةً عَلَى
حُدُودِهَا.

١٢ وَأَنْشَأَهُمْ عَلَى صُورٍ مُخْتَلِفَاتٍ،
وَأَقْدَارٍ مُتَفَاوِتَاتٍ، أُولَى أَجْنَحَةٍ،
تُسَبِّحُ جَلَالَ عِزَّتِهِ، لَا يَنْتَحِلُونَ مَا
ظَهَرَ فِي الْخَلْقِ مِنْ صُنْعِهِ، وَلَا
يَدْعُونَ أَنَّهُمْ يَخْلُقُونَ شَيْئًا مَعَهُ مِمَّا
انْفَرَدَ بِهِ، «بَلْ عِبَادٌ مُكْرَمُونَ لَا
يَسْبِقُونَهُ بِالْقَوْلِ وَهُمْ بِأَمْرِهِ
يَعْمَلُونَ».

on this section, describing the various angels he encountered on his heavenly journey (R). The Imām says that Allāh created angels as a novel creation, making

them inhabit the heavens *and populate the higher strata of His dominion*. The term '*al-ṣafīḥ al-a'lā*' is said to be one of the names of the heavens (T), or something higher than that (R). The conjunction '*thumma*' at the beginning of the sentence could either mean that the angels were created after the heavens and celestial bodies, or it could simply connote subsequence in speech (*ta'khīr al-bayān*), and some commentators consider the latter to be more correct (N). The statement *He filled its vacuous gaps and occupied the vastness of its space* connotes that the heavens are filled with angels. The fact that they inhabit and occupy that space also hints at their corporeality, as is evinced by numerous traditions (MB). The sound of the angels' glorification and worship is heard *between the voids of these vacuities*. The term '*zajal*' generally means loud voice or sound and is used to describe the trill of the glorifying angels as they praise their Lord and worship Him in the *hallowed sanctums* ('*ḥazā'ir al-qudus*').

The term '*ḥazā'ir*' comes from *ḥazr* which means forbidden or restricted, and it has been thus named here because entry into the *hallowed sanctums* is forbidden to the devils (*shayāṭīn*) (T). They are located behind *veiling curtains* which separate the angels from other creatures, and *screens of glory* where there is no disbelief, sin, injustice, corruption, ignorance, or deficiency (Z). However, this does not necessarily mean that the angels have attained the pinnacle of cognizance of Allāh, for subsequently the Imām describes a certain light that dazzles their sights and they are unable to look at it. Hence we are told that beyond the deafening reverberation ('*al-rajj alladhī tastakku minhu al-asmā'*) of the angel's glorifications, there is a light so radiant that even the angels cannot behold. Alternatively it could be a metaphor which means that despite their closeness to Him, the angels can still not know the Essence of Allāh (N). The phrase *having been held back bewildered* ('*fataqifu khāsi'atan*') is similar to what is mentioned in the verse: *...your sight will return to you bewildered while it is wearied* (Q67:4), and *at its boundary* means that it stops where its ability ends, because the faculty of sight is limited and it is not possible to see anything beyond its limit (I).

12 The angels were created *in different forms and with varied characteristics, each having [pairs of] wings*. Some commentators understand this to be figurative, meaning that angels are of diverse ranks in terms of their perfection and closeness to the Almighty, and 'wings' here represents the faculties by which they attain cognizance of Allāh (M). Indeed, when we turn to the verse: *All praise is for Allāh, Originator of the heavens and the earth, Appointer of the angels as messengers,*

possessing wings, two, three, or four... (Q35:1), we find that some exegetes have likewise offered a figurative reading of the term ‘wings’. However, some commentators reject such a metaphorical interpretation and say that there is no proof or reason for such a construal. Rather, the Imām’s statement means that angles were created with different forms, such that some resemble humans, others resemble certain animals like the lion, and some of them possess actual wings. As for their *varied characteristics*, it means that some are tall and others short, some are small and others large, etc. A tradition from Imām al-Šādiq mentions these different qualities of the angels, noting that the Noble Messenger saw their varied forms during his ascension (MB). *They glorify the majesty of His grandeur* is a reflection of the verse: *...those who are with your Lord glorify Him night and day, and they never weary* (Q41:38) (T).

They neither arrogate to themselves what is manifested in the world of His creation, meaning they never assert that they are divine beings, even though some humans made such assertions regarding them (I), *nor do they claim to create anything with Him that He alone made* thereby falsely alleging partnership with Him. *Rather they are but honoured servants. They do not precede Him in speech, and they act [only] according to His command* (Q21:26-7). They never act ostentatiously and never fabricate lies about themselves; they are created servants who obey every command of Allāh (Z). And complete, unquestioning obedience is what is meant by not preceding Him in speech. Some exegetes say that the reason angels are described as *honoured* is the excellence of their servitude to Allāh. Indeed, all intelligent beings are servants of the Almighty, but the angels are specifically referred to as servants because they find it an honour for themselves to serve Allāh and do not see themselves as anything other than His servants. The difference between honour among angels and humankind is that honour has to be earned by human beings but not by angels.

13 He made them *the trustees of His revelation* so it is impossible for them to act perfidiously regarding it. He selected some of them to send *to the Prophets, bearing His commands and prohibitions* as mentioned in the verse: *Allāh chooses messengers from among the angels and from among humankind; verily Allāh is Hearing, Seeing* (Q22:75). He safeguarded them *from the uncertainty of doubts* (‘*rayb al-shubuhāt*’) so they do not have any misgiving about what Allāh commands or forbids them (Z). Therefore *none among them strays from the path of [seeking] His pleasure*. This quality is general and applies to all the angels, as

13 Allāh made them, in their respective positions, the trustees of His revelation and sent them to the Prophets bearing His commands and prohibitions. He safeguarded them from the uncertainty of doubts, so none among them strays from the path of [seeking] His pleasure. He provided them with the benefits of divine succour and filled their hearts with humility and tranquil submission. He opened for them the accessible doors to His glorification and fixed for them clear beacons upon signposts of His Oneness. The burdens of sin do not weigh them down and the succession of nights and days do not alter them. The arrow of doubts cannot pierce the armour of their unshakable faith and misgivings do not swarm the bases of their certitude. The flame of malice does not burn between them, and perplexity does not dispossess them of their cognizance of Him that is etched in their inner consciences, or of His greatness and the awe of His glory that resides within their breasts. The whispering devils have no hope of influencing them so as to cast their filth upon their thoughts.

١٣ جَعَلَهُمُ اللَّهُ فِيمَا هُنَالِكَ أَهْلَ الْأَمَانَةِ عَلَى وَحْيِهِ، وَحَمَلَهُمُ إِلَى الْمُرْسَلِينَ وَدَائِعَ أَمْرِهِ وَنَهْيِهِ، وَعَصَمَهُمُ مِنْ رَيْبِ الشُّبُهَاتِ، فَمَا مِنْهُمْ رَائِعٌ عَنْ سَبِيلِ مَرْضَاتِهِ، وَأَمَدَّهُمْ بِفَوَائِدِ الْمُعُونَةِ، وَأَشْعَرَ قُلُوبَهُمْ تَوَاضُعَ إِحْبَابِ السَّكِينَةِ، وَفَتَحَ لَهُمْ أَبْوَاباً دُلَّالاً إِلَى تَمَاجِيدِهِ، وَنَصَبَ لَهُمْ مَنَاراً وَاضِحَةً عَلَى أَعْلَامِ تَوْحِيدِهِ، لَمْ تُثْقِلْهُمْ مُؤْصِرَاتُ الْأَثَامِ، وَلَمْ تَزَحْجِلْهُمْ عُقْبُ اللَّيَالِي وَالْأَيَّامِ، وَلَمْ تَرْمِ الشُّكُوكُ بِنَوَازِعِهَا عَزِيمَةَ إِيْمَانِهِمْ، وَلَمْ تَعْتَرِكِ الظُّنُونُ عَلَى مَعَاقِدِ بَيِّنَتِهِمْ، وَلَا قَدَحَتْ قَادِحَهُ الْإِحْنِ فِيمَا بَيْنَهُمْ، وَلَا سَلَبَتْهُمْ الْحَيْرَةَ مَا لَاقَ مِنْ مَعْرِفَتِهِ بِضَمَائِرِهِمْ، وَمَا سَكَنَ مِنْ عَظَمَتِهِ وَهَيْبَةِ جَلَالَتِهِ فِي أَثْنَاءِ صُدُورِهِمْ، وَلَمْ تَطْمَعْ فِيهِمُ الْوَسَاوِسُ فَتَقْتَرِعَ بِرَيْنِهَا عَلَى فِكْرِهِمْ.

they are protected from doubt and error that stems from the opposition of the base self to the intellect, since they do not have a base self and would not therefore stray from the path of obedience to Allāh (MB). They have been provided *benefits of divine succour* ('*fawā'id al-ma'ūnah*'), or according to one commentator, it should read "*awā'id al-ma'ūnah*" which gives the same meaning but is more correct here

(T). He *filled their hearts with humility and tranquil submission*. The term *'ikhbāt'* connotes humility (R), and this statement means that angels are always in a state of servile submission to their Lord. *The accessible doors* (*'abwāban dhulula'*) of glorification were opened for them, meaning that it was made easy for them to praise and glorify their Creator, and this is a metaphor for their being inspired to glorify Him (MB). As for the fixing of clear beacons *upon signposts of His Oneness*, it connotes ingraining the understanding of *tawhīd* in their intrinsic nature (M), so they are never in doubt about it (T).

The burdens of sin do not weigh them down since there is no way for angels to sin, and neither is there any reason to do so, for in the realm of angels where neither wealth, authority, desire, nor caprice exist, there is nothing but worship of the Almighty. They undergo no change through *the succession of nights and days* and are not altered thereby. So there is no aging, frailty, sickness, or pain among angels even with the passage of time. And how would there be any of this when there is no food, drink, or copulation among them? (Z). The phrase *'lam tartaḥilhum'* literally means that they are not made to travel forward or depart from where they are by the passing of days and nights, the way human beings do (T). The faith of angels is unshakable and the arrows of suspicion and doubt cannot move them. The term *'nawāzī'* comes from *naz'* which literally means pulling back the bowstring to shoot an arrow. *"Azīmata imānihim"* is rendered *the armour of their unshakable faith*, and it connotes the firmness and strength of their belief (N). The verb *'taṭarik'* means to teem, congest, or swarm, and here it signifies that presumptions or misgivings (*'zunūn'*) do not assail the firm conviction of the angels (R). The phrase *'qādiḥat al-ihn'* has been translated *the flame of malice*, and this is how most commentators have understood it. However, some have interpreted the phrase to mean 'the cankerworms of malice' since that is another meaning of the term *qādiḥah* (T). In any case, the connotation remains the same: there is no rancour, jealousy, or malice between angels. Perplexity does not plague them, since being perplexed means experiencing a state of confusion between two matters, and not knowing which one to choose or prioritize over the other. It occurs when one's whims or imagination contradict his intellect, and since angels do not suffer from this, *perplexity does not dispossess them of their cognizance of Him* (MB). Indeed, it is something that is *etched in their inner consciences* (*lāqa biḍamāirihim*) and cannot be purged therefrom, just as the cognizance of *His greatness and the awe of His glory that resides within their breasts* cannot be removed

14 Among them are those who are in the heavy rain clouds, on the peaks of lofty mountains, and in the depths of pitch darkness. And among them are those whose feet have pierced through the lowest stratum of the earth, so they are like white ensigns that have penetrated the fissures in the atmosphere. Under them blows a gentle breeze which restrains them in the same position they attain up to the extreme edge. Being occupied with His worship has freed them from other concerns, and the realities of faith have created a link between them and cognizance of Him. Their conviction in Him has made them deeply enthralled by Him, and their longing never goes beyond what is with Him to what is with others.

۱۴ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ هُوَ فِي حَلْقِ الْعَمَامِ الدُّلْحِ، وَفِي عِظَمِ الْجِبَالِ الشُّمَخِ، وَفِي قَسْرَةِ الظَّلَامِ الْأَيْهَمِ. وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ قَدْ حَرَقَتْ أَقْدَامُهُمْ تُحُومَ الْأَرْضِ السُّفْلَى، فَهِيَ كَرَايَاتٍ بَيْضٍ قَدْ نَفَذَتْ فِي مَخَارِقِ الْهَوَاءِ، وَتَحْتَهَا رِيحٌ هَفَافَةٌ تَحْبِسُهَا عَلَى حَيْثُ انْتَهَتْ مِنَ الْحُدُودِ الْمُتَنَاهِيَةِ، قَدْ اسْتَفْرَعَتْهُمْ أَشْغَالُ عِبَادَتِهِ، وَوَصَلَتْ حَقَائِقُ الْإِيمَانِ بَيْنَهُمْ وَبَيْنَ مَعْرِفَتِهِ، وَقَطَعَهُمُ الْإِيقَانُ بِهِ إِلَى الْوَلَةِ إِلَيْهِ، وَلَمْ تُجَاوِزْ رَغْبَتُهُمْ مَا عِنْدَهُ إِلَى مَا عِنْدَ غَيْرِهِ.

(M). The term '*al-wasāwis*' refers to the creatures of evil whisperings (*ulū al-waswās*), namely the devils (*al-shayāṭīn*), and they have been referred to in this manner as a hyperbole (R). '*Rayn*' literally refers to rust, or any kind of filth or pollution that covers something. Here it connotes the evil insinuations of the devils which cannot affect the thoughts of angels in any way. Some commentators say that the more correct version reads '*bi raybiḥā*' rather than '*bi rayniḥā*', in which case it would be translated as *by their doubts*, meaning the devils are not able to cast doubts in their minds as they do with human beings (T).

14 Some among the angels are *in the heavy rain clouds*, while others are *on the peaks of lofty mountains, and in the depths of pitch darkness*. Some commentators interpret the phrase '*fī khalq al-ghamām*' to mean that some of the angels are created in a form similar to that of clouds (T, Z). The adjective '*al-dullah*' means heavy or laden (R), so the clouds being described are heavy rain clouds. Another interpretation is that these angels are positioned within such clouds as they are

the ones responsible for rainfall and movement of the clouds, as mentioned in the verse: *those who drive [away] repellingly* (Q37:2). Ibn ‘Abbās is reported to have said that this verse refers to the angels who are in charge of the rain clouds (MB). Alternatively, these are angels who play a role in the creation of such clouds, by the command of Allāh (N). Whichever of these three meanings is accepted, it also applies to those angels that are *on the peaks of lofty mountains* as well as those who are *in the depths of pitch darkness*. The phrase ‘*qatrat al-ḡalām*’ means its intense darkness, and ‘*al-ihām*’ is that wherein one cannot find his way (I), as is the case in a pitch dark night (Z). It is possible that some angels live in this kind of total darkness in order to guide and protect those who fall into it (MB).

The feet of some angels *have pierced through the lowest stratum of the earth*, as mentioned in the first sermon where he said: *Others among them have feet that rest firmly on the lowest regions of the earth*. Evidently this description depicts the largeness in size of certain angels, and it may be that these statements are figurative and underscore the great rank of certain angels (N). Some commentators say that their ‘feet’ actually represent their knowledge of all that transpires even in the lowest depths of the earth (M). Their comparison to *white ensigns that have penetrated the fissures in the atmosphere* could be representative of two things: firstly, white has been used since it generally signifies cleanliness from filth, so it might mean that their knowledge is free from any kind of falsehood or doubt. Secondly, the penetration of ensigns may symbolize the acuteness of their knowledge which pierces the known world. However, this is if we go beyond the apparent meaning (MB). On the other hand, the apparent meaning is simply that there are certain angels who are so large that they span from the highest levels of the heavens until the lowest strata of the earth; and some commentators say that there is no reason at all to interpret this metaphorically (Z). The similitude continues by stating that under these ensigns, there blows *a gentle breeze which restrains them in the same position*, keeping the flag-like signs straight in the air, the way a flag would remain flying if the right amount of wind blows it, keeping it horizontal until its very edge (I). Since they are *occupied with His worship*, the angels are free from any other concerns and do not engage in any other activities. As a result, *the realities of faith have created a link between them and cognizance of Him* due to their continuous worship (N).

The phrase ‘*ḥaqāiq al-īmān*’ refers to deep conviction which truly deserves to be called ‘faith’, or to the clear evidence that leads to such conviction. It creates a

link between the angels and their cognizance of Allāh because conviction in the existence of a thing that one must attain is the strongest motivation that would impel one to seek it out; so faith and conviction in His presence joins them to cognizance of Him and acts as a means for them to attain closeness to Him (MB). Through this cognizance, they attain a sense of joy, bliss, and felicity, such that their certitude ('*al-īqān*') causes them to be *deeply enthralled by Him*. Hence, their deep faith turns them away from everything other than Allāh, who is their primary and only focus (Z). Then *their longing never goes beyond what is with Him to what is with others*, as they hope or desire only for what is with Allāh.

15 Continuing his phenomenal description of the angels, the Imām states that *they have tasted the sweetness of the ma'rifah of Allāh and have drunk from the quenching cup of His love*. Knowledge generally has a certain flavour for its seekers, and in particular, knowledge about the Creator has a unique and sweet taste. The angels tasted the sweetness of this knowledge and it penetrated the fibre of their being, and imbued them with a deep sense of love for Him and fearful awe of Him at the same time, thereby leading them to glorify and worship Him (Z). That is why the Imām says *the roots of His fear have been implanted in the depth of their hearts. As a result, they have bent their straight backs through prolonged worship*. Some commentators suggest that in a way, by saying this, Imām 'Alī seeks to encourage his listeners to be more like angels in their quest for knowing and loving Allāh, so as to become His sincere servants (N). The phrase '*suwaydā' qulūbihim*' refers to the core or the inner part of their hearts, and the term '*washjāh*' literally means roots of a tree, and here it is used figuratively to depict how deep their fear and awe is (I). Neither does their *excessive yearning* for Him reduce their entreaties, nor does extreme nearness to Him release them *from the tethers of their awe*. '*Ṭūl al-raqhbah*' literally means prolonged yearning and refers to their endless longing for Him, which does not reduce their petitions to Him. Among human beings, on the other hand, it is seen how when one yearns for something and desires to attain it by petitioning someone else and beseeching him for it, if this carries on for a long time without him getting what he yearns for, he becomes weary and the reasons that propelled him to desire that thing slowly begin fading away, until such a time that he no longer begs for it or even seeks it out. However, such a state does not overcome the angels, and their yearning for Allāh continues with the same fervour (MB). Likewise, their nearness to Him has not prevented them from freeing their lowered necks from the noose of utter humility before their Lord.

15 They have tasted the sweetness of His recognition and have drunk from the quenching cup of His love. The roots of His fear have been implanted in the depth of their hearts. As a result, they have bent their straight backs through prolonged worship. [Their] protracted yearning of Him has not reduced their entreaties, and extreme nearness [to Him] has not released them from the tethers of their awe. They are never overcome by self-admiration such as to deem their past deeds as great, and submissiveness brought about by veneration [of Him] leaves no room for them to esteem their own virtues. They remain unaffected by lassitude throughout their exertions, and their longing [for Him] does not diminish so as to turn them away from hope in their Lord. Neither do the tips of their tongues become dry due to prolonged invocations, nor are they preoccupied by other matters such that their [raised] voices of supplication to Him are silenced. Their shoulders are never misaligned as they stand [together] in worship, and they turn not their necks to the comfort of nonfeasance with respect to His command. Neither do the follies of negligence impinge on their resolve to strive, nor do the deceptions of desire impede their determination.

١٥ قَدْ ذَاقُوا حَلَاوَةَ مَعْرِفَتِهِ، وَشَرِبُوا
بِالْكَأْسِ الرَّوِيَّةِ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِهِ،
وَتَمَكَّنَتْ مِنْ سُودَاءِ قُلُوبِهِمْ
وَشَيْجَتُهُ خِيفَتُهُ، فَحَنَوْا بِطُولِ الطَّاعَةِ
اعْتِدَالَ ظُهُورِهِمْ، وَلَمْ يُنْفِدْ طَوْلُ
الرَّغْبَةِ إِلَيْهِ مَادَّةَ تَضَرُّعِهِمْ، وَلَا
أُطْلِقَ عَنْهُمْ عَظِيمُ الرُّلْفَةِ رِبْقَ
خُشُوعِهِمْ، وَلَمْ يَتَوَلَّاهُمُ الْإِعْجَابُ
فَيَسْتَكْثِرُوا مَا سَلَفَ مِنْهُمْ، وَلَا
تَرَكَتْ لَهُمْ اسْتِكَانَةُ الْإِجْلَالِ نَصِيئًا
فِي تَعْظِيمِ حَسَنَاتِهِمْ، وَلَمْ تَجْرِ
الْفَتَرَاتُ فِيهِمْ عَلَى طَوْلِ دُؤُوبِهِمْ،
وَلَمْ تَغْضُ رَغْبَاتُهُمْ فَيُحَالِفُوا عَنْ
رَجَاءِ رَبِّهِمْ، وَلَمْ تَجِفْ لِطَوْلِ
الْمُنَاجَاةِ أَسَالَتُ أَلْسِنَتِهِمْ، وَلَا
مَلَكَتُهُمُ الْأَشْغَالُ فَتَنْقَطِعَ بِهِمْ
الْجَوَارِ إِلَيْهِ أَصْوَاتُهُمْ، وَلَمْ تَحْتَلِفْ
فِي مَقَاوِمِ الطَّاعَةِ مَنَاقِبُهُمْ، وَلَمْ
يُثْنُوا إِلَى رَاحَةِ التَّقْصِيرِ فِي أَمْرِهِ
رِقَابُهُمْ؛ وَلَا تَعْدُو عَلَى عَزِيمَةِ
جَدِّهِمْ بِلَادَةُ الْغَفْلَاتِ، وَلَا تَتَفَضَّلُ
فِي هِمَمِهِمْ حَدَائِقُ الشَّهَوَاتِ.

Contrarily, when human beings become closer to kings and rulers in this world, their confidence increases and the awe they feel in the presence of the ruler reduces. This is partly because people know that positions of leadership in this world are temporary and eventually come to an end, so it is not impossible to envision oneself in a position of power that is currently occupied by another. However, the authority of Allāh is perpetual and unending, as is His omnipotence and omniscience, so one who is close to Him never finds his awe of Him diminished in any way (M). Unlike some individuals in this world, angels are *never overcome by self-admiration such as to deem their past deeds as great*. Angels are free from such a flaw, and that is why the narration found in al-Ṣadūq's *Thawāb al-A'māl wa Iqāb al-A'māl* is deemed weak. In it we are told how one angel was given the task of creating seven heavens and seven earths, and after he had done so, he felt a sense of pride in his work thinking, "Who can be like me?" So Allāh sent a tiny spark of fire to the angel, who tried to counter it with all that he had created but it was all destroyed, until the fire reached the angel because of the self-admiration he had felt (T).

Their submissive veneration of their Lord *leaves no room for them to esteem their own virtues*. No matter how much they worship Allāh, they never consider it to be something great, and their humility prevents them from feeling proud of their past worship, or considering it to be plentiful. Their focused veneration of the Creator precludes any such thought in them (MB). Throughout their lengthy exertions ('*tūli dū'ūbihim*'), they *remain unaffected by lassitude*, and neither do they get tired of their continual worship, nor is there the slightest change in the resoluteness of their intention (M). This is clearly stated in the verse: *They glorify [Him] night and day, never slackening* (Q21:20). Likewise, their longing for Him *does not diminish so as to turn them away from hope in their Lord*, because their love and desire for the ultimate perfection is persistent, and their knowledge of the greatness of their Lord is always increasing. As such, there is nothing that could cause them to become negligent of His worship or to have their hope in Him dwindle (N). The tips of their tongues do not turn dry due to prolonged invocations. The term '*asalāt*' refers to the sides and tip of the tongue (I). Some commentators interpret this to mean that they do not suffer fatigue in their invocations as human beings do, nor do their tongues dry up the way our tongues do (MB). Others take it to be a metaphor for their lack of weariness due to continual invocation (N). Nothing else distracts the angels such as to cause their

voices of supplication to Him to be silenced. Neither does worship tire them out, resulting in their voices being lowered, nor are they diverted by other preoccupations leading to the same result (M).

The term '*hams*' connotes a soft voice (R), and '*al-ju'ār*' means invocation or beseeching (T). Some commentators say that the term '*al-ju'ār*' refers to a loud or audible voice, and here it means that the sound of their voices, supplicating and invoking Allāh, is never reduced to whispers or silence (N). As they stand together in rows, worshipping, their *shoulders are never misaligned*. This means that they stand together for worship as one unit in perfect alignment and harmony (Z). By the statement: *they turn not their necks to the comfort of nonfeasance with respect to His command*, the Imām means that the angels do not raise their necks upwards (T), or turn their necks out of weariness brought on by prolonged worship, towards ease and comfort through reduction of worship or its cessation, thereby falling short in obeying the command of their Lord (MB). Their resolve to strive to please their Creator through worship and obedience is not impinged by *follies of negligence* ('*balādat al-ghafalāt*'), meaning they are not affected by heedlessness in their worship and in carrying out what they have been commanded to do (Z). Moreover, *the deceptions of desire* do not impede their determination, since things like forgetfulness, negligence, and being tempted by base desires ('*al-shahawāt*') applies to creatures with material bodies, and angels are luminous beings that are not affected by such things (M). In one narration from Imām al-Ṣādiq, we are told that a group of angels once condemned humankind for their inclination to desires and pleasures – meaning the lawful ones, not the unlawful – so Allāh cast in those angels the inclination towards desires and pleasures so that they would not fault the believers. When the angels felt that inclination within themselves, they turned to Allāh and sought forgiveness, seeking to be turned back to their previous state. So Allāh returned them to their previous condition (T).

16 *They have taken the Lord of the Throne as a recourse for the day of their need*, which is the Day of Resurrection (Z), or on the day when their souls will be taken (MB). Some say, however, that since angels, and indeed all creatures, need Allāh constantly, every day is a *day of their need* (T). Al-Majlisī opines that it is not far-fetched to assume that angels also get a kind of reward for their worship and obedience, by being granted greater closeness to, and cognizance of, Allāh, or being elevated in their ranks and so on, in which case this line might be referring to the day of their recompense (MB).

16 They have taken the Lord of the Throne as a recourse for the day of their need, and they betake themselves to Him when the creation turn yearningly towards other creatures. They attain not the maximum extent of His worship, and their fondness for His worship does not take them back except to the inner springs of their hearts which are never cut off from hope in Him and fear of Him. The basis of their fear is never terminated such that they might slacken in their efforts, nor are they fettered by cupidity so as to prefer what is easily achieved over their sedulity. They do not aggrandize their past deeds, for if they had considered them great their hope would have expunged from them their fear and trepidation. They do not differ among themselves about their Lord as a result of Satan's prevailing upon them. Estrangement does not disunite them and rancorous mutual envy does not overcome them. They are neither split into factions by [suspicions and] doubts, nor are they divided by varying ambitions. Thus they are captives of faith who are neither released from its fetters by deviation and divergence, nor by laxity and lassitude. There is not the thinnest integument in the celestial strata but that upon it is an angel prostrating or swiftly toiling. By their prolonged worship, they increase in their know-

١٦ قَدْ اتَّخَذُوا ذَا الْعَرْشِ ذَخِيرَةً لِيَوْمِ
فَاقْتَنِهِمْ، وَيَمَّمُوهُ عِنْدَ انْقِطَاعِ الْخَلْقِ
إِلَى الْمَخْلُوقِينَ بِرَغْبَتِهِمْ، لَا
يَقْطَعُونَ أَمَدَ غَايَةِ عِبَادَتِهِ، وَلَا
يَزْجِعُ بِهِمُ الْإِسْتِهْتَارُ بِلُزُومِ طَاعَتِهِ،
إِلَّا إِلَى مَوَادٍّ مِنْ قُلُوبِهِمْ غَيْرِ
مُنْقَطِعَةٍ مِنْ رَجَائِهِ وَمَخَافَتِهِ، لَمْ
تَنْقَطِعْ أَسْبَابُ الشَّفَقَةِ مِنْهُمْ فَيَتَوَا فِي
حَدِّهِمْ، وَلَمْ تَأْسِرْهُمْ الْأَطْمَاعُ
فَيُؤْثِرُوا وَشَيْكَ السَّعْيِ عَلَى
اجْتِهَادِهِمْ؛ لَمْ يَسْتَغْظَمُوا مَا مَضَى
مِنْ أَعْمَالِهِمْ، وَلَوْ اسْتَغْظَمُوا ذَلِكَ
لَنْسَخَ الرِّجَاءِ مِنْهُمْ شَفَقَاتٍ وَجَلِيلِهِمْ،
وَلَمْ يَحْتَلِفُوا فِي رَبِّهِمْ بِاسْتِحْوَاذِ
الشَّيْطَانِ عَلَيْهِمْ، وَلَمْ يُفَرِّقْهُمْ سُوءُ
التَّقَاتُحِ وَلَا تَوَلَّاهُمْ غِلُّ التَّحَاسُدِ،
وَلَا تَسَعَّبَتْهُمْ مَصَارِفُ الرَّيْبِ، وَلَا
اِقْتَسَمَتْهُمْ أَحْيَافُ الْهَمِّ، فَهُمْ
أَسْرَاءُ إِيْمَانٍ لَمْ يُفَكِّهْهُمْ مِنْ رَبِّقَتِهِ
رَيْغٌ وَلَا عُذُولٌ، وَلَا وَئَى وَلَا فُتُورٌ،
وَلَيْسَ فِي أَطْبَاقِ السَّمَاوَاتِ مَوْضِعٌ
إِهَابٍ إِلَّا وَعَلَيْهِ مَلَكٌ سَاجِدٌ أَوْ
سَاحٍ حَافِدٌ، يَزْدَادُونَ عَلَى طُولِ

ledge of their Lord, and veneration of
 their Lord [continually] increases in
 their hearts.

الطَّاعَةِ بِرَبِّهِمْ عِلْمًا، وَتَزْدَادُ عِزَّةً
 رَبِّهِمْ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ عِظَمًا.

The verb 'yammamūhu' means to turn and move towards something or someone (N), and the fact that they *betake themselves to Allāh* while the creation *turn yearningly towards other creatures* shows their trust and reliance upon Allāh as opposed to other creatures who rely on each other (Z). Angels never attain *the maximum extent of His worship* as their journey to perfect their worship of the Almighty never ends, since He is worthy of greater worship than they could ever offer (T). And because the maximum extent of infinite perfection has an infinite number of degrees, so its end can never be reached (M). The term '*istihtār*' connotes a deep fondness for something, to the extent that one does not care what others think about his attachment to it (R). The fondness of the angels for His worship *does not take them back except to the inner springs of their hearts which are never cut off from hope in Him and fear of Him*. This means that the motivation for their worship of Allāh stems from a deep-rooted sense of hope in Allāh and fear of Him, which is a result of their cognizance of Him (N). The basis of their fear is never terminated and its cord is never severed, *such that they might slacken in their efforts*.

The verb 'yanū' means to weaken (I), so the phrase '*fayanū fi jiddihim*' connotes slackening in their seriousness in worship (T). Likewise, they do not become captives of cupidity and avarice *so as to prefer what is easily achieved* ('*washīk al-saī*') in order to quickly attain what they crave of the ephemeral world, as humans do, *over their sedulity* and assiduous efforts in attaining true felicity through proximity to the Creator (MB). Some commentators say that this means the angels do not worship Allāh for the sake of reward; rather, they worship Him to please Him (R). They *do not aggrandize* ('*lam yasta'zimū*') their past deeds and lengthy acts of worship, for if they considered their actions to be great, *their hope would have expunged from them their fear and trepidation*. Since fear and hope need to be equal and balanced for one to earnestly continue his good work, if one overpowers the other, the result would be dereliction and laziness. When one considers his work to be copious and great, the natural result of such a feeling is that his hope would overpower his fear. That is why the angels never aggrandize

their actions (Z). *They do not differ among themselves about their Lord as a result of Satan's prevailing upon them* the way human beings do, so none of them ever attribute anything unworthy to his Lord (T). The implicit meaning of this statement is that all the differences in religious belief among humankind stems primarily from the misguidance of Satan, and this in turn leads to discord, tyranny, and bloodshed, as history attests (N).

They are not disunited out of *estrangement* ('*sū al-taqāṭu*') as their hearts are one and their goal is the same (Z), *and rancorous mutual envy does not overcome them*. This actually summarises the main causes of differences and discord. If people likewise treated each other with respect and were kind in their words to one other, it would go a long way to eliminate ill feelings of rancour and envy or hatred in them (N). Suspicions and doubts do not split them into factions, since as noted earlier, the root cause of doubt is assumption, conjecture, and imagination, and angels are bereft of these (M). The term '*maṣārīf al-rayb*' means different aspects and types of doubt and suspicion that could arise in the mind (MB). The angels are similarly not *divided by varying ambitions*. They all have the same purpose and ambition, namely to obey Allāh and to strive to please Him (Z). Angels are therefore *captives of faith* ('*usarā' imān*'), and they are *neither released from its fetters by deviation and divergence, nor by laxity and lassitude*. Describing them as captives bound by fetters alludes to their steadfastness in adhering to faith, such that nothing can sway them or allow them to detach themselves therefrom (N). The phrase '*mawḍi'ū ihāb*' literally refers to [the width of] a piece of untanned leather (T), and by saying that *there is not the thinnest integument in the celestial strata* ('*aṭbāq al-samāwāt*') *but that upon it is an angel prostrating or swiftly toiling*, the Imām is alluding to the vast number of angels that are present in the universe (Z).

It is reported that Imām al-Ṣādiq was once asked whether there are more angels or humans, so he said that the number of angels in the heavens is greater than the number of grains of sand on earth, and there is no space in the skies where one could step but that there is an angel present there, glorifying and praising Allāh (T). By their prolonged worship, the angels *increase in their knowledge of their Lord*, and at the same time *reverence of their Lord continually increases in their hearts*, which means that there is a progression and development they undergo, moving closer to the All-Perfect by their lengthy worship. Some commentators have suggested that mentioning these qualities of angels is meant to prompt

believers who have cognizance of Allāh to take a lesson and try to adopt some of the angelic traits. Traits such as: [i] lengthy worship, [ii] making no claims of greatness, [iii] remaining humble and tranquil, [iv] being imbued with faith and free from doubt, [v] having no ill feelings towards others, [vi] being in awe of the grandeur of the Creator, [vii] not being occupied by anything that could keep one away from worship, [viii] having more desire for what is with Allāh than what is with other creatures, [ix] drinking from the goblet of love for Allāh, [x] not being afraid of anyone but Allāh, [xi] never considering one's good deeds as great, and [xii] always having hope in Allāh and His mercy (I).

17 In this pericope, the Imām talks about how the earth was spread over the water. While describing the creation of the world, in the first sermon Imām 'Alī said that Allāh initially *made water flow therein, with waves surging, swelling layer upon layer*, and after that He made the heavens and the earth (N). The phrase '*kabasa al-arḍ*' means He made the land enter the water with great force (I), placing it therein with pressure. He thereby spread the earth *on stormy tumultuous waves and deep swelling seas, with its towering waves colliding and its soaring billows crashing, producing a foam like the camel stallion when it is excited*. The terms '*mustafḥilah*', '*zākhirah*', and '*awādhīy*', respectively connote excitement, rising high, and waves [or the uppermost part thereof] (I). Some say the third term refers specifically to huge waves (T). It is possible that words such as 'waves', 'seas', etc. which are used to describe what existed before this world are only similitudes employed to depict something we can relate to (N). Once the weight of the earth came to rest upon the water, its tumult yielded to its heaviness, and *its stirring agitation abated when the earth pressed upon it with its torso, and it was quelled when the earth rubbed down upon it with its withers*. The overall message of these lines is that the waters were tumultuous but placing the heavy earth on them calmed them down (R). The phrase '*idh waṭī'at-hu bi kalkalihā*' is rendered *pressed upon it with its torso* and refers to the entirety of the surface of the earth being pressed upon the waters. Similarly, the phrase '*idh tama'akat alayhi bi kawāhilihā*' is translated *rubbed down upon it with its withers* and describes how the earth was rolled over and rubbed upon the waters with its entire back as it was placed thereupon (T). Hence the water became calm, with its roaring waves having subsided, and *the bridle of servility turned it into a submissive captive* ('*munqādan asīran*'), meaning that as the earth settled upon it, the tumult ended with ease and the seas calmed down (Z).

DESCRIBING THE EARTH AND ITS
SPREADING ON THE WATER

17 He spread the earth on stormy tumultuous waves and deep swelling seas, with its towering waves colliding and its soaring billows crashing, producing a foam like the camel stallion when excited. Thus the tumult of the choppy water yielded to its heavy weight, and its stirring agitation abated when the earth pressed upon it with its torso, and it was quelled when the earth rubbed down upon it with its withers. Thus, it became calm and subdued after the roar of its stormy waves, and the bridle of servility turned it into a submissive captive as the earth settled, spreading itself in the midst of its expansive waves. And it [thus] put an end to its vain hubris and its ascendancy, its haughtiness and its excessiveness, and curbed the intensity of its flow. Thus it subsided after its rapid flux and became still after its blustering surges.

ومنها في صفة الأرض ودحوها على الماء

١٧ كَبَسَ الْأَرْضَ عَلَى مَوْرٍ أَمْوَاجٍ مُسْتَفْجَلَةٍ وَلَجَجَ بِحَارٍ زَاخِرَةٍ، تَلَطَّمُ أَوَاذِي أَمْوَاجِهَا، وَتَضْطَفِقُ مُتَقَادِفَاتٍ أَتْبَاجِهَا، وَتَزْغُو زَبْدًا كَالْمُحْوَلِ عِنْدَ هِيَاجِهَا، فَخَضَعَ جِمَاحُ الْمَاءِ الْمُتَلَاطِمِ لِثِقَلِ حَمْلِهَا، وَسَكَنَ هَيْجُ ارْتِمَائِهِ إِذْ وَطِئَتْهُ بِكُلِّكَلِهَا، وَذَلَّ مُسْتَحْذِيًّا إِذْ تَمَعَّكَتْ عَلَيْهِ بِكَوَاهِلِهَا، فَأَصْبَحَ بَعْدَ اضْطِحَابِ أَمْوَاجِهِ سَاجِيًّا مَقْهُورًا، وَفِي حَكْمَةِ الدَّلِّ مُنْقَادًا أَسِيرًا، وَسَكَنَتِ الْأَرْضُ مَذْحُوءَةً فِي لُجَّةِ تَيَّارِهِ، وَرَدَّتْ مِنْ نَحْوَةِ بَأْوِهِ وَاعْتِلَائِهِ، وَشُمُوخِ أَنْفِهِ وَشُمُوءِ غُلَوَائِهِ، وَكَعَمَّثِهِ عَلَى كِطْلَةِ جَزْيَتِهِ، فَهَمَدَ بَعْدَ نَزَقَاتِهِ، وَلَبَدَ بَعْدَ رَيَقَانِ وَتَبَاتِهِ.

So once the earth spread in the midst of its expansive waves and flowing current, the waters became still and were no longer agitated. A question that could be posed here is: this description seems contrary to the laws of physics, because when a heavy object is placed in still water, it gets agitated and rises, so how could it be that the agitated waters were actually made calm by the heavy earth? The answer given to this by some commentators is that if the water becomes agitated by strong winds, then it is possible for it to be calmed down by a heavy object

which acts as a barrier between it and the wind, and that was the case in this instance, since we note from what was mentioned in the first sermon that it was the wind that brought about tumult in the waters (MB). The figurative depiction of the waters in his statement *it thus put an end to its vain hubris and its ascendancy, its haughtiness and its excessiveness, and curbed the intensity of its flow* is another description of how the waters became calm, as noted in the subsequent phrase *so it subsided after its rapid flux and became still after its blustering surges*.

18 Once the earth was spread upon the water, and it settled, with its tumult having *subsided under its sides*, and lofty mountains were placed upon it, springs of water were made to *gush forth from their elevated peaks*. The adjectives ‘*al-shummakh al-budhdhakh*’ connote very high and lofty peaks (R), though the first of the two terms is considered to be a later addition by some commentators, as it is not found in some manuscripts (T), nor is it in our edition of the text. The reference to ‘shoulders’ of the earth (‘*aktāfihā*’) is metaphorical, and connotes the places upon which the weight of the mountains rest, just as shoulders are usually used by humans and animals to carry weighty loads. Likewise, the phrase “*arānīni unūfihā*’ literally means the bridges of their noses, and here it is used figuratively to refer to the elevated peaks from which water flows (MB). The earth’s movement was then regulated by large boulders and deep mountains which acted as *fixed anchors* (‘*rāsiyāt*’). Thus *its swaying came to a halt* with the penetration of the roots of the mountains *deep into its mantle*. Commentators say that since the word ‘*ḥarakāt*’ is plural, it shows that the earth has different kinds of movements, with some even listing up to eight types of movement (T). Indeed, this reality has been reflected in the Glorious Qur’ān as well. One verse states: *And We placed firm mountains in the earth lest it shake with them* (Q21:31). The term ‘*al-mayadān*’ in this instance refers to the swaying of the earth; and we know that the mountains act as pegs which hold the earth in place and prevent it from shaking. Once the earth was stilled, *a wide space between it and the sky* was created by the Almighty. As for what is meant by ‘*al-jaww*’ here, there are differing views. Some commentators say it means space, but since space has no boundaries as such, it does not seem to be the correct meaning. Perhaps the term is referring to the atmosphere or the levels above it such as the ozone layer, which has to be a certain distance away from the earth in order to ensure that the air on earth is breathable (N). For simplicity, we have translated the term as *sky*. Once there was air *that its inhabitants could breathe*, Allāh brought forth its dwellers,

18 When the excitement of the water had subsided under its sides and it bore the sky-scraping, lofty mountains on its shoulders, He made springs of water gush forth from their elevated peaks and channelled them to its vast plains and furrows. He regulated its movement with fixed anchors of solid boulders and rocky alps with lofty peaks. Then its swaying came to a halt due to the penetration of mountains into parts of its surface and their ingression deep into its mantle, and their mounting the expansive plains of the earth and its crust. He [then] created a wide space between it and the sky, and made air that its inhabitants could breathe. He [then] brought out to it its dwellers, having [prepared for them] all that they would require. Thereafter He did not leave the parched earth which was bereft of water from springs on its elevations and where rivers could not find their way across; rather, He created for it laden clouds which could revive its dead lands and bring forth its vegetation. He joined its clouds after they had separated into scattered cloudlets and detached tufts. Until water started to swirl within the raincloud and lightning began flashing in its linings. The scintillation did not abate in its massive white columns and its cumulous clouds. He sent it down in succession until its peripheries were

١٨ فَلَمَّا سَكَنَ هَيْجُ الْمَاءِ مِنْ تَحْتِ
أَكْتَفَاهَا، وَحَمَلَ شَوَاهِقَ الْجِبَالِ
الْبُذْخَ عَلَى أَكْتَفَاهَا، فَجَرَّ يَنَابِيعَ
الْعُيُونِ مِنْ عَرَانِينِ أُثُوفِهَا، وَفَرَّقَهَا
فِي شُهُوبٍ بِيَدِهَا وَأَخَادِيدِهَا،
وَعَدَّلَ حَرَكَاتِهَا بِالرَّاسِيَّاتِ مِنْ
جَلَامِيدِهَا، وَذَوَاتِ الشَّنَاخِبِ الشَّمِّ
مِنْ صَيَاخِيدِهَا، فَسَكَنْتْ مِنْ
الْمَيَدَانِ لِشُوبِ الْجِبَالِ فِي قِطْعِ
أَدِيمِهَا، وَتَغْلَغَلَهَا مُتَسَرِّبَةً فِي
جُزَيَّاتِ خَيَاشِيمِهَا، وَرُكُوبِهَا أَغْنَاكَ
شُهُولِ الْأَرْضِينَ وَجَرَائِمِهَا، وَفَسَحَ
بَيْنَ الْجَوِّ وَبَيْنَهَا، وَأَعَدَّ الْهَوَاءَ
مُتَسَمًّا لِسَاكِنِهَا، وَأَخْرَجَ إِلَيْهَا أَهْلَهَا
عَلَى تَمَامِ مَرَافِقِهَا. ثُمَّ لَمْ يَدَعْ جُرُزَ
الْأَرْضِ الَّتِي تَقْصُرُ مِيَاهُ الْعُيُونِ عَنْ
رَوَابِيهَا، وَلَا تَجِدُ جَدَاوِلَ الْأَنْهَارِ
ذَرِيْعَةً إِلَى بُلُوغِهَا، حَتَّى أَنْشَأَ لَهَا
نَاشِئَةً سَحَابٍ تُحْيِي مَوَاتِهَا
وَتَسْتَخْرِجُ نَبَاتَهَا، أَلْفَ عَمَامِهَا بَعْدَ
افْتِرَاقِ لَمْعِهِ وَتَبَايُنِ قَرَعِهِ. حَتَّى إِذَا
تَمَحَّضَتْ لُجَّةُ الْمُزْنِ فِيهِ، وَالتَّمَعَ
بَرْقُهُ فِي كُفْفِهِ، وَلَمْ يَنْمَ وَمِضُّهُ فِي
كَنْهَوْرِ رَبَابِهِ وَمُتَرَاكِمِ

hanging low [close to the earth] with southerly winds squeezing it [as a she-camel is squeezed while milking] thereby causing its rainfall and torrential downpour.

سَحَابِهِ، أَرْسَلَهُ سَحَابًا مُّدَارِكًا قَدْ
أَسْفَتْ هَيْدَبُهُ، تَمْرِيه الْجَنُوبُ دَرَرَ
أَهَاضِيهِ وَدَفَعَ شَائِبِيهِ.

- 19 And when the clouds rubbed their underbellies on the ground and cast off all the weight that was carried upon them, He brought forth through it vegetation from the lifeless earth and herbage from arid mountains. As a result, it delighted at being decorated with its gardens and prided itself at the covering it was given of blooming flowers and the adornment of its fresh hanging blossoms. He made all this a means of sustenance for people and fodder for livestock. He opened up pathways in its expanse and placed beacons [of guidance] for those who traverse on its highways.

١٩ فَلَمَّا أَلْقَتِ السَّحَابُ بَرْكَ يَوَانِيَهَا،
وَبَعَاغَ مَا اشْتَقَلَّتْ بِهِ مِنَ الْعِبَاءِ
الْمَحْمُولِ عَلَيْهَا، أُخْرِجَ بِهِ مِنْ
هَوَامِدِ الْأَرْضِ النَّبَاتِ، وَمِنْ زُغَرِ
الْجِبَالِ الْأَعْشَابِ، فَهِيَ تَبْهَجُ بِزِينَةِ
رِيَاضِهَا، وَتَزْدَهِي بِمَا أَلْبَسَتْهُ مِنْ
رَيْطِ أَزَاهِيرِهَا، وَحَلِيَةِ مَا شَمِطَتْ بِهِ
مِنْ نَاضِرِ أَنْوَارِهَا، وَجَعَلَ ذَلِكَ
بَلَاغًا لِلْأَنَامِ وَرِزْقًا لِلْأَنْعَامِ، وَخَرَقَ
الْفِجَاجَ فِي آفَاقِهَا، وَأَقَامَ الْمَنَارَ
لِلسَّالِكِينَ عَلَى جَوَادٍ طُرُقِهَا.

having prepared for them all that they would need to live and thrive, and to attain their goal through gathering provisions for the Hereafter (MB).

The elevated land that was dry, having no springs or rivers, was taken care of by the Almighty through rain. Had that not been the case, no water would have reached these parched peaks. But He *created for it laden clouds which could revive its dead lands and bring forth its vegetation*. This means that the rain clouds high above the earth gather over these elevations (Z) and pour rain upon them, bringing out their vegetation and reviving the dry, dead earth. Thus does He join its clouds *after they had separated into scattered cloudlets and detached tufts*. Then *water started to swirl* within the laden clouds and *lightning began flashing in its linings* as it prepared to pour out its rain. The phrase '*lam yanam wamiḍuhu*' is rendered *the scintillation did not abate*, and refers to the flashes of lightening

(*wamaḍa al-barq*) which continued scintillating within the massive white columns of the clouds (*fi kanahwari rabābihi*) (T). The description of how the laden cloud is then sent down is very beautiful. The Imām uses the phrase '*saḥḥan mutadārikan*' which connotes successive downpours (I) but the term *saḥḥa* also means becoming fat, and is used to refer to the fattening of animals (N). The term '*dirar*' is the plural of *dirrah*, which refers to copious amounts of milk that flows forth (I), so it is using the beautiful metaphor of milking an animal that the Imām describes how the winds drive the clouds and then they are squeezed thereby giving rise to rainfall (N). The phrase '*dufa' sha'ābibihi*' refers to a downpour with vehemence and without intermission (Z).

19 In continuing his figurative depiction of rain from the clouds, the Imām says *the clouds rubbed their underbellies on the ground*, by which he means that they let out the water through rain, thereby casting off *all the weight that was carried upon them*. The term '*bark*' literally means chest (*ṣadr*), and is used to refer to the part of the chest or underbelly of a camel that rests on the ground when it sleeps (N). As for '*bawānīhā*', it is from *al-bawānī* which originally referred to the rib cage that holds up the chest, and could mean anything that props up something else, like tent poles, etc. Some commentators mention five different possible meanings for *al-bawānī* (R). In another version of this statement from the Imām, he uses the term *sky* (*al-samā*) instead of *clouds*, which is perhaps more apt (T). In any case, the reference here is to the unburdening of clouds and release of the water they carry, which subsequently falls as rain, bringing forth through it *vegetation from the lifeless earth and herbage from arid mountains*. Hence the earth *delighted at being decorated with its gardens and prided itself at the covering it was given of blooming flowers and the adornment of its fresh hanging blossoms*. The beauty of nature is not hidden from anyone, but it is not simply the external beauty which is being alluded to; rather, it is also the effects thereof which bring a sense of inner joy and comfort, as well as heightened enthusiasm and positivity. As such, this natural beauty of blossoming flowers and lush green plants is representative of the continuity of flourishing life and thriving of human beings as well (N). One commentator compares the earth's joy and pride to how women show off their new attire and jewellery (T). And Allāh *made all this vegetation and herbage a means of sustenance for people and fodder for livestock*. The phrase '*balāghan lil-anām*' means that which suffices the people (I), or by which they may attain what they require or achieve their goal (MB).

Indeed, it is not only for food that humankind uses vegetation; they also use it for clothing (through plants like cotton), and shelter. Perhaps that is why the Imām used a general phrase that encompasses all basic needs (N). Finally, at the end of this section, Imām ‘Alī notes that the Almighty *opened up pathways in its expanse and placed beacons of guidance for those who traverse on its highways*. This statement echoes the verse: *...and We have made in it wide pathways so that they may find their way* (Q21:31). A tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq notes that were the earth not an expanse with such pathways, it would have been impossible for people to dwell upon it, or farm, or tend livestock, or attain what they need for their survival and flourishing (T). The term ‘*al-manār*’, which is translated as *beacons*, is considered by some commentators to mean natural wayposts like mountains, stars, etc. by which people may be guided to the right way. Hence, Allāh created pathways on earth along with natural markers and signs that can be used as guides to enable people to find their way (Z).

20 Having spread out His earth and *executed His command*, Allāh chose Ādam (‘a) from among His creation *and made him the first of his kind*. The divine command that was effectuated and executed refers to His creative order (*al-amr al-takwīnī*) by which Allāh made the world and perfected it (MB). The phrase ‘*awwali jibillatihi*’ may be a reference to the first human being, or the foremost among the creation in terms of status and position, or both (N). *He settled him in His paradise*, which was a place of continual blessings and bliss, even though Ādam was himself created from the clay of the earth (Z). The Almighty provided him with plentiful sustenance in the form of all manner of delectable foods therein. This is also mentioned in the verse that states: *We said, “O Ādam, dwell with your spouse in the Garden, and eat thereof [plenteous food] freely whencesoever you wish, but do not approach this tree lest you both become wrongdoers”* (Q2:35). He forbade him and his spouse from approaching that which would make him susceptible to His disobedience *and imperil his own position*. As the story of how Ādam and Ḥawwā’ ate from the forbidden tree is recounted, commentators present a variety of discussions related to the subject. One commentator quotes a rather peculiar view which holds that Ādam knew eating the forbidden fruit would lead to his expulsion from Paradise, yet he did so anyway because he wanted to be removed therefrom and sent to the world, since he was tired of a life of laziness.

20 And when He had spread out His earth and executed His command, He chose Ādam (a) from among His creation and made him the first of his kind. He settled him in His paradise, providing him with plentiful sustenance [and all kinds of delectable foods] therein. He also indicated to him what He had proscribed for him and informed him that approaching it would make him susceptible to His disobedience and imperil his own position. But he did what He had prohibited him – as He had foreknown he would – so He sent him down, after his repentance, to populate His earth with his progeny and in order that the proof be established through him among His servants. He did not leave them, after taking back his soul, without something to serve as definitive proof of His Lordship, and as a means between them and knowledge of Him. Rather, He sent to them proofs through the speech of His chosen Prophets and the bearers in charge of [delivering] His Message, era after era, until with our Prophet Muḥammad (ṣ) His proof was completed, with no room left for excuse, with all final warnings having been issued. And He ordained livelihoods, augmenting them and diminishing them. He distributed them in paucity as well as plenty and did so justly, to try whomever He desired with its prosperity and its penury, and

٢٠ فَلَمَّا مَهَّدَ أَرْضَهُ وَأَنْفَذَ أَمْرَهُ،
اخْتَارَ آدَمَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ خَيْرَةً مِنْ
خَلْقِهِ، وَجَعَلَهُ أَوَّلَ جِبَلَّتِهِ،
وَأَسْكَنَهُ جَنَّتَهُ، وَأَرْغَدَ فِيهَا
أَكْلَهُ، وَأَوْعَزَ إِلَيْهِ فِيمَا نَهَاهُ عَنْهُ،
وَأَعْلَمَهُ أَنَّ فِي الْإِقْدَامِ عَلَيْهِ
التَّعَرُّضَ لِمَعْصِيَّتِهِ، وَالْمُخَاطَرَةَ
بِمَنْزِلَتِهِ؛ فَأَقْدَمَ عَلَى مَا نَهَاهُ عَنْهُ
- مُؤَافَاةً لِسَابِقِ عِلْمِهِ -
فَأَهْبَطَهُ بَعْدَ التَّوْبَةِ لِيُعْمَرَ
أَرْضَهُ بِنَسْلِهِ، وَلِيُقِيمَ الْحُجَّةَ بِهِ
عَلَى عِبَادِهِ، وَلَمْ يُخْلِهِمْ بَعْدَ أَنْ
قَبَضَهُ مِمَّا يُؤَكِّدُ عَلَيْهِمْ حُجَّةَ
رُبُوبِيَّتِهِ، وَيَصِلُ إِلَيْهِمْ وَبَيِّنَ
مَعْرِفَتِهِ، بَلْ تَعَاهَدَهُمُ بِالْحُجَجِ
عَلَى أَلْسِنِ الْخَيْرَةِ مِنْ أَنْبِيَائِهِ،
وَمُتَحَمِّلِي وَدَائِعِ رِسَالَاتِهِ، قَرَنًا
فَقَرَنًا؛ حَتَّى تَمَّتْ بِنَيْتِ مُحَمَّدٍ
ﷺ حُجَّتُهُ، وَبَلَغَ الْمَقْطَعُ
عُدْرَةَ وَتُدْرُهُ، وَقَدَّرَ الْأَرْزَاقَ
فَكَثَّرَهَا وَقَلَّلَهَا، وَقَسَمَهَا عَلَى
الصُّبْقِ وَالسَّعَةِ فَعَدَلَ فِيهَا،
لِيَتْلِيَ مَنْ أَرَادَ بِمَيْسُورِهَا
وَمَعْسُورِهَا، وَلِيُخْتَبَرَ بِذَلِكَ

to test by this the gratitude and patience of the rich and the poor. Then He coupled its abundance with the hardships of destitution, its safety with [the distress of] unexpected calamities, and its pleasures of enjoyment with pangs of grief.

الشُّكْرَ وَالصَّبْرَ مِنْ غَيْرِهَا
وَفَقِيرَهَا، ثُمَّ قَرَنَ بِسَعْيِهَا عَقَائِلَ
فَاقْتِهَا، وَبِسَلَامَتِهَا طَوَارِقَ
آفَاتِهَا، وَبِفَرَجِ أَفْرَاحِهَا غُصَصَ
أَثْرَاحِهَا.

Instead, Ādam yearned for a life of hard work and struggle, as the joy that results from the fruits of labour and toil is even greater than heavenly bliss. Furthermore, a human being cannot attain perfection except through hard work (Z). In any case, Ādam did what Allāh had prohibited, *as He had foreknown he would*. This does not mean that he was forced to do what he did, or lacked free will. Rather, as is discussed in the topic of predestination and free will, the all-encompassing knowledge of Allāh does not compel any individual to act in a certain way. In fact, the Omniscient Creator knew that Ādam would make this choice out of his own volition. It is something akin to a teacher knowing that a certain student will fail the exams due to his lack of seriousness in his studies. The teacher's knowledge plays no role in the student's failure, the responsibility for which rests squarely on the shoulders of the student himself (N).

Once Ādam had repented for abandoning the better course of action ('*tarku awlā'*'), he was sent down, to populate the earth with his progeny and in order that the proof of Allāh may be established through him among His servants. As discussed earlier, belief in the infallibility of divinely chosen guides precludes the possibility of their defiant disobedience and sinning against Allāh. An interesting narration describes Ādam's own answer to the question of why he ate from the forbidden tree when he met [the soul of] Mūsā ('*a*'). In this imaginary or otherworldly encounter, he responds to Mūsā's question about his action saying that it had been written fifty-thousand years prior that he would do what he did – it was thus his preordained fate. This does not mean that he was compelled to do it; only that it was known and recorded that he would make such a choice (MB). After taking back his soul, the Almighty did not leave the progeny of Ādam *without something to serve as definitive proof of His Lordship*, and as a means of guidance which would grant them knowledge and cognizance of Him. Rather, He sent them

proofs through the speech of His chosen Prophets and those whom He made responsible for delivering His Message. This was done *era after era* (*‘qarnan fa qarnan’*), until with our Prophet Muḥammad (ṣ) His proof was completed, *with no room left for excuse, with all final warnings having been issued* (*‘balagha al-maḳṭa‘a ‘udhruhu wa nudhruhu’*). Indeed, we are clearly told in the traditions that there is no time in which the world is without a proof (*ḥujjah*) of Allāh, so much so that if there were only two people on earth, one of them would be His *ḥujjah* (T). Allāh then *ordained livelihoods, augmenting them and diminishing them*, meaning He decreed that some people would have more while others would have less, or that one person would be well off during a certain period in his life and face poverty at another time (MB). He did this based on His wisdom, and knowledge of what is best for the creation.

Hence His allotment in both paucity as well as abundance is just. And one of the goals of this allotment is to try whomever He wills with prosperity and with penury, in order *to test by this the gratitude and patience of the rich and the poor*. The wealthy are tested to see if they show gratitude by using their wealth to help the needy and spending it on what is lawful and beneficial, and the poor are tested to see if they bear their state patiently without resorting to unlawful means of acquiring wealth. Of course, as noted earlier, the same individual may face both these different conditions and trials at different times in his life (N). An interesting *ḥadīth qudsī* narrated by Imām al-Kāẓim states, “The Almighty Lord says, ‘I did not enrich the rich due to any special honour, nor did I impoverish the poor due to any abasement; rather, it is through this that I test the rich by the [presence of the] poor. And were it not for [their helping] the poor, the rich would never gain entry into Paradise’” (T). As per the divine practice (*sunnah ilāhiyyah*), everything has a balance and a counterbalance. When the Imām says that abundance is coupled with *the hardships of destitution*, safety with *unexpected calamities*, and pleasures with *pangs of grief*, that reflects this reality. Indeed we see that even when a person becomes wealthy, the opulence brings with it some difficulties for him, whether in the form of physical maladies, or at the very least stress and anxiety regarding how to safeguard his property. And this is also true for the security and pleasures enjoyed by human beings in this world (J). The term “*‘aqābīl’* is plural of *‘uqbūl*, which refers to the traces and remnants of a malady, and in this instance it generally refers to hardships (T).

21 He created lifespans, lengthening and shortening them, preponing and postponing them, and linked their reaches with death, making it a puller of their ropes and a means of cutting their twines asunder. He is the knower of secrets that are concealed by concealers, private conversations of those who speak in lowered voices, inner thoughts brought about by conjecture, firm convictions based on certainty, stolen glances of the eyes, that which is contained within the [veiled] hearts and the recesses of the unseen. And [He knows] what strains the ears to eavesdrop, the summer habitat of ants and the winter refuge of reptiles, the resounding cries of wailing women and the sound of light footsteps. And [He knows] the place fruits develop within the inner sheaths, the dens of beasts within the caves of mountains and their valleys, the hiding places of gnats between the trunks of trees and their barks, the sprouting points of leaves from the branches, the terminus of the mixed fluid in the passages of loins, the formation of clouds and their amassing, the raindrops of cloudbanks that have accumulated, that which is dispersed by whirlwinds through their vortices and wiped away by rains through their floods, the movement of land creatures in sand dunes, the nests of winged creatures on the peaks of mountains,

٢١ وَخَلَقَ الْأَجَالَ فَأَطَالَهَا وَقَصَّرَهَا، وَقَدَّمَهَا وَأَخَّرَهَا، وَوَصَلَ بِالْمَوْتِ أَشْبَابَهَا، وَجَعَلَهُ خَالِجاً لِأَشْطَانِهَا، وَقَاطِعاً لِمَرَائِرِ أَقْرَانِهَا. عَالِمُ السِّرِّ مِنْ ضَمَائِرِ الْمُضْمِرِينَ، وَنَجْوَى الْمُتَخَفَتِينَ، وَخَوَاطِرِ رَجَمِ الظُّنُونِ، وَعَقْدِ عَزِيمَاتِ الْيَقِينِ، وَمَسَارِقِ إِبْمَاضِ الْجُفُونِ، وَمَا ضَمِنَتْهُ أَكْنَائُ الْقُلُوبِ وَعَيَابَاتُ الْغُيُوبِ، وَمَا أَضَعَتْ لِاسْتِرَاقِهِ مَصَائِحِ الْأَسْمَاعِ، وَمَصَايِفِ الذَّرِّ، وَمَشَاتِي الْهُوَامِّ، وَرَجْعِ الْحَنِينِ مِنَ الْمُوَلَهَاتِ، وَهَمْسِ الْأَقْدَامِ، وَمُنْفَسَحِ الثَّمَرَةِ مِنْ وَلَائِحِ عُلْفِ الْأَكْمَامِ، وَمُنْقَمَعِ الْوُحُوشِ مِنْ غَيْرَانِ الْجِبَالِ وَأَوْدِيَّتِهَا، وَمُخْتَبِإِ الْبُعُوضِ بَيْنَ شُوقِ الْأَشْجَارِ وَالْحَيَّيْتِهَا، وَمَغْرِزِ الْأُورَاقِ مِنَ الْأَفْنَانِ، وَمَحْطِّ الْأَمْشَاجِ مِنْ مَسَارِبِ الْأَصْلَابِ، وَنَاشِئَةِ الْعُيُومِ وَمَتَلَا حِمَمَهَا، وَدُرُورِ قَطْرِ السَّحَابِ فِي مُتَرَاكِمِهَا، وَمَا تَسْفِي الْأَعَاصِيرُ بِذُيُولِهَا، وَتَعْقُو الْأَمْطَارُ بِسُيُولِهَا، وَعَوْمُ بَنَاتِ الْأَرْضِ فِي كُتُبَانِ الرِّمَالِ، وَمُسْتَقَرِّ

and the warble of vocal creatures in the darkness of their nests. And [He knows] what has been gathered by oysters and nurtured by waves of the seas, what has been covered by the darkness of night or shined upon by the light of day, and what is successively encompassed by veils of darkness and rays of light. And [He knows] the trace of every footstep, the feel of every motion, the echo of every sound, the movement of every lip, the resting place of every living being, the weight of every particle, the sobs of every grieving soul, and whatever is upon it of the fruits of trees or fallen leaves, and the settling place of a sperm drop [in the womb], or the point of accumulation of blood and fleshy tissue, or the start of [a new] life and offspring.

ذَوَاتِ الْأَجْنَحَةِ بِدُرَا شَنَاجِبِ
الْجِبَالِ، وَتَغْرِيدِ ذَوَاتِ الْمَنْطِقِ فِي
دَبَاجِيرِ الْأَوْكَارِ، وَمَا أَوْعَبَتْهُ
الْأَضْدَاءُ وَحَضَنْتْ عَلَيْهِ أَمْوَاجُ
الْبَحَارِ، وَمَا غَشِيَتْهُ سُدْفَةٌ لَيْلٍ أَوْ ذَرَّ
عَلَيْهِ شَارِقُ نَهَارٍ، وَمَا اغْتَقَبَتْ عَلَيْهِ
أَطْبَاقُ الدِّيَاجِيرِ، وَسُبْحَاتُ النُّورِ،
وَأَثَرِ كُلِّ خَطْوَةٍ، وَحِسِّ كُلِّ
حَرَكَةٍ، وَرَجْعِ كُلِّ كَلِمَةٍ، وَتَحْرِيكِ
كُلِّ شَفَةِ، وَمُسْتَقَرِّ كُلِّ نَسَمَةٍ،
وَمِثْقَالِ كُلِّ ذَرَّةٍ، وَهَمَاهِمِ كُلِّ
نَفْسٍ هَامَةٍ، وَمَا عَلَيْهَا مِنْ نَمْرٍ
شَجَرَةٍ أَوْ سَاقِطِ رَقَةٍ، أَوْ قَرَارَةٍ
نُطْفَةٍ أَوْ نُقَاعَةٍ دَمٍ وَمُضْغَةٍ، أَوْ نَاشِئَةٍ
خَلْقٍ وَسَلَالَةٍ.

21 Continuing with the previous theme, the Imām reminds the people that Allāh also created and allotted lifespans (*‘ajāl’*) for each individual, giving some longer lives than others. As for His *preponing and postponing them*, it could refer to the general precedence of some nations that lived before others came to this world, or it may be a reference to certain deeds that lead to the shortening of lifespans, like severing ties with near relatives, or to the lengthening thereof, like giving charity, as noted in the traditions (MB). By saying that He linked the reaches of lifespans with death, the Imām meant that the factors which cause the end of one’s life, such as terminal diseases, were linked with the demise of an individual, such that they became the ‘causes’ of his death (M). The statement: *making it a puller of their ropes and means of cutting their twines asunder* means that death was made a ‘puller’ of the ropes of lifespans, drawing them closer to itself every

moment, until it cuts the twines of their lives asunder (Z). The terms '*khālijan*' and '*ashṭānihā*' respectively mean 'one that draws or pulls', and 'its long ropes', i.e. the ropes of one's lifespan (T). '*Marā'ir*' is plural of *marīr* and also refers to ropes, but specifically those that are long, slender, and strongly twisted (R). Some commentators interpret these statements as an allusion to the different ways in which people die, with some living long lives and dying of old age, while others live for only a short time. Furthermore, his words imply that since death has many causes, even if one is able to avoid some, he is sure to be ensnared by others. As such, no one can escape death (N). Imām 'Alī then reminds his audience that nothing is hidden from Allāh, as He is the *knower of secrets that are concealed by concealers, private conversations of those who speak in lowered voices, inner thoughts brought about by conjecture, firm convictions based on certainty, stolen glances of the eyes, that which is contained within the hearts, and the recesses of the unseen*. As such, every secret is open and manifest for Him, and the silent whispers of those who seek to communicate privately is clearly heard by Him. One's imagination and assumption, which is based on mere conjecture and has no external reality, is known by Him just as those convictions and beliefs in which one has certainty. Even the stolen glances by which one spies something without anyone noticing are not hidden from Him, for *He knows the treachery of the eyes and what the chests conceal* (Q40:19) (Z). The phrase "*uqadi 'azīmāt al-yaqīn*" refers to those things in which one has firm faith and belief, based on certitude and conviction. And '*masāriq imād al-jufūn*' connotes that which is stolen by glances of the eyes, where the term '*al-jufūn*', which literally means eyelids, has been employed figuratively to refer to the eyes (MB). The word '*aknān*' has been joined to '*qulūb*' to connote the secrets that are hidden deep within the hearts, and '*ghayābāt al-ghuyūb*', rendered *recesses of the unseen*, similarly signifies deep, dark, secrets that cannot be perceived by other creatures (M).

Allāh knows *what strains the ears to eavesdrop*, meaning the speech or sounds that evoke a sense of curiosity such that one inclines to secretly listen to them (MB). *The summer habitat of ants and the winter refuge of reptiles* are likewise known to Him. The term '*al-hawām*' generally refers to scary snakes or reptiles that are venomous and harmful (I). The winter refuge mentioned here is a reference to the places where reptiles brumate in the cold of winter. Whether it is loud, *resounding cries of wailing women*, or the *sound of light footsteps* that are barely audible, nothing is hidden from Him. Even that which is seemingly veiled or

covered is not concealed from Him. Hence, He knows the *place fruits develop within the inner sheaths* and sepals, *the dens of beasts within the caves* and valleys of mountains, *the hiding places of gnats* between the trunks and barks of trees, *the sprouting points of leaves from the branches*, as well as *the terminus of the mixed fluid in the passages of loins*. So even when something is covered up, obscured, and hidden, Allāh knows everything about it. The term '*munqama*' means a hiding place, and '*ghīrān*' is the plural of *ghār*, meaning cave (Z). The phrase '*maghriz al-awrāq min al-afnān*' refers to the specific point at which a leaf is attached to its branch, and where its roots penetrate within the branch of the tree, thereby keeping it in place even when wind blows or heavy rain falls (N). As for '*maḥaṭṭ al-amshāj*', it refers to the location where the seminal fluid comes to rest, having passed through the loins of the father and entered into the womb of the mother, or the receptacle in which it settles and mixes with the ovum (M). The Omniscient Creator knows every detail about the formation, amassing, and raindrops of clouds, what is *dispersed by whirlwinds through their vortices and wiped away by rains through their floods*, as well as all the movement of *land creatures* ('*banāt al-arḍ*') within sand dunes, the nests of *winged creatures* ('*dhawāt al-ajniḥah*') on the peaks of mountains, and the warble of *vocal creatures* ('*dhawāt al-manṭiq*') inside their dark nests. Most commentators have interpreted both *winged creatures* and *vocal creatures* to mean birds, with the difference being that the latter refers specifically to birds which make audible sounds, chirping and tweeting, etc. (T). Given the context, this seems like the most appropriate meaning, and it is noteworthy that he did not say *dhawāt al-kalām*, but '*dhawāt al-manṭiq*', since the former does not generally apply to birds, but the latter does (R). Some insist that the term *manṭiq*, meaning speech, is used here figuratively (I, M) though interestingly, in the story mentioned in Q27:20-28, Prophet Sulaymān interrogates his birds and then has a conversation with Hudhud. There is also an entire literary work by the acclaimed Persian poet Farīd al-Dīn al-ʿAṭṭār titled *Manṭiq al-Ṭayr* (lit. the speech of birds).

The Imām further states that Allāh knows *what has been gathered by oysters and nurtured by waves of the seas, what has been covered by the darkness of night or shined upon by the light of day, and what is successively encompassed by veils of darkness and rays of light*. That which is nurtured by the sea includes Ambergris ('*anbar*') and other such valuable things found in the oceans (Z). That which is successively encompassed ('*mā iṭṭaqabat ʿalayhi*') by darkness and light refers to

what is continuously covered by darkness and then illuminated by light, one after the other (MB). As he emphasizes the omniscience of the Almighty, Imām ‘Alī says that Allāh knows *the trace of every footstep, the feel and sense of every motion, the echo and reverberation of every sound, the movement of every lip* as it utters something audible or in whispers, *the resting place of every living being*, be it a human or any other creature, and *the weight of every particle*. Indeed, *not an atom’s weight remains hidden from your Lord in the earth or in the heavens* (10:61) (T). The sobs of every grieving soul are known to Him, as is whatever is upon the earth of the fruits of trees or fallen leaves. The pronoun ‘*hā*’ in ‘*mā ‘alayhā*’ refers to the earth (R). The Imām once again repeats the example of the settling place of a sperm drop in the womb, perhaps because of its similarity to the planting of a seed that results in fruits (N). The point of accumulation of blood (‘*nuqā’ati damin*’) is interpreted by some to refer to a hollow cavity (*nuqrah*) in which blood accumulates (I). Alternatively, it could be a reference to a clot of coagulated blood (‘*alaqah*’), especially since it has been mentioned after the drop of seminal fluid (‘*nutfah*’) (T). The *fleshy tissue* (‘*mudghah*’) is a lump of flesh, as seen in the verse: *then We made the drop a clinging clot, then We made the clinging clot a lump of fleshy tissue, then We made the fleshy tissue bones...* (Q23:14). Neither is *the start of a new life* deep within in the mother’s womb, nor the newborn *offspring* unknown to Him (Z). Some commentators say that ‘*nāshi’ati khalqin*’ here refers to the sperm that leads to the conception of a child, since not all spermata do this (T). ‘*Sulālah*’ literally refers to whatever draws forth from a person. Hence offspring and seminal fluid are both called *sulālah* since they come from within an individual, though the former is what is meant here (MB).

22 *In all this*, meaning in all that Allāh knows of the minute details of His creation mentioned above, or in His creation of all this, with their varying attributes, qualities, and states (MB), *He endures no trouble* or toil. Furthermore, He is neither *hindered by any obstacle* in the preservation of what He has created, *nor does any weariness or languor impede Him* from having His commands executed and managing the affairs of His creatures. Indeed this is reflected beautifully in the part of Āyat al-Kursī which states: *His Throne encompasses the heavens and the earth, and He is not wearied by their preservation, and He is the Exalted, the Great* (Q2:255) (T). Of course, concepts like weariness, ennui, difficulty, toil, trouble, weakness, etc. apply only to material beings that are subject to change, and can thus never apply to Allāh (Z).

22 In all this He endures no trouble, and neither is He hindered by any obstacle in the preservation of what He created nor does any weariness or languor impede Him from enforcing His orders and managing the affairs of the creatures. Rather, His knowledge penetrates through them and they are counted by His reckoning. His justice encompasses them and they are engulfed by His bounty, despite their shortcomings in fathoming that of which He is worthy.

SUPPLICATION

23 O Allāh! To You belong the beautiful attributes and innumerable abundance. If expectation is directed towards You, You are the best satisfier of expectations and if hope is placed in You, You are the greatest hope one can have. O Allāh! You have granted me such [bounty] that I can praise none other than You, and I cannot extol anyone save You. And I direct it not towards the sources of disappointment and centres of misgiving. You have turned away my tongue from praises for human beings and extolment of created servants. O Allāh! For every extoller there is, from the one he extolls, a reward of recompense or a gift that is granted. And I have turned to You hoping for guidance towards the stores of [Your] mercy and the treasures of [Your] forgiveness.

۲۲ لَمْ تَلَحِقْهُ فِي ذَلِكَ كُفْلَةٌ، وَلَا اعْتَرَضَتْهُ فِي حِفْظِ مَا ابْتَدَعَ مِنْ خَلْقِهِ عَارِضَةٌ، وَلَا اعْتَوَرَتْهُ فِي تَنْفِيزِ الْأُمُورِ وَتَدَابِيرِ الْمُخْلُوقِينَ مَلَالَةٌ وَلَا فَتْرَةٌ، بَلْ نَقَذَهُمْ عِلْمُهُ وَأَحْصَاهُمْ عَدْدُهُ، وَوَسِعَهُمْ عَدْلُهُ وَغَمَرَهُمْ فَضْلُهُ، مَعَ تَقْصِيرِهِمْ عَنْ كُنْهِ مَا هُوَ أَهْلُهُ.

دعاء

۲۳ اللَّهُمَّ أَنْتَ أَهْلُ الْوُصْفِ الْجَمِيلِ وَالتَّعْدَادِ الْكَثِيرِ، إِنْ تُؤَمِّلُ فَخَيْرٌ مَأْمُولٍ وَإِنْ تُرْجَ فَأَكْرَمَ مَرْجُوٍّ. اللَّهُمَّ وَقَدْ بَسَطْتُ لِي فِيمَا لَا أَمْدَحُ بِهِ غَيْرَكَ، وَلَا أُثْنِي بِهِ عَلَى أَحَدٍ سِوَاكَ، وَلَا أُوجِّهُهُ إِلَى مَعَادِنِ الْخَيِّبَةِ وَمَوَاضِعِ الرَّيْبَةِ، وَعَدَلْتُ بِلِسَانِي عَنْ مَدَائِحِ الْأَدْمِيِّينَ، وَالنَّسَاءِ عَلَى الْمَرْبُوبِينَ الْمُخْلُوقِينَ. اللَّهُمَّ وَلِكُلِّ مَثْنٍ عَلَى مَنْ أَثْنَى عَلَيْهِ مُثُوبَةٌ مِنْ جَزَاءٍ، أَوْ عَارِفَةٌ مِنْ عَطَاءٍ؛ وَقَدْ رَجَوْتُكَ دَلِيلًا عَلَى ذَخَائِرِ الرَّحْمَةِ وَكُنُوزِ الْمَغْفَرَةِ.

Rather, *His knowledge penetrates through them* and counts them by His reckoning. As the Qurʾān states: *He has indeed taken account of them, and has numbered them precisely* (Q19:94). His all-encompassing justice covers them completely and they are *engulfed by His bounty*. This is despite their shortcoming in fathoming that of which He is truly worthy (*‘kunhi mā huwa ahluh’*) in terms of praise and glorification (MB).

23 This section and the one following it constitute the conclusion of his sermon and comprise a supplication related to what he spoke earlier. Quite aptly, the Imām links it to his preceding statement by saying: *O Allāh! To You belong beautiful attributes and innumerable abundance*. Indeed, our minds cannot even fathom the extent of the beauty of His attributes (Z). The term *‘al-ta’dāt al-kathīr’*, translated as *innumerable abundance*, has been interpreted differently by commentators, with some saying that it means the Almighty has many attributes of majesty and perfection (N), while others understand it to refer to His numerous bounties and blessings bestowed to the creatures (MB). His perfect attributes are innumerable (T), and His blessings are uncountable (M). Regarding His perfection that has no end, the Qurʾān states: *If all the trees on earth were pens, and the sea augmented with seven more seas [were ink], the words of Allāh would not be exhausted; verily Allāh is Mighty, Wise* (Q31:27) (Z). The Imām then states: *If expectation is directed towards You, You are the best satisfier of expectations* (*‘khayru ma’mūl’*) and *if hope is placed in You, You are the greatest hope one can have* (*‘akrama marjuw’*).

He is the best satisfier of expectations because He alone has the power to grant every wish and fulfil every aspiration (T), and He is the greatest hope because His bounty and generosity (*karam*) is not limited, even by the incessant petitions of the beggars (MB). As such, one ought to have no expectation or hope save in Allāh alone (Z). And it is precisely due to the copious bounty bestowed by Allāh that the Imām states: *I can praise none other than You, and I cannot extol anyone save You*. Hence we see that Imām ‘Alī mixes the praise and glorification of Allāh with gratitude for His blessings (N). And he does not direct any of his praise *towards the sources of disappointment and centres of misgiving*. The term *sources* (*‘ma’ādin’* lit. mines) here alludes to human beings or creatures in general, and some commentators note the similarity between mines and creatures is that when seeking benefit from either of them, one remains unsure whether he will attain what he needs from them or not (M). It is quite possible for one to be disappointed

by failing to gain what he hopes for from the creatures, and they are described as *centres of misgiving* (*'mawāḍi' al-rībah*) because there is always a possibility of them turning out to be contrary to what they are being praised for – so one can never be completely certain about their being worthy of praise (T).

The Imām then notes how praise belongs only to Allāh, as he says: *You have turned away my tongue from praises for human beings and extolment of created servants*. This implies that even the ability to praise is granted by Allāh, as well as the guidance pertaining to the right kind of praise, namely praise for the Creator instead of the creation. Indeed, when a wise person looks at the world and recognizes the Primary Cause, or the 'cause of all causes' (*musabbib al-asbāb*), he realizes that all praise is due only to Allāh (N). Of course, this does not mean one should not express gratitude to others; rather, it means that one needs to realize that the source of all goodness and bounty is Allāh (J). Subsequently, the Imām seeks reward for his praise, saying: *for every extoller there is, from the one he extolls, a reward of recompense or a gift that is granted*. The difference between the terms *'jazā'* and *'ārifah'* is that the former refers to recompense for an action that is undertaken, whereas the latter is a gift or a bestowal (Z). Then he mentions the reward and bestowal he hopes for from Allāh, namely guidance towards the stores of His mercy and the treasures of His forgiveness. This means that he hopes to be shown which actions would please Him the most, thereby making him worthy of His mercy and forgiveness. And it is as though he considers such actions to be stores of mercy or treasures (I). Some commentators have interpreted the statement to mean that having hope in Allāh is itself a guide (*'dalīlan'*) towards divine mercy and forgiveness (M). It is possible what the Imām was seeking here was the ability to do that which made him worthy of attaining this mercy and forgiveness from Allāh (N).

24 In conclusion, Imām 'Alī describes himself as one who stands before Him having singled out the Almighty *with the Oneness that is specifically His, and does not regard anyone deserving of these praises and laudation except Him*. Indeed, there is none other to whom such Oneness applies (T). Some commentators describe such a stance with the Qur'ānic term *'maqāmun maḥmūd'* (Z), and this is a befitting ending to a sermon that was given in response to one who had asked for a description of his Lord. The state described by the Imām is one of a person who is engrossed in glorifying and magnifying his Creator, who is One, and who alone is deemed worthy of all praise, since all the attributes of beauty and

24 O Allāh! Here [before You] stands one who has singled You out with the Oneness that is specifically Yours, and does not regard anyone deserving of these praises and laudation except You. I have a need for You the indigence of which cannot be remedied by anything but Your grace, nor can its destitution be alleviated but by Your favour and Your generosity. So grant us Your pleasure as we stand before you, and free us from the need to extend [our penurious] hands to anyone other than You, *indeed You have power over all things.*

۲۴ اَللّٰهُمَّ وَهَذَا مَقَامٌ مِّنْ اَفْرَدَكَ
بِالتَّوْحِيدِ الَّذِي هُوَ لَكَ، وَلَمْ يَرِ
مُسْتَحَقًّا لِهَـٰذِهِ الْمَحَامِدِ
وَالْمَمَادِحِ غَيْرَكَ، وَبِي فَاقَةٌ
إِلَيْكَ لَا يَجْبُرُ مَسْكَنَتَهَا إِلَّا
فَضْلُكَ، وَلَا يَنْعَشُ مِنْ خَلَّتْهَا
إِلَّا مَنَّكَ وَجُودُكَ، فَهَبْ لَنَا
فِي هَـٰذَا الْمَقَامِ رِضَاكَ، وَاعْغِنَا
عَنْ مَدِّ الْأَيْدِي إِلَى سِوَاكَ،
إِنَّكَ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ.

perfection are only His (MB). The phrase *I have a need for You* ('*bī fāqatun ilayk*') does not refer to a worldly or material need that might even be fulfilled by some creatures; rather, it is something deeper (M). It is something the *indigence of which cannot be remedied by anything but* divine grace, *nor can its destitution be alleviated but by* divine favour and generosity. This is nothing but His acceptance, pleasure, mercy, and forgiveness, none of which can come from anyone but the Lord of the Worlds (MB). That is why in closing, he states: *so grant us Your pleasure as we stand before you, and free us from the need to extend [our penurious] hands to anyone other than You, indeed You have power over all things.* What a beautiful supplication from Imām 'Alī, which can be recited at any time and contains lofty statements worthy of contemplation. We have many other supplications from him, such as the *du'ā* he would recite when he saw the new moon, and so on. In fact, like the Noble Prophet, the Imām would regularly encourage believers to supplicate to Allāh, and he referred to *du'ā* as the key to success and the shield of the believer (T).



**WHEN THE PEOPLE SOUGHT AFTER HIM TO PLEDGE ALLEGIANCE
FOLLOWING THE KILLING OF 'UTHMĀN**

- 1 Leave me alone and look for someone else, for we are facing a matter that has several facets and hues. Neither can the hearts handle it nor can the intellects bear it. Verily the horizons have turned cloudy and the clear path has become indiscernible. Know that if I respond to your pleas [and accept the caliphate], I will lead you according to what I know, and will pay no heed to the words of any speaker and the criticism of any reproacher. If you let me be, then I am like one of you and I might even be more willing than you to hear and follow the individual whom you select to manage your affairs. I am better for you as an adviser than as a ruler.
- دَعُونِي وَالتَّمَسُّوا غَيْرِي، فَإِنَّا مُسْتَقْبِلُونَ أَمْرًا لَهُ وُجُوهٌ وَأَلْوَانٌ، لَا تَقُومُ لَهُ الْقُلُوبُ وَلَا تَتَّبِثُ عَلَيْهِ الْعُقُولُ، وَإِنَّ الْآفَاقَ قَدْ أَغَامَتْ وَالْمَحَجَّةَ قَدْ تَنَكَّرَتْ. وَاعْلَمُوا أَنِّي إِنِ اجْتَبَيْتُكُمْ رَكِبْتُ بِكُمْ مَا أَعْلَمُ وَلَمْ أَضْغِ إِلَى قَوْلِ الْقَائِلِ وَعَثِبِ الْعَاتِبِ، وَإِنْ تَرَكْتُمُونِي فَأَنَا كَأَحَدِكُمْ وَلَعَلِّي أَشْمَعُكُمْ وَأَطْوَعُكُمْ لِمَنْ وَلِيْتُمُوهُ أَمْرَكُمْ، وَأَنَا لَكُمْ وَزِيرًا خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ مِنِّي أَمِيرًا.

CONTEXT

The context of this sermon is clearly evinced from its title. It was spoken by the Imām when people came to him seeking to make him their caliph and showing eagerness to pledge their allegiance (*bay'ah*) to him. This happened after 'Uthmān was killed, in the year 35 AH, in Madīnah. From what has been related in other sources (such as the accounts of al-Ṭabarī and Ibn Athīr), we realize that the Imām did not utter these words at one go as a sermon; rather, there was a conversation that took place between him and the people regarding the issue of the caliphate, and al-Sayyid al-Raḍī took a few excerpts of that conversation and presented them here as one of his sermon, having removed the address of the people to the Imām

(N). We also note that these words have been recorded in sources prior to the time of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, and were subsequently related by him from his own reliable sources. Other scholars like al-Shaykh al-Mufid in his *al-Jamal*, and Ibn Jawzī in his *Tadhkirat al-Khawāṣṣ*, also narrated this oration (N). Historical reports provide various accounts of how the people approached Imām ‘Alī, urging him to accept the caliphate. Some state that the Companions of the Prophet (ṣ) came to him saying, “Verily it is ‘Alī who is the [true] Commander of the Faithful,” whereas in other reports they said, “Now that this man has been killed, and the people cannot do without a leader, we find none more worthy to lead us this day than you...” (Z). Some narrators, like Sayf ibn ‘Umar, fabricated false reports of how Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr were coerced into pledging allegiance to him, yet it is clear from these words of the Imām that he was not keen for worldly power and authority. It should also be noted that a few scholars have expressed doubt about the attribution of certain sections of this sermon to the Imām (T).

COMMENTARY

1 The first question posed by one of the earliest commentators of *Nahj al-Balāghah* is: how is it that the Shī‘ah say ‘Alī (‘a) is the Imām appointed by Allāh after the Noble Prophet, without any gap (*faṣl*), yet when he was approached to take the pledge of allegiance, he said, “Leave me alone and look for someone else”? He then answers: Undoubtedly these people who wanted to now give him the pledge were the same individuals who had earlier given their pledges of allegiance to Abū Bakr, ‘Umar, and ‘Uthmān, and that was because they were deprived of their shares from the public treasury by ‘Uthmān. Furthermore, they knew of the abstemiousness (*zuhd*) of ‘Alī (‘a). Hence they were hoping that he would treat them the way they had been treated by the two first caliphs, and that is why he responded the way he did (R). Other commentators say that the Imām addressed the people in this manner in order to complete his argument (*itmām al-ḥujjah*) and to clarify that if he did accept the post, he would not follow their whims or act according to their expectations of him (MB). Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd states the position of the ‘*ammah*, namely that the apparent meaning of this sermon shows how the Imām had not been explicitly appointed by the Messenger of Allāh as his successor, for if he had been thus appointed, the Imām would not have said *leave me alone and look for someone else*. Nor would he have uttered the words: *I might*

even be more willing than you to hear and follow the individual whom you select to manage your affairs, or: I am better for you as an adviser than as a ruler (I). An interesting explanation for this response has been proffered by one commentator who says that since it is the nature of human beings to have a greater desire for what they are denied, the Imām responded in this manner in order to heighten their desire for his caliphate (M). However, it seems more likely that the Imām wanted to clarify his disinterest for the post, and to lay out the conditions under which he would accept it, should he choose to do so (N). Moreover, the comparison made by some to the statement of Abū Bakr where he asked to be excused from the responsibility of leadership saying “I am not the best amongst you...” is false, since the Imām meant that the people would not be able to bear his justice, whereas in Abū Bakr’s case, the latter pointed to his own inability (S).

Two reasons are given by the Imām for his initial refusal to accept the post, the second of which is then expounded by him. First, he talks about the complicated matter they are facing, and by this he is referring to what the Noble Prophet had informed him about the future, and the rise of the three rebellious groups among the Muslims and the civil war that will ensue (R). By calling this *a matter that has several facets and hues*, he means that during the civil strife, there will be a plethora of views and opinions, and various justifications will be given for different stances taken (MB). *Neither can the hearts handle it nor can the intellects bear it*, since it is something that would shake the very core of the Muslim community. By describing it in this manner, the Imām is highlighting the extent of the strife that is to come and how serious it will be. His statement: *verily the horizons have turned cloudy and the clear path has become indiscernible* means that doubt has engulfed the hearts and minds of the people, and most of them are ignorant of the path of truth and its location (T). This was the natural result of their giving in to their worldly desires and caprice, and their materialistic tendencies had clouded their judgement and made them blind, such that they could not distinguish the true path from a deep well or ditch. Some have said that such an attitude became all the more pervasive during ‘Uthmān’s reign due to his lavish bestowals from the public treasury and the fragmentation and stratification of the Muslim society that resulted therefrom (N). Commentators have noted the similarity between cloudy horizons which darken up the sky and bring forth lightening and rain, and the hearts that are darkened by sin and misdeeds, from which nothing but evil can come forth or would be expected (M).

The second reason is that his acceptance of such a position was conditional. Imām ‘Alī mentions three conditions on the basis of which he would consider giving in to their proposal that he take over the reins of leadership. These were that he will act upon what is found in the Qur’ān, as taught to him by the Messenger of Allāh, and that he would not accept any views or suggestions from the people in matters of religious law, and lastly that his decision would be final and no one would oppose or defy him (R). These conditions have been summarized in his statement: *I will lead you according to what I know and will pay no heed to the words of any speaker and the criticism of any reproacher*. Indeed the Imām was known for his strict adherence to the Book of Allāh and the teachings of the Noble Prophet. In fact, it has even been reported that ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb had said while appointing the *shūrā*, “If ‘Alī comes to take charge, he will surely carry you upon the [right] path.” And therefore, it was understood that he would pay no heed to any reproach or criticism by the people (Z). Some commentators have regarded his last statement *I am better for you as an adviser than as a ruler* as sarcastic, meaning: ...that is what you have always thought. It would thus be something akin to the verse: *Taste! Indeed you are the mighty and noble one!* (Q44:49), which is also meant sarcastically. However, given that some have doubted the attribution of these words to the Imām in the first place, the question could be moot (as would be the first question of how he could have told the people to leave him and seek out someone else to lead them). Even if we do accept these to be the verbatim statements of the Imām, some posit that it is not necessary for an Imām to also be the ruler or head of state (T). On the other hand, these statements could perhaps be better explained by noting that his saying *if you let me be, then I am like one of you* means that if they leave him alone, he would have no supporters and would thus have to remain silent about his right. Likewise, his saying *I might even be more willing than you to hear and follow the individual whom you select to manage your affairs* only means that though he does not doubt for a moment that the caliphate is his right, he would not take up arms for its sake, unless it meant securing the rights of the Muslims, and there were enough supporters for his cause (Z). The very fact that he used the phrase *I might be* (*‘alallī*) shows that he would only be willing to follow one who acted in accordance to the command of Allāh, and not one who went against it (M). In the end, we see that Imām ‘Alī was not thinking like a self-serving politician who sought to further his own agenda. He never saw authority or leadership as a sweet

fruit that had to be obtained. Rather, to him, it was a heavy burden and a great responsibility by means of which he had to further the cause of Islam and establish its principles (N).



ON HIS MERITS & KNOWLEDGE AND THE MISCHIEF OF BANĪ Umayyah

- 1 After praising Allāh and extolling Him, [I say:] O people, verily I have gouged out the eye of sedition, and no one else was bold enough to do this after its darkness surged and its rabidity intensified. So ask me before you lose me, for by He in whose hand is my soul, you will not ask me about anything between now and the Hour, nor about the faction that will guide a hundred and lead astray a hundred, but that I shall inform you about its caller, its leader, and its driver. [I will tell you about] where their mounts will stop to rest and where they will finally alight, who among them will be killed and who will die a natural death. When you have lost me, and you are afflicted by calamitous situations and distressing circumstances, many questioners will fall silent and many of those who are obliged to provide answers will cower. This will be a time when your wars are protracted and constantly flare up, and this world becomes constricted for you [with hardships] such that you feel as though the days of tribulation are unending, until Allāh grants victory to those virtuous ones among you who remain.

أَمَّا بَعْدَ حَمْدِ اللَّهِ وَالتَّنَاءِ عَلَيْهِ، أُيْهَهَا
النَّاسُ فَإِنِّي فَقَأْتُ عَيْنَ الْفِتْنَةِ وَلَمْ
يَكُنْ لِيَجْتَرِئَ عَلَيْهَا أَحَدٌ غَيْرِي بَعْدَ
أَنْ مَاجَ غَيْبُهَا وَاشْتَدَّ كَلْبُهَا.
فَاسْأَلُونِي قَبْلَ أَنْ تَفْقِدُونِي، فَوَ
الَّذِي نَفْسِي بِيَدِهِ لَا تَسْأَلُونَنِي عَنْ
شَيْءٍ فِيمَا بَيْنَكُمْ وَبَيْنَ السَّاعَةِ، وَلَا
عَنْ فِتْنَةٍ تَهْدِي مَائَةً وَتُضِلُّ مَائَةً، إِلَّا
أَنْبَأْتُكُمْ بِنَاقِعِهَا وَقَائِدِهَا وَسَائِقِهَا،
وَمَنَاحِ رِكَابِهَا وَمَحْطَ رِحَالِهَا، وَمَنْ
يُقْتَلُ مِنْ أَهْلِهَا قَتْلًا وَمَنْ يَمُوتُ
مِنْهُمْ مَوْتًا. وَلَوْ قَدْ فَقَدْتُمُونِي
وَنَزَلْتُ بِكُمْ كَرَّائِهِ الْأُمُورِ وَحَوَازِبِ
الْحُطُوبِ، لَأَطْرَقَ كَثِيرٌ مِنَ
السَّائِلِينَ وَفَشَلَ كَثِيرٌ مِنَ
الْمَسْئُولِينَ، وَذَلِكَ إِذَا قَلَصَتْ
حَزْبُكُمْ وَشَمَرَتْ عَنْ سَاقٍ، وَكَانَتْ
الدُّنْيَا عَلَيْكُمْ ضَيْقًا، تَسْتَطِيلُونَ مَعَهُ
أَيَّامَ الْبَلَاءِ عَلَيْكُمْ، حَتَّى يَفْتَحَ اللَّهُ
لِبَقِيَّةِ الْأَبْرَارِ مِنْكُمْ.

CONTEXT

This sermon has been related in a number of *sīrah* works and is a well-known oration that was given by Imām ‘Alī after the end of the Battle of Nahrawān, though al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has left out a few parts thereof (I). Some of the other sources that mention this sermon include *Tārīkh al-Ya‘qūbī*, *Ḥilyat al-Awliyā’* by Abū Na‘īm, and *al-Nihāyah* by Ibn Athīr, among others. According to a number of narrations reported by al-Shaykh al-Mufid, the first time Imām ‘Alī uttered the words “ask me before you lose me” was right after he became the caliph, when he came to the masjid wearing the turban (*‘amāmah*) of the Messenger of Allāh (ṣ) and his cloak, and proceeded to ascend the pulpit. After praising Allāh and advising the people, he uttered these timeless words, inviting the people to ask him whatever they wished (T). In fact, from the various narrations that have reached us, we see that the Imām said this a number of times on different occasions. The overall message of this sermon is reminding the people about his lofty status and merits, as well as that of the Ahl al-Bayt. He did this in order to awaken his audience from their heedlessness and edify the ignorant among them, so that they would know and truly understand who he was (MB). He also wanted to tell them about how evil the Banū Umayyah were, thereby evoking a sense of hatred in them for the latter (M). This was done in order to apprise them of the strife (*fitnah*) that was coming their way and warn them of the sedition and treachery of the Banū Umayyah which would result in great tribulation for all the Muslims once they usurped authority and forcefully came to power (N).

COMMENTARY

1 His first statement to the people, after praising Allāh and extolling Him, was regarding the *fitnah* and how he had quashed it. The phrase *‘qafa’atu ‘ayn al-fitnah*’ literally means I gouged out the eye of sedition, or poked it, or pushed it into its socket. It is a metaphor for how he defeated the agents of strife in the battles of Jamal, Ṣiffin, and Nahrawān (T). Alternatively, it could be a general reference to the different kinds of *fitnah* that came about after the passing away of the Noble Prophet (ṣ), such as the vying for power by the Muhājirīn and Anṣār, their usurping the land of Fadak, the appointment of ‘Umar as the next caliph by Abū Bakr, its passing to ‘Uthmān after ‘Umar, and then the different rebellions against the Imām during his rule (Z). Some commentators opine that the *fitnah* being referred to

here is specifically the defiance and rebellion of Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr in the Battle of Jamal (N). By saying that *no one else was bold enough to do this after its darkness surged and its rabidity intensified*, he meant that nobody else would have had the courage to stand up against fellow Muslims out of fear of sinning by fighting believers, and they did not know how to even go about fighting a battle against Muslims – what were the rules of engagement? Were they to pursue them if they fled? Were they to kill the injured or leave them? And what of taking prisoners of war or appropriating their possessions as spoils? The only one who could thus stifle these rebellions was the Imām himself (M). In a narration from Imām Ja'far al-Ṣādiq, he said that if Amīr al-Mu'minīn had not fought against them at that time, nobody after him would have known the rules of engagement in such battles (T). Furthermore, it shows that this *fitnah* was a complicated and difficult situation that no one else could have handled (S). And the phrase *after its darkness surged and its rabidity intensified* meant that the sedition had reached such a state that there was no other option but battle. Some commentators interpret the entire sentence to simply mean that due to his knowledge and status, it was only possible for the Imām to handle the situation and quell the *fitnah* and the doubts arising therefrom, and nobody else was capable or qualified to do so (Z).

Imām 'Alī then invited the people to ask him before they lose him. Such an open invitation was never made by any other individual at his time, even among the Companions. The few people who came later and sought to boast of their knowledge by uttering these words, or something similar, from the pulpit, were all humiliated when they could not answer the questions posed to them. It is narrated that Muqātil ibn Sulaymān once said, "Ask me about anything under the Throne [of Allāh]?" so a man named Qays al-Qayyās asked, "Who shaved Ādam's head after he performed the *ḥajj*?" at which Muqātil was left speechless. And in another report, someone asked him, "What colour was the dog of the People of the Cave?" so he fell silent. When Qatādah entered Kūfah, he proclaimed from the pulpit, "Ask me anything you like!" so Abū Ḥanīfah asked him whether the ant which Sulaymān spoke to was male or female, and Qatādah was dumbfounded by that question. In the year 109 AH, Ibrāhīm ibn Hishām al-Makhzūmī, who was the governor of Ḥijāz, proclaimed at Minā during the *ḥajj*, "Ask me! For I am the son of al-Waḥīd, and you will never get anyone more learned than me!" So a man from Iraq stood up and asked about the sacrifice – is it obligatory for all or not? Ibrāhīm ibn Hishām did not know how to answer that question and thus he came down from the pulpit.

Ibn al-Jawzī also once said from the pulpit, “Ask me before you lose me!” whereat a lady stood up and asked him, “It is said that ‘Alī (‘a) travelled to Madā’in for the funeral of Salmān al-Fārsī in a single night?” He replied, “Yes, this has been reported.” “We also know that ‘Uthmān’s body lay unattended for three days while ‘Alī (‘a) did nothing even when he was close by [in the same city],” she added. “Yes, that is the case,” replied Ibn al-Jawzī. So the lady said, “One of these two actions must have been incorrect [– so which was it]?” Unable to answer, Ibn al-Jawzī snapped at her, “If you have come out of your house without your husband’s permission, then woe be upon you. And if you have come out with his permission, then woe be upon him!” The woman answered with a serious tone, “Tell me then, did ‘Ā’ishah come out to fight ‘Alī (‘a) with the Prophet’s permission or without it?!” And thus was Ibn al-Jawzī silenced (T).

The Imām then swears by Allāh, *in whose hand* is his soul, that no question will be posed about anything until *the Hour* of the Day of Judgment, nor about *the faction that will guide a hundred and lead astray a hundred*, but that he would inform them *about its caller, its leader, and its driver*. He even promised to tell them about where their mounts would halt to rest and where they will finally alight, who among them will be killed, and who will die a natural death, if they asked him about it. Some commentators say that there are rational explanations for being able to predict future events such as what the weather will be like on the following day, the date and time of solar and lunar eclipses, or even impending wars between nations. If one knows how to correctly read and interpret signs and decipher the trajectory of events, he can easily come to such conclusions about what will transpire down the road. At the same time, Allāh granted some knowledge of the unseen to His beloved Prophet (ṣ), who in turn passed on some of that knowledge to Imām ‘Alī. Indeed, in more than one instance the Imām mentioned how the Messenger of Allāh had taught him things which were not known to anyone else (Z). While it is common for people to make general predictions or vague foretellings about the near future, which at times turn out to be true and at other times are proven false, the fact that the Imām has spoken about minute details regarding events of a distant future shows that his knowledge is from an otherworldly source (N). That is why he can talk about events that would transpire until the Day of Resurrection. Of course, as the Qur’ān clearly states, such knowledge of the unseen is not accessible by anyone save those granted special permission by Allāh. This has been explained by the Imām himself in detail

elsewhere, as we shall see. Some commentators say his mentioning the number hundred is not because this exact number was intended; rather, it is just as an example to depict a large number of people, since according to the Arabs, any number under a hundred is considered little (MB). Others interpret it in the opposite way, saying that the number hundred here shows that the Imām is not only aware of large armies and what they will do, but also of small factions and the activities they will undertake (N).

One way Imām ‘Alī encourages people to ask him is by warning them that when he leaves them and passes away, and they are afflicted by *calamitous situations and distressing circumstances*, the opportunity will be lost and many *questioners will fall silent and those who are obliged to provide answers will cower*. The term ‘*hawāzib al-khuṭūb*’ refers to difficult matters and distressing situations, and ‘*aṭraqa*’ literally connotes lowering one’s eyes to the ground and falling silent (T). What this means is that once he is no longer with them, if and when a calamity befalls them, or they encounter a difficult situation, they will find no one to turn to for answers on how to deal with it (Z). In this way, the Imām sought to encourage them to ask him what they wanted while they still could, lest they regret later when he is gone (N). He then informs them what the future holds for them, telling them that a time will come when *wars are protracted and constantly flare up*. The phrase ‘*qallaṣat ḥarbukum*’ means that their wars would be many, or would get compounded and increase in scope and severity, alluding thereby to their intensity and gravity. This is because when armies are joined together as one unit, it becomes more difficult than if they are divided into small contingents sent forth to different areas (MB). ‘*Shammarat ‘an sāq*’ literally means raising up one’s garment above the shanks and tucking it in. It is a metaphor for exertion and striving, and when applied to wars or battles, it means that they turn vehement and heated. The Imām tells them that this would be a time when the world becomes constricted for them, with perpetual hardships, such that they feel *as though the days of tribulation are unending*. It will be as though a single day is an eternity that never comes to an end, since one who enjoys ease and comfort counts time based on convention, whereas those who are undergoing extreme hardship find that each second is prolonged endlessly, and time passes very slowly for them (Z). This will continue *until Allāh grants victory to those virtuous ones* who remain. Some commentators interpret this to be in reference to the fall of Banū Umayyah, which would then relieve them of the constriction and hardship imposed on them

2 Verily, when seditions advance, they confound [the truth] and when they retreat, their reality becomes evident. They are misperceived on approach but recognized upon departure. They circle around like blowing winds, pummelling some towns and passing over others. Know that the sedition I fear most for you is the mischief of Banū Umayyah, for it is an evil that is blind and dark. Its state is general yet its affliction is specific. Tribulation befalls one who remains percipient in it but there is no difficulty for one who is blind to it.

3 By Allāh, you will surely find Banū Umayyah to be the worst overlords for yourselves after me, like the old feral she-camel that bites with its mouth, tramples with its fore-legs, kicks with its hind legs and refuses to be milked. They will remain with you until they leave none among you except those who benefit them or do not harm them. Their affliction upon you will not let up until rising against them would be tantamount to the rising of a slave against his master and of the disciple against his mentor. Their mischief will come upon you as an ugly, terrifying countenance, and in the manner of the dark pre-Islamic times, wherein neither a beacon of guidance nor a sign [of salvation] can be seen.

٢ إِنَّ الْفِتْنَ إِذَا أَقْبَلَتْ شَبَّهَتْ وَإِذَا
أَدْبَرَتْ نَبَّهَتْ، يُنْكَرُونَ مُقْبِلَاتِ
وَيُعَرَفُونَ مُدْبِرَاتِ، يُحْمَنُ حَوْمَ
الرِّيَّاحِ يُصِيبُنْ بَلَدًا وَيُخْطِئُنْ
بَلَدًا. أَلَا وَإِنَّ أَخْوَفَ الْفِتَنِ
عِنْدِي عَلَيْكُمْ فِتْنَةُ بَنِي أُمَيَّةَ،
فَإِنَّهَا فِتْنَةٌ عَمِيَاءُ مُظْلِمَةٌ، عَمَتْ
خُطُئُهَا وَخَصَّتْ بَلِيَّتُهَا، وَأَصَابَ
الْبَلَاءُ مَنْ أَبْصَرَ فِيهَا وَأَخْطَأَ
الْبَلَاءُ مَنْ عَمِيَ عَنْهَا.

٣ وَائِمُ اللَّهِ لَتَجِدَنَّ بَنِي أُمَيَّةَ لَكُمْ
أَرْبَابَ سُوءٍ بَعْدِي، كَالنَّابِ
الضَّرُوسِ: تَعْدِمُ بِفِيهَا، وَتَخْطِ
بِيَدِهَا، وَتَرْبُ بَرْجِلَيْهَا، وَتَمْنَعُ دَرَّهَا؛
لَا يَزَالُونَ بِكُمْ حَتَّى لَا يَثْرُكُوا
مِنْكُمْ إِلَّا نَافِعًا لَهُمْ أَوْ غَيْرَ ضَائِرٍ
بِهِمْ، وَلَا يَزَالُ بَلَاؤُهُمْ عَنْكُمْ حَتَّى
لَا يَكُونَ أَنْتِصَارُ أَحَدِكُمْ مِنْهُمْ إِلَّا
كَاتِصَارِ الْعَبْدِ مِنْ رَبِّهِ وَالصَّاحِبِ
مِنْ مُسْتَضْجِيهِ، تَرِدُ عَلَيْكُمْ فِتْنَتُهُمْ
سَوْهَاءَ مَخْشِيَةٍ وَقَطْعًا جَاهِلِيَّةً، لَيْسَ
فِيهَا مَنَارٌ هُدًى وَلَا عِلْمٌ يُرَى.

by that tyrannical dynasty (M). Alternatively, it may also be a general reference to the final world order that is established by Imām al-Mahdī, where justice will prevail and oppression will be uprooted (N).

2 In this pericope, the Imām discusses the nature of *fitnah* and what happens when it transpires. He says that in the event of strife and sedition, the truth becomes muddled and confounded (*'shabbahat'*). Some have divided such confusion into two kinds: one is where it is possible to refer to what is decisive and certain in order to clear up that which is confusing and arrive at an understanding regarding it. The other kind is such that no way can be found to clear up the confusion whatsoever (T). Of course, the confusion which results from *fitnah* does not confound each and every person; rather, it is the lay people and the simpleminded folk who are bewildered by it (Z). Nevertheless, once the *fitnah* comes to an end, the *reality becomes evident*. That is when the people awake from their ignorance and realize the evil that had befallen them. An example of this was seen in the *fitnah* of Jamal and Nahrawān where some people did not know which side was on the truth, but once the battles were over, the truth became evident and the people realized who was on the right (I). And thus it is that the *fitan* are *misperceived on approach but recognized upon departure*. This statement expounds the preceding one, emphasizing that in the beginning, such matters are confusing to the people and many err in their perception and understanding of them. That is because their callers resemble those who call towards the truth and guidance. Yet once the matters end, it becomes evident that they were far from the truth and actually followed the path of falsehood (M). To clarify how sedition is not always encompassing and sometimes affects some places while passing over others, the Imām gives the example of strong winds that blow in certain towns, pummelling them while passing over others (*'yuṣibna baladan wa yukhtīna baladan'*). This is because the circumstances in every place differs, and certain factors in a given town may prevent the spread of sedition therein, while other factors elsewhere may act as a catalyst for it (N).

Subsequently, the Imām turns to the *fitnah* which he fears most for the people, namely the sedition of Banū Umayyah, which he describes as *an evil that is blind and dark* (*"amyā' muḥlimah"*). This figuratively refers to their oppression and injustice, since the blind cannot see the path ahead and thus stray from it; and the same is also true for those who are in utter darkness. Thus the path of truth and justice would not be followed during the reign of the Banū Umayyah (M). By saying

its state is general yet its affliction is specific, the Imām meant that the Umayyads would rule over all the people, yet their oppression would specifically afflict those who were freethinkers (*al-aḥrār*), since they wished to enslave the people and bring them all under their yoke (Z). Alternatively, they were specifically against the Shi‘ah of Imām ‘Alī and the followers of the Ahl al-Bayt of the Prophet (ṣ), as history attests (T). The Imām then clarifies that the tribulation brought about by the Banī Umayyah would befall *one who remains percipient in it* but there will be no difficulty *for one who is blind to it*. Indeed, the percipient one would realize what is going on and aside from the oppression he directly undergoes, he would be filled with sorrow for the tyranny he witnesses against others as well. But the ignorant ones who are blind to what is occurring around them will remain at ease, and will be left alone as they conform to the expectations of the rulers and obey their orders, thereby posing no threat to the powers that be (MB).

3 He then describes the Banū Umayyah as *the worst overlords* (*‘arbāba sū’in*) over the people after him. And indeed this was truly the case, for history has recorded a long list of evils perpetrated by them. A number of examples of this have been mentioned by some commentators, including their forcefully taking *jizyah* from those of the *ahl al-dhimmah* who accepted Islam, claiming they had only done so to escape paying the tax (T). They did everything they could to fill their own coffers while stubbornly refusing to follow the injunctions of Islam and doing little for the betterment of the Muslim society as a whole. Hence the Imām compares them to an *old feral she-camel that bites with its mouth, tramples with its fore-legs, kicks with its hind legs, and refuses to be milked*. This figurative description fits the Umayyads to a tee, for instead of bringing benefit to the people, they caused harm (N). Just as such a camel bites, tramples, and kicks, so too did the Banū Umayyah harm the people by tormenting, torturing, and killing them without just cause. And just as the camel refuses to be milked, the Umayyads deprived people of their rightful share from the public treasury (MB). The Imām tells them that the Banī Umayyah will continue in this manner *until they leave none among you except those who benefit them or do not harm them*. So it was that the Umayyad caliphs would only leave two kinds of people unharmed: those who were of some benefit to them and who followed their path, and secondly those who never caused them any trouble and did not speak out against their oppression (M).

By saying that their tyranny will continue in this way *until rising against them would be tantamount to the rising of a slave against his master and of the disciple against his mentor*, the Imām means that the people will act like malcontent slaves, outwardly obeying them as they have no other choice, but inwardly they will hate them and be filled with rage against them. This meaning is reflected in a similar statement of the Imām from sermon no. 97 in which he says: *until the help accorded by one of you to one of them will be like a slave helping his master, when he is present he obeys him but when he is absent he speaks ill of him* (Z). Alternatively, it could mean that just as the uprising of a slave against his master or a disciple against his mentor is futile and ineffective, so too will the people be incapable of rising up against the Umayyads – such will be their state (MB). He further warned them that the *mischievousness* of the Banū Umayyah will come upon them *as an ugly, terrifying countenance*. The term ‘*shawhā*’ refers to one with an ugly face, and ‘*makhshīyyah*’ means frightening and scary (I). Some commentators have interpreted this to refer to that which is ugly and repugnant to the intellect and in the eyes of religion, while being frightening to the souls and terrifying to the hearts (MB). Moreover, it would be like *the dark, pre-Islamic times wherein neither a beacon of guidance nor a sign of salvation can be seen*. This means that the Umayyad rule would be entirely evil, where justice will be far off and tyranny will be pervasive (Z), just like things were during the Age of Ignorance (M).

4 Finally the Imām describes the position of the Ahl al-Bayt vis-a-vis the mischief of the Banū Umayyah. His statement that they are [*in a place*] *safe from it* and *do not advocate for it* means that they will remain aside and never support the evils of the Umayyad rulers. Of course, this does not mean that the Ahl al-Bayt were not affected by the misdeeds of the Banū Umayyah. Quite the contrary. Considered a threat to their rule, the Umayyads always kept the Ahl al-Bayt in their crosshairs and the Imāms were killed or poisoned, one after the other, and their progeny were also tormented and harmed by these rulers. Hence, when he says that the Ahl al-Bayt are in a place *safe from it*, it means that they are away from any responsibility for the evil of the Umayyads, and are hence safe from the sins they undertake. This meaning is made clearer by the next phrase where he notes that they *do not advocate for it*, meaning they neither support the misdeeds of the Umayyads nor call others towards it (N). To give hope to the people, Imām ‘Alī gives them the good news that the reign of the Banū Umayyah would not last, for *Allāh will dispel it* in the same way that skin is removed from flesh,

4 We, the Household of the Prophet, are [in a place] safe from it, and we do not advocate for it. Thereafter, Allāh will dispel it from you like the removal of skin [from flesh] through those who will inflict humiliation upon them, drive them [out] violently, and make them drink the brimming cups [of torment], not giving them anything but the sword, nor covering them with anything save fear. It is then that the Quraysh will wish, at the cost of the world and all that is in it, to see me in power [again] once, even if it is only for the length of time it would take to slaughter a camel, so that I may accept from them that which I am presently seeking only a part of, yet they are not giving it to me!

٤ نَحْنُ أَهْلُ الْبَيْتِ مِنْهَا بِمَنْجَاةٍ
وَلَكُنَّا فِيهَا بِدُعَاةٍ، ثُمَّ يَفْرُجُهَا
اللَّهُ عَنْكُمْ كَتَفْرِيجِ الْأَدِيمِ، بِمَنْ
يُسَوِّمُهُمْ حَسَفًا وَيَسُوقُهُمْ غُفًّا
وَيَسْقِيهِمْ بِكَأْسٍ مُصَبَّرَةٍ، لَا
يُعْطِيهِمْ إِلَّا السَّيْفَ وَلَا
يُخْلِسُهُمْ إِلَّا الْخَوْفَ، فَعِنْدَ
ذَلِكَ تَوَدُّ قُرَيْشٌ بِالدُّنْيَا وَمَا
فِيهَا، لَوْ يَزُونَنِي مَقَامًا وَاحِدًا،
وَلَوْ قَدَرَ جَزْرُ جَزُورٍ، لِأَقْبَلَ
مِنْهُمْ مَا أَطْلَبُ الْيَوْمَ بَعْضَهُ فَلَا
يُعْطُونِيهِ!

through those who will inflict humiliation upon them, driving them out violently, and making them drink cups of torment. They will not give them anything but the sword, nor cover them with anything save fear. The phrase ‘*ka tafrij al-adim*’ is translated *like the removal of skin* and according to some, it refers to the removal of skin from flesh, and is a metaphor for the relief they will attain by the downfall of the Umayyads (MB). He also says that their removal will be accompanied by both humiliation (‘*khasfan*’) and violence (‘*unfan*’), and will not be a smooth or calm transition. Rather, they will be forced to *drink the brimming cups* of torment, or, if the term ‘*muṣabbarah*’ is understood to mean filled with bitter aloes, then the translation would be *drink the cups of bitter aloes*, which may fit in better with the context; but both meanings are possible (T). Indeed, all this is referring to how the Banū ‘Abbās would treat the Banū Umayyah when deposing the latter from power. They would give them nothing but the sword and cover them only with fear and trepidation. And history confirms the truth of this, for that is exactly what the ‘Abbāsids did to the Umayyads, pursuing them and killing them wherever they

were found (Z). In fact, it is reported that the first ‘Abbāsīd caliph Abū al-‘Abbās al-Saffāḥ ordered that not only should all the Umayyads be killed, but even the graves of their predecessors should be opened, and their bodies exhumed and burned. He even went to the extent of feeding the corpses of the Umayyads to the dogs! That was the reason he got the title ‘al-Saffāḥ’ meaning the bloodthirsty, or the ‘shedder of blood’ (N).

Imām ‘Alī says that when all this transpires, *the Quraysh will wish, at the cost of the world and all that is in it, to see me in power again once*, or for one last stand, or for a brief period (*‘maqāman wāḥidan’*), in which they could then obey and follow me (MB). Some commentators opine that the term *Quraysh* here refers specifically to the Banū Umayyah (Z), whereas others say it is more general (T). The example of Quraysh is given because they were the most bitter enemies of the Imām – but they would now wish for his return and his rule, *even if it is only for the length of time it would take to slaughter a camel* (*‘jazri jazūr’*) (M). They would desire his coming to them in order that *he may accept from them* complete and unquestioning obedience, even though what he sought from them in the present was *only a part* thereof – meaning partial obedience or submission; yet they did not give that to him. Interestingly, it is reported that Marwān ibn Muḥammad, who was the last of the Umayyad rulers, said when he saw the ‘Abbāsīd ‘Abdullāh ibn Muḥammad take his place against him, “I would have loved to see ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib under this banner instead of this young man!” (MB). Though the apparent context of this sermon relates to the Umayyads and foretelling their downfall, some commentators have suggested that it refers to the time when the awaited Mahdī (‘a) will rise. However, this interpretation is not likely since firstly, during the final days before the rise of the awaited Imām, the Umayyads will not be a specific, identifiable group. Secondly, when the awaited Imām comes, he will establish the ‘Alawī order of complete justice such that there would be no need or reason to hope for the presence of Imām ‘Alī again, as he would do nothing differently (N).



ON THE ATTRIBUTES OF ALLĀH, MERITS OF THE PROPHETS AND THE AHL AL-BAYT, FOLLOWED BY ADMONITION

ALLĀH THE EXALTED

- 1 Blessed is Allāh, whom the heights of intellectual endeavour cannot reach and sagacious estimations cannot attain. He is the First who neither has a terminus to limit Him nor any end upon which He would cease [to be].

الله تعالى

١ فَتَبَارَكَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي لَا يَبْلُغُهُ بُعْدُ
الْهَمِّ وَلَا يَنَالُهُ حَدْسُ الْفُطْنِ،
الْأَوَّلُ الَّذِي لَا غَايَةَ لَهُ فَيَنْتَهِي
وَلَا آخِرَ لَهُ فَيَنْقُضِي.

ON THE DESCRIPTION OF PROPHETS

- 2 Allāh placed them in the best lodging and settled them in the best abode. They were transferred from noble loins to chaste wombs. Whenever a predecessor from among them passed away, a successor rose up for [the propagation of] Allāh's religion.

ومنها في وصف الأنبياء

٢ فَاسْتَوْدَعَهُمْ فِي أَفْضَلِ مُسْتَوْدَعٍ
وَأَقَرَّهُمْ فِي خَيْرِ مُسْتَقَرٍّ، تَنَاسَخَتْهُمْ
كَرَائِمُ الْأَصْلَابِ إِلَى مُطَهَّرَاتِ
الْأَرْحَامِ، كُلَّمَا مَضَى مِنْهُمْ سَلَفٌ
قَامَ مِنْهُمْ بِدِينِ اللَّهِ خَلَفٌ.

CONTEXT

This is considered an excerpt of the sermon that is mentioned in *al-Kāfi* (1:134-6) which al-Kulaynī says is one of the well-known sermons that was passed down from generation to generation. Al-Ṣadūq notes that Imām al-Ṣādiq said Amīr al-Mu'minīn gave this sermon when he sought to prepare the Muslims for a second encounter with Mu'āwiyah. In his *al-Iqd al-Farīd*, Ibn 'Abd Rabbih reports this sermon with some variance in wording under the heading 'al-Khuṭbat al-Gharrā'. Notably, he removed the part about the Ahl al-Bayt (N). There are four issues addressed in this oration. The Imām starts by extolling Allāh and mentioning His attributes. Then he talks about the qualities of the Prophets from the progeny of Ādam. Thirdly, he speaks about the Noble Prophet and his pure progeny. And finally, he gives some advice and admonition to the people. It is possible that this

sermon is actually a combination of excerpts from different sermons of the Imām, and the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places the first section in his 43rd sermon, the second and third sections in his 2nd sermon, and the last section in his 18th sermon. In any case, the oration contains some lofty teachings and reminders that are of great benefit for those who ponder over them.

COMMENTARY

1 He begins by praising Allāh and says: *Blessed is Allāh, whom the heights of intellectual endeavour cannot reach and sagacious estimations cannot attain*. The phrase ‘*tabārakallāh*’ has two possible meanings. First, it could mean that may His blessings abound and may His bounty increase, in which case it is a supplication (*du‘ā*). Second, it may mean that He is blessed and exalted in His attributes, such that none can ever be compared to Him, in which case it is an extolment (*tamjīd*) (I). The fact that *heights of intellectual endeavour* cannot reach Him has also been mentioned in the first sermon. Since His perfect attributes are not limited or restricted, they cannot be attained or comprehended entirely; because all the sentient creatures are limited in their understanding and therefore no matter how much effort they put in, it is impossible for them to fully grasp the nature and attributes of the Almighty. Rather, ‘all who try to swim in the sea of His majesty drown, and all who approach the lights of His beauty burn’ (MB). The phrase ‘*ḥads al-fiṭān*’, translated as *sagacious estimations*, refers to guesses, approximations, or speculations of the intellects, or of skilled minds. Just as purposeful rational endeavours and logical reasoning cannot make one fully understand Allāh, intellectual suppositions, theories, and conjecture can also not take one closer to comprehending Him (S, N).

It is noteworthy that guessing (‘*ḥads*’) results in presumption, not in certitude, and despite its greater flexibility and wider scope compared to logical reasoning, one can still not gain an understanding of the Creator through it (M). Indeed, Allāh is *the First who neither has a terminus to limit Him nor any end upon which He would cease* to be. We have discussed the meaning of His being the First and the Last in our commentary on sermon no. 64. The Imām’s statement here means that Allāh is the first of all, with nothing preceding Him and nothing to which He goes back to (since if any such point existed it would precede Him in existence). And He is the last of all, such that there is no end to Him, after which He ceases. The logical

argument for this is because beginnings and ends apply to corporeal beings and entities that are bound by time, and since Allāh is far above that, He has no limit or end (MB).

2 In this passage, the Imām describes the Prophets of Allāh. When he says that they were placed *in the best lodging* and settled *in the best abode*, the Imām is referring to the loins of their fathers and wombs of their mothers. These two terms ('*mustawda*' and '*mustaqarr*') have been mentioned in the verse: *And it is He Who brought you into being from a single soul, then there is [for you] a dwelling place and a depository...* (Q6:98) (T). The meaning of this statement is that the Prophets of Allāh were transferred from the loins of their forefathers to the wombs of their foremothers, both of whom were free from the impurity of unchastity and fornication. Indeed, it is our belief that Prophets have to come from a pure lineage, because having lowly parentage is a flaw that would cause people to turn away from, disparage, and despise an individual (Z). Thus *they were transferred from noble loins to chaste wombs*. The term '*tanāsakhathum*' connotes transferal, and in one version the word '*tanāsalathum*' is found instead (R). Some commentators suggest that this means even the slightest form of unlawfulness in their parents' union was not present. Examples of this could be the incorrect pronouncement of the marriage formula, or lack of approval by any of the two parties to the marriage, or any such thing that would render their marital union invalid or doubtful – none of this occurred in the case of the parents of any of the Prophets (MB). According to the foremost authorities of the Shi'ah, all the parents of Prophets, from the time of Ādam until the father of the final Prophet, 'Abdullāh, were Muslims (T).

The Imām then states that this world was never without guidance from the Almighty, because *whenever a predecessor from among them passed away, a successor rose up for the propagation of Allāh's religion*. The terms '*salaf*' and '*khalaf*' refer to the erstwhile predecessors and the latter generation respectively (I). According to some commentators, this statement also implies that the message brought by the Prophets was the same, as was their core mission. They all invited the people to belief in the Oneness of Allāh (*tawhīd*), His justice (*'adl*), and the Resurrection (*ma'ād*) (N). The fact that the Prophets came in succession has been mentioned in the verse: *Then We sent Our Messengers in succession. Whenever there came to a nation its Messenger, they would deny him, so We caused them to follow one another [to their doom] and turned them into [cautionary] tales; so away with a people who do not believe!* (Q23:44) (Z).

THE MESSENGER OF ALLĀH AND HIS
HOUSEHOLD

- 3 Until this great distinction of Allāh, the Glorified, reached Muḥammad (ṣ). He thus brought him forth from the best of all origins and the noblest of all roots, the same [lineal] tree from which He raised His Prophets and selected His trustees. His progeny are the best descendants, his family are the best kinsmen, and his lineal tree is the best of lineages. It grew in sanctity and excelled in nobility. It has tall branches and unreachable fruits. He is the leader of those who are Godway and the [means of] insight for those who follow guidance. He is a lamp whose flame is glowing, a shooting star whose light is shining, and a flint whose spark is bright. His conduct is upright, his practice is [a means of] guidance, his speech is decisive, and his judgment is just. He sent him after an interval in the sequence of Messengers, [at a time] when people were erring in their actions and nations were steeped in ignorance.

رسول الله وآل بيته

٣ حَتَّى أَفْضَتْ كَرَامَةُ اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ إِلَى مُحَمَّدٍ ﷺ، فَأَخْرَجَهُ مِنْ أَفْضَلِ الْمَعَادِنِ مَنَبَأً وَأَعَزَّ الْأُرُومَاتِ مَغْرَساً، مِنْ الشَّجَرَةِ الَّتِي صَدَعَ مِنْهَا أَنْبِيَاءُهُ وَانْتَجَبَ مِنْهَا أَمَنَاءُهُ؛ عَثْرَتُهُ خَيْرُ الْعَثَرِ وَأُسْرَتُهُ خَيْرُ الْأُسَرِ، وَشَجَرَتُهُ خَيْرُ الشَّجَرِ نَبَتْ فِي حَرَمٍ وَبَسَقَتْ فِي كَرَمٍ، لَهَا فُرُوعٌ طَوَالٌ وَتَمَرٌ لَا يَنَالُ، فَهُوَ إِمَامٌ مَنْ اتَّقَى وَبَصِيرَةٌ مَنْ اهْتَدَى، سِرَاجٌ لَمَعَ ضَوْؤُهُ، وَشِهَابٌ سَطَعَ نُورُهُ، وَزَنْدٌ بَرَقَ لَمْعُهُ، سِيرَتُهُ الْقَصْدُ وَسُنَّتُهُ الرُّشْدُ، وَكَلَامُهُ الْفَضْلُ وَحُكْمُهُ الْعَدْلُ، أَرْسَلَهُ عَلَى حِينٍ فَتْرَةٍ مِنَ الرُّشْلِ، وَهَفْوَةٍ عَنِ الْعَمَلِ، وَعَبَاوَةٍ مِنَ الْأُمَمِ.

- 3 The succession of Prophets continued until this great distinction of prophethood, reached the Noble Prophet Muḥammad (ṣ). With him as the final Messenger, the chain of Prophets came to a close (MB). The fact that he was brought forth from the best of all origins and the noblest of all roots, points to his being worthy and capable of undertaking the task and bearing the burden of prophethood as he met the qualification of having a pure genealogy and ancestry. Some have offered alternative interpretations for these phrases, saying that the

first phrase refers to Makkah while the second one refers to Prophet Ismā'īl (Z). Since this is followed by the phrase: *the same [lineal] tree from which He raised His Prophets and selected His trustees*, it is likely that both the *origins* ('*al-mā'ādin*') and *roots* ('*al-arūmāt*') refer specifically to Prophet Ibrāhīm or Prophet Ismā'īl (MB), though the former is even more likely since it is known that the Prophets and Messengers were from the progeny of Ibrāhīm ('*ā*') (T). In the same vein, the *progeny* of the Prophet were also *the best descendants* ('*khayr al-itar*'), and they were the ones about whom the Messenger of Allāh said, "I am leaving behind two weighty things for you: the Book of Allāh and my progeny. And these two will not part from each other until they come to me at the Pond." Then he placed his two fingers together to demonstrate how the Qur'ān and his '*itrah*' would always remain together. When Jābir heard this, he stood up and asked who the '*itrah*' of the Prophet were, so he (ṣ) replied, "Alī, [Fāṭimah], al-Ḥasan, al-Ḥusayn, and the Imāms from the descendants of al-Ḥusayn until the Day of Resurrection." This has been narrated by al-Ṣadūq in his *Kamāl al-Dīn*, from Imām al-Ṣādiq (MB).

The phrase *his family are the best kinsmen* refers to the Banū Hāshim, who were known to be the best clan of Quraysh (T). As for his *lineal tree*, it is either a reference to Ibrāhīm, or Ismā'īl ('*ā*'), or to Hāshim (M), or to Quraysh (T). It may even be referring to himself, meaning the tree of his lineage and progeny who would descend from him (MB). Describing this tree, the Imām *says it grew in sanctity and excelled in nobility. It has tall branches and unreachable fruits*. Some understand the phrase '*nabatāt fī ḥaramin*' to mean that it grew in the sacred precinct (*ḥaram*) of Makkah where the forefathers of the Prophet hailed from, while others say that it connotes honour and sanctity, meaning that the lineal tree of the Prophet grew in sanctity. As for the phrase '*basaqāt fī karamin*' – where the verb '*basaqāt*' connotes development and has been glossed as *tālat* (i.e. grew tall) by some commentaries (R) – signifies the greatness of the environment in which the Prophet grew up, being surrounded by his noble family and honourable individuals within it (N). The portrayal of its branches as tall emphasizes its eminence and distinction, and its fruits as described as unreachable, meaning the knowledge and merit of the Prophet's family is so great that they cannot be compared to any other family (M).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn then describes the Noble Messenger as *the leader of those who are Godwary and the means of insight for those who follow guidance*, since he is the leader of those who are devoted to Allāh and obey His commandments while

at the same time being a good role model for them, thereby illuminating the way for them through his conduct (MB). As such, he is like *a lamp whose flame is glowing, a shooting star whose light is shining, and a flint whose spark is bright*. It is possible that these three similitudes point to a single reality, which is the luminous existence of the person of the Noble Prophet, as well as his speech, actions, and thought. It may also be that the example of the *lamp* ('*sirāʾ*') alludes to the aspect of guidance from him, while the bright, shooting star ('*shihāb*') points to his repelling the devils and those who stand against the truth, and the similitude of the flint ('*zand*') pertains to the fact that the Prophet lit the first sparks in those who had the capacity, giving rise to the flame that would propel them towards perfection (N).

The phrase '*sīratuhu al-qasḍ*' has been translated *his conduct is upright*, and means that he followed a balanced, middle path, neither exceeding the bounds nor falling short (T). As such, his *sunnah* is a means of right guidance ('*al-rushd*'), his speech is decisive ('*al-faṣl*'), clearly distinguishing between truth and falsehood, and his judgment is just ('*al-ʿadl*'), without any bias or deviation (MB). The general connotation of all this is that the Noble Messenger never strayed from the path of truth and justice, even for a moment, and nothing could make him do so. Finally, the Imām notes that Allāh sent the Prophet after an interval in the sequence of Messengers ('*fatratin min al-rusul*'), at a time *when people were erring in their actions and nations were steeped in ignorance*. It is obvious that if ignorance and evil are pervasive in a society, and corruption engulfs it from all sides, then the work of the chosen Messengers and those who call for justice and morality becomes more difficult, and the greatness of their achievement in reforming such a society is more pronounced (N). And this was the case with our Noble Prophet (s).

4 In the last section of this oration, Imām 'Alī offers advice and admonition to his listeners. He tells them to *act according to the definitive signs* ('*al-āmin bayyinah*'), which some commentators understand as a prohibition against innovation in religion (R). Others construe *definitive signs* here as a reference to leaders on the path of guidance ('*a'immat al-hudā*'), or the evident laws of Allāh mentioned in His Book and in the Sunnah of His Prophet (Z). The Imām reminds them that it is not difficult to traverse this path because *the path is clear* ('*al-ṭarīqu nahjun*'), and its destination is known as it *leads to the Abode of Peace* (N).

ADMONISHING THE PEOPLE

عظة الناس

- 4 Act according to the definitive signs - may Allāh have mercy on you - for the path is clear and leads to the Abode of Peace. [Do this] while you are in the abode of propitiation, with opportunity and time; while the books [of your deeds] are open and the pens [of angels] are writing; while the bodies are healthy, the tongues are free, repentance is heard, and [good] deeds are accepted.

۴ اَعْمَلُوا - رَحِمَكُمُ اللَّهُ - عَلَى أَعْلَامٍ
بَيِّنَةٍ، فَالطَّرِيقُ نَهْجٌ يَدْعُو إِلَى دَارِ
السَّلَامِ، وَأَنْتُمْ فِي دَارٍ مُسْتَعْتَبٍ عَلَى
مَهَلٍ وَفَرَاغٍ، وَالصُّحُفُ مَنشُورَةٌ،
وَالْأَقْلَامُ جَارِيَةٌ، وَالْأَبْدَانُ صَحِيحَةٌ،
وَاللُّسُنُ مُطْلَقَةٌ، وَالتَّوْبَةُ مَسْمُوعَةٌ،
وَالْأَعْمَالُ مَقْبُولَةٌ.

The literal translation of '*yad'ū ilā dār al-salām*' is 'it invites to the Abode of Peace,' and the act of inviting by the path itself is meant metaphorically, because it is the one who shows the people the path and guides them towards it that actually invites them to Paradise (M). The Imām then reminds them that their time in this world is limited, telling them to follow the guidance they have while they are in *the abode of propitiation*, meaning a place wherein it is possible to make amends and appease the Almighty by repenting, reforming, and undertaking good deeds to make up for all the evil one has done (MB). This can be achieved in the world because of the availability of *opportunity and time* ('*mahālīn wa farāgh*') to think, consider, and perform good deeds, before the coming of death (M). Hence, the Imām urges them to act now, while the books of their deeds are open and the pens of angels are writing; *while the bodies are healthy, the tongues are free, repentance is heard, and good deeds are accepted*. With all these enabling factors present, it would be a cause of great regret for one to still not take advantage thereof for his own betterment in the Hereafter. None of these blessings of time, opportunity, health, freedom, and ability have been guaranteed to last for even one more day. Any or all of them can be taken away from a person in a split second. Then the doors of repentance are shut, the books of deeds are sealed, and the pens that record them stop writing. All this happens when one passes away, and indeed everyone will one day die – that is the inescapable reality (N).



ON THE DISTINCTION OF THE NOBLE PROPHET

1 He sent him when the people were lost in bewilderment and were recklessly engaging in mischief. Desires had lured them, self-conceit had caused them to stumble, and extreme nescience had made them temerarious. They were perplexed in the instability of their affair and the tribulation of their ignorance. Then he (s) expended the utmost effort in sincere admonition, traversed the path [of guidance], and called [them] towards wisdom and good counsel.

١ بَعَثَهُ وَالنَّاسُ ضَلَالٌ فِي حَيْرَةٍ،
وَحَابِطُونَ فِي فِتْنَةٍ، قَدْ
اسْتَهْوَتْهُمْ الْأَهْوَاءُ، وَاسْتَرَلَتْهُمْ
الْكِبَرِيَاءُ، وَاسْتَحَفَّتْهُمْ الْجَاهِلِيَّةُ
الْجَهْلَاءُ؛ حَيَارَى فِي زَلْزَالٍ مِنَ
الْأَمْرِ وَبَلَاءٍ مِنَ الْجَهْلِ، فَبَالَغَ
ﷺ فِي النَّصِيحَةِ وَمَضَى عَلَى
الطَّرِيقَةِ، وَدَعَا إِلَى الْحِكْمَةِ
وَالْمَوْعِظَةِ الْحَسَنَةِ.

CONTEXT

This seems to be an excerpt of a longer sermon, and no other source besides *Nahj al-Balāghah* is mentioned for it. Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd's version of this oration does contain some variance in wording thereby giving the impression that he was in possession of an alternative source of this sermon (N). From its contents, it is evident that the Imām spoke these words in order to underscore the importance of the religion of Islam and of the Noble Prophet who brought its teachings to the people. By describing the state of the people before its advent, and comparing how they lived to their lives at the present time, the Imām was able to show the valuable role of the Messenger of Allāh in uplifting the society of that time, and removing the bane of ignorance from them. The importance of this message was the reason behind its being repeated by the Imām time and again, and that is why we find it to be a recurring theme in many of his sermons (Z). Unfortunately, we do not have any more information about the context of this sermon. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes it as part of his sermon no. 18 wherein he has joined all

the orations that talk about the merits of the Noble Messenger and how he brought guidance to a people who were steeped in ignorance and barbarity.

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām states that Allāh sent the Noble Prophet, Muḥammad (ṣ), at a time *when the people were lost in bewilderment and were recklessly engaging in mischief*. There were different religious groups that existed among the Arabs during the time of the Prophet, including: idolators, dualists, pagan naturalists, Jews, Christians, Magians, and Sabaeans (T). Yet most of the people were *lost in bewilderment* (*‘dullālun fi ḥayrah*’); indeed, if one is both lost and bewildered, his chances of finding the way and being saved are much less when compared to one who is only lost, for the latter can use signs and landmarks to find his way while the former’s state of bewilderment would prevent him from being able to do this (N). The phrase *‘khābiṭūna fi fitnah*’ means coming together, one and all, to engage in mischief or corruption (R). Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd’s version reads *‘ḥāṭibūna*’ instead of *‘khābiṭūna*’, and is the plural of *ḥāṭib* which means one who gathers firewood. It is also a term used for one who gathers together that which is good and bad, or whose speech contains good and bad (I). However, the version quoted here is more correct, and the second form could only have been considered correct if it was *‘ḥāṭibu laylin*’ which gives the meaning mentioned by Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd, while the term *ḥāṭib* on its own simply refers to a gatherer of firewood (T). In any case, the phrase is talking about the state of the Arabs at that time, and how they would act contrary to what is expected in an organized community (MB), or even in a civilized society. The Imām then explains the reason for their behaviour, saying that it was because *desires had lured them, self-conceit had caused them to stumble, and extreme nescience had made them temerarious*. The phrase *‘istahwathum al-ahwā’* means that their whims and caprice had enticed them, or had led them to destruction (M). The term *‘al-kibriyā’* here connotes haughtiness (*takabbur*) (T), and *‘istakhaffathum al-jāhiliyyat al-jahlā’* means that the state of utter ignorance and lack of knowledge made them rash and reckless, or foolish and imprudent (MB).

The instability of their state and the tribulation of their utter ignorance left the Arabs of that age perplexed (*‘ḥayārī’*). Indeed, ignorance is the greatest tribulation for any community. Due to it, the Arabs would engage in infanticide,

killing their own children out of fear of poverty and starvation. They also invented all sorts of other illogical and harmful practices and customs, all resulting from their ignorance (T). One commentator says that this was comparable to the condition of the people before the coming of Prophet Mūsā (‘a) as well (S). The phrase ‘*al-jāhiliyyat al-jahlā*’ is used to emphasize the extent of their ignorance, just as the phrase *al-layl al-alyal* (where the term *layl* is repeated) emphasizes the darkness of a specific night (M). Then the Noble Prophet (ṣ) came to them and *expended the utmost effort in sincere admonition*. The term ‘*al-naṣiḥah*’ generally means wishing someone well and wanting what is good for him. It is also used to refer to sincere and honest advice and admonition. The Messenger of Allāh wanted his people to attain felicity and hence tried to guide them on the right path – the path of guidance which he was upon and traversed himself. Indeed, he was a man of action and not just words, and his conduct was effective in guiding the people as his speech (N). He called the people *towards wisdom and good counsel*, with advice that would penetrate the depths of their hearts. Some commentators have understood this to mean that the Noble Prophet would use wisdom and good counsel when inviting the people, thereby acting upon the instruction in the verse: *Call to the way of your Lord with wisdom and good exhortation...* (Q16:125) (MB, T).



ABOUT ALLĀH AND THE NOBLE PROPHET

ALLĀH THE EXALTED

- 1 All praise be to Allāh, the First with nothing before Him and the Last with nothing after Him. The Manifest with nothing above Him and the Hidden with nothing deeper than Him.

الله تعالى

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الْأَوَّلِ فَلَا شَيْءَ قَبْلَهُ،
وَالْآخِرِ فَلَا شَيْءَ بَعْدَهُ، وَالظَّاهِرِ فَلَا
شَيْءَ فَوْقَهُ، وَالْبَاطِنِ فَلَا شَيْءَ دُونَهُ.

ABOUT THE PROPHET (S)

- 2 His abode was the best abode and his birthplace the noblest of birthplaces, in the wellsprings of honour and the cradles of security. The hearts of the virtuous were made to incline to him and all eyes were turned to gaze towards him. Through him Allāh buried their rancour and put out the fire of enmity [between them]. He united them as brothers, through him, and separated those who were close [due to their unbelief]. Through him He honoured the abased and abased the [falsely] honoured. His speech was clear and his silence was expressive.

ومنها في ذكر الرسول ﷺ

٢ مُسْتَقَرُّهُ خَيْرُ مُسْتَقَرٍّ، وَمَنْبِيُّهُ
أَشْرَفُ مَنْبِئٍ، فِي مَعَادِنِ
الْكِرَامَةِ وَمَمَاهِدِ السَّلَامَةِ، قَدْ
صُرِفَتْ نَحْوُهُ أَفْنِدَةُ الْأَبْرَارِ،
وُثِّبَتْ إِلَيْهِ أَرْزَمَةُ الْأَبْصَارِ؛ دَفَنَ
اللَّهُ بِهِ الصَّغَائِنَ وَأَطْفَاءَ النِّوَابِرِ،
أَلْفَ بِهِ إِخْوَانًا وَفَرَّقَ بِهِ أَقْرَانًا،
أَعَزَّ بِهِ الدَّلَّةَ وَأَذَلَّ بِهِ الْعِرَّةَ،
كَلامُهُ بَيَانٌ وَصَمْتُهُ لِسَانٌ.

CONTEXT

There is no recorded context for this sermon, and it appears to have been mentioned only in *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). It consists of two sections, the first of which is praise for Allāh, and the second, longer section, is about the Noble Messenger. Some commentators have mentioned these two sections separately (T), and the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* mentions the first section as part

of his 29th sermon which he calls ‘al-Bālighah’, saying that it was the oration given by Imām ‘Alī on the first Friday after he became caliph. However, given the general nature of the statements, it is quite probable that the Imām repeated these words of praise on numerous occasions. In fact, even the second part of the sermon has a general purport and therefore, not knowing its exact context does not hinder the understanding of its meaning.

COMMENTARY

1 As with most, if not all, of his sermons, the Imām begins by praising Allāh and extolling Him. In doing so, he refers to the Almighty as *the First with nothing before Him and the Last with nothing after Him*. Some commentators gloss this as His having no beginning or end (Z), whereas others refer to the unchanging state of the Almighty, for everything other than Him is pervious to change and alteration and therefore qualities like being first or last may apply to them, but that is not the case with Allāh (T). Further details about this have been discussed in the commentary of sermon no. 64. The Imām also describes Him as *the Manifest with nothing above Him and the Hidden with nothing deeper than Him*. Some have understood the terms ‘*fawqahu*’ and ‘*dūnahu*’ to mean *more manifest* and *more hidden* respectively. That is because nothing is more manifest than Him, since His signs permeate everything in existence. At the same time, nothing is more hidden than Him because His Essence is unknowable (N). An alternative interpretation is that ‘*al-Zāhir*’ here means the One who overpowers everything and nothing can overcome Him, while ‘*al-Bāṭin*’ means that He knows what is hidden deep within the minds and hearts, and nothing is inaccessible to Him (Z).

2 In this part of the oration, the Imām talks about the virtues and merits of the Messenger of Allāh. He begins by mentioning his origins, saying that *His abode was the best abode and his birthplace the noblest of birthplaces, in the wellsprings of honour and the cradles of security*. The term ‘*mustaqarr*’ has been rendered as abode, and ‘*manbit*’ has been translated as birthplace. However, these two terms have a more general meaning, with the first signifying a place of settlement and the second denoting a place of growth and development. As such, commentators have offered differing interpretations of this statement. Some say that ‘*mustaqarr*’ here refers to the city of Madīnah, which became the Messenger’s abode, whereas ‘*manbit*’ refers to the city of Makkah (T). Others say that the first term refers to

Makkah whereas the second one refers to his noble lineage (Z). Yet others say that these two terms refer to the loins and womb of his parents, who were both monotheists (N). It may also be that the first refers to Makkah and the second to Madīnah (MB). *The wellsprings of honour and the cradles of security* are the respective qualities of his birthplace and abode (T), with the latter being a likely reference to Madīnah, where the Prophet finally felt safe from the persecution of the polytheists (Z). Alternatively, the phrase *wellsprings of honour* is a reference to prophethood, and *cradles of security* refers to the place that was free of filth and flaws, both apparent and hidden (MB), and this points to the honourable lineage of the Noble Messenger (N). The verbs ‘*ṣurifat*’ and ‘*thuniyat*’ have been mentioned in the passive tense to underscore the fact that it was by Allāh’s grace that *the hearts of the virtuous were made to incline to him and all eyes were turned to gaze towards him* (M). The reason people were attracted towards him was his impeccable character, and qualities such as humility and kindness (S), and because of this he stood out in a society that was filled with corruption and decadence, gaining the titles ‘*al-Ṣādiq*’ (the truthful) and ‘*al-Amīn*’ (the trustworthy) long before he began his prophetic mission. In fact, the love that was felt for him during his lifetime still persists even now in the hearts of believers (Z). Some commentators say this was actually the outcome of the supplication that had been made by Prophet Ibrāhīm in which he asked Allāh to *make the hearts of some people incline towards his progeny* (Q14:37) (MB).

Through the blessed presence of the Noble Messenger, Allāh *buried their rancour and put out the fire of enmity* between them. For instance, the generations-old animosity that existed between the Aws and the Khazraj was done away with through the Prophet, and the fires (‘*al-nawā’ir*’) of hatred were extinguished. This was one of the great blessings of Allāh, as the Qur’ān states: *Remember the blessing of Allah upon you, when you were enemies and He united your hearts, so by His blessing you became brothers...* (Q3:103). Thus, through the Noble Prophet, Allāh *united them as brothers* based on their belief in Him, while separating those who were close because of their unbelief. Indeed, many a believer had to cut off ties with his brother, father, uncle, son, or any other relative or friend due to their rejection of faith (T). For example, ‘Utbah ibn Rabī’ah was one of the first to stand up and fight against the Muslims in the Battle of Badr, while his son Ḥudhayfah fought on the side of the Messenger of Allāh. Likewise, ‘Abd al-Raḥmān ibn Abī Bakr was on the side of the polytheists, while his father Abū Bakr was with the

Prophet (Z). Through the Prophet, Allāh *honoured the abased, and abased the falsely honoured*. Some take this to mean that Islam, which was deemed lowly by those who had might and power, was raised up to a position of honour and authority, while polytheism, which used to be mighty, was abased. Thus the Muslims gained a dignified station due to their belief, like in the case of Salmān al-Fārsī, whereas the idolators lost their power and status due to their disbelief, like in the case of Abū Lahab (MB). Initially, the Muslims were deemed low and disparaged because of their poverty and lack of numbers, but gradually, by the blessing of Allāh they increased in number and wealth, and by the wise leadership of the Prophet they were able to gain superiority and a lofty status (N). In the end, the last quality of the Messenger of Allāh which Imām ‘Alī mentions is that *his speech was clear and his silence was expressive*. The phrase *‘kalāmuhu bayān’* has been interpreted in various ways. Some say that it means his speech was always true and just (Z), or that he would never speak out of his own whim, as the verses state: *Nor does he speak from [some] whim. It is nothing but a revelation revealed* (Q53:3-4) (T). It may also mean that through his speech, he clarified for the people what was required of them and imparted the teachings of Islam (M). At the same time, *his silence was expressive* (*‘šamtuhu lisān’*), meaning that even his silence conveyed meanings just as his words did, and was likewise beneficial. As we know, the silence of an Infallible implies tacit approval (*taqrīr*), which is probative, like his speech (MB). It could also indicate situations in which the Prophet was showing that silence was more appropriate. Indeed, there are times when silence conveys what even speech is unable to convey. Therefore, it is important for a person to know when to speak and when to stay silent (Z).



ON HIS COMPANIONS AND THE COMPANIONS OF THE MESSENGER OF ALLĀH

THE COMPANIONS OF ‘ALĪ (‘a)

أصحاب علي عليه السلام

- 1 Even if Allāh gives the oppressor time, He will never leave him unpunished. He ambushes him upon the road he travels and obstructs him like a bone choking his throat. Indeed, by He in whose hand is my soul, these people will attain victory over you, not because they are closer to the truth than you but because they are quick in acting on the falsehood of their leader while you are slow in observing my right. Nations today are fearful of the oppression of their rulers while I fear the oppression of my subjects. I sought to mobilize you for battle but you did not come forward. I made you hear but you did not listen. I called you secretly and openly, but you did not respond. I gave you sincere advice, but you did not accept it.

وَلَكِنَّ أَمَهْلَ اللَّهِ الظَّالِمَ فَلَنْ يَفُوتَ
أَخْذُهُ، وَهُوَ لَهُ بِالْمِرْصَادِ عَلَى مَجَارِ
طَرِيقِهِ، وَبِمَوْضِعِ الشَّجَا مِنْ مَسَاغِ
رِيقِهِ. أَمَّا وَالَّذِي نَفْسِي بِيَدِهِ،
لَيُظْهِرَنَّ هَؤُلَاءِ الْقَوْمَ عَلَيْكُمْ، لَيْسَ
لَاَنَّهُمْ أَوْلَى بِالْحَقِّ مِنْكُمْ، وَلَكِنْ
لِإِسْرَاعِهِمْ إِلَى بَاطِلِ صَاحِبِهِمْ،
وَإِطْأَائِكُمْ عَنْ حَقِّي. وَلَقَدْ
أَصْبَحَتِ الْأُمَمُ تَخَافُ ظُلْمَ رُعَاتِهَا،
وَأَصْبَحَتْ أَخَافُ ظُلْمَ رَعِيَّتِي.
اسْتَنْفَرْتُكُمْ لِلْجِهَادِ فَلَمْ تَنْفِرُوا،
وَأَسْمَعْتُكُمْ فَلَمْ تَسْمَعُوا، وَدَعَوْتُكُمْ
سِرًّا وَجَهْرًا فَلَمْ تَسْتَجِيبُوا،
وَنَصَحْتُ لَكُمْ فَلَمْ تَقْبَلُوا.

CONTEXT

This sermon compares the companions of Imām ‘Alī to those of the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ). It is said to have been delivered after the Battle of Nahrawān when the people of Kūfah refused to rise up and face the raiding armies sent by Mu‘āwiyah to different regions. What al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has quoted here is actually an excerpt of a much longer sermon, parts of which have been mentioned in a number of sources such as *Kitāb Sulaym ibn Qays al-Hilālī*, al-Kulaynī’s *al-Kāfi*, al-Mufid’s

Kitāb al-Irshād, Sibṭ ibn al-Jawzī's *Tadhkirah*, Ibn 'Asākir's *Tārīkh Damishq*, and al-Jāhiz's *al-Bayān wal-Tabyīn*, as well as a number of other sources, many of which were written before the time of al-Raḍī (N). The overall message of this sermon is a rebuke of his companions for their unwillingness to defend their lands and fight against the invading forces (MB). The Imām said this in the hope that it would rouse a sense of honour in the people and motivate them to take up arms against the enemy. To this end, he employed different statements of reproof, seeking to awaken them from their slumber of heedlessness. He even reminded them of the positive qualities of some companions of the Noble Prophet, in terms of their piety, faith, worship, and struggle in the way of Allāh with steadfastness and courage (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening section of the sermon is a warning addressed to the people of Shām, or to his companions (MB), with some commentators insisting that it was the former (M), while others say it was the latter (N). In any case, the reality that oppressors are never left unpunished, even if they are given some respite for a while, echoes what the Qur'ān states in the verse: *Never think that Allāh is heedless of what the unjust do; He only grants them respite until a day when eyes will stare [in horror], transfixed* (Q14:42). Indeed, Allāh knows all that His servants do, and He will surely requite those who act unjustly and oppress others, and nothing can thwart Him in the heavens or earth (Z). By stating that *He ambushes him upon the road he travels and obstructs him like a bone choking his throat*, the Imām was emphasizing that not only would nobody escape retribution, but their punishment will be sudden and swift. At the same time, mentioning the bone choking the throat hints at how the tyrant could be chastised using the same things by which he derives pleasure (MB) – the same throat through which he consumes what he finds tasty and delectable can become a means of punishment for him by having a bone stuck therein. The Imām then tells his listeners that they would be the losers, and their Syrian enemies would attain victory over them. He explains the reason for this, saying that it was *not because they are closer to the truth* but because *they are quick in acting on the falsehood of their leader* while his own followers were slow in observing his right and obeying his instructions.

Despite being upon the truth, and listening to his words, the Imām's followers did not heed his call and obey him. In contrast, even though Mu'āwiyah was

manifestly on the side of falsehood, his followers were united in obeying him. So it is not surprising that the latter would gain victory over the former (Z). Another point we learn from this statement is that when a group attains victory, it should not be concluded that their triumph was the result of their virtue, or siding with the truth. Rather, those who are united and work together to attain their goal have a better chance of winning. And there are numerous examples of this in history and even in the present day (N). To further strengthen his argument against them, the Imām notes that while most nations *are fearful of the oppression of their rulers*, he is afraid of the oppression of his subjects. Then he explains how his people have oppressed him, saying that when he sought to mobilize them for battle against the enemy, they *did not come forward*. He tried to make them hear, but they *did not listen*. He called them secretly and openly, but they *did not respond*. He even gave them sincere advice, but they *did not accept it*. Whoever knows about the situation of the Imām during his caliphate is aware of this reality. There were times when he could not even make his view known openly because of all the opposition he faced. He had only a few sincere and loyal followers, whereas the majority did not recognize his right to unfaltering loyalty and unquestioning obedience (MB).

2 His rhetorical question *are you present like those absent* is a form of rebuke to them due to their lack of response (T), as if to say that they are present physically but their minds are absent (Z). Likewise, he asks if they are *slaves in the guise of masters*, which could mean that though they are the eminent ones among the Arabs, their hearts are lowly and they lack valour, behaving like timid slaves. Alternatively it may mean that despite being his subjects, whose obedience to him is mandatory just as slaves have to obey their master, they behave like they are the masters by obstinately refusing to obey (MB). Some have glossed this line as: you do not care about rebuke and you do not fear punishment (T), and others say that they were like slaves in their lowliness and contemptible conduct, yet acted haughtily and arrogantly like masters (Z). The Imām then describes their attitude in more detail, saying that when he relates to them words of wisdom, they recoil, and when he counsels them with *far-reaching advice* (*‘al-mawīzat al-bālighah*), they disperse. This was because they had decided not to listen to him but would instead heed their own base desires and whims (Z). *Those who have rebelled* (*‘ahl al-baghy*) refers to Mu‘āwiyah and his Syrian followers (M), and *the people of Sabā* (*‘ayādī sabā*) is a simile, where the term *‘ayādī* actually refers to children,

2 Are you present like those absent, and slaves in the guise of masters?! I relate to you words of wisdom yet you recoil from them, I counsel you with far-reaching advice yet you disperse from it. I motivate you to fight against those who have rebelled but before I reach the end of my speech, I see you disperse like the people of Sabā. You return to your sittings and deceive one another [by speaking] against the counsel given to you. I set you straight in the morning but you return to me in the evening [bent] like the back of a bow. Weary is the straightener and incorrigible the straightened. O you whose bodies are present but whose wits are absent, [you] whose whims are diverse and who are a tribulation for their rulers. Your leader obeys Allāh yet you disobey him, while the leader of the people of Shām disobeys Allāh yet they obey him. By Allāh, I would have liked Mu‘āwiyah to exchange you for me as *dīnārs* are exchanged for *dirhams*, such that he takes from me ten of you and gives me one man from them.

أَشْهُودُ كَغَيَْابٍ وَعَيْدٌ كَأَرْبَابٍ!
أَتْلُو عَلَيْكُمُ الْحِكْمَ فَتَنْفِرُونَ مِنْهَا،
وَأَعْظَاكُمْ بِالْمَوْعِظَةِ الْبَالِغَةِ فَتَتَفَرَّقُونَ
عَنْهَا، وَأَحْكُمُكُمْ عَلَى جِهَادِ أَهْلِ
الْبَغْيِ فَمَا آتَيْ عَلَى آخِرِ قَوْلِي
حَتَّى أَرَاكُمْ مُتَفَرِّقِينَ أَيَْادِي سَبَا،
تَرْجِعُونَ إِلَى مَجَالِسِكُمْ
وَتَتَخَادَعُونَ عَنْ مَوَاعِظِكُمْ،
أَقُومُكُمْ عُذُوَّةً وَتَرْجِعُونَ إِلَيَّ عَشِيَّةً
كَظَهْرِ الْحَنِيَّةِ، عَجَزَ الْمُقَوْمُ وَأَعْضَلَ
الْمُقَوْمُ. أَيُّهَا الشَّاهِدَةُ أَبْدَانُهُمُ الْغَائِبَةُ
عَنْهُمْ عُقُولُهُمْ، الْمُخْتَلِفَةُ أَهْوَاؤُهُمْ
الْمُبْتَلَى بِهِمْ أَمْرَاؤُهُمْ، صَاحِبُكُمْ
يُطِيعُ اللَّهَ وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْصُونَ، وَصَاحِبُ
أَهْلِ الشَّامِ يَعْصِي اللَّهَ وَهُمْ يُطِيعُونَهُ،
لَوَدِدْتُ وَاللَّهِ أَنْ مُعَاوِيَةَ صَارَ فَنِي
بِكُمْ صَرَفَ الدِّينَارِ بِالدِّرْهَمِ، فَأَخَذَ
مِنِّي عَشْرَةَ مِنْكُمْ وَأَعْطَانِي رَجُلًا
مِنْهُمْ.

because one takes the help of one's children just as one uses the assistance of his own hands (R). Sabā was a man from Yemen, and he had ten children. He would regularly take benefit from his children, but later on, they all dispersed and established themselves in far off corners, and from them a whole tribe sprung forth. Their dispersal was proverbial and hence people would refer to it as an example of being scattered far away from each other (N). The Imām uses this

simile to describe how, when he tried to motivate the people to rise up against their enemy, before he could complete his speech, they would disperse and move far away.

They then returned to their sittings only to *deceive one another* ('*tatakhāda'ūn*') by speaking against the counsel given to them by the Imām. This they would either do by considering his words as fables (T), or disregarding it and acting as though they had not heard anything. One of the meanings of *takhādu'* is turning one's back on something (Z). The Arabs would use this verb (*khada'a*) to describe the action of someone who regularly gives and then suddenly stops giving, withholding his generosity (I). The Imām then tells them *I set you straight in the morning but you return to me in the evening bent like the back of a bow. Weary is the straightener and incorrigible the straightened*. These statements point to an important fact, namely that there were many hypocrites among the people of Iraq who made a concerted effort to nullify the effects of the Imām's speech. When people would come to listen to Imām 'Alī, they were captivated by his eloquence and awed by his presence and sublime etiquette, and they listened to his speech and were affected thereby. However, when they returned to their own gatherings, some devilish individuals would begin spreading false ideas and would confuse the people, thereby weakening their resolve and causing divisions among them. This is what the Imām means by his figurative statement that they were straightened by him in the morning but returned bent in the evening (N). The phrase "*ajaza al-muqawwim*" is rendered *weary is the straightener*, and refers to his weariness as a result of his futile attempts to straighten their thinking and their condition. From this description, we learn that the Kūfans at that time were not steadfast and lacked resolve (S). It is narrated by Nāfi' ibn Kulayb that he once went to Kūfah in order to meet the Imām, and sat by the pulpit as Imām 'Alī delivered a sermon, wearing a black turban. When he descended, his eyes were tearing up and he said, "*Indeed we belong to Allāh and to Him is our return. I straighten them by day and they return by night, bent – until when will this continue!?*" (T).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn then rebukes them once more, referring to them as people *whose bodies are present but whose wits are absent*, since they did not reason with their intellects (MB). He further describes them as those *whose whims are diverse and who are a tribulation for their rulers*. The phrase '*al-mukhtalifatu ahwā'uhum*' means that their ideas and opinions differed, with each one among them thinking of his own interests and ambitions (Z). Further explanation of this phrase is

presented in the beginning of the commentary on sermon no. 29. The result of all these negative traits is that such subjects become a bane and a tribulation for their leaders. Hence the Imām expressed his wish that Mu‘āwiyah would exchange them for him *as dīnārs are exchanged for dirhams*, such that he takes ten of them and gives him one man from his side in return. The disparagement in this statement is clear, since he equates the Syrian soldiers to gold and his own soldiers to silver, preferring one of the former to ten of the latter (MB). Some commentators understand this to mean that the Syrians were known to be obedient followers who remained steadfast behind their ruler, whereas the Iraqis were stubborn rebels, as history repeatedly showed (N). Others say that if such a trade had ever taken place, and the Syrians were exchanged for the Iraqis, they would have turned out to be even more treacherous and disloyal than the latter, because their obedience was based on their own interests, and Mu‘āwiyah had used bribery, monetary incentives, and other underhanded tactics to win them over, whereas Imām ‘Alī’s policies were based on truth and establishing of rights (Z). In any case, this example of exchanging his followers just as dirhams are exchanged for dīnārs was later employed by ‘Abdullāh ibn al-Zubayr when he addressed the people of Baṣrah, saying that he wishes he could exchange ten of the Iraqis for one Syrian, the way ten dirhams are exchanged for one dīnār (I). Interestingly, this exchange rate would later change, and by al-Mutawakkil’s time, one dīnār was equivalent to fifteen dirhams (T).

3 The Imām then addresses the Kūfans and tells them of the five qualities he has found in them. He uses the phrase *three qualities and two others* instead of simply saying ‘five qualities’. It has been suggested that this was because three of the qualities were positive whereas two were negative, and the Imām wanted to separate them (I). Others say that the reason for this separation was simply because three of them were in relation to one issue while two others pertain to a completely different matter, so according to the rules of elocution, they should be separated (T). What we note, however, is that these were five qualities in them that were all a tribulation for the Imām, yet he divided them in this way because three of them were present in them, while two were absent (R). The three qualities were being deaf despite having ears (‘*ṣummun dhawū asmāʿ*’), dumb despite the ability to speak (‘*bukmun dhawū kalām*’), and blind despite having eyes to see (‘*umyun dhawū aḥṣār*’). Anything that does not fulfil its function is like a missing

3 O people of Kūfah, I have encountered among you three qualities and two others: deafness in spite of having ears, dumbness in spite of the ability to speak, and blindness in spite of having eyes; neither [are you] truly free men during combat nor [are you] reliable brothers during tribulation. May your hands cleave to the dust! O you who are like the camels whose herdsmen have left them, whenever they are herded together from one side they disperse from the other. By Allāh, it is as if I see you, when the battle rages and the fighting becomes intense, separating from the son of Abū Ṭālib as a woman separates in parturition [from her newborn]. Indeed I stand on manifest proof from my Lord and the way of my Prophet, and I am certainly on the clear path which I have chosen above all others.

٣ يَا أَهْلَ الْكُوفَةِ، مَنِيتُ مِنْكُمْ بِثَلَاثٍ
وَأُتْنَتَيْنِ: صُمٌّ ذَوُو أَسْمَاعٍ، وَبُكْمٌ
ذَوُو كَلَامٍ، وَعُغْمِي ذَوُو أَبْصَارٍ، لَا
أَحْرَارٌ صِدْقٍ عِنْدَ اللَّقَاءِ، وَلَا
إِخْوَانٌ ثَقَّةٍ عِنْدَ الْبَلَاءِ، تَرَبَّتْ
أَيْدِيكُمْ! يَا أَشْبَاهَ الْإِبِلِ غَابَ عَنْهَا
رُعَاتُهَا كُلَّمَا جُمِعَتْ مِنْ جَانِبٍ
تَفَرَّقَتْ مِنْ آخَرٍ، وَاللَّهِ لَكَأَنِّي بِكُمْ
فِيمَا إِحَالُ أَنْ لَوْ حَمَسَ الْوَعَى
وَحَمِي الضَّرَابُ، قَدْ انْفَرَجْتُمْ عَنِ
ابْنِ أَبِي طَالِبٍ انْفِرَاجَ الْمَرْأَةِ عَنْ
قُبْلِهَا، وَإِنِّي لَعَلَى بَيِّنَةٍ مِنْ رَبِّي
وَمَنْهَاجٍ مِنْ نَبِيِّي، وَإِنِّي لَعَلَى
الطَّرِيقِ الْوَاضِحِ الْقُطْبَةِ لَقُطًّا.

or absent thing, and the primary function of ears, tongues, and eyes is to hear, speak, and see, respectively. More precisely, these means of perception are meant to enable one to hear, see, and speak about the truth. So if the eyes do not benefit from what they see, or the ears from what they hear, and the tongue remains silent from speaking the truth, then it is as though these senses are absent to begin with (Z). Some commentators note that the way in which the Imām has phrased these three qualities shows a sense of amazement on his part, as well as rebuke. Indeed, these abilities were given to human beings so that they could secure their wellbeing and felicity in this world and the next, but if they make no use of them then there would remain little difference between them and cattle (MB).

As for the two qualities they completely lacked, the first was that they were not *truly free men during combat* (*‘lā aḥrāru ṣidqin ‘inda al-liqā’*), meaning that

they did not possess the honourable qualities of freemen, such as valour, loyalty, and nobility, and this became evident during encounters where their lives were on the line. It is in such situations that those who are truly free come to be known and distinguished from the lowly and ignoble individuals (M). The second quality they lacked was reliability during times of tribulation and hardship. They were not *reliable brothers* ('*ikhwānu thiqatin*') who could be depended upon in trying times. Their lack of resolve and steadfastness made them poor companions and followers to have (N). The imprecation *may your hands cleave to the dust!* means may no good come to you, and since dust is mentioned, it is as if the prayer seeks that poverty should befall them until they are covered in dust (I), or their hands get dusty (R). The Imām then describes them using two analogies, the first of which compares them to *camels whose herdsmen have left them, whenever they are herded together from one side they disperse from the other*. The herdsman's duty is to gather the camels, or any other kind of livestock, together and keep them in one place, such that they can all be seen by him. If a single one of them wanders off, he brings it back to the herd. But if the herdsman is absent, the camels may wander off and become prey for any predator. And this was precisely the condition of the Imām's companions, because their defiance of his instructions left them like camels without a herder, making them a target for every unscrupulous one (Z).

The second analogy used by the Imām to describe the Kūfans relates to how they behave *when the battle rages and the fighting becomes intense*. The phrase '*fī mā ikhāl*' means in my estimation, based on the signs I see (MB). During intense fighting, the Imām says that they separate from him *the way a woman separates in parturition* from her newborn. Some commentators have offered other interpretations for this statement, but this reading is the only one that befits the status of the Imām and adheres to the propriety of the situation and the rules of elocution (N). The analogy would thus be comparing their desire for separation from the Imām during the heat of battle to the desire of a woman in labour to deliver her child quickly, thereby separating herself from it physically, in order to gain relief from the pangs of childbirth. Indeed, at that moment, nothing is more beloved to her or desired by her than the attainment of such relief (MB). Finally, the Imām reminds them that he stands *on manifest proof* from his Lord and the way of the Noble Prophet, and is on the clear path which he chose above all others. By this he means that all his decisions are based on the Qur'ān and the Sunnah (Z).

Some commentators understand this to be a clear reference to his Imāmah, which is a position bestowed by Allāh, not the people (T).

The phrase '*alquṭuhu laqṭan*' generally connotes carefully gathering something from different places, and this is an action that requires both astuteness and precision. Here the Imām uses this expression to inform his listeners how he continually chooses the best course and carefully selects the most appropriate way to advance the cause of truth (N). Some opine that the expression also implicitly means that the paths of misguidance are many, and that is why from among all the paths, he had to carefully identify and select the correct path of guidance (I).

4 In this last section of the oration, the Imām talks about two important issues. The first pertains to those leaders and guides who will never lead the people astray, and who should therefore be followed by all believers. The second is regarding the positive qualities of the special companions of the Noble Messenger, who are worthy of emulation (N). He begins by telling the people to *observe the household of your Prophet* and by this he was referring to his noble self and the righteous from his progeny, the eleven infallible Imāms (MB). He instructed the people to *adhere to their direction and follow their footsteps, for they would never take you out of the path of guidance and would never cast you back into error*, because they were made pure from all forms of wrongdoing and filth, as has been clearly declared in the verse: *Allāh only desires to keep all uncleanness away from you, O People of the House, and to purify you [with] a thorough purification* (Q33:33). Furthermore, they are the counterpart of the Qur'ān as stated by the Messenger of Allāh in his famous declaration known as the ḥadīth of 'the two weighty things' (*al-thaqalayn*) (Z). Even if one does not believe in their infallibility, or their being specially chosen by Allāh, there is no doubt about their truthfulness. And the Almighty instructs us to *be with the truthful* (Q9:119), so to adhere to the Ahl al-Bayt would be to follow Allāh's command (T). When the Imām says that the Ahl al-Bayt would *never cast you back into error*, he means the old error and misguidance of the Age of Jāhiliyyah (MB). To emphasize this further, he advises the people to emulate the household of the Prophet, remaining seated when they remain seated, and rising up if they rise up. The consequences of not doing so are then outlined: *do not go ahead of them as you will stray, and do not lag behind them as you will be ruined*. Undoubtedly, circumstances differ based on the prevailing conditions, so whenever they rise up and fight, the believers should follow them in doing so,

THE COMPANIONS OF THE MESSENGER
OF ALLĀH (ﷺ)

- 4 Observe the household of your Prophet, adhere to their direction and follow their footsteps, for they would never take you out of [the path of] guidance and would never cast you back into error. If they remain seated, you should remain seated and if they rise up, you should rise up. Do not go ahead of them as you will stray, and do not lag behind them as you will be ruined. I have seen the companions of Muḥammad (ﷺ) and I do not see anyone among you resembling them. They spent their days with dishevelled hair and dusty faces, and passed the night in prostration and standing in worship. They would alternate between placing their foreheads and their cheeks [on the earth], and stand [quivering], as if their feet were on live coals, from the thought of their resurrection. Between their eyes there were calluses [that looked] like the knees of goats, from their long prostrations. When Allāh was mentioned, their eyes flowed with tears until their collars became wet, and they trembled just as trees shake on a stormy day, out of fear of punishment and hope for reward [from the Almighty].

أَصْحَابُ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ

٤ انْظُرُوا أَهْلَ بَيْتِ نَبِيِّكُمْ فَالْزَمُوا سَمَتَهُمْ وَاتَّبِعُوا أَثَرَهُمْ، فَلَنْ يُخْرِجُوكُمْ مِنْ هُدًى وَلَنْ يُعِيدُوكُمْ فِي رَدًى، فَإِنْ لَبَدُوا، فَالْبُدُوا وَإِنْ نَهَضُوا فَانْهَضُوا، وَلَا تَسْبِقُوهُمْ فَتَضِلُّوا وَلَا تَتَأَخَّرُوا عَنْهُمْ فَتَهْلِكُوا. لَقَدْ رَأَيْتُ أَصْحَابَ مُحَمَّدٍ ﷺ فَمَا أَرَى أَحَدًا مِنْكُمْ يَشَبِّهُهُمْ؛ لَقَدْ كَانُوا يُصْبِحُونَ شُعْثًا غُبْرًا، وَقَدْ بَاتُوا سُجَّدًا وَقِيَامًا، يُزَاوِحُونَ بَيْنَ جَبَاهِهِمْ وَخُدُودِهِمْ، وَيَقْفُونَ عَلَى مِثْلِ الْجَمْرِ مِنْ ذِكْرِ مَعَادِهِمْ، كَأَنَّ بَيْنَ أَعْيُنِهِمْ رُكْبَ الْمِعْرَى مِنْ طَوْلِ سُجُودِهِمْ، إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ هَمَلَتْ أَثْيُنُهُمْ حَتَّى تَبْلُ جُيُوبُهُمْ، وَمَادُوا كَمَا يَمِيدُ الشَّجَرُ يَوْمَ الرِّيحِ الْعَاصِفِ، خَوْفًا مِنَ الْعِقَابِ وَرَجَاءَ لِلتَّوَابِ.

and whenever they remain silent and acquiesce, in that too they should be followed. Not doing so would lead one to ruin and straying from the right course (N).

Imām ‘Alī then speaks about the Companions of Rasūlullāh (ṣ), telling the people that he had seen them, and that none of those present with him resemble them. He then goes on to describe them saying that *they spent their days with dishevelled hair and dusty faces, and passed the night in prostration and standing in worship*. It is obvious that the Imām was describing an elite group of the Prophet’s companions, because all those who were present among them did not have these qualities. Hence, another version of his statement reads *‘laqad ra’aytu ithran min aṣḥābih’* meaning *I have seen the elite among his companions* (T). The way he speaks about these individuals shows that none of them were alive any more. In fact, many of them passed away during the lifetime of the Noble Messenger himself. These included individuals like Ḥamzah, Jafar, Zayd ibn Ḥārithah, ‘Abdullāh ibn Rawāḥah, ‘Uthmān ibn Maẓ‘ūn, and Sa’d ibn Mu‘ādh. Those who died some time after the Messenger included Salmān, Abū Dharr, al-Miqdād, ‘Ammār, Ḥudhayfah, and others (T). These were the individuals who *would alternate between placing their foreheads and their cheeks on the earth, and would stand quivering, as if their feet were on live coals, from the thought of their resurrection*. They used to place their foreheads on the ground, and at times rub their cheeks on the dust, out of humility before their Lord. The example of standing on live coals is just an analogy for how restless they were due to their fear of the Day of Judgment (MB). Due to their lengthy prostrations (*sujūd*), they had developed calluses that looked *like the knees of goats*. This figurative description depicts how long they would prostrate for – until the skin of their foreheads would eventually become dry and hard (M). Indeed, the Qur’ān also mentions the marks on their faces resulting from their prostrations: *You see them bowing and prostrating [in prayer], seeking grace from Allāh and [His] pleasure. Their mark is on their faces from the effect of prostration...* (Q48:29).

Whenever Allāh was mentioned in front of them, *their eyes flowed with tears until their collars became wet*. Out of fear and awe of Allāh, *they trembled just as trees shake on a stormy day*. Indeed, the Qur’ān also describes some of these reactions of the true believers when it says: *those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allāh is mentioned...* (Q22:35) (T). It is noteworthy that the Imām described

their trembling and weeping as being out of both apprehension of punishment and desire for reward. This is the way of the true servants of Allāh – they balance fear and hope (MB). These were just a few of the traits of the pious and devoted companions of the Noble Prophet. Indeed, they also possessed many other positive traits such as honesty, sincerity, abstemiousness, etc. (Z).



ALLUDING TO THE OPPRESSION OF THE BANĪ UMAYYAH

1 By Allāh, they will continue until they leave nothing that is decreed unlawful but that they deem it lawful, and [leave] no pact but that they break it, and until there remains no brick house or woollen tent but that their oppression will enter it and their evil policies will leave its dwellers restless. [This will continue] until two groups rise up crying: one crying for its religion and the other for this world, and until the help accorded by one of you to one of them will be like a slave helping his master, when he is present he obeys him but when he is absent he speaks ill of him. [And until] the one among you in greatest distress [from their evil] will be he who holds the best opinion about Allāh. So if Allāh grants you wellbeing, accept it and if you are made to face trials, endure it, for verily the outcome will be in favour of the Godwary.

وَاللّٰهُ لَا يَزَالُونَ حَتَّى لَا يَدْعُوا
لِلّٰهِ مُحَرَّمًا إِلَّا أَشْتَحِلُّوهُ، وَلَا
عَقْدًا إِلَّا حَلُّوهُ، وَحَتَّى لَا يَبْقَى
بَيْتٌ مَدْرٍ وَلَا وَبَرٍ إِلَّا دَخَلَهُ
ظُلْمُهُمْ، وَتَبَا بِهِ سُوءُ رَغْبِهِمْ،
وَحَتَّى يَقُومَ الْبَاكِيَانِ يَبْكِيَانِ:
بَاكِ يَبْكِي لِدِينِهِ وَبَاكِ يَبْكِي
لِدُنْيَاةٍ، وَحَتَّى تَكُونَ نُصْرَةُ
أَحَدِكُمْ مِنْ أَحَدِهِمْ كَنُصْرَةِ
الْعَبْدِ مِنْ سَيِّدِهِ، إِذَا شَهِدَ أَطَاعَهُ
وَإِذَا غَابَ اغْتَابَ بِهِ، وَحَتَّى
يَكُونَ أَعْظَمُكُمْ فِيهَا عَنَاءً
أَحْسَنُكُمْ بِاللّٰهِ ظَنًّا، فَإِنْ أَتَاكُمْ
اللّٰهُ بِعَافِيَةٍ فَاقْبَلُوا وَإِنْ ابْتَلِيْتُمْ
فَاصْبِرُوا، فَإِنَّ الْعَاقِبَةَ
لِلْمُتَّقِينَ».

CONTEXT

This oration is about the oppression of Banū Umayyah. In it, Imām ‘Alī briefly describes what the reign of the Umayyads would bring in its wake for the Muslims. His words are so profound and eloquent that in a few sentences the Imām was able to depict the evils of this accursed dynasty. The purpose of doing so was to inform

people of the consequences of their inertness and lethargy in countering the enemy while they still could. This sermon has been related in other works, such as Ibrāhīm al-Thaqafi's *al-Ghārāt*, and Ibn Qutayba's *al-Imāmah wal-Siyāsah*. The latter says that these words were spoken by the Imām after a sermon wherein he responded to criticism for distributing wealth equally among the Muslims (sermon no. 126). Some have even related this sermon from *Tadhkirat al-Khawāṣṣ* of Ibn al-Jawzī and *al-Irshād* of al-Mufid (N). History attests to the validity of all these foretellings by the Imām and how they came to pass just as he had said. Their obliviousness and lack of attention to his warning led the Muslims to a state where they were tyrannically oppressed by the rulers in a manner that was unprecedented. All in all, this oration constitutes a strong answer to those simple-minded individuals who questioned the need of taking up arms against the Banī Umayyah and asked why Muslims should fight Muslims (N).

COMMENTARY

1 He begins by swearing that *they will continue*, meaning the oppressors (MB, I, R), and more specifically, the Umayyad rulers (N, M, T), *until they leave nothing that is decreed unlawful but that they deem it lawful*, thereby describing their effort to tamper with divine ordinances to suit their own interests. There are many examples of this mentioned in the commentaries, some of which include: [i] The first Muslim ruler who openly drank wine was Mu'āwiyah. [ii] The first Muslim ruler who allowed usury was Mu'āwiyah. [iii] He also permitted marrying two sisters at the same time. [iv] He changed the laws of blood-money (*diyyah*) from what was instituted by the Prophet (ṣ). [v] He changed the sequence of the Eid prayer, putting the sermon first (N). These are just some of the examples pertaining to the corruption of the Umayyad king, Mu'āwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān. There are plenty of other instances from the history of Banū Umayyah that are shocking, and highlight just how depraved they were. Hishām ibn 'Abd al-Malik had appointed the agnostic Khālīd ibn 'Abdillāh al-Qasrī as his governor over Kūfah. Since his mother was a Christian, Khālīd built a church for her in front of the masjid, and whenever the *adhān* was recited, they would simultaneously ring the church bells. Khālīd held Hishām in higher esteem than the Noble Prophet and would say, "I swear that if the caliph commanded it, I would destroy the Ka'bah and tear it down, brick by brick. Then I would send all the bricks to him in Syria."

The infamous governor al-Ḥajjāj was once informed that people were visiting the grave of the Messenger of Allāh, so he commented, “Woe be to them! They are only visiting sticks and decayed bones. Why do they not circumambulate the palace of the caliph ‘Abd al-Malik instead? Do they not know that a person’s caliph is better than his Prophet?” And the Umayyad al-Walid ibn Yazīd used to pray facing other than the *qiblah*, quoting [the verse]: *whichever way you turn, there is the face of Allāh* (Q2:115) (T). Of course, the greatest of all oppressions committed by this dynasty was during the rule of Yazīd ibn Mu‘āwiyah where, within a span of three years, the grandson of the Messenger of Allāh (ṣ) was killed, the City of the Prophet was plundered, and the Ka‘bah was burnt. Indeed, the list of their evil deeds are too long to mention here, and it would not be an exaggeration to say that entire tomes could easily be written just about their improprieties and misdeeds.

Another quality of these despots was that they would leave *no pact but that they broke it*. This means it was not only the laws of religion that they belittled, they also broke the social rules that were established by convention. The word ‘*ḥallūhu*’ means to undo or unbind something, and here it refers to their nonadherence to agreements and pacts, thinking that they were above the law (M). They did this with respect to both the promises they made to people, and the covenant of the Almighty in the form of religious laws and injunctions. Examples of the latter have been given above, and one of the earliest examples of the former was when Mu‘āwiyah broke his pact with Imām al-Ḥasan (‘a) (MB). Imām ‘Alī subsequently warns that their oppression will affect all the people, since it will spread *until there remains no brick house or woollen tent but that their oppression will enter it and their evil policies will leave its dwellers restless*. By this, he described how widespread and rife their oppression will be. The mention of both brick houses and woollen tents means that it will encompass all areas, urban and rural, and will reach all corners, be they in the city or in far off villages. Thus, not even nomadic tribes or desert dwellers would remain safe from their oppression (N). The phrase ‘*nabā bihi sūru ra’yihim*’ means that their evil behaviour and impious conduct will cause the people to feel aversion and repulsion for them, and they will be restless and uneasy thereby (R). It could also refer to their evil policies and harmful decisions (I). The Imām says that this situation will prevail until two groups rise up crying out (‘*ḥattā yaqūm al-bākiyān yabkiyān*’); one *crying for its religion and the other for this world*. In some manuscripts the word ‘*yabkiyān*’ is absent, and since it only signifies emphasis, there is no change in meaning (T).

Perhaps the former refers to those who cry due to being unable to practice their religion and fulfil the obligations thereof, while the latter refers to those who cry due to losing their wealth and being brought to a wretched state in their worldly life (MB). Alternatively, the first group are those who will cry due to the forceful and unlawful change of religious injunctions by the Umayyads, through their fabrication of ḥadīth for example (S), whereas the second group will cry due to the torment they experience at their hands in this world.

An example of both of these can be adduced from the history of the bloodthirsty governor of the Umayyads, al-Ḥajjāj ibn Yūsuf. It was once reported to al-Ḥajjāj that the tax being collected from the Ahl al-Dhimma had decreased significantly because many of them had become Muslims, so al-Ḥajjāj ordered that the people of Baṣrah should pay the *jizya* tax despite being believers. At this they were rounded up and forcefully taxed, so the people began crying out and weeping at the injustice and unlawful taxation, since that tax did not apply to believers, but only to the Ahl al-Dhimma. The second example is that of those who were killed at the Battle of Maskin (or Dayr al-Jathāliq). It is said that al-Ḥajjāj killed four thousand people there – slaughtering anyone he could find. This caused some of the people to weep (T). The Imām then presents an analogy to describe how the people will react towards the Umayyad rulers, saying that they will act the way a slave does with his master, *when he is present he obeys him but when he is absent he speaks ill of him*. This has been interpreted in various ways. Some say it shows that they will be treated as slaves by the Umayyad rulers. And not the way kind masters treat their slaves; rather, the way cruel overlords treat their bondsmen, fettering them and dragging them against their will. Others read the statement differently to mean that if the people ever seek help from the Umayyad rulers, the help will be accorded to them the way a master begrudgingly helps his slaves, or harshly treats his recalcitrant slaves (I). Yet another interpretation is that the term '*nuṣrah*' here actually means *intiṣār*, i.e. revenge (R). This meaning matches what has been mentioned in sermon no. 92. Nevertheless, the first interpretation is considered most accurate here given the context (N), and due to their helplessness, all the people will be capable of is to speak ill of the rulers behind their backs. This oppression will continue to such an extent that the one among the people *in greatest distress* ('*āḥamukum 'anā'an*') from their evil *will be he who holds the best opinion about Allāh*. Some understand this to refer to the Shī'ah of Āl Muḥammad (T), whereas others simply take it as referring to those who are stronger in their

belief and more pious, for indeed the enmity of evil people with the righteous is greater, and the distress and hardship the latter face at their hands is more severe (MB). Some manuscripts read '*aẓamukum ghanā'an*' (with *ghayn* instead of '*ayn*'), meaning those who are most wealthy and rich, and in this case the meaning would be that during these oppressive times, the richest will be those who hold the best opinion about Allāh (I).

In closing, the Imām advises the people what they should do when they face this calamity, saying that *if Allāh grants you wellbeing, accept it and if you are made to face trials, endure it*. This statement contains within it a hint of compassion for them (N). Some have glossed it as a reference to two different situations they will face – one where there will be relative calm, under a governor who does not mistreat the people, and from whom the people hope for justice and compassion, just as Ibn al-Ash'ath was for the people of Iraq. The other was where they are tormented by a tyrant, like al-Ḥajjāj (T). The Imām tells them that when wellbeing is granted to them, they must welcome it and be grateful to Allāh for it. But when they are faced with hardships at the hands of evil rulers, they should remain patient and bear it, for *verily the outcome will be in favour of the Godwary* (Q11:49), and Allāh will surely reward them for this (MB).



ON ABSTEMIOUSNESS

- 1 We praise Him for what has been and seek His help in our affairs for what is yet to come; we ask Him for wellbeing in our faith just as we ask Him for wellbeing in our physical bodies.
- نَحْمَدُهُ عَلَى مَا كَانَ وَنَسْتَعِينُهُ مِنْ
أَمْرِنَا عَلَى مَا يَكُونُ، وَنَسْأَلُهُ الْمَعَاةَ
فِي الْأَذْيَانِ كَمَا نَسْأَلُهُ الْمَعَاةَ فِي
الْأَبْدَانِ.
- 2 Servants of Allāh, I advise you to repudiate this world which will leave you, even if you dislike its departure, and which will make your bodies old, even if you like to keep them youthful. Verily your example in relation to it is like that of travellers who feel like they have reached the end of their journey as soon as they embark on it and arrived at the landmark they seek as soon as they proceed towards it. How long does he who heads towards his destination hope his journey will take! And how likely is one's remaining [in it] when there is a [fixed] day that he cannot exceed, and a swift pursuer chasing after him in this world until he departs from it!
- عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، أُوصِيكُمْ بِالرَّفْضِ لِهَذِهِ
الدُّنْيَا النَّارَكَةِ لَكُمْ وَإِنْ لَمْ تُحِبُّوا
تَرْكَهَا، وَالْمُبْلِيَةِ لِأَجْسَامِكُمْ وَإِنْ
كُنْتُمْ تُحِبُّونَ تَجْدِيدَهَا، فَإِنَّمَا
مَثَلُكُمْ وَمَثَلُهَا كَسَفَرٍ سَلَكَوا سَبِيلًا
فَكَانَتْهُمْ قَدْ قَطَعُوهُ، وَأَمُّوا عِلْمًا
فَكَانَتْهُمْ قَدْ بَلَغُوهُ، وَكَمْ عَسَى
الْمُجْرِي إِلَى الْغَايَةِ أَنْ يَجْرِيَ إِلَيْهَا
حَتَّى يَبْلُغَهَا! وَمَا عَسَى أَنْ يَكُونَ
بَقَاءُ مَنْ لَهُ يَوْمٌ لَا يَعْدُوهُ، وَطَالِبٌ
حَثِيثٌ فِي الدُّنْيَا يَحْدُوهُ حَتَّى
يُفَارِقَهَا!

CONTEXT

This was part of one of the sermons that the Imām delivered on a Friday, as mentioned by al-Ṣadūq in his *Man Lā Yaḥḍuruḥu al-Faqīh* (T). It was also among the first sermons he gave as caliph (R). In it, he advises the people to be Godway and to reject the enticements of this world and its temptations. He does this by

mentioning its flaws and demerits, and in so doing he encourages the people to be indifferent towards this world, thereby espousing the quality of *al-zuhd* (MB). This oration has been mentioned in a number of sources earlier than al-Raḍī's time. It is also reported by Zayd ibn Wahab, who was one of the companions of Amīr al-Mu'minīn ('a) and had recorded many sermons of the Imām in a book titled *Khuṭab Amīr al-Mu'minīn 'alā al-Manābir fī al-Jum'a wal-A'yād wa Ghayrihā*. This also happens to be the first known book on the subject. Al-Muḥaddith al-Nūrī quotes the sermon from this early source in his *Mustadrak al-Wasā'il*, with slight differences in wording compared to what has been mentioned here by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. As noted above, al-Ṣadūq also recorded this oration in his works, and it is found in both *al-Faḡīh* and *Ma'ānī al-Akḥbār*, with some minor differences in wording. After al-Sharīf al-Raḍī, many others quoted this sermon in their own works as well (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Commencing his oration with praise for Allāh as was his wont, the Imām extols Him for what has past and seeks His aid in what is to come. By the phrase *what has been*, the Imām is referring to past blessings, for it is after one has received blessings that he expresses gratitude for them (M), and one can only praise that which has already taken place and is thus known to him (I). Some opine that it is not only the blessings that he is praising Allāh for, but also the difficult trials and bitter events that have transpired in his life, because the special servants of Allāh consider everything that befalls them to be a mercy from the Almighty and are content and pleased with it all (N). It is reported from the Noble Prophet that whenever something happened which he found pleasing he would say, "Praise be to Allāh for this blessing," and whenever anything he disliked happened, he would say, "Praise be to Allāh in every situation" (T). Similarly, the Imām seeks divine assistance for all matters that are *yet to come*, be they easy or difficult, and in this way he is asking for the ability to remain patient (Z). Seeking assistance for what is to come in the future is apt since one does not know what will befall him, and thus he should ask for Allāh's help to face whatever comes his way (I). The statement *we ask Him for wellbeing in our faith just as we ask Him for wellbeing in our physical bodies* shows that faith is also prone to sickness the way physical bodies are, and its ailments are more severe and harmful. Furthermore, preserving

our faith is more important than preserving our bodies. Hence he began with asking for wellbeing in faith before physical health (S). When we fall sick, it is because something is out of balance in our bodies, or because we have suffered an injury to it. Sickness in faith, on the other hand, is where the heart inclines to divert from the straight path, and the ill effects of this beset the heart itself (MB). Just as physical wellbeing makes life easy for us in this world, wellbeing in faith results in comfort and ease in the Hereafter. Thus we have been taught in one of the supplications to recite, “O Allāh, do not place our calamity in our faith (*Allāhumma lā tajʿal muṣibatānā fi dīninā*),” meaning do not let our calamity be the weakening of our faith (T). Perhaps the subtle point being conveyed here is that if people paid as much attention to their spiritual and religious wellbeing as they did to their physical wellbeing, they would be far better off. Yet how unfortunate it is that a small ailment can make one seek out numerous physicians, yet tens of spiritual ailments do not cause one to seek out even one spiritual doctor! (N).

2 The Imām now turns to his audience and begins to advise them about being abstemious in this world. He says *I advise you to repudiate this world which will leave you, even if you dislike its departure* (the vocative phrase “*ibādallāh*” is not present in some manuscripts). Some commentators have glossed the term ‘*al-raḥḍ*’ as *al-tark*, meaning to abandon (T), while others say it has a more specific connotation than mere abandonment (*akhaṣ min al-tark*) (R). It means to repudiate, reject, and abandon, and the Imām instructs the people to treat the world in this way because it will one day desert them, inevitably. In the same vein, Imām al-Ṣādiq reportedly told the companions, “Flee from this world towards Allāh, and remove your hearts from it, for you do not befit it and it does not befit you, and you will not remain for it nor will it remain for you. It is a deceptive, misleading tempter, enticing whoever falls for its deceptions, enthralling whoever is satisfied by it, and destroying whoever loves it” (MB). If the pronoun ‘*hā*’ in ‘*tarkuhā*’, which refers to the world, is read as an object, then the translation would read *leaving it*, i.e. leaving this world, instead of *its departure*, though this is less likely. In any case the essence of the meaning does not change. Some commentators state that the repudiation meant by the Imām specifically refers to rejection of all that is forbidden (*ḥarām*), or considered a sin, and not what is permitted (*ḥalāl*) (Z). The second quality of this world mentioned by the Imām is that it *will make your bodies old, even if you like to keep them youthful*. The term ‘*al-mublaʿah*’ means old or worn out, and here it connotes the way decrepitude sets

in gradually as one grows old. This includes the wrinkly skin, weakened bones, blurry eyesight, becoming hard of hearing, and general feebleness that people suffer with age (N). The desire to *keep them youthful* ('*tajdīdahā*') or to renew them, reverting to the previous state of vigour and vitality, is universal and all old people wish for it, even though it is not possible to attain. That is because this world acts as a barrier which prevents one from regaining the youthfulness and strength he has lost over time (MB).

Imām 'Alī then gives an analogy to describe their condition, saying that their *example in relation to it is like that of travellers who feel like they have reached the end of their journey as soon as they embark on it and arrived at the landmark they seek as soon as they proceed towards it*. This means that the relation of the people to this world is like that of travellers who reach their destination sooner than anticipated. Everything that is bound to happen in the near or distant future is like that which has already transpired. As we traverse our journey towards death, even though we are still alive and have not reached it, it is as though we have already arrived at the end, because death is certain and inescapable. That is why the Imām compares us to those who have already reached their destination and the end of their journey (Z). Alternatively, the analogy represents the swiftness of travel and depicts how quickly life in this world comes to an end (M). The term '*saḡīr*' is plural of *sāḡīr*, meaning one who goes out on a journey (T). The Imām then poses two rhetorical questions to underscore his message regarding the evanescence of this world. The phrase '*kam 'asā al-mujrī*' has been interpreted differently by commentators. Some take it to refer to the hope and expectation that the traveller has regarding the length of his journey before arriving at his destination (MB), whereas others consider it as a reference to the likelihood of arriving at one's destination quicker by racing one's steed towards it (M). In either case, the distance of the journey is a metaphor for one's lifespan in this world, and his destination is his grave (Z). The fixed and preordained *day that he cannot exceed* is the day of one's death, and the *swift pursuer chasing after him in this world* until his departure from it is none other than death (M). Indeed, the added phrase '*min al-mawt*' is even recorded in some manuscripts (T). The verb '*yaḥdūhu*' literally means to drive forward or spur on, and it perhaps refers to the causes of one's death being driven towards a person with the passage of time (MB). In some manuscripts, an added phrase is found here stating, '*wa muz'ijun fī al-dunyā ḥattā yufāriqahā raghman*' which is translated: *and a vexer in this world until he is forced*

3 So do not compete for the prestige and pride of this world, and neither be enamoured by its beauty and bounty, nor lose patience over its adversity and misery, for indeed its honour and pride will soon cease, its beauty and bounty will soon perish, and its adversity and misery will soon end. Every period in it comes to a close and every living being in it dies. Is there not for you in the vestiges of the ancients, and in your deceased forefathers, a moral and lesson if you apply reason! Don't you see that your predecessors do not return and those who survive them do not remain? Can't you see the people of this world passing their evenings and mornings in different conditions: one is dead and being mourned while another is consoled [for his loss]; one has fallen severely ill while another visits the sick; one is taking his last breath while another is hankering after this world as death pursues him; one is negligent yet he is not neglected; and it is the footsteps of their predecessors that those who remain follow!

4 Take heed! Remember the destroyer of delights, the spoiler of pleasures, and the curtailer of aspirations, while you leap towards evil actions. Seek the assistance of Allāh to duly fulfil His rights as required, and [to thank Him for] His countless blessings and favours.

۳ فَلَا تَتَافَسُوا فِي عِزِّ الدُّنْيَا وَفَخْرِهَا،
وَلَا تَعْجَبُوا بِزِينَتِهَا وَنَعِيمِهَا، وَلَا
تَجْزَعُوا مِنْ ضَرَائِهَا وَبُؤْسِهَا، فَإِنَّ
عِزَّهَا وَفَخْرَهَا إِلَى انْقِطَاعٍ، وَإِنَّ
زِينَتَهَا وَنَعِيمَهَا إِلَى زَوَالٍ، وَضَرَاءَهَا
وَبُؤْسَهَا إِلَى نَفَادٍ، وَكُلُّ مُدَّةٍ فِيهَا
إِلَى انْتِهَاءٍ، وَكُلُّ حَيٍّ فِيهَا إِلَى فَنَاءٍ.
أَوْ لَيْسَ لَكُمْ فِي آثَارِ الْأَوَّلِينَ وَفِي
آبَائِكُمُ الْمَاضِينَ تَبَصُّرَةٌ وَمُعْتَبَرٌ، إِنْ
كُنْتُمْ تَعْقِلُونَ! أَوْ لَمْ تَرَوْا إِلَى
الْمَاضِينَ مِنْكُمْ لَا يَرْجِعُونَ، وَإِلَى
الْخَلْفِ الْبَاقِي لَا يَبْقَوْنَ؟ أَوْ لَسْتُمْ
تَرَوْنَ أَهْلَ الدُّنْيَا يُمْسُونَ وَيُصْبِحُونَ
عَلَى أَحْوَالٍ شَتَّى: فَمَيِّتٌ يُبْكِي
وَأَخْرٌ يُعَزِّي، وَصَرِيحٌ مُبْتَلَى وَعَائِدٌ
يُعُودُ، وَآخِرٌ بِنَفْسِهِ يَجُودُ، وَطَالِبٌ
لِلدُّنْيَا وَالْمَوْتُ يَطْلُبُهُ، وَغَافِلٌ وَلَيْسَ
بِمَغْفُولٍ عَنْهُ؛ وَعَلَى أَثَرِ الْمَاضِي مَا
يَمْضِي الْبَاقِي!

۴ أَلَا فَادْكُرُوا هَادِمَ اللَّذَاتِ وَمُنْعَصَ
الشَّهَوَاتِ، وَقَاطِعَ الْأُمْنِيَّاتِ عِنْدَ
الْمَسَاوِرَةِ لِلْأَعْمَالِ الْفَاسِيحَةِ، وَاسْتَعِينُوا
اللَّهَ عَلَى أَدَاءِ وَاجِبِ حَقِّهِ، وَمَا لَا
يُحْصَى مِنْ أَغْدَادِ نِعَمِهِ وَإِحْسَانِهِ.

to depart therefrom and connotes unwillingness to leave this world and being forced to do so before attaining what we desire in it (Z).

3 Having mentioned its qualities, the Imām warns the people not to vie with each other for *the prestige and pride of this world* (*‘izz al-dunyā wa fakhrihā’*), thereby envying each other for its sake and seeking to outdo one another in how much wealth, power, influence, etc. they possess in the world (Z). He further advises them to *neither be enamoured by its beauty and bounty, nor lose patience over its adversity and misery*. In short, he gives the formula of *al-zuhd* to them, namely that they should neither exult or rejoice when they attain anything of this world, nor should they be despondent or disheartened if they lose anything thereof. He then proceeds to give a rational explanation why this attitude should be espoused, saying that *its honour and pride will soon cease, its beauty and bounty will soon perish, and its adversity and misery will soon end*. No wise person would covet that which perishes, or vie for that which goes bad, and only an ignorant person would seek out such things and value them. And since they do not last, any adversity or hardship they bring in their wake should be borne patiently, as it will soon pass (MB). This is then summed up in the statement *every period in it comes to a close and every living being in it dies*. It is interesting that we see those who have preceded us resting in their graves, and we walk past them without thinking of how one day we too will be besides them in the ground and the future generations will walk past us (N). Imām al-Bāqir is reported to have advised Jābir to take this world as a place where one stops briefly before departing therefrom, or as wealth that one sees in his dream only to wake up and find his hands empty. And he told him that to those who possess wisdom, this world is merely like a shade which soon disappears (T). Imām ‘Alī then asks another rhetorical question: *is there not for you in the vestiges of the ancients, and in your deceased forefathers, a moral and lesson if you apply reason!* Some manuscripts have the added word *‘muzdajar’* after the phrase *‘fi āthār al-awwālīn’*, in which case the translation would read *is there not a deterrent [from sin] for you in the vestiges of the ancients...* (T).

The Imām subsequently poses two questions to further press home the point. *Don’t you see that your predecessors do not return and those who survive them do not remain?* The impossibility of returning to this world once one leaves it and the inevitability of departure from this world are both implied here. Indeed, a wise person derives lessons from the state of others, and everything in this world has

within it something to learn from. The erstwhile generations amassed and treasured things which they then left behind, and their successors are following in their tracks. This is something to bear in mind (Z). Then, in the second question, the Imām mentions the different states in which people pass their lives in this world, asking: *can't you see the people of this world passing their evenings and mornings in different conditions...?* Various situations and circumstances are faced by people in this world, and pondering upon them can be quite effective in guiding an individual. In one place, a person has passed away and people are crying over him, while in another a *majlis* is kept for one who has departed this world, and people are offering condolences to his family. In one location there are some who lay ill on their beds, writhing in pain and moaning with discomfort, while friends and family come to visit them. In another part of the world there is one who is on the verge of death, suffering its pangs in his final moments, yet those around him can do nothing to save him. Another witnessed scene is that of individuals working very hard, and expending all their effort in seeking this world, running after it without any care for what is lawful and what is unlawful, only in order to amass more of it. Yet at the same time, death and its causes are following them, in hot pursuit. All of a sudden, they fall, tumbling from their mount, and everything comes to an end. Finally, there is a group comprised of heedless people, busy in their daily lives and worldly enjoyment, negligent but *not neglected*, since death is always after them. Throughout human history, these groups have existed, and it is lesson-giving for those who reflect, for indeed *it is the footsteps of their predecessors that those who remain follow* (N).

4 In the last section of this oration, Imām 'Alī advises the people to remember death and describes it using its disliked attributes and qualities. He uses three phrases to this end, calling death *the destroyer of delights*, *the spoiler of pleasures*, and *the curtailer of aspirations*. It is the destroyer of delights in the sense that it takes away the comfort for which people sometimes work tirelessly their entire lives, only to attain it in their final years when the signs of death become manifest for them, in the form of ailments or decrepitude, thereby preventing them from delighting in that which they acquired. Additionally, it is often seen how those enjoying the comforts of this world are suddenly struck with calamity, and in an instant death takes away all their joy (N). Similarly, death is the spoiler of pleasures since its arrival takes away pleasure, filling him with sorrow (in the case of someone dear passing away), or separating him from what he enjoys (in the case

of his own death). The term '*munaghghis*' means that which embitters, or turns turbid (T). It also connotes interruption or cutting short that which one would love to have more of. Death is likewise the curtailer of aspirations since human hope, desires, and aspirations are never-ending, and sometimes they even increase as one grows older. The only thing that can sever the cord of aspirations is death (N). The phrase *while you leap towards evil actions* is linked to the imperative *remember* ('*udhkurū*'), meaning that before you jump headlong into evil deeds, remember death (I). The term '*al-musāwarah*' means to leap, spring, or hasten towards something. It has been alternatively narrated as '*al-mushāwarah*', in which case the statement would mean that when you resolve to do evil, remember death (R). Finally, the Imām advises his audience to seek help from Allāh for two things: for the ability to fulfil His rights by obeying all His commands, and for the ability to praise and thank Him for *His countless blessings and favours*. In another place, the Imām told the people that every blessing has a right [of gratitude], so whoever fulfils it gets more thereof, and whoever falls short is in danger of losing it and facing chastisement (MB). The message here is that even for the ability to worship and obey Allāh, and to be thankful to Him for his incalculable blessings, one needs help from Allāh (M).



ABOUT THE MESSENGER OF ALLĀH AND HIS HOUSEHOLD

- 1 All praise be to Allāh, who spreads His grace among the creation and extends His generosity to them. We praise Him in all matters and seek His assistance for the observance of His rights. We bear witness that there is no god other than Him and Muḥammad (ṣ) is His servant and messenger. He sent him to manifest His command and articulate His remembrance. So he fulfilled this duty with trustworthiness and passed away upon righteousness, leaving behind among us the banner of truth. Whoever goes ahead of it apostatizes and whoever lags behind it is ruined, but the one who adheres to it attains [felicity]. Its guide is prudent in his speech, deliberate in his stand, and quick when he rises. And when you lower your necks [submissively] before him and point towards him with your fingers, death will come and take him away. Then you will remain after him as long as Allāh wills, until Allāh brings forth for you one who will bring you together and gather your dispersed ranks. So do not place expectations in one who does not come forward, and do not lose hope because of one who turns back, for

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ النَّاشِرِ فِي الْخَلْقِ
فَضْلَهُ، وَالْبَاسِطِ فِيهِمُ بِالْجُودِ
يَدَهُ، نَحْمَدُهُ فِي جَمِيعِ أُمُورِهِ،
وَنَسْتَعِينُهُ عَلَى رِعَايَةِ حُقُوقِهِ،
وَنَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ غَيْرُهُ، وَأَنَّ
مُحَمَّدًا عَبْدُهُ وَرَسُولُهُ، أَرْسَلَهُ
بِأَمْرِهِ صَادِعًا وَبِذِكْرِهِ نَاطِقًا،
فَأَدَّى أَمِينًا وَمَضَى رَشِيدًا،
وَحَلَفَ فِينَا رَايَةَ الْحَقِّ، مَنْ
تَقَدَّمَهَا مَرَقَ، وَمَنْ تَخَلَّفَ عَنْهَا
رَهَقَ، وَمَنْ لَزِمَهَا لِحَقَّ، دَلِيلُهَا
مَكِيثُ الْكَلَامِ، بَطِيءُ الْقِيَامِ،
سَرِيعُ إِذَا قَامَ؛ فَإِذَا أَنْتُمْ أَنْتُمْ لَهُ
رِقَابِكُمْ، وَأَسْرُتُمْ إِلَيْهِ
بِأَصَابِعِكُمْ، جَاءَهُ الْمَوْتُ
فَذَهَبَ بِهِ، فَلَبِثْتُمْ بَعْدَهُ مَا شَاءَ
اللَّهُ حَتَّى يُطْلِعَ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ مَنْ
يَجْمَعُكُمْ وَيَضُمُّ شُرُكَكُمْ، فَلَا
تَطْمَعُوا فِي غَيْرِ مُقْبِلٍ وَلَا
تَيَاسُوا مِنْ مُدْبِرٍ، فَإِنَّ الْمُدْبِرَ
عَسَى أَنْ تَزِلَّ بِهِ إِحْدَى قَائِمَتَيْهِ

indeed it is possible that one of his two feet may slip while the other remains steady, until eventually both return and become steadfast together

وَتَثْبَتِ الْأُخْرَى، فَتَرْجِعَا حَتَّى
تَثْبَتَا جَمِيعًا.

- 2 Look! The example of the progeny of Muḥammad (ṣ) is like that of stars in the sky: when one star sets another one rises. It is as though Allāh's favours upon you have been perfected and He has shown you what you used to hope for.

٢ أَلَا إِنَّ مَثَلَ آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ ﷺ
كَمَثَلِ نُجُومِ السَّمَاءِ: إِذَا حَوَى
نَجْمٌ طَلَعَ نَجْمٌ؛ فَكَأَنَّكُمْ قَدْ
تَكَامَلْتُمْ مِنْ اللَّهِ فِيكُمْ الصَّنَائِعُ،
وَأَرَأَيْتُمْ مَا كُنْتُمْ تَأْمُلُونَ.

CONTEXT

According to some commentators, this is part of a sermon given by the Imām on the third Friday after he became caliph (I). It is one of the orations that contains foretellings about the future, including what would happen after the Imām's death, and gives a general idea of when he would die (MB). He says that it will be at a time when the people will turn towards him in droves, and indeed it is reported that in the final month of his life, large groups of people came to the Imām and he was surrounded by more people than ever before in his life. So much so that he assigned one contingent of ten thousand people to his son al-Ḥasan, and another contingent of ten thousand to Abū Ayyūb al-Anṣārī, and so on, until a hundred thousand troops were ready to march out with him against the rebels and raiders from Syria. It was at that time that Ibn Muljam struck the Imām and he was martyred (N). Everything turned out just as the Imām had predicted in this early sermon. Imām 'Alī also alludes to the Imāms who would come after him, thereby giving the people a sense of hope (M). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this oration as part of a longer sermon called 'al-Ṭālūtiyyah' (no. 20), in which the Imām speaks about the Prophet, the Ahl al-Bayt, and leadership of the Muslim community.

COMMENTARY

1 As always, the Imām begins his sermon by praising Allāh. He also recites the testimony of faith (*al-shahādatayn*). Indeed, according to one well-known tradition, any sermon which does not contain the testimony of faith is like a “leprous hand” (*kal-yad al-jadhmā*) (N). He opens his speech by extolling the Almighty for two specific blessings, namely spreading His grace (*‘faḍlahu’*) among the creation and extending His generosity to them. It is obvious that the phrase *‘al-bāsiṭu fihim bil-jūdi yadahu’* is not meant literally, but rather as a metaphor for His munificence (M). He is praised *in all matters* because everything He does is based on wisdom and what is best for the creation (T), and His assistance is sought *for the observance of His rights*, meaning we seek His help to combat the urges of the base self and the sick heart, which try to hinder us from obeying Allāh and acting upon His commandments (Z). The testimony of faith in the Oneness of Allāh and the prophethood of Muḥammad (ṣ) is then mentioned, since acknowledgement of the fact that all blessings and favours are from Him leads one to the recognition that it is only He who is worthy of worship. And in order to worship Him as He desires, we need to learn His commandments from His chosen Messenger (N). It was the Prophet whom *He sent to manifest His command and articulate His remembrance*. The term *‘ṣādi’an’* means to proclaim openly, as mentioned in the verse: *So proclaim what you have been commanded, and turn away from the polytheists* (Q15:94) (T). Having fulfilled this duty with honour and fidelity, he (ṣ) *passed away upon righteousness* (*‘maḍā rashīdan’*). The latter phrase has also been interpreted as traversing the right course (N), or conveying the guidance from Allāh to the people (T). He left behind *the banner of truth*, meaning the Qur’ān, the *sharī‘ah*, and the Ahl al-Bayt (R), or the Qur’ān and the Sunnah (N), or the Qur’ān and the Ahl al-Bayt (I), or just the Qur’ān (T), and they are referred to as *the banner of truth* because through them the people are guided upon the right path, just as banners guide people in this world (MB).

Whoever goes ahead of it apostatizes like the rebel Khawārij (R), and *whoever lags behind it is ruined*, but *the one who adheres to it attains felicity*. Going ahead of the banner means opposing its instructions, and the verb *‘maraqa’* means exiting from the fold of faith (T). Those who lag behind this guidance are the individuals who do not follow it (MB), or who lack knowledge of its laws (T). In general, these two groups consist of those who transgress the limits by overstepping it (*ifrāt*) or falling short (*tafrīt*). It is only the third group, which adheres to the guidance,

following it and always remaining in its shadow, that joins the righteous and attains felicity (N). Some commentators gloss the verb *'laḥiqa'* as joining the Noble Prophet (ṣ) and being with him in Paradise (Z). The Imām then describes the qualities of *its guide* (*'dalīluhā'*), meaning the guide towards the banner (Z), or the one who carries it (N), or the one who goes ahead leading the people on the path which he knows well (MB), or indeed the banner itself (T). In any case, the Imām is talking about himself, since he was the guide of the people from among the *'itrah* of the Prophet (I). The three qualities are being *prudent in his speech, deliberate in his stand, and quick when he rises*. The phrase *'makīth al-kalām'* does not mean one who speaks less, as some commentators have averred. Rather, it means being deliberate and speaking after reflection and contemplation. Its opposite is *sarī' al-kalām* which refers to one who speaks without thinking, even if he speaks less (T). *'Baṭī' al-qiyām'* literally refers to being slow in standing, and here it connotes prudence and taking measured action, without haste or recklessness. And this is one of the attributes of wise people. Indeed, we find in one report that the Imām is said to have advised his son Muḥammad al-Ḥanafīyyah to consider the consequences of actions before undertaking them, and to ponder and reflect before embarking on anything important, lest he should regret later (MB). The final quality is *'sarī'un idhā qāma'* meaning that once the decision has been made to rise, he does so swiftly, without any delay or hesitation (N).

Imām 'Alī then alludes to his own death, saying that it would be when people finally submit to him, and *point towards him* with their fingers, meaning that he would become popular among the people and they would have respect for him (M), and some say that this attitude had reached its peak in his last days. However, other commentators reject this interpretation noting that in fact, during his final days, many people had rebelled and opposed the Imām, making him feel alone and saddened by their attitude, so the proposed meaning could not possibly hold true. Rather, he was generally referring to how short his caliphate would be (T). The Imām said that once death came and took him away, the people would *remain after him as long as Allāh wills, until Allāh brings forth* for them one who would unite them and gather their dispersed ranks. Regarding the identity of this individual, there are differences of opinion among the commentators. Some opine that it refers to the awaited Mahdī who will rise during End Times, while others say that it refers to the Banū 'Abbās who would come to overthrow the accursed Umayyads. The first interpretation is more likely correct since the positive

description given by the Imām does not befit the ‘Abbāsids, given their own tyranny against the people, and against Shī‘ah of ‘Alī (‘a) in particular. Furthermore, the context pertains to one who is the standard-bearer of truth, and undoubtedly the Banū ‘Abbās were not that – if anything they were the banner-men of falsehood! (N). Other commentators posit that since this unity among the faithful does not necessarily refer to their political or military stance; rather, it could connote their coming together upon the truth and the *wilāyah*, this was something that took place during the time of Imāms Muḥammad al-Bāqir and Ja‘far al-Ṣādiq (‘a) (Z).

The Imām then advises the people not to *place expectations in one who does not come forward* and not to *lose hope because of one who turns back*. By this he means that people should not be overly optimistic that something which is not yet destined, and the preparations for which have not yet been completed, will come to pass before its prerequisites are in place. Likewise, not seeing the rise of the awaited saviour should not lead to despondency and loss of hope among them when they are faced with tribulations and hardships (N). The first statement has also been interpreted to mean, ‘do not expect to have after me one who will rule over you the way I did, for that is highly unlikely’, and the second statement means, ‘do not lose hope in our guidance – the Ahl al-Bayt – for if you do not find any from the Prophet’s progeny gaining political authority, they are still there to guide you to the truth, so follow them and obey them’ (Z). Some commentators opine that these statements refer to those who have the required qualities to undertake the responsibility of the caliphate but are prevented from doing so (M), namely the other Imāms from the Ahl al-Bayt (T). The Imām then explains that *indeed it is possible that one of his two feet may slip while the other remains steady, until eventually both return and become steadfast together*, and this is why he is not rising at the moment people expect. The statement is read by some as a metaphor for some deficiency in the conditions required for his arrival, which is represented by one of his feet slipping, whereas the presence of other prerequisites for his coming is represented by the other foot which remains steady (MB). As such, both feet returning to their steadfast state connotes the attainment of all the required preconditions for his rising. Alternatively, the two feet may represent the religious and time-based political authority, so if one is lost by the passing away of the Imām, the other remains through his progeny, and eventually a time will come when even political authority will belong to one of their number (Z).

2 The Imām then tells the people that *the example of the progeny of Muḥammad (ṣ) is like that of stars in the sky: when one star sets another one rises*. By this, he was referring to the twelve infallible Imāms from the progeny of the Noble Messenger. He likened them to stars either because through them people are guided to the right way, or because whenever one Imām passes away, another takes his place just the way a rising star takes the place of one that has set (MB). Indeed, the Qurʾān clearly describes the guiding quality of stars, when it says: *...and by the stars they are guided [on their way]* (Q16:16). Of course, stars themselves do not rise and set – it is the rotation of the earth that makes it seem that way. Hence, the Imām employs these terms only in order to make people understand his point, and it is not meant literally (S). Finally, in the last line of the oration, Imām ‘Alī says *it is as though Allāh’s favours upon you have been perfected and He has shown you what you used to hope for*. This is referring to the special blessing of Allāh upon the people that will come about upon the rise of the Qā’im and the coming of the awaited Imām from the progeny of the Noble Prophet (ṣ). That will be a time when the state of affairs will be put in order, and the world will be filled with justice and equity (M). The narrations mention a number of other special blessings that believers will get when the Mahdī comes. For instance, we are told that one man will gain the strength of forty men, and that by the Imām placing his blessed hand on their heads, the people will have their intellects perfected, and that nothing of the wealth of this world will be out of reach for them, and so on (T). Alternatively, this statement means that by following the guidance of the infallible Imāms, one would attain whatever he aspires to and hopes for, and the blessings of Allāh are thus perfected for him. This is because of the role of these divine guides in helping one attain perfection in his religion, as well as his worldly life (N). It could also simply mean that Allāh has completed His blessings on the *ummah* by perfecting their religion for them and appointing for them divine guides, namely the Messenger of Allāh and the infallible Imāms from his Ahl al-Bayt (N).



ON FUTURE CALAMITIES

1 [Praise be to He who is] the First before every first and the Last after every last. His *firstness* necessitates that he has no beginning and His *lastness* necessitates that He has no end. I bear witness that there is no god but Allāh, a testimony affirmed both inwardly and outwardly, with the heart as well as the tongue.

2 O people, do not fall into sin by defying me, do not be lured [towards iniquity] by disobeying me, and do not wink at each other when you hear something from me. By He who split the seed and created man, whatever I convey to you is from the unlettered Prophet (s). Neither did the conveyor [of the message] lie nor was the listener ignorant. Verily, it is as though I see an extremely misguided person calling out in Shām and erecting his banners on the outskirts of Kūfah. When his mouth opens wide and his obduracy intensifies, and his footsteps become heavy in the land, then discord will bite its inhabitants with its fangs and war will rage with its [surging] waves, bringing about the gloomiest of days and the most traumatic of nights.

١ الْأَوَّلِ قَبْلَ كُلِّ أَوَّلٍ وَالْآخِرِ
بَعْدَ كُلِّ آخِرٍ، وَبِأَوَّلِيَّتِهِ وَجَبَ
أَنْ لَا أَوَّلَ لَهُ وَبِآخِرِيَّتِهِ وَجَبَ
أَنْ لَا آخِرَ لَهُ؛ وَأَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ
إِلَّا اللَّهُ شَهَادَةً يُوَافِقُ فِيهَا السِّرُّ
الْإِعْلَانُ وَالْقَلْبُ اللِّسَانُ.

٢ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، لَا يَجْرِمَنَّكُمْ شِقَاقِي،
وَلَا يَشْتَهْوِيَنَّكُمْ عِصْيَانِي، وَلَا
تَتَرَامَوْا بِالْأَبْصَارِ عِنْدَ مَا تَسْمَعُونَهُ
مِنِّْي. فَوَالَّذِي فَلَقَ الْحَبَّةَ وَبَرَأَ
النَّسَمَةَ، إِنَّ الَّذِي أُنَبِّئُكُمْ بِهِ عَنِ
النَّبِيِّ الْأُمِّيِّ ﷺ، مَا كَذَبَ
الْمُبَلِّغُ وَلَا جَهْلُ السَّامِعِ، لَكَأَنِّي
أَنْظُرُ إِلَى ضَلِيلٍ قَدْ نَعَقَ بِالشَّامِ،
وَفَحَصَ بِرَايَاتِهِ فِي ضَوَاحِي
كُوفَانَ؛ فَإِذَا فَعَرَّتْ فَاعَرَّتُهُ،
وَأَشْتَدَّتْ شَكِيمَتُهُ، وَثَقُلَتْ فِي
الْأَرْضِ وَطَأَتُهُ، غَضَّتِ الْفِتْنَةُ أَبْنَاءَهَا
بِأَنْيَابِهَا، وَمَاجَتِ الْحَرْبُ بِأَمْوَاجِهَا،
وَبَدَأَ مِنَ الْأَيَّامِ كُلُّوْحُهَا، وَمِنْ
اللَّيَالِي كُدُوحُهَا.

- 3 So when his crops mature and are ripe for harvest, and when his excitement heightens and his swords shimmer, the banners of pernicious rebellion shall be raised and will advance like the dark night and the surging sea. This, and how many thunderous storms will rip through Kūfah and tempestuous gales will pass through it. Soon they will lock horns [in battle] and the standing will be mowed [down] while the fallen will be [trampled upon and] crushed.
- ٣ فَإِذَا أُيْنِعَ زَرْعُهُ وَقَامَ عَلَى يَنْعِهِ،
وَهَدَرَتْ سَفَاشِقُهُ وَبَرَقَتْ بَوَارِقُهُ،
عُقِدَتْ رَايَاتُ الْفِتَنِ الْمُغْضَلَةِ،
وَأَقْبَلْنَ كَاللَّيْلِ الْمُظْلِمِ وَالْبَحْرِ
الْمُتَطِيمِ. هَذَا وَكَمْ يَحْرِقُ الْكُوفَةَ
مِنْ قَاصِفٍ، وَيَمُرُّ عَلَيْهَا مِنْ
عَاصِفٍ، وَعَنْ قَلِيلٍ تَلْتَفُّ الْقُرُونُ
بِالْقُرُونِ، وَيُحْصَدُ الْقَائِمُ وَيُحْطَمُ
الْمَحْضُودُ.

CONTEXT

As mentioned in its title, this oration generally addresses some future events and warns the Muslims, particularly the people of Iraq, of the dangers they will face. This is preceded by praise of Allāh and the expression of concern regarding the reaction of some people to his speech. It seems that there is no other source for this sermon besides the one used by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī (N). Furthermore, it is not known exactly when and where the Imām spoke these words. However, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places part of the oration within a longer sermon that was delivered by the Imām a few days before his martyrdom (4:630). It is quite possible that it is actually made up of excerpts of different sermons, and some commentators have offered their explanations of the different sections in separate volumes of their commentaries (T). This is especially the case with the first section, which does not seem to have a direct connection to the following two sections of the sermon.

COMMENTARY

1 From what we find in the commentaries, it can be assumed that some manuscripts start with the phrase ‘*al-ḥamdu lillāh*’ whereas this is missing (or

elided) in others. In any case, the Imām mentions the two attributes of Allāh as the First, and the Last. Details of this have already been discussed in the commentary of sermon no.s 64, 84, and 90. By saying that He is *the First before every first* he means that the Almighty is pre-eternal, and *the Last after every last* refers to the impossibility of His non-existence (MB). His *firstness* does not refer to precedence in time; rather it refers to an essential *firstness* which connotes pre-eternity (*azaliyyah*), and has no beginning in time. Likewise His *lastness* is essential, not subsequence in time, and connotes eternity and endlessness (N). Imām ‘Alī then testifies that *there is no god but Allāh* and describes it as *a testimony affirmed both inwardly and outwardly, with the heart as well as the tongue*. This speaks to the sincerity and deep-rooted belief and conviction he had, unlike the testimony of the hypocrites, about whom the Qur’ān says: *When the hypocrites come to you, they say, “We bear witness that you are indeed the Messenger of Allāh,” and Allāh knows that you are indeed His Messenger, and Allāh bears witness that the hypocrites are certainly liars* (Q63:1) (T). This shows that what is required of believers is not merely uttering the testimony of faith, but making it the cornerstone of their lives. Some commentators suggest that by saying this, the Imām was indirectly hinting at the insincerity and lack of conviction that plagued their hearts (MB). Perhaps the fact that he mentioned the attributes of Allāh before his *shahādah* can be read as an implicit message that for one to truly bear witness to Allāh’s Oneness, he needs to gain cognizance (*ma’rifah*) of Allāh and know Him.

2 The Imām then addresses the people directly and tells them not to *fall into sin by defying* him. He uses the phrase ‘*lā yaḥrimannakum shiqāqī*’ which is also mentioned in the Qur’ān when it quotes Prophet Shu‘ayb telling his people: *O my people! Let not your dissension with me lead you to suffer the same fate as what befell the people of Nūḥ...* (Q11:89) (T). Another way of reading this phrase would thus be ‘*do not let your dissension with me [and enmity for me] lead you to fall into sin*’. The sin being referred to here is calling him a liar and accusing him of dishonesty (I). The phrase ‘*lā yastahwiyanakum ‘iṣyānī*’ can also be translated as ‘*do not let your disobedience to me lure you [towards iniquity]*’, and is a warning to them not to allow their defiance and disobedience overcome their reason, thereby giving in to their whims and caprice (MB). He further tells them not to *wink at each other* when they hear anything from him. ‘*Lā tatarāmaw bil-abṣār*’ literally means do not cast glances at each other, and connotes a sign made with the eyes to convey a message

to another. In this case they were expressing their disbelief and disapproval of what the Imām was saying (I), thereby belying him and the warnings he gave about the future (MB). From these statements we deduce that the Imām had spoken to the people about future events before this, and he had noted their disbelief and rejection of his words (N). Whenever the Imām informed the people of anything from the unseen, the hypocrites would make signs to each other, winking or using facial expressions and the like, to express their disbelief (Z).

The Imām then swears by the Almighty *who split the seed*, causing it to break apart during germination, giving rise to a green plant which later bears fruit itself, *and created man* – and this oath was unique to Imām ‘Alī (R), or was first formulated by him (N). He swears that whatever he is telling the people is the truth, as taught to him by *the unlettered Prophet* (*‘al-nabī al-ummī*). Some manuscripts do not contain the adjective *‘al-ummī*, regarding which there are the same differing interpretations as those offered by exegetes of the Qur’ān. As such, some commentators opine that it means one who is from Umm al-Qurā, which is the city of Makkah (R). By saying *neither did the conveyor lie nor was the listener ignorant*, the Imām is referring to the Messenger of Allāh and himself as the conveyor and listener respectively. Indeed, there are several reports of the Prophet praying to Allāh to grant ‘Alī (‘a) an attentive mind, after which it is said that he never forgot anything (T). Having sworn that he was telling them nothing but the truth, the Imām speaks to them about what would befall them in the future. He says that it is as though he can see *an extremely misguided person calling out in Shām*. The term *‘ḍillīl* is the hyperbole of *ḍāll*, meaning misguided, lost, or astray, and some say it also includes the meaning of going to the extremes in misguiding others (*iḍlāl*) (R). The verb *‘na’aqa* literally means to make a sound like the bleating of sheep, and later it came to signify the call made to move sheep towards or away from something. By using this verb, the Imām is hinting at the ignorant nature of the people who followed the Banī Umayyah (N). Regarding the identity of the individual being described in these statements, there are varying opinions among commentators. Some say it refers to Mu’āwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān, others opine that it is ‘Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān, and yet others suggest that it could be the Sufyānī who will come in the final days. Those who say it was someone other than Mu’āwiyah argue that the Imām was apparently speaking about someone who would rise in the future, while Mu’āwiyah was present during the time of Amīr al-Mu’minīn (‘a) (MB). Furthermore, they claim that the qualities mentioned fit

the personality and actions of ‘Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān to a tee (I). They mention some of his statements and actions to demonstrate this. For example, it is reported that when he entered the city of Madīnah in the year 75 AH, he said to the people, “Indeed, I will remedy the ills of this nation with nothing but the sword...” and he forbade anyone from reminding him to be Godwary, on pain of death (T). The Imām says that this individual would erect his banners (*‘faḥaṣa bi rāyātihi’*) on the outskirts of Kūfah. The verb *‘faḥaṣa’* refers to searching for even ground, and it also means to furrow or dig the earth. Here, it means to install or erect banners (Z), likely signifying conquest or subjugation.

Continuing his description of this baneful individual, the Imām says *when his mouth opens wide and his obduracy intensifies*, meaning when he speaks, or yells, he utters that which causes harm and destruction (Z). Alternatively, he opens his maw to eat and consume everything he gets his hands on, which is a metaphor for greed and spreading corruption (R). It can be compared to when a wild beast opens its mouth to devour its prey (MB). The term *‘shakīmah’* originally referred to the transverse piece of iron placed in the mouth of a horse to control it, then it came to connote any kind of pressure and resistance. In the statement above, it signifies vehement defiance (N). *His footsteps become heavy in the land* means that he becomes more tyrannical and oppressive against the people (MB), stamping his feet with violence and bearing down thereby on the necks of his subjects. Some commentators say that this represents the time when ‘Abd al-Malik appointed the bloodthirsty despot al-Ḥajjāj as his governor in Iraq (I). This, then, would be the period when *discord will bite its inhabitants with its fangs and war will rage with its surging waves, bringing about the gloomiest of days and the most traumatic of nights*. The Imām likens this era to a dangerous animal that has large fangs by which it bites the people of the city, and figuratively depicts the pervasiveness of tyranny and corruption, as well as the tribulation that the people will have to endure in this period (MB). The Imām says warfare will be widespread at this time, raging like surging billows and drowning thereby all the lands in blood, sparing neither the aged nor the young (Z). The rhyming terms *‘kulūḥ’* and *‘kudūḥ’* mean scowling and injured respectively, and here they portray the extent of the gloom and distress during the days and the nights of this era (M). By mentioning both the nights and the days, the Imām means that this discord will continue throughout this age (I). Historical accounts of the tyranny of this period abound, and some commentators quote many such reports, spanning several pages (T).

3 The Imām then continues mentioning what will befall the Kūfans when this tyrannous and cruel individual is established in authority. He says that *when his crops mature and are ripe for harvest, and when his excitement heightens and his swords shimmer*, meaning once he gets settled in power, and his rule is entrenched firmly, he will give free rein to his caprice, and put all his effort into conquering what he desires and forcing others to submit to his will (Z). The meaning of the word ‘*shaqā’iqu*’, translated as *excitement*, has been discussed at length in the commentary of the Sermon of Shiqshiqiyah (I), and here it connotes the oppression and brutality of the tyrant (MB). The phrase ‘*baraqat bawāriquhu*’ literally means that its shiny things shimmer, and this refers to the swords and spearheads that shine as they are used in battle (I). The statement *the banners of pernicious rebellion shall be raised and will advance like the dark night and the surging sea* means that when this *fitnah* comes, it will bring in its wake numerous other *fitan*, in the form of rebellion, anarchy, and disorder, which the Imām likens to a dark night or a surging sea. The comparison to a dark night is due to how difficult it will be to attain guidance during this period, just as it is hard to find the way in utter darkness, and its similarity to a surging sea is in how encompassing it will be (M). It is suggested that these rebellions refer to the battles that were fought after the death of ‘Abd al-Malik by his sons and heirs, with the likes of Zayd ibn ‘Alī, as well as the rebellions in Kūfah during the days of Yūsuf ibn ‘Umar, Khālid al-Qasrī, ‘Umar ibn Hubayrah and others, all of which saw the perpetration of grave injustices including the looting of wealth and killing of innocents. (MB). Some say that these statements allude to the fact that the rule of this individual will be short lived, and he will not remain in power for long since the banners of rebellion will soon rise against him and his followers, and they will be attacked from all sides (N). It is also possible that this was a reference to how, once their time came, the Banū Umayyah would fall at the hands of the Banū ‘Abbās (T). The Imām thus tells the people that *many thunderous storms will rip through Kūfah and tempestuous gales will pass through it*. Indeed, not long after the Imām left this world, Iraq was engulfed by tribulations, and especially the city of Kūfah itself – which was always in the eye of the storm (N). This was exactly what the Imām foretold when he said that *soon they will lock horns and the standing will be mowed down while the fallen will be trampled upon and crushed*. The locking of horns (‘*taltaff al-qurūnu bil-qurūn*’) has been interpreted differently with some saying it means that diverse nations will mingle with one another (MB), while others understand it as the dying

of later generations the way those who preceded them died (R). Perhaps this difference is because the term ‘*qurūn*’ (sing. *qarn*) can mean horns or generations. Those who have taken the first meaning understand the locking of horns as a metaphor for battle and violent confrontation with weapons (Z), whereas those who take the term to mean generations of people interpret the phrase to mean mingling and mixing (N). In any case, the last phrases clarify that there will indeed be violence, where *the standing will be mowed down*, signifying that the leaders of Banī Umayyah will be killed, and *the fallen will be crushed*, which likely refers to their captives, who will be killed slowly by torture (I). Alternatively, the latter phrase could mean that their buried corpses would decay and turn to dust in the earth (S). It could also generally mean that the rebellion will raze down their edifice, leaving no trace thereof (Z). And indeed, history proved true what the Imām had foretold.



ON THE SAME THEME AND THE DAY OF JUDGMENT

THE DAY OF JUDGMENT

- 1 That is the day in which Allāh will gather the former and latter generations to examine the accounts and recompense the deeds. They [shall] stand submissively, with sweat trickling down to their mouths and the earth trembling beneath their feet. The one whose condition is best among them will be he who finds a place for his feet and a space for himself.

ALSO: ON THE CIRCUMSTANCES TO
COME OVER THE PEOPLE

- 2 Turmoil like the darkness of night, that none can withstand and whose banner can never be routed, will come to you fully bridled and saddled, urged on by its driver and strained by its rider. Its folk are a people whose savagery is severe yet their plunder is paltry. They will be fought for the sake of Allāh by a group deemed lowly in the eyes of the arrogant ones, and unknown on the earth but well known in the heavens. Woe be to you, O Baṣrah, when that happens, from the army that is a chastisement from Allāh and neither raises dust nor causes commotion. Thus will your inhabitants be afflicted with red death and dire starvation.

يوم القيامة

وَذَلِكَ يَوْمٌ يَجْمَعُ اللَّهُ فِيهِ
الْأَوَّلِينَ وَالْآخِرِينَ لِنَقَاشِ
الْحِسَابِ وَجَزَاءِ الْأَعْمَالِ،
خُضُّوعاً قِيَاماً، قَدْ أَلْجَمَهُمْ
الْعَرَقُ، وَرَجَفَتْ بِهِمُ الْأَرْضُ،
فَأَحْسَنُهُمْ حَالاً مَنْ وَجَدَ لِقَدَمَيْهِ
مَوْضِعاً وَلِنَفْسِهِ مَتْسَعاً.

ومنها: حال مقبلة على الناس

فَتَنٌ كَقَطْعِ اللَّيْلِ الْمُظْلِمِ، لَا تَقُومُ
لَهَا فَايِمَةٌ وَلَا تُرَدُّ لَهَا رَايَةٌ، تَأْتِيكُمْ
مَرْمُومَةً مَرْحُولَةً، يَخْفِزُهَا قَائِدُهَا
وَيَجْهَدُهَا رَاكِبُهَا؛ أَهْلُهَا قَوْمٌ شَدِيدٌ
كَلْبُهُمْ، قَلِيلٌ سَلْبُهُمْ، يُجَاهِدُهُمْ فِي
سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ قَوْمٌ أَذِلَّةٌ عِنْدَ الْمُتَكَبِّرِينَ،
فِي الْأَرْضِ مَجْهُوْلُونَ وَفِي السَّمَاءِ
مَعْرُوفُونَ. فَوَيْلٌ لَكَ يَا بَصْرَةَ عِنْدَ
ذَلِكَ مِنْ جَيْشٍ مِنْ نَقَمِ اللَّهِ، لَا
رَهْجَ لَهُ وَلَا حَسَّ، وَسَيَبْتَلِي أَهْلَكَ
بِالْمَوْتِ الْأَحْمَرِ وَالْجُوعِ الْأَغْبَرِ.

CONTEXT

This oration follows the same theme as the previous one, since it also contains information about calamities that would transpire in the future. It consists of two sections, and the second section is where this matter is particularly addressed. In the first section, the Imām talks about the horrors and difficulties of the Day of Judgment (MB). There is no available record of this sermon in sources prior to the time of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, however later sources have mentioned it (N). We do not know the context in which this sermon was given, but the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places the second section within a longer sermon that the Imām gave addressing the people of Baṣrah after the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH), and this seems to be quite likely, since the Imām mentions the city by name.

COMMENTARY

1 The day being referred to by the Imām is clearly the Day of Judgment, when *Allāh will gather the former and latter generations to examine the accounts and recompense them for the deeds they performed in the world*. This echoes the verses that state: *Say, "Verily the earlier and later generations will be gathered for the tryst of a known day."* (Q56:49-50) (T). The mention of both the earlier and later generations underscores the fact that all human beings will have their accounting done on the same day, individually, as stated in (Q19:95). The term '*niqāsh*' means careful scrutiny in accounting, and implies that every action, big and small, will be counted and recompensed (N). This is also clearly mentioned in the Glorious Qurān, when it states: *On that Day, humankind will proceed in separate groups to be shown their deeds. So whoever does an atom's weight of good will see it, and whoever does an atom's weight of evil will see it* (Q99:6-8). Likewise, the way in which they will stand submissively ('*khudū'an qiyāman*') has been alluded to in a number of verses, such as Q54:7, and it refers to how the people will be completely humbled, incapable of any kind of action that could save them from their state – that is when they will be certain that there is no might or power save with Allāh (M). The phrase '*aljamahum al-araq*' has been mentioned earlier (without a pronoun) in sermon no. 82, and it has been explained in detail there. A tradition from the Noble Prophet states that on the Day of Judgment, the sun will be brought closer, and the people will sweat profusely – according to their deeds – with some

having it reach their mouths (T). Yet it is not known whether the perspiration will only be a result of the heat, or also because of the intense shame and fear they feel, or perhaps both (N). As for the ground *trembling beneath their feet*, it has been suggested this could be a reference to the quaking that will take place after the second blowing of the Horn, as mentioned in some verses of the Qur'ān (MB). Some commentators have also offered a metaphoric reading of this statement, saying that it might refer to the trembling of hearts out of fear and awe of Allāh, or the horrors that are witnessed on that Day (M). However, others have rejected such a reading saying that when the apparent meaning is clear, there is no reason to assume a hidden or metaphoric meaning (N). The Imām then states that *the one whose condition is best among them will be he who finds a place for his feet and a space for himself*. This is understood as an allusion to the extremely large number of people who will be present there, and their seemingly endless multitude (Z). For this reason, there will be very little room and from the narrations we learn that one of the tribulations of that Day will be the narrowness and constriction felt by people due to lack of space (N). If the term '*naḥsihi*' is read as '*naḥasihi*', the translation would be *and room to breathe*. While this conveys the same overall meaning of lack of space, none of the commentators referred to have read the term in this way. The pious believers will have much more space than unbelievers, and they will possess light as others languish in darkness (S).

2 In this section the Imām speaks about future calamities that would befall the people, and according to some commentators, it is in reference specifically to what would happen in Baṣrah at the hands of the Zanj (M). Others posit that there has been some mix-up by the copyists or narrators, and the details mentioned here do not match what transpired with the Zanj. They suggest that these were actually two separate narrations that somehow got merged into one, as evinced from other early sources. Hence, the first part of this section (until the phrase *their plunder is paltry*) likely refers to the Tartars, not the Zanj. That is because the qualities mentioned match the Turks, for which they were well-known (T). The phrase '*qīṭa' al-layl*' refers to the darkest part of the night, as noted from the verse Q15:65 (I), and here it signifies the difficulty that will be faced during this turmoil, and how nobody will be able to find a means by which he could avoid or escape it (T). '*Lā taqūmu lahā qā'imah*' has been rendered *that none can withstand* and connotes the people's inability to counter the turmoil and those causing it (R). It may also mean that no edifice will be left standing by it, and all the buildings and fortresses will

be laid to waste and ruined by the turmoil (MB). Alternatively, it could mean that no horse will be able to remain standing still, since there will be constant galloping in their raids and assaults (M). And the same meaning is understood when it is said that their *banner can never be routed*, since nobody will be able to face them and defeat them (R). The fact that this *fitnah* will come *fully bridled and saddled, urged on by its driver and strained by its rider* means that the sowers of discord and causes of turmoil will be well prepared, just like a mount that is bridled, saddled, and ready for its rider or driver. In other words, everything will be ready for the advancement of their mission (N). It will be *strained by its rider* or pushed hard by him (*'yajhādūhā'*), meaning that the agents of *fitnah* will spare no effort in pursuing their goal (MB). These are people *whose savagery is severe yet their plunder is paltry*, meaning that their goal is to annihilate, not to loot (I). Some commentators have interpreted the phrase '*qalīlun salbuhum*' to mean that their losses or casualties are very few (N), but this meaning does not match the context or the apparent meaning. As noted above, this type of savagery was exhibited by the Tartars, so it is likely that they were the people being described here (T).

The Imām then speaks of those who will rise up to fight the corrupt evildoers for the sake of Allāh. He says that they will be *a group deemed lowly in the eyes of the arrogant ones, and unknown on the earth but well known in the heavens*. They are unknown in this world, and considered insignificant by the arrogant ones due to the fact that they are not worldly in their outlook, and never strive to amass wealth or acquire power in it. Yet they are recognized in the heavens because of their knowledge and cognizance, and their devout obedience to Allāh is seen by the angels (MB). Some commentators interpret their lack of renown to mean that they were obscure and unheard of before rising up to fight this enemy (I). Aside from the view that the enemy here refers to the Zanj or the Tartars, some suggest that it is referring to something which will transpire during End Times (N). The Imām then addresses the city of Baṣrah as a way of warning its inhabitants, saying *woe be to you, O Baṣrah, when that happens, from the army that is a chastisement from Allāh and neither raises dust nor causes commotion*. The terms '*raḥaḡ*' and '*ḥass*' mean rising dust and clamour respectively. This could mean that they would not come galloping on horses and causing commotion (M), or more generally that they would attack stealthily, taking the inhabitants of the city by surprise (N). According to one commentator, the *army* (*'jaysh*') mentioned here is actually a metaphor for drought and pestilence that would beset the people of Baṣrah, until

they perish thereby (I). However, since Amīr al-Mu'minīn follows this up by warning that the city's inhabitants will be *afflicted with red death and dire starvation*, and the first of these apparently refers to slaying and slaughter, the suggested meaning is less likely. Indeed, those who opine that the enemy they were being warned about were the Zanj say that historical records report how the Zanj killed thirty thousand (or according to another account, twenty four thousand) Baṣrans in a single assault (T). Nevertheless, some insist that *red death* may still mean pestilence, and the colour red would then be used only to imply severe hardship (MB). The phrase '*al-jū' al-aghbar*' literally means dust-coloured hunger, and the starvation they would face has been described thus because one who is starving lacks the strength to rise up, so he falls on the dusty ground and thus becomes dust-coloured (T).



ON ABSTEMIOUSNESS, THE SCHOLAR, AND END TIMES

BEING ABSTEMIOUS IN THIS WORLD

- 1 O people, look at the world as those who abstain from it and keep away from it, for by Allāh, it will shortly get rid of its residing inhabitants and afflict the opulent who feel safe. That which turns away and leaves it never returns and what is to come from it is not known so as to be anticipated. Its joy is mingled with grief and in it the strength of men is soon followed by weakness and frailty. So do not be deceived by the abundance of what impresses you in it due to the little that will accompany you from it. May Allāh have mercy on the individual who ponders and pays heed, takes lesson and gains insight. Soon, whatever is there in this world will be as though it never existed, while that which is in the Hereafter will be as though it has always existed. Every countable thing inevitably ends, every inevitable thing comes to pass, and all that will come to pass is near and approaching.

في التزهيد في الدنيا

أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، انْظُرُوا إِلَى الدُّنْيَا نَظَرَ
الرَّاهِدِينَ فِيهَا الصَّادِقِينَ عَنْهَا؛
فَإِنَّهَا وَاللَّهِ عَمَّا قَلِيلٍ تُزِيلُ
الْثَّائِي السَّاكِنَ، وَتَفْجَعُ الْمُشْرِفَ
الْآمِنَ، لَا يَزِجُ مَا تَوَلَّى مِنْهَا فَأَذْبَرُ،
وَلَا يُدْرِي مَا هُوَ آتٍ مِنْهَا فَيُنْتَظَرُ.
سُرُورُهَا مَشُوبٌ بِالْحُزْنِ، وَجَلْدُ
الرِّجَالِ فِيهَا إِلَى الضَّعْفِ وَالْوَهْنِ؛
فَلَا يُعْرَنُكُمْ كَثْرَةُ مَا يُعْجِبُكُمْ فِيهَا
لِقَلَّةِ مَا يَصْحَبُكُمْ مِنْهَا. رَحِمَ اللَّهُ
امْرَأً تَفَكَّرَ فَأَعْتَبَرَ، وَاعْتَبَرَ فَأَنْبَصَرَ،
فَكَانَ مَا هُوَ كَائِنٌ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا عَنْ
قَلِيلٍ لَمْ يَكُنْ، وَكَانَ مَا هُوَ كَائِنٌ
مِنَ الْآخِرَةِ عَمَّا قَلِيلٍ لَمْ يَزَلْ، وَكُلُّ
مَعْدُودٍ مُنْقَضٍ، وَكُلُّ مُتَوَقَّعٍ آتٍ،
وَكُلُّ آتٍ قَرِيبٌ دَانٍ.

CONTEXT

This oration consists of excerpts from a longer sermon, or from various sermons, and it is evident that al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has not mentioned the whole

sermon here. There are three general messages contained within this oration, the first of which is encouraging abstemiousness in this world, followed by the importance of reflection and taking lessons from what happens around a person. Secondly, the description of a true scholar is given, and finally, in the last section of the sermon, the tribulations that believers will face during the End Times has been mentioned. All in all, this speech contains important information that would help an individual both in his worldly, material life, as well as in his spiritual life (N). Though the context of this sermon is not recorded, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* says that it was spoken by the Imām in response to a man who was blaming the world (5:142). Parts of the oration have also been mentioned in sources earlier than the time of al-Raḍī, such as al-Kulaynī's *al-Kāfī*, Ibn Qutaybah's *Uyūn al-Akḥbār*, as well as the now lost work *al-Fitan* by Naʿīm ibn Ḥammād al-Khuzāʿī (d. 228 AH), according to what has been reported from al-Sayyid Ibn Ṭāwūs in *al-Malāḥim*.

COMMENTARY

1 In the first section, Amīr al-Mu'minīn (ʿa) talks about the importance of being indifferent to worldly pleasures. The phrase '*al-zāhidīna fihā*' has been rendered *those who abstain from it* and refers to the people who have little inclination towards the world and are uninterested in it. A detailed description of *al-zuhd* has been given in sermon no. 80 and its commentary. '*Al-ṣādīfīna ʿanhā*' means those who turn away from it out of disregard. The reasons for encouraging such an attitude are then clarified. Firstly, it is because this world *will shortly get rid of its residing inhabitants and afflict the opulent who feel safe*. The phrase '*al-thāwi al-sākin*' refers to one who lives in a place and is settled therein (N), to the extent of becoming comfortable and at rest there (T). All human beings, whether they are rich or poor, will soon be expelled from this world, like tenants evicted from their rented houses. The opulent will likewise be stripped of all the wealth, status, power, and other blessings they enjoyed in the world, and because of which they felt a sense of security and pride (Z). The second reason for espousing *al-zuhd* is that *whatever turns away and leaves it never returns* and *whatever is to come from it is not known so as to be anticipated*. By this, the Imām means that the blessings such as youth, time, and opportunity which pass away never return and cannot be regained when lost. At the same time, what will come in the future is unknown,

and its calamities and hardships usually befall suddenly, making it impossible for one to make preparations to forestall them (M). Thirdly, the joy of this world *is mingled with grief and in it the strength of men is soon followed by weakness and frailty*. This is something clearly witnessed by all, for it is rare to find one who is joyous and happy in it but that his happiness is replaced by sorrow due to some loss or hardship. We also see how with time, the vigour and vitality of youth gets replaced by the frailty and incapacity of old age, and how good health gets overtaken by all kinds of illness (MB). In one tradition, the Imām is reported to have said that people do not attain any blessing except after being separated from another. This is the reality of the material world – when one blessing arrives, another departs. For instance, someone is childless and prays for a child, yet when he is blessed with a child, he is beset by all sorts of problems in upbringing the child. Or a poor person prays for wealth, but when he gains it, he has to deal with thieves and coveters who desire to take away his wealth, and so on (N).

Having mentioned these attributes of the *dunyā*, the Imām once again advises the people not to get attached to it, warning them not to be *deceived by the abundance of what impresses one in it due to the little that will accompany him from it*. Seeing the majesty and glory of kings, with their huge armies and large palaces, or the numerous wives and children some possess, or any kind of wealth, be it money, property, or anything else of the sort, should not impress one to the point of beguiling him and making him think that success means acquiring such things in the world, because the fact is that nothing from this will accompany one into the grave save a simple shroud, some camphor for *ḥunūt*, and some sticks (MB). Indeed, there are many traditions that proclaim the ills of this world and warn us against attachment to it. One of the well-known traditions from the Noble Messenger states, “Love of this world is the root of every sin” (N). The Imām then makes a supplication for Allāh to shower His mercy on *everyone who ponders and pays heed, takes lesson and gains insight*. This is a call to reflect and contemplate, for indeed traditions tell us that thinking and reflection invites towards righteousness (*al-tafakkur yad’ū ilā al-birr*). Imām al-Šādiq was once asked how a person should reflect, so he replied saying, “One should pass by some ruins or [fallen] abodes and ask, ‘Where are your dwellers? Where are those who built you? Why do you not respond?’” (T). The phrase ‘*i’tabara fa abšara*’ means that he is a person who takes lessons from what he sees and hears, and follows advice that comes his way, thereby causing him to acquire an enlightened outlook and an

insightful stance. And this is something that only happens when one cuts himself off from his base desires and aspirations (MB). Others understand it to mean being able to discern the consequences and foresee the outcome of actions, and thereby take the necessary precautions (Z).

Subsequently, the Imām likens the existence of this world to its non-existence, since in the near future *whatever is there in this world will be as though it never existed, while that which is in the Hereafter will be as though it has always existed*. This statement is meant to jolt the people out of their slumber of negligence and make them realize that the real life is that of the Hereafter, which will be eternal (M). Indeed, all that exists of this world, including its adornments and glamour, will soon come to naught and perish, being like it never existed to begin with (MB). That is because *every countable thing inevitably ends, every inevitable thing comes to pass, and all that will come to pass is near and approaching*. What can be tallied and counted will eventually run out. Some note that it is a general philosophical principle that whatever can be counted is by necessity limited, and whatever is limited has an end. In this instance, the Imām is referring to the lifespan of human beings, which is counted in years, months, and days. In fact, it also refers to the lifespan of the world as a whole, which will also eventually end. Since this is inevitable, it will surely come to pass and is approaching closer at every moment. As such, the end of life in this world should not be considered something far off or remote; rather, it should be thought of as something close at hand (N). The phrases, *‘kullū mutawaqqa’in ātin’* and *‘kullū ātin qaribun dānin’* are deemed by most commentators to be specifically referring to death (Z).

2 The second section of this sermon is a description of the true scholar. Imām ‘Alī states that only he is learned who *knows his worth* (*‘arafa qadrahu’*), and being ignorant of his worth suffices to render one among the ignorant. We have been advised in the traditions not to gauge ourselves by what others say regarding us, whether it be positive or negative (T). Rather, a truly learned individual knows his own worth, meaning he knows his value, status, rank, and position in terms of his place in this world. He knows who he is, and what he was created for, so he is saved from the darkness of ignorance and attains salvation from perdition (MB). According to some commentators, a scholar who knows his worth protects his knowledge from being misused by the rich and powerful for their personal ends, due to his own avarice for wealth and status, and instead uses it to fulfil the needs of the people, or to guide those who have gone astray back to the right path.

QUALITIES OF A SCHOLAR

- 2 The learned one is he who knows his worth. It suffices as ignorance for a man to be unaware of his own worth. Verily, the most despised of men to Allāh, the Exalted, is the servant whom Allāh has left to his own devices. He [thus] strays from the straight path, and advances without a guide. If he is called to the tillage of this world he acts, but if he is called towards the tillage of the Hereafter he is sluggish. It is as though what he works for is obligatory upon him whereas that in which he slacks is not required of him!

END TIMES

- 3 That is the era in which none will be saved except every obscure believer, if he is present he is not recognized and if he is absent he is not missed. They are the lamps of guidance and the [illuminated] signs for [travellers on] night journeys. Neither do they go around spreading calumnies, nor do they blabber to reveal the flaws of others. They are the ones for whom Allāh opens the doors of His mercy and from whom He removes the distress of His chastisement. O people, a time will come upon you when Islam will be turned upside down like a pot is overturned with all that it contains. O people, verily Allāh has granted you protection from His being hard on you

صفة العالم

٢ الْعَالِمُ مَنْ عَرَفَ قَدْرَهُ، وَكَفَى بِالْمَرْءِ جَهْلًا أَلَّا يَعْرِفَ قَدْرَهُ؛ وَإِنَّ مِنْ أَبْغَضِ الرِّجَالِ إِلَى اللَّهِ تَعَالَى لَعَبْدًا وَكَلَهُ اللَّهُ إِلَى نَفْسِهِ، جَانِثًا عَنْ قَصْدِ السَّبِيلِ، سَائِرًا بِغَيْرِ ذَلِيلٍ، إِنْ دُعِيَ إِلَى حَرْثِ الدُّنْيَا عَمِلَ، وَإِنْ دُعِيَ إِلَى حَرْثِ الْآخِرَةِ كَسَلَ، كَأَنَّ مَا عَمِلَ لَهُ وَاجِبٌ عَلَيْهِ، وَكَأَنَّ مَا وَئَى فِيهِ سَاقِطٌ عَنْهُ!

آخر الزمان

٣ وَذَلِكَ زَمَانٌ لَا يَنْجُو فِيهِ إِلَّا كُلُّ مُؤْمِنٍ تَوَمَّ، إِنْ شَهِدَ لَمْ يُعْرِفْ، وَإِنْ غَابَ لَمْ يُفْتَقَدْ، أَوْلَيْكَ مَصَابِيحُ الْهُدَى وَأَعْلَامُ السُّرَى، لَيْسُوا بِالْمَسَايِخِ وَلَا الْمَذَابِيعِ الْبُذُرِ، أَوْلَيْكَ يَفْتَحُ اللَّهُ لَهُمْ أَبْوَابَ رَحْمَتِهِ، وَيَكْشِفُ عَنْهُمْ ضُرَاءَ نِقْمَتِهِ. أَئْيَهَا النَّاسِ، سَيَأْتِي عَلَيْكُمْ زَمَانٌ يُكْفَأُ فِيهِ الْإِسْلَامُ كَمَا يُكْفَأُ الْإِنَاءُ بِمَا فِيهِ. أَئْيَهَا النَّاسِ، إِنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ أَعَادَكُمْ مِنْ أَنْ يَجُورَ

but He has not spared you from being tested, and He, the most Sublime of all speakers, has said: *There are indeed signs in this, and indeed We put [people] to the test.*

عَلَيْكُمْ، وَلَمْ يُعَذِّبْكُمْ مِنْ أَنْ
يَبْتَلِيَكُمْ، وَقَدْ قَالَ جَلَّ مِنْ قَائِلٍ:
«إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ وَإِنْ كُنَّا
لُمُبْتَلِينَ».

He does not misuse his knowledge to create destructive weapons, for example, or any such thing that would cause harm to others, the way some modern-day scientists have done (Z). It is also possible that being aware of one's status could be a reference to humility, as it is common for those who gain knowledge to become arrogant, but it is only the true scholar who remains grounded and humble since he knows his position as a servant of Allāh who is totally dependent on Him (N). This statement was later adopted and used as a proverb by others (I). By saying that *the most despised of men to Allāh, the Exalted, is the servant whom Allāh has left to his own devices*, the Imām meant the obstinate, defiant individual whom Allāh is displeased with, and has hence turned His grace away from, thereby leaving him to his own devices ('*wakalahullāh ilā nafsih*'). Some say that this refers to the person who is careful about his relationship with the people but heedless of his duty towards the Creator (Z). Others opine that it is about those pseudo-scholars who present themselves as learned, but their conduct and attitude is one that is despised by the Almighty, and He turns away from them. As a result, they stray from the straight path and advance without a guide, losing their way and falling into destruction (N). To elaborate on the behaviour that led such an individual to displease his Lord, the Imām says *if he is called to the tillage of this world he acts, but if he is called towards the tillage of the Hereafter he is sluggish*. Cultivation of the tillage of this world is a metaphor for the undertakings from which one expects some worldly or material reward such as trade, farming, husbandry and the like. On the other hand, the tillage of the Hereafter refers to acts of worship or good deeds, for which reward will be attained in the Next World. For this latter kind of activity, the despised individual shows no enthusiasm and undertakes it sluggishly and lazily (MB). He acts *as though what he works for is obligatory upon him whereas that in which he slacks is not required of him*. It is true that working for this world is just as obligatory as working for the Hereafter. The

Prophets would work to earn their livelihoods, as did the Imāms and the friends (*awliyāʿ*) of Allāh. However, what the Imām means here is that such people spend all their effort only for worldly gain, and ignore everything else. They do everything for immediate reward and profit, but do not care about their Hereafter (Z).

3 The final section of this oration pertains to End Times. Amīr al-Muʾminīn describes it as an era filled with evil and injustice, and the narrations about the time just prior to the rise of the Mahdī say the same thing – that the world will be filled with oppression and wrongdoing (N). Some suggest that it refers to an era when people will turn away from religion and suffice with the outward performance of rituals (Z). Al-Sharīf al-Raḍī says, “By the words *every obscure believer*, he meant a person whom no one mentions and who does no one harm.” The term ‘*al-nūmah*’ means one who is unknown, and to whom no special attention is paid. It also refers to one who remains anonymous among the crowds, keeping away from the evil people. In one tradition where Imām ‘Alī used this term, it is reported that Ibn ‘Abbās asked him “What is *al-nūmah*?” So he said, “One who remains silent during the *fitnah*, and nothing [that supports it] is expressed by him” (T). Here, the Imām describes the obscurity of such a believer by saying *if he is present he is not recognized and if he is absent he is not missed*. Not only will such believers be saved themselves, they will also act as *lamps of guidance* for others, and illuminated signposts for night travellers. Wayfarers on the path of Allāh will be guided by their illumination (MB). This is because they act on their knowledge, are devoted to their religion, and their conduct and actions leave a positive effect on the souls, such that many lost individuals find the right path through them (Z). It is evident that when evil becomes pervasive and encompasses the entire society, being known as a pious believer would leave one vulnerable to the tyrants and despots. They would not let anyone who does not espouse their values practice his religion freely, and would do anything to hinder them or get rid of them altogether. As such, anyone who wishes to practice his faith would have to keep a low profile and remain under the radar, so to speak (N). The phrase ‘*laysū bil-masāyih wa lā al-madhāyīʿ al-budhur*’ has also been interpreted differently by commentators. Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī says, “‘*Al-masāyih*’ is the plural of *misyāh*, meaning one who goes around spreading corruption and calumny. ‘*Al-madhāyīʿ*’ is the plural of *midhyāʿ*, meaning one who, whenever he hears that a person has committed an immoral act, circulates and disseminates it. ‘*Al-budhur*’ is the plural of *badhūr*, meaning one whose levity is excessive and whose speech is

nonsensical.” Others understand the phrase differently and say that ‘*al-masāyih*’ refers to those who journey through the land or go about on the earth (from *siyāḥah*), and ‘*al-madhāyir*’ refers to those who divulge or make known that which ought to have remained hidden (T). Based on this, the phrase means that they are not among those who go about in the land, travelling from place to place thereby making themselves known to others, or inadvertently divulging that which ought to remain a secret (N).

It is for such unknown individuals who preserve their faith during times of tribulation that *Allāh opens the doors of His mercy and from whom He removes the distress of His chastisement*. In some manuscripts the phrase ‘*yaftaḥullāhu bihim*’ is found instead of ‘*yaftaḥullāhu lahum*’, in which case it means that through their presence, Allāh opens the door of mercy and removes the distress of chastisement for the people (S, MB). Indeed, a tradition from Imām al-Bāqir states that Allāh may defer the destruction of an entire village due to the presence of a single believer (T). Subsequently, the Imām proceeds to describe how hard these End Times will be, saying that it is a period *when Islam will be turned upside down like a pot is overturned with all that it contains*. In this way, he uses the analogy of an overturned vessel to describe the turmoil of the age, and some commentators note that just as an overturned container loses its benefit, due to their abandoning its tenets, the benefit of religion will also be lost by the people of this time (M). The Imām then tells his listeners that Allāh has given them security and protection *from His being hard on you* (‘*an yajūra ‘alaykum*’), meaning that Allāh does not treat anyone unjustly (Z), and He has stated unequivocally: *...and your Lord is never unjust to [His] servants* (Q41:46). However, *He has not spared you from being tested*, meaning that when corruption becomes prevalent during any age, He does not force them towards what is right and good; rather, he leaves them to choose for themselves, as a test (MB). He tests people with ease and hardship to distinguish the vile from the righteous, and renders them accountable and liable for their own state, and deserving of the reward or punishment they will get in the Hereafter (Z). Finally, the Imām recites a verse of the Qur’ān from Sūrah al-Mu’minūn, which states: *There are indeed signs in this, and indeed We put [people] to the test* (Q23:30). The context of this verse pertains to the story of Nūḥ (‘a) and how the people of his time were tested and then punished for their defiance. The purpose behind his mentioning this verse was to underscore how it is the practice of Allāh to test His

servants and try them in different ways, to make their virtues and vices known, thereby showing clearly that they deserve the requital that comes to them (MB).



THE PEOPLE BEFORE AND DURING THE TIME OF THE PROPHET

1 Now then, verily Allāh, the Glorified, sent Muḥammad (ﷺ) at a time when none among the Arabs recited a book or claimed prophethood or revelation. He fought against those who disobeyed him with those who obeyed him, leading them towards their salvation and hastening with them, lest death overtake them [before they are guided aright]. He would urge on the weary one [lagging behind] and attend to the dispirited, until he made him reach his goal, except for the irredeemable one in whom there was no good whatsoever. [He did this] until he showed them their [path to] salvation and placed them in their right position. Thus their handmills turned and their spears straightened. By Allāh, I was among those who charged after them until they had all fled and surrendered together to the command [of Islam]. I neither showed weakness nor cowardice, and neither was I disloyal nor was I lax. By Allāh, I shall split open falsehood until I extract the truth from its flank!

أَمَّا بَعْدُ، فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سُبْحَانَهُ بَعَثَ
مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ وَلَيْسَ أَحَدٌ مِنَ
الْعَرَبِ يَقْرَأُ كِتَابًا، وَلَا يَدَّعِي
نُبُوَّةَ وَلَا وَحْيًا؛ فَقَاتَلَ بِمَنْ
أَطَاعَهُ مِنْ عَصَائِهِ، يُسَوِّقُهُمْ إِلَى
مُنْجَاتِهِمْ، وَيُبَادِرُ بِهِمُ السَّاعَةَ
أَنْ تَنْزِلَ بِهِمْ، يَحْسِرُ الْحَسِيرُ
وَيَقِفُ الْكَسِيرُ فَيَقِيمُ عَلَيْهِ حَتَّى
يُلْحِقَهُ غَايَتُهُ، إِلَّا هَالِكًا لَا خَيْرَ
فِيهِ، حَتَّى أَرَاهُمْ مِنْجَاتَهُمْ،
وَبَوَّاهُمْ مَحَلَّتَهُمْ، فَاشْتَدَّ رَتْ
رَحَاهُمْ وَاسْتَقَامَتْ قَنَائُهُمْ؛ وَإِنَّمَا
اللَّهُ، لَقَدْ كُنْتُ مِنْ سَاقَتِهَا حَتَّى
تَوَلَّيْتُ بِحَذَائِفِهَا، وَاسْتَوْسَقْتُ
فِي قِيَادِهَا، مَا ضَعُفْتُ وَلَا
جَبْنْتُ، وَلَا خُنْتُ وَلَا وَهَنْتُ؛
وَإِنَّمَا اللَّهُ، لَا بُقْرَنَ الْبَاطِلَ حَتَّى
أُخْرِجَ الْحَقَّ مِنْ خَاصِرَتِهِ!

CONTEXT

This is an excerpt of the sermon that has already been mentioned (sermon no. 33), except that it is from a different narration (R). Al-Sharīf al-Raḍī is reported to have said, “Part of this sermon has been mentioned earlier, but since I found it in a different narration with some variance in wording, with some additions and elisions, I considered it pertinent to relate it again here.” One might conclude from this statement that both these orations are actually one and the same, and thus have the same context, despite the few differences found between them. However, some commentators opine that since some of the differences are substantial, it is also possible that these are two separate sermons (N). The context of the earlier sermon (no. 33) gives details about where and when Amīr al-Mu’minīn delivered that oration, and if indeed this is another version of the same sermon, then the context is the same. In summary, it was spoken by the Imām as he proceeded to fight against those who had rebelled in the Battle of Jamal. No alternative context is mentioned for this specific sermon, since most of the commentators do not consider it to be a different oration. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* actually merges the two into a single sermon (4:411).

COMMENTARY

1 The era in which the Final Messenger was sent is described by Amīr al-Mu’minīn as a time when none among the Arabs were reading a Book or claiming prophecy or revelation. This means that most of the Arabs at that time were unlettered, or it could mean that the Arabs did not have a revealed scripture that they were following. Since this was generally the case, it does not contradict the presence of a small number among them who would read the distorted versions of the Torah, Gospel, and Psalms that were present with them (MB). Though nobody claimed to be a Prophet, there were some who knew that a Prophet would be sent amongst them. Hence it is reported that just before the time of his appearance, a group named their sons ‘Muḥammad’ out of the hope that it would be their sons who were chosen for the task, for they had heard that the name of the Prophet who was coming would be ‘Muḥammad’. And something similar had also transpired during the time of Mūsā (‘a), as well as for the awaited Mahdī (‘a). Furthermore, false claimants to prophecy did rise up after the Prophet had started his mission, with a number of people making this claim, such as Musaylimah,

Aswad ibn Ka'b, and others (T). The Imām then notes how the Messenger of Allāh had to fight against his enemies and those who disobeyed him with the help of those who obeyed and followed him. It was this latter group who were led by him *towards their salvation* and he hastened with them, *lest death overtake them* before they were guided aright. The term '*al-sā'ah*' here is understood as the hour of their death, or what is sometimes referred to as *al-qiyāmah al-ṣuḡhrā*, not the Final Hour, meaning the Day of Judgment or *al-qiyāmah al-kubrā* (N). Some commentators, however, have taken it to mean the Day of Resurrection (I, T), in which case the phrase would be translated as *lest the Hour [of Judgment] overtake them*. It should be noted that the Messenger of Allāh invited the people to the truth with his wise words and exemplary conduct for many years, and it is only when they remained defiant and used violence against the believers that the command to rise up and fight them was given (Z). Some accounts note that out of the twenty-six campaigns led by the Prophet (ṣ), he only fought in nine. The rest were minor missions carried out by contingents led by commanders appointed by the Noble Messenger (T). The Imām further notes that when the weary one ('*al-ḥasīr*') lagged behind and the dispirited, broken one ('*al-kasīr*') halted, the Prophet *would attend to him until he made him reach his goal, except for the irredeemable one in whom there was no good whatsoever*. This shows the care and compassion of the Prophet, for he left no man behind, and would raise the weary, and nurture the broken. The term '*al-kasīr*' is taken by some to mean one whose leg is broken (T), or who is injured. He thus made the believers reach their goal, one and all, with the only exception being those who could not be saved and for whom there was no hope (M). This last group is considered by some to be those in whom there was no good at all, due to their headstrong obstinacy and defiance against the truth (I). Examples of certain individuals during the time of the Messenger who fall into this category have been mentioned in some commentaries in detail (T). According to other commentators, these statements constitute an analogy where the people are likened, in the way they traverse the path towards the Hereafter, to a caravan of camels, since the terms '*al-ḥasīr*' and '*al-kasīr*' are more commonly used for camels. The intended meaning is that whoever becomes weary and stops advancing on the path of truth due to weakness in his belief or some flaw in his ability to reason, would find the Prophet (ṣ) by his side, holding on to his arm and gently pulling him forward. He would strengthen him with conviction and encourage him to perform good deeds until he attains the goal of his creation

(MB). He did this *until he showed them their salvation and placed them in their right position*, meaning the place where they would find safety and refuge (Z).

The turning of their handmills (*'istadārat raḥāhum'*) and straightening of their spears (*'istaqāmat qanātuhum'*) are metaphors. The first signifies the organization of their affairs, because a handmill can only turn when its parts are properly aligned (I). The second also gives a similar meaning of their state becoming upright, and additionally connotes the attainment of might and power (N). Together, they give the meaning of development and prosperity (S). The Imām then describes his role during this time, saying that he *was among those who charged after them until they had all fled and surrendered together to the command* of Islam. He further stated that he *neither showed weakness nor cowardice*, emphasizing this with the declaration: *neither was I disloyal nor was I lax*. The phrase *'min sāqatihā'* also connotes the heat of battle, and means that the Imām would be right in the middle of the fighting (T), not merely watching from the sidelines. Some commentators opine that the female pronoun in *'ḥadhāfirihā'* refers to the elided term *al-jāhiliyyah*. Thus it was as if he was charging and fighting against the battalions of the Age of Ignorance (I). The verb *'istawsaqat'*, translated as *surrendered together*, literally means to gather together or to be arrayed (T). Hence, he was among those through whose efforts the forces of ignorance were defeated by the Muslims and they came under the domination of Islam the way camels are brought under the control of a camel-driver (MB). By saying that he was neither weak nor cowardly, nor disloyal nor lax, the Imām reminds them that his whole life has been spent struggling continuously for the sake of Islam, and he has borne hardships that are too great to imagine, yet with each difficulty his patience, steadfastness, and sincerity only increased (Z). In reality, it is usually one of these four traits that leads to defeat in battle: weakness, cowardice, betrayal, or laxity. The difference between weakness and laxity is that in the latter, one is able to do something but is sluggish and lazy, so he does not do it. Since none of these four traits were in him, the Imām was always successful in his battles (N). In the end, Imām 'Alī announces that he would surely *split open falsehood* until he has extracted *the truth from its flank*. Some scholars have remarked at the beauty of this simile, calling it wonderfully subtle (Z). From this statement we learn that truth is always present in this world, even when falsehood throws its cover upon it to conceal it. Therefore, by tearing apart the veils of falsehood, the truth can be made manifest, and this is what the Imām intended here (N).



ATTRIBUTES OF THE NOBLE PROPHET AND THE THREAT OF BANĪ UMAYYAH

THE NOBLE PROPHET

- 1 [Ignorance prevailed] until Allāh sent Muḥammad (ṣ) as a witness, a giver of glad tidings, and a warner. As a child, he was the best of all creatures, as an adult, he was the most eminent. He was the purest of the pure in disposition and the most generous in showering his bounty [to the needy].

BANŪ UMAYYAH

- 2 This world was not sweet for you in its pleasures and you were not capable of drawing milk from its udders except after having stumbled upon it with its noseband detached and its girth loose. What is unlawful of it had become like [easily accessible] thornless lote trees for certain groups, while what is lawful was far and unavailable. By Allāh, you came upon it like a shade extended for a fixed time. Thus the earth is vacant [and defenceless] for you and your hands are open in it while the hands of the [true] leaders are restrained from you. Your swords prevail over them while their swords are held back from you.

الرسول الكريم

١ حَتَّى بَعَثَ اللَّهُ مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ شَهِيداً وَبَشِيراً وَنَذِيراً، خَيْرَ الْبَرِيَّةِ طِفْلاً وَأَنْجَبَهَا كَهْلاً، وَأَطْهَرَ الْمُطَهَّرِينَ شَيْمَةً، وَأَجْوَدَ الْمُسْتَمْطَرِينَ دِيَمَةً.

بنو أمية

٢ فَمَا اخْلَوْلْتُ لَكُمْ الدُّنْيَا فِي لَذَّتِهَا، وَلَا تَمَكَّنْتُمْ مِنْ رِضَاعِ أَخْلَافِهَا إِلَّا مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا صَادَقْتُمُوهَا، جَائِلًا خِطَامُهَا، قَلِقًا وَضِيئُهَا، قَدْ صَارَ حَرَامُهَا عِنْدَ أَقْوَامٍ بِمَنْزِلَةِ السَّدرِ الْمُخْضُودِ، وَحَلَالُهَا بَعِيداً غَيْرَ مَوْجُودٍ، وَصَادَقْتُمُوهَا وَاللَّهُ ظِلًّا مَمْدُوداً إِلَى أَجَلٍ مَعْدُودٍ؛ فَالْأَرْضُ لَكُمْ شَاغِرَةٌ، وَأَيْدِيكُمْ فِيهَا مَبْسُوطَةٌ، وَأَيْدِي الْقَادَةِ عَنْكُمْ مَكْفُوفَةٌ، وَسُيُوفُكُمْ عَلَيْهِمْ مُسَلَّطَةٌ، وَسُيُوفُهُمْ عَنْكُمْ مَقْبُوضَةٌ.

CONTEXT

In this sermon, Imām ‘Alī mentions some of the attributes of the Noble Prophet (ﷺ) and then warns the Banū Umayyah before ending with a word of advice for the people. Hence there are three different subjects or themes in this oration. The early exegete ‘Alī ibn Ibrāhīm al-Qummī (d. ~ 307 AH), mentions the last part of this sermon in his exegesis under the verse Q16:25, as narrated by Imām al-Ṣādiq. Al-Shaykh al-Mufid likewise relates part of it in his *Kitāb al-Irshād* (N). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* notes that it has been reported Amīr al-Mu’minīn delivered this sermon (or at least part thereof) five days after he was given the pledge of allegiance as caliph (2:208).

COMMENTARY

1 In the first passage of this sermon, the Imām speaks about the great blessing granted to the people by the coming of the Noble Prophet (ﷺ), and he mentions seven qualities out of the numerous praiseworthy traits of the Final Messenger. Some commentators suggest the elided phrase that precedes the first sentence was ‘Ignorance prevailed among the people’ (N). Alternatively, the *‘hattā’* at the beginning is referring to something else preceding it which was omitted by al-Sharīf al-Raḍī. Most commentators take the attribute of being a *witness* (*‘shahīd’*) to mean that the Noble Prophet will be a witness to the deeds of the people on the Day of Judgment (M, I) as the Qur’ān states: *So how shall it be when We bring from every nation a witness and We bring you as a witness over them?* (Q4:41). As for being a *giver of glad tidings and a warner*, that too has been mentioned in the verse: *Indeed We have sent you with the truth as a bearer of glad tidings and a warner; and there no nation but that a warner has passed among them* (35:24). His glad tidings were for those who obeyed and followed him, while his warning was for those who opposed and disobeyed him (MB). To emphasize his unique virtue, the Imām states that even as a child, the Noble Prophet was *the best of all creatures*, and *as an adult, he was the most eminent*. Reports from his foster mother Ḥalimah al-Sa’diyyah attest to his greatness, right from infancy (S). Numerous accounts from his grandfather ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib and his uncle Abū Ṭālib, both of whom nurtured him as a child, also testify to his virtue, even at a young age. For instance, it is reported that he was the only one allowed to sit on ‘Abd al-Muṭṭalib’s carpet near the Ka’bah, when even the latter’s own children were not permitted by him to do

so. That was because of the great respect he had for his grandson. Abū Ṭālib testified, for his part, about the character of his nephew, saying, “I never witnessed him telling a lie, nor did I see him doing anything from the [practices of] Jāhiliyyah. I never saw him laughing except in the situation where laughter was appropriate, nor did he play frivolously with other children, nor did he pay any attention to them. Rather, solitude was preferred by him, as was humility” (T). The term *‘kahlan’* refers to one who is middle-aged, and some say that it is used for one who is above thirty years of age (N). His eminence as an adult was due to the purity of his heart and the beauty of his conduct (Z). That is why the Imām says *he was the purest of the pure in disposition and the most generous in showering his bounty* to the needy. He had to be the purest of the pure (*‘aṭhar al-muṭahharīn’*) in disposition, because he was sent to perfect the character of the people, so he had to have the purest character himself (M). The term *‘dīmāh’* refers to rainfall without any thunder or lightening, which lasts for at least a third of the day or night, and may continue for many days (T). Here, it is used metaphorically to depict the generosity of the Noble Messenger as one of the most munificent of those who are approached for assistance, or from whom open-handed bounty is expected (MB). Abū Dharr is reported to have said that he was once with the Messenger of Allāh, and they passed by the mountain of Uḥud. At that moment the Prophet asked him, “Do you see Uḥud?” He replied affirmatively. The Prophet then said that if he had gold that filled the entirety of that mountain, he would give it all away in the way of Allāh, not wishing to leave behind anything (Z). This is just one example of the generous nature of the Noble Prophet.

2 Some commentators opine that this section is not linked to what precedes it and there was a part of the sermon that was omitted by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī between these two passages (N). It has been suggested that this section is addressed to the Banū Umayyah (M), but other commentators say that it is generally addressed to all people (R), or to those few remaining companions of the Prophet and their successors (*tābiʿīn*) (I). The first opinion matches the context of the speech as seen in what follows, while the last opinion is more in line with the apparent meaning of his speech (MB). In any case, when the Imām describes this world as a place which *was not sweet* (*‘mā aḥlawlat’*) for the people and they *were not capable of drawing milk from its udders except after having stumbled upon it with its noseband detached and its girth loose*, he is figuratively saying that it was the Prophet who made the world submit to them, through his perfect message, exemplary

character, and continuous struggle. It was he (ṣ) who subjugated it for them and placed it at their feet. However, after he had left this world, it became like a dangerous beast, waiting for a strong and wise leader to take hold of its reins and lead it to the correct path, but it did not find one. Hence their state was like that of a rider who cannot control its mount (Z). An alternative interpretation is that it was only once the camel of leadership was released from its true owner, roaming about freely, that it was taken by the likes of ‘Uthmān and milked for all its gains and wealth, which the Umayyads then amassed (N). That is because when a camel is held by its owner, nobody else can gain access to it. So by saying that its halter was loose and its girth was slack, he meant that it had no one holding its reins, and that only happens when it is separated from its owner (MB). The term ‘*akhlāf*’ refers to the front and rear teats of the camel’s udder upon which the milker lays hold (R). The period being described by the Imām was one in which things got so bad that the unlawful *had become like thornless lote trees for certain groups, while what is lawful was far and unavailable*. The phrase ‘*al-sidr al-makhḍūd*’ refers to a lote tree that has no thorns, thereby making its fruit easily accessible (T). Indeed, after the time of the Prophet, that which was forbidden became easy to acquire, with nobody to prevent or block it, just like a thornless lote tree (Z). Conversely, that which was lawful had become *far and unavailable*, because people lacked piety. By describing their coming upon it and finding it to be *like a shade extended for a fixed time*, the Imām was saying that after the era of the Prophet, they found this world to be a place of ease and comfort for a brief period (T). Some interpret this to generally mean that the pleasures of this world are short-lived and will be followed by pain and remorse (Z).

The term ‘*shāghirah*’, which is used by the Imām to describe the world, means vacant, and usually applies to a town or city which has nobody remaining in it who could defend it from invaders (I). Here it means that there was nothing to prevent them from this world, or nothing of it was difficult for them to attain. Hence their hands were open and extended, reaching out to grab it. Consequently, they were free to act tyrannically and do whatever they wanted *while the hands of the true and righteous leaders were restrained* from them, due to the paucity of supporters and the overwhelming number of hypocrites and dissenters (MB). Similarly, his statement *your swords prevail over them while their swords are held back from you* meant that they had no awe or fear of their true (divinely appointed) leaders and would stubbornly defy them, while the latter held back from them (Z).

- 3 Beware, verily for every blood [that is shed] there is an avenger and for every right there is a demandant. Indeed, the avenger of our blood is the very same judge who adjudicates His own right, and that is Allāh – who can neither be thwarted by the one He seeks nor can He be evaded by the one who flees. So I swear by Allāh, O Banī Umayyah, you will soon find it in the hands of others and in the abode of your enemy! Know that the most percipient of eyes is one that focuses its gaze on virtue; know that the most perceptive of ears is one that listens to good advice attentively and accepts it.

ADVISING THE PEOPLE

- 4 O people, seek illumination from the flame of the lamp of the exhorter who follows what he preaches, and draw water from the clear spring that is unpolluted by turbidity. Servants of Allāh, do not incline towards your ignorance and do not yield to your desires, for indeed he who alights at this station [of ignorance and desire] is like one who settles on the brink of a collapsing bank, carrying [his] destruction on his back from one place to another by following his [own] opinion, which he constantly changes. He seeks to adhere that which does not stick and to bring together that which does not converge. So fear Allāh, and do not complain to one who can neither

٣ أَلَا وَإِنَّ لِكُلِّ دَمٍ ثَائِرًا وَلِكُلِّ حَقٍّ طَالِبًا، وَإِنَّ الثَّائِرَ فِي دِمَائِنَا كَالْحَاكِمِ فِي حَقِّ نَفْسِهِ، وَهُوَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي لَا يُعْجِزُهُ مَنْ طَلَبَ وَلَا يَفْوُتُهُ مَنْ هَرَبَ. فَأَقْسِمُ بِاللَّهِ، يَا بَنِي أُمَيَّةَ، عَمَّا قَلِيلٍ لَتَعْرِفْنَهَا فِي أَيْدِي غَيْرِكُمْ وَفِي دَارِ عَدُوِّكُمْ! أَلَا إِنَّ أَبْصَرَ الْأَبْصَارِ مَا نَفَذَ فِي الْخَيْرِ طَرْفُهُ؛ أَلَا إِنَّ أَسْمَعَ الْأَسْمَاعِ مَا وَعَى التَّذْكَيرَ وَقَبَلَهُ.

وعظ الناس

٤ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، اسْتَضِئُوا مِنْ شُعْلَةِ مِصْبَاحٍ وَاعْظُوا مُتَعِظًا، وَافْتَاخُوا مِنْ صَفْوِ عَيْنٍ قَدْ رُوِّقَتْ مِنَ الْكَدْرِ. عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، لَا تَزْكُنُوا إِلَى جَهَالَتِكُمْ، وَلَا تَتَفَادُوا لِأَهْوَائِكُمْ، فَإِنَّ النَّازِلَ بِهَذَا الْمَنْزِلِ نَازِلٌ بِشَفَا جُرْفٍ هَارٍ، يَنْقُلُ الرَّدَى عَلَى ظَهْرِهِ مِنْ مَوْضِعٍ إِلَى مَوْضِعٍ، لِرَأْيٍ يُحْدِثُهُ بَعْدَ رَأْيٍ، يُرِيدُ أَنْ يُلْصِقَ مَا لَا يُلْصِقُ وَيَتَقَرَّبَ مَا لَا يَتَقَارَبُ. فَاللَّهُ اللَّهُ أَنْ تَشْكُوا

redress your grievance nor undo with his opinion what has been determined for you.

إِلَى مَنْ لَا يُشْكِي شَجْوَكُمْ،
وَلَا يَنْقُضُ بَرَأِيَهُ مَا قَدْ أُبْرِمَ
لَكُمْ.

- 5 Verily there is no obligation on the Imām other than what he has been commanded to do by his Lord: to convey admonition, to strive in counselling [the people], to revive the *sunnah*, to enforce [legally prescribed] penalties on those who are deserving [of punishment], and to remit shares to their rightful owners. So hasten towards knowledge before its foliage dries up, and before you get too occupied with your affairs to acquire knowledge from those who have it. Forbid what is wrong and desist from it yourselves, for indeed you have only been commanded to forbid [others] after desisting [from it yourselves].

۞ إِنَّهُ لَيْسَ عَلَى الْإِمَامِ إِلَّا مَا
حُمِّلَ مِنْ أَمْرِ رَبِّهِ: الْإِبْلَاجُ فِي
الْمَوْعِظَةِ، وَالْاجْتِهَادُ فِي
النَّصِيحَةِ، وَالْإِحْيَاءُ لِلسُّنَّةِ،
وإِقَامَةُ الْحُدُودِ عَلَى مُسْتَحَقِّهَا،
وَإِصْدَارُ السُّهُمَانِ عَلَى أَهْلِهَا.
فَبَادِرُوا الْعِلْمَ مِنْ قَبْلِ تَضْوِيحِ
نَبِيِّهِ، وَمِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ تُشْغَلُوا
بِأَنْفُسِكُمْ عَنْ مُسْتَتَارِ الْعِلْمِ مِنْ
عِنْدِ أَهْلِهِ، وَأَنْهَوْا عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ
وَتَنَاهَوْا عَنْهُ، فَإِنَّمَا أُمِرْتُمْ بِالنَّهْيِ
بَعْدَ التَّأْهِيِ.

Others opine that this may be a reference to what happened in Karbalā', where the Banū Umayyah killed the rightful leader and Imām, and shed his blood and that of his family (MB).

- 3 This section is mentioned in al-Mufid's *Kitāb al-Irshād*, as part of a sermon that starts with the Imām introducing himself as the brother of the Prophet and the one chosen by him (T). People are warned that *for every blood* that is shed *there is an avenger and for every right there is a demandant*. The term '*thā'ir*' refers to one who does not stop at anything until he takes vengeance from the killer (of his kin) (R). Then the Imām says that *the avenger of our blood is the very same judge who adjudicates His own right, and that is Allāh*. By this he alludes to how the blood of the family of the Prophet would be spilled wrongfully, and he warns the Banī Umayyah, and indeed everyone else, that in doing so they are inviting the wrath

of Allāh, since it will be He who shall avenge them Himself (M). By describing the Almighty as the judge who adjudicates his own right, the Imām meant that He would not falter in seeking redress and punishing those who killed the Ahl al-Bayt, just like the judge who passes a verdict in favour of his own claim, thereby acting as both plaintiff and judge (I). And, of course, *He can neither be thwarted by the one He seeks nor can He be evaded by the one who flees*, as nobody can escape His grasp. Imām ‘Alī then turns to address the Banū Umayyah directly and says, after swearing by Allāh, *O Banī Umayyah, you will soon find it in the hands of others and in the abode of your enemy*. By this, the Imām meant that the rule and authority they enjoy will not remain with them and will pass on to others who are their enemies. And indeed, this transpired just as the Imām had foretold (N). The uprisings against the Umayyads gained momentum and the battles against them were continuous, because the hearts had inclined against them, and hatred for them had taken root. This was the obvious consequence of their unbridled tyranny and oppression against the people. Thus, when they were overthrown by the ‘Abbāsids, the latter killed the living among them and burned the corpses of their dead (Z). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then gives a general prescription when he states that *the most percipient of eyes is one that focuses its gaze on virtue and the most perceptive of ears is one that listens to good advice attentively and accepts it*. This statement is not linked to what precedes it and is not addressed specifically to the Banū Umayyah. Rather, it is advice for all those who would listen. The Imām means to say that looking at what is good and following it is a sign of wisdom, for the best thing that the eyes can see is that which increases insight and understanding, and brings benefit to the onlooker, leading to his felicity and success. Likewise, the best thing that ears can hear is the reminder and advice that can be pondered upon and accepted, to the benefit of the listener (MB). Some commentators opine that the gaze being referred to here actually connotes the intellect, because the eyes see but it is the mind that interprets and judges. Hence, the message is that one who truly sees is he who is able to differentiate between truth and falsehood, and between good and evil, so he espouses the former and eschews the latter (Z).

4 Now the Imām gives general advice to his audience, telling them to *seek illumination from the flame of the lamp of the exhorter who follows what he preaches and draw water from the clear spring that is unpolluted by turbidity*. The exhorter he is referring to here is himself, as he would practice what he preached, not like

many who only admonished with words but fell short in action (T). The imperative '*istaṣbiḥū*' literally means light your lamp, and here it connotes taking the illumination of guidance. The importance of following what one preaches is seen in the effectiveness of admonition, for only the word of one who practices his own advice penetrates the hearts (MB). The *clear spring* is also a figurative reference to the Imām himself, and just as drinking pure, unpolluted water from a clean source imbues the body with vigour and strength, so too does following the advice of a wise, practicing exhorter strengthen the believers (N). In this way, the Imām is encouraging the people to take benefit from his knowledge and follow his guidance, as he would lead them to the path of truth and felicity (Z). The warning *do not incline towards your ignorance* either means that they should be wary of ignorance, or should not be satisfied or content with it (M). The Imām then explains the consequence of *jahālah* and yielding to vain desires, saying that one *who alights at this station*, i.e. the station of ignorance and desire, is like the person *who settles on the brink of a collapsing bank*. This latter part is taken from the verse that states: *So is one who lays the foundation of his edifice on being mindful of Allāh and [seeking His] pleasure better, or one who founds his building on the edge of a crumbling precipice ('alā shafā juruḥin hārin), which then collapses with him into the fire of Hell?* (Q9:109) (T). Some commentators say that this could be in reference to those who wrongfully usurped the caliphate without being deserving thereof, thereby 'alighting at a station' which was not rightfully theirs. However, the more likely meaning, given the context, is that it is the station of inclining towards ignorance, while stubbornly clinging to one's own opinion, without following the appointed guide and leader. Such a person builds the edifice of his religion upon falsehood, so it is neither stable nor does it last (MB).

So it is that the Imām describes such an individual as one who carries his own *destruction on his back from one place to another by following his opinion* stubbornly, and paying no heed to the advice or guidance of others. Interestingly, such a person keeps changing his opinion ('*ra'yin yuḥdithuhu ba'da ra'yin*'). That is because his views are based on assumptions and speculation, and lack any evidence. Hence, in order to justify seemingly contradictory opinions, he has to come up with different ways of reinterpreting and restating his position (N). A thought-provoking analogy is then given by the Imām when he says that such an individual *seeks to adhere that which does not stick and to bring together that which does not converge*. It is as though he is trying to glue together two things that do not bond,

and join that which cannot come together. In so doing, he seeks to prove a falsehood using counterintuitive and illogical evidence (MB). Some sociologists say that ignorant people often overlook the contradictory nature of things and assume that they can be joined together (Z). Subsequently, he instructs the people to fear Allāh, and not to *complain to one who can neither redress your grievance nor undo with his opinion what has been determined for you*. The phrase '*man lā yushkī shajwakum*' means one who does not have compassion for you such that he would feel sad for you or seek to remedy your state (R). Or, it could mean one who is unable to remove your sorrow and do away with that which causes it (MB). Indeed, it is a sign of ignorance to complain to someone who does not care for the complainer and can be of no benefit or harm to him. Likewise, it is futile to complain to a person who has no knowledge of religion and no life-experience that could be of help (Z). These statements may be seen as a general proscription against taking advice from those who are unworthy (N). The phrase '*mā qad ubrima lakum*' has been interpreted by some to mean that which Satan has placed in their heart in order to misguide them (I). Others say that it means what Allāh has mandated, ordained, and determined for them (T).

5 Amīr al-Mu'minīn then mentions five responsibilities of the Imām, and this is addressed to all the people (R). When he says that *there is no obligation on the Imām other than what he has been commanded to do by his Lord* it means that as their leader, he will not be answerable in front of Allāh except for five things. They are [i] *to convey admonition* ('*al-iblāghu fī al-maw'izah*') which means not falling short in enjoining good and forbidding evil (Z). Indeed, Imām 'Alī would advise the people day and night, privately and in public, in writing and verbally, from close by and from a distance. His advice reached his friend and foe, his relative and those unrelated to him. This was also the practice of the Prophets. Every night, after the 'Ishā' prayer, the Imām would face the people and remind them to prepare provisions for the Hereafter. In the day time, he would walk among the people in the marketplaces and advise them to do good and eschew evil (T). [ii] *To strive in counselling the people* ('*al-ijtihād fī al-naṣīḥah*'). Given that the term *naṣīḥah* also connotes sincerity and goodwill, this phrase is interpreted as treating all the people equally, protecting their interests, both material and spiritual, and generally leading them all to a better and more prosperous life (Z). Because the Imām is like the Prophet in that his presence is a grace from the Almighty to His servants, it is incumbent on the Imām to strive and struggle in order to save the

people from Hell. Hence we note that the Imāms would go out of their way and expend great effort in trying to guide the people and save them from perdition (T). [iii] *To revive the sunnah* ('*al-ihyā'u lil-sunnah*'), meaning establishing the laws and upholding the fundamental principles as outlined in the Qur'ān and the Sunnah (Z). Here the reference is to the practice (*sunnah*) of the Noble Prophet, and no one else. That is why when 'Abd al-Raḥmān ibn 'Awf tried to impose a condition on Imām 'Alī on the day of the Shūrā council to the effect that he would follow the *sunnah* of the two previous caliphs, the Imām said, "There is no *sunnah* save the *sunnah* of the Prophet (ṣ)" (T). [iv] *To enforce legally prescribed penalties on those who are deserving of punishment* ('*iqāmat al-ḥudūd 'ala mustaḥiqqihā*'). The Noble Messenger is reported to have said, "...The legally prescribed punishment (*ḥadd*) that is carried out in the land is better than rain that falls for forty days." And there are many reports of how Amīr al-Mu'minīn was very meticulous when it came to carrying out the prescribed penalties (T). [v] *To remit shares to their rightful owners* ('*iṣdār al-suhmān 'alā ahlihā*'). In the past, the wealth of the public treasury (*bayt al-māl*) would be divided among the soldiers and the people, and with the passage of time, the government began spending it for public projects such as development of agriculture, healthcare, education, etc. During the Imām's time, the wealth was divided among the people, and this phrase means that it is the Imām's duty to give each person the share of the treasury that he deserves (Z). By mentioning these responsibilities and duties, it was as though the Imām was indirectly telling the people that for his part, he has fulfilled everything that was incumbent upon him. Therefore, it is they who had fallen short in their conduct and actions. When a leader of the Muslims fulfils the duties mentioned by the Imām here, he has accomplished what is expected of him by the Almighty (N). History tells us how most of those who came to power fell short in carrying out these responsibilities, and at times, even did the opposite of what they were supposed to do – like establishing innovations in religion, etc. (MB).

The Imām then advises the people to gain knowledge and hasten towards it *before its foliage dries up, and before you get too occupied with your affairs to acquire knowledge from those who have it*, by which he means himself (I), or the Ahl al-Bayt (M), who were the keepers of the treasures of knowledge bestowed upon the Noble Prophet. The metaphor of foliage drying up and withering connotes the loss of their opportunity to ask and learn this knowledge from him. Hence some commentators liken it to his statement, "Ask me before you lose me!" (T). He urges

the people to make haste and benefit from him while he was with them before they get *too occupied* with their affairs, meaning the problems that will come their way once the Banū Umayyah take charge (MB). The phrase '*mustathār al-ilm*' literally means the excitement and agitation of knowledge, and here it connotes extracting the knowledge and acquiring it from its source (I). In closing, the Imām instructs the people to *forbid what is wrong and desist from it* themselves, saying that they have only been commanded to forbid others after desisting from it themselves. Indeed it is a very shameful thing for a person to forbid others from doing something which he himself commits (M). Hence we note that the duty of the people may be summed up as: firstly, to acquire knowledge and increase their understanding and erudition; because ignorance is one of the causes of disharmony. Secondly, they must act on the knowledge they have gained and carry out their responsibility of enjoining good and forbidding evil.

Some commentators pose a question here: It is known that *nahy'an al-munkar* is obligatory upon all people, good and evil, so why did the Imām say *you have only been commanded to forbid others after desisting from it yourselves*? The answer given is that this statement means the command to forbid others only came to the people after the command to desist from the evil themselves, not that the latter is a condition for the former (I). Other commentators have, however, not found this to be a suitable answer. Rather, they say that both desisting from evil and forbidding others from it are mandatory obligations, and the final statement of the Imām in this sermon only emphasizes the greater importance of self-reform and keeping away from evil before telling others to do so (MB). One commentator suggests that desisting from sin is a condition for the perfection of *nahy'an al-munkar*, not for its being obligatory. This means that forbidding others from evil can only be done efficaciously when one avoids the evil himself (N).



ON THE EXCELLENCE OF ISLAM AND THE NOBLE PROPHET

THE RELIGION OF ISLAM

- 1 All praise be to Allāh who prescribed Islam and made its ways easy for those who came to it, and fortified its pillars against anyone who sought to conquer it. Thus He made it a security for one who clings to it, a [means of] peace for one who enters it, a proof for one who speaks through it, a witness for one who litigates by it, and a light for one who seeks illumination from it. [It is a means of] comprehension for one who reflects, understanding for one who ponders, a sign for one who keenly observes, an insight for one who is determined, a lesson for one who takes admonishment, salvation for one who believes, a dependable support for one who relies [on it], a comfort for one who entrusts [his affairs to it], and a shield for one who endures patiently. It is the brightest of paths and the clearest of all courses, with towering beacons, well-lit highways, and glowing lamps, with a thriving arena and a lofty goal. It is a gathering of race horses, all vying for a valuable prize, with riders that are honourable. Belief is its path, virtue is its lamp-post, death is its culmination, this world is its racecourse, the Day of Judgement is

دين الإسلام

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي شَرَعَ الْإِسْلَامَ
فَسَهَّلَ شَرَائِعَهُ لِمَنْ وَرَدَهُ، وَأَعَزَّ
أَرْكَانَهُ عَلَى مَنْ غَالَبَهُ، فَجَعَلَهُ
أَمْنًا لِمَنْ عَلِقَهُ، وَسَلَامًا لِمَنْ
دَخَلَهُ، وَبُرْهَانًا لِمَنْ تَكَلَّمَ بِهِ،
وَشَاهِدًا لِمَنْ خَاصَمَ بِهِ، وَنُورًا
لِمَنْ اسْتَضَاءَ بِهِ، وَفَهْمًا لِمَنْ
عَقَلَ، وَلُبًّا لِمَنْ تَدَبَّرَ، وَآيَةً لِمَنْ
تَوَسَّمَ، وَتَبْصِيرَةً لِمَنْ عَزَمَ،
وَعِبْرَةً لِمَنْ اتَّعَطَّ، وَنَجَاةً لِمَنْ
صَدَّقَ، وَثِقَةً لِمَنْ تَوَكَّلَ،
وَرَاحَةً لِمَنْ فَوَّضَ، وَحِجَّةً لِمَنْ
صَبَرَ؛ فَهُوَ أَبْلَجُ الْمَنَاهِجِ
وَأَوْضَحُ الْوَلَائِحِ، مُشْرِفُ
الْمَنَارِ، مُشْرِقُ الْجَوَادِّ،
مُضِيءُ الْمَصَابِيحِ، كَرِيمُ
الْمُضْمَارِ، رَفِيعُ الْغَايَةِ؛ جَامِعُ
الْحَلَبَةِ، مُتَنَافِسُ السُّبْقَةِ، شَرِيفُ
الْفُرْسَانِ؛ التَّصَدِيقُ مِنْهَاجُهُ،
وَالصَّالِحَاتُ مَنَارُهُ، وَالْمَوْتُ

its gathering point, and Paradise is its prize.

عَايَتُهُ، وَالْأُتَى مَضْمَارُهُ، وَالْقِيَامَةُ
حُلْبَتُهُ، وَالْجَنَّةُ سُبْقَتُهُ.

ABOUT THE PROPHET (ﷺ)

- 2 Until he lit a torch for the seeker of light and illuminated a sign for the one who lost his way. Thus he is Your trusted emissary, Your witness on the Day of Judgement, the one You sent as a blessing, and Your messenger with truth as a mercy. O Allāh, grant him a [generous] share from Your justice and award him manifold bounties from Your grace. O Allāh, elevate his edifice above all other built structures, honour him in Your presence, ennoble his status with You, give him the means of proximity [to You], and bestow upon him prestige and eminence. Resurrect us in his company, neither disgraced, nor regretful, nor deviated, nor having broken our oaths, nor having strayed, nor having misled others, nor enticed [by vain desires].

ومنها: في ذكر النبي ﷺ

٢ حَتَّى أَوْزَى قَبْسًا لِقَابِيسَ، وَأَنَارَ عِلْمًا
لِحَابِيسَ، فَهُوَ أَمِينُكَ الْمَأْمُونُ،
وَشَهِيدُكَ يَوْمَ الدِّينِ، وَبَعِيَّتُكَ نِعْمَةً،
وَرَسُولُكَ بِالْحَقِّ رَحْمَةً. اللَّهُمَّ أَقْسِمَ
لَهُ مَقْسَمًا مِنْ عَدْلِكَ، وَاجْزِهِ
مُضَعَّفَاتِ الْخَيْرِ مِنْ فَضْلِكَ. اللَّهُمَّ
أَعْلِلْ عَلَى بِنَاءِ الْبَانِينَ بِنَاءَهُ، وَأَكْرِمِ
لَدَيْكَ تَرْكَهُ، وَشَرِّفْ عِنْدَكَ مَنْزِلَهُ،
وَأَتِهِ الْوَسِيلَةَ، وَأَعْطِهِ السَّنَاءَ
وَالْفَضِيلَةَ؛ وَاحْشُرْنَا فِي رُفْرَتِهِ غَيْرَ
خَزَايَا، وَلَا نَادِمِينَ وَلَا نَاكِيبِينَ، وَلَا
نَاكِيبِينَ وَلَا ضَالِّينَ، وَلَا مُضِلِّينَ وَلَا
مَفْتُونِينَ.

CONTEXT

This oration comprises three sections, the first of which is about the religion of Islam. It is reported that this opening part of the sermon was spoken by the Imām at his home, or at Dār al-Imārah (in Kūfah), in response to someone who had asked him to describe the qualities of *islām* and *īmān* as well as those of *kufīr* and *nifāq*. Then he gave instructions that it should be transcribed and read out to the people [in different cities] (T). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* (4:214-5) explains the context of this sermon under aphorism no. 257, and notes that

aphorisms no.s 27, 216 and 257 are all part of this same sermon. Additionally, he notes that the questioner who asked the Imām about this was ‘Ammār ibn Yāsir, according to what al-Ghazālī mentions in his *Iḥyā al-‘Ulūm* (4:60), whereas in his *al-Kāfī*, al-Kulaynī says it was Ibn al-Kawwā (2:49). He also states that these words have been related from the Imām multiple times, with and without chains of transmission, and among those who have related it, or part of it, before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī are: al-Ḥarrānī in *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, al-Kulaynī in *Uṣūl al-Kāfī*, Abū ‘Alī al-Qālī in *Dhayl al-Amālī*, Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī in *Qūt al-Qulūb*, Abū Na‘īm in *Ḥilyat al-Awliyā*, and al-Ṣadūq in *al-Khiṣāl*. He further suggests that by examining all these sources, it becomes evident that al-Raḍī only related an excerpt that he selected, and not the entire sermon. Interestingly, the questioner is said to have posed his question on one day, and the Imām gave his response on the following day, having instructed that he come back the next day so that other people may benefit from the answer as well. He also said that his reply is based on what had been taught to him by the Noble Prophet (ṣ) himself.

COMMENTARY

1 Commencing by praising Allāh for prescribing and legislating the religion of Islam, the Imām says He has made *its ways easy* for those who come to it. The phrase *fasahhala sharā’i’ahu* literally means making the pathways to the watering holes or pools easy and accessible, and here it connotes making the rules and ordinances of religion easy for the people to follow. Indeed, we are told: *He has not placed upon you any hardship in religion...* (Q22:78) (T). The analogy of a running stream, the pathways to which are easily accessible, is quite apt here, since just as the fresh water of a stream quenches the thirst and revitalizes the body, so too does the religion quench the thirst of the soul and revitalize it (MB). Some commentators suggest that the meaning of the *ways* of Islam being made easy is that its teachings and rulings have been clearly explained for the people, such that they can all understand it without difficulty (M). At the same time, the Imām says, it is a religion whose pillars have been fortified against anyone who seeks to conquer it. The meaning of *‘arkānahu* here, according to some commentators, is the fundamental beliefs (*uṣūl al-‘aqidah*) of the religion, namely belief in Allāh, in the Noble Messenger (ṣ), in the Day of Judgment, and all the corollaries of these (Z). Others consider the statement to generally mean that Islam is a like a lofty

fortress which cannot be conquered by forces of falsehood, since Allāh has strengthened it and protects it from the unbelievers who seek to undermine it. As the verse states: *...and Allāh will never provide the disbelievers any way [to prevail] over the believers* (Q4:141) (MB). The Imām then describes Islam as *a security for one who clings to it, a means of peace for one who enters it, a proof for one who speaks through it, a witness for one who litigates by it, and a light for one who seeks illumination from it*. Indeed Muslims are provided security and peace by their faith which preserves them from bloodshed (since Islam has forbidden the unlawful spilling of blood). Whoever enters the fold of Islam is considered a brother to the believers, and his life and property are sacrosanct. It acts as proof for those who speak through it or argue by it, because it contains strong evidence and manifest arguments for its veracity. This is also why it is a witness for one who litigates with it (*‘shāhidan li man khāṣama bihī’*) – whoever among the Muslims has a dispute with an adherent of any other faith will find in Islam that which would constitute a witness for him, as stated in the verse: *Is one who stands on clear proof from his Lord, followed up by a witness from Him...* (Q11:17) (MB). As for it being an illuminating light for the believers, there are many verses in the Qur’ān that state this fact (T).

Imām ‘Alī then mentions some more qualities of the religion of Islam, noting that it is a means of *comprehension for one who reflects*. Some commentators say that *comprehension* here means knowledge (Z), whereas others opine that reflecting on its teachings opens up the minds of believers to divine illumination and comprehension of the hidden truths of this universe (MB). It is likewise a means of *understanding for one who ponders, a sign for one who keenly observes, an insight for one who is determined, and a lesson for one who takes admonishment*. By mentioning these qualities of the religion the Imām tells us that Islam is a luminous light which invites people towards itself. Then, those who reflect and ponder upon it are granted comprehension and understanding of it. Finally, the keen observer and one who takes admonishment from it is able to arrive at the core of its truth and reality (N). The verb *‘tawassama’* is translated as *keenly observes*, and means one who scrutinizes and tries to see that which is hidden or not immediately apparent, to observe the reality of a thing (MB). The fact that it is *an insight for one who is determined* means that for the resolute who wish to advance by means of it, Islam provides insight and perception (T). It is for such believers, who have conviction and certitude (*‘man ṣaddaqa’*), that Islam is a

salvation, just as it is a *dependable support* for those who rely on it (*'man tawakkala'*), a *comfort* for those who entrust their affairs to the Almighty (*'man fawwada'*), and a *shield* for those who endure patiently (*'man ṣabara'*). Indeed, placing one's affairs in the hands of Allāh (*tafwīḍ al-umūr*) is one of the highest stages of faith (S). The Imām then describes Islam as *the brightest of paths and the clearest of all courses, with towering beacons, well-lit highways, and glowing lamps, with a thriving arena and a lofty goal*. Indeed, the path of Islam to the Truth is the clearest of all paths, and the safest and most secure. None of its teachings are ambiguous or vague, and it welcomes every seeker and aspirant alike. All people have access to the Book of Allāh and the Sunnah of His Prophet without any restrictions. The phrase *'karīm al-miḍmār'* is rendered *thriving arena*, and means that it outstrips and outshines the other religions with its tenets and laws, or that one who acts upon its teachings surpasses all others in his good deeds and virtuous conduct (Z). It is also a *lofty goal* (*'rafi' al-ghāyah'*) since the purpose of Islam is to elevate and bring its adherents closer to the Almighty (M).

The Imām then says that it is a *gathering of race horses, all vying for a valuable prize, with riders that are honourable*. The term *'al-ḥalbah'* refers to horses that are assembled from every quarter for a race (R), and the *riders* in this analogy are the believing Muslims (MB). Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn himself explains the meanings intended by some of these analogies saying, *belief is its path, virtue is its lamp-post, death is its culmination, this world is its racecourse, the Day of Judgement is its gathering point, and Paradise is its prize*. It is noteworthy that by *goal* (*'ghāyah'*) he means death, which is the end or culmination of life in this world. Perhaps that is because to attain one's otherworldly goal, one has to pass through the gate of death. The phrase *virtue is its lamp-post* (*'al-ṣāliḥātu manāruh'*) means that good deeds done in this world are like beacons of light which illuminate the way for a believer (MB). All in all, there are twenty-five qualities of Islam the Imām mentions in this section of the sermon, to describe the religion and answer the one who questioned him about it (M).

2 Regarding this section, al-Sayyid al-Raḍī says, "This pericope was quoted earlier. I have repeated it here because the two reports vary slightly in wording." The earlier narration he is referring to is sermon no. 71, which contains many similar phrases. In it the Imām mentions some of the lofty qualities of the Noble Messenger and then supplicates for him. The elided phrase at the beginning of this section can be evinced from what was mentioned in the earlier narration, and

would read something along the lines of: 'He carried out his duties faithfully... until he lit a torch for the seeker of light and illuminated a sign for the one who lost his way. We likewise understand from the previous mention of this phrase (in sermon no. 71) that the person being referred to is the Noble Prophet himself (N). The meaning intended here is that he illuminated the truth, and made it manifest for those seeking it (T). The term '*ḥābis*' refers to one who halts his camel because he does not know how to find his way to his destination. In this instance it is used metaphorically to refer to those who are held back by the darkness of confusion and doubt, for whom the Prophet then lit the way (MB). As for his being Allāh's *trusted emissary*, it means that he was trusted to convey what was revealed to him (Z). The phrase '*amīnuka al-mā'mūn*' actually connotes an emphasis on his attribute of trustworthiness (N), and indeed the Noble Messenger was so reliable that even among the barbaric, polytheistic Arabs of that time, he was known as al-Amīn (T). That he will be Allāh's witness on the Day of Resurrection is stated in the verse: *On the Day We raise in every nation a witness against them from among themselves, We shall bring you as a witness against these [people]* (Q16:89). Likewise, the fact that the Rasūlullāh was sent as a blessing and a mercy for the people is clearly mentioned in the verse that states: *And We did not send you but as a mercy to the worlds* (Q21:107) (M). Amīr al-Mu'mīnīn then supplicates for the Noble Messenger, asking Allāh to *grant him a generous share from His justice and award him manifold bounties from His grace*. By this the Imām is asking Allāh to grant the Prophet a bountiful reward as would be expected from His justice, for the tremendous work he did (MB). In a way, this supplication implies great esteem for the Noble Messenger because it shows that the Imām believes him to be deserving of such a blessing— that is why he asks Allāh by His justice (Z). And of course, being the Most Munificent, Allāh grants even more bounty than what is deserved, through His grace (*'faḍl'*).

As noted in the commentary of sermon no. 71, the supplication *elevate his edifice above all other built structures* means make his religion prevail over all other religions. Some suggest that it may also mean: make his mansions in Paradise and his station therein higher and greater than that of others, but the first meaning is more likely (N). Imām 'Alī then asks Allāh to honour the Prophet, to ennoble his position, to grant him proximity, and to bestow upon him prestige and eminence. The phrase '*ātihi al-wasīlah*' has been interpreted by some to mean 'grant him the right of intercession', but most commentators say that here, it actually refers to the

ALSO: ADDRESSING HIS COMPANIONS

- 3 You have attained, by the grace of Allāh the Most High, such a position that [even] your maidservants are honoured and your neighbours are treated well. You are revered [even] by the one over whom you neither enjoy any distinction [in terms of might] nor is he obliged to you [for any favour]. You are feared [even] by one who is not apprehensive of an attack from you and over whom you have no authority. You now see the covenants made with Allāh being broken yet feel no rage, while you disdain the breaking of the pacts of your forefathers! The ordinances of Allāh would come to you, and would issue forth from you [to the people] and then come back to you again; yet you have relinquished your position to the tyrants, given them control over your affairs, and handed over to them the [charge of ruling according to the] ordinances of Allāh. They, in turn, act upon the dubious and advance towards [their vain] desires. By Allāh, even if they disperse you under every star, Allāh will surely gather you on the day that shall be their worst.

ومنها في خطاب أصحابه

۳ وَقَدْ بَلَّغْتُمْ مِنْ كَرَامَةِ اللَّهِ تَعَالَى
لَكُمْ مَنْزِلَةً تُكْرَمُ بِهَا إِمَاؤُكُمْ،
وَتُوصَلُ بِهَا جِيرَانُكُمْ،
وَيُعْظَمُكُمْ مَنْ لَا فَضْلَ لَكُمْ
عَلَيْهِ، وَلَا يَدَ لَكُمْ عِنْدَهُ،
وَيَهَابُكُمْ مَنْ لَا يَخَافُ لَكُمْ
سَطْوَةً، وَلَا لَكُمْ عَلَيْهِ إِفْرَةٌ، وَقَدْ
تَرَوْنَ عَهْدَ اللَّهِ مَنقُوضَةً فَلَا
تَغْضَبُونَّ، وَأَنْتُمْ لِنَقْضِ ذِمِّ
آبَائِكُمْ تَأْتِفُونَ! وَكَانَتْ أُمُورُ
اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ تَرْدٌ، وَعَنْكُمْ تَضُدُّ،
وَإِلَيْكُمْ تَرْجِعُ، فَمَكَّنْتُمُ الظُّلْمَةَ
مِنْ مَنْزِلَتِكُمْ، وَالْقَيْتُمْ إِلَيْهِمْ
أَزْمَتَكُمْ، وَأَسْلَمْتُمْ أُمُورَ اللَّهِ فِي
أَيْدِيهِمْ، يَعْمَلُونَ بِالشُّبُهَاتِ
وَيَسِيرُونَ فِي الشَّهَوَاتِ. وَإِنَّمَا
اللَّهُ، لَوْ فَرَّقَ بَيْنَكُمْ تَحْتَ كُلِّ
كَوْكَبٍ لَجَمَعَكُمْ اللَّهُ لِيَوْمٍ
لَهُمْ.

highest station in Paradise, in the proximity of Allāh, the beauty of which has been described in some traditions (MB, R, N). Finally, in this *duʿā*, the Imām asks to be resurrected in the company of the Noble Prophet, *neither disgraced, nor regretful, nor deviated, nor having broken our oaths, nor having strayed, nor having misled*

others, nor enticed by vain desires. The disgrace results from sinning against Allāh, the regret from transgressing the limits set by Allāh, and the deviation from straying away from the path of Allāh (MB). One commentator remarks that none of the Prophet's Companions praised him and prayed for him after his death as passionately as Imām 'Alī did, just as no one aided and served the Prophet during his lifetime as sincerely as Imām 'Alī and his family (I).

3 In this third part of the oration, Amīr al-Mu'minīn addresses his companions. According to some commentators, he particularly speaks to those of them who surrendered their towns and villages to the armies of Mu'āwiyah that would frequently carry out raids on the areas controlled by the Imām's governors, such as al-Anbār, etc. (MB). He begins by reminding them of their honourable station, which they have attained by the grace of Allāh through Islam, such that even their *maidservants are honoured* and their *neighbours are treated well*. The term '*jirān*' also includes those who have taken refuge with them and sought their patronage through covenants, by accepting the protected status of *dhimmī* (I). To emphasize their noble position further, the Imām tells them *you are revered even by the one over whom you neither enjoy any distinction* in terms of might, *nor is he obligated to you* for any favour. *You are feared even by one who is not apprehensive of an attack from you and over whom you have no authority*. Indeed, even the empires of Rome and Ḥabashah would revere them, and they were held in awe even by the distant kingdoms of India and China, who did not fear any attack from them (T). A beautiful tradition states, "Whoever fears Allāh, Allāh will make all others fear him. But whoever has no fear of Allāh, Allāh will make him fear everything!" (N). Having mentioned this great blessing of Allāh upon them, the Imām rebukes them for falling short in carrying out their obligations and fulfilling the right of Allāh. He mentions some of the ways that they showed ingratitude for the blessing of Allāh, telling them that even as they *see the covenants made with Allāh being broken* they *feel no rage*. On the other hand, they disdain the breaking of the pacts of their forefathers! By this the Imām meant that when they saw the Syrians and others like them carrying out wrongs and going against the laws and commandments of Allāh, by rebelling against the just Imām and raiding Muslim lands, they expressed no anger or disapproval. Instead, they preferred to remain silent in the face of that which they had the power to repel and fight off through armed struggle (MB). Some commentators say that there is a rhetorical question elided here, and the Imām means to ask them how they can remain calm and not get angry when the

covenants of Allāh are broken while they get enraged when the same thing happens with their ancestral pacts and agreements. By comparing this attitude to how they feel when any of the pledges of their ancestors are infringed, the Imām was highlighting their hypocrisy (T). When he says *the ordinances of Allāh would come to you, and would issue forth from you and then come back to you again*, the Imām means that the *sharī'ah* came to them from the Noble Prophet, and they took it from him, and then taught it to other people. Subsequently, the people would refer to them to ask questions about it and allay their doubts. Or the people they taught would return that knowledge back to them by teaching it to their children and grandchildren (Z). Alternatively, this statement means that the primary addressees of the ordinances of Allāh were the Muslims who lived at the time of the Noble Messenger, and what issued forth from them were questions, as they asked the Prophet for clarification regarding the ordinances. Finally, by receiving an authoritative response, the ordinances came back to them, or the benefit thereof returned to them (MB). Other commentators suggest that what the Imām is referring to here is the leadership (*ḥukūmah*), not the laws (*aḥkām*), given the context of his discourse. The statement thus means that the ruling authority was in your hands, then it went forth to others (who were only Muslims in name, and did not really care for its laws) , and finally it will return back to you (N).

Despite these great blessings, the Imām upbraids them for having *relinquished your position to the tyrants, given them control over your affairs, and handed over to them the ordinances of Allāh*. After all that the Noble Prophet did for them, and how he elevated them to a position that made them revered and feared by friend and foe, they allowed their leadership to fall in the hands of tyrants, giving them control and authority over their affairs, as well as the responsibility of ruling according to the commandments of Allāh. This happened due to their negligence, lassitude, and weakness (Z). These tyrants were the same people who would *act upon the dubious and advance towards their vain desires*. This was in stark contrast to the days of the Noble Prophet, when only the most righteous were tasked with such responsibility, and that is how Islam spread to different reaches of the land. Now the worst individuals, known for their prejudice and hypocrisy, had taken over the reins of leadership – the likes of the children of Abū Sufyān (N). The phrase '*ya'malūna bi al-shubuhāt*' means that they would commit unlawful acts when there was any assumed justification that could be used to render it permissible, and they would distort and misinterpret ordinances to this end. In

this way, they rushed towards their desires, not being hindered by any ruling or religious injunction (Z). In conclusion, the Imām promises the people that even if they get dispersed *under every star*, Allāh will surely gather them all *on the day that shall be their worst*. The figurative description of being scattered under every star is meant to convey a complete dispersal, far and wide, such that they could not possibly unite. Most commentators deem this to be in reference to how the Banī Umayyah would fall, and face retribution and a terrible fate at the hands of the Iraqis and the Banū ‘Abbās. Others opine that it may be referring to the time when Imām al-Mahdī will rise up, but this interpretation seems unlikely here as it does not match the context of the sermon (N).



ON ONE OF THE DAYS OF SIFFĪN

1 I have seen your flight and your absconding from the ranks. You were driven back by barbarous mobs and the bedouins of Shām, while you are the foremost of the Arabs and centres of nobility, possessors of dignity and loftiness. Yet the sighs of my heart subsided only when I saw you finally driving them back as they drove you back and dislodging them from their positions as they had dislodged you, striking them with blades and piercing them with spears. [As a result,] their vanguard fell upon their rearguard, just like thirsty camels that are turned and herded away from their watering troughs and prevented from their waterholes.

١ وَقَدْ رَأَيْتُ جَوْلَتَكُمْ وَأَنْحَيَارَكُمْ
عَنْ صُفُوفِكُمْ، تَحَوُّزُكُمْ الْجُفَاءُ
الطَّغَامُ وَأَغْرَابُ أَهْلِ الشَّامِ، وَأَنْتُمْ
لِهَامِيمِ الْعَرَبِ وَيَافِيخِ الشَّرَفِ،
وَالْأَنْفُ الْمُقَدَّمِ وَالسَّنَامُ الْأَعْظَمُ؛
وَلَقَدْ شَفَى وَحَاوَحَ صَدْرِي أَنْ
رَأَيْتُكُمْ بِأَخْزَةٍ تَحَوُّزُونَهُمْ كَمَا
حَاوُّوَكُمْ، وَتُزِيلُونَهُمْ عَنْ مَوَاقِفِهِمْ
كَمَا أَزَالُوكُمْ، حَسًّا بِالنَّصَالِ وَشَجْرًا
بِالرَّمَاكِ، تَزْكَبُ أَوْلَاهُمْ أُخْرَاهُمْ
كَالْإِبِلِ الْهِيمِ الْمَطْرُودَةِ، تُزْمَى عَنْ
حِيَاضِهَا وَتَذَادُ عَنْ مَوَارِدِهَا.

CONTEXT

This is an excerpt of a sermon that the Imām gave during the early days of the Battle of Şiffin, as his followers had shown reluctance to fight and sought to fall back before later returning to fight and gaining victory over the enemy. In his speech the Imām uses a soft tone to reproach them for fleeing, but then follows it up with praise for how they regrouped and came back with force to overcome the enemy. Thus, he encourages them while at the same time drawing their attention to the weak points that they need to correct (N). According to some narrations, on one of the days of battle, the right flank of the Imām's army were routed by the Syrians, then they regrouped and came back to fight, launching a daring assault on the enemy. That was the event that this speech was referring to (Z). It is said that

the soldiers then joined up with Mālik al-Ashtar who subsequently pounced on the enemy ranks with them until they scattered (MB). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* notes that this sermon was related by al-Ṭabarī in his *Tārīkh*, al-Kulaynī in *Furūʿ al-Kāfī*, and Naṣr ibn Muzāḥim in his *Waqʿat Šifīn*. Ibn Athīr has also discussed some of the difficult words and phrases of this oration in his *al-Nihāyah*. In *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah*, a longer version of this sermon has been mentioned, and a portion of sermon no. 124 of the *Nahj* has also been appended thereto as the author considers it to be part of the same sermon.

COMMENTARY

1 The phrase *‘inḥiyāzikum ‘an šufūfikum’* is rendered *your absconding from the ranks* and refers to how they turned away from their battle lines and fell back, or left their positions (R). It was a subtle way of referring to their flight from battle, and the Imām did not want to use the term ‘fled’ because of its highly negative connotation. Thus he used a more acceptable way of depicting their action using words that do not cause them distress (S, I). Indeed, fleeing from battle is considered so abhorrent that the jurists say it deserves a big penalty and painful punishment – except if one flees from his position to a more advantageous one to fight from, or to join another contingent that requires assistance. This is what has been stated in the verse: *O you who believe! When you encounter the disbelieves advancing [for battle], do not turn your backs to them. And whoever turns his back to them that day – unless as a stratagem for battle or to withdraw to another company – has indeed earned the wrath of Allāh, and his refuge is Hell, and [what] a wretched destination [it is]!* (Q8:15-16) (Z). Those who overpowered them and pushed them back are described as *barbarous mobs* (*‘al-jufāt al-ṣaghām’*) and the lowly bedouins of Syria. This description is used to contrast their honourable position with the ignoble status of their enemy (M). That is why he subsequently refers to them as the *foremost of the Arabs and centres of nobility, possessors of dignity and loftiness*. The term *‘lahāmīm’* is the plural of *luhmūm*, which refers to a noble steed (R), and here it means that they are the most eminent among the Arabs (MB). *‘Yāʿāfikh’* is the plural of *yāfūkh* and literally means the top of the head, or the part where the anterior and posterior bones of the head meet, or the point at which the head of an infant is soft and moves (T), only to later become hard and rigid. Here is used figuratively to refer to the summit of nobility, or its centre (N). *‘Anfal-muqaddam’*

means the bridge of the nose, or its foremost part, and in this instance it signifies eminence and dignity, just as the next phrase '*sanām al-a'ẓam*' figuratively connotes loftiness, even though its literal meaning is the highest part of the camels' hump (MB). Some commentators take the contrasting between the lowliness of their assailants and their own nobility to be a form of rebuke – as if to say, 'how could people as honourable and brave as yourselves be routed by a band of rabble lowlifes and flee from them?!' (Z). Indeed, it was clear that of the two sides in the Battle of Şiffin, one was comprised of Companions, the children of Companions, and eminent members of the society, while the other was made up of the remnants of the Age of Ignorance and the lowlife rabble who knew nothing of religion and were only after worldly gains (N).

Imām 'Alī then describes his own feelings as he witnessed this spectacle, saying that the sighs of his heart ('*waḥāwiḥa ṣadri*') only subsided when he saw them return and drive back the enemy as they had been driven back, and dislodging them from their positions as they had been dislodged, *striking them with blades and piercing them with spears*. Hence, we note that the Imām was initially pained by the way his forces were overcome by the enemy, but this pain and distress subsided when he saw his troops rally back and dislodge the enemy, fighting valiantly and striking them with their weapons (MB). He describes the way the enemy were overcome and driven away using an analogy of *thirsty camels that are turned and herded away from their watering troughs and prevented from their waterholes*. In such instances, the fear felt by the camels is so intense that it overpowers their thirst and they rush forward, falling on each other (M). In the same way, the enemy were overwhelmed by fright so they turned and fled with great speed, without caring about anything (Z). And they likewise fell upon each other in the process of fleeing (MB).



ONE OF THE SERMONS ON FUTURE TRIBULATIONS

ALLĀH THE EXALTED

الله تعالى

- 1 All praise belongs to Allāh, who is manifested before His creation by His [act of] creation, and is apparent to their hearts by His clear proof. He created all of creation without any deliberation, as deliberation does not apply except to those who possess [limited] minds, while He has no such mind. His knowledge penetrates the innermost veils of the unseen and encompasses the labyrinth of hidden beliefs.

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الْمُتَجَلِّي لِخَلْقِهِ بِخَلْقِهِ، وَالظَّاهِرِ لِقُلُوبِهِمْ بِحُجَّتِهِ، خَلَقَ الْخُلُقَ مِنْ غَيْرِ رَوِيَّةٍ، إِذْ كَانَتْ الرُّوِّيَّاتُ لَا تَلِيْقُ إِلَّا بِدَوِي الضَّمَائِرِ، وَلَيْسَ بِذِي ضَمِيرٍ فِي نَفْسِهِ، خَرَقَ عِلْمُهُ بَاطِنَ غَيْبِ السُّتُورَاتِ، وَأَحَاطَ بِغُمُوضِ عَقَائِدِ السَّرِيرَاتِ.

ALSO: ABOUT THE PROPHET (ﷺ)

وَمِنْهَا فِي ذِكْرِ النَّبِيِّ ﷺ

- 2 He chose him from the [lineal] tree of the Prophets, the illuminated niche, the forelock of eminence, the centre of al-Baḥḥā', the lamps for [illuminating] darkness, and [from] the sources of wisdom.

٢ اخْتَارَهُ مِنْ شَجَرَةِ الْأَنْبِيَاءِ، وَمَشْكَاةِ الضُّيَاءِ، وَذُؤَابَةِ الْعِلْيَاءِ، وَسُرَّةِ الْبُطْحَاءِ، وَمَصَابِيحِ الظُّلْمَةِ، وَيَنَابِيعِ الْحِكْمَةِ.

CONTEXT

This is a sermon that the author says is about great future events and calamities (*al-malāḥim*), because it contains some information regarding what would transpire during the Final Days, in the second half of the oration (T). The first half of the sermon contains three themes, beginning with praise and glorification of Allāh, followed by the greatness of the Noble Messenger and his precedence over all the other Prophets. Finally, the Imām hints at some of his own

positive attributes and offers a rebuke of the ignorant among the people who are heedless of his status and do not benefit from his presence (MB). Though there is no record of exactly when or where he gave this sermon, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places part of the oration within a longer sermon that Imām ‘Alī delivered in Kūfah a few days prior to his martyrdom (4:657). Al-Zamakhsharī has quoted parts of this sermon in his *Rabī‘ al-Abrār*, and al-Āmidī has also quoted two different sections thereof in *Ghurur al-Ḥikam wa Durar al-Kalim*, with slight variance in wording. Due to this variance, some scholars have opined that the source used by al-Āmidī was different from that of al-Raḍī’s *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N).

COMMENTARY

1 At the outset, the Imām praises Allāh for five things, namely [i] by His act of creation, He manifest Himself to His creation; [ii] by His clear proofs, He is apparent to the hearts of the people; [iii] His creation of everything required no deliberation or planning; [iv] His knowledge penetrates even the innermost curtains of the Unseen; [v] He encompasses even the most complex web of thoughts and feelings of His creatures (M). The fact that everything in creation is a manifestation of the Creator, or a means by which it may be known that a Creator exists, is known as *burhān al-naẓm* in Islamic philosophy. It is a reality that appears in numerous verses of the Qur’ān where people are urged to reflect upon various aspects of the creation to come to the obvious realization that something so beautiful and perfect could not have come about on its own, and must therefore have a Creator. We thus understand that in the phrase ‘*al-mutajallī li khalqihī bi khalqihī*’, the first instance of *khalqihī* refers to human beings, while the second refers to all of creation (N). As for His being *apparent to their hearts by His clear proof* it is because Allāh’s existence is known by every human heart, except that some hearts have been overcome by doubts resulting from blind following or incorrect assumptions, and the like (Z). That is why, by a little unbiased reflection, a person can quickly realize that there is indeed a Lord and Creator (M). This has been termed *burhān al-fiṭrah*, and it is hard-coded within every individual, such that if a person were to ponder about his creation, he would come to the undoubted realization that God exists (N). When the Imām says that no deliberation was required for Allāh to create the universe, he explains that this is because *deliberation does not apply except to those who possess limited minds, while*

He has no such mind. The fact that no planning, reflection, or deliberation is needed by the Almighty has been mentioned by the Imām in other instances as well, including in the first sermon (T). *His knowledge penetrates the innermost veils of the unseen* since His knowledge is unlimited and unrestricted. It penetrates right to the core of every thing, and He knows even the hidden thoughts, feelings, and beliefs of His creatures (N). Furthermore, His knowledge *encompasses the labyrinth of hidden beliefs* that are stored in the innermost recesses of peoples' hearts. Indeed, the Prophet was commanded to tell the people: *Whether you hide what is in your hearts, or disclose it, Allāh knows it...* (Q3:29). And in another verse we are told: *And if you speak aloud, then [it makes no difference, for] indeed He knows the secret, and what is even more hidden* (Q20:7). We have already discussed the detailed meaning of this in our commentary on sermon no. 85.

2 In this section, Amīr al-Mu'minīn mentions some of the qualities of the beloved Messenger of Allāh (ṣ). He employs six expressions to describe the Noble Messenger, saying that he was chosen from [i] *the lineal tree of the Prophets*; [ii] *the illuminated niche*; [iii] *the forelock of eminence*; [iv] *the centre of al-Baṭḥā*; [v] *the lamps for illuminating darkness*; and [vi] *the sources of wisdom*. Each of these six expressions points to one of the merits and virtues of the Noble Prophet (N). Being from the lineal tree of the Prophets ('*shajarat al-anbiyā*') is a reminder that he was from the lineage of Prophet Ibrāhīm ('a) (I). And according to Ibn 'Abbās, the verse: *and your movement among those who prostrate* (Q26:219) is interpreted to mean passing from the loins of Prophet to Prophet, until he too was born a Prophet (T). Some have interpreted *illuminated niche* ('*mishkāṭ al-ḍiyā*') as a metaphorical reference to the family of Ibrāhīm, because it is from his progeny that many of the Prophets were chosen, and the light of prophethood and guidance shone among them, just as light shines from a lamp in a niche (M). The term *mishkāṭ* also refers to the thing in which the wick of a lamp is placed. As such, some understand this phrase to mean that he was the preserver and carrier of the light of divine guidance and knowledge (N). The phrase '*dhu'ābat al-'alyā*', which is rendered as *the forelock of eminence*, is understood to be a metaphor for purity and refinement (T). Some have interpreted it as referring to Quraysh, since they were the most eminent tribe among the Arabs at that time (M). '*Surraṭ al-Baṭḥā*' is translated as *the centre of al-Baṭḥā*, since *surrah* means navel or middle point. Here, it figuratively connotes the best of Makkans (R), and this is a merit given the important position of Makkah as a sanctified place (Z). '*Maṣābiḥ al-ẓulmah*' and '*yanābīṭ al-ḥikmah*' both refer to the

PART OF THE SAME SERMON

وَمِنْهَا

3 [He was like] a roaming physician who had prepared his ointments and heated his instruments, using them when the need arises, for [remedying] blind hearts, deaf ears, and dumb tongues. With his medicines in hand, he sought out the places where negligence was rampant and confusion prevailed. [Yet] they did not take illumination from the radiance of [his] wisdom and did not kindle a flame from the flint of [his] brilliant knowledge. So in this they were just like grazing livestock and hard rocks.

٣ طَيْبٌ دَوَّارٌ بِطِبِّهِ، قَدْ أَحْكَمَ
مَرَاهِمَهُ وَأَحْمَى مَوَاسِمَهُ، يَضَعُ
ذَلِكَ حَيْثُ الْحَاجَةُ إِلَيْهِ، مِنْ قُلُوبٍ
عُمِيٍّ، وَأَذَانٍ صُمٍّ، وَاللِّسَنَةِ بُكْمٍ؛
مُتَّبِعٌ بِدَوَائِهِ مَوَاضِعَ الْغَفْلَةِ وَمَوَاطِنَ
الْحَيْرَةِ، لَمْ يَسْتَضِيئُوا بِأَضْوَاءِ
الْحِكْمَةِ، وَلَمْ يَقْدَحُوا بِزِنَادِ الْعُلُومِ
النَّاقِبَةِ، فَهُمْ فِي ذَلِكَ كَالْأَنْعَامِ
السَّائِمَةِ وَالصُّخُورِ الْقَاسِيَةِ.

4 Now the hidden realities have become clear for the people of insight, the path of truth has become evident for the wanderer, the Hour has unveiled its face and its sign has become apparent for the one who recognizes it. Why is it that I see you as bodies bereft of souls and as souls without bodies, as devotees without virtue, as traders without profits, as wakeful sleepers, as present absentees, as blind seers, as deaf listeners, and as dumb speakers!

٤ قَدْ انْجَابَتِ السَّرَائِرُ لِأَهْلِ الْبَصَائِرِ،
وَوَضَحَتْ مَحَجَّةُ الْحَقِّ لِخَاطِبِهَا،
وَأُسْفَرَتِ السَّاعَةُ عَنْ وَجْهِهَا،
وَظَهَرَتِ الْعَلَامَةُ لِمُتَوَسِّمِهَا. مَا لِي
أَرَاكُمْ أَشْبَاحًا بِلَا أَرْوَاحٍ، وَأَرْوَاحًا
بِلَا أَشْبَاحٍ، وَتُسَاكًا بِلَا صَلَاحٍ،
وَتُجَارًا بِلَا أَرْبَاحٍ، وَأَيْقَاطًا تَوَمًّا،
وَشُهُودًا غُيًّا، وَنَاطِرَةً عُمِيًّا،
وَسَامِعَةً صَمًّا، وَنَاطِقَةً بَكْمًا!

Prophets and Messengers, as they were like lamps that illuminated the darkness of ignorance, thereby dispelling it, and like wellsprings from which wisdom flowed to the people so that they could be guided aright thereby (MB).

3 The Imām then presents an interesting analogy in which he describes the Noble Messenger as *a roaming physician who had prepared his ointments and heated*

his instruments, using them when the need arises, for remedying blind hearts, deaf ears, and dumb tongues. The Prophet was a spiritual physician, curing the hearts and minds of the people and eradicating the sickness of ignorance and bad character (M). The fact that he was *a roaming physician* (*‘ṭabībun dawwārūn bi ṭibbīh’*) meant that he carried his medicine from place to place, going out to look for the sick instead of waiting for the sick to come to him, as is the wont of most doctors. His spiritual cures and remedies were in the form of advice and guidance, which he gave verbally to those whom he met, and by way of messages to those who were far away (T). Some consider the fact that he was described as *roaming* or moving from place to place to connote his greater skill and expertise, as one who moves about healing people gains greater experience and becomes more adept and proficient (MB). While it seems evident that this was a description of the Noble Prophet, many commentators say that the Imām was talking about himself here (Z, MB, T, M). One commentator expresses his astonishment at how the others did not even present it as a possibility that the Imām was talking about the Noble Prophet, while the context as well as content of what he says clearly refers to Rasūlullāh (N). The term *‘marāhim’* is plural of *marham*, which is the medicine and ointment that is placed on wounds to heal them (T). *‘Mawāsīm’* is plural of *mīsam*, which refers to the instrument that is used to cauterize open wounds (R). The two terms have been interpreted by some to refer to words of advice and warnings of painful punishment for disobedience, respectively (Z). Alternatively, they refer to the two messages brought to the people by the Prophet: one of glad tidings (*bashārah*) and the other of warning (*indhār*), for indeed the Messenger was both *bashīr* and *nadhīr* (N). He used these methods to cure the *blind hearts* and give them back their vision by preparing them to receive the light of guidance. He likewise remedied the *deaf ears* by restoring their ability to hear and accept good counsel, and the *dumb tongues* by preparing them to speak the truth (MB).

With his medicines in hand, he sought out the places where negligence was rampant and confusion prevailed. These places were actually figurative representations of ignorant hearts and minds (M). Some commentators link this to the subsequent phrase which states *they did not take illumination from the radiance of his wisdom*, and interpret it as the description of those misguided and ignorant people who were alluded to figuratively as *places where negligence was rampant and confusion prevailed* (N, Z). However, other commentators opine that there seems to be something elided between the two sentences, since they do not seem

directly linked (T). It is quite possible that the Imām is referring to two separate groups here, because negligence and confusion are two distinct things. The first is where one is unaware of the dangers that may befall him, whereas the second is where one is aware of the perils in front of him, but is perplexed and does not know how to avoid them (N). His statement *they did not take illumination from the radiance of his wisdom* means that they did not acquire anything from his wise teachings and lofty character, and *did not kindle a flame from the flint of his brilliant knowledge* means that they did not derive from his great knowledge the benefit they could have gotten (MB). And thus they were comparable to *grazing livestock and hard rocks*. The adjective ‘*al-sā’imah*’ is used for cattle that is left to graze on its own, untended (T). These descriptions apply to them because of the way they followed their base inclinations like animals, and were hard-hearted to the point that no words of advice penetrated their hearts (M). Indeed, the Qur’ān also uses this analogy when it states: *Then your hearts hardened after that; so they are like stones, or even harder...* (Q2:74) (MB).

4 Imām ‘Alī says that now *the hidden realities have become clear for the people of insight*, meaning that what the enemies of truth had concealed in their hearts about their intention to work towards the destruction of the religion of Allāh has become manifest (MB), and *the path of truth has become evident for the wanderer*, such that the truth is clearly distinguishable from falsehood, and no excuse remains for anyone who does not follow it (Z). The term ‘*khābiṭ*’ refers to one who stumbles in the dark, like a camel with weak eyesight that strikes the earth as it moves and is not protected from what could harm it (T). Some have suggested that the first phrase refers to what would happen after him, such as the future tyranny of Banū Umayyah, of which the people of insight had become aware. And the second phrase concerns the clarification of religious laws and duties (M). He then says that for those who can recognize it, *the Hour has unveiled its face and its sign has become apparent*. Perhaps the *sign* here refers to the coming of the Final Messenger, and the discord and strife that would later follow among the Muslims. Alternatively, it may simply be a warning that the Day of Resurrection is near (MB). Though over a thousand years have since passed, it does not negate this possibility because in comparison to the length of the world’s existence, this is a short span of time (N). Others suggest that *the Hour* here could refer to the time of one’s death, because it usually refers to Judgment, and the traditions tell us, “Verily one who dies, his Judgment starts forthwith” (Z). Imām ‘Alī then asks a rhetorical

question in which he gives a number of interesting analogies to describe the people. *Why is it that I see you as bodies bereft of souls and as souls without bodies* could mean that they are individuals with outward physical strength but without inward mental aptitude and spiritual fortitude. Or the opposite: they are able to reflect and deliberate, but lack the ability to practically carry out what they think of. It is clear that both these groups can never get anywhere (N). *Bodies bereft of souls* are like non-living things (*jamādāt*) in that they cannot benefit from the intellect or from admonition. This was also why they fell short in what was expected of them when it came to *jihād* and fighting the enemy. The phrase *souls without bodies* may refer to their frivolity and lack of seriousness, or lack of physical strength in countering the enemy in battle (MB).

The phrase '*nussākan bilā ṣalāh*' is rendered *devotees without virtue* and depicts them as ascetics without piety, or worshippers without sincerity (R). This is because they only practice religion as ritual, performing it outwardly, without seeking to please the Almighty or gain proximity to Him (Z). They were *traders without profits* because their deeds would be void, since they do not act sincerely for the sake of Allāh, so they will gain no reward for them (T). The five subsequent descriptions are oxymorons in which incongruous and contradictory terms are combined. The Imām says that they are *wakeful sleepers, present absentees, blind seers, deaf listeners, and dumb speakers*. This generally means that they were apparently awake and present, having eyes, ears, and tongues, but since they did not show any reaction to the events that were unfolding, and did not take any active steps, it was as though they were asleep, absent, blind, deaf, and dumb (N). Some commentators take these statements to generally mean that they were not ready to accept admonition, or take the good advice they were given. They did not pay heed or take lesson from what they witnessed around them, and were thus as the Qur'ān states: *...deaf, dumb, and blind, they do not apply reason* (Q2:171) (MB, Z).

5 Amīr al-Mu'minīn then talks about the future, and says that he can see *the banner of misguidance raised on its pole and dispersed with its offshoots*. This is considered to be an allusion to the End Times (I), as noted from the title of the sermon. It is specifically about the rise of the Sufyānī, the Yamānī, and the Khurāsānī, which will all take place in the same year, according to the traditions, as well as other events during the Last Days (T). However, some have suggested that *the banner of misguidance* was that of Mu'āwiyah and the Banī Umayyah (R).

5 [I see] the banner of misguidance raised on its pole and [its deviation] dispersed with its offshoots. It weighs you down with its weights and strikes you with its arms. Its leader has left the religion and persists in misguidance. So on that day, none from among you will remain except as the sediment at the bottom of a cooking pot, or like the dust that falls from shaking a sack. It will scour you as leather is scoured, and will thrash you as harvested wheat is thrashed. And it will pick out the believer amongst you just as a bird selects the large grain from among the fine grains.

6 Where are the pathways taking you, [why is] the darkness misleading you, and [why are] falsehoods deceiving you? Whence are you assailed and how are you deluded? For every term there is a written appointment and for every absence there is a return. So listen to your godly leader and keep your hearts attentive towards him, and if he calls out to you, rise up. The scout must tell his people the truth, he must gather his wits about him and maintain his presence of mind. He has indeed split open the matter for you just as the beads are split, and scraped it just as the gum is scraped [from the bark of a tree]. When this happens, falsehood will take its position and ignorance will climb on its mounts. Tyranny will increase while the callers

٥ رَايَةُ ضَلَالٍ قَدْ قَامَتْ عَلَى قُطْبِهَا
وَتَفَرَّقَتْ بِشُعَيْهَا، تَكِيلُكُمْ بِصَاعِهَا،
وَتَحْطِطُكُمْ بِبَاعِهَا. قَائِدُهَا خَارِجٌ مِنَ
الْمِلَّةِ قَائِمٌ عَلَى الضَّلَّةِ؛ فَلَا يَبْقَى
يَوْمَئِذٍ مِنْكُمْ إِلَّا نُفَالُهُ كَنُفَالَةِ الْقِدْرِ،
أَوْ نُفَاضَةُ كَنُفَاضَةِ الْعِجَمِ، تَغْرُكُكُمْ
عَزَكُ الْأَدِيمِ، وَتَدُوشُكُمْ دُوشَ
الْحَصِيدِ، وَتَسْتَخْلِصُ الْمُؤْمِنَ مِنَ
يَتْنِكُمْ اسْتِخْلَاصَ الطَّيْرِ الْحَبَّةَ
الْبَطِيئَةَ مِنْ بَيْنِ هَزِيلِ الْحَبِّ.

٦ أَيْنَ تَذْهَبُ بِكُمْ الْمَذَاهِبُ،
وَتَتِيَهُ بِكُمْ الْغَيَاهِبُ، وَتَحْدَعُكُمْ
الْكُوَاذِبُ؟ وَمِنْ أَيْنَ تُؤْتُونَ
وَأَنَّى تُؤْفَكُونَ؟ فَلِكُلِّ أَجَلٍ
كِتَابٌ، وَلِكُلِّ غَيْبَةٍ إِيَابٌ،
فَاسْتَمِعُوا مِنْ رَبِّائِكُمْ،
وَأَحْضِرُوا قُلُوبَكُمْ، وَاسْتَيْقِظُوا
إِنْ هَتَفَ بِكُمْ، وَلْيُصَدِّقْ رَائِدُ
أَهْلِهِ، وَلْيَجْمَعْ شَمْلَهُ، وَلْيَحْضِرْ
ذِهْنَهُ، فَلَقَدْ فَلَقَ لَكُمْ الْأَمْرَ فَلَقَ
الْخَرَزَةَ، وَقَرَفَهُ قَرْفَ الصَّمْغَةِ.
فَعِنْدَ ذَلِكَ أَخَذَ الْبَاطِلُ مَا خَذَهُ،
وَرَكِبَ الْجَهْلُ مَرَائِيَهُ،

[towards truth] will be few. Time will leap just as a rapacious beast pounces [upon its prey] and the bull camel of falsehood will begin to rumble after having been calm. People will become brothers in wickedness yet will desert one another due to religion. They will love each other based on lies but bear mutual hatred for one another in matters of truth.

وَعَظُمَتِ الطَّاعِيَةُ، وَقَلَّتِ
الدَّاعِيَةُ، وَصَالَ الدَّهْرُ صِيَالًا
السَّبْعِ الْعُقُورِ، وَهَدَرَ فَيَقُ
الْبَاطِلِ بَعْدَ كُظُومٍ، وَتَوَاحَى
النَّاسُ عَلَى الْفُجُورِ، وَتَهَاجَرُوا
عَلَى الدِّينِ، وَتَحَابُّوا عَلَى
الْكَذِبِ، وَتَبَاغَضُوا عَلَى
الصُّدُقِ.

- 7 So when this happens, the child will be [considered] an annoyance, rain will cause sweltering heat, the wicked will abound, and the virtuous will diminish. The people of that time will be wolves, its rulers will be wild beasts, its common folk will be gluttons, and its poor will be [as good as] dead. Truth will sink into the ground while lies will overflow, affection will be claimed by the tongues yet people will be at odds in the hearts. Immorality will be the basis of kinship while chastity will be surprising, and Islam will be worn like the furry garment, inside out.

فَإِذَا كَانَ ذَلِكَ كَانَ الْوَلَدُ غَيْظًا،
وَالْمَطَرُ قَيْظًا، وَتَفِيضُ اللَّئَامِ فَيْضًا،
وَتَغْيِضُ الْكَرَامِ غَيْضًا، وَكَانَ أَهْلُ
ذَلِكَ الزَّمَانِ ذُنَابًا، وَسَلَاطِينُهُ سِبَاعًا،
وَأَوْسَاطُهُ أَكْالًا، وَفُقَرَاؤُهُ أَمْوَاتًا،
وَعَارَ الصُّدُقُ وَقَاضَ الْكَذِبُ،
وَاسْتُعْمِلَتِ الْمَوَدَّةُ بِاللِّسَانِ وَتَسَاجَرَ
النَّاسُ بِالْقُلُوبِ، وَصَارَ الْفُسُوقُ نَسَبًا
وَالْعَقَافُ عَجَبًا، وَلَبِسَ الْإِسْلَامُ
لِبَسَ الْفُرِّ مَقْلُوبًا.

The phrase '*qad qāmat 'alā quṭbihā*' means that the banner has been entrenched in the ground and raised upright on its pole, and this is a metaphor for its being organized and established (MB). Alternatively, it refers to how the banner leads the way for the misguided (Z), and its being fixed and raised high means that it will not easily be dislodged (N). The dispersion of this misguidance *with its offshoots* refers to its spreading in the lands, and giving rise to other forms of corruption; and this deviation is likened to the branches and offshoots of a tree

that spread forth from it (MB). Some commentators say that this spreading is not of the banner itself, but of those who assist it and follow it, so the adjunct has been elided here, and it means that the misguided people will disperse in different places (I). Others say it is the banner itself whose streamers will spread out, thereby spreading the corruption of deviation everywhere (Z). In any case, the phrase connotes the dissemination of misguidance throughout the lands. '*Takīlukum bi šā'ihā*' literally means weighing you with its weights, or measuring you with its yardstick, but we have rendered it as *it weighs you down with its weights* because its connotation is that it will treat them as it wishes (T), and *kayl* here is a metaphor for hardship and difficulty (Z). Some commentators take the literal meaning, however, and say this phrase implies that the systems of misguidance which are established at that time will gauge everyone by their own criteria, and whoever does not meet their standards or follow their ways will be alienated and isolated. In this way, they will take control of all the people and then do with them as they will (N). It has been suggested that from the tense of the phrase, we can deduce that the Imām is talking about a future event. Perhaps the verb *takīlukum* means that the people will be dealt with in groups, just as weights are measured together, or that they will be toyed around with and those in authority over them will interfere in their affairs, just as one who weighs something adds and removes portions of it to arrive at the measurement he wants (MB). Similarly, it *strikes you with its arms* like one who strikes the leaves of a tree with his staff, or the camel that strikes the ground with its feet. In either case, it connotes abasement and subjugation, and using arms instead of hands only emphasizes the might of those who will subjugate them (MB).

The Imām then speaks about the leader of that tyrannical establishment, describing him as someone who *has left the religion and persists in misguidance*. This could be a reference to Mu'āwiyah and the rulers from Banī Umayyah (N), or to End Times figures such as the Sufyānī (T). It means that though the individual may outwardly pray, fast, and perform other religious rituals, he will not be a true Muslim and will actively work to spread misguidance, without fear of the Almighty or His wrath (Z). That will be the time when none of the believers remain, *except as the sediment at the bottom of a cooking pot, or like the dust that falls from shaking a sack*. The phrase '*thufālat al-qidr*' refers to what settles at the bottom of a pot (T), and '*nufādat al-ikm*' refers to that which falls off from a sack when it is shaken, be it small particles of dust, crumbs, or the like. This means the believers will be very

few and insignificant at that time, because the oppressors will not leave any eminent believer secure (N). Furthermore, they will be considered lowly in the eyes of the people and will have no influence or power whatsoever (MB). Imām ‘Alī then warns them that those in authority at that time *will scour you as leather is scoured, and will thrash you as harvested wheat is thrashed*. The analogy of being scraped like tanned leather and thrashed like harvested grain represents the way in which they will be totally humiliated and trodden upon by the tyrants of Banī Umayyah (M), or those who will come during the Last Days. During that time, he says, the believers among the people will be picked out and targeted, *just as a bird selects the large grain from among the fine grains*. Thus the people who will undergo the most difficult trials and tribulation during this period will be the true believers, because truth has a price, and that is the bearing of pains and hardships, especially when living in a tyrannical system where misguidance is prevalent (Z).

6 To get the attention of his audience, the Imām poses some rhetorical questions. *Where are the pathways taking you, the darkness misleading you, and falsehoods deceiving you?* In this way, he tries to wake his listeners up so that they may be attentive to his speech (N). The phrase ‘*tatīhu bikum al-ghayāhib*’ means the darkness is perplexing and bewildering you (R). In a way, he is rebuking them through these questions for their persistence upon misguidance, ignorance, and falsehood (MB). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then asks them *whence are you assailed and how are you deluded?* The phrase ‘*min ayna tu’tawn*’ means where does this sickness of ignorance and misguidance come to you from (M), and ‘*annā tu’fakūn*’, which is mentioned in Q40:62, means how are you misled and duped? One commentator opines that the Imām was telling the people they have no excuse to fall astray from the right path when they know who the infallible members of the Ahl al-Bayt are, and can easily access them for guidance (T). He then reminds them that *for every term there is a written appointment and for every absence there is a return*. By this the Imām is cautioning the people that what he has informed them regarding future events will come to pass as and when it has been ordained (Z). Alternatively, it is a reminder about death and the fact that their lifespans have been decreed, so when their time to leave this world comes, they will surely die (N). The absent one who will eventually return either figuratively refers to one’s action, which he may think has passed and will not be brought up again, only to find its consequence with him in the Hereafter. Or, it could refer to death which will surely come to take one away to the next life, since the term ‘*ghā’ib*’ has been

used to refer to death in sermons no. 63 and 82 earlier (S). Some have suggested that it may also be a reference to the return of the Mahdī from his occultation (T).

The advice he then gives the people is: *listen to your godly leader and keep your hearts attentive towards him, and if he calls out to you, rise up*. One of the descriptions of Amīr al-Mu'minīn by those who knew him was that he was '*rabbānī*', i.e. godly (I). Indeed the godly leader he is referring to here is himself, and by the term 'godly', he means one who is cognizant of Allāh (R), and who always seeks to please Allāh through his knowledge and action (MB). He instructs the people to keep their hearts attentive towards such a leader, meaning they should not suffice with being physically present before him, but should also pay heed to every word he speaks with complete attention, otherwise they will not benefit from him (I). Alternatively it could mean: bring his words to the fore of your minds and hearts (R). The imperative *rise up* ('*istayqīdū*') connotes waking up from the slumber of negligence when this godly leader calls you (MB). By the statement *the scout must tell his people the truth, he must gather his wits about him and maintain his presence of mind*, the Imām sought to highlight the responsibilities of a leader. One who leads the people must be honest and tell the people what is actually happening, truthfully. The phrase '*wal-yajma' shamlahu*' generally connotes bringing together and arranging one's affairs, and it is used here to refer to one's thoughts and decisions, such that the heart becomes free of whims and suspicions and can thus focus on guiding the people and leading them aright (MB). Alternatively, it may mean working towards a united stance among the people, for the benefit of all (Z). The leader must also *maintain his presence of mind* because of the important role he plays, and the detriment caused by negligence while in this position of leadership (T). Continuing his description of the godly leader, who is none other than himself, the Imām says *he has indeed split open the matter for you just as the beads are split, and scraped it just as the gum is scraped* from the bark of a tree. By this he means that he has clearly explained the matter of religion and removed anything they may have found to be unclear or ambiguous therein (R). The term '*al-kharazah*' refers to precious beads and gemstones, like those that are embedded in the crowns of kings, and '*qarf al-samghah*' is an expression which means that nothing is left, because even the sap of the tree, and the resin or gum that flows from it, is completely scraped (T). Thus the Imām was saying that he had not left anything unclarified for them, and had elucidated everything they required (Z). Alternatively, it could mean that he made

manifest for them the hidden meaning of matters, just like the inner part of the beads are seen after they are split, and the gum flows after the outer bark is cut open (MB).

The Imām then turns his attention, once again, to the future tribulation that will befall the people. He says that *when this happens, falsehood will take its position and ignorance will climb on its mounts*. Some commentators consider this to be a continuation of the previous section, which ended in his description of how the believers will be picked out, just as *a bird selects the large grain from among the fine grains* (M). Others say that the phrase *when this happens* refers to the unwillingness of his companions to follow his instructions and advice, and it means that as long as you are in such a condition, the enemies will keep assailing you time and again (Z). It is also possible that the phrase is referring to some elided passage that came before it (MB). However, it is more likely that it refers to what would happen when the banner of misguidance gets established (as mentioned in the beginning of section 5 above) (N). At such a time, a number of things will happen. *Falsehood will take its position*, meaning it will take over whatever it requires and is capable of seizing (T), or it will become firmly entrenched and established (MB). The phrase *ignorance will climb on its mounts* is a metaphor for ignorance spreading among the people, like a rider who is prepared to gallop with the intention of carrying out a raid (M). It could alternatively mean that ignorance and the ignorant will gain might and authority over the people (MB). This will be a time when *tyranny will increase while the callers towards truth will be few*. The term '*al-ṭāghiyah*' can mean tyranny in general, or a specific group of tyrants (I). It is these tyrants who will then actively silence those who call towards the truth, until their numbers dwindle (N).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn subsequently uses the analogy of a pouncing *rapacious beast* ('*al-sabū' al-'aqūr*') to describe the movement of time, and the rumbling of *the bull camel* to depict the spread of falsehood. Time has been compared to the hunting carnivore because it was due to its passage that all these evils and corruption came about, and falsehood is likened to a camel stallion because it is highly valued by its people, and its rumble after being silent and calm represents its becoming manifest after being hidden (MB). This will be a time, the Imām says, when *people will become brothers in wickedness yet will desert one another due to religion*, meaning that those who do not follow religion will hate the religious people and will keep away from them, as will the unchaste eschew the pure and

chaste (Z). *They will love each other based on lies but bear mutual hatred for one another in matters of truth.* These descriptions show that the society of that time will be mostly corrupt and will act in unison, as groups, when they undertake their sinful activities. Therefore, we can deduce that this will be something organized and planned, and that is even more dangerous (N). They will support each other and have affection for each other on the basis of the evil they perpetrate, while keeping aloof from the few who are devoted to religion and showing hatred for those who espouse the truth (I).

7 In continuing his warning about the future, the Imām informs the people that a time will come when children will be deemed an annoyance. The phrase '*kāna al-waladu ghayẓan*' means that the child will bring his parents despair by doing that which infuriates them (R), while it is generally expected that a child would bring joy to his parents (T). This does not refer to the generation gap which is always present between parents and their children in every age, since such a thing does lead to differences in outlook and attitude, but does not result in irritation, rage, or filial impiety (Z). Alternatively, it may mean that children will generally be an annoyance for their parents, who will be preoccupied in their own affairs and in dealing with extreme difficulties and tribulations. Hence they will actually wish they did not have children to begin with (MB). It will also be a time when *rain will cause sweltering heat* ('*al-maṭaru qayẓan*') which may mean that it will rain in the middle of summer, with its scorching heat, thus bringing more harm than benefit (T). Others have proffered different meanings for this, saying that it could refer to lack of rainfall, or the change of rain into something very hot, or even that rain would cause a rise in temperature (MB). According to one commentary, this phrase is meant metaphorically and connotes the rule of evil individuals who will hoard all the produce of the earth and prevent it from reaching the people. That is because another meaning of '*al-maṭar*' is goodness (*khayr*) and '*qayẓ*' also means drought (*jadb*) (Z).

The Imām then says this will be a time when *the wicked will abound and the virtuous will diminish*. Perhaps this means that prevailing conditions will allow evil characters to openly move about and have their way in the society, while virtuous individuals will be sidelined and isolated (N). The phrase '*tafiḍu al-lī'āmu fayḍan*' is a play on the common phrase *tafiḍu al-mā'u fayḍan* which means that the water is so much that it brims over the edge. Likewise '*taghīḍu al-kirāmu ghayḍan*' is from *taghīḍu al-mā'u ghayḍan*, which depicts water going into the earth and

getting depleted until the well is completely dried up (T). Hence these two phrases connote the large number of wicked people compared to very few virtuous ones (MB). The people of that time, the Imām notes, will be like wolves, their rulers like wild beasts, their common folk will be gluttons, and the poor will be as good as dead. The first group, which is only described as the people of that time (*‘ahlu dhālika al-zamān’*) refers, according to some commentators, to those who work for the government and support the evil tyrants of the day. When the rulers are predators, then it is but natural for their subordinates to be wolf-like (N). Alternatively, *the people of that time* refers to all those who benefit from the prevailing condition in that era and derive benefit from the rampant corruption and oppression. The rulers will be like *wild beasts* in that they will act with impunity and neither follow the laws of Islam, nor behave reasonably and rationally (Z).

At that time the common folk and the middle class will be gluttons (*‘awsāṭuhu ukkālā’*). Some have interpreted this phrase differently to mean that the commoners and middle class will be like a meal that is devoured by the ruling class (I). It is but natural that when rulers are evil, the trickle-down effect is that every member of the society that does not actively oppose them tends to follow the path of evil (N). Hence, the commoners too adopt this evil trait of gluttony, if we consider *‘ukkāl’* to be the plural of *ākil*, just as *ṭullāb* is the plural of *ṭālib* (MB). As for the poor of that time being *as good as dead* (*‘fuqarā’uhu amwāta’*), it means that they will face the peak of hardship and tribulation. Since death is considered the end of all hardship, it is used here allegorically to show the extent of difficulty they will suffer (M). Alternatively, they will be as good as dead in the sense that they will have no power or strength to overcome the oppression meted out against them (Z). Imām ‘Alī then says that this will be an era when *truth will sink into the ground while lies will overflow*. This depicts the dearth of truth and the ubiquity of falsehood. The former will be like the water that runs dry, sinking deep into the earth, while the latter will be similar to an overflowing spring (MB). Dishonesty has been specifically mentioned because lying is one of the cornerstones of evil, and causes the most harm (Z).

Underscoring the hypocrisy of that time, the Imām says that *affection will be claimed by the tongues yet people will be at odds in the hearts*. The phrase *‘tashājara al-nās bil-qulūb’* connotes having malice in the heart for others, and desiring their destruction and downfall (M). A tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq states, “Whoever

meets a fellow believer being two-faced and two-tongued, he will come on the Day of Judgment having two tongues of fire" (T). This will be a time when *immorality will be the basis of kinship while chastity will be surprising*. The immoral, wicked individuals will all be friends to each other due to their common behaviour, and there will be something like kinship between them. And people will be amazed at those who maintain their chastity, because such individuals will be very rare (I). Finally, Amīr al-Mu'minīn says about this future time that during this period, *Islam will be worn like the furry garment, inside out*. This can have two possible meanings, the first of which is that the rules of Islam will be overturned, such that what it forbids is deemed permissible and what it commands is forbidden. Alternatively, it could mean that the Muslims will seek this world through Islam instead of the Hereafter, and they will take religiosity as an outward adornment in order to secure worldly benefits (R). The subtle point that some commentators mention here is that the evil rulers of the time who want to do away with Islam will not openly seek to destroy the religion, but will instead use nefarious means to distort the teachings of Islam and introduce false ideas and innovations into it, thereby causing the Muslims to stray from the right path (N).



ON THE OMNIPOTENCE OF ALLĀH, HIS GREATNESS, AND THE RESURRECTION

THE MIGHT OF ALLĀH

- 1 Everything is submissive before Him and everything is sustained by Him. [He is the means of] sufficiency for all who are indigent, dignity for all who are abased, strength for all who are weak, and refuge for all who are persecuted. He hears the speech of one who speaks and knows the secret of one who remains silent. He provides sustenance to the one who lives, and to Him returns the one who dies.

- 2 [O Allāh!] The eyes have not seen You so as to describe You; rather, You existed before the describers among Your creation. Neither did You create the creation on account of loneliness, nor did You use them for any benefit. He whom You seek cannot outrun You and he whom You hold cannot escape You. He who disobeys You diminishes not Your authority and he who obeys You adds nothing to Your sovereignty. He who is angered by Your judgment cannot overturn Your decree and he who turns away from Your directive cannot do without You.

قدرة الله

١ كُلُّ شَيْءٍ خَاشِعٌ لَهُ، وَكُلُّ شَيْءٍ قَائِمٌ بِهِ؛ غَنَى كُلِّ فَقِيرٍ، وَعِزُّ كُلِّ ذَلِيلٍ، وَقُوَّةُ كُلِّ ضَعِيفٍ، وَمَفْرَعُ كُلِّ مُلْهُوفٍ؛ مَنْ تَكَلَّمَ سَمِعَ نُطْقَهُ، وَمَنْ سَكَتَ عَلِمَ سِرَّهُ، وَمَنْ عَاشَ فَعَالِيهِ رِزْقُهُ، وَمَنْ مَاتَ فَإِلَيْهِ مُنْقَلَبُهُ.

٢ لَمْ تَرَكَ الْعُيُونُ فَتُحَرِّ عَنْكَ، بَلْ كُنْتَ قَبْلَ الْوَاصِفِينَ مِنْ خَلْقِكَ، لَمْ تَخْلُقِ الْخَلْقَ لَوَحْشَةٍ، وَلَا اسْتَعْمَلْتَهُمْ لِمَنْفَعَةٍ، وَلَا يَسْبِقُكَ مَنْ طَلَبْتَ، وَلَا يُفْلِتُكَ مَنْ أَخَذْتَ، وَلَا يَنْقُصُ سُلْطَانَكَ مَنْ عَصَاكَ، وَلَا يَزِيدُ فِي مُلْكِكَ مَنْ أَطَاعَكَ، وَلَا يَرُدُّ أَمْرَكَ مَنْ سَخِطَ قَضَاءَكَ، وَلَا يَسْتَعْنِي عَنْكَ مَنْ تَوَلَّى عَنْ أَمْرِكَ.

CONTEXT

This oration is considered to be one of the most eloquent sermons in *Nahj al-Balāghah*. So much so that Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd says about it, “Whoever wishes to learn the art of eloquent oration, and recognize distinguished speech from regular speech, should ponder over this sermon. Indeed its comparison to all other speech, save the Words of Allāh and of His Prophet, is like comparing bright, shining celestial objects to dull, dark stones on earth...” (I). This sermon is known as ‘the Luminous Oration (*al-Zahrāʾ*)’, and before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, Ibn ‘Abd al-Rabbih mentioned it in his *al-Iqd al-Farīd*, though his version includes other passages that al-Raḍī has omitted here. Others who have mentioned part of this sermon in their works include al-Zamakhsharī and al-Āmidī in *Rabīʿ al-Abrār* and *Ghurar al-Ḥikam*, respectively (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has adduced the entire Luminous Oration (as sermon no. 7 of his work), however there is no mention of when and where the Imām gave this sermon. Nevertheless, due to the general purport of what is mentioned in it, not having information about the context does not hinder us from understanding what the Imām meant by these words.

COMMENTARY

1 This sermon commences with the mention of ten perfect attributes of Allāh (N), as part of the Imām’s discussion on *tawḥīd* and Divine Attributes (M). *Everything is submissive before Him*, meaning that everything is under His control and submits to His will (T), *and everything is sustained by Him* since nothing can exist without Him (R). In some manuscripts we find ‘*kullū shayʾin khāḍiʿun lahuʾ*’ instead of ‘*khāshiʿun lahuʾ*’, but the meaning is similar as both terms connote neediness and submission. This refers to the ontological (*takwīnī*) state of the creatures, due to their essential quality of requiring the Sustainer to bestow their existence to them at every moment (MB). It is reflected in the verse which states: *And to Allāh prostrates whoever is in the heavens and on the earth, willingly or unwillingly, and their shadows as well, in the mornings and the evenings* (Q13:15) (T). The Imām then says that He is the means of *sufficiency for all who are indigent* (‘*ghinā kullī faqīr*’), and in reality, every created being is needy and indigent, and it cannot exist for a single moment without the Creator and Sustainer (MB). Indeed, we need Him for every breath of air and every drop of water we require. That

makes us indigent, even if we own great wealth in this world (Z). He is the bestower of *dignity for all who are abased* (*‘izzu kulli dhalīl*), and given that the term *‘izzah* can also mean might, this phrase may likewise signify that He grants strength and might to those who are humbled and abased (Z). He is the *strength for all who are weak* (*‘quwwatu kulli ḍa‘īf*) also gives a similar meaning as what precedes it (MB), for Allāh is the source of all strength, and He grants ability to each creature in accordance with its capacity (M). Allāh is also a *refuge for all who are persecuted* (*‘maḥṣa’u kulli malhūf*). The term *‘malhūf* literally means one who is overcome by grief and sorrow due to losing a loved one, or something of value, and it sometimes refers to one who is oppressed and persecuted. At such a time, a person can only turn to Allāh, and hope that He will alleviate the pain and suffering he is undergoing (N). Indeed, *He hears the speech of one who speaks and knows the secret of one who remains silent*, so nothing is hidden from Him. This points to His all-encompassing knowledge, such that there is no difference between what is disclosed and what is concealed, as it is all known by Him (MB). *He provides sustenance to the one who lives, and to Him returns the one who dies*, meaning that He takes care of us both in life and death. If these ten qualities are understood well, and certitude is attained regarding them, it would suffice to reform an individual completely. That is because we would realize that we are not the true owners of anything, and can only attain what we need and want from Him alone. We cannot hide anything from Allāh, and in the end everything returns to Him (N).

2 Now the Imām mentions that which is negated from Allāh, and He does so while addressing the Almighty. This change from third-person to second-person address (*al-khiṭāb*) is considered very significant in the science of elocution (*‘ilm al-bayān*), and it mostly occurs when the speaker considers a subject to be of great importance. An example of this is seen in the first sūrah of the Qur’ān where the verses turn to a direct address when saying: *You alone do we worship and You alone do we beseech for help* (Q1:5) (I). One commentator opines that his statement *the eyes have not seen You so as to describe You; rather, You existed before the describers among Your creation* is amazing, and its style and structure is not replicable by even the most eloquent speakers (R). It means that as the eyes cannot see the Almighty, they cannot describe Him (MB). Rather, His existence is known through His signs and creation (Z). All corporeality is thus negated from Him, and since He has no physical body, He cannot be described with any material traits (N). The fact

that the intellect testifies to His pre-eternal existence means that only the hearts can perceive His attributes and describe Him, not the eyes which are highly limited in what they perceive (T). Indeed, it would be impossible for Him to be pre-eternal and corporeal at the same time, and that is why these two concepts are inversely linked (MB). The second thing that Imām ‘Alī negates is the idea that Allāh created what He did *on account of loneliness* (*‘li wahshah’*), or to *use them for any benefit* (*‘li manfā‘ah’*). How can the Almighty need a companion when He needs nothing and is perfect in every way? (Z) Rather, the Qur’ān clearly tells us that He only created the jinn and humankind to worship Him (Q51:56), and He says: *I do not desire any provision from them, nor do I desire that they should feed Me* (Q51:57) (T). Subsequently, the Imām says that none of the creation can ever outrun Allāh when He seeks them (*‘lā yasbiquka man ṭalabta’*), and when He seizes any of them, they cannot escape His grasp. The verb *‘yufliṭ’* connotes escaping and getting away suddenly. The well-known statement of ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb wherein he used a word from the same root to describe how the allegiance given to Abū Bakr was something that happened unexpectedly (*kānat faltatan*), shows that it is something which takes place all of a sudden (N). The Imām then states that neither does disobedience diminish Allāh’s authority, nor does obedience enhance it. This negates the comparison of His rule to that of the earthly kings and monarchs, because the latter can only remain in power as long as their subjects obey them, and the more obedient they are, the more power they have. However, Allāh is all-powerful, and nothing can add or diminish His power and authority. In fact, it is by His will that others gain power and authority in the world (M). One who is angered by His decree or is unhappy with it cannot do anything to overturn it, and whoever turns away from His command cannot gain independence from Him, and still needs Him. His command or *directive* (*‘amr’*) here refers to the laws He has laid down for humankind (T), whereas His *decree* (*‘qaḍā’*) is something ontological (*takwīnī*) and pertains to the nature of creation (MB). While the former can be accepted or rejected out of free will, the latter is something one has no control over and can do nothing about.

3 Continuing his supplication to the Almighty, the Imām says *every secret is overt before You and every unseen thing is visible*. Though at first glance, *‘sirr’* and *‘ghayb’* may seem synonymous, it is likely that the former refers to secrets concealed within the hearts of the people, which are all known to Allāh, and thus every secret is open and manifest before Him. On the other hand, the latter term

- 3 Every secret is overt before You and every unseen thing is visible. You are eternal so You have no end. To You all things ultimately return, so there is no escape from You. With You is the final tryst, so there is no deliverance from You except through You. In Your hand is the forelock of every creature and towards You lies the final goal of every living being. Glory be to You, how great is what we perceive of Your creation, yet how small is all greatness next to Your might! How awe-inspiring is what we see of Your kingdom, yet how little it is compared to what is hidden from us of Your dominion! How ample are Your bounties in this world, yet how few they are in comparison to the bounties of the Hereafter!

ABOUT THE NOBLE ANGELS

- 4 Among the [creation are] angels whom You have placed in Your heavens and raised above Your earth; they know You better than the rest of Your creation, fear You the most, and are closest to You. Never did they reside in loins nor were they carried within wombs. They were not created *from an extract of a base fluid* and have not been dispersed by the vicissitudes of time. Verily, despite their proximity to You and their status before You, with all their desires focused upon You, their plenteous worship of You and their lack of inattention towards Your command,

كُلُّ سِرٍّ عِنْدَكَ عَلَانِيَةٌ، وَكُلُّ غَيْبٍ
عِنْدَكَ شَهَادَةٌ؛ أَنْتَ الْأَبَدُ فَلَا أَمَدَ
لَكَ، وَأَنْتَ الْمُتَنَهَى فَلَا مَحِيصَ
عَنْكَ، وَأَنْتَ الْمُوَعَدُ فَلَا مَنْجَى
مِنْكَ إِلَّا إِلَيْكَ، بِيَدِكَ نَاصِيَةُ كُلِّ
دَابَّةٍ، وَإِلَيْكَ مَصِيرُ كُلِّ نَسَمَةٍ.
سُبْحَانَكَ، مَا أَعْظَمَ مَا نَرَى مِنْ
خَلْقِكَ، وَمَا أَصْغَرَ كُلَّ عَظِيمَةٍ فِي
جَنْبِ قُدْرَتِكَ! وَمَا أَهْوَلَ مَا نَرَى
مِنْ مَلَكُوتِكَ، وَمَا أَحْقَرَ ذَلِكَ فِيمَا
غَابَ عَنَّا مِنْ سُلْطَانِكَ! وَمَا أَشْبَعَ
نِعْمَكَ فِي الدُّنْيَا، وَمَا أَصْغَرَهَا فِي
نِعَمِ الْآخِرَةِ!

وَمِنْهَا: فِي الْمَلَائِكَةِ الْكَرَامِ

مِنْ مَلَائِكَةٍ أَشْكَّتَهُمْ سَمَواتِكَ،
وَرَفَعْتَهُمْ عَنْ أَرْضِكَ؛ هُمْ أَعْلَمُ
خَلْقِكَ بِكَ، وَأَخَوْفُهُمْ لَكَ،
وَأَقْرَبُهُمْ مِنْكَ، لَمْ يَسْكُنُوا
الْأَصْلَابَ، وَلَمْ يَضْمَنُوا الْأَرْحَامَ،
وَلَمْ يُخْلَقُوا مِنْ مَاءٍ مَهِينٍ، وَلَمْ
يَتَسَعَّبْهُمْ رَيْبُ الْمُنُونِ؛ وَإِنَّهُمْ عَلَى
مَكَانِهِمْ مِنْكَ، وَمَنْزِلَتِهِمْ عِنْدَكَ،
وَاشْتِجَاعِ أَهْوَائِهِمْ فِيكَ، وَكَثْرَةِ
طَاعَتِهِمْ لَكَ، وَقَلَّةِ غَفْلَتِهِمْ عَنْ

if they were to witness the reality of what remains hidden to them about You, they would regard their deeds as paltry, would censure themselves and realize that they did not worship You as You deserved to be worshipped, and did not obey You with the obedience that is due to You.

أَفَرَأَيْتُمْ لَوْ عَايَنُوا كُنْهَ مَا خَفِيَ عَلَيْهِمْ
مِنْكَ لَحَقُّوْا أَعْمَالَهُمْ، وَلَزَرَوْا عَلَى
أَنْفُسِهِمْ، وَلَعَرَفُوا أَنَّهَمْ لَمْ يَعْبُدُوْكَ
حَقَّ عِبَادَتِكَ، وَلَمْ يُطِيعُوْكَ حَقَّ
طَاعَتِكَ.

may refer to the unseen future or distant past, which is hidden from our senses. Alternatively, it may refer to various types of creatures that exist in the earth or heavens but we cannot perceive them (N). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then says *You are eternal so You have no end*, meaning that He has no beginning or end (T). One commentator says this phrase has such a profound meaning that only those who are well-grounded in knowledge can understand it (I). His statement *to You all things ultimately return, so there is no escape from You* means all that is created returns to Him, and everyone will be recompensed with what they deserve of reward and punishment. No one will be able to escape His judgment and requital (MB). Indeed, *the final tryst* ('*al-maw'id*') is with Allāh, so there is no deliverance from Him except through Him, meaning there is no way to be saved from the punishment of Allāh except through His obedience and worship (Z). *The forelock of every creature* is in His hand and towards Him *lies the final goal of every living being*. This indicates the reins of every creature is in Allāh's hand, and it is by His power and command that the creation continues to exist and is sustained. The Qur'ān says: *There is no moving creature but that He holds it by its forelock* (Q11:56). As for *the final goal* being with Him, that is an emphasis on the previous phrase where it was said that all things ultimately return to Him (M). Now the Imām begins to glorify Allāh, by saying *glory be to You, how great is what we perceive of Your creation, yet how small is all greatness next to Your Might!* All that we can see of the grand universe, and the beautiful celestial objects such as the stars and planets, as well as the towering mountains, flowing rivers, and vast forests of the earth, are nothing compared to the greatness of His might (T). Though what we see of His kingdom is greatly *awe-inspiring* ('*mā ahwala*'), it is little and insignificant *compared to what is hidden from us* of His dominion. Indeed, there is a lot which is veiled from us of what exists in the higher realms of the heavens – much more than what is

perceptible to us in this world (MB). Similarly, though His blessings and bounties are innumerable and vast in the life of this world, they still pale in comparison to the bounties of the Hereafter. This is the final part of the Imām's glorification and praise of Allāh, along with the admission that the intellects are limited in their capacity to fathom what is veiled from them (Z).

4 Al-Qummī has related this section in his exegesis with some variance in wording (T). In it the Imām speaks about angels. When he says that the angels have been placed in the heavens and raised above the earth, it means that this is their original position, and it is where most of the angels stay. However, it does not negate the possibility of some angels being on earth in order to carry out Allāh's directives and organize the affairs as per His command. For instance, the recording angels and those that stay besides the tomb of Imām al-Ḥusayn (ʿa) are on earth (MB). Since the discussion about angels is a subject pertaining to the unseen (*ghayb*), we have no choice but to adhere to the apparent meaning of what the Imām says about them, without assuming any metaphorical or allegorical meaning (Z). The Imām then states that out of all the creation, it is the angels who know Allāh better than the rest, who fear Him the most, and are closest to Him. These three qualities are linked closely to each other, because their heightened cognizance of the Creator leads the angels to be fearful of Him. This includes fear of falling short in carrying out His commandments, as well as the awe they feel for His might and majesty. These traits bring the angels closer to Him, and that is why they are the closest of all creation to Allāh (N). Some commentators understand their greater knowledge and fear to be the result of their witnessing the higher realms of existence, and their proximity to the Almighty as being due to the fact that they never disobey Him or sin (T). If one were to ask: is it not the case that some human beings, like the Prophets, Imāms, and the close friends (*awliyāʾ*) of Allāh are closer to Him and have a loftier station than angels? The answer would be that what the Imām says here is general, and those among humankind who are higher than angels are an exception to the general statement (N).

Then the Imām compares angels to human beings, saying that unlike the latter, they never resided *in loins nor were they carried within wombs. They were not created from an extract of a base fluid*, as mentioned about the creation of humankind in Q32:8. Furthermore, they *have not been dispersed by the vicissitudes of time*. This means that the angels were not created through the process of reproduction, and were not born of parents like human beings. The phrase '*lam*

yatasha‘abhum rayb al-manūn’ means the changes that come about with the passage of time do not affect them or cause them to disperse. This is an allusion to how they are not afflicted by ailments the way human beings are, nor do they grow old and decrepit (MB). The term ‘*al-manūn*’ originally meant weakness (T), and later came to signify death (R). The phrase ‘*rayb al-manūn*’ appears in Q52:30 and means *a doomed fate*, which likewise does not apply to angels. Lastly, the Imām mentions a hypothetical scenario where, if the angels who were close to Allāh because of their complete focus on Him and devout worship and obedience, came to perceive what had been veiled from them, *they would regard their deeds as paltry, would censure themselves, and realize that they did not worship and obey Allāh as He deserved to be worshipped and obeyed*. This statement shows that despite knowing Allāh better than all other creatures, the angels only know very little about His greatness and majesty. That is why if they came to know some of what they were ignorant of, they would see how their continual worship was actually quite insignificant in front of His unlimited grandeur (Z). Some commentators understand this to mean that if they achieved a true cognizance (*ma‘rifah*) of Allāh, they would realize that all their worship does not come close even to an iota of what He deserves (MB). The underlying message here is that the more one attains cognizance of the Almighty, the more devoted he will become in his worship and obedience. At the same time, it shows that no matter how much one worships Allāh, he can never fulfil His right. Moreover, it means that no creature has arrived at complete and perfect cognizance of Allāh, and that is something which cannot be attained by the creatures, as they are finite beings (N).

5 The terms ‘*khālīqan*’ and ‘*ma‘būdān*’ are both describing a state (*hāl*), so the first statement of this section means ‘I glorify You as my Creator and the One whom I worship’ (M). The implicit meaning of this glorification is that one negates any imperfection from the Almighty, as well as the possibility of His having any partner or peer (MB). The abode referred to in his statement *it is through Your good trial of Your creatures that You made an abode* is that of the Hereafter, as the Qurān tells us: *The life of this world is nothing but play and diversion; and verily it is the abode of the Hereafter that is [true] life, if only they knew* (Q29:64) (T). This means that Allāh created the abode of the Hereafter as a result of His testing the servants, and as a trial for them, in order to distinguish the felicitous from the wretched (MB). Most commentators consider this abode to be a reference to Paradise, because the qualities he subsequently mentions are descriptions of Paradise (Z).

DISOBEDIENCE OF THE CREATION

عصيان الخلق

5 Glory be to You, O Creator, O Worshiped One! It is through Your good trial of Your creatures that You made an abode [in the Hereafter] and placed in it a banquet of drinks and food, spouses and servants, palaces and running streams, orchards and fruits. Then You sent a caller to invite [people] towards it, but they neither responded to the caller, nor were they desirous of what You offered them, nor did they eagerly yearn for what You presented to them [of rewards and bounties].

٥ شُجِّحَانِكَ خَالِقاً وَمَعْبُوداً! بِحُسْنِ بَلَائِكَ عِنْدَ خَلْقِكَ خَلَقْتَ ذَاراً، وَجَعَلْتَ فِيهَا مَأْدِبَةً مَشْرَباً وَمَطْعَمًا، وَأَزْوَاجًا وَخَدَمًا، وَقُصُورًا وَأَنْهَارًا، وَزُرُوعًا وَثَمَارًا؛ ثُمَّ أَرْسَلْتَ دَاعِيًا يَدْعُو إِلَيْهَا، فَلَا الدَّاعِيَ أَجَابُوا، وَلَا فِيمَا رَغَبْتَ رَغِبُوا، وَلَا إِلَى مَا سَوَّيْتَ إِلَيْهِ اسْتَأْفُوا.

6 They proceeded towards the carcass that they had been shamed for eating and consented to love it. And when one loves a thing, it renders him blind and makes his heart sick, so he sees with an unseeing eye and hears with an unhearing ear, with desires having stupefied his intellect and the world having caused his heart to die, while his spirit yearns for it [constantly]. Thus, he is its slave and [the slave] of one who possesses any of it. Wherever it moves, he goes after it and wherever it turns, he turns to face it. Neither is he deterred by any deterrent from Allāh, nor does he heed any admonition from a [divinely sent] admonisher. Yet he sees those who are taken while [they are] heedless, to the place where there is neither rescission nor return –

٦ أَقْبَلُوا عَلَى حَيْفَةٍ قَدْ افْتَضَّحُوا بِأَكْلِهَا، وَاضْطَلَحُوا عَلَى حُبِّهَا؛ وَمَنْ عَشِقَ شَيْئًا أَغْشَى بَصَرَهُ وَأَمْرَضَ قَلْبَهُ، فَهُوَ يَنْظُرُ بَعَيْنٍ غَيْرِ صَحِيحَةٍ وَيَسْمَعُ بِأُذُنٍ غَيْرِ سَمِيعَةٍ، قَدْ خَرَقَتِ الشَّهَوَاتُ عَقْلَهُ، وَأَمَاتَتِ الدُّنْيَا قَلْبَهُ، وَوَلِهَتْ عَلَيْهِهَا نَفْسُهُ، فَهُوَ عَبْدٌ لَهَا وَلِمَنْ فِي يَدَيْهِ شَيْءٌ مِنْهَا، حَيْثُمَا زَالَتْ زَالَ إِلَيْهَا، وَحَيْثُمَا أَقْبَلَتْ أَقْبَلَ عَلَيْهَا؛ لَا يَنْزَجِرُ مِنَ اللَّهِ بِرَاجِرٍ، وَلَا يَتَّعِظُ مِنْهُ بِوَاعِظٍ، وَهُوَ يَرَى الْمَأْخُودِينَ عَلَى الْغُرَّةِ، حَيْثُ لَا إِفَالَةَ وَلَا رَجْعَةَ، كَيْفَ نَزَلَ بِهِمْ

how that which they were ignorant of befell them and separation from this world, from which they considered themselves safe, came to them, and they proceeded to that which was promised to them of the Hereafter. What they experienced defies description: [they suffered] both the agony of death and the grief of loss at the same time, such that their limbs got paralyzed and their colour changed.

مَا كَانُوا يَجْهَلُونَ، وَجَاءَهُمْ مِنْ
فِرَاقِ الدُّنْيَا مَا كَانُوا يَأْمُنُونَ، وَقَدِمُوا
مِنَ الْآخِرَةِ عَلَى مَا كَانُوا يُوعَدُونَ؛
فَعَيَّرُ مُؤَصِّفٍ مَا نَزَلَ بِهِمْ:
اجْتَمَعَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ سَكْرَةُ الْمَوْتِ
وَحَسْرَةُ الْفَوْتِ، فَفَتَرَتْ لَهَا
أَطْرَافَهُمْ وَتَغَيَّرَتْ لَهَا أَلْوَانُهُمْ.

Indeed, He placed in it *a banquet of drinks and food, spouses and servants, palaces and running streams, orchards and fruits*. The term ‘*maḍubah*’, which can also be pronounced *māḍabah*, is food to which people are invited, and the term *ādib* refers to one who invites others for a meal. And the term ‘*zurūʿan*’, rendered as *orchards*, refers to planted trees, but it could also refer to crops like wheat or legumes (I). The eight things mentioned here are what constitute every royal banquet (T), and for this banquet the inviter who calls others to it is none other than the Noble Prophet (ﷺ) (MB), or generally all the Messengers sent by Allāh (N). However, the Imām says despite his invitation, *they neither responded to the caller, nor were they desirous of what You offered them, nor did they eagerly yearn for what You presented to them*. This pertains specifically to the disobedient sinners and disbelievers who obstinately rejected the invitation of their Lord (M).

6 Instead of answering the caller who was inviting them to a heavenly banquet, the people *proceeded towards the carcass that they had been shamed for eating and consented to love it*. Like scavengers who eat carrion, they sought to devour this world and its adornments. The term ‘*jīfah*’, meaning carcass, is a metaphor for this world since the people of wisdom, insight, and certitude have an aversion to it just as one would be averse to a rotting corpse (MB). Alternatively, it may refer to all that has been forbidden and made unlawful by Allāh, and just as scavengers flock to carrion, those whose natures and dispositions are like wild dogs, hyenas, and vultures, rush towards what has been made *ḥarām* (Z). This metaphor could have been used to show that the inner reality of this world is something putrid since it is polluted by all kinds of injustice and sin (N). The phrase

‘iftaḍāḥū bi aklihā’ means they were disgraced and put to shame for devouring it. Indeed, after understanding that it is something akin to a rotting carcass, eating of it would obviously be repugnant and shameful (MB). They *consented to love it*, meaning that they agreed among themselves to do so, since it was the object of their common affection. That is why they all hate the people of righteousness who aspire after the Hereafter, because they are enemies of that which they love (T). The Imām then mentions a general principle, that *when one loves a thing, it renders him blind and makes his heart sick*. Indeed, love blinds the eye and ails the heart. It impairs one’s senses such that *he sees with an unseeing eye and hears with an unhearing ear, with desires having stupefied his intellect and the world having caused his heart to die, while his spirit yearns for it* constantly. With these words, it is as if the Imām, as a physician of the soul, has diagnosed the root cause of what ails the people, namely their deep attachment to the allures of this world (N). It is this trait that robs the human being of his ability to reason and perceive the truth. Such individuals do not follow any rules, and never think about the consequences of their actions. All that consumes their minds is their beloved, and that is what they think about constantly (Z). Thus, one who is besotted by this world becomes a slave to it, and also becomes servile to the one who possesses it. It is reported that al-Ḥaṣīn ibn al-Mundhir once said, “I wish I had a mountain of gold the size of Uḥud, none of which I would spend!” Someone asked, “Then what use would it be to you?” He replied, “It would make many people serve me, because [desire for] wealth makes people servants” (T). Since the focus of such an individual is entirely on the *dunyā*, wherever it goes, he follows, and wherever it turns, he turns; like a slave who follows behind his master. Rather, his servitude is more intense and disgraceful, because a slave may serve his master as he has no choice, but this individual serves this world because of his deep affection and desire for it (M). He is *neither deterred* by any warning from Allāh, *nor does he heed any admonition* from a divinely sent admonisher. Neither do the warnings found in divine scriptures and teachings of the Prophets deter such people from being attached to this world, nor does seeing how people have died and left their fortunes behind open their eyes to the futility of this kind of behaviour (MB).

One who loves this world *sees those who are taken while heedless*, to the place from which *there is neither rescission nor return*, meaning he witnesses how death suddenly comes to people from different directions while they are negligent of it, and how they cannot return to life again. Despite that, he does not take a lesson

and stop being attached to the world (Z). The term '*iqālah*' means rescinding or cancelling a contract or agreement, and some have said that it originally meant saving a person from falling. In this instance, it refers to being forgiven for sins (N). The besotted lover of this world sees how *that which they were ignorant of befell the people he knew and separation from this world, from which they considered themselves safe, came to them, and they proceeded to that which was promised to them of the Hereafter*. The phrase '*mā kānū yajhalūn*' means that which they had not experienced, or the reality of which they were unaware, and it refers to the pangs of death (T). Imām 'Alī then explains that *what they experienced defies description: [they suffered] both the agony of death and the grief of loss at the same time, such that their limbs got paralyzed and their colour changed*. The two most difficult assaults of death are the pangs thereof (*sakarāt al-mawt*) in which stupefaction and perplexity overcomes a dying person, causing great anxiety and unease. And secondly, the regret and sadness of losing all that one has spent a lifetime attaining, as well as what one is attached to and loves (N). The Imām then goes on to describe some of the effects of the death pangs, saying that as they begin to lose feeling in their extremities, the limbs of the dying person become paralyzed, and the colour of their skin changes. This is because the pain of extraction spreads throughout different parts of the body, and it is a pain that scholars say nobody but the one who experiences it can know (MB). Indeed, the pangs of death are so painful that some have compared it to having one's body rubbed against a thorny tree, with the sharp thorns piercing every nerve in his body (M). And we are told that it is only true believers who will remain steadfast in their faith during these painful final moments (S).

7 Continuing his elucidation and warning about death, the Imām says after its pangs overtake the dying, *death penetrates deeper into them, forming a barrier between each of them and his ability to speak*. The penetration ('*wulūj*') of death is a metaphor for losing mobility and function in different parts of the body, as if each limb and organ dies in turn. A tradition from Imām al-Bāqir states that life and death are two creations of Allāh, and whenever death enters a person, there is no part of his body that it enters but that life departs therefrom (MB). Interestingly, we are told that usually one of the first faculties that is lost by a dying person is speech. Indeed this makes it even more frightening, for one sees and hears things but can tell no one about it (N). The dying person thus *lies among his family, looking with his eyes and listening with his ears, with sound mind and functioning*

7 Then death penetrates deeper into them, forming a barrier between each of them and his ability to speak. He thus lies among his family, looking with his eyes and listening with his ears, with sound mind and functioning intelligence. He ponders over how he wasted his life and in what he passed his time. He recalls the wealth he accumulated, blindly seeking after it, and acquiring it from recognized and dubious sources. The consequences of amassing it have now caught up with him as he witnesses its separation. It will remain for those he leaves behind. They will enjoy it and revel in it, so it will be an easily acquired comfort for others yet its burden will rest on his back. And the man is bound by it, unable to get free, so he bites his hand out of regret for what becomes evident to him about his affair at the time of death, and he renounces what he used to covet during his lifetime, wishing that the one who envied him on account of it and was jealous of him over it would have amassed it instead of himself.

8 Death continues to permeate his body until it enters his ears [causing them to lose function]. So he lies among his family, neither speaking with his tongue nor listening with his ears. He keeps glancing at their faces and sees the movements of their tongues, yet is unable to hear the sound of their

٧ ثُمَّ اِزْدَادَ الْمَوْتُ فِيهِمْ وَلُجَاً،
فَحِيلَ بَيْنَ أَحَدِهِمْ وَبَيْنَ مَنْطِقِهِ،
وَإِنَّهُ لَبَيْنَ أَهْلِهِ يَنْظُرُ بِبَصَرِهِ وَيَسْمَعُ
بِأُذُنِهِ، عَلَى صِحَّةٍ مِنْ عَقْلِهِ وَبَقَاءٍ
مِنْ لُبِّهِ، يُفَكِّرُ فِيمَ أَفْنَى عُمْرِهِ وَفِيمَ
أَذْهَبَ ذَهْرَهُ، وَيَتَذَكَّرُ أَمْوَالاً
جَمَعَهَا، أَعْمَصَ فِي مَطَالِبِهَا،
وَأَخَذَهَا مِنْ مُصَرَّحَاتِهَا وَمُسْتَتَبَاتِهَا،
قَدْ لَزِمَتْهُ تَبَعَاتُ جَمْعِهَا وَأَشْرَفَ
عَلَى فِرَاقِهَا، تَبَقَّى لِمَنْ وَرَاءَهُ
يَنْعَمُونَ فِيهَا وَيَتَمَتَّعُونَ بِهَا،
فَيَكُونُ الْمَهْنَأُ لِغَيْرِهِ وَالْعَبَاءُ عَلَى
ظَهْرِهِ، وَالْمَرْءُ قَدْ عَلِقَتْ رُهُونُهُ بِهَا،
فَهُوَ يَعْصُ يَدَهُ نَدَامَةً عَلَى مَا أَضْحَرَ
لَهُ عِنْدَ الْمَوْتِ مِنْ أَمْرِهِ، وَيَرْهَدُ
فِيمَا كَانَ يَزْعَبُ فِيهِ أَيَّامَ عُمْرِهِ،
وَيَتَمَنَّى أَنْ الَّذِي كَانَ يَغْبِطُهُ بِهَا
وَيَحْسُدُهُ عَلَيْهَا قَدْ حَارَهَا دُونَهُ.

٨ فَلَمْ يَزَلِ الْمَوْتُ يُبَالِغُ فِي جَسَدِهِ
حَتَّى خَالَطَ سَمْعَهُ، فَصَارَ بَيْنَ أَهْلِهِ
لَا يَنْطِقُ بِلِسَانِهِ وَلَا يَسْمَعُ بِسَمْعِهِ،
يُرَدِّدُ طَرْفَهُ بِالنَّظَرِ فِي وُجُوهِهِمْ،
يَرَى حَرَكَاتِ أَلْسِنَتِهِمْ وَلَا يَسْمَعُ

speech. Then death intensifies its grip and takes away his sight just as it took away his hearing, after which the soul departs from his body, leaving him as a corpse among his family. They will then feel uneasy being close to him and will distance themselves from his proximity. Neither can he aid the mourner nor respond to any caller. Then they will carry him to a marked spot in the ground and place him in it, surrendering him to his deeds and ceasing to be in his company.

رَجَعَ كَلَامِهِمْ. ثُمَّ أَزْدَادَ الْمَوْتُ
الْتِّبَاطَ بِهِ، فَقَبَضَ بَصَرَهُ كَمَا قَبَضَ
سَمْعَهُ، وَخَرَجَتِ الرُّوحُ مِنْ
جَسَدِهِ فَصَارَ جِيفَةً بَيْنَ أَهْلِهِ، قَدْ
أَوْحَشُوا مِنْ جَانِبِهِ، وَتَبَاعَدُوا مِنْ
قُرْبِهِ، لَا يُسْعِدُ بَاكِياً وَلَا يُجِيبُ
دَاعِياً؛ ثُمَّ حَمَلُوهُ إِلَى مَحَطٍّ فِي
الْأَرْضِ، فَأَسْلَمُوهُ فِيهِ إِلَى عَمَلِهِ،
وَانْقَطَعُوا عَنْ رُؤْرَتِهِ.

intelligence. This means that the dying person is aware of his surroundings, even though it may not seem that way. He listens to the speech of those around him, and sees their expressions, understanding what is happening because his mind is sound. All this just adds to his remorse and regret, because he realizes that he will soon depart this world and proceed to the Hereafter, where he will face the consequences of his actions (MB). It is in these moments that *he ponders over how he wasted his life and in what he passed his time.* The final moments before one dies are a time of awakening from heedlessness for those who were deeply engrossed in this world. Many who perpetrated evil in their lives expressed regret during their final moments, including the likes of Mu'āwiyah (T). This awakening brings with it the realization that one has to account for every deed, and every penny he earned and spent in his life. As such, the dying person *recalls the wealth he accumulated, blindly seeking after it, and acquiring it from recognized and dubious sources.* This is the time when he worries about the illicit income he acquired, knowing that the *consequences of amassing it have now caught up with him as he witnesses its separation.* Yet there is no way to make amends at this juncture, for he cannot even speak so as to have someone help him. And even if he does utter words, they are considered to be the utterings of a delirious, dying man (N).

Despite having to bear the punishment for acquiring unlawful wealth himself, his heirs will inherit and enjoy the wealth. *It will remain for those he leaves behind*

to revel in, thereby being *an easily acquired comfort for others* but a burden for himself! The term '*al-ibū*' means a heavy load (R), and here it figuratively refers to the sins that one has committed (M). Seeing how his heirs will enjoy what he strove for while he pays the penalty for it leads the dying individual to feel anger and envy along with his remorse and regret. One report states that when 'Amr ibn al-Āṣ was dying, his son came to him, so he said, "Take that treasure chest which is filled with wealth – and how I wish it was filled with dung instead!" (T). The phrase '*qad ghalīqat ruhūnuhu bihā*' means that the dying person will be bound and fettered by his illicit wealth and unable to secure his freedom by paying its ransom or making amends (M). Or it simply means he could not pay back what he owes, so like collateral which was given as security for a loan, it now becomes the possession of another (I). Some commentators suggest that this phrase means one is unable to take benefit of any good deeds he may have done, because he is held back therefrom by the illicit wealth he earned in the world (MB). The Imām then mentions three reactions of such a dying person, saying that he *bites his hand out of regret for what becomes evident to him about his affair at the time of death*. This is the result of the immense distress one feels upon seeing how all the things he loves and worked so hard to attain in this world are taken away from him in an instant (N). The Qur'ān mentions a similar description of regret when it says: *And the Day the unjust one will bite his hands, saying, "How I wish I had followed the way with the Messenger!"* (Q25:27). The second reaction is that *he renounces what he used to covet during his lifetime*. Now he cares little for the things he craved and yearned for all the days of his life. Some commentators note that this change in attitude is because of his state and inability, not because he wilfully reformed himself and no longer craves those things (Z). The third reaction is *wishing that the one who envied him on account of it and was jealous of him over it would have amassed it instead of himself*. This is when the grave consequences of having these things becomes apparent to him (MB). He recalls how there were many people who envied him for his wealth and sought to take it from him, but he prevented them from doing so using his guile and cunning. But now he wishes that he had let them take it all so that he would be saved from the accounting and the punishment that would follow (N).

8 As the march of death continues for the dying person, permeating his body, he loses his ability to hear as like his tongue, his ears also stop working. *So he lies among his family, neither speaking with his tongue nor listening with his ears*. In

some manuscripts, the phrase '*khālaṭa lisānuhu sam'ahu*' appears, with the added term '*lisānuhu*', in which case the translation would read *until his tongue joins his ears [both having lost function]*. However, one commentator notes that this is an error because it is death that joins and mixes with the ears, causing them to lose function, not the tongue (T). As the dying man lies there, unable to speak or hear, *he keeps glancing at their faces and sees the movements of their tongues, yet is unable to hear the sound of their speech*. This is one of the difficult stages of death, and it signifies the complete severance of communication between the dying and those around him (N). Subsequently, *death intensifies its grip and takes away his sight just as it took away his hearing*. Some commentators note the natural causes of the faculties of speech, hearing, and sight being lost in this order, attributing it to the way they have been created and how they function in the body (M). From this description we see that the pangs of death gradually increase in intensity and severity until the dying person leaves this world. Then *the soul departs from his body, leaving him as a corpse among his family*. The subtle message here is that at this point, those who were close to the person begin to have aversion to his body, which now lies lifeless. People are naturally averse to corpses and dislike being in their presence. It also shows that the physical body should not be something one is proud of or by which one seeks superiority over others. Some scholars opine that the human corpse is more abominable than the carcass of animals, because one need not perform a ritual bath (*ghusl*) after touching the latter, but it becomes obligatory to do so after touching a corpse (MB). At this juncture, his close relatives *will feel uneasy* ('*awḥashū*') being near him and *will distance themselves from his proximity*. This is despite their affection for him, and their previous desire to be near him and to have him close by (Z). The reason behind this may be explained as the natural tendency to fear that the dead may somehow pull any living soul nearby towards death. Thus it is that when one's soul is taken out of his body, people wish to leave his side and move far away from him (MB). Now he can neither *aid the mourner* by consoling him, *nor respond to any caller* who calls out to him. Finally, the people around him *carry him to a marked spot in the ground and place him in it, surrendering him to his deeds and ceasing to be in his company*. Indeed, his people only accompany him until he is laid to rest in the grave, after which he is left to his deeds, for it is his deeds that will remain with him. Thus it is as if the dead man's relatives have surrendered him to his deeds (T). The phrase '*inqaṭā'ū 'an zawratihī*' literally means they stop visiting him, and it connotes leaving

JUDGMENT [DAY]

9 Until the time when the prescribed term is complete, the affair reaches its preordained end, the last of creation joins with the first, and the command of Allāh, based on what He wills for the renewal of His creation, comes to pass. Then, He will shake the sky and cleave it, He will quake the earth and stir it, and He will uproot its mountains and scatter them, as they crush each other out of awe of His majesty and fear of His punishment. [Then] He will remove all who are within it, renewing them after their decay and gathering them after their dispersal. Then He will separate them in order that He may question them about [their] concealed actions and deeds performed in secret. He will divide them into two groups, rewarding these and exacting retribution from those. As for the obedient ones, He will reward them with His proximity and keep them forever in His abode, wherein those who settle never depart and their situation never changes. They are never stricken by fear, nor are they affected by ailments, nor are they faced with dangers, nor are they forced to travel.

10 As for the sinful people, He will settle them in the worst abode, shackle the hands to the necks, bind the forelocks with the feet, and clothe them in garments of tar and attires cut out of

القيامة

٩ حَتَّىٰ إِذَا بَلَغَ الْكِتَابَ أَجَلَهُ، وَالْأَمْرُ مَقَادِيرُهُ، وَالْحَقُّ آخِرُ الْخَلْقِ بِأَوَّلِهِ، وَجَاءَ مِنْ أَمْرِ اللَّهِ مَا يُرِيدُهُ مِنْ تَجْدِيدِ خَلْقِهِ، أَمَّا السَّمَاءُ وَقَطَرُهَا، وَارْتَجَّ الْأَرْضُ وَارْجَفَهَا، وَقَلَعَ جِبَالَهَا وَنَسَفَهَا، وَذَكَ بَعْضُهَا بَعْضًا، مِنْ هَيْبَةِ جَلَالَتِهِ وَمَخُوفِ سَطَوَاتِهِ، وَأَخْرَجَ مِنْ فِيهَا فَجَدَّذَهُمْ بَعْدَ إِخْلَاقِهِمْ، وَجَمَعَهُمْ بَعْدَ تَفَرُّقِهِمْ؛ ثُمَّ مَيَّرَهُمْ لِمَا يُرِيدُهُ مِنْ مَسْأَلَتِهِمْ عَنْ خَفَايَا الْأَعْمَالِ، وَخَبَايَا الْأَفْعَالِ، وَجَعَلَهُمْ فَرِيقَيْنِ أَنْعَمَ عَلَى هَؤُلَاءِ وَأَنْتَقَمَ مِنْ هَؤُلَاءِ. فَأَمَّا أَهْلُ الطَّاعَةِ فَأَتَابَهُمْ بِجَوَارِهِ، وَخَلَدَهُمْ فِي دَارِهِ، حَيْثُ لَا يَظْعَنُ النُّرَّالُ، وَلَا تَتَغَيَّرُ بِهِمُ الْحَالُ، وَلَا تُنَوِّبُهُمُ الْأَفْرَاعُ، وَلَا تَنَالُهُمُ الْأَشْقَامُ، وَلَا تَعْرِضُ لَهُمُ الْأَخْطَارُ، وَلَا تُشَخِّصُهُمُ الْأَشْفَارُ.

١٠ وَأَمَّا أَهْلُ الْمَعْصِيَةِ، فَأَنْزَلَهُمْ شَرَّ دَارٍ، وَغَلَّ الْأَيْدِي إِلَى الْأَعْنَاقِ، وَفَرَنَ النَّوَاصِي بِالْأَقْدَامِ، وَالْبَسَهُمُ

fire. [They will be] in a chastisement whose heat is severe, with a door that is closed on the inmates, in a fire which has scorching vehemence and clamour, blazing flames and frightening roars. Its inmate cannot depart from it, its prisoner cannot secure his release by paying a ransom, and its fetters cannot be broken. Neither is there a time limit for that abode after which it ceases to exist, nor is there a fixed term for its people that would come to an end.

سَرَايِلَ الْقَطِرَانِ وَمُقَطَّعَاتِ النَّيِّرَانِ،
فِي عَذَابٍ قَدِ اشْتَدَّ حَرُّهُ، وَبَابٍ قَدْ
أُطْبِقَ عَلَى أَهْلِهِ، فِي نَارٍ لَهَا كَلْبٌ
وَلَجَبٌ، وَلَهَبٌ سَاطِعٌ، وَقَصِيفٌ
هَائِلٌ، لَا يَظَعُنُ مُقِيمُهَا، وَلَا يُفَادَى
أَسِيرُهَا، وَلَا تُفْصَمُ كُبُورُهَا؛ لَا مُدَّةَ
لِلدَّارِ فَتَقْنَى، وَلَا أَجَلَ لِلْقَوْمِ
فَيَقْتَضَى.

him all alone, and not remaining in his company. After a while, they even stop visiting his grave altogether.

9 The next phase for those who leave this world, which the Imām now speaks about, is facing accounting and judgment. The phrase *when the prescribed term is complete* ('*idhā balagha al-kitābu ajalāh*') is derived from Q2:235 and connotes the arrival of the time for something (T). The term '*al-kitāb*' refers to what Allāh has decreed for the people of how long they will remain in their graves, and when the Day of Judgment will be (MB). '*Al-amru maqādīrahu*' is rendered as *the affair reaches its preordained end* and connotes the coming to pass of what had been ordained by the Almighty of events and their outcomes (M). This is when the last of creation are joined with the first among them in death, which will cause them all to perish, without exception (N). In this way, all human beings are the same before death (S). Then, when Allāh wills to renew His creation ('*tajdid khalqih*'), *He will shake the sky and cleave it, He will quake the earth and stir it, and He will uproot its mountains and scatter them, as they crush each other out of awe of His majesty and fear of His punishment*. The phrase '*amāda al-samā*' has been recorded as '*amāra al-samā*' in some narrations, and though both verbs connote shaking and convulsion, the second seems to be more correct here since it has also been mentioned in the Qur'ān, in the verse that states: *On the day when the sky sways [violently] from side to side* ('*tamūru al-samāu mawran*', Q52:9) (T). All these changes point to the end of this world as we know it. The sky will be split asunder, the earth will quake, and the mountains will be pulverized to dust. These events

have been mentioned in different verses of the Glorious Qurʾān. Indeed, everything in this world has a purpose, and once it has fulfilled its purpose, it perishes and remains no more. Hence we understand that the second genesis (*al-nashʾat al-ukhrā*) will come about when the first genesis (*al-nashʾat al-ūlā*) has ended. Allāh will then bring out all those who are within the earth, *renewing them after their decay and gathering them after their dispersal*. The disintegrated bones shall be gathered and given new life once more. This gathering after dispersal could refer to the assembly of parts of their bodies after they have been separated, or the coming together of individuals in the plain of *maḥshar* from different corners of the earth, and this latter meaning seems more correct (MB).

They will then be separated from each other, *in order that He may question them about concealed actions and deeds performed in secret*. The term '*khabāyā*' is plural of *khabīyyah* and means a thing that is concealed (R). When the people are resurrected from their graves, each will be identified individually and questioned about his specific deeds and doings, whether in public or in private, by One who knows of their every glance, thought, and feeling (Z). It has been suggested that the *concealed actions* ('*khafāyā al-aʿmāl*') could refer to those actions that were done covertly, but within the community, while the deeds done in secret ('*khabāyā al-afʿāl*') refers to actions that one undertook in private, while alone (N). The people will be divided into two groups, one rewarded and blessed while the other punished and requited. The Qurʾān says about this: *Verily the virtuous shall be in bliss, and verily the wicked shall be in Hellfire* (Q82:13-14). Those who are obedient will be rewarded *with His proximity* ('*bi jiwārih*') and kept *forever in His abode* ('*khalladahum fī dārih*'). In this way, they will be ennobled and exalted for the good they did. This statement is an encouragement for the believers who yearn for this station and an eternal abode in Paradise, a place *wherein those who settle never depart and their situation never changes*. Indeed, those who enter it are never expelled from it, and the blessings they enjoy therein never end or change (MB). The inhabitants of Paradise *are never stricken by fear, nor are they affected by ailments, nor are they faced with dangers, nor are they forced to travel*. These are the things that regularly trouble people in this world and are a cause of worry for them. However, none of these hardships hamper the felicity and joy of the inhabitants of Jannah, and such perils do not threaten them in their heavenly abode. The difference between never having to depart it and never being compelled to travel is perhaps that the former connotes being forced to leave, as is the case with those

who are evicted from their homes in this world, while the latter refers to having to travel from place to place in order to earn a living or acquire something they wish for or need. Neither of these will affect the dwellers of Paradise (N).

10 However, the situation is entirely different for wicked sinners. Imām ‘Alī says that the sinful people will be settled *in the worst abode*, with their hands shackled to their necks, their forelocks bound to their feet, clothed *in garments of tar and attires cut out of fire*. All this is clearly mentioned in different verses of the Qur’ān, which some commentators have listed in detail (T). The phrase ‘*muqatta‘āt al-nūrān*’ means attires of fire which resemble loose gowns (R). Their forelocks will be bound to their feet with chains and shackles before being cast into the fire of Hell (MB). It should be remembered that these punishments are just, and those who will face them are deserving of such treatment for their actions in the world. Indeed, we see how evil some people are in the *dunyā*, and the only requital that would rightfully recompense them for their evil is the chastisement of the Hereafter mentioned here (Z). The severity of punishment is detailed further, as the Imām says that *its heat is severe*, and once they are in it, the door will be bolted on its inmates so there is no way they could escape. Its fire *has scorching vehemence and clamour, blazing flames and frightening roars*. The term ‘*kalab*’ originally meant urging on a horse by use of spurs, in order to have it gallop faster. Later it became a term that generally connoted vehemence, severity, and pressure. As for ‘*lajab*’, it refers to clamour, loud noise, and roaring (N). Some commentators say that though the fire of the Hereafter is unlike what we perceive in this world, the Imām uses qualities that we can relate to in order to describe it, because most people can only understand that which they can perceive with their senses (M). One of the important aspects of this punishment is its permanence. *Its inmate cannot depart from it, its prisoner cannot secure his release by paying a ransom, and its fetters cannot be broken*. Each time they seek to exit it, they are forced back into it, as the Qur’ān states (Q22:22). That is because there is no time limit for that abode after which it ceases to be, nor are there lifespans for its denizens that would come to an end, thereby alleviating their torment. A tradition attributed to the Messenger of Allāh states that death will be brought on the Day of Resurrection in the form of a ram. It will then be slaughtered between Paradise and Hell, and an announcer will announce, “O People of Paradise! Eternity without death [awaits you]! And O People of Hell! Eternity without death [awaits you]!” (MB). If an objective thinker were to ponder over these punishments and their severity, it

ALSO: ABOUT THE PROPHET (ﷺ)

11 He disdained this world and belittled it. He considered it unimportant and trivialized it. He knew that Allāh had withheld it from him by choice and expanded it for others because of its inferiority. So he turned away from this world with his heart, banished thoughts about it from his mind, and liked its beauty to remain hidden from his sight so that he would neither take from it any apparel nor hope to stay in it. He conveyed [the Message] from his Lord thereby leaving no excuse for anyone, advised his people by warning them, called [them] towards Paradise with glad tidings, and made them fear Hell through admonition.

THE AHL AL-BAYT

12 We are the [descendants of the] tree of prophethood, the locus of the [divine] Message, [the house that is] frequented by angels, the sources of knowledge, and the wellsprings of wisdom. Mercy awaits our supporter and lover, while chastisement awaits our enemy and hater.

ومنها: في ذكر النبي ﷺ

١١ قَدْ حَقَّرَ الدُّنْيَا وَصَغَّرَهَا، وَأَهْوَنَ بِهَا وَهَوَّنَهَا، وَعَلِمَ أَنَّ اللَّهَ رَوَّاهَا عَنْهُ اخْتِيَارًا، وَبَسَّطَهَا لِغَيْرِهِ احْتِقَارًا؛ فَأَعْرَضَ عَنِ الدُّنْيَا بِقَلْبِهِ، وَأَمَاتَ ذِكْرَهَا عَنْ نَفْسِهِ، وَأَحَبَّ أَنْ تَغِيبَ زِينَتُهَا عَنْ عَيْنِهِ لِكَيْلَا يَتَّخِذَ مِنْهَا رِيَاشًا، أَوْ يَرْجُو فِيهَا مَقَامًا. بَلَغَ عَنْ رَبِّهِ مُعْذِرًا، وَنَصَحَ لِأُمَّتِهِ مُنْذِرًا، وَدَعَا إِلَى الْجَنَّةِ مُبَشِّرًا، وَخَوَّفَ مِنَ النَّارِ مُحَذِّرًا.

أهل البيت

١٢ نَحْنُ شَجَرَةُ النُّبُوَّةِ، وَمَحَطُّ الرِّسَالَةِ، وَمُخْتَلَفُ الْمَلَائِكَةِ، وَمَعَادِنُ الْعِلْمِ، وَيَنَائِبُ الْحُكْمِ؛ نَاصِرُنَا وَمُجِبُّنَا يَنْتَظِرُ الرَّحْمَةَ، وَعَدُوْنَا وَمَنْغِضُنَا يَنْتَظِرُ السَّطْوَةَ.

would be enough to deter him from sin. And indeed that was the goal of the Imām in mentioning this (N). Perhaps it is for the same reason that we have been encouraged in the narrations to stop and ponder upon the verses that describe the blessings of Paradise and the chastisements of Hell.

11 In this section, Imām ‘Alī talks about the Noble Prophet (ﷺ). He says that Rasūlullāh *disdained this world and belittled it, considered it unimportant and*

trivialized it. This means that he considered this world lowly and insignificant, because of his *zuhd* and his disinterest in its wares. One commentator suggests that this means the Messenger of Allāh belittled the wealth of this world that was in the possession of others (I), however even though it is true that he deemed the wealth that others possessed as insignificant, in this instance the Imām is talking about the Prophet's own disinterest in possessing wealth, and his considering it as something lowly and unimportant (T). *He knew that Allāh had withheld it from him by choice and expanded it for others because of its inferiority.* The Prophet recognized that Allāh had purposely turned the world away from him while bestowing it to others due to its lowliness. The term '*ikhtiṭyāran*' which is rendered *by choice*, either means that Allāh chose to do that knowing it was better for him, or by the choice of the Noble Messenger (ṣ) himself, since narrations tell us that Allāh had offered all the wealth of the world to him, but he chose not to accept it and was satisfied with his state (MB). Given the structure of the statement, the first meaning is more correct (T). Similarly, the term '*iḥtiqāran*' means that the world and its material wealth is considered of little value in the sight of the Almighty.

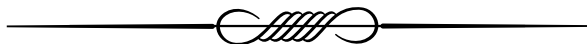
A tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq states that when Allāh wishes good for a servant, He makes him abstemious in this world, and learned in religion, and He shows him the world's flaws. Whoever is granted this has truly been given the best of this world and the next (MB). Thus the Noble Prophet *turned away from this world with his heart, banished thoughts about it from his mind, and liked its beauty to remain hidden from his sight so that he would neither take from it any apparel nor hope to stay in it.* Indeed, from the *sīrah* of the Prophet we see how he lived a very simple life, eating plain food and often going hungry when no food was available. Even when he later gained control over great treasures, he would spend it all on the needy. Imām 'Alī and the subsequent Imāms also followed in the Prophet's footsteps and lived very simple lives (Z). Imām al-Sajjād is reported to have said that there is no better deed, after attaining cognizance of Allāh and of His Prophet, than despising the adornments of this world. Indeed there are many branches of sin, all of which have one common source which is love of this world (T). Having highlighted the abstemiousness and *zuhd* of the Noble Messenger, the Imām then mentions how he carried out his duty of conveying the message of Allāh to the people. The phrase '*ballagha 'an rabbihi mu'dhiran*' means that he conveyed the message in a manner that left people with no possible excuse for disbelief (M), so that they cannot claim, on the Day of Judgment, that they were ignorant or unaware

of it. Furthermore, he *advised his people by warning them* of the chastisement of Allāh for those who are defiant and sinful (T). He gave glad tidings of Paradise to those who listened and obeyed (Z), and cautioned them against sin and disobedience. The phrase '*wa khawwafa min al-nāri muḥadhdhiran*' is not present in all manuscripts and has hence not been included in some commentaries (MB, T).

12 In the final part of this sermon, as recorded by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, Imām 'Alī mentions the status of the Ahl al-Bayt. Some commentators say that what is mentioned here is not connected to what precedes it, thereby implying that something before it has been omitted (I). His saying *we are the [descendants of the] tree of prophethood* is a reminder of what the Messenger of Allāh had himself said about Imām 'Alī and his Ahl al-Bayt on numerous instances. On one occasion, the Prophet said, "I and 'Alī are from a single tree, whereas all other people are from different trees." Regarding his beloved daughter, the Prophet said, "Fāṭimah is part of me. Whoever pleases her has pleased me and whoever angers her has angered me." And he also said that his two grandsons al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn were from him (T). The Ahl al-Bayt were *the locus of the [divine] Message* ('*maḥaṭṭu al-risālah*'), but that does not mean they were all recipients of divine revelation as some extremists (*ghulāt*) wrongly claimed. Rather, it means that it was in their household where revelation came down, to one of the members thereof, namely the Messenger of Allāh. Alternatively, it could mean that whatever was revealed to the Noble Prophet was taught and passed down to the Imām and then to the Infallibles among his progeny. And there are many narrations that confirm this (MB). The phrase '*mukhtalaf al-malā'ikah*' means the place where angels regularly descend (Z). Though they did not receive any revelation, the Ahl al-Bayt were indeed visited by angels on different occasions, as evidenced by a number of reports and traditions (T). However, here the phrase could refer to the household in which the Messenger of Allāh was present (I).

Another quality of the Ahl al-Bayt is that they are *the sources of knowledge and the wellsprings of wisdom*. This is because they are the heirs of the knowledge of the Prophet, and the protectors of the Book and the Sunnah. The difference between sources or mines ('*ma'ādin*') and wellsprings ('*yanābir*') is that people have to go towards the mines in order to acquire something from them, whereas wellsprings flow forth towards those who benefit therefrom (N). In the end, the Imām promises that *mercy awaits our supporter and lover*, and indeed this is

evident from the prophetic statement, “O ‘Alī, a [true] believer can never hate you, and a hypocrite can never love you.” If love for him is a sign of belief, then loving him and supporting him would surely make one deserving of divine mercy (Z). He then says that *chastisement awaits our enemy and hater*, who cannot be a believer, as stated by the Messenger of Allāh, so he is either a hypocrite or an infidel. In either case, chastisement awaits him. By telling them what to expect, the Imām informs them of something that will certainly transpire, for a person only awaits that which he is sure will come to pass (MB). Some understand this last statement as a way of inspiring his followers to support him and assuring them that their enemies will face the wrath of Allāh (M).



ON THE PILLARS OF FAITH

AL-ISLAM

- 1 Verily, the best means for those who seek proximity to Allāh, the Glorified, is belief in Him and His Messenger, and striving in His way, for it is indeed the apogee of Islam; and sincere declaration of His oneness, for it is [in] the intrinsic nature [of man]; and establishment of prayer, for it is the [pillar of] religion; and giving of alms-tax, for it is a compulsory obligation; and fasting in the month of Ramaḍān, for it is a shield against punishment; and going for pilgrimage to the House [of Allāh] and visiting it, for these two acts banish poverty and wash away sins; and maintaining ties of kinship, for it multiplies wealth and prolongs life; and giving charity secretly, for it covers up wrongdoings; and giving charity openly, for it wards off a horrible death; and doing good [to others], for it saves one from falling into disgrace.
- 2 Rush forth in the remembrance of Allāh, for it is the best remembrance; and desire that which He has promised the Godwary, for His promise is the truest promise; and follow the way of your Prophet, for it is the best course; and emulate his practice, for it is the most rightly guiding of all practices.

الإسلام

- ١ إِنَّ أَفْضَلَ مَا تَوَسَّلَ بِهِ الْمُتَوَسِّلُونَ إِلَى اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ: الْإِيمَانُ بِهِ وَبِرَسُولِهِ، وَالْجِهَادُ فِي سَبِيلِهِ فَإِنَّهُ ذِرْوَةُ الْإِسْلَامِ، وَكَلِمَةُ الْإِحْلَاصِ فَإِنَّهَا الْفِطْرَةُ، وَإِقَامُ الصَّلَاةِ فَإِنَّهَا الْمِلَّةُ، وَإِيتَاءُ الزَّكَاةِ فَإِنَّهَا فَرِيضَةٌ وَاجِبَةٌ، وَصَوْمُ شَهْرِ رَمَضَانَ فَإِنَّهُ جُنَّةٌ مِنَ الْعِقَابِ، وَحُجُّ الْبَيْتِ وَاعْتِمَارُهُ فَإِنَّهُمَا يَنْفِيَانِ الْفَقْرَ وَيَرْحَضَانِ الذَّنْبَ، وَصِلَةُ الرَّحِمِ فَإِنَّهَا مَثْرَاءٌ فِي الْمَالِ وَمَنْسَأَةٌ فِي الْأَجَلِ، وَصَدَقَةُ السِّرِّ فَإِنَّهَا تُكَفِّرُ الْخَطِيئَةَ، وَصَدَقَةُ الْعَلَانِيَةِ فَإِنَّهَا تَدْفَعُ مِيتَةَ الشُّوْءِ، وَصَنَائِعُ الْمَعْرُوفِ فَإِنَّهَا تَقِي مَصَارِعَ الْهَوَانِ.
- ٢ أَفِيضُوا فِي ذِكْرِ اللَّهِ فَإِنَّهُ أَحْسَنُ الذِّكْرِ، وَارْغَبُوا فِيَمَا وَعَدَ الْمُتَّقِينَ فَإِنَّ وَعْدَهُ أَصْدَقُ الْوَعْدِ، وَاقْتَدُوا بِهَدْيِ نَبِيِّكُمْ فَإِنَّهُ أَفْضَلُ الْهَدْيِ، وَاسْتَوْا بِسُنَّتِهِ فَإِنَّهَا أَهْدَى السُّنَنِ.

MERITS OF THE QUR'ĀN

3 Learn the Qur'ān, for it is the best of discourses; and acquire a deep understanding of it, for it is the spring garden of hearts; and heal yourselves with its light, as it is a cure for the chests; and recite it well, for it is the most beneficial of narratives. Verily the scholar who acts contrary to his knowledge is like the confounded ignoramus who does not recover from his ignorance; rather, the argument against him is stronger, regret is more incumbent for him, and he is more blameworthy before Allāh.

فضل القرآن

٣ وَتَعَلَّمُوا الْقُرْآنَ فَإِنَّهُ أَحْسَنُ الْحَدِيثِ، وَتَفَقَّهُوا فِيهِ فَإِنَّهُ رِبْعُ الْقُلُوبِ، وَاسْتَشْفُوا بِنُورِهِ فَإِنَّهُ شِفَاءُ الصُّدُورِ، وَأَحْسِنُوا تِلَاوَتَهُ فَإِنَّهُ أَنْفَعُ الْقَصَصِ. وَإِنَّ الْعَالِمَ الْعَامِلَ بِغَيْرِ عِلْمِهِ كَالْجَاهِلِ الْحَائِرِ الَّذِي لَا يَسْتَفِيقُ مِنْ جَهْلِهِ، بَلِ الْحُجَّةُ عَلَيْهِ أَعْظَمُ وَالْحَسْرَةُ لَهُ أَلْزَمُ، وَهُوَ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَلْوَمُ.

CONTEXT

This sermon has been narrated in a number of sources that predate *Nahj al-Balāghah* such as al-Shaykh al-Ṣadūq's *Man Lā Yahḍuru al-Faqīh* and *ʿIlal al-Sharāʿi*, as well as al-Kulaynī's *al-Kāfī*, and al-Ḥarrānī's *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*. In these early sources, the oration is narrated from Abū Baṣīr, from Imām al-Bāqir who quotes it as one of the statements of Imām ʿAlī. Some sources also quote it from the early narrator al-Ḥusayn ibn Saʿīd al-Ahwāzī (author of the well-known works *Kitāb al-Zuhd*, and *Kitāb al-Muʾmin*). These sources narrate the sermon with slight variation in wording. For instance, the version found in *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl* starts with the phrase, *ʿal-ḥamdu lillāhi fāṭir al-khalq wa khāliq al-iṣbāḥ* (N). In some sources this oration has been referred to by the name *ʿal-Dībāj* (lit. the decorated tapestry) but one commentator says that since there is no mention of this term within the sermon itself, it would perhaps be more appropriate to call it *ʿal-Wasilah* (T). The first part of this sermon has been attributed to the Noble Prophet by some historians, but that is quite normal as most of the teachings we have from Imām ʿAlī are based on what the Prophet had taught him. Unfortunately, we do not have details about the place and time when this sermon was delivered by the Imām.

However, given its general purport, lack of a detailed context does not lead to problems in understanding what was said by the Imām.

COMMENTARY

1 The goal of this oration is to guide people towards that by which they can attain closeness to Allāh. The *best means for those who seek proximity to Allāh* ('*mā tawassala bihi al-mutawassilūn*'), is *belief in Him and His Messenger*. The Imām mentions this first, before anything else, because it is the foundation and cornerstone. In this instance, it simply means conviction and faith, since attestation and action is mentioned later, separately (MB). Everything by which one draws closer to another is referred to as a *wasīlah* and here the Imām is referring to that which draws one closer to Allāh, His good pleasure, and His reward (Z). Since belief (*īmān*) is the primary foundation, the ten things the Imām subsequently mentions are considered branches thereof (R). He says that *striving in His way* ('*al-jihādu fī sabīlihi*') is the *apogee of Islam*. The term '*dhirwah*' literally means the uppermost part of a camel's hump, and here it figuratively describes the highest part or summit of Islam. Some commentators suggest that this is because it is only when one has true conviction that he would hasten towards meeting his Lord without fear of death, and strive against the enemy. That is why it has been mentioned even before such important actions as ritual prayer (*ṣalāh*) (M). Others say that *jihād* has been mentioned first because it entails repelling or forestalling any harm (*daf' al-ḍarar*), and this is a prerequisite that has to be taken care of before undertaking any other action (I). The next thing which is a *wasīlah* to the proximity of Allāh is the *sincere declaration of His oneness*. The phrase '*kalimat al-ikhhlās*', which literally means the testament of sincerity, refers to the testimony of faith (*shahādah*) and belief in His oneness, which the Imām says is part of the *intrinsic nature* ('*al-fītrah*') of human beings (N). Indeed *tawḥīd* is what all the Prophets called their people to, and it is not merely the verbal utterance thereof which is meant here. Rather, it refers to that which makes one incline to the worship of Allāh, and to reliance on Him alone, not on wealth or status, nor on lineage or intelligence and the like (Z).

The next *wasīlah* to attain nearness to Allāh is the establishment of prayer, for it is the pillar of religion. The term '*al-millah*' here refers to that which Allāh has legislated for His servants and taught through His Prophets, so that they may attain

His proximity thereby. Due to the centrality of prayer in Islam, the word '*al-millah*' has been employed here with the article '*al*', to emphasize its importance. Indeed, the Noble Messenger said that prayer (*ṣalāh*) is the pillar of religion (MB). The fifth thing mentioned by Imām 'Alī is giving *zakāt*, which he calls a compulsory obligation ('*farīdatun wājibah*'). Some commentators have understood the term *farīdah* to mean a specific portion of one's wealth that belongs to the deserving among the needy (R). Based on this, the phrase '*innahā farīdatun wājibah*' would mean that it (*zakāt*) is a portion of wealth that one must set aside and give to the needy (I). Indeed, all the acts of worship mentioned by the Imām are obligatory, so mentioning this quality about *zakāt* in particular is only to emphasize its importance (N). Sixth is the fast of the month of Ramaḍān, which the Imām describes as a *shield against punishment* ('*junnatun min al-ʿiqāb*'). Some say that this particular benefit has been mentioned for fasting because it is the strongest protection one can have against the Fire of Hell. Indeed, Satan beguiles the people through lowly desires (*shahawāt*), and these desires are heightened through eating and drinking, just as they are weakened through hunger. Hence, when one remains hungry during his fast, he weakens his base inclinations and thereby avoids many of the sins he would otherwise have committed. In this way he is protected from divine punishment (MB). Next the Imām says that pilgrimage (*ḥajj*) to the Ka'bah and visiting it (*ʿumrah*) are two acts that *banish poverty and wash away sins*. This points to both the material and spiritual benefits of the major and minor pilgrimage to Makkah. It washes away one's sins by bringing about a transformation in the sincere pilgrim, after he seeks repentance for his sins. Traditions tell us that one who comes back from a successful pilgrimage is like a newborn child, meaning he is without sin. Likewise, pilgrimage alleviates poverty and financial difficulty because while they gather for pilgrimage, Muslims meet their brothers in faith from different parts of the world and establish contacts that may prove useful for future business and mutual economic benefit (N). Furthermore, there are many traditions from the Infallibles that promise those who undertake the pilgrimage that they will not suffer from poverty (T).

Maintaining ties of kinship is the next thing that the Imām mentions, saying that *it multiplies wealth and prolongs life*. The multiplication of wealth is linked to the responsibility undertaken by an individual to assist his kin with his wealth, and since it is Allāh who sustains all creatures, He provides a person with extra wealth to enable him to assist his kin economically (M). At the same time, if one keeps

ties with his kin and is good to them, they can be a cause of his gaining more wealth through their support. *Ṣilat al-raḥim* also prolongs life in at least two ways, the first being that the support accorded by relatives protects one from his enemies who could harm him or even kill him. Secondly, when one is close to his relatives, they pray for him and their supplications for his long life may act as a means of the delaying of his death (MB). The next *wasīlah* is giving charity, and the Imām mentions two types of giving: that which is done secretly, and that which is done publicly. He says that giving charity secretly *covers up wrongdoings*, while giving charity openly *wards off a horrible death* (*'tadfa'u mītata al-sū'*). The former type of charity is considered to be more sincere, and it protects the reputation and respect of the recipients. As such, it brings about greater blessings and reward. A famous tradition from the Prophet says that giving charity in secret extinguishes the wrath of God (T). Giving publicly, on the other hand, has the added benefit of encouraging others to give as well, and gaining the prayers of others for the donor (N). The *horrible death* mentioned here includes things like drowning or being burned alive, or dying in a tragic accident, and many other narrations also reiterate that giving charity publicly saves one from such kinds of death (MB). Finally, Amīr al-Mu'minīn says that doing good to others *saves one from falling into disgrace*. The phrase *'ṣanā'i'u al-marūf* means acts of virtue, especially showing kindness and doing favours to others. And mentioning this here is akin to presenting a general summary after speaking of specific cases (*dhikr al-ām bād al-khāṣ*). Indeed, all the previous acts that are mentioned in this section are good deeds. Of course, it is also likely that in this instance, *'ṣanā'i'u al-marūf* refers specifically to being kind to others and assisting them (N). By doing this, one wins the hearts of the people and this then acts as a protection for him against disgrace and dishonour (MB).

2 After mentioning some of the best means of gaining proximity to Allāh, the Imām follows it up with an instruction that would result in the perfection of these actions (MB). He says *rush forth in the remembrance of Allāh, for it is the best remembrance*. The imperative *'afīḍū* comes from *ifāḍah*, which literally means flowing forth in abundance, and here it connotes copious and regular remembrance of Allāh (N). It is described as *'aḥsanu al-dhikr* because it leads to positive outcomes in both this world and the next (MB). A tradition from the Noble Prophet states that Allāh loves the one who remembers Him often, and whoever does this gains freedom from two things: from hellfire and from hypocrisy (T). Scholars tell us there are three kinds of *dhikr*: the verbal, outward *dhikr*, the inward *dhikr* in the

heart, and the highest form of *dhikr* which comes from one's soul and the very fibre of his being. Since the Imām's words are general, they encompass all three forms here (S). The Imām then tells the people to yearn for what Allāh has promised the Godwary, *for His promise is the truest promise*. That which the Godwary have been promised is mentioned in the Qur'ān, in a number of verses, such as: *Verily for the Godwary there is triumph, gardens and vineyards, comely maidens well-matched in age, and a brimming cup. Neither shall they hear any idle talk therein nor lying – a reward from your Lord, a gift commensurate* (Q78:31-36) (T). Lastly, in this section, Amīr al-Mu'minīn advises his listeners to follow the way of the Prophet, as that is the best course, and to emulate his practice, for it is *the most rightly guiding of all practices* ('*ahdā al-sunan*'). Indeed, as the greatest of all Prophets, his *sīrah* would be the greatest *sīrah*, and hence the most worthy of emulation (MB).

3 The Imām then addresses the importance of the Book of Allāh, and urges the people to learn the Qur'ān since it is *the best of discourses*. This means it is the best speech, because it is ever-new and relevant (MB). Learning the Qur'ān could mean memorizing it, thereby learning it by heart, and then acting upon it. A tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq states that one who commits the Qur'ān to memory and acts upon it will be with the noble and virtuous envoys [among the angels] in Paradise (T). The second stage, after having learned the Qur'ān, is to *acquire a deep understanding of it, for it is the spring garden of hearts*. The phrase '*tafaqqahū fihī*' means reflect upon its contents, and it is described as a *spring garden* to figuratively depict how different kinds of secrets and mysteries, subtle allusions, noble sciences, and lofty teachings are present in it, just as a spring garden contains a variety of flowers that bring delight to the eyes (MB). The third stage is to *heal yourselves with its light, as it is a cure for the chests*. It is a spiritual remedy for inner maladies such as bad character, but also a cure for outward, physical illnesses as well. Traditions tell us of how people would at times come to the Prophet complaining of headaches or other ailments, and he would instruct them to recite certain verses or sūrahs of the Qur'ān (T). The fourth and final stage is to *recite it well, for it is the most beneficial of narratives*. By reciting it well, the benefits of the Qur'ān become apparent for the people, and the hearts incline towards it. Narrations describe to us what is meant by reciting the Qur'ān well, telling us that it should neither be recited like rhythmic poetry, nor like unconnected prose. It should likewise not be recited in the tone that is common among the immoral sinners, nor should be it sung like a musical tune. Rather, it should be recited at a moderate pace the way

the virtuous recite it, with pauses for reflection and contemplation, and with a sad, yet beautiful voice (T). With these four directives, the Imām summarizes the responsibility of believers towards the Glorious Qurʾān.

In the end, the Imām speaks about the learned person who does not act on his knowledge. He likens such a person to *the confounded ignoramus who does not recover from his ignorance*. The phrase ‘*al-jāhil al-ḥāʾir*’ refers to one who is ignorant and perplexed (*mutaḥayyir*), and in one version it is narrated as ‘*al-jāhil al-jāʾir*’ which means the ignorant and unjust one, or he who transgresses the bounds (R). The verb ‘*yastafiq*’ means to wake up or recover consciousness, and is sometimes used to describe returning to a state of sanity (T). Interestingly, the comparison made by the Imām here is not simply to an ignorant person. Rather, he compares the learned who does not act on his knowledge to a confounded ignoramus who can never recover from his ignorance, which is even worse. That is because he deliberately went against what he knew to be right, and as a result he was deprived of divine guidance (N). The case against such an individual is stronger (‘*al-ḥujjatu ʿalayhi aʿzam*’) because he has no excuse for acting the way he does (MB). Some commentators have interpreted the phrase ‘*al-ḥasratu lahu alzam*’ to mean that his remorse will last longer because despite having access to that which could lead to his felicity, he did not use it and ended up wretched (N). Indeed, such individuals are *more blameworthy before Allāh*, and according to some traditions, they will be punished so severely in Hell that the other denizens will be disturbed by the foul stench they emit (Z). And Imām al-Ṣādiq is reported to have said that the ignorant person is forgiven seventy sins before a single sin of a knowledgeable person is forgiven (N).



IMPUGNING THIS WORLD

1 Now then, verily I caution you against this world, for it is sweet and green, surrounded by desires, endearing itself with the evanescent, exciting wonder with a trifling, adorning itself with hopes, and embellishing itself with deception. Its joys do not last and there is no safeguard from its afflictions. It is very deceitful and harmful, fickle and short-lived, waning and perishing, devouring and destructive. When it reaches the limit of the desire of those who covet it and are pleased with it, it goes no further than what Allāh, the Glorified, describes: *[It is] like water We send down from the sky so it gets mingled with the vegetation of the earth. Then it becomes dry chaff, scattered by the winds. And Allāh holds absolute power over all things.*

2 Never was a person joyful due to this world but that it subsequently brought him tears [of sorrow], never did he attain its comfort afore but that it gave him adversity abaft, and never did the light rain of ease drizzle on him in it but that the raincloud of tribulation [also] poured upon him. Unsurprisingly, if in the morning it was his supporter, in the evening it became an unrecognizable stranger. If one side of it

۱ أَمَّا بَعْدُ، فَإِنِّي أُحَذِّرُكُمْ الدُّنْيَا، فَإِنَّهَا
حُلْوَةٌ خَضِرَةٌ، حَفَّتْ بِالشَّهَوَاتِ،
وَتَحَبَّبَتْ بِالْعَاجِلَةِ، وَرَاقَتْ بِالْقَلِيلِ،
وَتَحَلَّتْ بِالْأَمَالِ، وَتَزَيَّنَتْ بِالْعُزُورِ،
لَا تَدُومُ حَبْرَتُهَا، وَلَا تُؤْمِنُ فَجَعَتُهَا،
غَرَارَةٌ ضَرَارَةٌ، حَائِلَةٌ زَائِلَةٌ، نَافِدَةٌ
بَائِدَةٌ، أَكَالَةٌ غَوَالَةٌ؛ لَا تَعْدُو إِذَا
تَنَاهَتْ إِلَى أُمِّيَّةِ أَهْلِ الرَّغْبَةِ فِيهَا
وَالرِّضَاءِ بِهَا أَنْ تَكُونَ كَمَا قَالَ اللَّهُ
سُبْحَانَهُ: «كَمَا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ
فَاخْتَلَطَ بِهِ نَبَاتُ الْأَرْضِ فَأَصْبَحَ
هَشِيمًا تَذْرُوهُ الرِّيَّاحُ وَكَانَ اللَّهُ عَلَى
كُلِّ شَيْءٍ مُقْتَدِرًا».

۲ لَمْ يَكُنْ امْرُؤٌ مِنْهَا فِي حَبْرَةٍ إِلَّا
أَغْقَبَتْهُ بَعْدَهَا غَبْرَةٌ، وَلَمْ يَلْقَ مِنْ
سَرَائِهَا بَطْنًا إِلَّا مَنَحَتْهُ مِنْ
ضَرَائِهَا ظَهْرًا، وَلَمْ تَطْلُقْ فِيهَا
دِيمَةٌ رَحَاءً إِلَّا هَتَّتْ عَلَيْهِ مُرْنَةً
بَلَاءً! وَحَرِيٌّ إِذَا أَصْبَحَتْ لَهُ
مُنْتَصِرَةٌ أَنْ تُنْسِيَ لَهُ مُتَنَكِّرَةً،
وَأِنْ جَانِبٌ مِنْهَا اعْدُوْدَبَ

becomes pleasant and sweet, another turns bitter and blighted! No individual attains any of its prosperity that he seeks but that he is burdened by the hardship of its calamities, and he passes not of it an evening under the wing of security but that in the morning he is on the wingtips of fear. It is very deceitful, and all that is in it is deception. It is perishing and all who are upon it perish. There is no good in anything from its provisions except Godwariness.

وَإِخْلَوْلَى، أَمَرَ مِنْهَا جَانِبٌ
فَأَوْبَى! لَا يَنَالُ امْرُؤٌ مِنْ
غَضَارَتِهَا رَغْبًا، إِلَّا أَزْهَقَتْهُ مِنْ
نَوَائِبِهَا تَعْبًا؛ وَلَا يُمَسِّي مِنْهَا فِي
جَنَاحِ أَمْنٍ، إِلَّا أَصْبَحَ عَلَى
قَوَادِمِ خَوْفٍ. غَرَارَةٌ غُرُورٌ مَا
فِيهَا، فَانِيَةٌ فَإِنْ مَنْ عَلَيْهَا، لَا
خَيْرَ فِي شَيْءٍ مِنْ أَزْوَادِهَا إِلَّا
التَّقْوَى.

CONTEXT

From the parts of this sermon that have been narrated by al-Kulaynī in *al-Kāfi*, in a tradition reported from Imām al-Bāqir, we learn that Imām ‘Alī gave this sermon in Baṣrah, right after the Battle of Jamal, in the year 36 AH. Al-Jāḥiz, in his *al-Bayān*, narrates this sermon and attributes it to the Khārijite Qaṭarī ibn al-Fujā’ah (d. 79 AH), while most other early narrators attribute it to Amīr al-Mu’minīn (‘a). One commentator opines that it is possible Qaṭarī took the Imām’s sermon from the latter’s companions who had heard it, and then delivered it as his own (I). Following al-Jāḥiz, Ibn ‘Abd Rabbih also attributed it to Qaṭarī in his *al-‘Iqd al-Farīd*, and this kind of misattribution by these two authors was quite common, as they falsely claimed that the words of Imām ‘Alī had been spoken by other individuals, such as Ma’mūn al-‘Abbāsī and others (T). It is noteworthy that this particular oration has been narrated in a number of sources that predate *Nahj al-Balāghah*, as well as some that were written after it, with slight variance in wording. These include *al-Mūniq* by al-Marzbānī, al-Ḥarrānī’s *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, al-Qāḍī al-Quḍā’ī’s *al-Dustūr*, and Ibn Ṭalḥah al-Shāfi’ī’s *Maṭālib al-Su’ūl*, which al-Majlisī quotes in *Biḥār al-Anwār* (MB). Ibn Athīr also mentions some of the difficult words of this sermon in his *al-Nihāyah*, but his version is quite different in many instances (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening statement of this sermon is a warning. The Imām caution the people against this world (*‘uḥadhdhirukum al-dunyā’*). Some understand this as a warning against that which has been forbidden of this world (Z). Others take it as a general word of caution, the way one would inform a person of a lurking enemy or a dangerous predator (T). Of course, by *‘al-dunyā’* the Imām does not mean the sky, land, rivers, mountains, and so on, since these are that natural features of this world. Rather, he is referring to aspects of worldly life that cause one to become heedless of his Creator and the purpose of his life (S). The reasons for this warning are then expounded upon. He says this world is *sweet and green* (*‘ḥulwātun khaḍīrah’*), thereby alluding to that which causes one to be enticed and attracted to it (MB). These qualities are linked to the senses of taste and sight, and include everything that brings pleasure to an individual when it is consumed or observed. Some suggest that these two senses give rise to the most heightened forms of delight in human beings, and hence they have been mentioned here (M). Then, continuing his description of this dangerous world, the Imām says that it is *surrounded by desires, endearing itself with the evanescent, exciting wonder with a trifling, adorning itself with hopes, and embellishing itself with deception*. The phrase *‘taḥabbabat bi al-‘ājilah’* means that it makes the ephemeral and perishing beloved to the people, or it endears them through pleasures which are immediate but short-lived (MB). *‘Rāqat bi al-qalīl’* means that its few insignificant wares are adorned in such a way that the hearts of worldly people are attracted to them, despite their triviality. Likewise, its hopes are adorned and embellished, since they are not actually real. Rather, they are based on whims and delusions (N).

The Imām then uses rhyming prose, with four pairs of adjectives, to describe this world. He calls it *deceitful and harmful* (*‘gharrāratun ḡarrārah’*), *fickle and short-lived* (*‘ḥāīlatun zāīlah’*), *waning and perishing* (*‘nāfidatun bāīdah’*), *devouring and destructive* (*‘akkālatun ghawwālah’*). The term *‘ghawwālah’* connotes that which assails one suddenly, from an unexpected place (T). This final description uses the metaphor of a predator that hides in the grass, hunting its prey. When it finds the right opportunity, it pounces upon the unsuspecting creature and devours it – and that is how the world treats its inhabitants (MB). *When it reaches the limit of the desire of those who covet it and are pleased with it, it goes no further than what Allāh, the Glorified describes in the verse: [It is] like water We send down from the sky so it gets mingled with the vegetation of the earth. Then it*

becomes dry chaff, scattered by the winds. And Allāh holds absolute power over all things (Q18:45). This means that even if the world were to show its brightest colours to those who seek it, and they attain whatever they aspire thereof, it will still be nothing more than embellishment. And before long, it will all be taken away from them, as though they never possessed any of it in the first place. That is the similitude which is mentioned in the verse quoted by the Imām here (M).

2 Continuing his description of this *dunyā*, the Imām notes that nothing in it ever makes a person joyful but that it subsequently brings him to tears. He uses *tears* as the opposite of *joy* because weeping is mostly caused by sorrow (R). Use of the verb '*ʿaqabathu*' means that all the happiness experienced in this world is sure to be followed by sadness (MB). Never does one attain *its comfort afore* ('*sarrāihā baṭnan*') but that it gives him *adversity abaft* ('*ḍarrāihā ṣaḥran*'). The reason why comfort, ease, and happiness have been linked to the fore (*baṭn*, lit. belly), is that it is when this world turns to face someone with its boons that he gains comfort and joy. And usually when one comes towards a person, his front, and belly, is visible to him. Conversely, its adversity arrives when it turns its back on someone, and usually when one turns away, his back (*ṣaḥr*) becomes visible to him (T). This statement echoes the one preceding it, and means that when the world turns towards anyone with its bounties and comforts, it will soon turn away from him, leaving him with adversity and affliction. The term '*manaḥathu*' means it (i.e. the world) grants him, and here it has been used sarcastically to refer to how the individual will be made to face hardship after comfort. This is similar to the verse that states: *So give them glad tidings of a painful punishment* (Q3:21), when it is clearly not something to be gladdened by (MB). The Imām reiterates this by saying that *never did the light rain of ease drizzle on him in it but that the raincloud of tribulation poured upon him*. '*Dīmatu rakhā*' refers to a light rain that lasts and persists, and Imām 'Alī is once more highlighting how the state of this world keeps changing, so one who enjoys well-being and prosperity today will have to face adversity tomorrow. *Unsurprisingly, if in the morning it was his supporter, in the evening it became an unrecognizable stranger*. The term '*ḥariyyun*' has been rendered as *unsurprisingly*, and it means that it is befitting and expected. One says something is unsurprising when what is expected or anticipated happens (I).

The Imām further states that if one side of this world *becomes pleasant and sweet*, another *turns bitter and blighted!* Hence pure, unending happiness can never be attained in this world by anyone, just as endless, utter sorrow does not

exist herein. *No individual attains any of its prosperity that he seeks but that he is burdened by the hardship of its calamities, and he passes not of it an evening under the wing of security but that in the morning he is on the wingtips of fear.* The term ‘*qawādim*’ refers to the pinion or tips of a bird’s wing, which consist of some feathers on the edge of the wings that are the first to fall off (T). The analogy given here again symbolizes the fickleness and quickly altering state of this world. Like its bounties, its security also does not last, and quickly turns into fear (MB). Then he says that this world is *very deceitful, and all that is in it is deception* (‘*gharrāratur ghurūrun mā fihā*’), meaning its illusory gain gives no real benefit and actually causes harm (Z). *It is perishing and all who are upon it perish* so it is futile to become attached to it, since both the world and those who live in it will pass away (MB). The only thing from its provisions that is good is Godwariness, because that is the goal of creation. Indeed, only through *taqwā* can a human being attain nearness to the Almighty. The Imām mentions *taqwā* as one of the provisions of this world because it is only in this *dunyā* that one can attain it. That is why believers have been told it is the best provision (*khayr al-zād*) which they could acquire (Q2:197) (M).

3 This world is such, says the Imām, that *whoever takes less from it gains much of what safeguards him*, meaning that abstemiousness and lack of interest in worldly gains and pleasure results in greater security from punishment and negative outcomes (M). Similar statements from the Imām also emphasize the benefit of contentment with what suffices, and not seeking more than what one needs of this world (Z). Indeed, *whoever amasses plenty of it acquires much of what ruins him, and it departs from him in a short while*. That is because this world is like sea-water, the more one drinks of it, the more thirsty he becomes; until, in the end, it kills him (T). The common outcomes of attachment to this world are then highlighted by the Imām through a series of rhetorical questions. *How many of those who relied upon it has it distressed* with different forms of sadness (MB), and affliction. Like those who relied upon its good health before being struck by a terminal illness, or upon its wealth before calamity brought about loss (Z). How many who *felt tranquil* with this world has it *thrown to the ground* when they were least expecting it. About the Marwānid ruler Sulaymān ibn ‘Abd al-Malik, it is reported that he once wore his regal attire and a bright green turban. Then he looked at himself in the mirror and remarked, “By Allāh, I am a youthful king [with many years ahead]!” Yet he died no more than a week later (N). Thus we note how

3 Whoever takes less from it gains much of what safeguards him, and whoever amasses plenty of it acquires much of what ruins him, and it departs from him in a short while. How many of those who relied upon it has it distressed, and [how many] who felt tranquil with it has it thrown to the ground, and [how many] who enjoyed greatness has it humbled, and [how many] who possessed hauteur has it abased! Its authority is [always] shifting, its life is turbid, its pleasantness is bitter, its sweetness is like myrrh, its foods are poisons, and its ropes are ragged. Its living are exposed to death, its healthy are exposed to ailment, its dominion is despoiled, its mighty are vanquished, its affluent are stricken [by misfortune], and its neighbours are plundered.

4 Are you not in the dwellings of those before you, who lived longer, left more lasting traces, had farther aspirations, were greater in number, and had larger armies! How dedicated they were in their devotion to the world, and how great was their preference for it! Then they departed from it with neither provision to sustain them nor mounts to carry them across. Did you ever hear that the world ransomed itself for them? Or supported them in any way? Or afforded them good company? Rather, it imposed on them afflictions, constrained them with catastrophes,

۳ مَنْ أَقَلَّ مِنْهَا اسْتَكْتَرَّ مِمَّا يُؤْمِنُهُ،
وَمَنْ اسْتَكْتَرَّ مِنْهَا اسْتَكْتَرَّ مِمَّا
يُؤْيِقُهُ، وَزَالَ عَمَّا قَلِيلٍ عَنْهُ. كَمْ
مِنْ وَائِقٍ بِهَا قَدْ فَجَعْتُهُ وَذِي
طُمَأْنِينَةٍ إِلَيْهَا قَدْ صَرَعْتُهُ، وَذِي
أُتْبَهَةٍ قَدْ جَعَلْتُهُ حَقِيرًا، وَذِي
نَحْوَةٍ قَدْ رَدَّتُهُ ذَلِيلًا! سُلْطَانُهَا
دَوَّلٌ، وَعَيْشُهَا زَنَقٌ، وَعَذْبُهَا
أَجَاجٌ، وَخُلُوقُهَا صَبِرٌ، وَغِدَاؤُهَا
سِمَامٌ، وَأَسْبَابُهَا رِمَامٌ، حَيْثُهَا
بِعَرَضٍ مَوْتٌ، وَصَحِيحُهَا
بِعَرَضٍ سُقْمٌ، مُلْكُهَا مَسْلُوبٌ،
وَعَزِيزُهَا مَغْلُوبٌ، وَمَوْفُورُهَا
مَنْكُوبٌ، وَجَارُهَا مَحْزُوبٌ.

۴ أَلَسْتُمْ فِي مَسَاكِينِ مَنْ كَانَ قَبْلَكُمْ
أَطْوَلْ أَعْمَارًا، وَأَبْقَى آثَارًا، وَأَبْعَدْ
آمَالًا، وَأَعَدَّ عَدِيدًا، وَأَكْثَفْ
جُنُودًا! تَعَبَّدُوا لِلدُّنْيَا أَيَّ تَعَبْدٍ،
وَأَتَزَوَّاهَا أَيَّ إِيْتَارٍ، ثُمَّ طَعْنُوا
عَنْهَا بِغَيْرِ رَادٍ مُبْلَغٍ وَلَا ظَهَرٍ قَاطِعٍ.
فَهَلْ بَلَغَكُمْ أَنَّ الدُّنْيَا سَحَتْ لَهُمْ
نَفْسًا بِفِدْيَةٍ؟ أَوْ أَعَانَتْهُمْ بِمُؤْنَةٍ؟ أَوْ
أَحْسَنْتْ لَهُمْ صُحْبَةً؟ بَلْ أَرْهَقَتْهُمْ
بِالْفَوَادِحِ، وَأَوْهَقَتْهُمْ بِالْفَوَارِعِ،

abased them with calamities, rubbed their noses in the dust, trampled upon them with hooves, and assisted against them twists of fate. You have seen how it changed for those who submitted to it, preferred it, and clung to it, when they departed from it for the eternal separation. Did it provide them aught but starvation? Or did it make them dwell but in narrow spaces? Or did it illuminate for them [with] anything but darkness? Or did it cause anything to ensue for them but regret? Is this what you prefer? Or is it what you feel assured about? Or is it what you covet? How evil an abode it is for one who does not distrust it, and does not fear it while [residing] in it.

وَصَغَصَعَتْهُمْ بِالنَّوَائِبِ، وَعَفَّرَتْهُمْ
لِلْمَنَاحِرِ، وَوَطَّئَتْهُمْ بِالْمَنَاسِمِ،
وَأَعَانَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ رَيْبَ الْمَثُونِ، فَقَدْ
رَأَيْتُمْ تَنَكَّرَهَا لِمَنْ دَانَ لَهَا، وَآثَرَهَا
وَأَحْلَدَ إِلَيْهَا، حِينَ ظَعَنُوا عَنْهَا
لِفِرَاقِ الْأَبَدِ. وَهَلْ زَوَّدَتْهُمْ إِلَّا
السَّعْبَ؟ أَوْ أَحَلَّتْهُمْ إِلَّا الضَّنْكَ؟ أَوْ
نَوَّرَتْ لَهُمْ إِلَّا الظُّلْمَةَ؟ أَوْ أَعَقَبَتْهُمْ
إِلَّا النَّدَامَةَ؟ أَفَهَذِهِ تُؤَيِّزُونَ؟ أَمْ إِلَيْهَا
تَطْمِئُونَ؟ أَمْ عَلَيْهَا تَحْرِصُونَ؟
فَبُسَّتِ الدَّارُ لِمَنْ لَمْ يَتَّهِمْهَا، وَلَمْ
يَكُنْ فِيهَا عَلَى وَجَلٍ مِنْهَا.

many *who enjoyed greatness* in this world were humbled by it, and many *who possessed hauteur* were abased. Then, all they were left with in the end was regret. When the ‘Abbāsid ruler al-Mu‘taṣim was on his death bed, after having reigned for eight years and eight months, he reportedly said, “Had I known how short my life would be, I would not have done what I did!” (T).

The power and authority that is wielded in this world keeps shifting (*‘sulṭānuhā duwwal’*), and moves from hand to hand, never remaining with a single person perpetually (Z). *Its life is turbid, its pleasantness is bitter, its sweetness is like myrrh, its foods are poisons, and its ropes are ragged.* Some commentators say that the terms *bitter* (*‘ujā’*) and *myrrh* (*‘ṣabir’*) are metaphors for ailments and afflictions that change happiness and joy into sadness and sorrow (M). Only the unlawful foods of this world are poisons (*‘simām’*), and its ropes are described as worn out and ragged (*‘rimām’*), meaning whoever clings to them will fall to his doom (Z). *Its living are exposed to death, its healthy are exposed to ailment, its dominion is despoiled, its mighty are vanquished, its affluent are stricken, and its neighbours are plundered.* Though it may seem like Amīr al-Mu‘minīn is

belabouring the point here, it is only because of the gravity of the matter that he emphasizes it in this manner. The last two phrases mean that those who are rich and have much in terms of possession, thus being considered *neighbours* of this material world, are plundered and their wealth is usurped and snatched away from them (M). Some have interpreted the term '*jāruhā*' here to mean one who is under the protection of this world. Indeed, such a person is not afforded the protection he hopes for and what he possesses is taken away from him, even if it is by death (Z).

4 Taking inspiration from the verse: *And you dwelt in the abodes of those who were unjust to themselves [before], and it was made clear to you how We dealt with them, and We gave you [many] examples* (Q14:45), the Imām asks his audience rhetorically whether their dwellings were not previously occupied by those who came before them; those *who lived longer, left more lasting traces, had farther aspirations, were greater in number, and had larger armies*. Indeed, the very early generations lived much longer. For instance, the Qur'ān states that Prophet Nūḥ preached among his people for *a thousand less fifty years* (Q29:14). Some commentators have mentioned, as examples, a number of individuals who are said to have lived a very long time, such as Luqmān the wise, who lived for three thousand years (T). Their having *left more lasting traces* and monuments can be clearly seen and witnessed, such as the pyramids in Egypt, the ancient citadels, etc. Their farther or lengthier aspirations ('*ab'ada āmālan*') is linked to their long lifespans, for the longer one lives, the farther he aspires to reach. This phrase may also connote greater resolve ('*uluw al-himam*'), and there is no doubt that they had greater determination and were more hardworking than people of the later ages. Some have interpreted the phrase '*a'adda 'adīdan*' to mean that they were more prepared and had greater provisions ('*udad*') while others suggest that it means they faced many more enemies (I). However, based on the verse Q40:82, we understand that the most correct meaning is that they were *greater in number* (T). This also fits in well with the next phrase which states that they had larger armies ('*akthafu junūdan*').

Having described their qualities, the Imām notes their deep attachment to this world: *how dedicated they were in their devotion to the world, and how great was their preference for it!* It was as if they worshipped ('*ta'abbadū*') this world as their god, and chose it over the Hereafter (MB). But in the end *they departed from it with neither provision to sustain them ('zādin muballigh')* nor mounts to carry them

across (*‘ẓahrin qāṭi’*), so they journeyed to the Hereafter with no supplies or conveyance to facilitate ease of travel (Z). They had spent all their time and energy running after the world, and thus ended up wasting the opportunity to acquire much needed provisions for the Hereafter (N). Through a series of more rhetorical questions, the Imām reminds them that this world never *ransomed itself* for anyone, or *supported them in any way*, or even *afforded them good company*. The phrase *‘sakhat lahum nafsan bi fidyah’* means generously sacrificing itself when it was time for them to depart from it, as a ransom, so that they could be spared from death. Or it could mean giving away a soul in lieu of them, so that they could live (MB). Alternatively, it simply means that the wares one acquires of this world cannot be used as a ransom to save him from death, just as it cannot help him face the painful death-pangs (*sakarāt*) or accompany him into the Hereafter (Z).

Not only does this world not afford any help or companionship to its devotees, it actively harms them. It imposes on them *burdensome afflictions* (*‘al-fawādiḥ’*), engulfs them with *catastrophes* (*‘al-qawāri’*), abases them with *calamities* (*‘al-nawāib’*), rubs their noses in the dust, tramples upon them with hooves, and assists *the twists of fate* (*‘rayb al-manūn’*) against them. In some manuscripts, instead of *‘fawādiḥ’*, the term *‘qawādiḥ’* is found, which is the plural of *qādiḥah*, meaning corruption and blight (I). One commentator notes how, interestingly, when mentioning the aid that the world did not give to its devotee, the Imām begins by stating the biggest possible thing it could have done (i.e. ransoming itself), and then moves on to smaller ways of helping, such as offering company. However, when it comes to how the world harms its folk, he starts with a smaller adversity and then moves to what is worse until he says that they get completely trampled and destroyed by the world (N). To stress this point further, Imām ‘Alī reminds the people about how this world changes for those who submit to it (*‘dāna lahā’*), prefer it (*‘ātharahā’*), and cling to it (*‘akhlada ilayhā’*), when they die and depart from it. By this the Imām is telling them to think about those whose deaths they have witnessed themselves, during their own lifetimes, which is more relatable to them than the reports of previous generations. The phrase *‘dāna lahā’* means submitting to it and obeying it (T), or being close and attached to it (MB). Once again, the Imām uses a set of rhetorical questions to evoke a sense of realization and awakening in his listeners, asking them if this world provided those who clung to it with anything other than starvation (*‘al-saghab’*), or allowed them to dwell in anything but narrow spaces (*‘al-ḍank’*), or illuminated any darkness for them, or

caused them anything but regret. Of course not. Rather, they left the bounties of this world for a dark, narrow grave, filled with remorse (Z). It made darkness their illumination and hunger their provision (MB). He then asks the people if this is the end they prefer for themselves, or feel assured about or covet. And traditions tell us that this is the end for all those who yearn for this world. One *ḥadīth qudsī* quotes the Almighty as saying to Mūsā, "Verily My righteous servants disregard [the allures of] the world to the extent of their knowledge, while the rest of the people covet it to the extent of their ignorance" (T). *How evil an abode it is for one who does not distrust it and does not fear it while residing in it*, meaning one who does not suspect its disloyalty and take precaution out of wariness of it will end up suffering (Z). Conversely, for one who is on his guard and is cautious of its deception, it is the best abode because through it he can acquire the provisions he needs for the Hereafter (MB).

A narration states that the Noble Prophet was once sad, so an angel came to him and said, "O Muḥammad! Here are the keys to the treasures of the earth. Your Lord says to you, 'Open it and take therefrom whatever you wish, for nothing will be reduced of it with Me.'" So the Messenger of Allāh said, "This world is the abode of one who has no abode, and only those who lack intellect amass [material wealth from] it." The angel said, "By He who has sent you as a Prophet with truth! I have heard these exact words from an angel who spoke them in the fourth heaven when I was entrusted with these keys!" (T).

5 In this last section of the sermon, the Imām addresses his audience with the intention of rousing them from their heedlessness by reminding them of their ultimate end in this world. *So know – and you do know – that you will surely leave it and depart from it*, and he was only reminding them of it because they were not acting as those who know they will one day depart from this world (T). He then tells the people to *take admonition in it from the history of those who said 'who is more powerful than us?'*, referring to the haughtiness of the people of 'Ād as mentioned in Q41:15. They were arrogant of their might and boasted about it. They would hew their dwellings in the mountains and had great physical strength. Yet when they defied their Lord and His chastisement descended upon them, they were all destroyed (N). *They were carried to their graves, so they are not called riders, and they were lowered therein, so they are not called guests*. In some manuscripts the added word '*al-ajdāth*' is found, in which case the translation would read, and they were lowered *into the burial pits*.

5 So know – and you do know – that you will surely leave it and depart from it. Take admonition in it from those *who said ‘who is more powerful than us?’* They were carried to their graves, so they are not called riders, and they were lowered therein, so they are not called guests. Tombs were made for them from the broad earth, and from the dust, shrouds, and from decayed bones, neighbours. These are neighbours who neither answer any caller, nor prevent any wrongdoing, nor pay heed to any lamentation. If they get rain, they do not rejoice and if they face famine, they do not despair. [They are] together yet alone, neighbours yet remote, close by yet never visiting one another, and near yet never approaching each other. [They are] forbearing, with their rancour having disappeared, and unaware, with their malice having died. Their affliction is not feared and their support is not expected. They have exchanged the surface of the earth for its belly, its broadness for narrowness, kinsfolk for estrangement, and light for darkness. Just as they came to it, so too did they leave it: barefoot and unclothed, having departed from it with their deeds towards the eternal life and the everlasting abode, as He, the Glorified, has said: *As We originated the first creation, so shall We bring it back – a promise binding upon Us. Indeed We shall do it.*

ه فَاعْلَمُوا - وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ - بِأَنَّكُمْ تَارِكُوهَا وَظَاعِنُونَ عَنْهَا، وَاتَّعْظُوا فِيهَا بِالَّذِينَ «قَالُوا مَنْ أَشَدُّ مِنَّا قُوَّةً»: حُمِلُوا إِلَى قُبُورِهِمْ فَلَا يُدْعَوْنَ رُكْبَانًا، وَأُنْزِلُوا فَلَا يُدْعَوْنَ ضَيْفَانًا؛ وَجُعِلَ لَهُمْ مِنَ الصَّفِيحِ أَجْنَانٌ، وَمِنَ الثَّرَابِ أَكْفَانٌ، وَمِنَ الرُّفَاتِ حِيرَانٌ، فَهُمْ حِيرَةٌ لَا يُجِيبُونَ دَاعِيًا، وَلَا يَمْنَعُونَ ضَيْمًا، وَلَا يُبَالُونَ مُنْدَبَةً، إِنْ حِيدُوا لَمْ يَفْرَحُوا، وَإِنْ قُحِطُوا لَمْ يَقْنَطُوا، جَمِيعٌ وَهُمْ آحَادٌ، وَحِيرَةٌ وَهُمْ أَبْعَادٌ، مُتَدَاتُونَ لَا يَتَرَاوَرُونَ، وَقَرِيبُونَ لَا يَتَقَارَبُونَ؛ حَلَمَاءٌ قَدْ ذَهَبَتْ أَصْغَانُهُمْ، وَجُهَلَاءٌ قَدْ مَاتَتْ أَحْقَادُهُمْ، لَا يُخْشَى فَجْعُهُمْ، وَلَا يُزَجَى دَفْعُهُمْ، اسْتَبَدَّلُوا بِظَهْرِ الْأَرْضِ بَطْنًا، وَبِالسَّعَةِ ضَيْقًا، وَبِالْأَهْلِ غُرْبَةً، وَبِالنُّورِ ظُلْمَةً، فَجَاءُوهَا كَمَا فَارُّوْهَا، حُفَاءَ عُرَاءَ، قَدْ ظَنَعُوا عَنْهَا بِأَعْمَالِهِمْ إِلَى الْحَيَاةِ الدَّائِمَةِ وَالْدَارِ الْبَاقِيَةِ، كَمَا قَالَ سُبْحَانَهُ: «كَمَا بَدَأْنَا أَوَّلَ خَلْقٍ نُعِيدُهُ وَعَدًا عَلَيْنَا إِنَّا كُنَّا فَاعِلِينَ».

However, since this word is missing in most manuscripts, and its absence is more apt according to the rules of eloquence, it is likely to have been written later, on the margins, and mistaken to be part of the original text (T). Some commentators say that they were not *riders* ('*rukbānan*') or *guests* ('*dīfānan*'), meaning that they were no longer referred to by terms used for the living, since among the Arabs, whenever people were on mounts, they would be referred to as *riders*, and when they came down from their mounts, they would be called *guests* (MB). However, others reject this explanation saying that those who dismounted were not always guests, and would not be generally referred to as such. Rather, the meaning intended here is that despite being carried by others on a bier, they were not called *riders*, and despite being laid to rest in the grave, they were not called *guests* (T). Their tombs were made from *the broad earth*, and from the dust, their *shrouds*, and their *neighbours* were decayed bones. The term '*al-ṣafīḥ*' literally means a large, flat stone, but here it means the surface of the earth (N). In some versions, the term '*aknān*' is found instead of '*akfān*', which would mean that their coverings were from dust. This allows for a literal and apparent reading. However, if we read it as *shrouds* the way it is recorded here, we would have to interpret the phrase figuratively to mean that the dust acts like a shroud for the dead since it covers them from all sides the way an actual shroud does, and because of how it makes contact with the whole body. Alternatively it could be because shrouds soon wear away and turn into dust (MB). As for their neighbours being decayed bones, that is simply because dead bodies are buried next to each other (Z).

Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn begins to describe the inhabitants of the graves, saying that they *are neighbours who neither answer any caller, nor prevent any wrongdoing, nor pay heed to any lamentation*. In short, they are dead and buried, so they do not perceive that which transpires above ground, be it war, drought, mourning, or anything else (Z). Until yesterday they were alive among the people, yet now nothing that happens on the earth affects them (N). *If they get rain, they do not rejoice, and if they face famine, they do not despair*. The passive verb '*jūdū*' literally means being shown generosity, and here it connotes the generosity of the sky in the form of copious rain. The dead neither show enthusiasm and joy when it rains, nor are they distressed when there is a drought (MB). They are *together yet alone, neighbours yet remote, close by yet never visiting one another, and near yet never approaching each other*. That is because though their graves are right next to each other, they are not aware of each other's presence (Z).

The feelings of malice and rancour they had for each other while alive has now disappeared, so the dead are returned to a default state of being unaware, unknowing, and hence forbearing (*‘hulamā’*). This trait is mentioned here figuratively, for one can only really be forbearing when he has the ability to show anger, which is something he lacks at this moment (MB). Some commentators understand the term *‘hulamā’* to mean intelligent and wise, and say that this trait has been used because wise people do not harbour grudges or malice for others (N). No harm or affliction is feared from the dead (*‘lā yukhshā faj’uhum’*), just as no support is expected from them, since they neither have the ability to inflict harm nor to render assistance. That is because now, *they have exchanged the surface of the earth for its belly, its broadness for narrowness, kinsfolk for estrangement, and light for darkness*. All they had has been taken from them, including their ability to influence their surroundings and others. They left this world in the same state as they came to it: *barefoot and unclothed*, meaning that they entered their graves without any possessions save their deeds, having separated from all that they owned upon death (Z). In the end, the Imām quotes part of Q21:104: *As We originated the first creation, so shall We bring it back – a promise binding upon Us. Indeed We shall do it*. Thus he ends his sermon about leaving this world by recalling the resurrection of the dead as a new creation (N).



111

ON THE ANGEL OF DEATH

- 1 Do you sense it when he enters a house? Or do you see him when he takes a soul? How does he take the soul of a foetus in the womb of his mother?! Does he reach it through any part of her body? Or does the soul respond to his call with the permission of its Lord? Or does he stay with him in her belly? How can one describe his God when he is unable to describe a creature like himself?
- هَلْ تُحِسُّ بِهِ إِذَا دَخَلَ مَنْزِلًا؟ أَمْ هَلْ تَرَاهُ إِذَا تَوَفَّى أَحَدًا؟ بَلْ كَيْفَ يَتَوَفَّى الْجَنِينَ فِي بَطْنِ أُمِّهِ؟! أَيْلِجُ عَلَيْهِ مِنْ بَعْضِ جَوَارِحِهَا؟ أَمْ الرُّوحُ أَجَابَتْهُ بِإِذْنِ رَبِّهَا؟ أَمْ هُوَ سَاكِنٌ مَعَهُ فِي أَحْسَانِهَا؟ كَيْفَ يَصِفُ إِلَهَهُ مَنْ يَعْجزُ عَنْ صِفَةِ مَخْلُوقٍ مِثْلِهِ؟

CONTEXT

It is believed that this oration is an excerpt of a much longer sermon about the Oneness of Allāh, and the inability of the limited human mind to understand the kernel of His attributes (M). The fact that this claim has been made by al-Baḥrānī in his commentary means that he had access to the whole sermon from a source other than *Nahj al-Balāghah*, though unfortunately that source has not reached us (N). It is not known when and where the Imām spoke these words. ‘Alī ibn Muḥammad ibn Shākir al-Laythī has narrated this oration in his work *Uyūn al-Ḥikam wal-Mawā’iz* with some variance in wording. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has included it as part of his version of the Sermon of ‘al-Ashbāh’ (1:273). The entire speech of the Imām can be summarized into a single point, and that is: the inability of human beings to understand how the Angel of Death takes the souls shows that they are unable to comprehend something that they witness before them; then how could they ever be able to understand the true nature of the Creator Himself? (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Referring to the Angel of Death, Amīr al-Mu'minīn asks: *Do you sense it when he enters a house? Or do you see him when he takes a soul?* The verb 'tuḥissu' connotes perceiving with the physical senses. These are rhetorical questions since nobody sees or senses angels as they are not a physical entities so as to be perceived by any of the five human senses (M). Some commentators say that angels have subtle ethereal bodies (*jisman laṭīfan*) which cannot be seen (MB). A tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq states that there is no family that lives in any kind of home but that the Angel of Death glances over them five times a day (T). The Imām then turns to the question of how the Angel of Death takes souls, for everyone knows that death entails the removal or detachment of the soul from the physical body, but nobody knows exactly how this is done. By what means does the Angel of Death take numerous souls all around the world in a single moment? Some have surmised that it is by calling them towards himself, which results in their rushing to him by the permission of Allāh, while he remains in his place. Others say that the whole earth lies before him like a table, so he can take from it whatever he wishes with ease. A third group opined that he has a host of subordinate angels who assist him. Though each of these views can be argued for using some traditions, one commentator says that none of them are correct. Rather, the secret lies in the will of Allāh, which is instantaneous as He only has to say 'Be!' and it is (Z).

Imām 'Alī gives the example of an unborn child and asks how the Angel of Death takes *the soul of a foetus in the womb of his mother, does he reach it through any part of her body? Or does the soul respond to his call with the permission of its Lord? Or does he stay with him in her belly?* The purpose of posing these questions was to highlight the mystery of death, and how it is not something simple to grasp (S). Some commentators note that the Angel of Death can reach any place and is not impeded by physical barriers. That is how he even reaches the drowning person in the depths of the oceans, for example. Hence it is easy for him to reach the foetus inside the mother's womb (MB). In any case, the exact way in which death occurs or the soul is taken is something we have very little understanding about, and it is a reality beyond our comprehension (N). That is precisely why Imām 'Alī then goes on to say that since we are unable to describe a created being like ourselves, namely the Angel of Death, how can we expect to describe our Creator?! Indeed, we can never know His Essence. Those who resort to philosophy

and come up with different theories and hypotheses about this subject are therefore only shooting arrows in the dark and wasting their time (Z). When some people had asked the Noble Messenger about the soul, the answer he was commanded to give them echoes this very point. The Qurʾān says: *And they ask you about the rūḥ. Say, "The rūḥ is [something] from the command of my Lord, and you have not been given from knowledge but a little."* (Q17:85).



CONDEMNING THE WORLD

1 I caution you about this world, for it is a volatile place and is not an abode for settlement. It has adorned itself with deceptions and deceives [others] with its adornments. It is an abode which is lowly before its Lord, so He has mixed its lawful with its unlawful, its good with its evil, its life with death, and its sweetness with bitterness. Allāh neither chose it for His friends, nor withheld it from His enemies. Its good is scant yet its evil is ready at hand. Its amassed fortune dwindles, its dominion is snatched away, and its thriving face desolation. What good is there in an abode that collapses like a dilapidated building, and a lifetime that expires just as provisions perish, or a period that elapses like the completion of a journey!

۱ وَأَحْذَرُكُمْ الدُّنْيَا، فَإِنَّهَا مَنْزِلٌ قُلْعَةٍ وَلَيْسَتْ بِدَارٍ تُجْعَلُ، قَدْ تَزَيَّنَتْ بِغُزُورِهَا وَعَرَّتْ بِزِينَتِهَا، دَارٌ هَانَتْ عَلَى رَبِّهَا، فَخَلَطَ حَلَالَهَا بِحَرَامِهَا، وَخَيْرَهَا بِشَرِّهَا، وَحَيَاتِهَا بِمَوْتِهَا، وَخُلُوقَهَا بِمَرِّهَا؛ لَمْ يُصِفْهَا اللَّهُ لِأَوْلِيَائِهِ، وَلَمْ يَضِنَّ بِهَا عَلَى أَعْدَائِهِ؛ خَيْرُهَا زَهِيدٌ، وَشَرُّهَا غَتِيذٌ، وَجَمْعُهَا يَنْقُذُ، وَمَلِكُهَا يُسَلِّبُ، وَعَامِرُهَا يَخْرُبُ. فَمَا خَيْرُ دَارٍ تُنْقَضُ نَقْضُ الْبِنَاءِ، وَعُمْرٍ يَفْنَى فِيهَا فَنَاءُ الزَّادِ، وَمُدَّةٍ تَنْقَطِعُ انْقِطَاعَ السَّيْرِ!

2 Include that which Allāh has made obligatory on you in what you seek. Ask Him to enable you to fulfil His rights as He has commanded you. Make your ears hear the call of death before you are called by it. Verily the hearts of those who are abstemious in this world weep even when they laugh, and their grief increases even when they rejoice. Their aversion for themselves abounds even when they

۲ فَاجْعَلُوا مَا افْتَرَضَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ طَلِبَتِكُمْ، وَاسْأَلُوهُ مِنْ أَدَاءِ حَقِّهِ مَا سَأَلَكُمُ، وَأَسْمِعُوا دَعْوَةَ الْمَوْتِ آذَانَكُمْ قَبْلَ أَنْ يُدْعَى بِكُمْ. إِنَّ الزَّاهِدِينَ فِي الدُّنْيَا تَبْكِي قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِنْ ضَحِكُوا، وَيَشْتَدُّ حُزْنُهُمْ وَإِنْ فَرَحُوا،

are envied for what they have been given. Remembrance of death has disappeared from your hearts, and has been supplanted by false hopes. This world has thus gained greater mastery over you than the Hereafter, and the evanescent life has taken you away from the eternal one. You are only brethren in the religion of Allāh. Nothing has caused divisions among you save foul dispositions and corrupt consciences. Consequently, you neither help each other, nor wish each other well, nor spend generously on each other, nor have affection for each other.

وَيَكْتُمُ مَقْتُهُمْ أَنْفُسُهُمْ وَإِنْ
اغْتَبَطُوا بِمَا رَزَقُوا. قَدْ غَابَ عَنْ
قُلُوبِكُمْ ذِكْرُ الْآجَالِ،
وَحَضَرَ تَكُمُ كَوَاذِبُ الْأَمَالِ،
فَصَارَتِ الدُّنْيَا أَمْلَكَ بِكُمْ مِنَ
الْآخِرَةِ، وَالْعَاجِلَةُ أَذْهَبَ بِكُمْ
مِنَ الْآجِلَةِ، وَإِنَّمَا أَنْتُمْ إِخْوَانٌ
عَلَى دِينِ اللَّهِ مَا فَرَّقَ بَيْنَكُمْ إِلَّا
حُبُّ السَّرَائِرِ وَسُوءُ الصَّمَائِرِ،
فَلَا تَوَارَزُونَ، وَلَا تَتَصَحُّونَ،
وَلَا تَبَادُلُونَ، وَلَا تَوَادُّونَ.

CONTEXT

The context of this sermon is not known, but the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes it as part of one of the Friday sermons of the Imām (4:222). Al-Zamakhsharī mentions a section of this sermon in his *Rabīʿ al-Abrār*, and al-Āmidī has taken various phrases from it and included them in his *Ghurur al-Ḥikam wa Durar al-Kalim*. The variance in wording between what al-Āmidī has quoted and what we find here leads us to believe that he used a source other than *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). Though the oration has one underlying message, and that is to keep away from the temptations of this world and focus on the Hereafter, the Imām uses three approaches to convey his advice. First, he mentions the flaws of this world and its transient nature. Then he proceeds to remind the people that they will all die one day, so it is futile to be attached to this material world which they will eventually have to leave behind. Finally, Imām ‘Alī mentions some of the negative consequences of loving this world (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Amīr al-Mu'minīn commences with a word of caution. He warns the people about this world, *for it is a volatile place and is not an abode for settlement*. The phrase '*manzilu qul'ah*' refers to a place where one does not reside or settle (T). Rather, it is one from which a person would have to depart at any moment (MB). Or it is an area which does not have what those who stay there require, so they are forced to depart therefrom time and again (I). The term '*nuj'ah*' is the opposite of this, and signifies a place where one finds goodness and blessing, so he would certainly seek to settle there (N). The Imām goes on to say that this world *has adorned itself with deceptions and deceives with its adornments*. The eloquence and beauty of this sentence is clear by the way he transposes the two phrases such that the second is like the mirror opposite of the first, though both convey the same message (T). Some have interpreted it to mean that worldly adornments are causes of deception and at the same time, it is when one is deceived that he would consider this world to be something worthy of acquisition (M). However, in reality, *it is an abode which is lowly before its Lord, so He has mixed its lawful with its unlawful, its good with its evil, its life with death, and its sweetness with bitterness*. Everything that gives joy or delight to a person in this world is accompanied by that which harms or hurts him (Z). It is reported that the Noble Messenger once passed by the carcass of a small goat, with its ears cut off, lying in a trash heap. He asked his companions, "What is the value of this?" They replied, "If it were alive, perhaps one dirham." So the Prophet said, "By He in whose hand is my soul, this world is more lowly in the sight of Allāh than this carcass is to its owner!" (MB). Hence *Allāh neither chose it for His friends, nor withheld it from His enemies*. The phrase '*lam yusfihallāhu li awliyā'ih*' means that Allāh has not made this world pure for His friends, with no turbidity or trouble therein (T). Rather He made them face all sorts of hardship in it, while giving His enemies what they desire of it. This is because He seeks to ennoble His friends and let the others fall deeper into their misguidance (MB).

This world is such, says the Imām, that *its good is scant ('zahīd') yet its evil is ready at hand ('atīd')*, meaning that its good is meagre at best, and its evil is ready and ever present. *Its amassed fortune dwindles, its dominion is snatched away, and its thriving face desolation*. So how could one with intelligence not recognize the fickle and transient nature of this world? (N). The Imām then gives three analogies wherein he compares this world to *an abode that collapses like a dilapidated*

building, and a lifetime that expires just as provisions perish, or a period that elapses like the completion of a journey. These three similitudes are indeed apt in the way they summarize the qualities of this transient world (MB). In short, the harm of this world outweighs its benefit, its wealth perishes, what is built in it falls to ruin, and the life one lives in it eventually comes to an end (Z).

2 Having described the flaws and shortcomings of this world, the Imām instructs the people to take from it only what is necessary. He enjoins them to *include that which Allāh has made obligatory on you in what you seek.* This pertains to knowledge of the correct creed as well as prescribed acts of worship (MB), which should be sought just as one seeks what he requires of this material world (T). In other words, the least they should do is give the same importance to the obligatory deeds as they do to their personal needs, and should not value the latter more than the former. Alternatively, it may be interpreted as supplicating to Allāh and seeking the ability to carry out what He has made obligatory, among the other things one prays for. However, the first meaning is more likely intended here, given that the following sentence conveys the second meaning, and would thus be an unneeded repetition (N). Indeed, part of one's sincere effort to carry out the commandments of Allāh entails asking Him *to enable you to fulfil His rights as He has commanded you.* The use of *su'āl* appears twice in this sentence, once as an imperative to ask Allāh, and then in the past tense ('*sa'alakum*') to connote His command and injunction. The term *su'āl* has been used for His command here in order to employ the rhetorical device of *al-muqābalah* (lit. correspondence) (I), which increases the eloquence and beauty of the speech. The Imām then tells the people to make their ears *hear the call of death* before they are called by it, meaning that preparation for death should be made before it comes (MB). It is reported that Imām al-Sajjād would recite on the 27th night of the month of Ramaḍān, "O Allāh, grant me aversion to the abode of deception, and inclination to the abode of eternity, and preparation for death before the time of its advent" (T).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn then proceeds to give an interesting description of those who are detached from this world, saying that their hearts *weep even when they laugh, and their grief increases even when they rejoice.* These renunciants who are indifferent to material possessions are sorrowful, and their hearts weep because of what they recognize of their weaknesses and faults, as well as the mistakes they sometimes make, even when they outwardly look cheerful in order to preserve decorum and social etiquette (N). Their grief does not mean that they have lost

hope, as they are indeed hopeful of Allāh's mercy. Rather, it is because they fear the consequences of their sins and misdeeds, and blame themselves for not worshipping Allāh as He ought to be worshipped (Z). *Their aversion for themselves abounds even when they are envied for what they have been given*, meaning that they hate their base souls for urging them towards evil, even when others envy them for whatever blessings they have been granted (MB). Their aversion and hatred is specifically for the aspect of the soul that pulls towards evil (*al-naḥs al-ammārah*) (S). Some commentators read the passive verb '*ightabīṭū*' as the active '*ightabaṭū*' and interpret it to mean that they have aversion for their lower selves even when they are delighted by what they have been granted (R).

Imām 'Alī then addresses his audience and tells them why this world has gained greater mastery over them than the Hereafter. He says it is because remembrance of death and the final end ('*dhikr al-ājal*') has disappeared from their hearts, and *has been supplanted by false hopes*. The phrase '*amlaku bikum*' means that it (i.e. the world) has greater control over you, and does not mean that it is given preference by you or is more deserving of you (*awlā bikum*), as some say (T). Subsequently, the Imām reminds the people that *they are only brethren in the religion of Allāh* so they should be united and of one mind. Some commentators read this more generally to mean that all people are created upon a singular *fiṭrah*, which is the religion of Allāh and belief in His unicity (*tawḥīd*) (I). However, it is clear that in this instance the Imām is urging them to maintain unity among themselves, as Muslims (N). The factors that cause divisions among them have been summed up by the Imām as their *foul dispositions* ('*khubth al-sarā'ir*') and *corrupt consciences* ('*sū' al-ḍamā'ir*'). These refer, respectively, to their negative inner traits and their evil intentions and beliefs (MB), and include everything from envy, prejudice, and malice, to love for this world and narrow-mindedness (N).

Here one may ask: most of the differences among the scholars in matters of faith go back to their varying views, based on their individual *ijtihād*, so why is it that the Imām has limited the factors of division to these two things? The answer is that the divisions being referred to here are those which separate the people into factions and sects, and this does not result merely from different views of scholars. Their *ijtihād* does not cause mutual enmity of different groups, so that is not the kind of difference he is referring to here (Z). This fact is further understood when we read the following lines which state: *you neither help each other, nor wish each other well, nor spend generously on each other, nor have affection for each other*.

3 Why is it that you rejoice with the little that you acquire of this world yet are not saddened by the abundance of which you are deprived of the Hereafter? You are troubled by the little of this world that you lose, to such an extent that it becomes evident on your faces and your lack of patience over what is taken away from you; as though it is your permanent abode and its wares will always remain with you. Nothing prevents any of you from confronting his brother regarding what he dreads of his shortcomings except the fear that he too will confront him with something similar. You are of one mind in rejecting the eternal and loving the transitory [abode]. For each of you, religion is only a soupçon upon his tongue – like the act of one who has finished his work and secured the satisfaction of his master.

۳ مَا بِالْكُم تَفْرَحُونَ بِالْيَسِيرِ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا تُدْرِكُونَهُ، وَلَا يَحْزَنُكُمُ الْكَثِيرُ مِنَ الْآخِرَةِ تُحْزَمُونَهُ. وَيَقْلُقُكُمُ الْيَسِيرُ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا يَفُوتُكُمُ، حَتَّى يَبَيِّنَ ذَلِكَ فِي وُجُوهِكُمْ، وَقَلَّةِ صَبْرِكُمْ عَمَّا رُويَ مِنْهَا عَنْكُمْ؛ كَأَنَّهَُا دَارُ مُقَامِكُمْ، وَكَأَنَّ مَتَاعَهَا بَاقٍ عَلَيْكُمْ. وَمَا يَمْنَعُ أَحَدَكُمْ أَنْ يَسْتَقْبِلَ أَحَاهُ بِمَا يَخَافُ مِنْ غِيْبِهِ، إِلَّا مَخَافَهُ أَنْ يَسْتَقْبِلَهُ بِمِثْلِهِ، قَدْ تَصَافَيْتُمْ عَلَى رَفْضِ الْأَجْلِ وَحُبِّ الْعَاجِلِ، وَصَارَ دِينَ أَحَدِكُمْ لَعَقَةً عَلَى لِسَانِهِ، صَنِيعَ مَنْ قَدْ فَرَّغَ مِنْ عَمَلِهِ وَأَخْرَزَ رِضَى سَيِّدِهِ.

The phrase '*lā tawāzarūn*' literally means that some of you do not help others to carry their heavy load (R). Due to the differences among them, they no longer assist each other or care for each other, and thus fail to fulfil the rights of their fellow brothers in faith (MB). When this happens, the only beneficiary is the external enemy, who takes every advantage of the weakness among the believers which results from their disunity (N).

3 The Imām then asks them rhetorically, as a means of reproof, why they *rejoice with the little* that they acquire of this world yet *are not saddened by the abundance* of which they are deprived of the Hereafter. They express gladness when they get that which will perish soon of this world, yet feel no sense of loss and regret when what would have remained with them forever is forfeited (Z).

Conversely, when they lose even a little of this world, they are greatly troubled; to the extent that their lack of patience becomes evident on their faces. As though this world is their permanent abode and its wares will always remain (N). The verb *'yuqliqum'* means it agitates or perturbs you, and *'zuwiya'* means seized or taken away (MB). Following this, Imām 'Alī speaks of the reason why people are hesitant to enjoin each other to good and forbid evil. He tells them *nothing prevents any of you from confronting his brother regarding what he dreads of his shortcomings except the fear that he too will confront him with something similar*. This statement could mean that the only thing which prevents these worldly people from exposing the flaws of others is the fear that their own flaws would also then be exposed. Hence, they do not hide their brothers' secrets out of fear of Allāh, or due to any virtue in themselves. Rather, they are only apprehensive that their own faults will be divulged, and that is what hinders them from confronting others regarding their faults (MB). One commentator suggests the word *'yakhāfu'* was actually *yukhfi*, in which case the translation would be *nothing prevents any of you from confronting his brother with what he conceals of his own shortcomings*. Since everybody has some flaw in himself which he keeps concealed from others, he cannot confront someone else for the latter's hidden fault as he could easily be told of his own fault that he is hiding (T).

The common worldview held by such individuals is then highlighted by the Imām when he says *you are of one mind in rejecting the eternal and loving the transitory world*. The verb *'taṣāfaytum'* means you were sincere and honest with each other in your common attitude towards this world and the next. That is because for each of them, religion is only a dollop upon his tongue. The term *'lu'qatan'* literally means a small amount of something edible that remains and is licked away, and here it is used metaphorically to refer to something expressed outwardly in religion, such as the testimony of faith (*shahādatayn*), without it being established in the heart or practiced in action (M). It is narrated that when Imām al-Ḥusayn arrived at Karbalā', he addressed his companions and told them that the people who had come to fight him were slaves of this world, and religion to them was merely like a small trace of food licked by the tongues. They follow it as long as their lives are comfortable, but the moment trials befall them, only few remain religious and devoted (T). In the end, Amīr al-Mu'minīn compares the deeds of such people to the actions of *one who has finished his work and secured the satisfaction of his master*. Just as one who has already satisfied his master no longer

needs to exert himself, so too do they act without any seriousness or effort in their religion (MB). They do not work for the Hereafter or show concern for it, as though they feel they will not be held accountable since they have already acquired Allāh's pleasure and fulfilled all His rights, so nothing else remains upon them thereof (Z).



ADVISING THE PEOPLE

1 All praise be to Allāh who has linked praise with blessings and blessings with gratitude. We praise Him for His bounties as we praise him for His trials. We seek His help against these [carnal] souls which are slow in carrying out what they have been commanded but quick to do what they have been forbidden. We seek His forgiveness from what His knowledge [already] encompasses and His record preserves – knowledge which is not limited and a record which omits nothing. We believe in Him with the conviction of one who has observed the unseen and has discovered what was promised – a belief the purity of which negates all polytheism, and its certitude [removes] all doubt. We bear witness that there is no god but Allāh, alone, without any partner, and that Muḥammad, may Allāh bless him and his progeny, is His servant and His Messenger – the two testimonies that elevate speech and raise deeds. The scales in which they are placed will never be light, and the scales from which they are removed will never be heavy.

الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الْوَاصِلِ الْحَمْدُ
بِالنَّعْمِ، وَالنَّعْمَ بِالشُّكْرِ، نَحْمَدُهُ
عَلَى آلَائِهِ كَمَا نَحْمَدُهُ عَلَى
بَلَائِهِ، وَنَسْتَعِينُهُ عَلَى هَذِهِ
النُّفُوسِ الْبِطَاءِ عَمَّا أُمِرَتْ بِهِ،
السَّرَّاعِ إِلَى مَا نُهِيتَ عَنْهُ،
وَنَسْتَغْفِرُهُ مِمَّا أَحَاطَ بِهِ عِلْمُهُ
وَأَخْصَاهُ كِتَابُهُ - عِلْمٌ غَيْرُ
قَاصِرٍ، وَكِتَابٌ غَيْرُ مُعَادِرٍ،
وَتُؤْمِنُ بِهِ إِيْمَانٌ مَنْ عَايَنَ
الْغُيُوبَ، وَوَقَفَ عَلَى الْمُوعُودِ،
إِيْمَانًا نَفَى إِخْلَاصُهُ الشُّرَكَ،
وَيَقِينُهُ الشَّكَّ، وَنَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ
إِلَّا اللَّهُ وَحْدَهُ لَا شَرِيكَ لَهُ، وَأَنَّ
مُحَمَّدًا صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَآلِهِ
وَسَلَّمَ عَبْدُهُ وَرَسُولُهُ، شَهَادَتَيْنِ
تُضَعِدَانِ الْقَوْلَ وَتَرْفَعَانِ الْعَمَلَ،
لَا يَخِفُ مِيزَانٌ تَوْضَعَانِ فِيهِ وَلَا
يَتَقَلُّ مِيزَانٌ تَرْفَعَانِ عَنْهُ.

CONTEXT

Like most of his other sermons, this oration by Amīr al-Mu'minīn contains advice about being Godwary, eschewing worldly desires, and working for a better Hereafter (MB). A large part of this sermon has been mentioned by the author of *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, which was most likely authored before *Nahj al-Balāghah*. Al-Zamakhsharī has also mentioned a section of it in his *Rabī' al-Abrār*, and the variance in wording suggests that he used a source other than the one used by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Unfortunately, we do not have information about where and when the Imām spoke these words. However, when al-Shaykh al-Ṭūsī mentions it in his *Amālī*, he prefaces it by saying, “Amīr al-Mu'minīn would say...” thereby implying that this sermon contains words and themes that were commonly spoken by Imām 'Alī in his orations. The fifth century scholar al-Qāḍī al-Quḍā'ī, who was a close subject of the Fāṭimid rulers in Egypt, also quoted part of this oration in his *Dustūr Ma'ālīm al-Ḥikam*. This sermon has been attributed to Zayd ibn 'Alī by the early grammarian Abū Ja'far al-Naḥḥās in his *Umdat al-Kitāb*, but it is likely that Zayd was only quoting his great grandfather Amīr al-Mu'minīn. So beautiful and subtle is this oration that the eighth century author of *al-Ṭirāz*, Yaḥyā al-Zaydī, says about it, “If there was any human speech that could be considered a miracle, this would be the first, and if there was any speech that none could match, then after the words of Allāh, this would be that second speech” (N).

COMMENTARY

1 As with most of his sermons, the Imām begins by praising the Almighty. When he says that Allāh has *linked praise with blessings and blessings with gratitude*, he means it is by praising Him that one becomes deserving of His blessings (N), and by showing gratitude, one becomes worthy of being granted an increase in those blessings (MB). Thus does Allāh proclaim in the Qur'ān: *If you are grateful, I will surely enhance you with more [blessing]* (Q14:7). Just as gratitude brings about more blessings, the attainment of blessings makes it necessary to show gratitude (Z). Then the Imām says that just as we praise Him for His bounties, we also *praise him for His trials*. That is because His trials are based on wisdom, so they are praiseworthy just like His blessings. Furthermore, blessings are also trials and trials are also sometimes blessings, since they result in reward for one who bears them patiently (M). Help is then sought from Allāh by the Imām against

these [carnal] souls which are slow in carrying out what they have been commanded but quick to do what they have been forbidden. The base soul usually procrastinates or is sluggish and apathetic towards anything other than that from which it derives pleasure. Therefore, it behoves us to seek help from Allāh against the inclinations and temptations of the base soul, as well as its hinderances (Z). Imām ‘Alī describes his belief in Allāh as *the conviction of one who has observed the unseen and has discovered what was promised*, because belief in what one sees is stronger and deeper than that which is based on secondary reports. Here, the allusion is to the belief of the cognizant (*īmān al-‘ārifīn*), and the Imām was their master and chief. That is why he said, “If the veils were cast aside, my certitude would not increase,” meaning he has already attained the height of certitude (*yaqīn*) (I).

Scholars tell us there are three levels of certitude. The first is called *‘ilm al-yaqīn*, and it is attained through a process of acquiring evidence and proof. The second is *‘ayn al-yaqīn*, and one arrives at it through witnessing and seeing something with his own eyes, such as the conviction one will have on the Day of Judgment, when he sees the resurrection himself. Finally, the third and highest level of certitude is *ḥaqq al-yaqīn*, and that is where one becomes so close to something that it is as though he can touch it and feel it with all his senses. It is this level of certitude that the Imām possessed (N). Subsequently the Imām recites the testimony of faith (*shahādatayn*) and describes it as *the two testimonies that elevate speech and raise deeds*. According to some commentators, this means that not every testimony is beneficial; rather, only when it meets certain criteria does it bring benefit (T). If the testimony is sincere and from the heart, only then can it have the effect mentioned by the Imām here (R). The utterances and deeds that are raised thereby are the good word (*‘al-kalim al-ṭayyib*) and the righteous action (*‘al-‘amal al-ṣāliḥ*) as mentioned in Q35:10. Each is elevated and enhanced in value by one’s faith as expressed in his testimony (MB). Then the Imām adds, regarding this testimony, that *the scales in which they are placed will never be light while the scales from which they are removed will never be heavy*. This means for actions to be considered truly righteous, belief and faith is a precondition (Z).

2 Being mindful of Allāh is described as a provision (*‘al-zād*) for the Hereafter and a refuge (*‘al-mā‘ādh*). To clarify this further, the Imām says that it is *a delivering provision and a redemptive refuge* (*‘zādun mubligh wa mā‘ādhun munjih*) meaning it is a provision that enables one to arrive at his destination, and a refuge that grants him safety and security (I). Indeed, through *tawqā* one attains safety

2 I advise you, O servants of Allāh, to espouse Godwariness, which is the provision [for the Hereafter] and with it is the refuge: a delivering provision and a redemptive refuge. The caller most able of making people listen has called towards it and the most percipient listener has grasped it. So the caller conveyed it and the one who paid heed attained success. O servants of Allāh! Verily Godwariness has deterred the friends of Allāh from what He made unlawful and instilled fear of Him in their hearts, until their nights passed in wakefulness and their noon-time in thirst. So they took comfort through toil and quenching through thirst; they saw the end as near and hastened towards [good] deeds; they rejected false aspirations and kept sight of death.

3 Moreover, verily this world is a place of annihilation and toil, vicissitudes and lessons. As for its annihilation, time has tautened its bow [in readiness] and its arrow never misses, and its wounds never heal; it strikes the living with death, the healthy with sickness, and the unscathed with injury. It is an eater that does not get sated and a drinker that is never quenched. As for its toil, a person amasses [in it] what he does not [get to] consume and builds what he does not occupy. Then he goes back to Allāh, the Exalted, carrying no wealth

٢ أَوْصِيَكُمْ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ بِتَقْوَى اللَّهِ،
الَّتِي هِيَ الرِّزَادُ وَبِهَا الْمَعَادُ: رَادٌّ
مُبْلِغٌ وَمَعَادٌ مُنْجٍ، دَعَا إِلَيْهَا
أَشْمَعُ دَاعٍ وَوَعَاهَا خَيْرُ وَاعٍ،
فَأَسْمَعَ دَاعِيَهَا وَفَارَ وَاعِيَهَا. عِبَادَ
اللَّهِ، إِنَّ تَقْوَى اللَّهِ حَمَتُ أَوْلِيَاءَ
اللَّهِ مَحَارِمَهُ، وَالزَّمَتْ قُلُوبَهُمْ
مَخَافَتَهُ، حَتَّى أَشْهَرَتْ لِبَالِهِمْ،
وَأَظْمَأَتْ هَوَاجِرَهُمْ، فَأَخَذُوا
الرَّاحَةَ بِالنَّصَبِ وَالرَّيَّ بِالظَّمِّ،
وَاسْتَقَرُّوا الْأَجَلَ فَبَادَرُوا الْعَمَلَ،
وَكَدَّبُوا الْأَمَلَ فَلَا حَظُّوا الْأَجَلَ.

٣ ثُمَّ إِنَّ الدُّنْيَا دَارُ فَنَاءٍ وَعَنَاءٍ،
وَعَبْرٍ وَعَبْرٍ، فَمِنْ الْفَنَاءِ أَنَّ
الدَّهْرَ مُوتِرٌ قَوْسُهُ، لَا تُحْطِئُ
سَهَامُهُ وَلَا تُؤَسِّي جِرَاحُهُ،
يَزِمِي الْحَيَّ بِالْمَوْتِ،
وَالصَّحِيحَ بِالسَّقَمِ، وَالنَّاجِيَ
بِالْعَطْبِ؛ أَكِلٌ لَا يَشْبَعُ وَشَارِبٌ
لَا يَنْقَعُ. وَمِنْ الْعَنَاءِ أَنَّ الْمَرْءَ
يَجْمَعُ مَا لَا يَأْكُلُ، وَيَبْنِي مَا لَا
يَسْكُنُ، ثُمَّ يَخْرُجُ إِلَى اللَّهِ

and taking nothing [he] built. As for its vicissitudes, you see [in it] the pitiful one becoming enviable and the envied one turning pitiful. This is nothing but a blessing that has quickly passed and a misfortune that has descended [in its place]. As for its lessons, a man may be on the verge of [attaining] his aspiration when it is cut short by the [sudden] arrival of his death; then neither is the aspiration attained nor is the aspirant spared. Glory be to Allāh, how deceptive is its joy, how thirst-inducing its quenching, and how sunny its shade! Neither can that which approaches be repelled nor can that which has passed return.

تَعَالَى لَا مَالًا حَمَلَ وَلَا بِنَاءً
نَقَلَ. وَمِنْ غَيْرِهَا أَنَّكَ تَرَى
الْمَرْحُومَ مَغْبُوطًا، وَالْمَغْبُوطَ
مَرْحُومًا، لَيْسَ ذَلِكَ إِلَّا نَعِيمًا
زَلَّ وَبُؤْسًا نَزَلَ. وَمِنْ عِبَرِهَا أَنَّ
الْمَرْءَ يُشْرِفُ عَلَى أَمَلِهِ فَيَقْتَطِعُهُ
حُضُورُ أَجَلِهِ، فَلَا أَمَلٌ يُدْرِكُ
وَلَا مُؤْمَلٌ يُتْرَكُ. فَسُبْحَانَ اللَّهِ مَا
أَعْرَسُ شُرُورَهَا، وَأَظْمَأَ رِيَّهَا،
وَأَضْحَى فَيْئَهَا! لَا جَاءَ يُرَدُّ وَلَا
مَاضٍ يَرْتَدُّ.

and wellbeing both in this world and the Hereafter, and that is why every Prophet and Imām urged the people to espouse Godwariness (Z). In some manuscripts, the word '*al-ma'ād*' is found instead of '*al-ma'ādh*', and it has been argued that this is the more correct reading. The translation of '*ma'ādun munjiḥ*' would be a *beneficial gain* (T) or a *successful return* (MB), depending on how the term '*al-ma'ād*' is interpreted. The phrases '*asma'u dā'in*' and '*khayru wā'in*' respectively refer to one who does his best to get the message heard by the people and one who listens to the message most attentively. Commentators say that the first phrase refers to the Noble Messenger (M), and the second refers to Imām 'Alī (N). However, it is quite possible that a general meaning is intended here, which encompasses all those callers towards the truth who tried their best to make the people listen, and all those pious people who would keenly listen to their message and follow it (Z). It has also been suggested that the best caller could refer to Allāh, whereas the most percipient listeners refer to His Prophets and Messengers (MB). The Imām then mentions some of the outcomes of Godwariness, saying that it deters *the friends of Allāh from what He made unlawful* and instils *fear of Him in their hearts*. The verb '*ḥamat*' connotes prohibiting something harmful or injurious, and indeed that

which has been decreed unlawful has been prohibited because it is harmful for human beings. The phrase *until their nights passed in wakefulness and their noontime in thirst* means that the friends of Allāh would, out of fear and awe of Him, spend wakeful nights in prayer and worship, and during the long, hot days, they would fast (R). Alternatively, it is a figurative description of their continued fear of Allāh, day and night (Z). The term '*hawājirahum*' comes from *al-hājirah*, which means midday, when the heat is severe (T).

So they took comfort through toil and quenching through thirst, meaning that they took the comfort of the Hereafter through toil in this world, and got access to the heavenly springs by remaining thirsty for a short while in this worldly life (MB). *They saw the end as near and hastened towards good deeds; they rejected false aspirations and kept sight of death*. Whoever anticipates his death prepares for it, so he does not have long hopes for the distant future (Z). Considering one's departure from this world to be imminent leads a person to undertake many good deeds and prepare provisions for the next life (MB). One may ask: why has the Imām repeated the word '*al-ajal*' twice here – does that not go against the rules of eloquence? The answer is that he used this term twice with two different meanings. In the first instance where he says '*istaqrabū al-ajal*' the term refers to one's lifespan and the allotted time he has in the world, whereas in the second instance, where he says, '*falāḥazū al-ajal*', it refers to death (I). The opposite of this is also possible, where the first instance refers to death and the second to one's lifespan, but is less likely because it would require interpreting the latter as the shortness of one's lifespan (MB). In any case, due to the difference in meaning, there is no diminution in the beauty of the speech. If anything, it makes the Imām's words even more articulate and eloquent.

3 Since the main obstacle that prevents a person from becoming Godwary is love for this world, after advising the people to espouse *taqwā*, the Imām speaks about the ephemerality of this world and its lack of true value (N). He says that it is *a place of annihilation and toil, vicissitudes and lessons*, before proceeding to explain each of these four characteristics of the *dunyā*. As for its annihilation ('*al-fanā*'), he says *time has tautened its bow and its arrow never misses and its wounds never heal*. Here Amīr al-Mu'minīn compares time to an archer, and in his analogy, the arrows of this archer represent the events and calamities that come to pass according to what has been divinely decreed, such that there can be no change or alteration in them. This is metaphorically depicted by the archer who never misses

his target (MB). These ‘arrows’ of time can be different things, such as sorrow, distress, hardship, sickness, poverty, loss of loved ones, and so on (Z). Its ultimate wound is death, from which one can never recover! One commentator gives the example of how al-Mughīrah ibn Shu‘bah had fled from Kūfah when it was struck by the plague. Once the plague was over, it was suggested to him that he should return. But the moment he went back to the city, he caught the plague and died (T). Thus does the passage of time in this world strike *the living with death, the healthy with sickness, and the unscathed with injury*. The term ‘al-‘aṭab’ means destruction (*al-halāk*), so the phrase ‘al-nājī bil-‘aṭab’ can also be rendered *the safe with destruction*. The Imām then says that this world is like *an eater that does not get sated and a drinker that is never quenched*, meaning that it consumes the human beings until nothing is left of them (N). Others say that this is a description of time (*al-dahr*), with its continuous march, like an eater and drinker that continually consumes everything until nothing remains (M). The verb ‘yanqa’ means drinking until one is fully quenched; one says ‘naqa’a al-māu al-‘aṭasha’ meaning the water alleviated and quelled the thirst (R). The Imām then explains the second quality of this world, namely its toil (‘al-‘anā’), which results in a person amassing in this world *what he does not get to consume and building what he does not occupy*. Indeed, there are many cases where one invests in a home which he never gets to live in, or saves money for the future which he never gets to see. In one tradition from Imām ‘Alī we are told that many a person weaves clothes to wear, only to have them be his shroud, and builds a house to live in, only to have it be the location of his grave (N).

As for its vicissitudes (‘ghiyarihā’), in it the pitiful one becomes enviable and the envied turns pitiful. *This is nothing but a blessing that has quickly passed and a misfortune that has descended in its place*. The term ‘al-marḥūm’ refers to one who evokes compassion, pity, and mercy due to his dire state and poverty. The vicissitudes of life may lead such a person to become envied (‘maghbūṭ’) later because of his great wealth, and people start to feel jealous of him. And the opposite happens to one who was affluent in the past but is now a pauper (R). The last characteristic of this world mentioned by the Imām here is its lessons (‘ibarihā’). In it, *a man may be on the verge of attaining his aspiration when it is cut short by the sudden arrival of his death; then neither is the aspiration attained nor is the aspirant spared*. People expend their utmost efforts to attain what they desire, until death comes upon them while they might be very close to acquiring what

they seek (Z). The Imām then glorifies Allāh and expresses his wonder at this world, and *how deceptive is its joy, how thirst-inducing its quenching, and how sunny its shade!* Some versions read ‘*a’azza surūrahā*’ instead of ‘*agharra surūrahā*’, in which case the translation would read *how rare is its joy* (T). Its drink parches instead of quenching, and its shade causes one to feel heat rather than coolness. These two metaphors refer to the futility of seeking worldly pleasures and reliance upon this world, respectively (MB). Then the Imām says, *neither can that which approaches be repelled nor can that which has passed return*, which has been interpreted in different ways. Some commentators say that the one who approaches or arrives (‘*jā’in*’) and cannot be repelled refers to death, while the one who passes or leaves (‘*māḍin*’) and cannot return refers to the dead person (MB). Others say that the two terms refer to generations of human beings who come to this world and then leave it with no one having the ability to hinder their arrival or departure (N).

4 In the same vein, the Imām declares his wonder at how the living are so close to the dead that they will soon join them in death. Yet the dead are so distant from the living that they are separated and cut off from them. Usually, when something is near another thing, a mutual closeness is understood between them, but this rule does not apply when it comes to the living and the dead, and this evokes wonder (T). The nearness of death is depicted in a beautiful statement attributed to the Noble Messenger wherein he said, “...My eyes do not blink but that I feel Allāh may take my soul before my eyelids touch, and my eyes do not open after blinking but that I feel Allāh may take my soul before they are wide open...” (N). The statement *nothing is worse than evil except its punishment, and nothing is better than good except its reward* alludes to the great reward and severe punishment of the Hereafter (MB). In one tradition from Imām ‘Alī which is somewhat similar, he said, “The doer of good is better than it, and the doer of evil is worse than it.” In this tradition he is comparing the deeds to their agents, and in the statement of this sermon, he is comparing the deeds to their outcomes (N). Expounding on this further, the Imām says that everything of this world sounds better than it looks, while everything in the Hereafter looks better than it sounds. The phrase ‘*samā’uhū a’zamu min ‘iyānihi*’ means that the descriptions heard about what is in this world are exaggerated, and things are found to be unlike what was described (S). In contrast, about the Hereafter, he says “*‘iyānuhu a’zamu min samā’ihi*’ since what will be seen and experienced of it is much greater than what

4 Glory be to Allāh, how close the living is to the dead in how soon he will meet him, and how far the dead is from the living in how separated he is from him! Certainly nothing is worse than evil except its punishment, and nothing is better than good except its reward. In this world, everything that is heard is greater than what is seen, while everything of the Hereafter that is seen is greater than what is heard. So suffice yourselves with hearing in lieu of seeing, and with reports in lieu of the unseen. Know that what is diminished of this world and augmented in the Hereafter is better [for you] than what is diminished of the Hereafter and augmented in this world. How many a diminished one gains profit while an augmented one faces loss! Verily that which you have been enjoined to do is more wide-ranging than what you have been forbidden from, and what has been made lawful for you is more than what has been prohibited. So leave what is less for what is more, and what is restricted for what is capacious.

5 Your sustenance has been guaranteed and you have been commanded to act. So seeking what has been guaranteed for you should never be given a higher priority than doing what has been enjoined upon you. But, by Allāh, doubt has intervened and certitude has been impinged upon, until it seems as though what was guaranteed for

٤ فَسُبْحَانَ اللَّهِ، مَا أَقْرَبَ الْحَيِّ مِنَ الْمَيِّتِ لِلْحَاقِقِ بِهِ، وَأَبْعَدَ الْمَيِّتِ مِنَ الْحَيِّ لِانْقِطَاعِهِ عَنْهُ! إِنَّهُ لَيْسَ شَيْءٌ بِشَرٍّ مِنَ الشَّرِّ إِلَّا عِقَابُهُ، وَلَيْسَ شَيْءٌ بِخَيْرٍ مِنَ الْخَيْرِ إِلَّا ثَوَابُهُ، وَكُلُّ شَيْءٍ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا سَمَاعُهُ أَعْظَمُ مِنْ عَيَانِهِ، وَكُلُّ شَيْءٍ مِنَ الْآخِرَةِ عَيَانُهُ أَعْظَمُ مِنْ سَمَاعِهِ، فَلْيَكْفِكُمْ مِنَ الْعَيَانِ السَّمَاعُ، وَمِنَ الْغَيْبِ الْحَبْرُ. وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ مَا نَقَصَ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا وَزَادَ فِي الْآخِرَةِ خَيْرٌ مِمَّا نَقَصَ مِنَ الْآخِرَةِ وَزَادَ فِي الدُّنْيَا، فَكُم مِّنْ مَنْقُوصٍ رَّابِحٍ، وَمَزِيدٍ خَاسِرٍ! إِنَّ الَّذِي أُمِرْتُمْ بِهِ أَوْسَعُ مِنَ الَّذِي نُهِيتُمْ عَنْهُ، وَمَا أُحِلَّ لَكُمْ أَكْثَرُ مِمَّا حُرِّمَ عَلَيْكُمْ، فَذَرُّوا مَا قَلَّ لِمَا كَثُرَ وَمَا ضَاقَ لِمَا اتَّسَعَ.

٥ قَدْ تُكْفَّلُ لَكُمْ بِالرِّزْقِ، وَأُمِرْتُمْ بِالْعَمَلِ، فَلَا يَكُونَنَّ الْمَضْمُونُ لَكُمْ طَلِبَةً أَوْلى بِكُمْ مِنَ الْمَفْرُوضِ عَلَيْكُمْ عَمَلُهُ، مَعَ أَنَّهُ وَاللَّهِ لَقَدْ اعْتَرَضَ الشَّكُّ وَدَخَلَ الْيَقِينُ، حَتَّى كَأَنَّ الَّذِي ضُمِنَ لَكُمْ قَدْ فُرِضَ

you has become incumbent upon you and what has been made obligatory on you is no longer required of you. So hasten towards good deeds and fear the suddenness of death, for verily one cannot hope to turn back time the way he hopes for the return of his livelihood. Whatever is lost of one's income today may be hoped for tomorrow with increment, but what has elapsed of one's lifetime yesterday, its return cannot be hoped for today. Hope is only for what is to come, while for that which has passed there is only disappointment. So 'be mindful of Allāh with the mindfulness due to Him and do not die except as Muslims.'

عَلَيْكُمْ وَكَأَنَّ الَّذِي قَدْ فُرِضَ
عَلَيْكُمْ قَدْ وُضِعَ عَنْكُمْ. فَبادِرُوا
الْعَمَلَ وَخَافُوا بَغْتَةَ الْأَجَلِ، فَإِنَّهُ لَا
يُزَجَى مِنْ رَجْعَةِ الْعُمُرِ مَا يُزَجَى
مِنْ رَجْعَةِ الرِّزْقِ، مَا فَاتَ الْيَوْمَ مِنْ
الرِّزْقِ رُجِي غَدًا زِيَادَتُهُ، وَمَا فَاتَ
أَمْسٍ مِنَ الْعُمُرِ لَمْ يُرَجِ الْيَوْمَ
رَجْعَتُهُ. الرَّجَاءُ مَعَ الْجَائِي وَالْيَأْسُ
مَعَ الْمَاضِي، فَ«اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ حَقَّ تَقَاتِهِ
وَلَا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلَّا وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ».

has been described thereof. One commentator says that this is why many of the verses that describe what will happen in the Hereafter are prefaced by the phrase 'wa law tarā' (and were you to see...) (T). Imām 'Alī then tells the people: *so suffice yourselves with hearing in lieu of seeing and with reports in lieu of the unseen*, which means that hearing about the severity of the Fire and its terrors should be sufficient for them to stop committing evil deeds, so that they do not end up seeing that Fire and experiencing it in the Hereafter (R). Furthermore, the reports about the unseen rewards and punishments that they have received through the Prophet should be sufficient for them to act and take the necessary provisions for the next world (MB).

The statement *what is diminished of this world and augmented in the Hereafter is better [for you] than what is diminished of the Hereafter and augmented in this world* means that whatever decreases one's share of the world yet increases his share of the Hereafter is better for him than that which decreases his share in the Hereafter while increasing it in this world. No matter how advantageous something is in this world, it can never compare to the everlasting bounties of the Hereafter (Z). Thus, *many a diminished one gains profit while an augmented one faces loss*

(*'kam min manqūshin rābiḥin wa mazādin khāsir'*). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then reminds the people that what they have been enjoined to do is more wide-ranging (*'awsa'u'*) than what they have been forbidden, and what has been made lawful for them is much more than what has been prohibited. Some commentators understand the phrase *'alladhī umirtum bihi'* to connote that which has been made permissible for the people, or what has been recommended to them, such as marriage and the like. Such things are greater in number than what has been forbidden and deemed unlawful (R). And since there are so many lawful options available to the believers, they ought to *leave what is less for what is more, and what is restricted for what is capacious*. The phrase *'mā dāqa li mā ittasa'a'* literally means [leaving] that which is narrow for that which is wide, and connotes the few restrictions of religion compared to its numerous freedoms and permissions. For instance, the laws of religion allow us to use any kind of vessel, made from any material except gold and silver. Similarly, a man is permitted to adorn himself by wearing clothes of any fabric other than silk and gold brocade. Hence, it behoves us to show gratitude to Allāh for making the laws of His religion easy for us to follow (T).

5 The Imām then warns the people not to give priority to seeking livelihood over obeying and worshipping Allāh, because *sustenance has been guaranteed and you have been commanded to act*. The command to act here refers to performing what is mandated and made obligatory upon us, as well as the good deeds that have been recommended to us (Z). Indeed, that is exactly how Imām 'Alī himself explains it when he says that *seeking what has been guaranteed for you should never be given a higher priority than doing what has been enjoined upon you*. Of course, this does not mean that one should not make an effort to earn his livelihood; rather it only means that it should not be given priority over the commandments of Allāh. When Imām al-Ṣādiq was once told about a man who was in need, he asked, "What is he doing today?" They said, "He is in his house, worshipping his Lord." He asked, "Where does he get his provisions from?" They said, "From one of his brothers." So the Imām said, "Verily the one who provides for him is performing greater worship [than him]!" (MB). However, the Imām says, *doubt has intervened and certitude has been impinged upon* (*'laqad i'taraḍa al-shakku wa dukhila al-yaqīn'*), meaning that those who worry more about this world than the Hereafter do so because of their weak faith, their lack of trust in Allāh, and their uncertainty about His justice (Z). They doubt the guarantee of Allāh to provide them with sustenance. As a result,

they expend so much effort in seeking this world that they end up neglecting what has been made obligatory upon them (MB). It is reported that among the advice Luqmān gave to his son was that he told him how one who feels uncertain or has doubts should recall that Allāh sustained him in three states wherein it was impossible for him to sustain himself: He sustained him while he was in his mother's womb, and when he was born, He sustained him by making his mother's milk flow from her breasts, providing him all the nutrition he needed to grow. Once he was weaned off his mother's milk, He provided him with food through the earnings of his parents, until he grew to become an independent adult. Truly the Lord who sustained him during these stages would not abandon him once he had grown up (T).

The Imām then tells the people to *hasten towards good deeds and fear the suddenness of death, for verily one cannot hope to turn back time the way he hopes for the return of his livelihood*. It is generally recommended for one who intends to do a good deed not to delay it, for traditions tell us that Satan and his minions try their best to dissuade anyone who intends to do good from carrying it out (T). Here, Imām 'Alī gives another reason why we should not postpone good deeds we intend to undertake – because death may come upon us suddenly before we have the chance to perform them. Since the subject pertains to acquiring livelihood, the Imām explains that carrying out what we are enjoined to do, without postponing it or wasting any time, is more important than earning livelihood because the time and opportunity which is lost can never be recovered, and one can never hope to turn back the clock. On the other hand, whatever income is lost can be recovered in the future. The phrase '*al-raqā' ma'a al-jā'ī*' means that hope lies in what is to come in the future, and this refers to the livelihood that will come to an individual as long as he lives (R), while '*al-ya's ma'a al-māḍī*' refers to despair for what has passed of one's life, never to return (MB). It is narrated that a man once came to Imām al-Sajjād to complain about some difficulties he had. The Imām responded by saying that each human being faces at least three calamities every single day. The first is that with each day, his lifespan reduces, and that time will never return, yet he remains unconcerned about this. The second is that the provision he uses each day is to be accounted for by him: if it is lawful, he has to give account for it, and if it is unlawful, he will be punished for it. The third calamity is that every day one moves a step closer to his eternal abode in the Hereafter, not knowing whether it will be in Paradise or Hell (N). Amīr al-Mu'minīn ends by quoting part of verse

Q3:102 wherein the believers are commanded: *be mindful of Allāh with the mindfulness due to Him and do not die except as Muslims*. It has been suggested that he recited this particular verse because the good deeds which he urged people to hasten towards must be based on Godwariness (M).



SEEKING RAIN

- 1 O Allāh! Our mountains have cracked and our land is covered in dust. Our cattle are wandering aimlessly [out of thirst] and are bewildered in their enclosures. They are crying out the way mothers mourn for their dead children. They are tired of moving to and fro in their pastures and yearning for their water holes. O Allāh! Have mercy on the bleating of the sheep and yearnful cries of the camels. O Allāh! Have mercy on their bewilderment as they go forth [in search of pasture] and their cries as they return to their enclosures [hungry]. O Allāh! We have come out to You at a time when years of emaciating drought have overwhelmed us, and the rain clouds have turned their backs on us. You are the hope for the distraught and the sufficer for the beseecher.
- اللَّهُمَّ قَدْ انْصَحَتْ جِبَالُنَا،
وَاعْبَرَتْ أَرْضُنَا، وَهَامَتْ دَوَابُّنَا،
وَتَحَيَّرَتْ فِي مَرَابِضِهَا، وَعَجَبَتْ
عَجِيجَ التَّكَالَى عَلَى أَوْلَادِهَا،
وَمَلَّتِ التَّرْدُّدَ فِي مَرَاتِعِهَا
وَالْحَنِينَ إِلَى مَوَارِدِهَا. اللَّهُمَّ
فَارْحَمْ أَنْيْنَ الْأَنَةِ وَحَنِينَ الْحَائَةِ.
اللَّهُمَّ فَارْحَمْ خَيْرَتَهَا فِي
مَذَاهِبِهَا، وَأَنِتَهَا فِي مَوَالِجِهَا.
اللَّهُمَّ خَرَجْنَا إِلَيْكَ حِينَ
اغْتَكِرَتْ عَلَيْنَا حَدَايِرُ السَّنِينِ،
وَأَخْلَفْتَنَا مَخَابِلُ الْجُودِ؛ فَكُنْتَ
الرَّجَاءَ لِلْمُبْتَئِسِ، وَالْبَلَاغَ
لِلْمُلْتَمِسِ.
- 2 We call You at a time when people have lost all hope, rainclouds have been withheld, and grazing animals have perished, [pleading] that You not take us to task for our deeds or punish us for our sins, and [asking You to] spread Your mercy over us through clouds of torrential rain, copious spring showers, luscious vegetation, and heavy downpours that bring to life
- نَدْعُوكَ حِينَ قَنَطَ الْأَنَامُ، وَمُنِعَ
الْغَمَامُ، وَهَلَكَ السَّوَامُ، أَلَّا
تُؤَاخِذَنَا بِأَعْمَالِنَا، وَلَا
تَأْخُذَنَا بِذُنُوبِنَا، وَانْشُرْ عَلَيْنَا
رَحْمَتَكَ بِالسَّحَابِ الْمُبْتَعِقِ، وَالرَّبِّيعِ
الْمُغْدِقِ، وَالتَّيْبَاتِ الْمُوْنِقِ، سَحًّا
وَابِلًا تُحْيِي بِهِ مَا قَدْ مَاتَ وَتَرُدُّ بِهِ

what was dead and restore what was lost. O Allāh! [We seek] rain from You: life-giving, quenching, consummate, sweeping, pure, blessed, salubrious, and fruitful; its foliage exuberant, its branches fruit-bearing, and its leaves bright green. [A rain] with which You invigorate the weak among Your servants and revive the lifeless among Your lands. O Allāh! [We seek] rain from You by which our highlands get covered with herbage, our valleys begin to flow, our surroundings become fecund, our fruits thrive, our cattle prosper, our remote areas get water and our rural areas derive benefit - out of Your vast blessings and bountiful gifts to Your needy creatures and Your untamed beasts.

مَا قَدْ فَاتَ. اللَّهُمَّ سُقِنَا مِنْكَ مُحْيِيَةً
مُزَوِّيَةً، تَامَةً عَامَّةً، طَيِّبَةً
مُبَارَكَةً، هَنِيئَةً مَرِيعةً، زَاكِيًا بُشَّةً،
ثَامِرًا فَرْعُهَا، نَاصِرًا وَرَقُهَا؛ تُنْعِشُ
بِهَا الضَّعِيفَ مِنْ عِبَادِكَ، وَتُحْيِي بِهَا
الْمَيِّتَ مِنْ بِلَادِكَ. اللَّهُمَّ سُقِنَا
مِنْكَ تُعْشِبُ بِهَا نِجَادُنَا، وَتَجْرِي بِهَا
وِهَادُنَا، وَيُخْصِبُ بِهَا جَنَابُنَا، وَتُقْبِلُ
بِهَا ثِمَارُنَا، وَتَعِيشُ بِهَا مَوَاشِينَا،
وَتُنْدِي بِهَا أَقَاصِينَا، وَتَسْتَعِينُ بِهَا
ضَوَاحِينَا، مِنْ بَرَكَاتِكَ الْوَاسِعَةِ،
وَعَطَايَاكَ الْجَزِيلَةِ، عَلَى بَرِيَّتِكَ
الْمُزْمَلَةِ وَوَحْشِكَ الْمُهْمَلَةِ.

CONTEXT

This oration, or supplication, is one in which Amīr al-Mu'minīn beseeched Allāh in a year wherein the skies withheld their bounty upon the earth and its inhabitants, and life became difficult for them. And since supplication is one of the means of attaining divine grace (*ināyah*), the Imām prays to Allāh to alleviate their suffering and bless them with rain (Z). As he beseeches Allāh, he expresses the desperation, weakness, and suffering the people are undergoing before asking for rain (R). The beauty of his supplication and the expressions employed therein are such that if read with understanding, it fills one with an elevated sense of spirituality (N). Some commentators say that this oration is actually part of a longer sermon by the Imām which al-Shaykh al-Ṣadūq has quoted in his *Man Lā Yaḥḍuruḥu al-Faqīh*, albeit with much variance in wording (MB). In his *Tahdhīb al-Aḥkām* and *Miṣbāḥ al-Mutahajjid*, al-Shaykh al-Ṭūsī also mentions this supplication. Among the Sunnī scholars, al-Zamakhsharī and Ibn Athīr have

quoted this oration, or part thereof, in their respective works *Rabīʿ al-Abrār* and *al-Nihāyah fī Gharīb al-Ḥadīth*. The practice of offering *ṣalāt al-istisqāʾ* was instituted by the Noble Messenger, who had himself prayed this *ṣalāh* with his companions. And there is a consensus among Muslim scholars, of different sects, that if rain does not fall after this prayer is offered, then it is recommended to repeat it (Z). *Istisqāʾ* is of different types, the simplest of which involves supplication without any prayer, and the next stage is supplicating after prayer, and finally the best method is offering two rakʿahs of prayer specifically for seeking rain (MB). Details about the method of offering *ṣalāt al-istisqāʾ* can be found in the manuals of Fiqh.

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām begins his supplication by calling out to Allāh, saying: *our mountains have cracked and our land is covered in dust*. According to al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, Amīr al-Muʾminīn's words '*inṣāḥat jibālunā*' mean that the mountains have cracked from the effect of the drought. The expression *inṣāḥa al-thawb* is used to describe a garment when it is torn. The phrase *inṣāḥa al-nabtu* or *ṣāḥa* or *ṣawwaḥa* is also used for a plant that withers and dries up. The parched mountains and dust-filled plains depict the effects of the drought that the people are suffering. However, the suffering also extends to other creatures, and the Imām notes how the *cattle are wandering aimlessly out of thirst and are bewildered in their enclosures*, as they moan like bereaved mothers ('*ajj al-thakālā*'). Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī notes that the phrase '*wa hāmat dawwābunā*' means they are thirsty, as *al-huyām* means thirst. However, some commentators suggest that this phrase can also have another meaning, and that is to move about aimlessly out of the intense thirst they feel (I, N). *They are tired of moving to and fro in their pastures and yearning for their water holes*, meaning they are too exhausted to search for pasture in the places where they usually would go to graze, for now they find no foliage there. Likewise, their usual water holes are dry, and they are tired of going there (MB). The term '*al-ḥanīn*' refers to the sound they make out of yearning and desire (T).

The Imām then asks Allāh to *have mercy on the bleating of sheep and yearnful cries of the camels*. The terms '*al-ānnah*' and '*al-ḥānnah*' refer to sheep and camels respectively (R). He further asks the Almighty to *have mercy on their bewilderment as they go forth in search of food, and their cries as they return to their enclosures*

hungry, not having found anything to eat. On the question of why the Imām began his supplication by mentioning the suffering of cattle, one commentator suggests it is because these innocent animals are close to Allāh’s mercy (MB), while another says that it was the practice of the Noble Prophet he was emulating. The Messenger of Allāh is reported to have said that were it not for the cattle with access to abundant pasture, the infants being nursed, and the old people bowing in worship, Allāh would pour forth upon the people His painful chastisement [for their sins] (I). Imām ‘Alī then implores Allāh and says *we have come out to You at a time when years of emaciating drought have overwhelmed us, and the rain clouds have turned their backs on us*. Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī comments that the term ‘*ḥadābīr*’ in the phrase ‘*ḥadābīr al-sinīn*’ is plural of *ḥidbār*, which literally means a camel that has been emaciated by difficult travel. Thus the Imām likens the drought-stricken years to such a camel. Al-Raḍī then quotes [the Arab poet] Dhū al-Rummah, who said:

*Emaciated camels that cannot stand except kneeling
on the ground, ridden hard into the desert wastelands.*

The verb ‘*akhlafatnā*’ comes from *khalafa al-wa’d* meaning he broke his promise, and here it metaphorically describes how the rainclouds from which abundant rainfall was expected turned away without any downpour. The term ‘*al-jawd*’ refers to plentiful rain, which flows over everything (T).

2 Continuing his supplication, the Imām describes their state at that moment saying, *people have lost all hope, rainclouds have been withheld, and grazing animals have perished*. The rhyming words ‘*al-anām*’, ‘*al-ghamām*’, and ‘*al-sawām*’ increase the beauty of the cadence of his speech. Some commentators say that the withholding of rainclouds has been mentioned in the passive tense because the Imām did not want to ascribe the withholding of rain to Allāh, out of reverence and etiquette (I). Others say that the verb is actually in the active tense ‘*manā’a*’ because the verbs that come before and after it are also in the active tense. In that case, the translation would read: *rainclouds have withheld [their] rain* (T). The term ‘*al-sawām*’ refers to animals that graze in the open, especially camels (MB). Imām ‘Alī then presents two requests before the Almighty, which make up the core of his supplication. First, he asks Allāh *not take us to task for our deeds or punish us for our sins*. Indeed, traditions tell us that certain misdeeds lead to drought and scarcity of food, such as the sin of miserliness (I) and of unjust judgements by those in authority, among others. During the time of Prophet Mūsā, it is reported that he

once went out with the Banī Isrā'īl to pray for rain, so Allāh revealed to him that He would not answer their prayer because among them there was one who persistently slandered others (*namām*) (T). The second request by the Imām was to ask Allāh to spread His mercy over the people *through clouds of torrential rain, copious spring showers, luscious vegetation, and heavy downpours that bring to life what was dead and restore what was lost*. The term '*al-sahāb al-munbā'iq*' refers to torrential clouds from which rain bursts forth (I), and '*al-rabī' al-mughdiq*' means a spring with plentiful water (T). Alternatively, the latter term could refer to the abundance of vegetation that is fruitful (MB). The term '*al-mūniq*', which is used to describe the vegetation, literally means something that brings about gladness and wonder, and it refers to luscious, green vegetation (N).

The Imām then proceeds to describe, in detail, the type of rain he seeks from his Lord, saying that it should be *life-giving, quenching, consummate, sweeping, pure, blessed, salubrious, and fruitful*. These adjectives have been understood by some as relating to the growth of vegetation specifically, so it means that the water should be life-giving to the dead earth and quenching for the plants, such that they bear consummate fruit. It should be sweeping in that it reaches all the plants, and it should be unpolluted, wholesome, and tasty. He then describes the vegetation that he hopes would grow from this blessed rain, saying that *its foliage* should be *exuberant, its branches fruit-bearing, and its leaves bright green*. The phrase '*nāḍīran waraquhā*' means that its leaves are bright and beautiful (MB). The verb '*tun'ish*' literally means to elevate or raise, and here it signifies bringing the weak back on their feet, being revived and invigorated. The qualities he mentions specify the exact type of rainfall the Imām is asking for, because it is evident that not all rainfall is the same – some can even cause more harm than good (N). The terms '*nijād*' and '*wihād*' refer to elevated and low-lying areas respectively (T). Amīr al-Mu'minīn asks Allāh for this out of His *vast blessings and bountiful gifts* to His *needy creatures and untamed beasts*. The phrase '*waḥshika al-muhmalah*' refers to animals and beasts that have no care-taker or owner, and are left to fend for themselves (I).

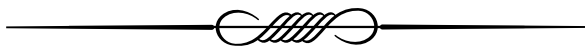
3 In this last section of the oration, the Imām mentions further details about the kind of rain he seeks. He says it should be from *a drenching sky, abundant and heavy; with showers clashing upon showers and raindrops plunging upon raindrops*. The word '*samā*' here refers to the water of the sky (T), and hence it could also be translated as *a drenching rain* (R). The term '*mukhḍilah*' which means drenched

3 And send down upon us a drenching sky, abundant and heavy; with showers clashing upon showers and raindrops plunging upon raindrops; with neither deceptive lightning, nor rainless cloudbanks, nor scattered clouds, nor light drizzles accompanied by cold winds. [Let it be thus] so that with its abundant herbage the famine-stricken may thrive, and by its blessing the drought-stricken may come to life. Verily, You send down rain after they have lost all hope, and unfold Your mercy, and You are the Guardian, the Praiseworthy.

٣ وَأَنْزِلْ عَلَيْنَا سَمَاءً مُخَضِّجَةً،
مِدْرَاراً هَاطِلَةً، يُدَافِعُ الْوَدْقُ
مِنْهَا الْوَدْقُ، وَيَحْفِرُ الْقَطَرُ مِنْهَا
الْقَطَرُ، غَيْرَ حُلْبٍ بَرْقُهَا، وَلَا
جَهَامٍ غَارِضُهَا، وَلَا قَرَعَ رَبَائِهَا،
وَلَا شَفَانَ ذَهَابِهَا، حَتَّى يُخْصِبَ
لِإِمْرَاعِهَا الْمُجْدِبُونَ، وَيَحْيَا
بِرَكَّتِهَا الْمُسْتَشُونَ؛ فَإِنَّكَ تُنْزِلُ
الْغَيْثَ مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا قَطُّوا، وَتَنْشُرُ
رَحْمَتَكَ وَأَنْتَ الْوَلِيُّ الْحَمِيدُ .

or soaked, is sometimes used figuratively to refer to years of plentiful rain and blessing. And the adjective '*hāṭilah*' describes rain that falls with huge raindrops (N). Lightening that is considered to be deceptive is one which is not followed by rainfall. The word '*khullab*', used to describe this kind of lightening, also means a person who promises something but does not fulfil his promise (T). The term '*jahām*' refers to a cloud that holds no water (N), and it is usually a white cloud (R). According to al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, the term '*al-qaza*' in the phrase '*wa lā qaza'in rabābuhā*' refers to small scattered fragments of cloud. And he says that the phrase '*wa lā shaffānin dhihābuhā*' connotes *light rain whose drizzles do not bear cold winds*. That is because the terms '*al-shaffān*' and '*al-dhihāb*' mean cold wind and light rain, respectively. The word '*dhāta*' is elided here because the listener would know that it is implied. The Imām ends his supplication by stating the fact that it is Allāh who sends down rain after the people have lost all hope. Interestingly Imām 'Alī mentions 29 qualities of rain in this sermon, while others who seek rain usually mention no more than one or two adjectives to describe it (N). Many commentators have outlined the etiquette and method of performing the prayer of rain (*ṣalāt al-istisqā'*) in their commentaries on this sermon (N, Z, MB). One commentator notes that among the well-known early scholars, Abū Ḥanīfah was

the only one who claimed that there is no prayer for rain (I), despite the fact that according to narrations that the Noble Prophet had led the people in such a prayer. Generally, however, *ṣalāt al-istisqā'* is established and accepted by all Muslims, and according to some narrations, even earlier Prophets, like Sulaymān ibn Dāwūd (‘a), had gone out to pray for rain (S).



ADVISING HIS COMPANIONS

- 1 He sent him as a caller towards truth and a witness over the creatures. Thus, he conveyed the messages of his Lord without being languid or falling short, and he fought in the way of Allāh against His enemies without showing weakness or giving excuses. He is the leader of those who are Godwary and the vision of those who are guided.

١ أَرْسَلَهُ دَاعِيًا إِلَى الْحَقِّ وَشَهِيدًا عَلَى الْخَلْقِ، فَبَلَغَ رِسَالَاتِ رَبِّهِ غَيْرَ وَانٍ وَلَا مُقْصِرٍ، وَجَاهَدَ فِي اللَّهِ أَعْدَاءَهُ غَيْرَ وَاهِنٍ وَلَا مُعَذَّرٍ، إِمَامٌ مِّنْ أَتَقَى، وَبَصَرٌ مِّنْ اهْتَدَى.

ALSO PART OF THIS SERMON:

ومنها

- 2 If you knew what I know of what is wrapped hidden from you, then you would surely have gone out into the open, weeping over your deeds and beating yourselves in grief, and you would have abandoned your wealth with none to guard it or take charge of it. Then everyone would only care for himself, without paying attention to anyone else. But you forgot what you were reminded of and felt safe from what you had been warned about. Consequently, your views have gone amiss and your affairs are scattered [and disordered].

٢ وَلَوْ تَعْلَمُونَ مَا أَعْلَمُ مِمَّا طَوِيَ عَنْكُمْ غَيْبُهُ، إِذَا لَخَرَجْتُمْ إِلَى الصُّعَدَاتِ تَبْكُونَ عَلَى أَعْمَالِكُمْ وَتَلْتَدِمُونَ عَلَى أَنْفُسِكُمْ، وَلَكَّرْتُمْ أَمْوَالَكُمْ لَا حَارِسَ لَهَا وَلَا خَالِفَ عَلَيْهَا، وَلَهَمَّتْ كُلَّ امْرِئٍ مِنْكُمْ نَفْسُهُ لَا يَلْتَفِتُ إِلَى غَيْرِهَا، وَلَكِنْكُمْ نَسِيتُمْ مَا دُكِّرْتُمْ وَأَمِنْتُمْ مَا حُدِّرْتُمْ، فَتَاهَ عَنْكُمْ رَأْيُكُمْ وَتَشَّتْ عَلَيْكُمْ أُمُورُكُمْ.

CONTEXT

This is an excerpt of a longer sermon that the Imām gave in Kūfah, and he sought thereby to encourage his followers to prepare to fight the Syrian rebels. He

expressed his dissatisfaction with their indolence, and informed them of what will befall them due to their negligence and indifference towards what was happening, and the plots that were being hatched against them by the enemy (M). What al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has mentioned of this sermon here comprises two general themes. The first pertains to some of the praiseworthy traits of the Noble Messenger, while the second is about news of the unseen future and what would happen to the people of Kūfah due to their evil deeds (MB). According to al-Shaykh al-Ṭūsī in his *Miṣbāḥ al-Mutahajjid* (1:380-381), the Imām delivered this sermon on a Friday. Abū Maṣṣūr al-Harawī (d. 370 AH), in his *Tahdhīb al-Lughah* (7:48-49), says that Imām ‘Alī spoke these words towards the end of his life, in the year 40 AH. It has been noted that many of those who doubt the provenance of *Nahj al-Balāghah* and its attribution to Imām ‘Alī have particularly taken exception with this sermon, since it foretells the tyranny of Ḥajjāj ibn Yūsuf which transpired after the Imām had left this world. We have already presented an answer to this objection in our introduction. Moreover, this oration is quoted by many historians and scholars, both before and after al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. These include: Ibn ‘Abd Rabbih in *al-Iqd al-Farīd*, al-Mas‘ūdī in *Murūj al-Dhahab*, and Ibn al-Faḥh in his *al-Buldān* (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The pronoun ‘him’ in the statement *He sent him as a caller towards truth and a witness over the creatures* refers to the Noble Messenger, and the praiseworthy qualities of the Prophet that are subsequently mentioned have been spoken of by the Imām a number of times before as well (Z). Regarding the role of the Messenger as a witness over the creatures, it means that he will testify against the sinner because of his sins, and for the devoted believer because of his devotion to Islam. One may ask: if Allāh is all-knowing, why does He need witnesses? The answer is that when testimony is given against a person who commits a wrongful act, it causes him to be abased and humiliated, while at the same time negating any justification or excuse he might present for his misdeed. So when the people learn that the Prophets will bear witness against them, it may deter them from undertaking wrongful actions (I). The phrase ‘*ghayra wānin*’ means without weakness or laxity (N), and indeed the Prophet never tired or showed any languor in conveying the message of his Lord to the people. In fact, reports tell us that even on the last day of his life, despite severe illness, he still went to the masjid and

addressed the people, giving them advice and admonition (T). Furthermore, *he fought in the way of Allāh against His enemies without showing weakness or giving excuses*. The term '*mu'adhdhir*' refers to one who comes up with lame excuses and justifications for something without actually having a proper, valid excuse (I). In pointing out that the Messenger of Allāh never showed feebleness in the face of the enemies, the Imām was implicitly telling the Kūfans that their hesitation, laxity, and procrastination in facing their enemies was something that went against the practice of their Prophet (N). He then describes the Messenger of Allāh as *the leader of those who are Godwary and the vision of those who are guided*, because he is the role model for the Godwary and shows them how to traverse the path of righteousness and virtue. At the same time, he is the light that illuminates the path towards felicity for those who are guided, thereby letting them see just as one sees the way with his eyes and follows the path to his destination (MB).

2 From this section onwards, Imām 'Alī talks about certain future events. He prefaces his speech about what would transpire by telling the people that had they known the mysteries and hidden truths he knew regarding the future, they would *surely have gone out into the open, weeping over their deeds and beating themselves in grief*. That which was *wrapped hidden* ('*tuwiya 'ankum ghaybuhu*') from the people is how tyrants would gain authority over them as a punishment for their lassitude in carrying out the commands of Allāh and in obeying the Imām on different occasions, such as when Mu'āwiyah's raiders attacked the different townships (T). The term '*al-ṣu'udāt*' connotes open plains or pathways, since *al-ṣā'id* is a land with an even surface (I). Hence the phrase '*lakharajtum ilā al-ṣu'udāt*' means you will go out of your houses, abandoning comfort and ease, due to the apprehension and distress you experience, and will sit on the open paths or the dusty ground *weeping over your deeds and beating yourselves in grief* (MB). The verb '*taltadimūna*' means *striking your chests* the way some women do when they lament (T), and it may also include slapping the faces (R). Furthermore, the Imām says that if they came to know of these realities, they would have abandoned their wealth *with none to guard it or take charge of it*. Normally, when people have to travel, they leave their property in the hands of someone who would safeguard it and take care of it. However, this description shows that the calamity which will afflict them is going to be so severe that they will abandon everything and will only be concerned about saving their own lives (N). The phrase '*lahammat kulla imri'in*' has also been narrated '*la ahammat kulla imri'in*' (*every person will surely be*

concerned for...), and some commentators say that the latter is more correct (I), since it is also used in the verse Q3:154 to give the same meaning (T). People will be so worried about their own survival that they will pay no *attention to anyone else*. It has been suggested that these statements are in reference to what would transpire on the Day of Resurrection, as mentioned in the Qurʾān. However, given that the end of the oration talks about the tyranny of al-Ḥajjāj, and the sermon was addressing the attitude of the Kūfians with respect to battle, it is far more likely that these are descriptions of how the people will react to the torment and oppression meted out to them by the Umayyads in the future (N).

The Imām then mentions the cause of these tribulations, saying that it is because the people *forgot what they were reminded of and felt safe from what they had been warned about*. That which they forgot was the importance of organizing their affairs despite having been warned of the schemes of the enemy and how they sought to gain control over them by causing divisions among them (MB). One commentator suggests that what they forgot was the principle: those who help an oppressor, or even excuse him for his oppression, Allāh will make tyrants rule over them. This is reflected in the verse: *Thus do we make the unjust gain authority over each other because of what they used to commit* (6:129) (T). The phrase *ʿfatāha ʿankum raʿyukum* is rendered *your views have gone amiss* as the verb *tāha* means to lose the right way and end up confounded or perplexed (R). The phrase thus alludes to their inability to reason and understand. As a result, their *affairs are scattered* and in complete disarray, due to the attacks of the enemy on their lands (MB).

3 Because of their persistent defiance and unwillingness to heed admonition, Imām ʿAlī expresses his wish to be rid of them, and says *I wish that Allāh would separate me from you and join me with those who have a greater right to be with me than you*. Those being referred to by the Imām as being more deserving of his companionship are the Noble Messenger and his righteous Companions, like Ḥamzah, Jaʿfar, and others who were considered praiseworthy by him (I). Indeed, the virtuous enjoy the company of other virtuous people, while the vicious enjoy the company of those like them. Having spent about half his life in the presence of the Messenger of Allāh, only to later live with the treacherous Kūfians, it is only natural for the Imām to recall the past and wish to be back in the company of the great individuals who were no longer present (Z). The Imām remembers them fondly, and describes them as *individuals with auspicious ideas who preferred*

3 I wish that Allāh would separate me from you and join me with those who have a greater right to be with me than you. They were, by Allāh, individuals with auspicious ideas who preferred forbearance, spoke the truth, and eschewed iniquity. They proceeded forward on the [right] path and ran on the road [of guidance]. Consequently, they succeeded in attaining eternal reward and bountiful ease.

4 By Allāh, an arrogant and overbearing young man from [the tribe of] Thaḳīf shall gain authority over you. He will eat away your crops and melt away your fat. So proceed, O Abū Wadhahāh!

٣ وَلَوْ دِدْتُ أَنَّ اللَّهَ فَرَّقَ بَيْنِي وَبَيْنَكُمْ،
وَأَلْحَقَنِي بِمَنْ هُوَ أَحَقُّ بِي مِنْكُمْ،
قَوْمٌ وَاللَّهِ مَيَّامِينُ الرَّأْيِ، مَرَّاجِحُ
الْحِلْمِ، مَقَاوِيلُ بِالْحَقِّ، مَتَّارِكُ
لِلْبَغْيِ، مَضُّوا قُدُماً عَلَى الطَّرِيقَةِ،
وَأَوْجَفُوا عَلَى الْمَحَجَّةِ، فَظَفَرُوا
بِالْعُقْبَى الدَّائِمَةِ وَالْكَرَامَةِ الْبَارِدَةِ.

٤ أَمَّا وَاللَّهِ، لَيَسْلَطَنَّ عَلَيْكُمْ غُلَامٌ
تَقِيفٌ، الذِّئَالُ الْمَيَّالُ، يَأْكُلُ
خَضِرَتَكُمْ، وَيَذِيبُ شَحْمَتَكُمْ، إِيَّهِ
أَبَا وَدَحَةَ!

forbearance, spoke the truth, and eschewed iniquity. The phrase ‘*mayāmīn al-raʿy*’ means their views and ideas were blessed and felicitous, and ‘*marājih al-ḥilm*’ connotes their seriousness and maturity as well as forbearance and calmness (MB). The term ‘*maqāwīl*’ is plural of *miqwāl*, which is the hyperbole of *qāʾil*, meaning speaker or proclaimer, and is used to describe how they would regularly and fearlessly speak the truth. An example of this is seen in the life of Abū Dharr who spoke openly against the injustice of the Umayyads. Likewise ‘*matārik*’ is the plural of *mitrāk*, which is the hyperbole of *tārik*, meaning one who abandons or forsakes, and it means that they would shun treachery and iniquity (T). The phrase ‘*arjafū ʿalā al-mahajjah*’ depicts how they hastened or rushed on the road (R). The *road* could be a reference to the path of the *sharīʿah* (T), or generally the right path of guidance (MB). As a result, these lofty individuals whose company the Imām yearned for *succeeded in attaining eternal reward and bountiful ease*. The phrase ‘*al-karāmah al-bāridah*’ means the bounty that is taken without any hardship or difficulty, such as the ‘heat’ of warfare (I).

4 Having previously alluded to what was hidden from the people, the Imām now informs them about what would happen to them in the future. He tells the

people that *an arrogant and self-conceited young man from the tribe of Thaḳīf shall gain authority over you*. When the Kūfans showed their apathy and indifference towards what was going on in Muslim lands, and how Mu'āwiyah's henchmen were wreaking havoc and killing innocents everywhere, like what Busr ibn Arṭāh had done in Yemen, going as far as butchering the two sons of 'Ubaydullāh ibn 'Abbās, Imām 'Alī promised them that they would come to be ruled by the tyrant from Thaḳīf. In some reports, he even prayed for this to be hastened upon them (T). There is a consensus that the person being referred to by the Imām here is al-Ḥajjāj ibn Yūsuf al-Thaqaḫī, whom the Imām describes as '*al-dhayyāl*', meaning one who moves arrogantly, carrying himself in a conceited manner, and '*al-mayyāl*', as he would be overbearing, despotic, and inclined towards injustice and away from the truth (MB). *He will eat away your crops and melt away your fat* figuratively depicts how he will usurp the wealth of the people in his dominion, and humiliate and abase them (Z). Then the Imām spoke as if he was addressing him as one would address someone who was present before him: *so proceed, O Abū Wadhahāh!* The word '*ihin*' here means increase or continue (S). Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī says, "The term '*al-wadhahāh*' refers to the fetid black beetle. This phrase is being addressed to al-Ḥajjāj, and the latter had an incident with such a black beetle, but this is not the place to relate it." Some commentators note that this meaning has not been mentioned in the known Arabic lexicons (I). Others say that since the term *wadhahāh* refers to dung, the beetle here is a dung beetle (M). Though many different stories are mentioned pertaining to al-Ḥajjāj and the beetle, it is likely that here the Imām uses this phrase to symbolize the vileness of al-Ḥajjāj, both spiritually and physically. Indeed, it is said that he was an ugly, swarthy, bald, man – as though he himself looked like a dung beetle (Z). Among the accounts that have been narrated is that one day a beetle came on his prayer mat, so al-Ḥajjāj shooed it away, but it came back, so he shooed it away, again but it came back. So al-Ḥajjāj caught hold of it and it bit his hand. As a result, his hand became swollen and it is from this swelling that he died. Some said that this happened because Allāh wanted to cause his death by one of [what is deemed] the most insignificant among His creation, just as He had caused Namrūd's death by the insect that entered his nose (T). As the Imām had foretold, al-Ḥajjāj became the governor of Iraq in the year 75 AH, and the details of his exploits, tyranny, and oppression have been recorded in the chronicles of history, and some have mentioned these details in their commentaries as well (T, I).



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REBUKING THE NIGGARDLY

- 1 Neither do you spend any wealth for the One who bestowed it [to you], nor do you risk your lives for the One who created [your] souls. You claim honour through [the religion of] Allāh among His servants, yet you do not honour Allāh among His servants! So take a lesson as you settle in the homes of those who came before you, and [from] your separation from your closest brothers!
- ١ فَلَا أَمْوَالَ بَدَلْتُمُوهَا لِلَّذِي رَزَقَهَا، وَلَا أَنْفُسَ خَاطَرْتُمْ بِهَا لِلَّذِي خَلَقَهَا، تَكْرُمُونَ بِاللَّهِ عَلَى عِبَادِهِ، وَلَا تُكْرِمُونَ اللَّهَ فِي عِبَادِهِ! فَاعْتَبِرُوا بِنُزُولِكُمْ مَنَازِلَ مَنْ كَانَ قَبْلَكُمْ، وَانْقِطَاعِكُمْ عَنْ أَصْلِ إِخْوَانِكُمْ!

CONTEXT

This short statement is evidently part of a longer sermon from which it was excerpted by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Though we have no information regarding when or where it was spoken, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has included this oration as part of a sermon that Imām ‘Alī gave at the end of the Battle of Ṣiffin. Interestingly, the author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* mentions no other early source for this oration. However, in his commentary, Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd notes that one phrase has been narrated differently elsewhere, so he must have had access to another narration from a different source (N). In any case, the underlying theme of this oration is universal in nature, and it addresses a common human problem, namely miserliness. In it, the Imām rebukes those who are stingy with their wealth and their lives, not ready to spend either for the sake of earning Allāh’s pleasure.

COMMENTARY

1 The opening line of this oration is a reproof against the people for their unwillingness to spend from their possessions and wealth *for the One who*

bestowed it to them. The beauty and poignancy of this phrase is clear for anyone who reflects upon it (MB). It reminds them that the true owner of all wealth is Allāh, and it is He who grants their sustenance. What they possess, therefore, is a trust that has been given to them, yet they clutch it tightfistedly as though they are the real owners of their wealth (N). Elsewhere the Imām explained that it is only those who are certain about Allāh's promise of recompence that generously spend their wealth in charity (S). Not only were they stingy with their possessions, they were also likewise with their lives. Hence the Imām reproaches them for their unwillingness to risk their lives *for the One who created* them in the first place. This is a reference to their not wanting to participate in *jihād* for the sake of Allāh (Z). Subsequently, the Imām mentions another negative quality of these people. He notes that they *claim honour* through the religion of Allāh *among His servants*, yet they *do not honour Allāh among His servants*. The phrase '*tukramūna billāh*' means that you expect to be honoured for the sake of Allāh. They did this either because they thought of themselves as servants of Allāh (N), or claimed a special position as Companions of the Messenger of Allāh (T). In any case, they generally wanted to be honoured for the sake of Allāh, since they considered themselves devout believers, yet they never honoured others for the sake of Allāh, nor did they benefit His servants or show kindness to them (I).

The Imām then tells the people to take a lesson from two things: from their residence *in the homes of those who came before* them, and from their *separation from their brothers*. As for the first of these, the Qur'ān clearly mentions it in the verse: *And you dwelt in the abodes of those who were unjust to themselves [before], and it was made clear to you how We dealt with them, and We gave you [many] examples* (Q14:45). In other words, just as those who came before left everything behind, they too will do the same when they die. Therefore, being stingy with wealth holds no benefit for people in the long run (N). The second thing to consider is how one gets separated from his close brothers when they leave this world and are transferred to their narrow graves, which they too will one day come to inhabit. As such, people should prepare to meet their end in the same manner, and collect provisions for the Hereafter (MB). The phrase '*aṣl ikhwānikum*', has been understood by some to mean 'the source of connection to your brothers', and is said to refer to the father who was the link between one and his brother, now separated by death (I). However, according to most commentators, it means the closest or most special among one's brothers (M). Indeed, another version of this

phrase reads '*awṣal ikhwānikum*' which clearly depicts this meaning – it refers to the brothers who were closest to a person and with whom he had the strongest bond (T). The lesson to be learned, therefore, is that just as those whose houses you now inhabit and the close friends and brothers with whom you once shared company have left everything behind and now rest in their tombs with no earthly possessions, you too will one day leave everything behind and rest in your grave. So do not be niggardly with what you possess (N).



ON THE RIGHTEOUS AMONG HIS COMPANIONS

1 You are the supporters in the cause of truth, the brethren in faith, the shields on the day of tribulation, and the close associates to the exclusion of others. With your support I strike the one who turns back and hope for the obedience of the one who advances forward. So assist me with sincere counsel that is free from perfidy and unimpaired by doubt, for by Allāh, I am the most worthy of all people for [leadership of] the people!

أَنْتُمْ الْأَنْصَارُ عَلَى الْحَقِّ،
وَالْإِخْوَانُ فِي الدِّينِ، وَالْجُنُنُ
يَوْمَ الْبَأْسِ، وَالْإِطَانَةُ دُونَ
النَّاسِ، بِكُمْ أَضْرِبُ الْمُذْبِرَ،
وَأَرْجُو طَاعَةَ الْمُقْبِلِ، فَأَعِينُونِي
بِمُنَاصَحَةٍ خَلِيَّةٍ مِنَ الْغَشِّ،
سَلِيمَةٍ مِنَ الرَّيْبِ، فَوَاللَّهِ إِنِّي
لَأَوْلَى النَّاسِ بِالنَّاسِ!

CONTEXT

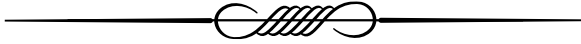
This is an excerpt of the sermon in which Imām ‘Alī addressed his companions after the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH), which was the first battle he fought after becoming the caliph. In it he praised his companions for their courage and steadfastness, by which they managed to end the hostilities and subdue the enemy in a single day. In doing so, the Imām wished to encourage them to remain on the same path of determination and steadfastness, and he likewise wished to strengthen their faith and Godwariness (Z). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* considers this oration to be part of the sermon known as ‘al-Bālighah’ that the Imām gave when he entered the city of Kūfah and addressed its residents (4:507). In his *Tārīkh*, al-Ṭabarī quotes this sermon, with differences in wording, as one of the speeches given by the Imām after the arbitration (in the year 37 AH), however, the wording and tone of the sermon fits the earlier context better. Others who have quoted this oration include Ibn Qutaybah in his *al-Imāmah wal-Siyāsah* (N), and the earliest known sources of this sermon are the works of al-Madā’inī (d. 225 AH) and al-Wāqidi (d. 207 AH) (I).

COMMENTARY

1 Implicit in the Imām's statement *you are the supporters in the cause of truth* is the fact that the followers of the rebels, such as Mu'āwiyah, are supporters of falsehood (T). They are *the brethren in faith* inasmuch as believers are brethren to each other, as stated in the Qur'ān (Q49:10) (MB). They are *shields on the day of tribulation* because when the battle starts, and fighting rages, they act like shields in protecting each other (T). The phrase '*yawm al-ba's*' is rendered *the day of tribulation* and refers to the time when fighting starts or becomes intense (MB). The term '*junan*' is plural of *junnah*, meaning that which covers and protects one from assailing weapons (R). Imām 'Alī also calls them '*al-biṭānatu dūna al-nās*', meaning that unlike others, they are his close associates whom he can confide in and seek counsel from (N). He then tells them that with their support he strikes *the one who turns back* and hopes for the obedience of the one who advances forward. By this he means that he fights those who turn their backs on the truth (MB), and rise up in rebellion and enmity against the believers (N). As for those who advance forward and whose obedience he hopes for, it refers to those who had opposed him but when they saw his companions and their praiseworthy morals and etiquette, they were inclined towards him and their hearts began to obey him after they had outwardly stood against him (I). In other words, just as his supporters help him to fight the enemies in battle, they also assist him in carrying out propagation of his cause through their righteous conduct among the people (N).

Subsequently, the Imām asks them to assist him *with sincere counsel that is free from perfidy and unimpaired by doubt*. It has been suggested that *munaṣaḥah* here refers to wishing him well and supporting him, not offering counsel (S). Some versions read '*munāṣaḥatin jaliyyah*' instead of '*khalīyyah*', in which case it means advice that is clear and evident (R), or pure and unsullied (MB). The term '*al-ghishh*' means treachery or deceit (R). When he says that their advice should be *unimpaired by doubt*, it means that it should be free from any doubt in his rightfulness to the caliphate and leadership over them (MB). The Imām then swears by Allāh that he is the worthiest of all people to lead them, thereby giving them the reason why he expected their unconditional support (N). One commentator opines that even if there had been nothing in the Qur'ān and the Sunnah about his appointment as the rightful successor of the Messenger of Allāh, the conduct and character of the Imām would have sufficed as proof that he was the most deserving of leadership. Indeed, it is a known fact that whenever he had

to decide between what was good for himself and what was right according to the religion, he would always choose the latter (Z).



ADDRESSING THE SOLDIERS

1 [He gathered the people and exhorted them to *jihād* but they fell silent for a while.] So he (‘a) said, “What is the matter with you – have you become dumb?” A group of them replied, “O Amīr al-Mu’minīn, if you go forth we shall be with you.” Whereupon he (‘a) said:

2 What is the matter with you? Neither do you follow the right course nor are you guided to the right path! Does it behove me to go forth in this situation? Rather, the only one who should go forth in such circumstances is the man whom I select among your brave and valiant warriors. It does not behove me to leave the army, the city, the public treasury, the land revenues, the dispensation of justice among the Muslims, and looking into the rights of claimants, and then go out in one contingent in order to pursue another, shaking from one side to another like the unfeathered arrow in an empty quiver. Indeed, I am only [like] the axle of the mill – it rotates around me while I remain in my position, and when I separate from it, its pivot is displaced and its lower millstone gets disturbed. This is, by Allāh, very bad advice.

١ [قَدْ جَمَعَ النَّاسَ وَحَضَّهُمْ عَلَى
الْجِهَادِ فَسَكَتُوا مَلِيًّا] فَقَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ: مَا
بَالَكُمْ أَمْحَرَشُونَ أَنْتُمْ؟ فَقَالَ قَوْمٌ
مِنْهُمْ: يَا أَمِيرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ إِنْ سِرْتَ
سِرْنَا مَعَكَ. فَقَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ:

٢ مَا بَالَكُمْ؟ لَا سُدِّدْتُمْ لِرُشْدٍ وَلَا
هُدًى لِقَصْدٍ! أَفِي مِثْلِ هَذَا يَنْبَغِي
لِي أَنْ أَخْرُجَ؟ وَإِنَّمَا يَخْرُجُ فِي
مِثْلِ هَذَا رَجُلٌ مِمَّنْ أَرْضَاهُ مِنْ
شُجْعَانِكُمْ وَذَوِي بَأْسِكُمْ، وَلَا
يَنْبَغِي لِي أَنْ أَدَعَ الْجُنْدَ، وَالْمَضَرَ،
وَبَيْتَ الْمَالِ، وَجَبَايَةَ الْأَرْضِ،
وَالْقَضَاءَ بَيْنَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ، وَالنَّظَرَ فِي
حُقُوقِ الْمُطَالِبِينَ؛ ثُمَّ أَخْرَجَ فِي
كَتِيبَةٍ أَتْبَعُ أُخْرَى، أَتَقَلَّقُلْ تَقَلَّقُلْ
الْقُدْحَ فِي الْجَفِيرِ الْفَارِغِ، وَإِنَّمَا أَنَا
قُطْبُ الرَّحَى - تَدُورُ عَلَيَّ وَأَنَا
بِمَكَانِي، فَإِذَا فَارَقْتُهُ اسْتَحَارَ
مَدَارُهَا، وَاضْطَرَبَ ثِفَالُهَا. هَذَا لَعَمْرُ
اللَّهِ الرَّأْيِ السُّوْءَ.

3 By Allāh, had it not been for my hope for martyrdom when I meet the enemy – if my meeting him [in battle] was ordained – I would have prepared my mount and then departed from you, and I would not have sought you out as long as the south and north winds blow. (You are slanderers and fault-finders, absconders and connivers. Verily there is no benefit in your large numbers as long as your hearts lack solidarity. I have brought you to the clear path whereupon none perishes save he who is destroyed [by his own hand]. The one who remains steadfast proceeds towards Paradise while the one who slips moves towards the Fire!)

۳ وَاللّٰهِ لَوْ لَا رَجَائِي الشَّهَادَةَ عِنْدَ
لِقَائِي الْعَدُوِّ - لَوْ قَدْ حُمَّ لِي لِقَاؤُهُ
- لَقَرَّبْتُ رِكَابِي ثُمَّ شَخَصْتُ
عَنْكُمْ، فَلَا أَطْلُبُكُمْ مَا اخْتَلَفَ
جَنُوبٌ وَشَمَالٌ. [طَعَانِينَ عَيَّابِينَ،
حَيَّادِينَ رَوَّاعِينَ. إِنَّهُ لَا غَنَاءَ فِي
كَثْرَةِ عَدَدِكُمْ مَعَ قِلَّةِ اجْتِمَاعِ
قُلُوبِكُمْ. لَقَدْ حَمَلْتُكُمْ عَلَى الطَّرِيقِ
الْوَاضِحِ الَّتِي لَا يَهْلِكُ عَلَيْهَا إِلَّا
هَالِكٌ، مَنْ اسْتَقَامَ فَإِلَى الْجَنَّةِ، وَمَنْ
زَلَّ فَإِلَى النَّارِ!]

CONTEXT

There is some ambiguity regarding exactly when this sermon was delivered by the Imām. Most commentators simply say that it was after one of the raids carried out by the Syrian army against some of his subjects in the borderlands of Iraq, after the Battle of Nahrawān in 38 AH (I, MB). However, one commentator states that it was specifically after the raid carried out by Busr ibn Arṭāh against the Ḥijāz (T). It is said that news of Busr ibn Arṭāh's march reached the Imām while he was at Ṣiffīn, and he was also informed that some of his followers had secretly left the battle – that was when he went on the pulpit and gave this oration (S). Amīr al-Mu'mīnīn castigates the people for their apathy, silence, and unwilling-ness to defend their lands against the invading enemy. Ibn Athīr has explained the meaning of some words and phrases of this oration in his *al-Nihāyah*, and the fact that Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd mentions when this sermon was given by the Imām leads us to conclude that he must have had another source for it besides *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). In al-Thaqaḥī's *al-Ghārāt*, there is a sermon which is similar in its theme and

message, and that is what led some commentators to deduce that this oration was made after the raid of Busr ibn Arṭāh (T).

COMMENTARY

1 Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī says that the Imām had *gathered the people and exhorted them to jihād* yet instead of responding positively to him, they *fell silent for a while*. The phrase '*fasakatū maliyyan*' means that they kept silent for a long time (T). It is then that the Imām said to them reproachingly, "*What is the matter with you - have you become dumb?*" At that point, some of them spoke up and said, "*O Amīr al-Mu'minīn, if you go forth we shall be with you,*" meaning if you march against the enemy, we will march with you. The term '*mukhrasūn*' means those who have been made dumb (I), so it is as though the Imām is describing them as having been struck dumb and left unable to speak, and that is why they do not respond to him (N). From the version mentioned by al-Thaqafi, we see that the person who said, "If you march we will march with you," was Abū Burdah ibn 'Awf al-Azdī, who was a hypocrite and would send written reports to Mu'āwiyah about what was happening in the camp of Imām 'Alī (T).

2 It seems the Imām then spoke with anger and that was reflected in his tone. He said *what is the matter with you? Neither do you follow the right course nor are you guided to the right path!* There is a difference of opinion among commentators regarding whether the latter part of this statement is simply informative and seeks to describe the people, or it is actually a prayer against them. Those who say that it is a supplication against the people for their apathy, take it to mean 'may you never follow the right course or be guided aright!' (MB). However, others say that this is merely a statement of fact regarding their conduct, and the form of a supplication has only been employed as a means of censure and reproof (Z). The Imām then asks rhetorically, *does it behove me to go forth in this situation?* expressing how completely wrong they were in their suggestion and how ridiculous their advice was (MB). Indeed, nowhere in the world and at no time in history do we find any ruler go out to fight small bands of insurgents or personally lead troops to tackle small incidents of insecurity. Rather, they have some courageous commanders and loyal soldiers to whom they assign this task. That is because they cannot leave the centre of power vacant for every such occurrence (N). He explains the reason why it is not prudent, practical, or befitting for him to

march out himself noting: *it does not behove me to leave the army, the city, the public treasury, the land revenues, the dispensation of justice among the Muslims, and looking into the rights of claimants*. The phrase '*jibāyat al-arḍ*' refers to the land tax or revenues that are collected therefrom (R).

The duties of the Imām as ruler of the Muslims were many, and he was responsible for ensuring the smooth running of both the economy and judiciary. Petitioners would regularly come to him to present their case and seek their rights, and he would have to ensure that there was a fair distribution of public monies as well. As such, with all the responsibilities that fell on his shoulders, it was not prudent for him to leave the city and the army, only to go forth with a small contingent in order to fight the raiders who were attacking the borderlands, leaving behind all his other duties. Indeed, he describes such an act of going out *in one contingent in order to pursue another, as shaking from one side to another like the unfeathered arrow in an empty quiver*. The verb '*taqalqala*' means to shake or be disturbed and agitated, and '*al-qidh*' refers to an arrow before it has been furnished with feathers and an arrowhead (T). This analogy is used here to describe a state of agitation and disquiet as well as separation from the army and supporters, just as the last arrow has nothing to prevent it from shaking in its quiver (MB). Some commentators note that this simile was often used to describe a nobleman who undertook a task that he ought to have delegated to someone under him, thereby abandoning what was more important for him to oversee (M).

In the *sīrah* of the Noble Prophet, we see that he too only participated in the huge, important battles, wherein he led the troops personally. However, in the smaller encounters, he would appoint commanders to take contingents and fight the enemy as per his instructions (N). To further emphasize this point, Imām 'Alī gives another analogy, comparing himself to *the axle of the mill* or the pivot in the grinding stone ('*quṭb al-raḥā*'). Explaining the similitude, he says *it rotates around me while I remain in my position, and when I separate from it, its pivot is displaced and its lower millstone gets disturbed*. Indeed, as long as a ruler is in the central capital, the affairs of a country run smoothly and in an organized fashion (T). If he were to leave his position, things would begin to go awry, just as the millstone cannot turn properly and remain steady without the axle in its place, and may grind to a halt altogether (MB). This is why the Imām considered the idea of leading a detachment against the Syrian raiders to be bad advice ('*al-ra'ḡ al-sū*').

3 In this section of the oration, the Imām explains why he continues to remain with these people, despite their repugnant conduct. He says that it was *hope for martyrdom* that led him to stay, otherwise he *would have prepared his mount and then departed* from them. Hence we note that it was only his yearning for martyrdom in the way of Allāh that led the Imām to remain in his position among the people, otherwise he would have left them, and would not have sought them out *as long as the south and north winds blow*. By this expression, the Imām meant that he would then never go to them again (N). Subsequently, the Imām describes the evils and faults of the Kūfans (I); however, it should be noted that this last portion of the oration has not been recorded in some manuscripts (M). Amīr al-Mu'minīn tells them that they are *slanderers and fault-finders*, since they would malign those who are above them and try to find fault with those who are like themselves (R). They were likewise *absconders and connivers*. The term '*ḥayyādīn*' means those who incline away or stray from the path of truth, whereas '*rawwāghīn*' refers to those who employ guile to cheat and deceive others (N). The Imām then tells them that *there is no benefit in your large numbers as long as your hearts lack solidarity*, for indeed two men whose hearts are aligned and in agreement are of greater benefit than a thousand whose hearts differ (T). Imām 'Alī then tells them that he has done his duty by bringing them *to the clear path whereupon none perishes save he who is destroyed [by his own hand]*. By this he means that he has shown them the path of security which would lead them to safety and salvation if they adhere to it until the end. However, the exception is for those who destroy themselves by their own deeds or who only outwardly show themselves to be followers thereof (Z). Finally he says that whoever *remains steadfast* upon the path he has shown them will proceed *towards Paradise while the one who slips moves towards the Fire!*



MENTIONING HIS MERITS AND ADVISING THE PEOPLE

1 By Allāh, I have been taught to convey the messages, fulfil the promises, and [clarify] all the expressions. With us, the Ahl al-Bayt, are the doors of [wise] judgment and illumination of the [divine] ordinance. Be aware that the courses of religion are singular and its ways are straight. Whoever follows it reaches [his destination] and acquires [his goal], while the one who steps away from it goes astray and regrets. Work for the day for which provisions are stored, and in which secrets are examined. One whose present intellect does not benefit him, then that which is far from him would be less helpful, and that which is absent would be useless. Beware of the fire whose heat is severe, whose abyss is deep, whose adornment is iron, and whose drink is purulent. Verily the good repute which Allāh, the Exalted, confers on a man among the people is better for him than the wealth that he bequeaths to one who does not praise him.

١ تَاللّٰهِ لَقَدْ عَلَّمْتُ تَبْلِيغَ
الرَّسَالَاتِ، وَإِثْمَامَ الْعِدَاتِ،
وَتَمَامَ الْكَلِمَاتِ. وَعِنْدَنَا - أَهْلَ
الْبَيْتِ - أَبْوَابُ الْحُكْمِ وَضِيَاءُ
الْأُمْرِ. أَلَا وَإِنَّ شَرَائِعَ الدِّينِ
وَاحِدَةٌ، وَسُبُلُهُ قَاصِدَةٌ، مَنْ أَخَذَ
بِهَا لِحَقٍّ وَعَنِيمٍ، وَمَنْ وَقَفَ عَنْهَا
ضَلَّ وَنَدِمَ. اْعْمَلُوا لِيَوْمٍ تُدْخَرُ
لَهُ الدَّخَائِرُ، وَتُبْلَى فِيهِ السَّرَائِرُ،
وَمَنْ لَا يَنْفَعُهُ حَاضِرُ لُبِّهِ فَعَازِبُهُ
عَنْهُ أَعْجَزُ، وَعَائِبُهُ أَعْوَزُ. وَاتَّقُوا
نَارًا حَرُّهَا شَدِيدٌ، وَقَعْرُهَا بَعِيدٌ،
وَحِلْيَتُهَا حَدِيدٌ، وَشَرَابُهَا
صَدِيدٌ. أَلَا وَإِنَّ اللِّسَانَ الصَّالِحَ
يَجْعَلُهُ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى لِلْمَرْءِ فِي
النَّاسِ خَيْرًا لَهُ مِنَ الْمَالِ يُورِثُهُ
مَنْ لَا يَحْمَدُهُ.

CONTEXT

It is evident from the content of this oration that the Imām was reminding the people of his station and how it is incumbent upon them to follow him, obey him, and take knowledge of the religion and its laws from him. Hence he mentions

some of his own merits and his precedence over others, so that the people would not prefer anyone above him in this matter. For the percipient individual, it is evident that these words also prove his sole right to the caliphate and leadership over the people (MB). The first part of this sermon was recorded by Sulaym ibn Qays al-Hilālī before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, while its other sections are found as separate quotations in works like *Ghurar al-Ḥikam wa Durar al-Kalim*, with slight variance in wording. This leads us to believe that the compiler of *Ghurar al-Ḥikam* used a source other than *Nahj al-Balāghah*. Furthermore, Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd has reported that some of the words and phrases of this sermon were narrated differently, which likewise shows us that other sources for this oration were accessible to him (N). We have no information regarding the time and place when Imām ‘Alī spoke these words. However, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this oration within a longer sermon that the Imām gave after he had returned from Ṣiffīn (1:329).

COMMENTARY

1 Imām ‘Alī begins by swearing that he has *been taught to convey the messages, fulfil the promises and [clarify] all the expressions*. He was taught all this by the Noble Prophet (Z), and the phrase ‘*tablīgh al-risālāt*’ has been glossed as conveying the rules of the *shar‘ah* to the people after the passing away of the Messenger of Allāh (I, R). Alternatively, it could refer to all that the Noble Prophet brought to the people. Indeed Imām ‘Alī and the Infallibles from his progeny were the vessels of the Prophet’s knowledge, the guardians of his secrets, and the trustees of his teachings which they conveyed to his *ummah* (MB). By ‘*itmām al-‘idāt*’ the Imām means all the pledges and promises that the believers have been given by the Almighty (N), or the specific promise of Allāh regarding him, which the Noble Messenger had informed him about (MB). It could also be a reference to his fulfilment of the pledges on behalf of the Prophet, who had once called him by the title ‘*munjizu maw‘idī*’, meaning the one who fulfils my promises (R). Or it could mean carrying out what he was made responsible for by Allāh (S). As for ‘*tamām al-kalimāt*’, it may refer to the deeper meanings (*ta’wīl*) of the Qur’ān (I), or a clear understanding of the meanings of both verses of the Qur’ān and the speech of the Noble Messenger (N). Then, to reiterate that he has knowledge of all that the *ummah* needs for their guidance, the Imām said *with us, the Ahl al-Bayt, are the*

doors of [wise] judgment and illumination of the [divine] ordinance (R). The phrase '*abwāb al-ḥukm*' can mean both agents of fair judgment between people, and doors through which the divine commandments (*aḥkām*) are expounded and made clear to the people (MB). If read as '*abwāb al-ḥikam*' then it means that they are the gateways to wisdom (N). Some commentators understand '*ḍiyā al-amr*' to refer to rational beliefs (I) which are illuminated and made clear by them (N), while others consider it to connote knowledge of the Qur'ān and Sunnah, which the Ahl al-Bayt possess more of than anyone else (Z).

The Imām then reminds his listeners that *the courses of religion are singular and its ways are straight*. The term '*qāsidah*' means level and straight (R), or short and accessible (I). The singularity of the course is mentioned here as an allusion to the futility of divisions and disunity (Z). The *courses of religion* connote religious teachings, including that which pertains to creed, law, and morals, all of which have a single goal. It could also refer to the different paths taken towards Allāh through religious praxis (N). Some commentators suggest that this singular path refers figuratively to the Ahl al-Bayt, because they are the doors of faith and the chosen guides of the people (MB). *Whoever follows it reaches his destination and acquires his goal, while the one who steps away from it goes astray and regrets*. Indeed, abandoning the path of the Ahl al-Bayt only leads to remorse and regret (T). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then reminds the people about the Day of Judgment. The phrase '*tublā fihī al-sarā'ir*' is derived from the verse: *on the day when the innermost secrets are examined* (Q86:9), and it refers to the scrutinization of consciences (R), or divulging what is deep within the hearts of people (T). Since belief and practice are dependent on the strength of one's reasoning and intellection, the Imām says that *one whose present intellect does not benefit him* would find *that which is far from him* to be less helpful, and *that which is absent would be useless* (MB). By this he means that whoever is not deterred from wrongdoing by his own intellect and conscience, then the intelligence and admonition of others would not benefit him (I). Alternatively, it means that one who does not benefit from his intellect in the present would certainly not be able to make use of it after death as he faces the horrors of the Hereafter (M). The term '*āzib*' means something that is far and hidden (T), and '*awaz*' connotes something that cannot be found or accessed, and is thus useless and of no benefit (MB).

Imām 'Alī subsequently warns the people of *the fire whose heat is severe, whose abyss is deep, whose adornment is iron, and whose drink is purulent*. The phrase

‘*ḥilyatuhā ḥadīd*’ literally means its ornaments are iron, and this is a figurative way of describing the chains and fetters that will shackle the inhabitants of Hell (I). The denizens of Hell will be made to drink a purulent liquid, as the Qur’ān states in Q14:16 (N). Finally, the Imām says that the good repute (‘*al-lisān al-ṣāliḥ*’) which Allāh confers on a person is *better for him than the wealth that he bequeaths to one who does not praise him*. A similar statement is found in sermon no. 23 (section 4), and by it the Imām means that acquiring praiseworthy traits and carrying out righteous actions such as giving charity, which causes one to be deemed virtuous by others in this world and gains him reward in the next, is far better than amassing wealth for those who will inherit from him with no gratitude for his efforts (MB). This statement could also be understood as encouragement to the people to undertake ‘perpetual charities’ (*ṣadaqāt jāriyah*) such as building schools, digging wells, and such kinds of contributions that would continue to accrue reward for them even after they die (N).



AFTER THE NIGHT OF HARĪR

- 1 A man from among his companions stood up and said, "You forbade us from arbitration then commanded us to accept it, so we know not which of these two instructions was more correct." So he (a) struck one hand of his with the palm of the other and then said:
- ١ قَدْ قَامَ إِلَيْهِ رَجُلٌ مِنْ أَصْحَابِهِ فَقَالَ: نَهَيْتَنَا عَنِ الْحُكُومَةِ ثُمَّ أَمَرْتَنَا بِهَا، فَمَا نَدْرِي أَيُّ الْأَمْرَيْنِ أَرْشَدُ؟ فَصَفَّقَ عَلَيْهِ، إِحْدَى يَدَيْهِ عَلَى الْأُخْرَى ثُمَّ قَالَ:
- 2 This is the reward of one who abandons the pledge! By Allāh, had I forced you – when I ordered you to do as I had instructed – towards an undesirable thing in which Allāh has ordained good, [that would have been better]. Then, if you had been steadfast, I would have guided you, if you became bent, I would have straightened you, and if you refused, I would have replaced you. This would have been the surest way. But with whom and towards whom? I want to derive my treatment from you but you proved to be my disease; like the extractor of a thorn with a thorn when he knows that the thorn bends only towards itself.
- ٢ هَذَا جَزَاءُ مَنْ تَرَكَ الْعُقْدَةَ! أَمَّا وَاللَّهِ لَوْ أَنَّنِي حِينَ أَمَرْتُكُمْ بِمَا أَمَرْتُكُمْ بِهِ حَمَلْتُكُمْ عَلَى الْمَكْرُوهِ الَّذِي يَجْعَلُ اللَّهُ فِيهِ خَيْرًا، فَإِنْ اسْتَقَمْتُمْ هَدَيْتُكُمْ وَإِنْ اعْوَجَجْتُمْ قَوَّمْتُكُمْ وَإِنْ أَبَيْتُمْ تَدَارَكْتُكُمْ، لَكَانَتْ الْوُثْقَى، وَلَكِنْ بِمَنْ وَإِلَى مَنْ؟ أُرِيدُ أَنْ أَدَاوِيَ بِكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ دَائِي؛ كَنَاقِشِ الشُّوْكَةِ بِالشُّوْكَةِ وَهُوَ يَعْلَمُ أَنَّ صَلَاحَهَا مَعَهَا.

CONTEXT

The context of this oration is made clear from the preamble preceding it, and we understand that it was spoken by the Imām in order to refute the contentions of the Khawārij. In it Imām ‘Alī also expresses his sadness at the way people were

behaving, and recalls how virtuous the earlier generation of believers had been (MB). It is said that the Imām spoke these words after the Night of al-Harīr, which was a very violent night in the Battle of Şifḥīn (N). Having fought for almost the entire night, Mu‘āwiyah’s forces were all but defeated, and that was when ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ came up with the idea of raising the *maṣāḥif* on spears and calling for arbitration (M). He knew that this move would lead to division among the followers of Imām ‘Alī, whether he accepted their proposal or not. And that is precisely what happened. Some of the Imām’s companions urged him to accept the call for arbitration, while others opposed it and knew it was only a ruse to end the battle when they were on the verge of complete victory. Amīr al-Mu‘minīn himself recognized it as subterfuge, as noted in the commentary of sermon no. 35 (Z). Many sources have mentioned this sermon, both before and after al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, and each has its own chain to the source. These include: *al-Iqd al-Farīd* by Ibn ‘Abd Rabbih, *al-Irshād* and *al-Ikhtisās* by al-Shaykh al-Mufīd, *Maṭālib al-Sa‘ūl* by Muḥammad ibn Ṭalḥah al-Shāfi‘ī, *al-Iḥtijāj* by al-Ṭabarsī, and *Rabī‘ al-Abrār* by al-Zamakhsharī (N). The part of the final section which describes the qualities of the virtuous is quoted by Abū Ja‘far al-Iskāfi (d. 240 AH) in his *al-Mi‘yār wal-Muwāzanah* as an answer of the Imām to a group who claimed to be his Shī‘ah.

COMMENTARY

1 Details of the context of this oration are mentioned first, and we are told that one of the companions of Imām ‘Alī stood up and said, “You forbade us from arbitration then commanded us to accept it, so we know not which of these two instructions was more correct.” It was then that the Imām struck one hand of his with the palm of the other and began his speech. The act of striking one’s hand on the back of the other is known as *al-taṣfiq bil-yad* and is done to create a sound (R). The Khawārij believed they had erred in advocating for the arbitration when they saw copies of the Qur‘ān raised on spears, and hence sought forgiveness from the Almighty, and considered it a requisite for every believer who was present there to do likewise. One of their arguments against Amīr al-Mu‘minīn was that he changed his position from being against the arbitration in the beginning to subsequently ordering it, and they asked which of these two contrary positions was correct. Indeed, in their view it was not possible for both positions to have been correct. Since the reality was that they were the ones who had forced the

Imām to accept the arbitration, on pain of death, only to later realize their own mistake, the Imām expressed his dismay at their blaming him for changing his position. His outrage at their affront is what led him to strike his hand, which is an act that expressed his ire and indignation (MB). Some commentators say the answer to this question was that the Imām had earlier forbidden them from accepting the arbitration, and he later instructed them to act based on the new circumstances, in which the only recourse was to accept the arbitration. This is something akin to how a doctor instructs a sick person to avoid consuming something one day and then tells him to consume it the next, when his symptoms change (I). However, this understanding is deemed incorrect by others, as explained below.

2 In response to the question of the man who had expressed misgivings about his decision, the Imām took umbrage and said that this was *the reward of one who abandons the pledge*. In reality, it was not that Imām ‘Alī changed his view because of the change in circumstances as suggested by some commentators. Rather, he had opposed the arbitration from the beginning, because it was based on purely evil intentions. However, once they had forced him to accept the arbitration, and had concurred to send representatives from both sides to come up with an agreement, the Imām then forbade them from breaking their word (T). The term ‘*al-‘uqdah*’ here means the sound position as well as the pledge of obedience (N). The phrase ‘*man taraka al-‘uqdah*’ refers to those who abandoned the sound position, which was to continue fighting the Syrians until victory, which was close at hand, was achieved (Z). The Imām then swears by Allāh that if he had been able to force the people to do what they found undesirable, but *in which Allāh has ordained good*, that would have been the best and surest way (T). He goes on to outline how he would have continued the battle with those whom he had compelled to accept his command, if that had been possible for him to do, saying if they had been steadfast, he would have guided them, and if they became bent, he would have straightened them. If they had refused to fight altogether, he would have replaced them with others. But alas, he was not given the opportunity to do any of this by the weak-minded individuals among his companions (N).

According to some commentators, his question *but with whom and towards whom?* means: whom could I have gotten support from and whom could I have turned to for assistance? That is because his compelling them would have led them to refuse to fight for him in defiant disobedience, then he would be unable to

replace them with other followers from distant lands in time, since by the time they joined him the battle would have been over (MB). Others interpret this question to mean that if the Imām decided to fight against those of his followers who had opposed him and joined the ranks of the Khawārij, whom would he take support from to fight them? He could certainly not depend on his companions who were themselves in a state of disarray and division (Z). He then uses the analogy of medicine by which one seeks to remedy his ailment, saying *I want to derive my treatment from you but you proved to be my disease*. He means that he sought reform through his followers, but they turned out to be the cause of the disorder themselves (MB). He then uses a well-known simile: *like the extractor of a thorn with a thorn when he knows that the thorn bends only towards itself*. The verb *naqasha* is used to describe how a thorn is extracted or pulled out by cutting through the skin and outer flesh until it can be removed (T). The tweezer-like instrument that is used to pull out thorns is called *al-minqāsh* (R). Here, the Imām is likening the situation to extracting one thorn using another, when that would likely result not only in failure, but also the pricking of the second thorn, which would only increase the problem (N). The above simile is used to describe one who asks his enemy's friend for help against his enemy, while the person is inclined to help his friend more than the one seeking his assistance (MB). Hence, by expecting their support to fight off the Syrian rebels, the Imām would be like one who tries to use a thorn to remove another thorn, which is an exercise in futility (N).

3 Imām 'Alī now turns his address to the Almighty and complains to his Lord that *the physicians have despaired of this deadly disease*, and by '*al-dā' al-dawīy*' he means the attitude of the people who had grown accustomed to defiantly disobeying his commands, while he uses the term *physician* to refer to himself (M). Indeed, the divinely appointed guides were physicians of the hearts and souls, and elsewhere the Imām also referred to the Noble Messenger as a physician (S). Alternatively, the disease he speaks of is that of ignorance and heedlessness, as well as the inability to recognize what is in their interests, while the physicians are himself and his close companions, or himself and all the others who prayed thus to Allāh among the Prophets and their legatees (MB). The Imām also complains that *the water-drawers have tired of the ropes of these wells*, by which he again figuratively refers to how those who seek to advise and guide the blind and foolish people have become weary as they find their words have no effect on them (Z).

3 O Allāh, the physicians have despaired of this deadly disease and the water-drawers have tired of the ropes of these wells. Where are those who were invited to Islam and accepted it, who read the Qurʾān and resolutely acted according to it, who were exhorted to fight and they separated she-camels from their young, removed their swords from their sheaths, and went out to the frontiers marching steadily row by row? Some of them perished and some survived.

4 Neither were they given glad tidings for those who survived nor condoled for those who died. Their eyes were weakened due to weeping, bellies emaciated due to fasting, lips dry due to supplication, complexions pale due to wakefulness, and the dust of humility was visible on their faces. They are my departed brothers, and it behoves us to long for them and bite our hands at their separation! Verily Satan makes his ways easy for you; he wants to unfasten the ties of your religion, knot by knot, and to give you division in exchange for unity, and with division he causes sedition. So turn away from his incitements and provocations, and accept the sincere advice of one who gifts it to you, and bind it to yourselves firmly.

٣ اللَّهُمَّ قَدْ مَلَّتْ أَطِبَّاءُ هَذَا الدَّاءِ الدَّوِيِّ، وَكَأَلَّتِ التَّرْعَةُ بِأَشْطَانِ الرِّكِيِّ. أَيَّنَ الْقَوْمَ الَّذِينَ دُعُوا إِلَى الْإِسْلَامِ فَقَبِلُوهُ، وَقَرَأُوا الْقُرْآنَ فَأَحْكَمُوهُ، وَهَيَّجُوا إِلَى الْجِهَادِ فَوَلَّوْهُمُ اللَّفَّاحَ أَوْلَادَهَا، وَسَلَبُوا السُّيُوفَ أَعْمَادَهَا، وَأَخَذُوا بِأَطْرَافِ الْأَرْضِ زَحْفًا زَحْفًا وَصَفًا صَفًّا؟ بَعْضُ هَلَكَ وَبَعْضٌ نَجَا.

٤ لَا يُبَشِّرُونَ بِالْأَحْيَاءِ، وَلَا يُعَزَّوْنَ عَنِ الْمَوْتِ؛ مُزَّهُ الْعُيُونِ مِنَ الْبُكَاءِ، خُمَصُ الْبُطُونِ مِنَ الصَّيَامِ، ذُبُلُ الشِّفَاهِ مِنَ الدُّعَاءِ، صُفْرُ الْأَلْوَانِ مِنَ السَّهَرِ، عَلَى وُجُوهِهِمْ غَبَرَةُ الْخَاشِعِينَ، أُولَئِكَ إِخْوَانِي الدَّاهِيُونَ، فَحَقَّ لَنَا أَنْ نَنْظِمَ إِلَيْهِمْ وَنَعَضَّ الْأَيْدِي عَلَى فِرَاقِهِمْ! إِنَّ الشَّيْطَانَ يُسَنِّي لَكُمْ طُرُقَهُ، وَيُرِيدُ أَنْ يَحُلَّ دِينَكُمْ عُقْدَةً عُقْدَةً، وَيُعْطِيَكُمْ بِالْجَمَاعَةِ الْفُرْقَةَ، وَبِالْمُزَقَّةِ الْفِتْنَةَ؛ فَاصْدِفُوا عَنْ نَزَاغَاتِهِ وَتَفَنَاتِهِ، وَاقْبَلُوا النَّصِيحَةَ مِمَّنْ أَهْدَاها إِلَيْكُمْ، وَاعْقِلُوهَا عَلَى أَنْفُسِكُمْ.

It is as though their ignorance is like a bottomless well from which the water-drawers would continue pulling until they grew tired, without any success (M). In this analogy, the Imām is the *water-drawer*, and he tried to use his profound knowledge to enliven their dead hearts but his admonition had little effect on them (MB). Then the Imām fondly recalls the previous generation of sincere and pure-hearted believers. They accepted Islam sincerely and wholeheartedly, and made the Qurʾān their means of judgment, acknowledging that it was from their Lord. They would ponder upon its meanings and act upon its teachings (MB). The phrase '*wallahū al-liqāḥa awlādahā*' is rendered *they separated she-camels from their young* and means that they tore away the camels from nurslings whom they were feeding out of their zeal to rush into battle (R). Most commentators, however, use the alternative narration where the phrase reads '*walihū walaha al-liqāḥi ilā awlādiḥā*' which means *they were enthralled by it (jihād) just as she-camels are enthralled by their young*, meaning that they enthusiastically rushed forward for *jihād* (MB).

These godly individuals who were keen to give their lives in the cause of their faith *removed their swords from their sheaths, and went out to the frontiers marching array by array and row by row*. This depicts their courage and valour, as they never thought of sheathing their swords and fleeing from battle or withdrawing therefrom. The fact that they marched in unison also highlights their unity of purpose and common outlook. Indeed, if such qualities are found in any community, it would result in their success (N). Some commentators understand the phrase '*akhadhū bi aṭrāf al-arḍ*' to mean that they surrounded and besieged the enemy (I), while others take it, along with the subsequent adjective '*zahfan zahfan*', to mean that they would march in the land against the enemy slowly (T). The slowness, however, is not a reference to their speed but to their tranquillity and calmness (R). Their moving row by row ('*ṣaffan ṣaffan*') can also mean that they made up a large army and moved forward detachment after detachment, or battalion after battalion (MB). This kind of nostalgic recollection of the past by the Imām is common in times of hardship, wherein one remembers the good times of the past and thinks about those individuals whose company he enjoyed, comparing that to the difficult people whom he now faces (M). *Some of them perished and some survived*, meaning some of these pious individuals had died, such as Zayd ibn Ṣawḥān who died in the Battle of Jamal, and 'Ammār ibn Yāsir

who died at Şiffin, while others like Mālik al-Ashtar and Muḥammad ibn Abī Bakr had survived these battles, but were martyred later (T).

4 Continuing the description of the pious forebears, Imām ‘Alī says that they were neither *given glad tidings for those who survived nor condoled for those who died*, meaning that due to their deep desire for martyrdom, they were neither gladdened by their survival, nor did they express sorrow for those who were killed such as to evoke empathy and get condolences (MB). This was a sign of their lofty spirit because of which they were not distraught when they lost one of their number, nor did they rejoice or congratulate each other when they survived in battle (N). The Imām then mentions five other qualities of such individuals, saying that *their eyes were weakened due to weeping, bellies emaciated due to fasting, lips dry due to constant supplication, complexion pale due to wakefulness, and the dust of humility was visible on their faces*. The phrase ‘*murhu al-‘uyūn*’ would refer to those whose eyes did not have kohl, and thus were pervious to injury and disease (R). Here, it connotes eyes that have grown weak due to excessive weeping out of the fear of Allāh (MB). As for ‘*khumṣ al-buṭūn*’ it refers to those who are lean and lank in the belly (R). Their dry, cracked lips (‘*dhubul al-shifāh*’) are the result of endless *dhikr* and supplication to Allāh, and their pale, yellowish complexion (‘*ṣufr al-alwān*’) is the result of remaining awake during the night, in worship of the Almighty (N). Some commentators understand *the dust of humility visible on their faces* as a reference to their detachment from this world (M), while others take it to mean the marks (*sīmā*) of worship and humility that were visible on their faces (MB). Having described them thus, the Imām expresses his sadness at their departure saying *they are my departed brothers, and it behoves us to long for them and bite our hands at their separation*. The phrase ‘*naẓma’a ilayhim*’ literally means we thirst to meet them, and it expresses his desire and yearning for their company (N). These brothers whom the Imām yearned for were the great, sincere companions of the Messenger of Allāh, like Ja’far ibn Abī Ṭālib, Abū Dharr, Sa’d ibn Mu’adh, and others (I). The biting of one’s hand is a metaphor for regret and sadness, as used in the verse: *And the Day the unjust one will bite his hands, saying, “How I wish I had followed the way with the Messenger!”* (Q25:27). Here, the Imām uses this metaphor to express his sorrow at being separated from his departed brothers (MB).

In the end, he warns the people about their sworn enemy, Satan. He begins by pointing out how *Satan makes his ways easy* for them. The verb ‘*yusannī*’ means to

make the path easy with the intention of getting others to follow it, and it also connotes opening the doors wide and giving effortless access (R). Shayṭān presents his way as being one of ease in order to entice the people to traverse it, and get them to abandon the path of guidance by portraying it as one of difficulty. Once they enter his way, he leads them, step by step, away from the laws and commandments of the Creator and the divinely ordained religion (N). He aims *to unfasten the ties of the religion knot by knot* and to bring about *division in exchange for unity, and with division he causes sedition*. His unfastening the ties of their religion means that he detaches the people from their beliefs, one by one, and thereby spreads corruption and evil in the society (M). Once he has caused corruption to take root, in the form of misguidance, immorality, and wickedness, he uses these tools to instil hatred among the people, thus causing division and disunity among them (see Q5:91). This in turn leads to the kindling of sedition and dissent (*fitnah*), which ruins both the religious and worldly lives of the people (N). Hence Imām ‘Alī advises them to *turn away from his incitements and provocations, and accept the sincere advice of one who gifts it to you and bind it to yourselves firmly*. The verb ‘*iṣḍifū*’ means turn aside (T), or move away (R), and here it connotes distancing oneself from Satan and his corrupt followers (Z). The terms ‘*nazaghātihi*’ and ‘*naḥathātihi*’ refer to Satan’s corrupting influences and his inciting whisperings into the hearts, respectively (MB). By *one who gifts it to you* the Imām means himself, and he tells the people to bind the advice to themselves firmly, the way an unruly camel or horse is tied firmly (MB). That means they should adhere to his advice and never become heedless of it (I).



ADDRESSING THE KHAWĀRIJ

1 [The Khārijites went out towards their camp, persistent in their rejection of the arbitration, so he (‘a) said to them,] “Were all of you with us in Ṣiffīn?” They replied, “Some of us were there but others were not.” He said, “Then divide yourselves into two groups. Let one group consist of those who were at Ṣiffīn and the other of those who were not present there, so that I may address each group separately.” Then he shouted to the people saying, “Stop talking and keep silent to hear what I say, and turn your attention towards me. And whomever we ask for testimony, let him speak according to his knowledge about it.” Then he addressed them at length and part of what he (‘a) said included:

١ [قَدْ خَرَجَ الْخَوَارِجُ إِلَى مُعَسْكَرِهِمْ وَهُمْ مُقِيمُونَ عَلَى انْكَارِ الْحُكُومَةِ فَقَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ: أَكُلُّكُمْ شَهِدَ مَعَنَا صِفِّينَ؟ فَقَالُوا: مِنَّا مَنْ شَهِدَ وَمِنَّا مَنْ لَمْ يَشْهَدْ. قَالَ: فَأَمْتَارُوا فِرْقَتَيْنِ، فَلْيَكُنْ مِنْ شَهِدَ صِفِّينَ فِرْقَةً وَمَنْ لَمْ يَشْهَدْهَا فِرْقَةً، حَتَّى أَكَلِّمَ كُلًّا مِنْكُمْ بِكَلَامِهِ، وَنَادَى النَّاسَ فَقَالَ: أَفْسِكُوا عَنِ الْكَلَامِ وَأَنْصِتُوا لِقَوْلِي، وَأَقْبِلُوا بِأَفْئِدَتِكُمْ إِلَيَّ، فَمَنْ نَشَدْنَاهُ شَهَادَةً فَلْيَقُلْ بِعِلْمِهِ فِيهَا. ثُمَّ كَلَّمَهُمْ بِكَلَامٍ طَوِيلٍ مِنْ جُمْلَتِهِ أَنْ قَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ:

2 Did you not say, when they had raised the copies of the *muṣḥaf* – by way of subterfuge, guile, artifice, and deceit – “They are our brothers and followers of our creed; they asked us to pardon them and have sought peace through the Book of Allāh, the Glorified, so our opinion is to accept this from them and relieve them of their misery”? Then I said to you, “This is an affair the apparent aspect of which is faith but its inner reality is enmity. Its beginning

٢ أَلَمْ تَقُولُوا عِنْدَ رَفْعِهِمُ الْمَصَاحِفَ - حِيلَةً وَغِيلَةً وَمَكْرًا وَخَدِيعَةً: إِحْوَانُنَا وَأَهْلُ دَعْوَتِنَا، اسْتَقَالُونَا وَاسْتَرَاخُوا إِلَى كِتَابِ اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ، فَالرَّأْيُ الْقَبُولُ مِنْهُمْ وَالتَّنْفِيسُ عَنْهُمْ؟ فَقُلْتُ لَكُمْ: هَذَا أَمْرٌ ظَاهِرُهُ إِيمَانٌ وَبَاطِنُهُ عَدُوَانٌ، وَأَوَّلُهُ رَحْمَةٌ وَآخِرُهُ نَدَامَةٌ، فَأَقِيمُوا عَلَى شَأْنِكُمْ،

is compassion but the end is regret. So stick to your position, and remain steadfast on your path. Grit your teeth in battle and do not pay heed to the cries of the crier who would mislead [you] if answered and be disgraced if ignored.”

وَالزُّمُّوا طَرِيقَكُمْ، وَعَضُّوا عَلَى
الْجِهَادِ بَنَاجِذِكُمْ، وَلَا تَلْتَفِتُوا إِلَى
نَاعِي نَعَقٍ إِنْ أُجِيبَ أَضَلَّ، وَإِنْ
تُرِكَ ذَلِكَ.

CONTEXT

Based on the content of this sermon, it can be deduced that the Imām spoke these words before the Battle of Nahrawān (in 37 or 38 AH) as a means of completing the argument (*itmām al-hujjah*) and leaving no excuse for the Khawārij. Amīr al-Mu'minīn's words proved very effective and led most of the Khawārij to repent and turn away from the battle (N). Al-Sayyid al-Raḍī introduces this oration as the speech which the Imām gave addressing the Khawārij, who had condemned his acceptance of the arbitration, when he had gone to their encampment (*mu'askar*). From other sources, we note that the exact location of their encampment was half a *farsakh* from Kūfah, in a village called Ḥarūrā' (and that is why the Khawārij would later come to be known as al-Ḥarūriyyah). The Imām had first sent Ibn 'Abbās to speak to them, but later he went to them himself and addressed them (T). Some of the arguments presented by the Imām to the Khawārij have already been discussed earlier in sermon no. 36 (MB). A shorter version of this oration has been narrated by al-Ṭabarsī in *al-Ihtijāj*, and Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd says that even though it seems the different sections of this oration are linked, it is actually made up of three disparate sections that are not connected to each other. This, he claims, was the wont of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, as he would regularly select small excerpts of longer sermons, which he considered more eloquent, and then join them together as one speech even though they were not spoken in this way (I).

COMMENTARY

1 Before talking to the Khawārij, the Imām asked them if they were all present in the Battle of Ṣiffin. They responded that only some of them were there. Since not much time had elapsed between the two battles of Ṣiffin and Nahrawān, it is

unclear how the second group, consisting of those Khawārij who were not present at Šiffin, joined them. Perhaps the ideas of the Khawārij had spread among some quarters of the residents of Kūfah such that they joined their ranks, or it comprised of their children and other family members. In any case, Imām ‘Alī separated them into two distinct groups, to be addressed separately. This shows that when an important matter needs to be discussed, and those in the audience are not the same, then it is prudent to separate them in order that each group is spoken to in a manner best befitting their circumstance, for the speech to be most effective (N). Having told them to separate into two groups, the Imām instructed them to quieten down and listen to his words. The fact that he had to shout out these instructions shows that there was clamour and noise among the Khawārij as the Imām was about to speak. He thus instructed them to become silent and listen attentively to what he had to say. Then, he said that if he asked anyone for testimony, *let him speak according to his knowledge about it*. By this he meant that those whom he questions should reply and testify with honesty, and should not conceal what they know (MB). The Imām then gave a lengthy sermon, part of which has been adduced here by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī.

2 Amīr al-Mu’minīn reminded them of what they had said when, *by way of subterfuge, guile, artifice, and deceit*, the copies of the *muṣḥaf* had been raised. A subtle point to note here is that by separating the Khawārij into two groups based on whether they were present at Šiffin or not, it was as if the Imām was telling the people that if the second group had joined the ranks of the Khawārij out of ignorance, the first group cannot claim that they were unaware of what transpired at Šiffin since they witnessed the trickery of the enemy first hand – so what reason would they have to rise up against the Imām and lay blame on him? (N). More generally, this was one of the many instances in history where human beings took the most sacred of things and used it in the vilest manner to attain their goals (J). ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ knew that when the ignorant followers of the Imām saw copies of the text of the Qur’ān raised on spears, they would accept calls for an armistice, and that is why he used this ploy as they were on the verge of losing the battle. Seeing the Glorious Qur’ān raised on lances caused some among the companions of Imām ‘Alī to say, *“They are our brothers and followers of our creed; they asked us to pardon them and have sought peace through the Book of Allāh.”* The phrase *‘al-tanfisū ‘anhum’* means granting them relief (R). In response to their statement, the Imām warned them that this was only a trick by the enemy. His saying *this is an*

affair the apparent aspect of which is faith but its inner reality is enmity meant that though turning to the Qur'ān was a positive step that is outwardly indicative of faith, in truth it was only a ruse to conceal their enmity, which was their hidden intent (M). As such, *its beginning is compassion but the end is regret*, meaning that it evoked a sense of mercy and compassion in you for them, but that would end only in regret once you realize they were insincere (MB). Some commentators have also listed other examples of how Mu'āwiyah used trickery and subterfuge to acquire political power and maintain it (Z). After warning them of the true intentions of the enemy, Imām 'Alī had advised his followers to stick to their position, and remain steadfast on the path. *Grit your teeth in battle and do not pay heed to the cries of the crier who would mislead you if answered*, was his advice to them that they ignored. The term *al-nawājīdh* refers to the furthest molar teeth behind the canines, and *al-nā'iq* is one who drives animals by crying out after them (T). In other words, the Imām told them to continue their efforts in fighting the enemy and ignore the calls for arbitration made using the raised *maṣāḥif* (M). Since *the crier* refers to the call of the Syrians for arbitration, the Imām said it would *mislead you if answered and be disgraced if ignored*, because by responding positively to their call they would fall for their subterfuge, but if they ignored them, the rebels would be defeated and hence disgraced (T). Some commentators note that in this way, the Imām was instructing his followers to stop listening to the enemy, for doing so allowed them to spread their influence and play with the psychology of the people (S).

3 Despite his warning and good advice to them, the people disobeyed the Imām and advocated for the arbitration. The phrase '*hādhihi al-fā'lah*' has been interpreted by some to mean their acceptance of the arbitration, while the verb '*aṭaytumūhā*' signifies their advancing towards it (MB). Then, as another response to the doubt they had raised regarding his position on the arbitration, the Imām states that if he rejected it, it would not have been *mandatory upon him*, nor would he have to *bear it as a sin*. Since the Imām recognized it as an insincere ploy on the part of the enemy, it was not incumbent on him to accept the arbitration even if it led to a cessation of hostilities and a truce (N). As such, he could not be considered blameworthy for not accepting it, and rejecting it was not a sin on his part. On the other hand, had he chosen to accept it, considering it the best option at that moment, he would still be the one with the right of obedience, and the people were dutybound to accept and obey him (MB).

3 (Yet this came to pass, and I saw that you supported it. By Allāh, if I had rejected it, it would not have been mandatory upon me, nor would Allāh have made me bear it as a sin. And by Allāh, if I had accepted it, I would [still] be the one with the right to be followed, for verily the Book [of Allāh] is with me, [and] I never separated from it since I became its companion.)

۳ [وَقَدْ كَانَتْ هَذِهِ الْفَعْلَةُ، وَقَدْ رَأَيْتُكُمْ أُعْطِيتُمُوهَا، وَاللَّهِ لَئِنْ أَبَيْتُهَا مَا وَجِبَتْ عَلَيَّ فَرِيضَتُهَا وَلَا حَمْلَنِي اللَّهُ ذَنْبَهَا، وَاللَّهُ إِنْ جِئْتُهَا إِنِّي لِلْمَحْقُوقِ الَّذِي يُتَّبَعُ، وَإِنَّ الْكِتَابَ لَمَعِي، مَا فَارَقْتُهُ مِذْ صَحِبْتُهُ.]

4 We had been with the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ), and fought against [our own] fathers, sons, brothers, and close relatives. Yet with every adversity and hardship, our belief kept increasing as did our adherence to the right course, submission to the command [of Allāh], and endurance of the pain of injury. But now we have to fight our brethren in Islam because of the intrusion of deviance, crookedness, doubts, and [false] interpretations. And whenever we find a means by which Allāh would consolidate our disordered affairs, and by which we may be closer to each other in whatever remains common between us, we seek it and desist from everything else.

۴ فَلَقَدْ كُنَّا مَعَ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ وَإِنَّ الْقَتْلَ لَيَدُورُ عَلَى الْآبَاءِ وَالْأَبْنَاءِ وَالْإِخْوَانِ وَالْقَرَابَاتِ، فَمَا نَزَدَا عَلَى كُلِّ مُصِيبَةٍ وَشِدَّةٍ إِلَّا إِيمَانًا وَمُضِيًّا عَلَى الْحَقِّ، وَتَسْلِيمًا لِلْأَمْرِ، وَصَبْرًا عَلَى مَضْضِ الْجِرَاحِ. وَلَكِنَّا إِنَّمَا أَضْجَحْنَا نِقَابِلُ إِخْوَانِنَا فِي الْإِسْلَامِ عَلَى مَا دَخَلَ فِيهِ مِنَ الزَّيْغِ وَالْإِغْوِجَاجِ، وَالشُّبْهَةِ وَالْتَّأْوِيلِ، فَإِذَا طَمِعْنَا فِي خَصْلَةٍ يَلُمُّ اللَّهُ بِهَا شَعْنًا، وَتَدَانِي بِهَا إِلَى الْبَقِيَّةِ فِيمَا بَيْنَنَا، رَغِبْنَا فِيهَا وَأَمْسَكْنَا عَمَّا سِوَاهَا.

To further emphasize his right over them, Amīr al-Mu'minīn reminds them of his closeness to the Qur'ān, stating that the Book of Allāh is with him, and he has *never separated from it* since he *became its companion*, meaning since it was revealed to the Messenger of Allāh and conveyed by him to the believers. He mentions the Qur'ān here specifically because the call for arbitration was made using the text of

the Qur'ān (N). Since he knew the Qur'ān better than they did, it was futile for them to use that as an excuse to further their agenda (MB). It should be noted that this entire third section of the oration is missing in some manuscripts, such as the ones used by Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd and al-Baḥrānī. As such, some commentators suggest that it must have been marginalia that later got incorporated in the text (T).

4 In this section of the oration, Imām 'Alī compares the early days of Islam to their current situation, and explains some of the reasons why they find themselves in different circumstances. He says that during the time of the Noble Prophet, the Muslims had fought against their own disbelieving fathers, sons, brothers, and close relatives. Yet with every adversity and hardship, their faith kept increasing, as did their *adherence to the right course, submission to the command of Allāh, and endurance of the pain of injury*. While Islam gives a lot of importance to keeping ties with near of kin, it also enjoins struggling against injustice and the unjust, whoever they may be, even if they are family members (Z). When these sincere believers were thus commanded to fight their close relatives who had rejected Islam and risen in opposition to it, though it was something difficult for them to bear, they accepted and obeyed, submitting wholeheartedly to the will of Allāh. This part of the oration has been mentioned earlier, with a slight difference in wording, in sermon no. 55. It has been suggested that the Imām spoke these words here to tell the Khawārij what was expected of them in terms of obedience to their leader (MB). Some commentators say the subsequent part that starts with the statement *but now we have to fight our brethren in Islam* is not linked to what precedes it (I). The Imām explains why it has become necessary to fight them, saying that it is *because of the intrusion of deviance, crookedness, doubts, and false interpretations* that have crept into the religion. The Imām's statement means that just as they fought in the early days for the establishment of Islam, they have to fight now for its preservation and protection from corruption (M). Furthermore, there is a discussion about whether those who defiantly rebelled in this manner can be called 'Muslims', and some commentators opine that in reality their actions had taken them outside the circle of true believers. They were only called Muslims to distinguish them from the Ahl al-Dhimma and the idolators (I). Nevertheless, since there was still an apparent bond of brotherhood between them, the Imām said that whenever he thought there could be a way by which their affairs could be brought to order, and through which there may be reconciliation, he would seek it and desist from everything else.



ADDRESSING HIS COMPANIONS BEFORE BATTLE

- 1 Whoever among you feels a sense of [strength and] courage when facing the enemy yet sees among his brothers one who is faint-hearted must defend him valiantly, with the greater courage given to him, just as he would defend himself, for if Allāh had willed, He would have made him [timid] like him. Verily death is a swift seeker, neither does he who remains steadfast escape it nor does he who flees thwart it. The noblest death is being killed [in the way of Allāh]! By He in whose hand is the soul of the son of Abū Ṭālib, a thousand strikes of the sword is easier for me [to bear] than dying on my bed (in other than obedience to Allāh).
- وَأَيُّ امْرِئٍ مِنْكُمْ أَحَسَّ مِنْ نَفْسِهِ
رَبَاطَةً جَاشٍ عِنْدَ اللَّقَاءِ، وَرَأَى مِنْ
أَحَدٍ مِنْ إِخْوَانِهِ فَشَلًّا، فَلْيُذَبِّ عَنْ
أَخِيهِ بِفَضْلِ نَجْدَتِهِ الَّتِي فَضَّلَ بِهَا
عَلَيْهِ كَمَا يَذُبُّ عَنْ نَفْسِهِ، فَلَوْ شَاءَ
اللَّهُ لَجَعَلَهُ مِثْلَهُ. إِنَّ الْمَوْتَ طَالِبٌ
حَيْثُ لَا يُفَوِّتُهُ الْمُقِيمُ، وَلَا يُعْجِزُهُ
الْهَارِبُ. إِنَّ أَكْرَمَ الْمَوْتِ الْمَوْتَ
وَالَّذِي نَفْسُ ابْنِ أَبِي طَالِبٍ يَدِهِ،
لَأَلْفُ ضَرْبَةٍ بِالسَّيْفِ أَهْوَنُ عَلَيَّ مِنْ
مَيِّتَةٍ عَلَى الْفَرَاشِ [فِي غَيْرِ طَاعَةِ
اللَّهِ].

CONTEXT

In this oration, the Imām encourages his followers to help each other fight the enemy. He advises them to defend their brothers-in-arms just as they would defend themselves, for it is through such an attitude that the whole community can work together as a single individual (M). From the title found in some commentaries, it is evident that these words were spoken by Amīr al-Mu'mīnīn at the Battle of Ṣiffīn. Also, from its length and structure, we can deduce that it is an excerpt of a longer sermon. This speech has been adduced, sometimes in part only, in a number of other sources, such as al-Kulaynī's *al-Kāfi*, Ibn 'Abd Rabbih's *al-Iqd al-Farīd*, al-Mufīd's *al-Jamal* (wherein he reports from al-Wāqidi) and *al-Irshād*, Ibn Miskawayh's *Tajārub al-Umam*, and al-Ṭūsī's *al-Amālī* (N). In the extant

manuscripts, it only states that this speech was given by the Imām just before battle, without specifying which battle it was (MB). However, according to the report by al-Wāqidi as well as what we find in *al-Kāfī*, it was during the Battle of Jamal that these words were spoken by Imām ‘Alī, and in al-Mufid’s account in *Kitāb al-Irshād*, it states that he gave this oration when he entered Baṣrah (T). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places it in the much longer sermon given before the Battle of Jamal, in which the Imām taught the people the etiquette of warfare and the laws of battle (4:428). It is also possible that the Imām gave this advice to his followers before both battles (Ṣifīn and Jamal) (N).

COMMENTARY

1 There are some important lessons to learn from this brief oration. First is the importance of concord and brotherhood among soldiers in an army, where the stronger among them support the weaker ones. The courageous should defend the faint-hearted against the enemy, and one who is calm and composed should shield those who are fearful. That is his duty and gratitude for being granted strength and bravery, for indeed without these blessings, he might have been timid like some of the other members of his contingent. The phrase *‘rabāṭata ja’shin’* signifies a sense of courage and steadfastness in one’s heart, and here it means that one is able to keep his heart firm and restrain himself from fleeing battle through his bravery (T). Whoever possesses this kind of fearlessness should defend his timorous companions from the enemy just as he would defend himself, because a successful army fights as one, and an army is only as strong as its weakest link (Z). The term *‘fashala’* in this context means cowardice and weakness, and the imperative verb *‘falyadhubba’* connotes defending fiercely and continually (R). The phrase *if Allāh had willed He would have made him like him* can be interpreted in two ways. It may mean that Allāh could have made the courageous man like the timid one (T), or He could have made the timid fighter like the courageous one by granting him courage (MB). In any case, the result is the same: that one ought to show gratitude for His blessing of courage and steadfastness by defending his brother-in-arms (N). It is quite apt that the man known for his unrivalled bravery, ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib (‘a), was giving them this advice on courage (S). The second lesson is in the form of a reminder about the inevitability of death. Recalling that one will have to die eventually makes a person stronger and more resolute in battle, and facing mortal

enemies becomes easier for him (M). Since death is *a swift seeker* ('*tālibun ḥathīthun*'), trying to flee the battle to save one's life is futile (Z). And since death is an assiduous seeker, it takes both one who is ready for it, and thus steadfast in battle ('*al-muqīm*'), as well as one who flees in order to elude it ('*al-hārib*') (MB). The third lesson is that not all kinds of death are the same. Rather, some forms of death are more noble and of greater value than others. *The noblest death* is being killed in the battlefield, fighting in the way of Allāh, as a martyr. That is because dying as a martyr ensures a good repute in this world and great reward in the eternal Hereafter (M). Hence the Imām swears that *a thousand strikes of the sword is easier* for him to bear *than dying on my bed (in other than obedience to Allāh)*. This means that capitulating in the face of oppression and preferring peace with injustice to struggle against tyranny, only to die of old age or of an ailment later, is to leave this world as a sinner who has acted contrary to the command of Allāh (Z). The phrase *in other than obedience to Allāh* is not found in some of the early manuscripts and some commentators suggest that it was inadvertently added later and was not part of the Imām's speech (T). In that case, the Imām is only comparing dying as a martyr in battle to dying of 'natural causes' on one's bed. The latter is something he considered completely unbearable, and his saying it is more difficult than a thousand strikes of the sword was not a mere hyperbole or a symbolic expression; rather, due to his deep love for Allāh and yearning to meet Him, and please Him, he truly would have preferred a thousand strikes of the sword over a natural death (MB). This also speaks to the great status of martyrs and the unique virtue of martyrdom which all the brave, sincere friends of Allāh aspire to (N).



123

REBUKING SOME OF HIS COMPANIONS

1 It is as if I see you making rustling noises like the sound made by lizards! You neither take any right nor do you prevent any oppression. You have been let free on the path, so salvation is for the one who plunges forward while destruction awaits the one who tarries.

١ وَكَأَنِّي أَنْظُرُ إِلَيْكُمْ تَكِشُونَ
كَشِيشَ الضَّبَابِ! لَا تَأْخُذُونَ
حَقًّا وَلَا تَمْنَعُونَ ضَمِيمًا. قَدْ
خُلِّيتُمْ وَالطَّرِيقَ، فَالْتَجَاءُ
لِلْمُقْتَحِمِ وَالْهَلَكَةُ لِلْمُتَلَوِّمِ.

CONTEXT

Some commentators consider this to be part of the previous sermon, while others take it as a separate oration since its content is not related to what precedes it (N). Furthermore, it has been suggested that the phrase '*minhā*' which is found in some manuscripts, and leads us to conclude that this was part of the previous sermon, is a mistake or a scribal error (MB). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has also placed this within a different sermon that was delivered by the Imām during one of the days of the Battle of Şiffin (4:552). Moreover, it has been mentioned in al-Mufid's *Kitāb al-Irshād* and Ibn Qutaybah's *Tārikh al-Khulafā* as part of a longer sermon against those who had dallied and been slow to respond to his call to rise up and fight (T).

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām uses an analogy to describe their unwillingness to fight and their fleeing from battle (M). He says that it is like the rustling sound made by lizards when they cry out (R), or the sound of their skin when they move. The term '*al-dibāb*' is plural of *ḍabb*, which is a certain species of lizard with a rough, jointed tail, like a moloch (T). When the Imām said to them *it is as if I see you making rustling noises like the sound made by lizards*, he was describing how they failed to

remain steadfast when facing the enemy; rather, they would flee from their swords, even falling down over each other as they ran away, and their brushing against each other would make a sound similar to that of lizards (Z). Some interpret the analogy to mean that they could not speak out coherently against the Banī Umayyah, and whatever they said was as incoherent as the rustling sound of lizards (T). Others consider it to mean that they would become as weak as lizards, unable to stand up for their rights (S). The general connotation here, however, is that they were cowards and deserters, which the Imām then emphasizes by saying *you neither take any right nor do you prevent any oppression*, and this is the height of disgrace and dishonour (I). Indeed, what could be worse and more wretched than being unable to defend one's right or prevent injustice against oneself or one's brother? (N). The phrase '*qad khullitum wal-ṭariq*' means that you have been left free before the path (R), so it is up to you to choose which way to proceed. It reflects the verse: *Indeed We have guided him upon the way, be he grateful or ungrateful* (Q76:3) (T). In other words, the Imām is telling them that the path to salvation is in front of them, and nothing is hindering them from traversing it, so they can either advance on that path and save themselves, or remain defiant and face destruction (Z). That is the meaning of the phrase *so salvation is for the one who plunges forward while destruction awaits the one who tarries*. The terms '*al-muqtaḥim*' and '*al-mutalawwim*' refer respectively to one who enters into it and one who waits or pauses in hesitation (R). So safety from disgrace in this world and hellfire in the Hereafter is for one who enters wholeheartedly into *jihād* and advances towards it, while damnation awaits the one who holds back and turns away from fighting in the way of Allāh. Alternatively, it could mean that safety from the sword of the enemy is for one who plunges forward, advancing fiercely, because in so doing his enemy will become frightened of him and turn away from him, while destruction from the enemy's sword awaits one who is hesitant and slow, because that strengthens his enemy and makes him more audacious in his attack, as experience has shown (MB).



MOTIVATING HIS COMPANIONS TO FIGHT

1 Place the armoured soldier forward and the unarmoured one behind. Grit your teeth as that makes the swords skip off the skull, and bend around the sides of the spears as that turns away their blades. Lower your gaze as that makes the spirit stronger and causes the hearts to be more tranquil. And silence the clamour as that helps to drive away cowardice.

2 As for your banner, do not lower it or abandon it, and do not place it save in the hands of the brave among you and the defenders of what must always be protected, for verily it is the patient ones who endure befalling calamities that surround their banners, encircling them on both sides, and the rear and the front. They neither fall behind, thereby surrendering them, nor do they advance ahead of them, thereby leaving them unguarded.

١ فَقَدِّمُوا الدَّارِعَ وَأَخَّرُوا الْحَاسِرَ،
وَعَضُّوا عَلَى الْأَضْرَاسِ فَإِنَّهُ أَتْبَى
لِلسُّيُوفِ عَنِ الْهَامِ، وَالتَّوُّوا فِي
أَطْرَافِ الرِّمَاحِ فَإِنَّهُ أَمْرٌ لِلْأَسِنَّةِ،
وَعَضُّوا الْأَبْصَارَ فَإِنَّهُ أَرْبَطُ لِلْجَاشِ
وَأَسْكَنُ لِلْقُلُوبِ، وَأَمِيتُوا الْأَصْوَاتَ
فَإِنَّهُ أَطْرَدُ لِلْفَشْلِ.

٢ وَرَايَتَكُمْ فَلَا تُمِيلُوهَا وَلَا تُخْلُوهَا،
وَلَا تَجْعَلُوهَا إِلَّا بِأَيْدِي شُجْعَانِكُمْ،
وَالْمَانِعِينَ الدَّمَارَ مِنْكُمْ، فَإِنَّ
الصَّابِرِينَ عَلَى نُزُولِ الْحَقَائِقِ هُمُ
الَّذِينَ يَحْفُونَ بِرَايَتِهِمْ، وَيَكْتَفُونَهَا
حِفَافَتِهَا وَوَرَاءَهَا وَأَمَامَهَا، لَا
يَتَأَخَّرُونَ عَنْهَا فَيَسْلِمُوهَا، وَلَا
يَتَقَدِّمُونَ عَلَيْهَا فَيُفَرِّدُوهَا.

CONTEXT

This oration is made up of excerpts from different sermons, since some parts thereof seem unrelated and we have other narrations which are similar, yet address separate issues (MB). Nevertheless, the overall message and purpose of this sermon is to encourage his companions to wage *jihād*, and remind them about some of the ethics of warfare. Some sources mention that this sermon was given

by the Imām before the Battle of Şifḥīn (in 37 AH) (T). It has also been narrated, with variance in wording, as well as additions and omissions, in a number of other early sources. Naşr ibn Muzāḥim (d. 202 AH) mentions it in his *Waḳʿat Şifḥīn*, and in his *Tārīkh*, al-Ṭabarī also reports it from Abū Mikhnaḥ as one of the sermons given by the Imām in the year 37 AH. It is likewise mentioned in al-Kulaynī's *al-Kāfi*, and Aḥmad ibn Aṭḥam al-Kūfī narrates it in his *al-Futūḥ* as well (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places most of this sermon within a longer oration given by the Imām before the Battle of Jamāl (4:434). However, he considers the last section to be part of a different sermon that the Imām gave during the Battle of Şifḥīn (4:555).

COMMENTARY

1 The first section of this sermon contains advice to soldiers on how to arrange their ranks and prepare to face the enemy. The terms '*al-dāri*' and '*al-ḥāsir*' respectively refer to one who is wearing a coat of mail for protection and one who is neither wearing armour nor any chain mail (I). It is obvious that placing those who have protective armour in the front is prudent as they are less likely to be harmed by the enemy's attack, with swords, arrows, and spears, compared to those who have no such armour. From this statement, we can also conclude that some of the troops did not have armour, either because they could not afford it or they found it too heavy and difficult to wear (N). The second piece of advice Imām 'Alī imparts to the soldiers is that they should grit their teeth, *as that makes the swords skip off the skull*. This is similar to the advice he gave to his son Muḥammad al-Ḥanafīyyah, as mentioned in sermon no. 11, as well as what he said in sermon no. 65 in his description of the art of combat. Some commentators take this instruction to be metaphorical, connoting calming oneself and remaining patient in battle (R). However, as noted in the commentaries of the other instances where this advice was given, the action of biting down on the back teeth does indeed make the skull a little harder to penetrate (N). Thirdly, he tells them that they should twist when facing lances and bend around the sides of the spears, for that will make spearheads glide off their bodies and turn away their blades from them. Indeed, such manoeuvring makes it more difficult for the enemies to harm them with their spears (T). Some commentators interpret this instruction differently, and say that movement of the body is what enables one to strike the enemy more effectively

with his spear. So they read this as advice on how to launch an offensive against the enemy with spears, rather than how to avoid the same (M). However, given that the previous advice and that which follows all pertain to defensive moves, the former meaning is more likely what was intended (N). The fourth advice to the soldiers is to lower their gaze, *as that makes the spirit stronger and causes the hearts to be more tranquil*. This is better than looking straight at the enemy, for that may lead to dread and anxiety, especially when they see their numbers and arms. Furthermore, looking down prevents the enemy from noticing any inkling of fear in their eyes (MB). The same advice is also mentioned in sermon no. 11 and has been further elaborated in its commentary. Next the Imām advises them to *silence the clamour as that helps to drive away cowardice*. It is reported that in the Battle of Badr, the Muslims were proceeding quietly and that struck fear into the hearts of their enemy, since they expected they would move forward with commotion and noise as was common in those days (T). Silence at this time is beneficial, since talking in battle causes one to lose focus and can also impede the physical strength of fighters (N). The link between clamour and cowardice is also seen in the way cowards make loud noises and thunderous roars while the brave remain silent (I), as noted in sermon no. 9.

2 Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī tells the army about the importance of their standard and mentions three things they must be careful of regarding the banner. The first is that it should not be lowered, and the second is that it should never be abandoned. Finally, it should only be given in the hands of the brave warrior who would defend it as something that must always be protected. The phrase *‘fa lā tumīlūhā’* means do not let the banner tilt and lean on one side, thereby being lowered, but keep it upright and straight at all times (T). This is because its lowering causes loss of hope among the soldiers, since they always look at the banner and gather around it (MB). For the same reason, it should never be abandoned or left in the hands of weaklings and cowards who would easily let it fall (M). Since the flag is the centre of focus for the soldiers and they are guided by it and organized around it, giving it to a brave soldier is of paramount importance and can mean the difference between victory and defeat (Z). The term *‘al-dhimār’* refers to whatever one is obliged to preserve, guard, defend, or protect, and for the loss or neglect of which one must be blamed and severely reproved. It includes things that are sacred or inviolable, such as a man's family and property (R). Here, it is used to describe a person who will protect the banner as something inviolable

and will staunchly defend it. Being chosen for the position of flag-bearer is both an honour and a great responsibility. Thus we find that the Noble Messenger gave the banner to Imām ‘Alī in the Battle of Khaybar, for example (N). The Imām goes on to describe the type of individuals who should be made standard-bearers, saying *it is the patient ones who endure befalling calamities that surround their banners*, meaning no matter what difficulty befalls them, they hold the banner high and protect it from all sides (M). The term ‘*al-ḥaqā’iq*’ here is the plural of *ḥāqqah*, which refers to a grave calamity or a very difficult matter (I). Since the importance of the banner was well-known to the people, it was common for enemies to try and attack the standard-bearer of their opponents, and since the banner was constantly under enemy attack, it would have to be protected from all sides (N). Some commentators understand ‘*al-ḥaqā’iq*’ as the plural of *ḥaqīqah* (R), so they suggest that ‘*nuzūl al-ḥaqā’iq*’ here means putting the banners in their rightful positions, or defending the banners when anything necessitates that, such as enemy attacks. In any case, the brave standard-bearer would defend his banner from all sides, be it right or left, from the front or the rear. *They neither fall behind, thereby surrendering them, nor do they advance ahead of them, thereby leaving them unguarded*; rather, they remain with their banners and adhere firmly to them, guarding them with all their might and fighting all the enemies who approach them (MB).

3 Further advice on how to fight together against their enemy is given by the Imām when he tells his followers that each of them should first deal with his opponent (‘*qirnahū*’), fighting him fiercely and not allowing him to escape (Z). Then, he should turn to help his brother against the latter’s opponent as well. The term ‘*ajza’a*’ means to suffice, and here it connotes being a strong fighter who can repel the attack of one’s adversary (R). He should never leave his rival to his brother, *such that both his own rival and his brother’s rival join forces against him*. This means that he should not allow his own opponent to join forces with his brother’s opponent, so that they act together to overpower his brother (MB). In other words, if one turns away to flee from his enemy, that soldier will then join forces with others to overpower his brother, and that is tantamount to aiding the enemy (Z). This comprehensive advice about how to conduct oneself in battle is a testament to the meticulous preparation and attention to detail exercised by the Imām in these matters (S).

3 Every man should deal with his rival and [then] assist his brother as well, and he should not leave his rival to his brother such that both his own rival and his brother's rival join forces against him. By Allāh, even if you flee from the sword of the fleeting world, you will not remain safe from the sword of the Hereafter. You are the foremost among the Arabs and possessors of loftiness. Verily fleeing [from battle] incurs the wrath of Allāh, [and brings about] inescapable disgrace and lasting shame. And he who flees neither lengthens his life nor is it a hindrance between himself and the day of his death. Who will go towards Allāh like the thirsty man goes towards water? Paradise lies beneath the edges of spears. Today the reports [of your valour] will be tested!

4 (By Allāh, I am more eager to meet them [in combat] than they are to return to their homes.) O Allāh! If they reject the truth, scatter their ranks, disband their unity, and let them perish on account of their sins. They will not be removed from their position without facing the continuous piercings [of the spears] that leave gaping wounds, and strikes [of the swords] that split the skulls, fragment the bones, and sever the forearms and feet, and until they are attacked by contingent after contingent, and assaulted by detachments that are

٣ أَجْرًا أَمْرُو قِرْنَهُ وَآسَى أَخَاهُ
بِنَفْسِهِ، وَلَمْ يَكِلْ قِرْنَهُ إِلَى أَخِيهِ
فَيَجْتَمِعَ عَلَيْهِ قِرْنُهُ وَقِرْنُ أَخِيهِ.
وَإِنَّمِ اللَّهُ لَئِنْ فَرَرْتُمْ مِنْ سَيْفِ
الْعَاجِلَةِ، لَا تَسْلَمُوا مِنْ سَيْفِ
الْآخِرَةِ، وَأَنْتُمْ لَهَا مِيمُ الْعَرَبِ،
وَالسَّنَامُ الْأَعْظَمُ، إِنَّ فِي الْفِرَارِ
مَوْجِدَةَ اللَّهِ، وَالذَّلَّ الْإِلَازِمَ،
وَالْعَارَ الْبَاقِيَّ، وَإِنَّ الْفَارَّ لَغَيْرِ
مَزِيدٍ فِي عُمُرِهِ، وَلَا مَحْجُوزٍ
بَيْنَهُ وَبَيْنَ يَوْمِهِ. مَنْ رَائِحٌ إِلَى
اللَّهِ كَالظَّمْآنِ يَرِدُّ الْمَاءَ؟ الْجَنَّةُ
تَحْتَ أَطْرَافِ الْعَوَالِي! الْيَوْمَ
تُبْلَى الْأَخْبَارُ!

٤ [وَاللَّهِ لَأَنَا أَشَوْقٌ إِلَى لِقَائِهِمْ مِنْهُمْ
إِلَى دِيَارِهِمْ.] اللَّهُمَّ فَإِنْ رَدُّوا الْحَقَّ
فَافْضُضْ جَمَاعَتَهُمْ، وَشَتِّتْ
كَلِمَتَهُمْ، وَأَبْسِلْهُمْ بِخَطَايَاهُمْ. إِنَّهُمْ
لَنْ يَزُولُوا عَنْ مَوَاقِفِهِمْ دُونَ طَعْنٍ
دِرَاكٍ يَخْرُجُ مِنْهُ النَّسِيمُ، وَضَرْبٍ
يَقْلِقُ الْهَامَ، وَيُطِيحُ الْعِظَامَ، وَيُنْدِرُ
السَّوَاعِدَ وَالْأَقْدَامَ، وَحَتَّى يُزَمُوا
بِالْمَنَاسِرِ تَتَّبِعُهَا الْمَنَاسِرُ، وَيُزَجَّمُوا
بِالْكَتَائِبِ تَقْفُوهَا الْحَلَابِبُ، وَحَتَّى

followed by cavalries for support, and until their cities are continuously assailed by army after army, and until horses trample upon the surface of their lands, their fields, and their pastures.

يُجَرِّ بِبِلَادِهِمُ الْخَمِيسُ يَتْلُوهُ
الْخَمِيسُ، وَحَتَّى تَدْعَقَ الْحُيُولُ فِي
نَوَاحِرِ أَرْضِهِمْ، وَبِأَعْيَانِ مَسَارِيهِمْ
وَمَسَارِحِهِمْ.

Amīr al-Mu'minīn then reminds them of the futility of absconding and fleeing from battle, since even if they manage to escape *the sword of the fleeting world*, they would not *remain safe from the sword of the Hereafter*. Then, appealing to their sense of honour and nobility, he tells them that such cowardice would not be expected of them as they *are the foremost among the Arabs and possessors of loftiness*. This description is also seen in sermon no. 106, and details thereof can be found in its commentary. The Imām then mentions three negative consequences of fleeing from battle, namely *the wrath of Allāh, inescapable disgrace, and lasting shame*. The phrase '*mawjidadallāh*' refers to Allāh's anger and displeasure (R). Indeed, in this regard the Qur'ān states: *And whoever turns his back to them that day – unless as a stratagem for battle or to withdraw to another company – has indeed earned the wrath of Allāh...* (Q8:16) (T). *Inescapable disgrace* translates '*al-dhull al-lāzim*', which connotes ignominy that remains with a person as long as he lives and is a source of *lasting shame* ('*al-ār al-bāqī*') for him, and possibly even for his progeny (Z). Furthermore, fleeing from the battlefield does not ensure that one will live longer, nor does it act as an impediment to his death. The Qur'ān clearly says this: *Say, "Fleeing will do you no good if you flee from death or slaughter, since you will not be allowed to enjoy [life] but for a little while [longer]."* (Q33:16). Indeed, everyone's death has already been decreed, and when his time comes, he will die, regardless of which state he is in (M).

The Imām then asks who among them would *go towards Allāh like the thirsty man goes towards water*? By this he means rushing with zeal to fight in the way of Allāh, yearning for martyrdom, the same way a thirsty person yearns for water and approaches it (N). The phrase '*aṭrāf al-awālī*' could refer to all the edges of spear blades, or only their topmost points or tips (T). His statement *Paradise lies beneath the edges of spears* is similar to the statement attributed to the Noble Prophet in which he said, during the Battle of Uḥud, "Paradise lies under the shade of swords

(*al-jannatu taḥta ḡilāl al-suyūf*).” That was likewise meant as encouragement and motivation to rush into battle against the enemy with the promise of Paradise for those who would do so. Indeed, even the Qur’ān tells us that the price of entry into Paradise is self-sacrifice and patience in the face of hardships (Q3:142) (Z). Then Imām ‘Alī tells them *today the reports [of your valour] will be tested*, meaning the reports of what transpires in battle will show the true status of individuals, whether they have strong faith or are only hypocrites, whether they are brave warriors or weak cowards, and other such qualities (MB). These reports could include information about their actions or speech in the battlefield (N).

4 The opening phrase of this section, where Imām ‘Alī states that he is *more eager to meet them [in combat] than they are to return to their homes*, is not found in some manuscripts (T). The Imām’s eagerness was actually to meet his Lord, due to his complete submission to Him, and the easiest way to achieve that was by fighting the enemies of Allāh and attaining martyrdom thereby. That is why he was eager to meet his enemy in battle (Z). Alternatively, it means that the Imām had a zeal for the establishment of justice, and that could only be done by fighting the enemies of justice. His mentioning this to his followers implied that they too should cultivate the same kind of zeal for combat against the enemies of Allāh (N). Praying against those who would stubbornly challenge the truth and reject it, the Imām asks Allāh to *scatter their ranks, disband their unity, and let them perish on account of their sins*. This was his supplication against the Syrian rebels who decided to persist in their rebellion (I). The phrase *‘albishum bi khaṭāyāhum’* means deliver them to perdition, as seen by the use of the same verb in the verse: *Those are the ones delivered to perdition for what they have earned...* (Q6:70). The Imām prays that they should be disunited among themselves, and differ in their views, thereby weakening them before they are completely destroyed because of the sins they have committed (MB). It is noteworthy that his supplication against them was conditional upon their obstinate refusal to accept the truth. That is because the Imām’s objective was not gaining ascendancy over them and becoming their ruler. Rather, it was only that they should accept the truth (N). Then he said that they would only be dislodged from their positions and removed from their rebellious stance by the language of force, when they face the *continuous piercings [of the spears] that leave gaping wounds, and strikes [of the swords] that split the skulls, fragment the bones, and sever the forearms and feet*. The phrase *‘ta’nin dirākin’* connotes successive piercings that continuously jab the

enemy (R). *Gaping wounds* translates ‘*al-nasīm*’, which literally means wounds so large that a ‘breeze’ could have passed through them (I). ‘*Yundir al-sawāʿid*’ means that their forearms are severed and cut off (T). To emphasize the way in which they have to be forcefully dealt with, the Imām says that they will not turn back from their rebellion *until they are attacked by contingent after contingent..., and until their cities are continuously assailed by army after army, and until horses trample upon the surface of their lands, their fields, and their pastures*. The term ‘*al-manāsir*’ is plural of *minsar*, which refers to a contingent that usually goes ahead of the main army (R). The continuous attack of contingents and armies signifies the importance of not leaving the battle incomplete, such that the enemy could recuperate and launch another attack after regrouping (N). The term ‘*al-ḥalāʾib*’ generally refers to supporters who come from all directions to assist (I), and would particularly be used for one’s paternal cousins who came to his aid (R). Since the term also means a group of horses, some commentators say that here it refers to a cavalry (N). An army is also called ‘*al-khamīs*’ because it is made up of five sections: the centre, the right flank, the left flank, the vanguard, and the rear (T). As-Sayyid al-Raḍī says that the term ‘*al-daʿq*’ means pounding (*al-daqq*), i.e. the horses of the cavalry pound with their hooves as they trample on their land. He adds that the phrase ‘*nawāḥiri arḍihim*’ means opposite parts of the land that face one another. It is said, ‘*manāzilu banī fulān tatanāḥar*’ meaning the houses of such-and-such tribe face one another. One commentator remarks that if the army of the Imām had followed this instruction in the Battle of Ṣiffīn where these [last] statements were made, the sedition of the Umayyads would forever have been quashed; but alas, they heard his words yet did not follow him (N).



ON THE KHAWĀRIJ AND THEIR OPINION ABOUT THE ARBITRATION

1 We did not make people the arbiters; rather, we took only the Qurʾān as the arbiter. This Qurʾān is only [a series of] lines inscribed between two covers, it does not speak with a tongue and requires an interpreter, so only men can speak on its behalf. When these people invited us to make the Qurʾān an arbiter between us, we were not the group that turned away from the Book of Allāh, for Allāh has said: *And if you dispute concerning anything, refer it to Allāh and the Messenger*, where referring to Allāh means that we must decide according to His Book while referring to the Prophet means that we must take from his Sunnah. Thus, if arbitration were to be truly done based on the Book of Allāh, we are the most worthy of all people for it, and if it is done based on the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ), then we are the most worthy of all people and have a greater right than them to it.

2 As for your question: 'Why did you specify a period for the arbitration between yourself and them?' I only did this so that the ignorant may find clarity and the informed one may fortify his conviction. I hoped that Allāh would improve the condition of

١ إِنَّا لَمْ نُحَكِّمِ الرِّجَالَ، وَإِنَّمَا حَكَّمْنَا الْقُرْآنَ. هَذَا الْقُرْآنُ إِنَّمَا هُوَ حَظٌّ مَسْطُورٌ بَيْنَ الدَّفْئَتَيْنِ، لَا يَنْطِقُ بِلِسَانٍ وَلَا يُدَّ لَهُ مِنْ تَرْجُمَانٍ، وَإِنَّمَا يَنْطِقُ عَنْهُ الرِّجَالُ. وَلَمَّا دَعَانَا الْقَوْمُ إِلَى أَنْ نُحَكِّمَ بَيْنَنَا الْقُرْآنَ لَمْ نَكُنِ الْفَرِيقَ الْمُتَوَلِّيَّ عَنْ كِتَابِ اللَّهِ، وَقَدْ قَالَ اللَّهُ شُبْحَانَهُ: «فَإِنْ تَنَازَعْتُمْ فِي شَيْءٍ فَرُدُّوهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَالرَّسُولِ»، فَرَدُّهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ أَنْ نُحَكِّمَ بِكِتَابِهِ، وَرَدُّهُ إِلَى الرَّسُولِ أَنْ نَأْخُذَ بِسُنَّتِهِ؛ فَإِذَا حُكِمَ بِالْصِّدْقِ فِي كِتَابِ اللَّهِ فَنَحْنُ أَحَقُّ النَّاسِ بِهِ، وَإِنْ حُكِمَ بِسُنَّةِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ فَنَحْنُ أَحَقُّ النَّاسِ وَأَوْلَاهُمْ بِهَا.

٢ وَأَمَّا قَوْلُكُمْ: لِمَ جَعَلْتَ بَيْنَكَ وَبَيْنَهُمْ أَجَلًا فِي التَّحْكِيمِ؟ فَإِنَّمَا فَعَلْتُ ذَلِكَ لِیَسْبِیْنَ الْجَاهِلِ، وَیَسْتَبِیْتَ الْعَالِمِ، وَلَعَلَّ اللَّهَ أَنْ يُصْلِحَ فِي هَذِهِ الْهُدْيَةِ أَمْرَ هَذِهِ الْأُمَّةِ، وَلَا تُؤَخَّذَ

this nation during this truce, so it would not be seized by constrictions, thereby being hasty, before the truth becomes clear, and follow the first falsehood [that comes its way].

بِأَكْظَامِهَا، فَتَعْجَلَ عَنْ تَبَيُّنِ الْحَقِّ،
وَتَتَّقَادَ لِأَوَّلِ الْعَيِّ.

CONTEXT

This sermon was addressing the position of the Khawārij, who had opposed the arbitration after initially advocating it. Further details of that are mentioned in the commentary of sermon no. 35, and his response to them has also been discussed in the commentary of sermon no. 36 (MB). Some commentators say that this oration was given by the Imām after he heard about the outcome of the arbitration and how Abū Mūsā al-Ash‘arī had been duped by ‘Amr ibn al-Āṣ (M). In his *Tārīkh*, al-Ṭabarī mentions that this sermon was delivered in the year 37 AH, when the Imām came to the Khawārij while they were arguing with Ibn ‘Abbās about the issue of the arbitration. The Imām asked Ibn ‘Abbās to remain silent and then he began speaking to them. He asked them, “Who is your leader?” They replied, “Ibn Kawwā” So the Imām addressed him asking, “Why have you risen up in opposition to us?” He said, “Because of your acceptance of the arbitration in the Battle of Ṣiffīn.” At that, the Imām asked him, by Allāh, whether he knew that they were the ones who called for the acceptance of arbitration when the *maṣāhif* were raised on lances, and that he had opposed this and advised them against it, but they refused to listen to him and insisted on the arbitration. Having no answer, they asked, “Do you consider it fair to allow a man to judge in a case of bloodshed?” The Imām replied, “We did not make men the judges, rather we placed the Qur’ān as the judge.” Then he gave this sermon, or part thereof (N). According to some, this sermon actually comprises excerpts from three orations that were given by the Imām at different times. The first part thereof, comprising the first two sections, was in the context mentioned above. The second part, made up of the first half of the third section, was addressed to ‘Amr ibn al-Āṣ, and the last part was addressed to his followers after the Battle of Nahrawān, encouraging them to prepare for a second encounter with Mu‘āwiyah (T). Portions of this sermon have

been mentioned in other early sources such as *al-Tadhkirah* by Sibṭ ibn al-Jawzī, *al-Irshād* by al-Mufid, and *al-Ihtijāj* by al-Tabarsī.

COMMENTARY

1 The first clarification given by Imām ‘Alī was that he did not appoint men to arbitrate; rather, he sought arbitration from the Qur’ān. However, the Imām explains, this Qur’ān is only a series of written lines, enclosed between two covers. It does not speak with a tongue and therefore requires an interpreter, and those who speak on its behalf are men. The term ‘*al-daffatayn*’ refer to the two covers on either side of the written Qur’ān, which used to be made of wood in the past, and later of leather and other such materials (I). By this statement, the Imām negates one of the premises of their accusation, clarifying that the men who were acting as arbitrators were bound to act upon the Qur’ān, and could not pass judgement based on their own reasoning (M). By *interpreter* (‘*tarjumān*’), the Imām means a person who is capable of understanding it and has knowledge of its words and meanings (Z). Indeed, the matter of arbitration was no different from what was expected of any Muslim judge (*qāḍī*) in the land, which was to pass judgment based on the teachings of the Qur’ān and the Sunnah (N). The Imām then explains how when the Syrians proposed to have the Qur’ān arbitrate between them, he did not turn away from the Book of Allāh, because Allāh has Himself commanded: *And if you dispute concerning anything, refer it to Allāh and the Messenger...* (Q4:59). He further explains that *referring to Allāh means that we must decide according to His Book while referring to the Prophet means that we must take from his Sunnah*. This is an elucidation of what is meant by the part of the verse he quoted (T). As such, the Imām had accepted the ruling of the Qur’ān, not of Mu‘āwiyah and his minions. This was even made clear in a letter the Imām had sent to Mu‘āwiyah wherein he said, “You called us to an arbitration based on the Qur’ān, though you are not one of its adherents, and it is not to you that we responded favourably. Rather, we responded to the Qur’ān and its ruling” (Z). Imām ‘Alī then notes that if the arbitration had been executed in accordance with the Book of Allāh, *we are the most worthy of all people for it*, meaning I would have been found to be the person most worthy of the caliphate. And if it had been executed according to the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allāh, then *we are the most worthy of all people and have a greater right than them to it*, meaning I would have been established as the most

deserving. Alternatively, he meant that he was the most worthy of acting upon the Qur'ān and the rulings found in the Book of Allāh and the Sunnah of the Noble Messenger, for he had been taught by him personally (MB).

2 In this section of the sermon, the Imām responds to one of the objections of the Khawārij pertaining to the reason for his assigning a specific period for the arbitration. Early sources tell us that in the truce agreed upon by the Imām, the arbitrators were given one year to work out the differences of the two sides and come up with a mutually agreeable solution, based on the Qur'ān and Sunnah (N). Granting sufficient time meant that things could progress with calmness and deliberation. The time would allow the ignorant ones to *find clarity* by learning what they were hitherto unaware of, and would increase the conviction of the informed ones who were aware of the reality of the situation. Thus, the Imām hoped that the interval would lead to reforming the state of the believers (I). The truce ('*al-hudnah*') gave people time to ponder their affair, so that those who acted out of emotion and prejudice could reconsider their stance and reflect on the matter. Yet surprisingly, the ignorant and headstrong Khawārij kept insisting upon a quick decision on this matter (N). The phrase '*lā tu'khadha bi akẓāmiḥā*' is rendered *would not be seized by constrictions*, and means that it would give the nation time to breathe again, and grant them some relief from the strain of battle (Z). Given that *kaẓm* refers to the throat or windpipe (T), the literal meaning of this metaphor would be to avoid the stifling and suffocation of the nation that resulted from fighting each other, or remaining ignorant of the truth due to its obfuscation by the enemy (MB). When faced with a distressing situation that brings about anxiety and unease, people seek a swift end to their predicament, which leads them to make hasty decisions. So the Imām says that he did not want the constriction and suffocation of battle to lead them to be impulsive *before the truth becomes clear*. In other words, had he not given them that period of relief, it would have perhaps led to their falling deeper into error (I). Furthermore, their haste would have led them to follow *the first falsehood* that came their way. Some commentators consider the first falsehood ('*awwal al-ghay'*') to be a reference to the act of raising the *maṣāḥif* on spears (MB), while others take it to be a general statement meaning that they would easily fall prey to falsehood (N). Indeed, if the Imām had rejected the armistice and hastened the matter, it would have been tantamount to blocking the way for those who had erred; but in this way, he gave them all the opportunity to repent and reform (Z).

3 Verily the best of all people in the sight of Allāh is he for whom acting upon the truth is more beloved – even if it causes him loss and distress, than falsehood – even if it brings him benefit and increase. So where are you being misled to?! And from where have you been assailed?! Prepare for the march against the people who have wavered from the truth and do not see it, who have been enticed by iniquity and do not wish to turn away from it [towards justice]. They abide not by the Book and have deviated from the [right] path.

4 You are neither a strong handle that one could cling to, nor are you mighty supporters that one can depend upon. You are the worst kindling for the fire of battle! Fie on you! I have suffered great agony from you. One day I call you loudly and another day I whisper to you in private, yet neither are you truly free men when called upon, nor are you trustworthy brothers when spoken to in confidence!

٣ إِنَّ أَفْضَلَ النَّاسِ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ مَنْ
كَانَ الْعَمَلُ بِالْحَقِّ أَحَبَّ إِلَيْهِ -
وَإِنْ نَقَصَهُ وَكَرَّئُهُ - مِنَ الْبَاطِلِ
وَإِنْ جَرَّ إِلَيْهِ فَائِدَةٌ وَزَادَهُ، فَلَا
يُتَاهِ بِكُمْ؟! وَمِنْ أَيْنَ أُتِيتُمْ؟!
اسْتَعِدُّوا لِلْمَسِيرِ إِلَى قَوْمٍ
حَيَارَى عَنِ الْحَقِّ لَا يَنْصُرُونَهُ،
وَمُؤَرَّعِينَ بِالْجَوْرِ لَا يَعْدِلُونَ بِهِ،
جُفَاءً عَنِ الْكِتَابِ، نُكِبَ عَنِ
الطَّرِيقِ.

٤ مَا أَنْتُمْ بِوُثِيقَةٍ يَغْلَقُ بِهَا، وَلَا
رَوَافِرَ عِزٍّ يَعْتَصِمُ إِلَيْهَا؛ لِبُئْسَ
حُشَّاشُ نَارِ الْحَرْبِ أَنْتُمْ! أَفَّ
لَكُمْ! لَقَدْ لَقِيتُ مِنْكُمْ بَرْحًا،
يَوْمًا أَنْادِيكُمْ وَيَوْمًا أَنْاجِيكُمْ،
فَلَا أَحْرَارَ صِدْقٍ عِنْدَ النَّدَاءِ،
وَلَا إِخْوَانَ ثِقَةٍ عِنْدَ النَّجَاءِ!

3 Amīr al-Mu'minīn describes those whom Allāh loves and considers the best of people, saying that they are the ones who hold the truth dearer than falsehood, even if it causes them *loss and distress* while falsehood brings them *benefit and increase*. By mentioning this, the Imām sought to encourage the people to espouse the truth regardless of what it entails, and to eschew falsehood even if it profits them (M). As mentioned earlier, according to some sources this statement was part of the advice addressed to 'Amr ibn al-Āṣ, reminding him that for one who has faith, adhering to the truth will bring reward in the Hereafter, whereas

falsehood will result in punishment and loss in the next life, even if it brings about temporary gain in this world (T). The two rhetorical questions *where are you being misled to?! And from where have you been assailed?!* are meant to awaken the people from their heedlessness, and draw their attention to the truth that is in front of them (Z). ‘*Ayna yutāhu bikum*’ means where are you heading in your bewilderment (T) and confusion (MB)? And ‘*min ayna utitum*’ means how did Satan enter upon you, or how did doubt beset you (I)? Imām ‘Alī then describes the enemy against whom he urges his followers to march. They are those *who have wavered from the truth and do not see it* and *who have been incited by iniquity and do not turn from it*. The phrase ‘*ḥayārā ‘an al-ḥaqq*’ literally means confounded or distracted from the truth (MB), and it refers to Mu‘āwiyah and the Syrians (T). ‘*Mūza‘ina bil-jawr*’ means they were enticed or seduced by tyranny and injustice, while ‘*lā ya‘dilūna bihi*’ means that they find nothing to be as pleasing to them and are unwilling to exchange it with anything else (I). Indeed, these were people who did not abide by the teachings of the Qur‘ān, and had deviated from the right path. The phrase ‘*jufātin ‘an al-kitāb*’ means they were far from the Book of Allāh (MB), or were in disagreement with it, acting contrary to it (I). By describing their foes in such detail, the Imām sought to urge his followers to rise up against them with the required passion and fervour one should have when faced with such an evil enemy (Z).

4 In this final section, Amīr al-Mu‘minīn rebukes his followers for their apathy. He tells them that they are *neither a strong handle* he could cling to for support, nor are they *mighty supporters* that he can depend upon. The term ‘*wathīqah*’ is used to mean firm handle (M), and ‘*zawāfir*’ is the plural of *zāfirah*, and connotes kinsfolk and supporters or aides (I). Because they could not be relied upon to support or defend the Imām and the Muslims from their enemy, he tells them *you are the worst kindling for the fire of battle*, by which he expresses his disappointment with them (T). Being *the worst kindling* here means that they are of no use at all in battle (Z), or that they cannot ignite the fire that is required for a successful encounter against the enemy (N). The expression *fire on you* (‘*uffin lakum*’) is used to censure their cowardice and abandonment (Z). He tells them that he has suffered *great agony* at their hands. The term ‘*barḥan*’ means difficulty, distress, and affliction. It also connotes annoyance and inconvenience. In another version this term has also been narrated as ‘*tarḥan*’, meaning sadness (I). The Imām then says that sometimes he calls them loudly, rallying them in public to

come forth and prepare for *jihād*, and at other times he whispers to them, discussing with them privately concerning matters pertaining to stratagems of war, and trying to guide them regarding it. *Yet neither are you truly free men when called upon, nor are you trustworthy brothers when spoken to in confidence*, meaning that when they are openly called to come forth, they do not show their support like brave, free men, and when they are spoken to in private, they do not keep the secret (MB). In other words, what the Imām is conveying by these statements is that if any difficulty has come about in his rule, and in countering their enemies, it is due to the unworthiness and ineptitude of some of his followers who showed weakness and apathy at every juncture. They neither responded to his calls, not followed his admonition, nor did they hide the secrets that were shared regarding how to fight the adversary (N).



WHEN HE WAS CENSURED FOR EQUAL DISTRIBUTION

- 1 Do you instruct me to seek support by oppressing those over whom I have authority?! By Allāh, I will never do that as long as the world goes round, and as long as one star follows another in the sky! If it were my own property, I would have distributed it equally among them, then how could I not do so when it is their property?!
- 2 [Then he (‘a) said:] Look, verily giving wealth where it is unwarranted is wastefulness and extravagance. It elevates the giver in this world, but lowers him in the Hereafter. It honours him among people, but disgraces him in the sight of Allāh. No man spends his wealth in that which is inappropriate or gives it to the underserving but that Allāh deprives him of their gratitude, and their affection is diverted towards someone else. Then if he slips one day and needs their help, they would prove to be the worst friends and the most ignoble comrades!
- ١ أَتَأْمُرُونِي أَنْ أَطْلُبَ النَّصْرَ بِالْجَوْرِ فَيَمَنُّ وَلَيْتُ عَلَيْهِ؟ وَاللَّهِ لَا أَطُورُ بِهِ مَا سَمَرَ سَمِيرٌ، وَمَا أَمْ نَجْمٌ فِي السَّمَاءِ نَجْمًا! وَلَوْ كَانَ الْمَالُ لِي لَسَوَّيْتُ بَيْنَهُمْ، فَكَيْفَ وَإِنَّمَا الْمَالُ لَهُمْ؟
- ٢ [ثُمَّ قَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ:] أَلَا وَإِنَّ إِعْطَاءَ الْمَالِ فِي غَيْرِ حَقِّهِ تَبْذِيرٌ وَإِسْرَافٌ، وَهُوَ يَرْفَعُ صَاحِبَهُ فِي الدُّنْيَا وَيَضَعُهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ، وَيُكْرِمُهُ فِي النَّاسِ وَيُهِينُهُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ، وَلَمْ يَضَعْ أَمْرُؤُ مَالَهُ فِي غَيْرِ حَقِّهِ وَلَا عِنْدَ غَيْرِ أَهْلِهِ إِلَّا حَرَمَهُ اللَّهُ شُكْرَهُمْ وَكَانَ لِعَيْنِهِ وَدُّهُمْ، فَإِنْ زَلَّتْ بِهِ النَّعْلُ يَوْمًا فَاحْتَأَجَّ إِلَى مُعَوْنَتِهِمْ فَشَرُّ خَلِيلٍ وَالْأَمُّ خَدِينٍ!

CONTEXT

From the title of this sermon found in the manuscript used by Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd, we note that it was Amīr al-Mu‘minīn’s response to the complaints he received when he standardized treasury stipends with no privilege for precedence or nobility. It is noteworthy that distributing the stipends equally among the

people was a practice of the Noble Prophet, and during his caliphate, Abū Bakr continued following that *sunnah*. It was only during the time of the subsequent caliphs that division became unequal, and was based on arbitrary factors such as nobility, status in the community, and so on (M). According to Ibn Qutaybah, this was an excerpt of a longer sermon given by the Imām at Şifīn (in 37 AH), part of which also includes sermons no. 97 and 142 (N). In his *al-Imāmah wal-Siyāsah*, Ibn Qutaybah reports that one of his companions advised Imām ‘Alī to follow the practice of granting greater shares to the noblemen among the Arabs, as that was what Mu‘āwiyah was doing (and was thus winning them over), because people are generally more inclined to this world. Then, once the affair was settled and the Imām’s authority was established firmly, he could go back to his equal distribution. However, Amīr al-Mu‘minīn rejected this advice and that is when he gave this oration (Z). The version reported by al-Kulaynī also has a similar preamble, where a group of his followers asked the Imām why he does not give an extra share to the noblemen among them to gain their support, at least until the foundation of his rule is firmly established. To this the Imām responded that he was unwilling to use unlawful means to attain a lawful goal, and then he spoke the words of this sermon (N).

A number of historical reports lead us to conclude that it was due to his egalitarian practices and equal distribution of the public wealth that Imām ‘Alī came to be hated by many of the so-called nobility. For instance, al-Ṭabarī reports that ‘Aṭā’ said to Abū ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī, “I adjure you, by Allāh, tell me when you started detesting ‘Alī (‘a) – was is not when he came to Kūfah and began to divide the public treasury among the people equally, and refused to give you and your family a greater share [as you had been given before]?” He replied, “Since you have made me swear by Allāh, then yes [that is when I started hating him].” In contrast, Mu‘āwiyah was able to gain favour with many people by lavishing special favours upon them and giving them preferential status among the people (T). As for the sources that quote this oration, there are some from before the time of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī and others after him as well. They include the work of Ibn Qutaybah mentioned above, *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl* by al-Ḥarrānī, *al-Kāfi* by al-Kulaynī, *al-Majālis* by al-Mufid, and *al-Amālī* by al-Ṭūsī (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The question *do you instruct me to seek support by oppressing those over whom I have authority?* shows that unequal distribution of public funds is a form of injustice and oppression. Giving the wealth of the weak to the strong is an innovation in religion, and goes against the teachings of the Qurʾān and Sunnah. That is why when Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr argued with Imām ʿAlī about this and told him he was going against the practice of ʿUmar, the Imām replied that the Book of Allāh and the Sunnah of His Prophet also opposed the practice of the second caliph (T). The verb *ʿa-taʾmurunnī* was actually *ʿa-taʾmurūnanī*, then the two *nūns* joined though *idghām* (R), like in the verse Q39:64 where the same word is found. Some read this rhetorical question as a reproof, meaning, 'how can you ask me to seek support through injustice' (MB). Indeed, for the Imām, the whole purpose of authority over the people was the establishment of justice, so doing anything to undermine that would be unthinkable (N). To emphasize this further, the Imām stated that he would never accept to do so, or even to approach it (*lā aṭūru bihi*), *as long as the world goes round*. The phrase *ʿmā samara samūr* means as long as there is day and night (MB), or as long as time marches forward (I). And *as long as one star follows another in the sky* was another way of expressing his complete unwillingness to do what had been suggested. Both these statements signify perpetuity and continuity (T), such that it was not something regarding which he would ever change his mind in the future. To drive the point home, the Imām tells them that had it been his own property, he would still have surely distributed it equally among the people, then how could he not do so when it is their property? In some manuscripts, the phrase *ʿinnamā al-mālu lahum* reads *ʿinnamā al-mālu mālullāh*, meaning it is the property of Allāh. In that case, since the Imām is Allāh's representative on earth, He has to ensure that the wealth is distributed among the people equally and fairly (Z), and that the share of the weak and poor is not usurped by the rich and powerful (MB).

2 Imām ʿAlī then explained the evils of gratuitous spending and squander to them, saying *verily giving wealth where it is unwarranted is wastefulness and extravagance*. Though the terms *ʿtabdhūr* and *ʿisrāf* are sometimes taken as synonyms, there is difference between them. *Tabdhūr* comes from *badhara*, meaning scattering seeds on the ground, and it is used to depict wastage of blessings by casting them away, and of wealth by squandering it uselessly. *Isrāf*, on the other hand, connotes extravagance in using the blessings, such that one

transgresses the limits of moderation, without there necessarily being any apparent squandering. For instance, if one were to buy very expensive food for a few people, spending thereby an amount that could easily feed tens of people, that would be considered *isrāf* (N). Both of these actions have been condemned in the Glorious Qurʾān (in Q17:27 and Q7:31, for example) (T). Then the Imām explains that such action may elevate the giver in this world, but it will be a cause of his humiliation and abasement in the Hereafter (M). The elevation attained thereby is spurious, but it is followed by a very real and painful downfall (S). That is because such inappropriate spending may lead him to be honoured among the people, but it *disgraces him in the sight of Allāh*. Indeed, no one has followed this path (of wastefulness) except that Allāh has deprived him of the love of those whom he seeks to endear through wealth, and when he ever needs them, he finds none of them ready to assist him (I). That is what he means when the Imām says that *Allāh deprives him of their gratitude* (*‘ḥaramahu Allāh shukrahum’*), and *their affection is diverted towards someone else* (*‘kāna li ghayrihi wudduhum’*). Furthermore, traditions also tell us that whoever refuses to spend his wealth on those who are deserving and have a right to it, he will be forced to spend twice as much in what is improper or harmful (T). In short, the retribution for wastefulness and extravagance will be seen in this world even before it is experienced in the Hereafter (MB). If, one day, such a wasteful person falls into hardship, and requires the assistance of those whom he favoured, they will prove to be *the worst friends and the most ignoble comrades*. The term *‘khaḍīn’* means friend (R), and in some manuscripts the two phrases *‘sharru khalīlīn’* and *‘al’amu khaḍīnīn’* are transposed and read *‘sharru khaḍīnīn’* and *‘al’amu khalīlīn’* (T), but this does not change the overall meaning. Not only do those people refuse to help him, they even stoop to causing him more harm and compounding his suffering, by censuring him and through other means (N). One commentator says that an example of such behaviour was seen when ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān had been besieged by the people, just before he was killed. At that time, according to what al-Ṭabarī’s reports, Ṭalḥah was one of those who was most vocal against him, even though he had previously gifted him fifty thousand dirhams (T).



ADDRESSING THE KHAWĀRIJ

1 If you insist upon the belief that I am mistaken and have gone astray, then why do you deem the entire *ummah* of Muḥammad (ṣ) to have strayed due to my [supposed] error, accusing them all because of my mistake, and calling them unbelievers on account of my sins?! Your swords are on your shoulders and you unsheathe them rightfully and wrongfully, without distinguishing one who has committed a crime from one who has not.

2 You know that the Messenger of Allāh (ṣ) stoned the married adulterer, but he then prayed upon him and allowed his family to inherit from him. He executed the murderer but allowed his heirs to inherit his property. He severed [the hand of] the thief and whipped the unmarried fornicator, but then let them have their shares from the booty and marry Muslim women. Thus the Prophet (ṣ) took them to task for their transgressions and established the right of Allāh among them, but he did not deprive them of their shares as accorded by Islam, nor did he remove their names from among his followers. Then you are the most evil of all people; those by whom Satan has shot his target and

١ فَإِنْ أَبَيْتُمْ إِلَّا أَنْ تَزْعُمُوا أَنِّي
أَخْطَاْتُ وَضَلَلْتُ، فَلِمَ تَضَلِّلُونَ
عَامَّةَ أُمَّةِ مُحَمَّدٍ ﷺ بِضَلَالِي،
وَتَأْخُذُونَهُمْ بِخَطِيئَتِي،
وَتَكْفُرُونَهُمْ بِذُنُوبِي؟! سَيُؤْفِكُمْ
عَلَى عَوَانِقِكُمْ تَضَعُونَهَا مَوَاضِعَ
الْبَرَاءَةِ وَالسَّقَمِ، وَتَخْلِطُونَ مَنْ
أَذْنَبَ بِمَنْ لَمْ يَذْنِبْ.

٢ وَقَدْ عَلِمْتُمْ أَنَّ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ ﷺ
رَجَمَ الزَّانِيَ الْمُحْصَنَ ثُمَّ صَلَّى
عَلَيْهِ ثُمَّ وَرَّثَهُ أَهْلَهُ، وَقَتَلَ الْقَاتِلَ
وَوَرَّثَ مِيرَاثَهُ أَهْلَهُ، وَقَطَعَ
السَّارِقَ وَجَلَدَ الزَّانِيَ غَيْرَ
الْمُحْصَنِ ثُمَّ قَسَمَ عَلَيْهِمَا مِنَ
الْفَيْءِ وَنَكَحَا الْمُسْلِمَاتِ؛
فَأَخَذَهُمْ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ ﷺ
بِذُنُوبِهِمْ، وَأَقَامَ حَقَّ اللَّهِ فِيهِمْ،
وَلَمْ يَمْنَعْهُمْ سَهْمَهُمْ مِنْ
الْإِسْلَامِ، وَلَمْ يُخْرِجْ أَسْمَاءَهُمْ
مِنْ بَيْنِ أَهْلِهِ. ثُمَّ أَنْتُمْ شِرَارُ

with whom he has struck forth in his wilderness [of misguidance].

النَّاسِ، وَمَنْ رَمَى بِهِ الشَّيْطَانُ
مَرَامِيَهُ وَضَرَبَ بِهِ تِيهَهُ!

CONTEXT

The historian al-Ṭabarī mentions this in his report on events that took place in the year 37 AH, just before the Battle of Nahrawān, quoting from Abū Mikhnaf, with slight variance in wording. In his *al-Nihāyah*, Ibn Athīr mentions part of this sermon as well (N). The Imām addresses the Khawārij in this oration, and shows the invalidity of their position and how their stance contradicts the clear teachings of Islam as taught to them by the Noble Messenger. Since they claimed that anyone who committed a major sin had thereby apostatized, they considered Amīr al-Mu'minīn's acceptance of the arbitration to have rendered him *persona non grata* as far as Islam is concerned. The overall message of this oration was to disprove this false doctrine of the Khawārij using rational arguments and historical evidence. Even though the address was to the Khawārij, there are many general lessons in this sermon that can benefit all believers (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* (5:553) places this in a longer sermon where Imām 'Alī responds to the Khawārij when they asked him to repent for having accepted the arbitration, arguing that it was a major sin to leave judgment to people rather than to Allāh. They said, "We accepted the arbitration, and in doing so we committed a sin, and as a result we became *kāfirs*. Now we have repented, so if you also repent, then we are with you and by your side." That is when the Imām responded, and this oration was part of his response.

COMMENTARY

1 It was the belief of the Khawārij that whoever perpetrated what they deemed to be a major sin (*kabīrah*) had removed himself from the fold of Islam thereby. And since they considered the arbitration that took place after the Battle of Ṣiffīn to be a major sin, they claimed that by accepting it, Imām 'Alī had apostatized and must therefore repent. They mentioned this to Ibn 'Abbās when he came to debate them, and even told Amīr al-Mu'minīn their position directly, as noted above. The

Imām presented four arguments against them, showing that they were mistaken in their claim, and their doctrine was false (MB). He began by arguing how even the hypothetical acceptance of their stance regarding him would not justify their branding all the people as *kāfir*. Though the Imām does not accept their premise to begin with, he uses this argument to show the irrationality of their claim which applied a blanket judgment on all the people at one go (M). In this way, the Imām showed that their barbaric actions of killing innocent children and livestock because they considered him as an apostate was unjustifiable and inexcusable, let alone completely irrational (I). In reality, as one commentator has pointed out, they branded anyone who disagreed with them as an unbeliever whose blood was lawful. They did not allow for any mistake in *ijtihād* if it resulted in an opinion that went contrary to their own. Based on this line of thinking, in their eyes nobody but the Khawārij themselves were Muslims. All other people were astray and misguided unbelievers (Z). They argued that the land had become an abode of disbelief (*dār al-kufr*), and thus fighting all its inhabitants was warranted, so they killed all those whom they encountered as long as they did not share their beliefs (MB). The Imām describes how they would strap their swords around their shoulders, using them indiscriminately against the people. The phrase '*taḍā'ūnahā mawāḍi'a al-barā'ati wal-saqami*' has also been reported as '*taḍā'ūnahā mawāḍi'a al-bur'ati wal-suqmi*' and literally means: you use them against the sound and the sick. Here, however, it refers to using their swords to strike both the innocent and the guilty, without distinguishing between them (N). In doing so, they mix those who have committed a sin with those who have not ('*takhlīṭūna man adhnaba bi man lam yudhnib*'), and this was the practice of the Khawārij of Baṣrah specifically, not the Khawārij of Kūfah (T). In any case, blaming someone for the sin of another goes against the Qur'ān itself, for it clearly states: *no bearer shall bear the burden of another* (Q53:38) (Z).

2 The second argument given by the Imām against the Khawārij shows how they were clearly contravening the practice of the Noble Messenger. He points out the main flaw in their doctrine that all those who perpetrate major sins become unbelievers using the example of how the Prophet had treated sinners during his time. He reminds them how the Messenger of Allāh had stoned an adulterer, as per the penalties prescribed in Islam, but he subsequently prayed over him and allowed his Muslim family to inherit from him. From this it is understood that the Prophet dealt with those who committed major sins as Muslims (Z). It should be

noted here that the penalty of stoning is only carried out when eight stringent conditions are met. Furthermore, the fact that the Messenger of Allāh prayed over the stoned individual and allowed his family to inherit from him proves that he was still deemed a Muslim, even after perpetrating the major sin of adultery (MB). A second example was how the Prophet had the murderer executed yet allowed his heirs to inherit from him, and distributed his property to his family. Two other examples from the practice of the Noble Prophet were that he cut the hand of the thief and flogged the unmarried fornicator yet continued to give them a share of the war booty and allowed them to marry Muslim women, which means that he still considered them to be Muslims. Hence we see that the Messenger of Allāh punished the sinners and carried out the mandated penalties, but he did not deprive them of their share of Islam's benefits, nor did he remove their names from the list of Muslims (Z).

An anecdote from the life of the early jurist Wāṣil ibn 'Aṭā' (d. 131 AH) is quite interesting. It is said that Wāṣil was once travelling with his companions when they came upon some Khawārij and were immediately overcome with a sense of dread. Wāṣil told his companions, "If they ask you anything, remain silent and let me do the talking." When they encountered them, the Khawārij asked, "What creed do you follow?" Wāṣil replied, "We are a group of polytheists who have sought refuge with you so as to learn about the word of God from you, and ask that you teach us about Islam and its rules." They replied, "We grant you refuge," and they started talking to them about Islam. After they had finished, Wāṣil said, "I and my companions hereby accept the religion of Islam, so now escort us safely to our destination, as the Qur'ān states: *And if any of the polytheists seeks your protection, grant him protection so that he hears the word of Allāh, then convey him to his place of safety* (Q9:6)." The Khawārij looked at each other and said, "What he says is right," and so they escorted them safely to the place they were heading, until they had left the area of the Khawārij (N). Imām 'Alī subsequently tells them that they are the worst of people ('*shirār al-nās*'), and indeed in one report it is stated that the Messenger of Allāh had foretold the Battle of Nahrawān, and had described it as a fight where the worst of creation (*sharr al-khalq wal-khalīqah*) would be killed by the best of creation (T). He further said that they are those *by whom Satan has shot his target and with whom he has struck forth in his wilderness of misguidance*. The phrase '*man ramā bihi al-shayṭānu marāmiyahu*' means one who is shot like an arrow, far away from the right course, and thereby completely misled (I).

3 Two types of people will soon be destroyed due to [their stance regarding] me: one who loves [me] excessively, such that his love takes him away from the truth, and one who hates [me] excessively, such that his hatred takes him away from the truth. Those in the best condition with regards to me are the ones who are upon the middle course, so adhere to it. And remain with the assembled group, for verily Allāh's hand is upon the collective. And beware of disunion, for verily one who is isolated from people is [easy prey] for Satan, like the sheep separated from the flock is for a wolf.

4 Beware, whoever calls towards this banner [of disunity], kill him, even if he is under this turban of mine. The two arbitrators were only appointed to revive what the Qur'ān revives and to abolish what the Qur'ān abolishes. Its revival means being united upon it while its abolishment means being [divided and] separated from it. If the Qur'ān drove us towards them, we were to follow them, and if it drove them towards us, they were to follow us. So neither have I brought any calamity [upon you] - may you be deprived of fathers - nor have I deceived you in your affair, nor confused you about it. Rather, it was your own assembly that unanimously decided to select two men [for the arbitration], and we took their pledge

٣ وَسَيَهْلِكُ فِي صِنْفَانِ: مُحِبٌّ مُفْرِطٌ يَذْهَبُ بِهِ الْحُبُّ إِلَى غَيْرِ الْحَقِّ، وَمُبْغِضٌ مُفْرِطٌ يَذْهَبُ بِهِ الْبُغْضُ إِلَى غَيْرِ الْحَقِّ، وَخَيْرُ النَّاسِ فِي حَالِ النَّمْطِ الْأَوْسَطِ فَالزَّمُوا السَّوَادَ الْأَعْظَمَ فَإِنَّ يَدَ اللَّهِ عَلَى الْجَمَاعَةِ، وَإِيَّاكُمْ وَالْفُرْقَةَ، فَإِنَّ الشَّاذَّ مِنَ النَّاسِ لِلشَّيْطَانِ كَمَا أَنَّ الشَّاذَّ مِنَ الْغَنَمِ لِلذِّئْبِ.

٤ أَلَا مَنْ دَعَا إِلَى هَذَا الشَّعَارِ فَاقْتُلُوهُ وَلَوْ كَانَ تَحْتَ عِمَامَتِي هَذِهِ، فَإِنَّمَا حُكِّمَ الْحَكَمَانِ لِيُحْيَا مَا أَحْيَا الْقُرْآنُ، وَيُمِيتَ مَا أَمَاتَ الْقُرْآنُ، وَإِخْيَاؤُهُ الْاجْتِمَاعُ عَلَيْهِ، وَإِمَاتُهُ الْإِفْتِرَاقُ عَنْهُ، فَإِنْ جَرَّنَا الْقُرْآنُ إِلَيْهِمْ اتَّبَعْنَاهُمْ، وَإِنْ جَرَّهُمْ إِلَيْنَا اتَّبَعُونَا. فَلَمْ آتِ - لَا أَبَا لَكُمْ - بُجْرًا، وَلَا خَلْتُكُمْ عَنْ أَمْرِكُمْ، وَلَا بَسَّيْتُه عَلَيْكُمْ، إِنَّمَا اجْتَمَعَ رَأْيُ مَلَائِكَتِكُمْ عَلَى اخْتِيَارِ رَجُلَيْنِ، أَخَذْنَا عَلَيْهِمَا أَلَّا

that they would not transgress the [limits set out by the] Qurʾān, but they deviated from it and abandoned the truth though they both saw it. Acting unjustly was their wont so that is the course they followed, despite our having stipulated to them earlier that they should arbitrate with justice and have the truth in their sights, before they gave their wrong opinion and presented their unjust judgment.

يَتَعَدَّى الْقُرْآنَ، فَتَاهَا عَنْهُ،
وَتَرَكَ الْحَقَّ وَهُمَا يُبْصِرَانِهِ،
وَكَانَ الْجَوْرُ هَوَاهُمَا فَمَضَا
عَلَيْهِ، وَقَدْ سَبَقَ اشْتِنَاؤُنَا عَلَيْهِمَا
- فِي الْحُكْمَةِ بِالْعَدْلِ،
وَالصَّمْدِ لِلْحَقِّ - سُوءَ رَأْيِهِمَا
وَجَوْرَ حُكْمِهِمَا.

Alternatively, it could mean that he is the target that is successfully shot at by Satan (N). ‘*Ḍaraba bihi tīhahu*’ means that he has been led into bewilderment and confusion by Satan (I). Indeed, the Khawārij were an example of the ‘party of Satan’, as mentioned in the verse: ...*They are the party of Satan. Verily it is the party of Satan who are the losers* (Q58:19) (Z).

3 Amīr al-Muʾminīn then states that two types of people will soon perish due to their position with regards to him: the one who loves him excessively (‘*muḥibbun mufrīṭ*’) and the one who hates him excessively (‘*mubghīḍun mufrīṭ*’). He explains this further by saying that the former is one whose love for him takes him away from the truth, across the boundary of what is right, while the latter is one whose hatred likewise takes him away from the truth towards what is not right. A tradition attributed to the Noble Prophet reflects this beautifully. He (ṣ) said, “In you, O ‘Alī, is the example of ‘Īsā son of Maryam. The Jews hated him to the extent of levelling vile accusations against his mother, while the Christians loved him to the extent of elevating him above his station” (I). The term ‘*mufrīṭ*’ refers to one who transgresses the boundary, while *muḥibbun* (with *tashdīd*) refers to one who falls short and is neglectful. As for one who openly manifests his enmity and hatred, he is called a *nāṣibī* (Z). The one who loves excessively is also called *ghālī* (or *mughālī*), while he who hates is also called *qālī*, as noted from other narrations (R). There are numerous historical reports of the Infallibles condemning and even punishing those who falsely attributed to them the station of divinity or prophethood (T). The correct position, the Imām explains, is that of those on the middle course (‘*al-namaṭ al-awsaṭ*’), meaning those who abandon

extremism and follow the path of moderation, which is the straight path that leads to felicity (MB). Indeed, all true believers love Imām ‘Alī, while it is only the hypocrites and unbelievers who hate him; as the Prophet said, “None but the believer will love you and none but the hypocrite will hate you” (I). Yet when it goes beyond the limits, this same love can be a cause of destruction. That is why the Imām instructs the people to adhere to the middle path, and to *remain with the assembled group, for verily Allāh’s hand is upon the collective*. According to some commentators, ‘*al-sawād al-a’zam*’ refers to the group that is upon the truth and has many followers, and their consensus constitutes evidence of their being on the right (R). Here, the Imām was referring specifically to the majority of the people who followed and obeyed him as a just ruler, as opposed to the small groups that rebelled against him (MB). Some commentators explain the statement *Allāh’s hand is upon the collective* by highlighting the responsibility of enjoining good and forbidding evil, such that those who live in believing societies and are part of the collective always have someone to guide them when they go wrong, while those who keep away from the main body of believers easily fall prey to wrong ideas and go astray (N). That is why the Imām warns them of division and disunity, saying that *one who is isolated from people is easy prey for Satan, like the sheep separated from the flock is for a wolf*. There are many similar traditions from the Noble Prophet and Imām ‘Alī about the importance of unity and remaining with the collective (I). It is important to note that the term *al-jamā’ah* does not simply mean majority in terms of numbers (S). In one report we find that a man asked Amīr al-Mu’minīn to define the terms ‘*sunnah*’, ‘*bid’ah*’, ‘*firqah*’, and ‘*jamā’ah*’. So the Imām said, “*Sunnah* refers to the practice of the Prophet (ṣ). *Bid’ah* is that which goes against that practice. *Firqah* is a group that is upon falsehood, even if they are many in number. And *jamā’ah* are those who are upon the truth, even if they are few in number” (T).

4 The Imām stresses the importance of remaining united by saying that *whoever calls towards this banner of disunity should be killed, even if he is under this turban of mine*. The term ‘*shī’ār*’ refers to a sign of people in war. It is set up so that a man may know his companions in order to fight alongside them, and can be in the form of a war cry or a banner or standard. Here, the Imām was specifically referring to the banner of rebellion by the Khawārij, and according to some accounts their sign was that they would shave off the middle of their heads and leave the hair that grew on the sides of the head (I). From the version of this

statement reported by al-Mas'ūdī, which contains the phrase '*ilā hādhihi al-khuṣūmah*' instead of '*ilā hādha al-shi'ār*' we understand that the banner being referred to is that of dissension and disunity (T). Some commentators posit that the term '*shi'ār*' here refers to the slogan of the Khawārij '*lā ḥukma illā lillāh*', however the previous meaning is more likely correct in this context (N). The phrase '*wa law kāna taḥta 'imāmatī*' is translated *even if he is under this turban of mine*, and was spoken as a hyperbole. It means even if the one who makes the call is so close to me that he is deemed one of my near companions (M), or is one who has taken protection and refuge with the most sacrosanct of all things, he should still be killed (I). Some have interpreted the phrase to mean 'even if it were I myself', but this meaning is considered inappropriate here (N). Imām 'Alī then clarifies to them why the arbitrators had been appointed and what their mandate was. He says that they *were only appointed to revive what the Qur'ān revives and to abolish what the Qur'ān abolishes*. In fact, this was clearly stated in the written truce between them as well (T). The Imām only accepted arbitration that was based upon the Qur'ān, not their own judgment or inclinations (Z). As such, the ruling on the matter was left to the Qur'ān, not to two fallible individuals as the Khawārij had wrongfully asserted (MB). Expounding what he meant by revival and abolishment of the teachings of the Qur'ān, the Imām states that *its revival means being united upon it while its abolishment means being divided and separated from it*. The terms *ihyā'* and *imātah*, which connote enlivening and annihilating respectively, are used metaphorically here. It means that if the two arbitrators act together upon the Qur'ān and follow its teachings, it will be as though they have revived it and given life to its rulings and the benefits that accrue therefrom. However, if they turn away from the Qur'ān and its injunctions, they will be like those who bring an end to that which could have benefitted them, and done away with the lofty teachings of the Glorious Qur'ān (M).

The Imām explains that the agreement was *if the Qur'ān drove us towards them, we were to follow them and if it drove them towards us, they were to follow us*. Thus, if it was based upon the Qur'ān, the decision of the arbitrators would be final and it would be respected, whether it was for or against them. This is something similar to the verse that states: *...And surely either we or you are upon guidance or in manifest error* (Q34:24) (Z). Clearly the Qur'ān would drive the people towards the Imām as their rightful leader. The problem was, however, that the arbitrators went against the Book of Allāh, and did not follow its teachings (MB). Amīr al-

Mu'minīn then tells them that since he had only accepted the judgment of the Qur'ān, he did not, as they falsely claimed, bring a calamity upon them, nor did he deceive them in their affair or confuse them about it. The meaning and usage of the phrase '*may you be deprived of fathers*' has been explained in the commentary of sermon no. 36. The term '*bujr*' connotes some evil or grave matter (R). By saying this, the Imām means that he has done nothing that would warrant the label of '*kāfir*' or one who has strayed from the right path (MB). He then reminded them that while he had accepted the arbitration, it was their own assembly that unanimously decided to select two men for the arbitration. In this way, he dissociated himself from the selected individuals who were tasked with the arbitration, since his own choices for who should be charged with the matter were rejected by them (M). In the end, despite having given their pledge that they would not transgress the limits set by the Qur'ān, they deviated from it and *abandoned the truth though they both saw it*. This meant that they knowingly cast aside the Book of Allāh and thereby strayed from the correct path (MB). The phrase '*kāna al-jawru hawāhumā*' is rendered *acting unjustly was their wont* and means that they were biased and prejudiced individuals with no foresight to realize the consequences of their actions (N). Hence they followed the path of injustice despite the Imām's *having stipulated to them earlier that they should arbitrate with justice and have the truth in their sights*. The term '*istithnā'unā*' literally means 'our exception', and here it refers to the stipulation to exclude all but what is just and true according to the Qur'ān. Nevertheless, they acted contrary to his instructions and *gave their wrong opinion and presented their unjust judgment* which was neither based on the Qur'ān, nor on the Sunnah of the Noble Messenger. As such, all the blame falls upon their shoulders, since they did not fulfil their duty as just arbitrators (MB).



ON THE FUTURE OF BASRAH

- 1 O Ahnaf! It is as though I see him advancing with an army raising neither dust nor clamour, with neither the rattling of reins nor the neighing of horses. They trample the ground with their feet as though they were the feet of ostriches. [Then he (‘a) said:] Woe to your busy streets and decorated houses, which have terraces like the wings of vultures and ducts like the trunks of elephants, from those whose dead are not mourned and for whose missing no search is carried out. [As for me,] I am the one who turns this world over on its face, values it according to its true measure, and looks at it as it ought to be seen.

يَا أَحْنَفُ، كَأَنِّي بِهِ وَقَدْ سَارَ
بِالْجَيْشِ الَّذِي لَا يَكُونُ لَهُ غُبَارٌ وَلَا
لَجَبٌ، وَلَا قَعَقَعَةٌ لُجْمٍ، وَلَا
حَمَحَمَةٌ خَيْلٍ، يُشِيرُونَ الْأَرْضَ
بِأَقْدَامِهِمْ كَأَنَّهُمْ أَقْدَامُ النَّعَامِ. [ثُمَّ
قَالَ عَلَيْهِ السَّلَامُ:] وَيْلٌ لِسُكُكِكُمْ الْعَامِرَةَ،
وَالدُّورِ الْمُزْحَفَةِ الَّتِي لَهَا أَجْنِحَةٌ
كَأَجْنِحَةِ الشُّمُورِ، وَخَرَاطِيمُ
كَخَرَاطِيمِ الْفِيلَةِ، مِنْ أَوْلَيْكَ الَّذِينَ
لَا يُنْدَبُ قِتْلُهُمْ، وَلَا يُفْقَدُ غَائِبُهُمْ.
أَنَا كَابُ الدُّنْيَا لَوَجْهَهَا، وَقَادِرُهَا
بِقَدْرِهَا، وَنَاطِظُهَا بِعَيْنِهَا.

DESCRIBING THE TARTARS

- 2 It is as though I see them as a people whose faces are like scraped shields. They wear clothes of white silk and brocade, and groom the finest horses for themselves. There will be so much bloodshed [at their hands] that the wounded shall walk over the corpses and those who escape will be fewer than those taken prisoner! [One of his companions said to him, “O Amīr al-Mu’minīn, you have been given

منها في وصف الأتراك

كَأَنِّي أَرَاهُمْ قَوْمًا كَأَنَّ وُجُوهَهُمْ
الْمَجَانُّ الْمُطْرَقَةُ، يَلْبَسُونَ السَّرَقَ
وَالدِّيَّاجَ، وَيَعْتَقِبُونَ الْخَيْلَ الْعِتَاقَ،
وَيَكُونُ هُنَاكَ اسْتِحْرَارٌ قَتْلٍ، حَتَّى
يَمْشِي الْمَجْرُوحُ عَلَى الْمَقْتُولِ،
وَيَكُونُ الْمُفْلِتُ أَقْلَ مِنَ الْمَأْسُورِ!
[فَقَالَ لَهُ بَعْضُ أَصْحَابِهِ: لَقَدْ

knowledge of the unseen!" Where-
 upon he (‘a) laughed.]

أُعْطِيتَ يَا أَمِيرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ عِلْمَ
 الْغَيْبِ! فَضَحَكَ عَلَيْهِ.

CONTEXT

This is an oration in which Imām ‘Alī informs his listeners of the future calamities that would befall the inhabitants of Baṣrah. Two groups who would cause much bloodshed in the city are alluded to by Amīr al-Mu’minīn. The first are the Zanj and their leader, known as ‘Alī ibn Muḥammad al-Zanjī, who rose up in rebellion during the rule of Muṭadī al-‘Abbāsī and carried out many raids and massacres. The second are the Mongols (or Tartars) who also caused much bloodshed. After he informed the people about these future events, one of those who were present in the audience asked the Imām if he had knowledge of the unseen (*ghayb*). In response, Imām ‘Alī gives an interesting clarification on the concept of knowledge of the unseen. In some versions, this sermon has been divided into two separate orations, with the second two sections counted as a different sermon (N). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* says that this oration is actually part of a longer sermon that was given by Amīr al-Mu’minīn at Baṣrah after the Battle of Jamal, and it is linked to sermon no. 100. In his commentary, Ibn Maytham al-Baḥrānī has mentioned other parts of this sermon that are not found in *Nahj al-Balāghah*.

COMMENTARY

1 Aḥnaf ibn Qays was the one being addressed by Imām ‘Alī, and he was one of the leaders of the Banū Tamīm. He lived during the time of the Noble Prophet but was not one of his Companions, and he did not meet the Messenger of Allāh. The Prophet had sent messengers to the Banū Tamīm inviting them to Islam but none of them responded positively. Aḥnaf told them, "He is inviting you to sublime moral character so respond to him!" So they accepted Islam along with Aḥnaf. He was one of the eminent Tābi‘īn due to his acumen and intelligence, as well as his good character, and was also one of the staunchest supporters of Amīr al-Mu’minīn. He did not participate in the Battle of Jamal, because he had written to the Imām saying, "If you wish I can join you with a hundred members of my family,

or I could remain behind and prevent four thousand tribesmen from coming out against you.” So the Imām replied saying, “Stay behind and prevent the four thousand swords from attacking us, and that would suffice as support.” Aḥnaf ibn Qays did participate in the Battle of Şiffin alongside the Imām and even offered him some advice. He further took the Imām’s side in the matter of rejecting the arbitration (Z). According to some accounts, however, after the martyrdom of Imām ‘Alī, Aḥnaf pledged allegiance to Mu‘āwiyah, refused to assist Imām al-Ḥusayn in Karbalā’, and even fought in Ibn Zubayr’s army against Mukhtār (S). Aḥnaf’s *kunyah* was Abū Baḥr, not Abū Bakr as some have mistakenly stated (T). The Imām tells Aḥnaf that it is as though he can *see him advancing with an army raising neither dust nor clamour*. By this he is most likely referring to the leader of the Zanj, though he does not mention him by name. This was the individual who rose up in Baṣrah in the year 255 AH, and he called all the slaves to join his revolt, causing sedition with hundreds, and later thousands, of slaves under his command. He would incite them and give them hope of freedom and wealth in order to urge them on (Z). They rose up against their masters and perpetrated some of the most horrific atrocities against them. The term ‘*lajab*’ means noise or sound (I), and the Zanj army raised no dust or clamour because they were on foot, as the slaves could afford no horses, and many of them were even barefoot. That is also why the Imām describes them as moving without *the rattling of reins* or *the neighing of horses* (N). Their feet are compared to those of ostriches, which are usually short and wide, with spread-out fingers. Their trampling on the ground depicts the pounding of their steps as they march forward (MB). Regarding the identity of this army and its leader, al-Sayyid al-Raḍī says, “By this, he (‘a) was alluding to the [rebellion of] the Chief of the Zanj.” The exact lineage of this individual is not known, and he is said to have introduced himself with different backgrounds over the course of his rebellion. Furthermore, different groups later sought to distance themselves from him and thus rejected the possibility of his being related to them in any way (MB).

The Imām then said *woe to your busy streets and decorated houses, which have terraces like the wings of vultures and ducts like the trunks of elephants*, by which he describes the state of the city of Baṣrah, thriving at that time, with houses like mansions and palaces, having huge balconies and terraces, or overhanging rooftops like the wings of huge birds, and water ducts and sprouts that are like elephant trunks. The phrase ‘*sikakikum al-‘āmirah*’ refers to streets which are

paved for easy passage, and quarters that are developed and flourishing (MB). ‘*Al-nusūr*’ is plural of *nasr*, which refers to a vulture or an eagle (N). *From those whose dead are not mourned and for whose missing no search is carried out* alludes to the Zanj, as they were so violent and severe that they did not care about death or injury (MB), or it means that they were slaves who neither had families that would mourn for them when they died, nor kin who would look for them if they went missing. These were traits of the slaves of that time, who were captured and brought by force from far off lands, especially from the African continent, and contrary to Islamic teachings, they were treated like animals or even worse than that (N). Though their violence against the innocent can never be justified, such inhumane treatment has never led to anything good in human history. As such, when the Zanj revolted – and their rebellion lasted for a little over fourteen years – they would kill young and old, men and women, and burn, loot, and spoil what they came across (T). Some commentators have mentioned lengthy details about the uprising of the Zanj, what they did, and how they were finally defeated (I). Others even compare the treatment of the Zanj before their rebellion to the way African Americans have been treated in the United States in recent history (Z). At the end of this section, the Imām says that he is *one who turns this world over on its face, values it according to its true measure, and looks at it as it ought to be seen*. These words are similar to those spoken by Prophet ʿĪsā when he said, “I threw down this world on its face. I have no wife who may die, nor any house that may be destroyed. My pillow is a stone, [my bed is the ground,] my carpet is mud, and my lamp is the moon” (I). However, others say that the context of the Imām’s speech here is something different. He meant that he had encompassed the world and understood its apparent aspect as well as its hidden aspect, like one who turns something over on itself and sees all sides thereof (T). Alternatively, it could connote his disinterest in this world, as he knew its true worth and saw it for what it is (MB). The phrase ‘*nāẓiruhā bi ʿaynihā*’ has been interpreted by some to mean that he looked at this world as it truly is, meaning that he saw it as something insignificant (N). Others say that it means he saw this world with eyes of wisdom and insight (MB).

2 According to al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, this section of the sermon was about the Tartars who would rise up in the future. Some commentators take this to be a prophecy foretelling the Mongol invasion of Muslim heartlands in the 7th century AH, initially under Chingiz Khan and culminating in the sack of Baghdad under

Chingiz's grandson Hulegu Khan in 656 AH. The Imām said that it was as though he could see them *as a people whose faces are like scraped shields*. The term '*al-majān*' is plural of *mijan*, meaning shield, and '*al-muṭraqah*' means wrinkled, marked, or scuffed (R). This description was apt because their faces were wide and round, like shields, and their being *scraped* depicts the roughness that was clearly seen in their countenance (MB). The Imām then said that their attires would be made of *white silk and brocade* ('*al-saqar wal-dībāj*'), and though in the beginning they were not wealthy and wore rough clothes, as they raided different lands and took spoils, they became so rich that they started wearing luxurious clothes made from the finest materials, and riding the most expensive mounts. Some commentators suggest it is also possible that since it was believed silk clothing strengthens one's heart and is more impervious to swords, they chose that as their battle attire (N). They likewise groomed *the finest horses for themselves* since they required the best steeds for battle. The phrase '*ya'taqibūna al-khayl al-ītāq*' means that they would tie up the strong and purebred horses and keep them prepared to be ridden in case the need arose (MB). The Imām then said that *there will be so much bloodshed at their hands that the wounded shall walk over the corpses and those who escape will be fewer than those taken prisoner*. The phrase '*istiḥrāru qatlin*' means intense and violent killing (R). The two examples given clearly depict how severe and grave the situation would be. There would be no space on the ground to walk because of the number of fallen corpses, so the injured would have to tread upon the bodies of the dead. Those not killed will end up as slaves, having been captured by the Mongol hoards, and only a small number will actually manage to escape (N). Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd lived at the time of the Tartars and he gave some first or second hand accounts of their practices. He said that they were some of the most enduring warriors who never fled battle. They would make their own weapons by hand, and their horses never required barley, but would instead graze on grass and shrubs. When they attacked, they would massacre people in the thousands and lay waste to entire villages and cities. Many times, they would kill even those who surrendered to them (I). Indeed, the description given here by the Imām fully matches what later came about when the Mongols invaded (Z).

A question that may arise here is: what was the purpose of informing the people about an event that would transpire after about six centuries? In response to this, it has been suggested that perhaps the Imām wanted to inform them how their improper actions during his time, and their inclining towards falsehood and

turning away from the truth, would have very painful consequences for their people in the future. It is also possible that the Imām was warning them about future trials in order to get them to reform themselves and unite under the banner of truth, in order to forestall what would befall them or reduce its impact (N). At this point, one of the Imām's companions interjected saying, "O Amīr al-Mu'minīn, you have been given knowledge of the unseen!" Whereupon the Imām laughed and then proceeded to respond to him. On the question of why the Imām laughed when this comment was made, it has been suggested that this was the practice of the Prophets and their legateses. Whenever they were reminded of a special favour of Allāh upon them, they would laugh or smile. An example of this was when the Noble Prophet was once asked to pray for rain and when he did so, it rained so much that the people asked him to pray for it to stop raining. He thus pointed towards the cloud and it stopped raining, so he laughed until his teeth could be seen and said, "I bear witness that I am the Messenger of Allāh!" (T). Others opine that he did this only out of gratitude to Allāh for His blessing (MB). The words uttered by the one who interjected are also interpreted by some to be a question rather than a statement, since it was thought that knowledge of the unseen is only with Allāh, so the questioner said "O Amīr al-Mu'minīn, have you been given knowledge of the unseen?" In that case, perhaps the Imām laughed because the questioner had asked what was on the minds of many listeners, and now he could clarify the matter for them (N).

3 The person who had made this interjection was a Kalbī, meaning he belonged to the tribe of Banū Kalb, and that is why the Imām addressed him as a brother from Kalb (*'yā akhā kalb'*). He then explained to the man how his information about future events was not knowledge of the unseen (*"ilm al-ghayb"*); rather, it is only what was learnt from the one possessing knowledge. This meant that he learnt it from the Noble Prophet, as he later explains. Theologians have discussed the issue of knowledge of the Imāms at length, and they mostly agree that the Imāms were blessed with certain types of hidden knowledge, such as being aware of what was in the minds of some individuals, or knowing what would transpire before it did. However, this does not mean they knew the unseen in the absolute sense. Rather, it was a grace (*lutf*) of Allāh granted to them in particular circumstances (T). Imām 'Alī then explains that knowledge of the unseen refers to knowledge of *that which has been enumerated by Allāh, the Glorified, in the verse:*

3 [He said to the man, who belonged to the tribe of Banū Kalb:] O brother of [the Banū] Kalb, this is not knowledge of the unseen; rather, it is only what was learnt from the one possessing knowledge. As for knowledge of the unseen, it refers to knowledge of the Hour, and that which has been enumerated by Allāh, the Glorified, in the verse: *Verily with Allāh lies knowledge of the Hour, and He sends down the rain and knows what is inside the wombs. No soul knows what it will earn tomorrow, and no soul knows in what land it will die; verily Allāh is Knowing, Aware.* So Allāh [alone] knows what is in the wombs, whether male or female, ugly or beautiful, generous or mean, wretched or felicitous, and who will be fuel for the Fire or in the company of Prophets in the Gardens [of Paradise]. This is the knowledge of the unseen which no one knows but Allāh. Everything else is knowledge that Allāh taught His Prophet (ﷺ), who in turn taught it to me, and he prayed for me that my heart may retain it and my bosom may embrace it.

۳ [وَقَالَ لِلرَّجُلِ وَكَانَ كَلْبِيًّا:] يَا أَخَا كَلْبٍ، لَيْسَ هُوَ بِعِلْمٍ غَيْبٍ، وَإِنَّمَا هُوَ تَعَلُّمٌ مِنْ ذِي عِلْمٍ، وَإِنَّمَا عِلْمُ الْغَيْبِ عِلْمُ السَّاعَةِ، وَمَا عَدَّدَهُ اللَّهُ سُبْحَانَهُ بِقَوْلِهِ «إِنَّ اللَّهَ عِنْدَهُ عِلْمُ السَّاعَةِ وَيُنَزِّلُ الْغَيْثَ وَيَعْلَمُ مَا فِي الْأَرْحَامِ وَمَا تَدْرِي نَفْسٌ مَآذَا تَكْسِبُ غَدًا وَمَا تَدْرِي نَفْسٌ بِأَيِّ أَرْضٍ تَمُوتُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ خَبِيرٌ»، فَيَعْلَمُ اللَّهُ سُبْحَانَهُ مَا فِي الْأَرْحَامِ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثَى، وَقَبِيحٍ أَوْ جَمِيلٍ، وَسَخِيٍّ أَوْ بَخِيلٍ، وَشَقِيٍّ أَوْ سَعِيدٍ، وَمَنْ يَكُونُ لِلنَّارِ حَطَبًا، أَوْ فِي الْجَنَّةِ لِلنَّبِيِّينَ مَرَاتِقًا؛ فَهَذَا عِلْمُ الْغَيْبِ الَّذِي لَا يَعْلَمُهُ أَحَدٌ إِلَّا اللَّهُ، وَمَا سِوَى ذَلِكَ فَعِلْمٌ عَلَّمَهُ اللَّهُ نَبِيَّهُ ﷺ فَعَلَّمَنِيهِ، وَدَعَا لِي بِأَنْ يَحْبِسَهُ صَدْرِي وَتَضُمَّ عَلَيْهِ جَوَانِحِي.

Verily with Allāh lies knowledge of the Hour, and He sends down the rain and knows what is inside the wombs... (Q31:34). As for knowledge of the Hour, it refers to the Day of Resurrection, which is the first and foremost reality the knowledge of which is only with Allāh (MB). Knowledge of when it will rain could be calculated or predicted using a number of methods, but it is never a hundred percent accurate and reliable. Rather, it constitutes an educated guess based of weather patterns and the like. And when it comes to artificial rain that is produced by seeding

clouds, that is not considered to be creation; instead, it is a kind of transformation of one thing to another (Z). As for what is in the wombs, Imām ‘Alī himself explains that Allāh alone knows what is in the wombs, *whether male or female, ugly or beautiful, generous or mean, wretched or felicitous, and who will be fuel for the Fire or in the company of Prophets in the Gardens of Paradise*. Indeed, traditions tell us that “the felicitous is felicitous in his mother’s womb, and the wretched is wretched in his mother’s womb,” meaning that from the time one is born, it is known to Allāh whether that individual will be felicitous or wretched, good or evil (T). So even if modern science can see ‘into the wombs’ to determine the physical state of an unborn foetus, nobody can know of the latent traits of the unborn child, and whether he or she will be generous or niggardly, courageous or cowardly, and so on (Z).

Regarding the fact that *no soul knows what it will earn tomorrow*, which is the fourth thing that constitutes knowledge of the unseen, a question that could arise is: Allāh had informed His Prophet of some things that he would gain in the future, such as His promise that Makkah would be conquered. Likewise, the Messenger of Allāh had informed Imām ‘Alī about some future events like how he would have to fight the rebels, and so on. Is that not knowledge of the unseen that only Allāh possesses? The answer to this is that what the verse is referring to is knowledge of everything that will be gained or earned in the future, which does not contradict the possibility of being given some limited knowledge thereof (I). And finally, the fifth thing which is part of *ilm al-ghayb* pertains to where one will die. It is narrated that Abū Bakr ibn ‘Ayyāsh once came to Imām al-Kāẓim and said, “I saw a dream last night in which I asked you how much longer I would live [in this world], so you raised your right hand and spread out your five fingers. But I did not understand whether you meant I would live for five more years, months, or days?” So the Imām replied, “That was pointing to the five things that are mentioned in the verse: *Verily with Allāh lies knowledge of the Hour, and He sends down the rain and knows what is inside the wombs. No soul knows what it will earn tomorrow, and no soul knows in what land it will die; verily Allāh is Knowing, Aware* (Q31:34). It was as though I was telling you ‘What you have asked about is part of knowledge of the unseen which only Allāh knows’” (R). Having clarified what constitutes knowledge of the unseen, Imām ‘Alī says *everything else is knowledge that Allāh taught His Prophet*, who in turn taught it to him. Furthermore, the Messenger of Allāh had prayed for him that his heart may retain the knowledge and his *bosom may*

embrace it. Indeed, there is a report from the Noble Messenger in which he said, regarding the verse: ...*and that a receptive ear might grasp it* (Q69:12), “I prayed to Allāh to make it your ear, O ‘Alī.” And the Imām said, “After this, I never forgot anything that I heard, and it is not possible for me to forget” (Z).



ON MEASURES AND SCALES

1 O servants of Allāh! You, and whatever you aspire to from this world, are [like] guests for a specific period, and [like] debtors called upon for repayment: [your] lifespan is diminishing while [your] deeds are being recorded. Many a diligent worker wastes his efforts and many a toiling labourer faces loss. You live in an era where virtue only increases [one] in retreat, and evil in advancing, and Satan only increases in his eagerness to ruin humankind. This is the time when his accoutrements have become strong, his schemes have become widespread, and his prey has become easy [to ensnare].

2 Cast your glance at the people wherever you wish, do you see anything other than a poor man struggling in poverty, or a rich man who has replaced Allāh's blessing with ingratitude, or a miser who has taken stinginess with the right of Allāh as a means of increase [in his wealth], or an insolent person turning a deaf ear to all counsel?!

١ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، إِنَّكُمْ - وَمَا تَأْمَلُونَ مِنْ هَذِهِ الدُّنْيَا - أَثَوِيَاءُ مُؤَجَّلُونَ، وَمَدِينُونَ مُقْتَضَوْنَ: أَجَلٌ مُنْقُوصٌ، وَعَمَلٌ مَحْفُوظٌ، قُرْبٌ دَائِبٌ مُضَيِّعٌ، وَرُبُّ كَادِحٍ خَاسِرٌ. وَقَدْ أَضْبَحْتُمْ فِي زَمَنِ لَا يَزِدُّادُ الْخَيْرُ فِيهِ إِلَّا إِذْبَارًا، وَلَا الشَّرُّ فِيهِ إِلَّا إِقْبَالًا، وَلَا الشَّيْطَانُ فِي هَلَاقِ النَّاسِ إِلَّا طَمَعًا، فَهَذَا أَوَانٌ قَوِيَتْ عُدَّتُهُ، وَعَمَّتْ مَكِيدَتُهُ، وَأَمَكَنْتْ فَرِيسَتُهُ.

٢ اضْرِبْ بِطَرْفِكَ حَيْثُ شِئْتَ مِنَ النَّاسِ، فَهَلْ تُبْصِرُ إِلَّا فَقِيرًا يُكَابِدُ فَقْرًا، أَوْ غِيًّا بَدَلَ نِعْمَةٍ اللَّهِ كُفْرًا، أَوْ بَخِيلًا اتَّخَذَ الْبُخْلَ بِحَقِّ اللَّهِ وَفْرًا، أَوْ مُتَمَرِّدًا كَأَنَّ بَأْذَنَهُ عَنِ سَمْعِ الْمَوَاعِظِ وَقَرَأَ؟!

CONTEXT

Though the title of this sermon states that it is about measures and scales (*fi dhikr al-makāyil wal-mawāzīn*), some commentators point out that nothing about weights and measures is found in this oration. Perhaps, they say, the author meant

that it was generally about the ethics of trade and business (I). Others posit that since it was the practice of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī to take only excerpts of sermons, it is likely that this oration contained some mention of weights and measures, and perhaps the Imām was informed that people were cheating when they measured their commodities, so he spoke these words in order to forbid them from this practice (MB). One commentator suggests that the term '*al-makāyil*' was a scribal error, and the actual term was '*al-makāyid*' (meaning schemes of deception), and '*al-mawāzīn*' was a later addition by note-takers (T). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* says that this is an excerpt of a longer sermon, and al-Zamakhsharī and al-Āmidī have mentioned parts thereof in their respective works *Rabīʿ al-Abrār* and *Ghurar al-Hikam*. Though it is not known when and where Amīr al-Mu'minīn spoke these words, it can be surmised from the content of his speech that he was addressing traders in the marketplace. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this oration within a longer one given by the Imām in response to someone who was blaming this world and speaking ill thereof (5:128).

COMMENTARY

1 In the opening section of his address, the Imām reminds the people that this world is evanescent and perishing, so no wise person would rely on it or become infatuated by it. His statement *you, and whatever you aspire to from this world, are guests for a specific period, and debtors called upon for repayment*, means that no matter what you desire from this lowly world, including a long and comfortable life, you remain a guest in it for a fixed span of time. And whatever you have been granted in this world will be taken back, and you are accountable for it, just like a debtor who is held accountable for his debt (MB). Some commentators interpret the phrase '*athwiyāu mu'ajjalūn*' to mean those who stay for a predetermined time, so even if they hope to live forever, they will never do so (T). And the phrase '*madīnūna muqtaḍawn*', which literally means those with debts that are due for repayment, is understood to be a metaphor for the duties that are made obligatory upon believers by the *sharīʿah*, and for which they will be held to account (M). *Many a diligent worker wastes his efforts and many a toiling labourer faces loss* means it is not the amount of work that is put in which matters in the end; rather, it is the quality thereof, represented by the extent of one's *tawqā* and sincerity of intention. That is why the Imām is quoted as having said elsewhere, "How many

of those who fast gain nothing therefrom save hunger and thirst, and how many who stand in prayer [at night] get nothing from it save sleeplessness and difficulty” (Z). One may strive to do good, but later spoil his efforts by showing off or seeking praise, or nullify his charity by hurting the feelings of those whom he assists, or generally perform acts of worship without fulfilling the required conditions, thereby rendering them void (MB). Others interpret the statement differently, saying that it means many people waste their efforts by working for this temporary world, and face a loss since they toil for that which will not last and neglect the everlasting Hereafter (T). Alternatively, it means that if the action is itself wrong, then no matter how diligently it is performed, and how good one’s intention is, it still leads to loss (S).

The Imām then tells them the era they live in is one where *virtue only increases in retreat, and evil in advancing*, and that was because his predecessors had made the people accustomed to worldly comforts. As such, it was difficult, and sometimes even impossible, to reform them. Furthermore, the rebels who rose up against the Imām had only made the situation worse, and that is why virtue and righteousness was turning back while evil was advancing (T). This description also means that it was an era when the followers of caprice and desire were more in number and strength than those who adhered to the path of right guidance (MB). This was a time when Satan had increased *in his eagerness to ruin humankind*, since every period in which corruption becomes ubiquitous, and the oppressed are abandoned while the tyrants are supported – that is the era of Satan. And from the traditions we learn that during such times, the believers are responsible and will be questioned for both their actions and their inaction, and for their speech as well as their silence (Z). Of course, since the time of his expulsion from Paradise, Satan has been keen to destroy humankind, and he even vowed to use all the means at his disposal toward this end. However, in an era where evil reigns, this desire in Satan is heightened (T), and it becomes easier for him to attain his goal (N). That is because it is a time when *Shayṭān’s accoutrements have become strong, his schemes have become widespread, and his prey has become easy* to ensnare, for he has more devilish people helping his cause (T). The strengthening of his accoutrements (*‘qawīyat ‘uddatuhu’*) is a metaphor for evil and corruption which are Satan’s provisions and weapons, and his victims have become easy prey because they have strayed from the path, and it is therefore easy for him to target them (MB).

2 Imām ‘Alī then gives examples of the consequences of corruption, telling his listeners to cast their glance at the people wherever they wish, for all they will see is *a poor man struggling in poverty, or a rich man who has replaced Allāh’s blessing with ingratitude, or a miser who has taken stinginess with the right of Allāh as a means of increase in his wealth, or an insolent person turning a deaf ear to all counsel*. In this way, the Imām points to four groups that constitute clear signs of a degenerate and corrupt society. The phrase ‘*faqīran yukābidu faqran*’ describes the indigent who bears great hardship and suffering as a result of his poverty, and it alludes to how the needy detest their state and disdain it (N). On the other hand, those poor people who are content with whatever Allāh has provided them will actually gain reward for bearing their poverty. The spread of poverty in society is a consequence of social injustice and economic disparity resulting from an unjust and corrupt system of government (Z). ‘*Ghaniyyan baddala ni‘matallāhi kufran*’ refers to the wealthy individual who turns away from the remembrance of Allāh and instead of showing gratitude for His blessings, he gets so engrossed with his wealth and possessions that he forgets his Lord (MB). The third group is that of misers who withhold what is due to Allāh, thinking that it will increase their wealth (‘*ittakhadha al-bukhla bi ḥaqqillāhi wafran*’). Traditions depict how such individuals will be resurrected from their graves with their hands shackled to their necks, and will face abasement for having been niggardly and withholding the right of Allāh (T). The fourth group are those insolent individuals who turn a deaf ear to all advice and counsel. They are those whose hearts have been sealed, so no amount of admonition can get through to them (MB). It is interesting that the Imām told the people to look around in any direction they wished, and they would see nothing but one of these four types of people. That shows how much corruption had spread in the society, until it seeped into every nook and cranny (N).

3 In order to clarify further how corrupt the society had become, Amīr al-Mu’minīn poses a series of rhetorical questions. In this way, he compares the state of those who lived in the previous generation, and spent their lives honourably as pious believers, to the people of his own time who were immersed in corruption and evil. *Where are your virtuous and righteous ones? Where are the freemen and the magnanimous among you? Where are those who are cautious in their earning and have integrity in their conduct?* Perhaps it could be said that the Imām was linking the qualities of virtue, magnanimity, and freedom of thought to being

3 Where are your virtuous and righteous ones? Where are the freemen and the magnanimous among you? Where are those who are cautious in their earning and have integrity in their conduct? Have they not all departed from this lowly, fleeting, and vexatious world? Have you not been left among the dregs of society, whose censure the lips do not utter, due to the insignificance of their position and to do away with their mention? So *indeed we belong to Allāh, and to Him do we return*. Corruption has appeared and there is none to oppose or change it, nor is there anyone to prevent or deter it. With this, do you expect to attain the proximity of Allāh in His Holy Abode and to be regarded His most intimate friends? Far be it! Allāh cannot be defrauded of His paradise and His good pleasure cannot be secured save by obedience to Him. May Allāh curse those who enjoin good yet abandon it themselves, and forbid evil yet act upon it themselves!

٣ أَيْنَ أَحْيَارُكُمْ وَصَلَحَاؤُكُمْ؟ وَأَيْنَ
أَحْرَارُكُمْ وَسَمَحَاؤُكُمْ؟ وَأَيْنَ
الْمُتَوَرَّعُونَ فِي مَكَاسِبِهِمْ
وَالْمُتَتَرِّهُونَ فِي مَذَاهِبِهِمْ؟ أَلَيْسَ
قَدْ طَعُنُوا جَمِيعاً عَنْ هَذِهِ الدُّنْيَا
الدَّيَّةِ، وَالْعَاجِلَةِ الْمُنْعَصَةِ، وَهَلْ
خُلِفْتُمْ إِلَّا فِي خُتَالَةٍ لَا تَلْتَقِي
بِذِمَّتِهِمُ الشَّفَتَانِ، اسْتِصْغَاراً لِقَدَرِهِمْ
وَذَهَاباً عَنْ ذِكْرِهِمْ؟ فَاِإِنَّا لِلَّهِ وَإِنَّا
إِلَيْهِ رَاجِعُونَ، ظَهَرَ الْفَسَادُ فَلَا
مُنْكَرَ مُعَيَّرٍ وَلَا زَاجِرَ مُرْدَجِرٍ. أَفَبِهَذَا
تُرِيدُونَ أَنْ تَجَاوِرُوا اللَّهَ فِي دَارِ
قُدْسِهِ، وَتَكُونُوا أَعَزَّ أَوْلِيَائِهِ عِنْدَهُ؟
هَيْهَاتَ! لَا يُخَدَعُ اللَّهُ عَنْ جَنَّتِهِ، وَلَا
تُنَالُ مَرْضَاتُهُ إِلَّا بِطَاعَتِهِ. لَعَنَ اللَّهُ
الْأَمْرِينَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ النَّارِكِينَ لَهُ،
وَالنَّاهِينَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ الْعَامِلِينَ بِهِ!

honest in one's business dealings and honourable in one's conduct. The phrase '*al-mutawarri'ūna fī makāsibihim*' means that they are careful to observe all the rules pertaining to trade and business, adhering to the norms of fairness and justice, and eschewing all forms of cheating, swindling, or deception. '*Al-mutanazzihūna fī madhābihihim*' refers to those who keep away from corrupt dealings, or the use of fallacious reasoning and false justification for deceiving others (MB). *Have they not all departed from this lowly, fleeting, and vexatious world?* is a rhetorical question that serves two purposes. The first is to remind the people that they will one day die and leave this lowly abode of the *dunyā* (M). The second is to show that those

from whom they could learn good conduct through emulation, have all left this temporary world (MB). Now that their virtuous predecessors are no longer alive, the Imām says that people have been left among *the dregs of society* (*‘huthālah’*), *whose censure the lips do not utter, due to the insignificance of their position and to do away with their mention*. The phrase *‘lā taltaqī bidhammihim al-shafatān’* is recorded in some versions as *‘lā taltaqī illā bidhammihim al-shafatān’* in which case it would be rendered *whom the lips can only speak of censuringly*. The reason for their spurning any mention of these individuals is that they consider them too insignificant to speak of (M). Indeed, a noble person would avoid even mentioning the names of such repulsive and despicable individuals, and would ignore them completely (Z). Imām ‘Alī then utters the *kalimat al-istirjā’* (*‘innā lillāhi wa innā ilayhi rāji‘ūn’*) to highlight the great calamity that has befallen the people, since their outward corruption is leading them to corrupt their souls (T).

The Imām notes that corruption has spread everywhere, yet no one condemns it or disapproves of it. By this he reminds them that it is their duty to enjoin good and forbid evil. The Noble Prophet is reported to have said, “When my nation forsakes enjoining good and forbidding evil, then let them prepare for chastisement from Allāh” (T). The negative rhetorical question *with this, do you expect to attain the proximity of Allāh in His Holy Abode and to be regarded His most intimate friends* is used to warn his listeners that by remaining silent in the face of evil and corruption, they are risking their Hereafter. Indeed, one who neglects his duty to command what is right and forbid what is wrong cannot attain the lofty station of nearness to Allāh, let alone the coveted title of friend of Allāh (N). The phrase *‘dār qudsihi’* refers to Paradise, and *al-quds* connotes something pure (R). *Allāh cannot be defrauded of His paradise and His good pleasure cannot be secured save by obedience to Him*, means you cannot gain entry into Paradise by trickery and without being obedient to the Almighty. Cheating and trickery is only applicable when one can hide something from another, and since nothing can ever be hidden from Allāh, it is impossible to deceive Him (MB). Finally, the Imām curses those who *enjoin good yet abandon it themselves, and forbid evil yet act upon it themselves*. Some commentators opine that this curse includes all those whose words and actions do not conform to their religion and creed. So whoever believes in the Messenger of Allāh but does not follow his teachings out of defiance, he is also included in this curse (Z). However, most commentators understand it to be limited to those who enjoin good and forbid evil without acting upon their own

advice. Indeed, the verses about this clearly state: *O you who believe! Why do you say that which you do not do? It is grievously abhorrent in the sight of Allāh that you should say that which you do not do* (Q61:2-3) (MB).



ADDRESSING ABŪ DHARR WHEN HE WAS EXILED TO AL-RABADHAH

- 1 O Abū Dharr, you got angry for the sake of Allāh, so have hope in Him for whom you became angry. Verily, the people feared you for their worldly life while you feared them for your faith, so leave them with that for which they fear you and flee from them with that for which you fear them. How great is their need for what you deny them and how needless you are of what they deny you! You will soon know who has gained more tomorrow, and who is more enviable. Even if the skies and lands were closed over a servant who then became mindful of Allāh, Allāh would certainly open a way out for him! Never allow anything to give you comfort save the truth, and let nothing make you feel alone save falsehood. If you had accepted their world, they would have certainly loved you, and if you had cut a portion from it [for yourself], they would have given you asylum.
- يَا أَبَا ذَرٍّ، إِنَّكَ غَضِبْتَ لِلَّهِ فَارْجُ
مَنْ غَضِبْتَ لَهُ، إِنَّ الْقَوْمَ
خَافُوكَ عَلَى دُنْيَاهُمْ وَخَفْتَهُمْ
عَلَى دِينِكَ، فَاتْرُكْ فِي أَيْدِيهِمْ
مَا خَافُوكَ عَلَيْهِ، وَاهْرُبْ مِنْهُمْ
بِمَا خَفْتَهُمْ عَلَيْهِ؛ فَمَا أَحْوَجَهُمْ
إِلَى مَا مَنَعْتَهُمْ، وَمَا أَغْنَاكَ عَمَّا
مَنَعُوكَ! وَسَتَعْلَمُ مِنَ الرَّابِحِ غَدًا،
وَالْأَكْثَرُ حَسَدًا. وَلَوْ أَنَّ
السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَيْنِ كَانَتَا
عَلَى عَبْدٍ رَتَقَا ثُمَّ اتَّقَى اللَّهَ،
لَجَعَلَ اللَّهُ لَهُ مِنْهُمَا مَخْرَجًا! لَا
يُؤْنِسُنَّكَ إِلَّا الْحَقُّ، وَلَا
يُوحِشُنَّكَ إِلَّا الْبَاطِلُ، فَلَوْ قِيلَتْ
دُنْيَاهُمْ لَأَحْبَبُوكَ، وَلَوْ قَرَضْتَ
مِنْهَا لَأَمْنُوكَ.

CONTEXT

This oration is reported by al-Kulaynī in the last volume of his *al-Kāfi* with a chain of narrators, and slight variance in wording. From what he mentions, we note that it was not Imām ‘Alī alone who came to commiserate with Abū Dharr when he was being exiled to al-Rabadhah (which was a small desert village about

125 kms from Madīnah); rather, Imām al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn (ʿa) were also present, so was ʿAmmār and according to one version, ʿAqīl, who came and spoke to him, showing support and sympathy. The speech was likewise recorded in al-Jawharī's book *al-Saqīfah*, and that was the source used by Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd (N). This address was delivered by Imām ʿAlī to Abū Dharr al-Ghifārī on the outskirts of Madīnah, just as he was about to leave. The Imām had come with his sons to bid farewell to this noble and praiseworthy companion of the Messenger of Allāh. It is reported ʿUthmān's orders were that nobody should speak to Abū Dharr, escort him, or bid him farewell, and he commanded Marwān ibn Ḥakam to take him out of the city. Hence the people kept a distance from him, except Imām ʿAlī and al-Ḥasanayn, and ʿAmmār and ʿAqīl. They came out with him and escorted him. Imām al-Ḥasan began to speak with Abū Dharr, so Marwān said, "Don't you know that the caliph has forbidden speaking to this man?" At that point Imām ʿAlī raised his whip and struck the front of Marwān's mount and censured him. So Marwān returned angrily to ʿUthmān and informed him what had happened. Dhakwān, the freedman of Umm Hānī bint Abī Ṭālib, was present and he said, "I committed to memory all that was spoken there." Then he proceeded to relate this oration from Amīr al-Mu'mīnīn. All those who were present also spoke a few words, expressing their grief at being separated from Abū Dharr, a man loved by the Noble Prophet and by his closest companions (T). In his *Tārīkh*, al-Ṭabarī records the exiling of Abū Dharr under the events that transpired in the year 30 AH, though he says that he is loath to recount the details thereof. Abū Dharr passed away two years later, in 32 AH. It is unfortunate that some scholars tried to whitewash ʿUthmān's crime of exiling this noble companion from Madīnah by claiming that Abū Dharr himself decided to leave the city; and this sermon clearly negates any such claim (S).

COMMENTARY

1 Imām ʿAlī begins by praising Abū Dharr al-Ghifārī for what he had done, saying: *O Abū Dharr, you got angry for the sake of Allāh, so have hope in Him for whom you became angry.* Abū Dharr would enjoin good and forbid evil, saying, "My beloved friend, the Messenger of Allāh, advised me to always speak the truth, even if it was bitter, and not to fear the blame or censure of anyone in the way of Allāh." Abū Dharr was neither a leader, nor a commander of an army, nor a governor, nor was he wealthy or powerful. He possessed very little and led a simple life. However,

he was audacious when it came to speaking truth to power, and was completely sincere. He was determined and resolute, never silenced by fear or threats, and could never be bought for any amount of money. In short, he was a man of true faith whose sole purpose in life was to please Allāh (Z). That which angered Abū Dharr was the breaking of Allāh's laws and the misappropriation of public wealth by those in power. When he was initially sent to Syria, he openly spoke against the practices of Mu'āwiyah, and since the latter found no way to silence him, he complained about him to 'Uthmān. That was when he was sent to Madīnah, and then exiled to al-Rabadhah (I). By his stating that Abū Dharr's anger was for the sake of Allāh, Amīr al-Mu'minīn testified to his sincerity and that he had not become wroth for any personal reasons, but only to please the Almighty (M). Furthermore, he consoled Abū Dharr by telling him to remain hopeful in Allāh, as it was for Him that he had been roused to anger (N).

The Imām then contrasts the opposite reasons for their fear saying *the people feared you for their worldly life while you feared them for your faith*, which means that they feared you would corrupt their worldly status while you were afraid they would corrupt your religion (MB). *So leave them with that for which they fear you and flee from them with that for which you fear them*, meaning let them have their worldly possessions, and do not take anything thereof lest you become like them; and preserve your faith, fleeing away with it in order to save it (T). What he was forbidding them was something they greatly needed (*'mā aḥwajahum'*) to keep away from, namely evils and misdeeds. That is because the benefits of eschewing those evils were so great, and the harm brought about by them were so grave, that they could not arrive at any success without avoiding those evils. Alternatively, the phrase *how great is their need for what you deny them* means: how great is their need for what you have deprived them of by your leaving from their midst, namely your religion and your practice thereof (MB). In contrast, how little did he need the thing they denied him, which was their worldly possessions and wealth. The Imām's statement *you will soon know who has gained more tomorrow, and who is more enviable* is commiserative, because this life is short and the Day of Judgment will soon come, bringing in its wake disgrace, abasement, and punishment for the oppressors and lovers of this world. Conversely, the veracious will be showered with blessings and bounties which will cause others to envy them (N).

To give Abū Dharr even more hope, the Imām tells him that as long as he clings to *taqwā*, even if the skies and earth close in on a true servant of Allāh, He

will show him a way to escape and *open a way out for him*. By this, the Imām was informing him of the tribulations that await him in the wilderness, while at the same time advising him to remain mindful of Allāh as in doing so, He will bless him with a way out of his plight (M). He then advises Abū Dharr never to seek comfort in anything save the truth (*‘lā yu’nisannaka illā al-ḥaqq’*), and to allow nothing to make him feel lonely, deserted, or frightened save falsehood (*‘lā yūḥishannaka illā al-bāṭil’*). The last point mentioned by Imām ‘Alī to Abū Dharr was *if you had accepted their world, they would have certainly loved you*, meaning if you had accepted their proposals for worldly gain, they would have liked you and taken your side. *And if you had cut a portion from it, they would have given you asylum*, meaning if you had partaken of their offers of wealth and power, they would have accorded you full protection. Indeed, the rulers whom he spoke out against were always ready to make deals in order to secure their positions. They would willingly bestow wealth and patronage to anyone who was ready to capitulate and acquiesce to their actions and plans (N). A report from Imām al-Ṣādiq states that ‘Uthmān once sent two servants and two hundred gold coins to Abū Dharr. He told the servants to convey his greetings to the latter and say, “The caliph has gifted you these coins to use as you need.” Abū Dharr asked, “Has he given this amount to any others among the Muslims?” They replied in the negative, so he said, “I am but one among the Muslims; what brings them ease brings me ease.” They said, “The caliph has said that this money is from his own wealth, and it has not been mixed with anything unlawful.” Abū Dharr replied, “I have no need for it. I began this day of mine as the richest of all people.” When they questioned him how that could be when they only saw very little with him of belongings, he replied, “I am rich with the *wilāyah* of ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib and his guided progeny, who guide to the truth” (T).



ON THE QUALITIES OF A TRUE LEADER

- 1 O differing souls and disunited hearts, whose bodies are present but wits are absent, I am gently leading you upon the path of truth, yet you are fleeing from it the way goats run away from the roar of a lion! It is quite impossible for me to uncover, through you, the justice that is hidden by darkness, or to straighten the truth that has been bent.

١ أَيَّتْهَا النُّفُوسُ الْمُخْتَلِفَةُ، وَالْقُلُوبُ الْمُتَشَتِّتَةُ، الشَّاهِدَةُ أَبْدَانِهِمْ، وَالْغَائِبَةُ عَنْهُمْ عُقُولُهُمْ، أَطَّارُكُمْ عَلَى الْحَقِّ وَأَنْتُمْ تَنْفِرُونَ عَنْهُ نُفُورَ الْمِعْزَى مِنْ وَغْوَةِ الْأَسَدِ! هَيْهَاتَ أَنْ أَطْلَعَ بِكُمْ سِرَارَ الْعَدْلِ، أَوْ أُقِيمَ اعْوِجَاجَ الْحَقِّ.
- 2 O Allāh! You know that what we did was neither for the purpose of seeking power, nor to acquire anything from the worthless vanities [of this world]. Rather, we only sought to restore the guideposts of Your religion and bring about reform in Your cities, so that the oppressed among Your servants might be safe and Your forsaken commands may be established. O Allāh! I was the first to turn [towards You], and to hear and respond [to Your message]. No one preceded me in prayer save the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ).

٢ اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّكَ تَعْلَمُ أَنَّهُ لَمْ يَكُنِ الَّذِي كَانَ مِنَّا مُنَافَسَةً فِي سُلْطَانٍ، وَلَا الِتِمَاسَ شَيْءٍ مِنْ فُضُولِ الْخُطَامِ، وَلَكِنْ لِنَرْدِ الْمَعَالِمِ مِنْ دِينِكَ، وَنُظْهِرِ الْإِضْلَاحَ فِي بِلَادِكَ، فَيَأْمَنَ الْمَظْلُومُونَ مِنْ عِبَادِكَ، وَتُقَامَ الْمَعْطَلَةُ مِنْ حُدُودِكَ. اللَّهُمَّ إِنِّي أَوَّلُ مَنْ أَنْابَ، وَسَمِعَ وَأَجَابَ، لَمْ يَسْبِقْنِي إِلَّا رَسُولُ اللَّهِ ﷺ بِالصَّلَاةِ.
- 3 Indeed, you know that it does not behove one who is in charge of the honour, life, wealth, legal ordinances, and leadership of the Muslims to be a miser, such that he would greedily seek [to acquire] their wealth, nor to be an

٣ وَقَدْ عَلِمْتُمْ أَنَّهُ لَا يَنْبَغِي أَنْ يَكُونَ الْوَالِي عَلَى الْفُرُوجِ وَالِدِمَاءٍ وَالْمَعَانِمِ وَالْأَحْكَامِ وَإِمَامَةِ الْمُسْلِمِينَ الْبَخِيلُ،

ignorant individual, as he would then mislead them by his ignorance, nor to be harsh thereby cutting them off with his harshness, nor to be iniquitous with [public] wealth such that he favours one group over another, nor to accept bribes in issuing judgments thereby doing away with the rights [of others] and holding them back from their rightful owners, nor should he forsake the Sunnah thereby causing the nation to fall into ruin.

فَتَكُونُ فِي أَمْوَالِهِمْ نَهْمَةً، وَلَا
الْجَاهِلُ فَيُضِلَّهُمْ بِجَهْلِهِ، وَلَا
الْجَافِي فَيَقْطَعُهُمْ بِجَفَائِهِ، وَلَا
الْحَائِفُ لِلدُّوَلِ فَيَتَّخِذَ قَوْمًا
دُونَ قَوْمٍ، وَلَا الْمُزْتَشِي فِي
الْحُكْمِ فَيَذْهَبَ بِالْحُقُوقِ
وَيَقِفَ بِهَا دُونَ الْمَقَاطِعِ، وَلَا
الْمُعْطَلُ لِلْسُّنَةِ فَيُهْلِكَ الْأُمَّةَ.

CONTEXT

This is an excerpt of a sermon delivered by Amīr al-Mu'minīn on the pulpit of Kūfah, according to what Mujāhid reported from Ibn 'Abbās, as recorded in Sibṭ ibn al-Jawzī's *Tadhkirat al-Khawāṣṣ*, as well as al-Majlisī's *Biḥār al-Anwār*. Though it is not known when exactly he spoke these words, some have surmised from its contents that it may have been after the arbitration (in 37 AH). Other early sources have mentioned parts of this sermon as well, such as *Dā'im al-Islām* by Qāḍī Nu'mān, and *al-Nihāyah* by Ibn Athīr. Some of the variances found in other sources give us reason to believe that this sermon was recorded in other works prior to *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this oration within a much longer sermon that was delivered by the Imām a few days prior to his martyrdom, meaning it was spoken in the year 40 AH. In any case, the sermon was a reproof addressed to those of his followers who reneged on their duty to obey him without question. The Imām also mentioned some of his qualities that necessitate obedience to him by his subjects, following up with an allusion to those who wrongfully usurped the caliphate despite being unworthy and lacking the qualities required of a good leader (MB).

COMMENTARY

1 By addressing the people as those with *differing souls and disunited hearts, whose bodies are present but wits are absent*, the Imām was pointing to their varying opinions and agitated hearts which led them to become negligent about what was in their best interest. The absence of their wits likewise alludes to their negligence and lack of recognition of the truth (M). Some opine that their differences and disunity was the main cause of the problems being faced by the Muslims. Their inattentiveness has also been mentioned by the Imām in sermons no. 29 and 96, thereby highlighting their lack of perspicacity in relation to what was happening around them (N). He tells them *I am gently leading you upon the path of truth, yet you are fleeing from it the way goats run away from the roar of a lion*. The verb ‘*aẓ’arukum*’ means I am gently urging you forward (T), or am making you incline towards the truth and desire to seek it (Z). Though the Imām tried all the means at his disposal to bring them towards the correct path, they turned to flee from it like goats from a lion’s snarl! It is interesting that he did not say they were running away from a lion, but only from the sound of a lion. This means that the extent of their timidity was such that, like goats, they sought to flee even before seeing the lion itself (N). This depicts how quickly they would run away from the truth (M). Because of such an attitude, the Imām says that it is quite impossible for him to uncover, through them, *the justice that is hidden by darkness, or to straighten the truth that has been bent*.

The term ‘*sirār*’ usually refers to the last nights of the lunar month in which the moon is invisible and thus there is complete darkness (T). The phrase ‘*aṭla’ bikum*’ has been interpreted by some to mean delivering you to a specific destination. In that case, the Imām means it is unlikely that he would be able to deliver them to the best position of justice and equity due to their conduct (Z). Alternatively, it means that he cannot make manifest for them what is hidden of justice and rectify their abandonment thereof and their disunity (MB). Another interpretation of the phrase is that it is far from likely that he would be able to unveil the obscured face of justice through them and by means of their support (N). Some have suggested that the term *sirār* could be interpreted as *surūr*, which refers to the lines on one’s forehead, so the phrase would mean that he deemed it impossible to brighten the face of justice and make it shine through them (I). In any case, the overall purport of this phrase is the same. The Imām further states

that it is likewise quite impossible for him to *straighten the truth that has been bent* or become distorted due to the prevalence of ignorance and misguidance among the people (MB). In reality, Imām ‘Alī is referring to those who have become crooked and whose views have been perverted, since the truth itself can never be made crooked or bent (Z).

2 The goal of a divinely sanctioned government, such as his own, are mentioned by the Imām here in brief. It is a template for all believing leaders to follow as well (N). He says, *O Allāh! You know that what we did*, referring to his encouraging the people to fight the enemy and protect their lands from invaders (T), or his acceptance of the caliphate (N), or the battles he fought (I), namely the Battle of Jamal and Şiffin (Z), or all of these actions together (MB). All that he did *was neither for the purpose of seeking power, nor to acquire anything from the worthless vanities of the world*. He did not vie for power or authority like those who preceded him (T), nor did he seek the worthless glitter of this fleeting world which have no real value or benefit (MB). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then explains why he took up the mantle of leadership, stating that it was only in order to restore the guideposts of the religion of Allāh, and bring about reform in the cities, so that the oppressed among His servants might be safe and His forsaken commands may be established and upheld. The phrase ‘*al-ma’ālima min dīnika*’ refers to the signs that guide one to Allāh’s religion (T); Imām ‘Alī accepted the caliphate in order to return Islam to its original state as taught and practiced by the Noble Prophet (Z). He had to *restore* these guideposts and waymarks because some of those in authority before him had effaced them (N). As for bringing about reform in the lands, it means doing away with injustice and corruption (MB), such that those who are oppressed may feel secure, and not fear for their life, freedom, possessions, and sustenance. Interestingly, similar words to these were spoken about two decades later by Imām al-Ḥusayn in one of his sermons, a couple of years prior to Mu’āwiyah’s death (S).

The phrase ‘*al-mu’aṭṭalatu min ḥudūdika*’ is not restricted to the penalties ordained by Allāh, such as flogging fornicators or severing the hands of thieves. Rather, it encompasses everything that is prescribed and proscribed by Him (Z). Having clarified his goal in accepting leadership, the Imām testifies to the veracity of his speech by stating that he was the first to turn towards Allāh, and to hear and respond to His Messenger (N). As the foremost believer, he would not resort to falsehood or speak any untruth (T). By saying that nobody preceded him in prayer save the Messenger of Allāh, Imām ‘Alī was implying that for a person like him,

whose whole life was spent in submission to the Almighty, it could not even be surmised that he would seek the paltry gains of this world (I). A tradition reported from Imām al-Šādiq states that the first congregational prayer was led by the Prophet with Amīr al-Mu'minīn praying next to him. Then Abū Ṭālib passed by with Ja'far, and when he saw them, he told Ja'far to join them in prayer. When the Prophet realized that he had joined them, he moved forward and they both prayed behind him (T).

3 The Imām now turns to the qualities that are not befitting one who takes on the responsibility of leadership. By saying *you know* ('*qad'alimtum*'), Imām 'Alī was implying that the qualities he would mention were evident, based on clear reason (N). The phrase '*al-wālī 'alā al-furū'*' is rendered *one who is in charge of the honour of people*, though it literally means one who is responsible for the marital affairs and conjugal contracts of the community. He is the one who has to carry out the legal penalty for fornication and adultery, and conclude marriage contracts as well as divorce proceedings in accordance with the rules of the *sharī'ah* (Z). Likewise, the ruler must maintain order and preserve the lives ('*al-dimā*', lit. blood) of his subjects, by protecting them from enemies or those who wish them harm, and their wealth ('*al-maghānim*', lit. gains) by ensuring security. He is also responsible for the laws and ordinances, and ensuring all the people follow them (Z). He can only do this by providing leadership and governance that is just, where the rights of all his subjects are respected and fulfilled. However, if he is a miser, all his efforts will be focussed on acquisition of wealth, and he would do whatever it took to attain this goal. Then neither would there be security nor any respect for the law (N). The term '*nahmah*' connotes expending great effort towards something (I), and here it means that a miserly leader would be propelled by his greed to misappropriate the wealth of his subjects. There are many examples of this in history. One commentator mentions 'Uthmān's giving his uncle, al-Ḥakam ibn Abī al-Āṣ, who had been expelled by the Noble Prophet, a hundred thousand dirhams from the public treasury, as an example of such misappropriation (T). The second quality not befitting of a leader is ignorance. That is because *he would then mislead them by his ignorance*. An ignorant leader has no knowledge of the laws and regulations of religion, and is unaware of the intricacies of governance and management of affairs. As such he would make wrong decisions and pass incorrect judgments, thereby misleading all those who follow him (M). One of the qualities

of the divinely appointed Imām is his encompassing knowledge, which makes him best suited for leadership.

The third quality that does not befit a leader is harshness. The Imām notes that a harsh leader cuts off his subjects and alienates them. People require justice from their ruler and he should thus be someone approachable and compassionate. He should be patient with those who turn to him for assistance and to present their needs, and listen to the complaints of the oppressed (Z). A harsh, abrasive, and unsympathetic leader is hated by the people, and they get fed up with him (M). Some have interpreted the phrase *'fayaqṭa'ahum bi jafā'ihī'* to mean that he cuts them off from what they require, and he does that by his cruel behaviour which prevents people from approaching him out of fear (I). The fourth negative quality which should not be in any leader is iniquity with public wealth *such that he favours one group over another*. The phrase *'al-ḥā'if li al-duwal'* means being unjust with wealth, as *'al-duwal'* is the plural of *dūlah*, which connotes wealth that is in circulation. A righteous leader should divide the public wealth fairly and equitably (I). Indeed, this was one of the biggest mistakes of the third caliph, and it brought in its wake disastrous consequences (N). Another version reads *'al-khā'if li al-duwal'*, which means that he is afraid of the changes that happen around him, and that is also a negative quality for any leader (M). The fifth quality that is unbefitting of any leader is being corrupt and accepting bribes in order to pass rulings in someone's favour. In a well-known tradition, the Noble Messenger is said to have cursed both the giver and the receiver of bribes, as well as any intermediary thereof (MB). Any ruler or judge who takes bribes is sure to trample on the rights of others. Given that the term *'al-maqāṭi'*, which is the plural of *maqṭa'*, refers to the point where something arrives, the phrase *'yaqifu bihā dūna al-maqāṭi'* means that the rights do not reach their true owners or deserving recipients because of the bribe that has been taken by the judge (I).

Finally, the sixth quality mentioned by Imām 'Alī which is improper for any leader is forsaking the Sunnah, *thereby causing the nation to fall into ruin*. Indeed, if a ruler abandons the guidance of the Noble Prophet, as reflected in his words and deeds, he will cause the Muslim community to perish. That is because it would entail turning away from divine guidance, and the *sharī'ah*, which has been prescribed for the betterment of human beings, and guides them to felicity both in this world and the next (MB). Some commentators suggest that the term *'al-sunnah'* here may also be a reference to the *sunnah* of Allāh and His laws, or even

the generally accepted righteous practices of the people (*sunnah ṣāliḥah*) as noted in the advice given by the Imām to Mālik al-Ashtar (N); however most commentators consider it to refer specifically to the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allāh (Z, M).



ON ABSTEMIOUSNESS IN THIS WORLD

PRAISING ALLĀH

- 1 We praise Him for what He takes and gives, and for what He bestows and tests [us with]. He is aware of all that is hidden and witnesses every secret. He knows all that the chests conceal and all that the eyes secretly gaze at. We bear witness that there is no god save Him, and that Muḥammad (ṣ) is His specially chosen and sent [Messenger] – a testimony affirmed both inwardly and outwardly, with the heart as well as the tongue.

حمد الله

١ نَحْمَدُهُ عَلَى مَا أَخَذَ وَأَعْطَى،
وَعَلَى مَا أَبْلَى وَابْتَلَى، الْبَاطِنُ
لِكُلِّ خَفِيَّةٍ، وَالْحَاضِرُ لِكُلِّ
سَرِيرَةٍ، الْعَالِمُ بِمَا تُكِنُّ
الصُّدُورُ، وَمَا تَخُونُ الْعُيُونُ.
وَنَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ غَيْرُهُ، وَأَنَّ
مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ نَجِيُّهُ وَبَعِيثُهُ،
شَهَادَةً يُوَافِقُ فِيهَا السِّرُّ الْإِغْلَانُ
وَالْقَلْبُ اللَّسَانُ.

ADMONISHING THE PEOPLE

- 2 Verily it is, by Allāh, serious, not a jest, and the truth, not a lie. It is nothing other than death, with a caller most clearly heard and a driver most hasty. So never let the masses beguile you from [being mindful of] your soul, for you have seen those who lived before you, among whom was he who amassed wealth and feared poverty, feeling safe from the consequences – due to lengthy aspirations and thinking of death as a distant thing – how death descended upon him, snatched him from his homeland, and took him from his sanctuary. He was carried on a wooden

ومنها: في عظة الناس

٢ فَإِنَّهُ وَاللَّهِ الْجِدُّ لَا اللَّعِبُ، وَالْحَقُّ لَا
الْكَذِبُ، وَمَا هُوَ إِلَّا الْمَوْتُ أَشْمَعُ
ذَاعِيهِ، وَأَعْجَلَ حَادِيهِ، فَلَا يُغَوِّنُكَ
سَوَادُ النَّاسِ مِنْ نَفْسِكَ، وَقَدْ رَأَيْتَ
مَنْ كَانَ قَبْلَكَ مِمَّنْ جَمَعَ الْمَالَ
وَحَذَرَ الْإِقْلَالِ، وَأَمِنَ الْعَوَاقِبَ -
طُولَ أَمَلٍ وَاسْتِغْثَادَ أَجَلٍ - كَيْفَ
نَزَلَ بِهِ الْمَوْتُ فَأَزَعَجَهُ عَنْ وَطَنِهِ،
وَأَخَذَهُ مِنْ مَأْمَنِهِ، مَحْمُولًا عَلَى
أَعْوَادِ الْمَنَائِيَا يَتَعَاطَى بِهِ

bier, passed on from person to person,
 lifted upon shoulders, and held [up] by
 fingertips.

الرَّجَالُ الرَّجَالِ، حَمَلًا عَلَى
 الْأُمْنَاكِبِ وَإِفْسَاكَ بِالْأَنَامِلِ.

CONTEXT

This is an admonitory sermon in which Amīr al-Mu'minīn counsels the people to avoid attachment to this world and its fleeting pleasures. Some sentences of this oration have been quoted by al-Āmidī in *Ghurur al-Hikam wa Durar al-Kalim*, and the variance in wording gives us reason to believe that he used a different source from that of al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Furthermore, Ibn Athīr has quoted one line of this sermon in his *al-Nihāyah* (N). Unfortunately, we do not have any information about when and where the Imām gave this speech. However, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places the first part thereof, consisting of praise of Allāh, within a sermon the Imām gave in Madīnah before marching out to face the rebels in the Battle of Jamal. He considers the second part of the sermon to be from a longer oration called 'al-Ṭālūtiyyah' (2:431). In any case, the message of this oration is universal, and therefore is not restricted by its specific context.

COMMENTARY

1 As with most of his sermons, the Imām began by praising the Almighty. He praises Allāh for *what He takes and gives*. It is obvious that He would be praised for what He gives, but regarding what He takes, some commentators suggest that it refers to the covenant He took from all of mankind in 'ālam al-dharr, as mentioned in Q7:172. Alternatively, it could refer to taking the creatures to task for what He has made incumbent upon them, specifically the fiscal dues of *khums*, *zakāt*, etc. It could also mean that which He takes from His servants in order to test them with poverty and hardship, after their having been wealthy. Though all of this seems to bring immediate difficulty and hardship for the servants, He is praised for it because it leads the patient, believing servants to eternal felicity in the Hereafter. It is also possible that this phrase means that He seizes ('*akhadha*') the guilty sinners with punishment, and grants ('*aṭā*') the righteous believers rewards (MB). The Imām likewise praises Him *for what He bestows and tests* the servants

with, as showing gratitude even for His trials is a sign of contentment with His decree (*al-riḍā bi qadā'ihī*) and patience in the face of tribulations (Z), which are praiseworthy traits in themselves. The term '*al-bāṭin*' means one who has knowledge of the hidden aspects of things (R), hence '*al-bāṭin li kulli khafīyyah*' is rendered *He is aware of all that is hidden*, for He knows and sees everything that is concealed (MB). Likewise, '*al-ḥāḍir li kulli sarīrah*' means that He is fully aware of every secret, and is present and witnesses it. That is why commentators have glossed '*al-ḥāḍir*' as *al-shāhid*, i.e. the witness (Z).

He knows all that the chests conceal and all that the eyes secretly gaze at as stated in Q40:19. The phrase '*mā takhūnu al-ʿuyūn*' refers to what the eyes secretly spy, or the glances that convey unspoken messages in order to betray someone (MB). Imām 'Alī then testifies that there is no god but Allāh, and *that Muḥammad (ṣ) is His specially chosen and sent Messenger*. The term '*al-naḥīb*' means the chosen and most excellent one, while '*al-ba'īth*' refers to one who is sent as a messenger (N). The Imām states that his testimony is *affirmed both inwardly and outwardly, with the heart as well as the tongue*. This means that he bore witness with complete sincerity (M), and it was something he firmly believed in, with complete conviction, not merely words uttered by the tongue (N).

2 Amīr al-Mu'minīn now admonishes the people, and starts by stressing the seriousness of the matter. He says that *it is, by Allāh, serious, not a jest, and the truth, not a lie*. The pronoun 'it' either refers to something the Imām had spoken earlier and was elided by al-Raḍī, or to what the Imām mentions subsequently, namely death (M). Since death is a reality that cannot be escaped, and is a grave matter, he states that it is not a jest. Furthermore, by introducing it in this way, the Imām was also striking fear into the hearts of his listeners, and warning them. He uses ten forms of emphasis here, which have been enumerated by some commentators (MB). The Imām then described death as having a call that is *most clearly heard and a driver most hasty*. The sound of its caller is heard from all directions, and its cry 'departure!' fills the air as the Angel of Death takes the souls of young and old, as commanded by the Almighty (N). The phrase '*ʿajala ḥādīh*' literally refers to one who quickens the pace of his camel by uttering sounds to make it walk faster (T), and here it figuratively refers to the speed with which death comes, and drives the souls away (MB). The Imām then tells them never to let the masses beguile them. The phrase '*sawād al-nās*' refers to the masses (I), and here he means that they should not be deceived by the multitudes who are alive, or of how long some of

them have been living, thinking that they too will live equally long (Z). The phrase *from your soul* ('*min nafsika*') here alludes to their being distracted from reforming their souls and improving themselves (MB). Some commentators interpret it to mean that they should not allow their base soul to make them forget the many people they see dying around them (M). Indeed, those who are alive have seen the people who lived before them, *among whom was he who amassed wealth and feared poverty, feeling safe from the consequences*, yet in the end they died and left everything behind. The phrase '*ḥadhira al-iqlāl*' means he accumulated wealth thinking that he would thereby protect himself from the penury and destitution he feared. '*Amina al-awāqib*' means that because he thought he still had more time, and it was too soon to worry about death, he felt secure from the consequences of his actions, and was complacent about retribution (N).

The living have witnessed how such individuals behaved because of their *lengthy aspirations and thinking of death as a distant thing*, yet death descended upon them suddenly, and snatched them away from their homes and their sanctuaries (MB). Those who died were then carried on wooden biers, *passed on from person to person, lifted upon shoulders, and held up by fingertips*. The phrase '*a'wād al-manāyā*' literally means the wooden planks of death, and here it refers to the biers upon which corpses are carried to the graveyard (M). The bier is carried by passing it forward from one person to another, as they each carry it on their shoulders and grip it with their fingers. The phrase '*imsākan bil-anāmīl*' has been understood to mean that they hold the bier with their fingertips, as though they are afraid to clasp it with their whole hands (N). However, other commentators opine that the term *fingertips* here is used to refer to the whole hand, as part of a thing is sometimes used to imply the whole thing (*tasmiyat lil-kull bi-ismi juz'ihī*) (MB). It may be that some individuals only touch the bier with their fingertips as they consider it beneath their status to carry the body of that person on their shoulders (S).

3 The Imām emphasizes the point further by asking them rhetorically about what they have seen of those people *who had far-flung aspirations* and cherished long hopes ('*ya'malūna ba'īdan*'), who constructed great edifices and lofty buildings, and amassed abundant wealth; *how their houses turned into graves and what they amassed got ruined*. The term '*al-mashūd*' refers to a building that is erected with mortar or gypsum (I), or a lofty, high-rise building (N). Those who lived earlier built, amassed, married, procreated, and had many aspirations, but they could not

3 Did you not see those who had far-flung aspirations, constructed lofty buildings, and amassed plenty – how their houses turned into graves and what they amassed got ruined. Their wealth passed on to their heirs and their spouses became part of other families. They can neither increase their good deeds nor can they atone for their evil deeds! Yet whoever covers his heart with Godwariness excels in virtue and succeeds in his efforts. So take advantage of it and do what is required to attain Paradise; verily this world has not been created for you as a place of permanent residence. Rather, it was created for you as a passage in order that you may take provisions from it [in the form] of [good] deeds for the permanent abode [of the Hereafter]. So quickly prepare for departure from it and keep your riding mounts close for the [imminent] relocation.

۳ أَمَّا رَأَيْتُمُ الَّذِينَ يَأْمُلُونَ بَعِيداً، وَيُنْشَوْنَ مَشِيداً، وَيَجْمَعُونَ كَثِيراً - كَيْفَ أَضْبَحَتْ يُيُوثُهُمْ قُبُوراً، وَمَا جَمَعُوا بُوراً، وَصَارَتْ أَمْوَالُهُمْ لِلْوَارِثِينَ، وَأَزْوَاجُهُمْ لِقَوْمٍ آخَرِينَ، لَا فِي حَسَنَةٍ يَرِيدُونَ، وَلَا مِنْ سَيِّئَةٍ يُسْتَعْتَبُونَ! فَمَنْ أَشْعَرَ النَّفْسَ قَلْبُهُ بَرَزَ مَهْلُهُ وَفَارَ عَمَلُهُ. فَاهْتَبِلُوا هَبْلَهَا، وَاعْمَلُوا لِلْجَنَّةِ عَمَلَهَا، فَإِنَّ الدُّنْيَا لَمْ تُخْلَقْ لَكُمْ دَارَ مَقَامٍ، بَلْ خُلِقَتْ لَكُمْ مَجَازاً لَتَرْوُدُوا مِنْهَا الْأَعْمَالَ إِلَى دَارِ الْقَرَارِ؛ فَكُونُوا مِنْهَا عَلَى أَوْفَازٍ، وَقَرَّبُوا الظُّهُورَ لِلرَّيَالِ.

live long enough to fulfil their aspirations and were taken from their mansions to their desolate graves, and from their developed habitations to their lonely tombs (Z). Indeed, with the passage of time, even grand palaces are reduced to ruins, and places where houses once stood turn into graveyards (J). Likewise, the wealth of those people *passed on to their heirs and their spouses became part of other families*, and this is something we witness every day (MB). Once death comes, people *can neither increase their good deeds nor can they atone for their evil deeds*, since no action can be undertaken after death, nor can one repent (Z). Therefore, whoever, while still alive in this world, *covers his heart with Godwariness excels in virtue and succeeds in his efforts*. The phrase ‘*man ash’ara al-taqwā qalbahu*’ literally means

one who dons the inner garment of Godwariness, meaning he adheres to it as closely as his inner garments adhere to his body (I). Whoever does this excels in virtue and outpaces his peers (*'barraza mahaluhu'*), arriving at the ultimate destination of felicity before them through his good actions (MB). The phrase *'fahtabilū habalahā'* has been rendered *so take advantage of it*, and means seek out its benefit (T), and the pronoun *it* refers to the opportunity one has to do good deeds while alive in this world (Z). The imperative *do what is required to attain Paradise* means work hard and exert the effort required to become worthy of entry into Paradise. Indeed, entry into the everlasting abode of bliss and bounty is not free, and nobody can lay claim to it due to their lineage or title. Rather, it is only through correct belief and righteous actions based on Godwariness that one can attain a place in Paradise (N).

The Imām then reminds the people that this world is only created *as a passage in order that you may take provisions* from it in the form of good deeds *for the permanent abode* of the Hereafter. The term *'majāzan'* means a passage, pathway, or means (T). He advises the people to make haste and *quickly prepare for departure* from this world. The phrase *'alā awfāz'* means to hasten and to be quick (Z), and *'qarribū al-ḡuhūr li al-ziyāl'* means bring your mounts closer and make ready the backs of your camels for departure, and your relocation from this world to the next (T). Some commentators opine that the term *backs* (*'al-ḡuhūr'*) is a metaphor for the mounts (R), while others say that it is a metaphor for the good deeds that will carry people in the Hereafter like riding mounts carry them in this world (M). By telling people to be quick in their preparation, the Imām implies that time is very limited and there are many obstacles ahead. Furthermore, the exact moment of departure from this world is not known, so it is of paramount importance that one should always be ready, since death can come at any moment (N).



ON THE GREATNESS OF ALLĀH, THE QUR'ĀN, AND THE PROPHET

THE GREATNESS OF ALLĀH

- 1 This world and the Hereafter have submitted their reins to Him, and the heavens and earths have surrendered their keys to Him. The blooming trees prostrate to Him in the morning and evening, produce luminous fire for Him from their branches, and yield their harvest in the form of ripe fruits at His command.

عظمة الله تعالى

١ وَانْقَادَتْ لَهُ الدُّنْيَا وَالْآخِرَةُ بِأَرْمَتَيْهَا، وَقَدَفَتْ إِلَيْهِ السَّمَاوَاتُ وَالْأَرْضُضُونَ مَقَالِيدَهَا، وَسَجَدَتْ لَهُ بِالْعُدُودِ وَالْأَصَالِ الْأَشْجَارُ النَّاصِرَةُ، وَفَدَحَتْ لَهُ مِنْ قُضْبَانِهَا النَّيِّرَانَ الْمُضْيِيَّةَ، وَآتَتْ أَكْلَهَا بِكَلِمَاتِهِ التَّمَارُ الْيَانِعَةُ.

ABOUT THE QUR'ĀN

- 2 The Book of Allāh is present among you. It speaks and its tongue does not falter. It is a house whose pillars do not collapse and a might whose supporters are not vanquished.

منها: في القرآن

٢ وَكِتَابُ اللَّهِ بَيْنَ أَظْهُرِكُمْ، نَاطِقٌ لَا يَغْيَا لِسَانَهُ، وَيَبِيتُ لَا تُهْدَمُ أَرْكَائُهُ، وَعِزٌّ لَا تُهْرَمُ أَغْوَانُهُ.

ABOUT THE MESSENGER OF ALLĀH

- 3 He sent him after an interval in the sequence of Messengers, during a period of conflicting opinions [among the people]. He made him follow the earlier Messengers and through him brought revelation to a close. Thus, he fought in the way of Allāh against those who turned back from Him and equated others with Him.

منها: في رسول الله

٣ أَرْسَلَهُ عَلَى حِينِ فِتْرَةٍ مِنَ الرُّسُلِ، وَتَنَازُعٍ مِنَ الْأَلْسُنِ، فَفَقَّيَ بِهِ الرُّسُلَ، وَخَتَمَ بِهِ الْوَحْيَ، فَجَاهَدَ فِي اللَّهِ الْمُدْبِرِينَ عَنْهُ وَالْعَادِلِينَ بِهِ.

CONTEXT

This oration consists of two main parts: the first has three themes, namely glorification of Allāh, the importance of the Qurʾān, and the status of the Noble Messenger. The second part comprises advice to the people (MB). Though other known sources for this sermon are not extant, Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd states that what has been related by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī here are only excerpts that he chose from a longer sermon. From this statement, we can surmise that Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd had seen the whole sermon, though he has not alluded to any source. However, it is also possible that he only deduced this from the sermon itself, because al-Sayyid al-Raḍī uses the phrase '*wa minhā*' (*and from the same sermon*) a number of times, which shows that he has excerpted parts thereof. And the fact that these sections are not linked in terms of the subjects discussed also leads us to conclude that they were taken from a longer sermon. Portions of this oration were later mentioned, with slight variance in wording, in al-Āmidī's *Ghurar al-Ḥikam*, and it is possible that he may have had a different source to which he referred (N). Unfortunately there is no available information regarding when and where this speech was given by Imām 'Alī.

COMMENTARY

1 This introductory pericope points to some aspects of the greatness of the Almighty. First he says that both this world and the Hereafter have *submitted their reins* to Allāh. Using the analogy of animals and riding mounts whose reins are in the Hands of the Almighty, he notes that Allāh has complete control over creation (N). Second, the Imām notes that *the heavens and earths have surrendered their keys to Him*. This echoes the verse of the Glorious Qurʾān that states: *To Him belong the keys of the heavens and the earth* (Q39:63). The verb '*qadhafa*' literally means to cast or toss, but here it is used metaphorically to mean submit and surrender. The keys of the heavens and earth are also metaphors for the bounties and treasures of Allāh in the heavens and on earth (M). The third sign of Allāh's greatness mentioned by the Imām is the prostration of blooming trees to Him in the morning and evening. The phrase '*al-ashjār al-nāḍirah*' refers to trees with lush, green leaves, and though such trees, along with everything else in creation, prostrate before Allāh at all times, as the Qurʾān tells us (Q22:18), the Imām specifically mentions their prostration *in the morning and evening* because he is

referring to a specific kind of prostration, which takes place when the morning and evening dew forms on the surface of its leaves, and causes the spread of a fresh scent therefrom. This is over and above the general prostration of submission that all creatures in existence perform at every moment (T). The fourth sign of His greatness is how these very same trees *produce luminous fire for Him from their branches* through kindled flames, and this is indeed one of the wonders of creation. From water and earth, He brings forth a creation in the form of plants and trees which become the source of light and heat when used as kindling for fire. And it is this same fire which then alleviates many difficulties and makes things easier for humankind (N). The derivation of fire from green trees is one of the signs of Allāh, as mentioned in the verse: *He who made for you fire from the green tree, so that with it you kindle [flames]* (Q36:80) (I). The last thing mentioned by the Imām here is how these trees *yield their harvest in the form of ripe fruits at His command*. The term '*kalimātihi*' here refers to His power, authority, and will, as exemplified by His command "Be!" (MB). Referring to His command as His words ('*kalimātihi*') is metaphorical, and it is akin to the words spoken by a commander as he orders others (M). By mentioning these signs, it was as though the Imām was urging his listeners to remember Allāh and show gratitude to Him for His blessings (Z).

2 In this short section, the Imām speaks about the importance of the Glorious Qur'ān, and using pithy sentences, he conveys a wealth of meaning (N). The phrase '*kitābullāh bayna aḥḥurikum*' means that the Book of Allāh is manifestly present before you, and is something that can be relied upon (T). By saying this he reminds them that the Qur'ān is available and accessible to them (MB), and its guidance can be attained at any time and place (N). He then describes the Qur'ān as a speaker that does not falter or stutter in its speech ('*nāṭiqun lā ya'yā lisānuhu*'). This means that it is not inarticulate (I), and though it does not literally speak, it is called a speaker because like one who speaks in order to convey and clearly communicate something, the Qur'ān also conveys and clarifies what it communicates (MB). The fact that it does not falter in its speech could also allude to how the passage of time does not render the Qur'ān or its teachings old and outdated; rather, it is ever fresh and relevant (N). Alternatively, it could mean that it never falls short in clearly conveying the laws of Allāh (MB). The Imām then describes it as *a house whose pillars do not collapse*, because the Qur'ān is a protection for those who follow its teachings, just as a house protects its inhabitants from the elements, predators, etc. (M). By saying that its *pillars do not collapse*, the Imām was alluding

to its timelessness, and the fact that its guidance and protection lasts through the ages. In one tradition, Imām al-Ṣādiq was questioned why the Qurʾān remains ever-pertinent and the more it is read and studied, the more one learns from it. He replied, “Allāh did not create it for one time only, nor did he create it for one people only. Rather, it is new in every age and invigorating for all people until the Day of Judgment” (T). Lastly, the Imām says that the Qurʾān is a mighty force whose supporters are never vanquished. Some commentators opine that the Qurʾān is referred to as “*izzun*” because it is a means by which might and strength can be attained, and its *supporters* (‘*aʿwānuhu*’) refer to Allāh, the Prophets, and the angels (MB). As such, the Book of Allāh is considered an impenetrable fortress that protects one from all dangers and harm (Z).

3 In the third section, Imām ‘Alī speaks about the Noble Prophet and briefly describes when and how he was sent to the people. This has already been explained in great detail in the first sermon (sections 17-21), as well as in sermon no. 88. Allāh *sent him after an interval in the sequence of Messengers*, meaning at a time when there had been a period without any divinely chosen Messengers sent to the people, and revelation had been cut off from them (MB). This was *a period of conflicting opinions* among the people. The phrase ‘*tanāzuʿin min al-alsun*’ literally means that tongues would fiercely quarrel, and during the age in which the Messenger of Allāh was sent, there were a lot of disputes regarding matters pertaining to belief and religion, between the idolators and the People of the Book, as well as among the Arabs themselves. The word ‘tongues’ here implies that these disputes were limited to verbal disagreements, and were not physical altercations (Z). The Almighty made the Noble Prophet *follow the earlier Messengers*, as stated in the verse: *Then We sent Our Messengers following in their footsteps* (Q57:27) (I). In other words, the Imām was saying that the Messenger of Allāh continued the mission of the Prophets who preceded him, since the core of the message they all brought was the same. Furthermore, he brought the mission to its most perfect end and thus became the last Prophet and Messenger to mankind (N). This section ends with the Imām’s statement about how the Noble Messenger *fought in the way of Allāh against those who turned back from Him and equated others with Him*. The phrase ‘*al-ʿādilīna bihi*’ means those who ascribed equals or peers to Him (I). Disbelievers at that time were of two types: those who completely rejected God and did not believe in Him, and those who were polytheists and ascribed partners to Allāh. The Prophet strove against both these groups, initially using propagation

ABOUT THIS WORLD

- 4 Verily this world is the limit of what is visible to the [spiritually] blind, he does not see anything beyond it. The possessor of insight sees through it and knows that the [true] abode is beyond it. Thus the seer anticipates departure from it while the blind gazes at it. The seer collects provision from it while the blind collects provision for it.

ALSO: ADMONISHING THE PEOPLE

- 5 Know that there is nothing [in this world] but that its owner [eventually] gets satiated and weary of it, except life, for he sees no comfort in death. And this is just like the wisdom which enlivens the dead heart, gives sight to the blind eye, hearing to the deaf ear, and quenches the thirsty, and in this there is complete sufficiency and safety. The Book of Allāh is that by which you see, speak, and hear. Part of it speaks through other parts, and part of it testifies for other parts. It does not differ [in its statements] about Allāh nor does it mislead its own follower from [the path of] Allāh.

- 6 You have agreed upon rancour among yourselves and herbage has grown on your filth. You are sincere friends to each other in your love of aspirations, yet bear enmity against each other in acquiring wealth. The malevolent one

منها: في الدنيا

٤ وَإِنَّمَا الدُّنْيَا مُتَنَهَى بَصَرِ الْأَعْمَى، لَا يُبْصِرُ مِمَّا وَرَاءَهَا شَيْئًا، وَالْبَصِيرُ يَنْفُذُهَا بَصَرُهُ، وَيَعْلَمُ أَنَّ الدَّارَ وَرَاءَهَا، فَالْبَصِيرُ مِنْهَا شَاخِصٌ وَالْأَعْمَى إِلَيْهَا شَاخِصٌ، وَالْبَصِيرُ مِنْهَا مَتَرُودٌ وَالْأَعْمَى لَهَا مَتَرُودٌ.

منها: في عظة الناس

٥ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّهُ لَيْسَ مِنْ شَيْءٍ إِلَّا وَيَكَادُ صَاحِبُهُ يَشْبَعُ مِنْهُ وَيَمْلَأُهُ إِلَّا الْحَيَاةَ، فَإِنَّهُ لَا يَجِدُ فِي الْمَوْتِ رَاحَةً، وَإِنَّمَا ذَلِكَ بِمَنْزِلَةِ الْحِكْمَةِ الَّتِي هِيَ حَيَاةٌ لِلْقَلْبِ الْمَيِّتِ، وَبَصَرٌ لِلْعَيْنِ الْعَمِيَاءِ، وَسَمْعٌ لِلْأُذُنِ الصَّمَاءِ، وَرِيٌّ لِلظَّمْآنِ، وَفِيهَا الْغِنَى كُلُّهُ وَالسَّلَامَةُ. كِتَابُ اللَّهِ يُبَصِّرُونَ بِهِ، وَتَنْطِقُونَ بِهِ، وَتَسْمَعُونَ بِهِ، وَتَنْطِقُ بَعْضُهُ بِبَعْضٍ، وَيَشْهَدُ بَعْضُهُ عَلَى بَعْضٍ، وَلَا يَخْتَلِفُ فِي اللَّهِ، وَلَا يُخَالِفُ بِصَاحِبِهِ عَنِ اللَّهِ.

٦ قَدْ اصْطَلَحْتُمْ عَلَى الْغِلِّ فِيمَا بَيْنَكُمْ، وَتَبَّتِ الْمَرْغَى عَلَى دِمْنِكُمْ، وَتَصَافَيْتُمْ عَلَى حُبِّ الْأَمْوَالِ، وَتَعَادَيْتُمْ فِي كَسْبِ الْأَمْوَالِ. لَقَدْ

has bewildered you and the deluder
has led you astray. And Allāh is the one
to whom I turn for assistance, for both
myself and for you.

اَسْتَهَامَ بِكُمْ الْحَيْثُ، وَتَاهَ بِكُمْ
الْعُرُورُ، وَاللَّهُ الْمُسْتَعَانُ عَلَى نَفْسِي
وَأَنْفُسِكُمْ.

(*tabligh*) and conveying the message of truth to them. He employed this method for thirteen years, and was able to get many people to accept Islam during that time. However, when he saw that the enemy was using all means at their disposal, including physical torture, to hinder people from accepting the true religion, he was forced to undertake other measures, including fighting them on the battlefield (N).

4 The Imām then talks about this world, likening it to what is seen by the blind, namely darkness and obscurity. He thinks that he perceives it as it truly is, but that is not the case, because what he sees lacks illumination (I). Through this depiction, Amīr al-Mu’minīn aims to make people realize the true nature of this world and detach themselves from its fleeting allurements (MB). *Verily this world is the limit of what is visible to the blind*, meaning those who are spiritually blind, or whose hearts are blind (T). A physically blind individual may believe in Allāh and the Day of Judgment as though he witnesses them, so in reality he is able to see them, even though he cannot see the shining sun. On the other hand, whoever denies the existence of Allāh and the Last Day is blind in comparison, even if his physical eyes have the visual acuity of a telescope. So the person whose only goal is attainment of this world, and he does nothing for the Hereafter, is actually blind to it even if he acknowledges its existence in theory (Z). Some commentators understand the term *blind* (*‘al-‘mā’*) here to mean ignorant (*al-jāhil*), because he is ignorant of the truth and fails to see it (MB). Such an individual *does not see anything beyond* this world. In contrast, the one who truly can see, and possesses insight, looks through it, with his gaze penetrating to see what is beyond it. He thus knows that there is a home, which is the true abode, after it. This means that he is aware of the Hereafter, and of the Second Genesis (Q53:47) (Z). In this way, Amīr al-Mu’minīn compares those who are enthralled by this world with those who seek the truth. The former are like people with very narrow vision, and cannot see beyond the four walls of the prison that is this world, whereas the latter are able to look beyond the veils of the transient world (N). As such, *the seer anticipates departure from it while the blind gazes at it*. When talking about sight, the term

‘*shākhīṣ*’ refers to one who opens his eyes wide and gazes without blinking (R). The dual use of this term here is one of the rhetorical devices wherein the same word is repeated twice to mean two different things (*tajnīs*). So the phrase ‘*minhā shākhīṣ*’ means waiting to depart or leave, whereas ‘*ilayhā shākhīṣ*’ means gazing towards it (i.e. this world) (I). Consequently, the sighted *collects provision from it while the blind collects provision for it*, meaning that the sighted gather provisions of good deeds and piety from this world, while the blind take it to be their final, permanent abode and thus get consumed by its allurements and outward beauty, and work towards attaining its pleasures and fleeting gains (MB).

5 The Imām begins this section by noting there is nothing in this world but that he who possesses it eventually *gets satiated and weary of it, except life*. That is because *he sees no comfort in death*. Though this statement is general, it aims to highlight how the wretched fear and despise death. Indeed, we find that narrations speak of the way close friends of Allāh yearn for death, and desire to meet their Beloved. For instance, it is reported that the Noble Messenger said, “There is no comfort for a believer other than meeting Allāh” (MB). Alternatively, this may be an allusion to the difficulty of dying and the discomfort of death itself, for death is, in and of itself, an uncomfortable reality for people. Thus, while a believer looks forward to what comes after death, he still has to undergo the pangs of death when he dies, and grief when his loved one passes away (M). This is different from the fear of death experienced by those who have done evil in this world and know that punishment awaits them in the next life. Imām al-Sajjād says in one of his supplications, “Make my life a means of increase in every kind of virtue, and my death a relief for me from every evil” (N). The Imām then says, *and this is just like the wisdom which enlivens the dead heart...* Commentators differ regarding what the pronoun *this* is referring to here. Some say it refers to desire to remain alive, because through it one can strive and struggle, for if one lacked this he would have no hope, and without hope there can be no serious action. That is why hope is considered a mercy, as mentioned in the traditions of the Noble Messenger (Z). Indeed, worldly life is something with which people never get satiated, and we can derive a lesson from that, hence it is akin to *wisdom* (‘*ḥikmah*’). Others opine that the pronoun *this* is referring to the statement of the Noble Prophet that the Imām just quoted, or it refers to fear of death (S).

The Imām then lists five qualities of wisdom, the first of which is that it gives life to a dead heart, meaning that it revives the heart and soul that has died as a

result of ignorance (N). Secondly, it *gives sight to the blind eye* that could not see due to some impediment, which is then removed by wisdom allowing the eye to see clearly (MB). Furthermore, it restores *hearing to the deaf ear*, and *quenches the thirsty*. These are all metaphors that portray the removal of ignorance through wisdom, and doing away with obstacles that hinder a person (M). Undoubtedly, one who wishes to manage his affairs with reason and knowledge has to have a sound mind, hearing, and sight (Z). The fifth and last quality of this wisdom is that it provides *complete sufficiency and safety* from the tribulations of this world (T). Subsequently the Imām tells them it is through the Book of Allāh that they see and perceive, speak with reason, and hear the truth. That is because the Qurʾān provides profound knowledge and incontrovertible arguments which can render any disputant speechless. It also attracts the attention of listeners by its unmatched eloquence and wisdom (Z). The close friends of Allāh would always speak in the language of the Qurʾān. One tradition states that Imām al-Bāqir said, “When I speak to you regarding something, ask me where it is mentioned in the Book of Allāh” (T). Lastly, the Imām says that the Qurʾān does not contain any differing or contradictory statements about Allāh, *nor does it mislead its own follower from the path of Allāh*. Each and every word and statement in the Glorious Qurʾān points to a single goal, and that is reaching the Truth (M). Thus, nothing in the Qurʾān would ever take away a person from this path, as long as it is understood correctly and adhered to faithfully (N).

6 Like a skilled physician, Imām ‘Alī addresses some of the spiritual ailments of the people and, considering what is mentioned previously, he implies that with access to the Book of Allāh, it does not suit them to fall prey to such maladies of the heart (N). His statement, *You have agreed upon rancour among yourselves* is an allusion to their adherence to malevolence and rancour (R). The term ‘*al-ghill*’ refers to a kind of latent malice that leads to treachery and dishonesty, and saying that they have agreed upon it means that they have allowed themselves to hold such inner hatred and malice for others (N). In the phrase *herbage has grown on your filth*, the filth (‘*diman*’) refers to jealousy and spite, and the analogy of herbage is used to portray how long one has held these feelings and grudges in the heart, until its roots have grown and sunk down deep. Alternatively, *al-diman* could mean a refuse dump, in which case it is a metaphor for hearts that are filled with pollution, dirt, and filth in the form of evil thoughts and negative emotions towards others (MB). Hence, some commentators interpret this phrase to mean

that outwardly they were bright, but inwardly they had hearts filled with darkness. They came off as ascetic and pious, but within them were feelings of malice, rancour, and jealousy (Z). They were *sincere friends to each other* in their love of worldly aspirations yet bore *enmity against each other* in acquiring wealth, meaning they would work together when they sought the same things and had the same goals. However, when it came to gaining wealth, they would fight one another as each one wanted the wealth for himself only (N). The phrase '*laqad istahāma bikum al-khabīth*' is rendered *the malevolent one has bewildered you* and means that Satan has caused you to move around as though you are confused and perplexed (I), unable to distinguish the path of truth from that of falsehood (N). Likewise, *the deluder* ('*al-gharūr*') refers to Satan, as mentioned in the Qur'ān (Q31:33) (T). Some commentators note that if the term is read as *al-ghurūr*, with a *dhamma*, then it means 'delusion', but reading it as *al-gharūr* is more correct here (N). In conclusion, the Imām says that it is Allāh to whom he turns for assistance, *for both myself and for you*. Some commentators state that the Imām sought Allāh's help for himself in order to continue overpowering *al-naḥs al-ammārah* with his intellect, and he sought Allāh's help for the people that they should get the ability and strength to overpower their base self and vain desires (M).



WHEN CONSULTED BY ‘UMAR IBN AL-KHATTĀB ABOUT MARCHING ON ROME

- 1 Allāh has taken it upon Himself, for the followers of this religion, to strengthen their domain and conceal their hidden weakness. Indeed, He who helped them when they were few and could not prevail, and protected them when they were few and could not defend themselves, is Ever-Living and does not die.
- 2 Verily, when you proceed towards this enemy yourself, coming face to face with them, and adversity befalls you, there will be no place of refuge for the Muslims other than their remotest cities, nor one to whom they could turn to after you. So send a veteran warrior to them [instead], and with him, those who have been tested in battle and are sincere. If Allāh grants you victory, then that is what you like, but if the converse happens, you will be a support for the people and a recourse for the Muslims.
- ١ وَقَدْ تَوَكَّلَ اللَّهُ لِأَهْلِ هَذَا الدِّينِ
بِإِعْزَازِ الْحَوَازِ، وَسَثْرِ الْعَوَازِ،
وَالَّذِي نَصَرَهُمْ وَهُمْ قَلِيلٌ لَا
يَنْتَصِرُونَ، وَمَنْعَهُمْ وَهُمْ قَلِيلٌ لَا
يَمْتَنِعُونَ، حَيٌّ لَا يَمُوتُ.
- ٢ إِنَّكَ مَتَى تَسِرْ إِلَى هَذَا الْعَدُوِّ
بِنَفْسِكَ، فَتَلْقَهُمْ فِتْنَكُ، لَا تَكُنْ
لِلْمُسْلِمِينَ كَانِفَةً دُونَ أَقْصَى
بِلَادِهِمْ، لَيْسَ بَعْدَكَ مَرْجِعٌ
يَرْجِعُونَ إِلَيْهِ، فَابْعَثْ إِلَيْهِمْ
رَجُلًا مُحَرَّبًا، وَاحْفَظْ مَعَهُ أَهْلَ الْبَلَاءِ
وَالنَّصِيحَةِ، فَإِنْ أَظْهَرَ اللَّهُ فَذَلِكَ مَا
تُحِبُّ، وَإِنْ تَكُنِ الْأُخْرَى كُنْتَ
رِذَاءً لِلنَّاسِ وَمَثَابَةً لِّلْمُسْلِمِينَ.

CONTEXT

Some commentators of *Nahj al-Balāghah* say that these words were spoken by the Imām in Madīnah, in the year 15 AH, when the Byzantine Emperor marched towards Muslim lands. Upon learning of this, ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb decided to head out with the army to face them and he sought Amīr al-Mu’minīn’s advice on the matter (N). According to another account, after the Muslims had besieged Bayt al-Maqdis in Palestine, its inhabitants expressed their willingness to sign a peace

treaty with them, on condition that the caliph of the Muslims be the one who personally came to sign it. The commander of the Muslim army, Abū 'Ubaydah, wrote to 'Umar regarding this and the latter sought to leave for Palestine. It was at this point that the Imām spoke to him and gave him advice, telling him not to go, but he refused to listen (Z). Other accounts contain different versions of events, with some saying that 'Umar marched out to fight the Byzantines, and when they realized he had come to the battlefield himself, they got frightened and agreed to sign a peace treaty. In any case, it has been noted that most of these historical reports are narrated on the authority of Sayf, who was a known fabricator, and are hence deemed completely unreliable. Furthermore, there is no evidence, other than the unreliable reports, that these words were spoken by the Imām at the time when 'Umar proceeded to fight the Byzantines. Rather, from what al-Shaykh al-Mufid has mentioned, it is likely that he had said this at the time of the battle of Nahāwand, and al-Sayyid al-Raḍī had only assumed that it was spoken during the conquest of Palestine (T).

COMMENTARY

1 Imām 'Alī tells the second caliph that Allāh has guaranteed the followers of His religion that He will protect their land and guard their honour. Some have suggested that this was a way of strengthening his resolve in the face of a strong, intimidating enemy, so that he should not get overwhelmed by fear of them (N). The verb '*tawakkala*' means that Allāh has taken charge of their affair, like a trustee (*wakīl*) (MB). In another version, the verb '*takaffala*' is used instead, in which case it would mean that Allāh is their guarantor (*kafīl*) (I). The term '*al-ḥawzah*' refers to the land which is in the possession of the Muslims, while '*al-awrah*' here refers to the frontiers from which the enemy penetrates (Z), or any weak points in the borderlands where it is feared that the enemy may invade or attack (T). Some have interpreted the terms more generally to mean the territory of the Muslims and their collective body, and the fault or negative quality that should be kept hidden from the enemy, respectively (MB). The promise mentioned by the Imām here is not something that was restricted to the time of the Noble Messenger; rather, it is true during all ages (N). Some even interpret it as a guarantee of triumph to the *ummah* of the Prophet (Z). To further emphasize the importance of relying on Allāh, the Imām reminded 'Umar of how Allāh helped the Muslims when they

were few and could not have otherwise prevailed, granting them victory and the upper hand over the enemy (M).

2 The Imām then offers his advice to the second caliph, telling him that it would not be prudent for him to leave the capital and personally accompany the army to face the Byzantines. He explains the reasoning behind this, noting that if anything happens to the caliph, it would lead to turmoil and hardship for the Muslims (M). One commentator says that if someone asks: then why did the Noble Prophet personally participate in battles, and why did Amīr al-Mu'minīn also lead the armies personally in the battles of Jamal, Şiffin and Nahrawān? The answer to this would be that the Noble Messenger and Imām 'Alī did not go out to fight foreign armies. The only exception was the expedition to Tabūk, which was against the Byzantines, but in that instance the Prophet left Amīr al-Mu'minīn behind in Madīnah as his representative (T). Imām 'Alī tells 'Umar that if he leads the expedition against the enemy, and after engaging them he is defeated, the Muslim fighters will have no stronghold to give them refuge other than their remotest lands, nor would they have one whom they could turn or resort to after him. By this the Imām meant that if the caliph went to war and was killed in battle, the Muslims will lose their ruler until such a time as another person is given the pledge of allegiance, and in the meanwhile they will have no central authority to refer to (N). The verb '*tunkab*' signifies being visited by adversity, and in this instance it means being defeated and killed (N). The Imām then advises 'Umar to send a veteran warrior to the enemy instead, *and with him, those who have been tested in battle and are sincere*. The phrase '*rajulan miḥraban*' refers to a seasoned fighter and a veteran of battles (I) who knows the art of warfare and has experienced it. Sending such an individual with a group of tested and sincere fighters is wiser and more likely to lead to the desired result. If he did this, and the Muslim army was victorious, that is the goal they all hoped for and sought. But if they failed, the rest of the Muslims would still be safe in their land under the caliph's rule (Z). Using this logical argument, Imām 'Alī responded to 'Umar's request for advice on the matter. Indeed, if the caliph remained safe, even if the Muslim army was defeated, he could still prepare another, stronger army to go and fight the foreign enemy, while at the same time preserving the security of the Muslim populace (N).



ADDRESSING AL-MUGHĪRAH IBN AL-AKHNAS

- 1 O son of the accursed, without posterity,
and of a tree which has neither roots
nor branches. Will you deal with me?!
By Allāh, Allāh will not grant success
to the one whom you support, nor will
the one whom you have raised stand.
Get away from us, may Allāh keep you
far away! Then do your worst, and may
Allāh have no mercy upon you if you
hold back!
- يَا ابْنَ اللَّعِينِ الْأَبْتَرِ، وَالشَّجَرَةِ الَّتِي
لَا أَصْلَ لَهَا وَلَا فَرْعَ، أَأَنْتَ
تَكْفِينِي؟! فَوَ اللَّهِ مَا أَعَزَّ اللَّهُ مَنْ أَنْتَ
نَاصِرُهُ، وَلَا قَامَ مَنْ أَنْتَ مُنْهَضُهُ؛
اخْرُجْ عَنَّا أَبْعَدَ اللَّهُ نَوَاك! ثُمَّ ائْبُلْغْ
جُهِدَكَ، فَلَا أَبْقَى اللَّهُ عَلَيْكَ إِنْ
أَبْقَيْتَ!

CONTEXT

From the author's preamble to this oration mentioned in *Nahj al-Balāghah*, we learn that some words were exchanged between 'Uthmān ibn 'Affān and Amīr al-Mu'minīn when al-Mughīrah ibn al-Akhnas said to 'Uthmān, "I will deal with him for you." Whereupon Imām 'Alī said this to al-Mughīrah. Other sources tell us that the discussion pertained to the caliph's unhappiness with the Imām due to his accompanying Abū Dharr to the outskirts of the city as he was leaving, having been exiled by 'Uthmān. The latter had ordered that nobody should accompany Abū Dharr to bid him farewell, but Imām 'Alī nevertheless escorted him. As he was returning someone told the Imām that the caliph is angry with you for having gone with Abū Dharr, and that is when the Imām went to him. When asked why he disobeyed the order, he replied, "Do you think that everything you command us is to be obeyed, even when it goes against the obedience of Allāh and the truth? Absolutely not!" Other reports tell us that this happened when 'Uthmān openly spoke against Abū Dharr after he was brought to him from Syria, and Amīr al-Mu'minīn defended Abū Dharr (T). We know that the Imām spoke these words in Madīnah, and based on the foregoing version of events, it was in the year 30 AH.

Others opine that the discussion between ‘Uthmān and Imām ‘Alī was regarding the latter’s misappropriation of public funds, and his bestowing large sums to his family and close supporters (Z). One commentator says that the Imām did not say this in the presence of ‘Uthmān; rather, it was when, seeing that ‘Uthmān had turned a deaf ear to his advice and admonition, Imām ‘Alī decided to keep aloof from him altogether. At that time, whenever any Companion of the Prophet went to ‘Uthmān, he would complain about Imām ‘Alī to him, so Zayd ibn Thābit al-Anṣārī offered to speak to the Imām on his behalf and ask him to visit the caliph. ‘Uthmān liked the idea so Zayd went to the Imām and al-Mughīrah ibn al-Akhnas was with him, along with some other people. First Zayd spoke, informing the Imām that ‘Uthmān was complaining that he had severed ties with him and kept aloof from him. Then the Imām spoke, explaining that he only did that when he saw ‘Uthmān rejecting his advice and admonition. It was then that al-Mughīrah interjected and spoke harshly to Amīr al-Mu’minīn and in response to him, the Imām uttered the words of this oration (I). If this second version of events was the context of this speech, then it would have been around the year 35 AH.

COMMENTARY

1 Imām ‘Alī refers to al-Mughīrah as *son of the accursed* because his father al-Akhnas was one of the leaders of the hypocrites, and his family only ostensibly became Muslims after the conquest of Makkah. His brother Abū al-Ḥakam ibn al-Akhnas fought against the Muslims in the Battle of Uḥud and Imām ‘Alī killed him in that battle. That is why al-Mughīrah held a grudge against the Imām. He referred to the man as the son of one without posterity (*‘al-abtar*) because all his progeny were misguided, evil people, so it was as though he never had any descendants; rather, one without any progeny was better than him (Z). Calling him one *of a tree which has neither roots nor branches* figuratively means that he had no noble lineage or honourable family tree and was thus lowborn (M). Some commentators suggest that this was because al-Mughīrah was from Thaḳīf, and the lineages of Thaḳīf are suspect, as the identity of their forefathers is not known for certain. It has even been claimed that they are the descendants of Thamūd (T). In one tradition it is reported that the tribe of Thaḳīf were cursed by the Messenger of Allāh, or that he said, “Were it not for ‘Urwah ibn Maṣ‘ūd, I would have cursed

Thaqīf" (Z). Alternatively, not having roots and branches connotes the negation of positive attributes, for a tree that lacks strong roots and fructive branches is of no use to anyone (MB). Subsequently, the Imām asks a negative rhetorical question: *Will you deal with me*, signifying his outrage that a man like al-Mughīrah would dare to show such audacity as to threaten him. The question carries within it an implication of disdain and disparagement (M). Some versions have the term '*takuffanī*' instead of '*takfīnī*', in which case it would mean *will you prevent [or restrain] me* (MB). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then swears that *Allāh will not grant success to the one whom you support*, meaning 'Uthmān (T). The phrase '*mā a'azzallāh man anta nāṣiruhu*' literally means that Allāh will not render mighty or will not honour the one whom you support. Hence, some have said that it means whoever is supported by the likes of al-Mughīrah ibn al-Akhnas is abased (*dhalīl*), even it is the caliph himself (Z).

The phrase '*anta munhiḍuhu*' means one whom you have raised or made stand, and *nāhiḍah* refers to the paternal relatives who get angered on one's behalf when he is wronged (T). The Imām then tells al-Mughīrah to get out, saying, *may Allāh keep you far away!* The phrase '*ab'adallāhu nawāka*' means may Allāh make your destination be far off (MB), and it is used to wish one to remain distant (R). Another version reads '*ab'adallāhu naw'aka*' which alludes to the setting of specific stars that are said to have an effect on rain. Thus the phrase would literally mean 'may Allāh keep away your rain' (I). However, the first version seems more correct here given the context. The Imām then challenges him to do his worst ('*ablugh juhdak*'), meaning give it your all and try your best to do whatever harm you can to me. Some commentators opine that it should be read with a *fathah* as '*jahdak*' since *al-juhd* with *dhamma* refers to physical strength while *al-jahd* with *fathah* refers to speech. So when one says *ajhid jahdaka*, it means speak your most hurtful speech as you have intended (T). Finally, to lay even more emphasis, the Imām tells al-Mughīrah, after daring him to do his worst, *may Allāh have no mercy upon you if you hold back*, meaning may the Almighty remove His mercy upon you if you show any compassion or hold back from the worst harm you could inflict upon me (MB). By saying this, Amīr al-Mu'minīn was alluding to the fact that al-Mughīrah was too insignificant and weak to threaten a person like the Imām, and even if he expended all his efforts, he would not be able to any real harm to the Imām (N).



ON THE MATTER OF PLEDGING ALLEGIANCE

- 1 Your pledging allegiance to me was not on impulse, and my position is not the same as yours. I seek you for the sake of Allāh while you seek me for your own sake. O people! Assist me to reform you. By Allāh, I will take the right of the oppressed from his oppressor and will pull the oppressor by the nose ring until I bring him to the waterhole of truth, even though he may be unwilling.
- لَمْ تَكُنْ بَيَعْتُمْ إِيَّايَ فَلْتَهُ، وَلَيْسَ
أَمْرِي وَأَمْرُكُمْ وَاحِدًا، إِنِّي أُرِيدُكُمْ
لِلَّهِ، وَأَنْتُمْ تُرِيدُونَنِي لِأَنْفُسِكُمْ. أَتَيْهَا
النَّاسُ، أَعِينُونِي عَلَى أَنْفُسِكُمْ، وَإِنَّمِ
اللَّهُ لَأَنْصِفَنَّ الْمَظْلُومَ مِنْ ظَالِمِهِ،
وَلَأَقْوَدَنَّ الظَّالِمَ بِخِزَامَتِهِ حَتَّى
أُورِدَهُ مِنْهُلِ الْحَقِّ وَإِنْ كَانَ
كَارِهًا.

CONTEXT

According to what has been reported by al-Shaykh al-Mufid in his *al-Irshād*, this was part of the oration given by Amīr al-Mu'minīn in Madīnah when 'Abdullāh ibn 'Umar, Sa'd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ, Muḥammad ibn Maslamah, Ḥassān ibn Thābit, and Usāmah ibn Zayd refused to pledge allegiance to him after his accession to the caliphate in the year 35 AH. Al-Mufid quotes the entire oration, and in the beginning, Imām 'Alī explains that people have a choice as long as they have not pledged allegiance, but once they pledge allegiance then they have no choice and must submit to their ruler. He then noted that the oath of allegiance was to be given by all the Muslims, so whoever turns away from it has actually turned away from the religion, and has opted to follow a path different from that of the Muslims. Then he explains that the pledge given to him was not based on spontaneous impulse (T). Indeed, the sources are clear that Imām 'Alī had initially declined to accept the caliphate when the people went to him. It was only after they compelled him to accept it that he did (Z). Therefore, it was something that was done with deliberation and not on the spur of the moment.

COMMENTARY

1 The term '*faltah*' refers to something spontaneous, sudden, and unexpected. It is a matter that transpires without consideration or planning. By saying that the oath of allegiance given to him as caliph of the Muslims was not something done on impulse, the Imām was indirectly alluding to how Abū Bakr became caliph, since 'Umar had famously said, "The *bay'ah* given to Abū Bakr was something done on impulse (*faltah*), but Allāh protected us from its evil" (I). Commentators note how this statement has been the object of much discussion and many treatises have been written regarding it over the ages, with some scholars of the Ahl al-Sunnah trying to give 'Umar's words a positive meaning, despite its apparently negative connotation (Z). The Imām's statement, *my position is not the same as yours* means that the goal and intention of the Imām in accepting the caliphate was different from their goal and intention in taking him to be their caliph (MB). The implication was that unlike the materialistic, worldly rulers who seek the obedience and loyalty of their subjects in order to gain prestige thereby and work towards the fulfilment of their own personal ambitions and desires, the Imām sought them *for the sake of Allāh*. In other words, the Imām wanted to establish the laws ordained by Allāh among them, thereby earning His pleasure. In contrast, the people sought the Imām for their own benefit (N).

The phrase '*a'īnūnī 'alā anfusikum*' literally means 'assist me, [even if it be] against yourselves,' and is a call to adhere to justice and shun base desires (I). The connotation is that the Imām wanted them to assist him to make them better individuals, as he trained them to follow the path of truth (Z). And this could only be realized if they obeyed his commands and kept away from what he forbade, thereby complying with his instructions (MB). Finally, Imām 'Alī promises that he will bring justice to the oppressed, and drag *the oppressor by the nose ring until he brings him to the waterhole of truth, even though he may be unwilling*. Some commentators say that the waterhole is a metaphor for truth because it alleviates the pain of the oppressor just as water alleviates the thirst of one who is parched (M). Others say that the analogy is that of an unruly camel which refuses even to drink water, so its owner forces it towards the waterhole so that it would drink. In this way, the Imām not only sought to take the rights of the oppressed from their oppressors, but also to benefit the latter by reforming them and restoring order and justice. That is because when injustice becomes pervasive in any society,

nobody remains immune from its negative consequences (N). His mentioning *the nose ring* implies that he will abase and humiliate the oppressors and will drag them like one who pulls his stubborn camel, until he has taken back from him the rights of those he has oppressed, though he may be averse (MB). It is noteworthy that these words were addressed to the majority of the Imām's followers, but as for the elite among them, they had the same goals as he did (I).



ABOUT TALHAH AND AL-ZUBAYR

1 By Allāh, they could not find anything I did wrong, nor did they do justice between me and themselves. Now they are demanding a right which they gave up and [revenge for] blood which they spilled themselves. So if I participated in it with them, then they too have a share in it, but if they committed it without me, the petition should only be made against them. Verily, the first act of justice for them should be to pass judgment against themselves. Verily my insight is with me; neither have I confused matters [for anyone] nor have I been confounded by them. They are surely a rebellious group that is made up of the darkly disloyal, the poisonously dangerous, and the highly dubious. Yet verily the matter is clear, and falsehood has been removed from its foundation and its tongue has been severed from its mischief. By Allāh, I will fill for them a cistern from which I alone will draw water. They will neither turn from it quenched nor will they drink from any source after it!

۱ وَاللّٰهِ مَا أَنْكَرُوا عَلَيَّ مُنْكَرًا، وَلَا جَعَلُوا بَيْنِي وَبَيْنَهُمْ نَصْفًا، وَإِنَّهُمْ لَيَطْلُبُونَ حَقًّا هُمْ تَرَكُوهُ، وَدَمًا هُمْ سَفَكُوهُ، فَإِنْ كُنْتُ شَرِيكُهُمْ فِيهِ فَإِنَّ لَهُمْ نَصِيبَهُمْ مِنْهُ، وَإِنْ كَانُوا وَلَوْهُ دُونِي فَمَا الظَّالِمَةُ إِلَّا قَبْلَهُمْ، وَإِنْ أَوَّلَ عَذْلِهِمْ لِلْحَكَمِ عَلَى أَنْفُسِهِمْ. إِنَّ مَعِيَ لَبَصِيرَتِي، مَا لَبَسْتُ وَلَا لُبِسَ عَلَيَّ، وَإِنَّهَا لَلْفَيْقَةُ الْبَاغِيَّةُ، فِيهَا الْحَمَاءُ وَالْحُمَمَةُ وَالشُّبُهَةُ الْمُغْدِرَةُ، وَإِنَّ الْأَمْرَ لَوَاضِحٌ، وَقَدْ رَاحَ الْبَاطِلُ عَنْ نَصَابِهِ، وَانْقَطَعَ لِسَانُهُ عَنْ شَغْبِهِ. وَإِنَّمَا اللَّهُ لَأَقْرَطَنَّ لَهُمْ حَوْضًا أَنَا مَاتِحُهُ، لَا يَصُدُّرُونَ عَنْهُ بِرِيٍّ، وَلَا يَغْبُونَ بَعْدَهُ فِي حِسِّي!

CONTEXT

This is part of a longer sermon given by Imām ‘Alī regarding Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr. The goal of the Imām was reproof, and he rebuked these two individuals

as well as the others who joined them in rebellion against him (MB). According to al-Shaykh al-Mufīd, Amīr al-Mu'minīn gave this sermon at Dhū Qār before leaving to fight in the Battle of Jamal in 36 AH. It has been mentioned in a number of other early sources. Ibn 'Abd al-Barr quotes it in his *al-Istī'āb* when discussing the life of Ṭalḥah, and Ibn Athīr mentions it in his *Usd al-Ghābah*. Al-Mufīd narrates it from al-Wāqidi in his *al-Jamal*, whereas the version cited by Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd was narrated from Abū Mikhnaf (N). Given that the Battle of Jamal was fought under the pretext of avenging the blood of 'Uthmān ibn 'Affān, and the blame for his killing was being levelled at the Imām, many commentators mention how it was actually al-Zubayr, Ṭalḥah, and even 'Ā'ishah (the instigators of the rebellion that resulted in the battle), who were behind the assassination of the third caliph (Z). This fact is also alluded to by Amīr al-Mu'minīn in this oration, and he disavows any assertion that he played a role in the killing of 'Uthmān, as the rebels had falsely claimed. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* mentions this as part of a long sermon that the Imām gave when he first received word that Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr had broken their pledge of allegiance to him and reneged on their oaths (4:370).

COMMENTARY

1 Regarding the three individuals who were instigating rebellion against the Imām, he says *they could not find anything I did wrong, nor did they do justice between me and themselves*. By this he meant that the false allegations they made against him regarding 'Uthmān's assassination and their blaming him for the equal distribution of public funds are not actually wrongs that he could be held liable for; rather, they only stem from jealousy against him and desire to be granted a privileged position among the people (MB). The term '*niṣṣan*' means justice (*inṣāf*) and fairness (I). He further states that *they are demanding a right which they gave up and [revenge for] blood which they spilled themselves*, meaning that they are calling for a right by coming out against the Imām through an uprising in Baṣrah, while they were the ones who abandoned that very same right in Madīnah (I). And it is said that by '*ḥaqqan*' he was referring to assisting and supporting 'Uthmān; however, it may also refer to the right of retribution (*qiṣās*) which they had abandoned by not doing anything to prevent his killers (MB). In fact, history attests to how it was Imām 'Alī who had many times defended 'Uthmān and tried

to assist him out of his predicament by advising him, while these other individuals had left him to his fate (Z). Moreover, they were the ones who were blameworthy for spilling his blood, since they were most vocal in provoking the people against him. Details of this have already been mentioned in sermon no. 22 and the commentary thereof. ‘Uthmān is even reported to have regretted granting so many favours to Ṭalḥah when he saw how the latter was inciting people against him. Al-Zubayr also openly called the people to kill ‘Uthmān, saying that he had brought about innovations in the religion (MB).

Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī presents a rational argument against them, saying that if he had been their partner in this affair, they would still have their share of culpability, but if they undertook it on their own (which they did), then *the petition should only be made against them*, and it is they who should be the targets of vengeance. The term ‘*al-ṭalibah*’ refers to that which is sought or demanded (I), and here it means vengeance for ‘Uthmān. Indeed, not only was the Imām not complicit in his assassination, he actually tried to prevent it and at one point even sent his sons al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn to defend him (N). In the hypothetical scenario that the Imām had participated in some way or another in ‘Uthmān’s killing, they would still be in the wrong to lay blame on him since they were active partners in the same action, and hence have no moral standing to place blame on anyone (Z). Rather, if they were truly after justice, *the first act of justice for them should be to pass judgment against themselves*, since they had claimed that was the goal of their uprising. They were culpable for breaking their allegiance to the Imām as well as participating in ‘Uthmān’s killing, so they were doubly blameworthy because they had also acted against the present caliph by breaking their oaths and rebelling, while having participated in the killing of the former caliph themselves (MB).

Imām ‘Alī subsequently states that he has *his insight* and his wits about him, so he is neither confounded nor has he confused anyone. A similar statement was made by the Imām in sermon no. 10 and has been discussed in its commentary. Hence, he was sure that those who had risen up against him were *a rebellious group that is made up of the darkly disloyal, the poisonously dangerous, and the highly dubious*. Some commentators say that the definite article ‘*al*’ in ‘*al-fi’ah al-bāghiyah*’ indicates that it refers to the group that the Noble Prophet had informed the Imām about (R), when he told him that one of his wives would lead a rebellious group against him in Iraq (N). The term ‘*al-ḥam’u*’ refers to a dark slime that gets

further corrupted by moisture and wetness, and it also figuratively refers to a foolish and ignorant individual (I). In this instance it connotes deception and disloyalty (M). The more well-known term '*al-ḥama*', which is also mentioned in the Qur'ān (Q15:26), refers to dark mud. Another variant has the term '*ḥaman*', which refers to a male relative, and in this instance it is said to refer to al-Zubayr, who was the Prophet's paternal cousin (Z). The second term, '*al-ḥummah*', means venom or poison, most commonly of a scorpion, and it connotes the harm, corruption, and misguidance of this rebellious group (I). Alternatively, the two terms ('*al-ḥam'u wal-ḥummah*') figuratively allude to the malice and rancour in the hearts of these rebels (MB).

'*Al-shubhah al-mughdifah*' literally means hidden dubiousness, and the verb *tughdifu* is used for a woman who hides her face with a mask (I). The rebels were suspicious and dubious because of their hypocrisy in seeking vengeance for 'Uthmān (Z). Some commentators note that this meaning would apply if the term was read '*al-mughdafah*' with a *fathah*, but if read as '*al-mughdifah*' with *kasrah*, it means dark doubts and denotes that which leads to falling into the darkness of ignorance until one cannot find his way and perishes (MB). However, the Imām asserts that *the matter is clear*, by which he means that it is clear and evident for anyone with intellect that their uprising, after having pledged allegiance to him, was based on deceit and founded on rancour and jealousy, and on worldly goals and aspirations. The falsehood they brought had no basis as it had been *removed from its foundation* (MB). Furthermore, *its tongue has been severed from its mischief* and curbed from inciting evil. The term '*al-shaghb*' means provocation and incitement of evil and corruption (I). Some understand this statement to mean that by killing the instigators of the Battle of Jamal, the spread of their evil and mischief would be forestalled (Z). Others take it to mean that after the matter was made clear, there remained no room for falsehood to base its claims and its tongue was rendered mute (MB).

Finally, the Imām threatens the rebels in the sternest terms. His statement: *I will fill for them a cistern from which I alone will draw water...* has been explained in the commentary of sermon no. 10. Unlike other pools from which the thirsty emerge having quenched their thirst, those who come to fight the Imām will not return from the battlefield alive (MB). As such, the 'pool' or *cistern* ('*ḥawḍ*') here metaphorically represents death (Z). The term '*ḥisyin*' refers to water that is

ON THE MATTER OF PLEDGING

ALLEGIANCE

ومنه: في أمر البيعة

2 You advanced towards me like she-camels leaping towards their new born offspring, saying: "[We pledge to you] allegiance! Allegiance!" I closed my hand but you forced it open, I drew back my hand from you but you pulled it out.

٢ فَأَقْبَلْتُمْ إِلَيَّ إِقْبَالَ الْعُودِ
الْمَطَايِلِ عَلَى أَوْلَادِهِنَّ،
تَقُولُونَ: الْبَيْعَةُ الْبَيْعَةُ! فَبَضْتُ
كَفِّي فَبَسَطْتُمُوهَا، وَنَارَعْتُكُمْ
يَدِي فَجَادَبْتُمُوهَا.

3 O Allāh! These two individuals have cut me off and done injustice to me. They have broken their allegiance to me and incited people against me. So unravel their pact and do not make firm what they have contrived. Show them the evil of what they hope for and work towards. I had asked them to return [to their pledge] before the battle, and I waited for them before the encounter, but they disregarded the kindness and rejected [the course of] safety.

٣ اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّهُمَا قَطَعَانِي وَظَلَمَانِي،
وَنَكَثَا بَيْعَتِي، وَأَلْبَا النَّاسَ عَلَيَّ؛
فَاخْلُلْ مَا عَقَدَا، وَلَا تُحْكَمْ
لَهُمَا مَا أَبْرَمَا، وَأَرِهِمَا الْمَسَاءَةَ
فِيمَا أَمَلَا وَعَمِلَا، وَلَقَدْ
اسْتَبْتُهُمَا قَبْلَ الْقِتَالِ،
وَاسْتَأْنَيْتُ بِهِمَا أَمَامَ الْوَقَاعِ،
فَعَمَطَا النُّعْمَةَ، وَرَدَّا الْعَافِيَةَ.

hidden under sand, which is then dug up and the water is then removed therefrom (I). It signifies fresh water (Z), that is cool to drink (MB).

2 Here, the Imām describes the fervour and enthusiasm with which the people had given him their pledge of allegiance, comparing it to the way she-camels snuggle their newborn offspring. And in sermon no. 53, he described them as rushing upon him the way thirsty camels *spring upon each other upon reaching the water hole*. ‘*Al-ūdh al-maṭāfil*’ refer to female camels that have just given birth to their calves (T). The repetition of the term ‘*al-bay‘ah*’ (allegiance) twice is understood by some commentators to mean: ‘take our pledge of allegiance for the present’ and ‘take our pledge of allegiance for the future’ (R). Alternatively, the repetition depicts the intensity of their desire and yearning to make him their

caliph (MB). The Imām reminds them that he was not keen to accept the post, saying that he closed his hand and shut his palm, but they forced it open. He drew away his hand, snatching it back from them, but they pulled it towards themselves in order to pledge their allegiance to him as the caliph of the Muslims. This describes how insistent the people were that they wanted the Imām as their leader (N). The implication, therefore, is that they voluntarily, and even enthusiastically, gave their oaths of allegiance to the Imām, and none of them were compelled to do so (MB).

3 In this last section of the oration, Imām ‘Alī complains to Allāh about Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr in particular, saying, *these two individuals have cut me off and done injustice to me. They have broken their allegiance to me and incited people against me.* The verb ‘*qaṭa’ānī*’ means that the two of them have severed ties with him, despite being related to him by kinship. Both were from the same tribe of Quraysh, and al-Zubayr was even the Imām’s cousin (MB). The phrase ‘*allabā al-nās ‘alayya*’ means that the two of them had incited the people and provoked them to rise up against the Imām (I). Amīr al-Mu’minīn subsequently asks the Almighty to *unravel their pact and do not make firm what they have contrived*, thereby praying that all their seditious and treacherous plans be brought to naught (Z). The phrase ‘*fahlul mā ‘aqadā*’ literally means undo the knots they have tied, and here it connotes the negative intentions they held within themselves which they sought to act upon. And that which they *contrived* (‘*abramā*’) was rebellion and fighting against the Imām (MB). He asked Allāh to show Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr *the evil of what they hope for and work towards*. One commentator opines that by this he meant that they should taste the ill consequences of their actions in this world (I). The phrase ‘*wa arihimā al-masā’ata fīmā ammalā wa ‘amilā*’ has been interpreted by some to mean show them failure in what they seek, by causing the opposite of what they hope for to transpire (M). Finally, the Imām states that he had asked both of them to return to their pledge before beginning the battle, and even gave them time to reconsider what they were undertaking, but they rejected his kindness and scorned his offer of safe-conduct. The verb ‘*istathabtuhumā*’ means he sought from them adherence to their pledge of allegiance to him (R), or asked them to return to their pledge (Z). Another version reads ‘*istatabtuhumā*’, meaning he wanted them to repent to Allāh for the sin of breaking their oaths of allegiance (I). The verb ‘*istānaytu*’ means that he was patient with them and gave them time to reconsider their stance (R). In response, they scorned his kindness (‘*ghamaṭā al-*

ni'mah'), and turned away all his messengers, insisting on battle (T). They thereby rejected the course of safety (*'raddā al-āfiyah'*), which lay in unity of the Muslims and working together for the betterment of the community (Z). As a consequence, they lost their safety both in their worldly life, as well as in their religion and Hereafter (MB).



HINTING AT FUTURE EVENTS

- 1 He will direct desires towards guidance [at a time] when people have turned guidance towards desires, and he will turn opinions towards the Qurʾān [at a time] when people will have turned the Qurʾān towards [their] opinions.

١ يَعْطِفُ الْهَوَىٰ عَلَى الْهُدَىٰ إِذَا
عَظُمُوا الْهُدَىٰ عَلَى الْهَوَىٰ،
وَيَعْطِفُ الرَّأْيَ عَلَى الْقُرْآنِ إِذَا
عَظُمُوا الْقُرْآنَ عَلَى الرَّأْيِ.

ALSO PART OF THE SAME SERMON

- 2 [The situation will worsen] until war rages among you, showing its fangs, with udders full of milk that is sweet to suckle but with a sour aftertaste. Beware, tomorrow – and the morrow brings with it what you know not – a ruler who is not from them shall take all their governors to task for their misdeeds, and the earth will pour forth its deeply buried treasures and surrender its keys to him. He will show you the course of true justice and will revive the Book and the Sunnah that will have become lifeless [among the people].

ومنها
٢ حَتَّى تَقُومَ الْحَرْبُ بِكُمْ عَلَى سَاقٍ،
بَادِيًا تَوَاجِدُهَا، مَمْلُوءَةً أَخْلَافُهَا،
حُلُورًا رِضَاعُهَا، عَلَقَمًا عَاقِبَتُهَا. أَلَا
وَفِي غَدٍ - وَسَيَاتِي غَدٍ بِمَا لَا
تَعْرِفُونَ - يَأْخُذُ الْوَالِي مِنْ غَيْرِهَا
عُمَّالَهَا عَلَى مَسَاوِي أَعْمَالِهَا،
وَتُخْرِجُ لَهُ الْأَرْضُ أَفَالِيدَ كِبِدِهَا،
وَتُلْقِي إِلَيْهِ سِلْمًا مَقَالِيدَهَا، فَيُرِيكُمْ
كَيْفَ عَدْلُ السَّيْرَةِ، وَيُحْيِي مَيِّتَ
الْكِتَابِ وَالسُّنَّةِ.

CONTEXT

Though the title states that this sermon is about the great and tumultuous events of the future (*'al-malāḥim'*), commentators are mostly in agreement that the first part thereof is about the advent of the Qā'im, who would rise up during End Times, according to what is mentioned in numerous traditions (M). Al-Āmidī has quoted parts of this oration in his *Ghurar al-Ḥikam*, and since some

commentators like Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd have categorically stated that the initial section of this oration refers to the last Imām, it can be deduced that they had access to another source for this sermon wherein further details were mentioned (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places it within a lengthy sermon titled ‘al-Bayān’, in which Amīr al-Mu’minīn spoke of many future events, and he gave this sermon after the Battle of Nahrawān, in the year 38 AH (3:602). From a narration mentioned by al-Ṭabarsī in his *al-Ihtijāj*, which is similar in wording to the present oration, the Imām quotes the Noble Messenger telling him about the future, and it is said that he spoke these words a few days after the Conquest of Baṣrah, meaning the Battle of Jamal, in 36 AH (1:195-6).

COMMENTARY

1 The future occurrences that Imām ‘Alī talks about in this oration pertains, in the view of most commentators, to the advent of al-Imām al-Mahdī. By saying that he will bend whims and desires to conform to guidance, at a time when most people will have bent guidance to conform to their whims and desires, the Imām is referring to how the awaited Imām will return religion to its proper position and free the people from the fetters of false beliefs (M). He will thus bring back the lost souls that have strayed from the right path and fallen into the dark pit of their endless worldly desires back to the correct way and the straight path (MB). Some non-Shi‘ī commentators opine that the reference here is to an Imām who will be born in the future (I), however, from the statements of Imām ‘Alī to his companion Kumayl, it is clear that Allāh never leaves this world without a proof (*ḥujjah*). Therefore, the reference here is to the living, awaited Imām, al-Mahdī al-Muntaẓar (T). The fact that he will come at a time when *people have turned guidance towards desires* shows that it will be in an age where injustice and iniquity will be pervasive and the teachings of religion will be distorted. He will then bring it back to its rightful place and restore its lofty teachings and re-establish them (MB). As for his turning *opinions towards the Qur’ān* at a time when *people will have turned the Qur’ān towards their opinions*, it means that he will reject any opinion or theory that goes against the Qur’ān. He will bring people back to that which is in complete conformity with the Book of Allāh at a time when they will have been interpreting it based on their own views, forcing it to fit their preconceived notions and ideas (M). One commentator suggests that the first statement regarding directing the

whims and desires aright refers to rational guidance, whereas the second statement about turning opinions and views towards the Qur'ān refers to scriptural guidance (N).

2 Some other End Times events are discussed in this section of the sermon. The phrase '*taqūmu al-ḥarbu bikum 'alā sāqin*' means that war will become fierce, raging among you, since standing upon shanks (*al-qiyām 'alā sāqin*) is a metaphor for severity and seriousness (T). Though the term '*al-nawājidh*' literally refers to the molars, and showing one's molars usually depicts laughing or smiling widely until even the inner teeth become visible, our translation for the term here is *fangs*, as it fits better with the theme of raging war and bloodshed. Alternatively, it could be rendered as *showing its innermost teeth* as a figurative expression denoting how warfare will reach the zenith of its ferocity (I). Some say that the expression is actually an analogy depicting the way a lion bares its teeth when it is angry or hunting prey (MB). Subsequently, the Imām uses another analogy to describe the intensity of the bloodshed and its different phases, comparing it to the camel that provides milk, with its udders full and flowing. The milk is sweet to suckle, but has a sour aftertaste. In the same way, those who will rush to war with the hope of quick victory will face terrible and destructive consequences (N). Others interpret the analogy of full udders to mean that all the equipment of warfare will be readily available for use (M). The word '*alqaman*' refers to an intensely bitter colocynth, but it also has a general meaning of anything bitter (T). Imām 'Alī then talks about the rise of a future leader, saying that the morrow will bring with it what people do not know. The phrase '*sayā'ti ghadun bimā lā ta'rifūn*' contains within it the dual implication that what will transpire in the future is very important and great, while also highlighting the special merit of the Imām who has knowledge that people are ignorant of (M). He then proceeds to give them a glimpse of the future he was alluding to, and says that a *ruler who is not from them* will gain authority and he will *take all their governors to task for their misdeeds*. The phrase '*al-wālī min ghayrihā*' means a ruler who is not from the same clans as those who were ruling at that future time (R). One commentator suggests that the phrase could mean a ruler who is not part of the warfare, since he deems the pronoun '*hā*' in '*ghayrihā*' as referring back to the war that will be prevalent at that time (Z), but this interpretation seems weak. In any case, commentators agree that the person Imām 'Alī is talking about is the Mahdī, and he is the one who will establish justice and punish those rulers and governors for their misdeeds. Indeed, there are

numerous reports in the works of all the Muslims which clearly say that when the Mahdī comes, he will fill the world with justice and get rid of all injustice and oppression (Z).

The fact that *the earth will pour forth its deeply buried treasures and surrender its keys to him* means that during the reign of the Mahdī, valuable treasures within the earth will be easily discoverable and attainable, and at the same time he will have unfettered access to those treasures as his rule will be all-encompassing (N). The phrase '*afālīdha kabidihā*' literally means pieces of its liver, which is a metaphor for the treasures buried within the earth (MB). In this regard, a tradition from Imām al-Bāqir states that the Mahdī will have all the wealth of this world, from what is within it and what is upon it, gathered unto himself. He will then tell the people to come and take whatever they want therefrom, saying, "Come, here is that for which you cut off ties with your near relatives, and spilt blood unlawfully, and undertook what was forbidden by the Almighty..." (T). Some interpret surrendering of the keys by the earth to him as its bestowing its hidden bounties and making available its hitherto concealed treasures to the Imām (Z). The Imām then says that the awaited Qā'im will show the people *the course of true justice and will revive the Book and the Sunnah that will have become lifeless* among them. This means that he will practically display to the people what it means to be just, and will revive and invigorate the Qur'ān and the Prophetic Sunnah at a time when people will have abandoned them both (MB). Indeed, traditions tell us that he will behave as the Noble Messenger behaved, and will judge as he judged (T).

3 In this last section, Imām 'Alī mentions an individual who will come in the future, raise *a cry in Shām* and lead *his banners to the outskirts of Kūfah*. There is some discussion about the identity of this individual, with more than one commentator suggesting that it refers to the Umayyad ruler 'Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān (d. 86 AH), especially since a similar statement is found in sermon no. 100 and has been shown to refer to 'Abd al-Malik (T). However, other commentators say that the Imām was referring to one of the antagonists of the End Times, namely the Sufyānī (R). The phrase '*fa 'aṭafa 'alayhā*' is rendered *he turns aggressively towards it*, since the verb '*aṭafa*' denotes both inclination and assault, and also because the Imām compares it to the way an ill-tempered she-camel nips and snaps. The analogy of the mordacious camel ('*ḍarūs*'), given to biting, represents the oppression of this individual and his tyranny (Z). The picture is made even clearer when the Imām says that this person will cover the ground *with decapitated*

PART OF THE SAME SERMON

منها

3 It is as though I can see him now, having raised a cry in Shām and led his banners to the outskirts of Kūfah. He turns aggressively towards it like a mordacious she-camel and covers the ground with [decapitated] heads. His mouth is wide open and his footsteps are heavy on the ground. His reach shall be far and his onslaught severe. By Allāh, he will surely cause you to be scattered in the corners of the earth until none remain among you but a few, like kohl in the eye. You will continue in this way until the Arabs return to their senses. So adhere to the established precedents, the clear signs, and the [teachings of the] early period upon which rests the legacy of Prophethood. And know that Satan makes his ways easy so that you may follow on his heels.

۳ كَأَنِّي بِهِ قَدْ نَعَقَ بِالشَّامِ، وَفَحَصَ
بِرَايَاتِهِ فِي ضَوَاحِي كُوفَانَ، فَعَطَفَ
عَلَيْهَا عَطَفَ الضَّرْوَسِ، وَفَرَشَ
الْأَرْضَ بِالرُّءُوسِ، قَدْ فَعَّرَتْ
فَاغْرُثُهُ، وَتَقَلَّتْ فِي الْأَرْضِ وَطْأَتُهُ،
بَعِيدَ الْجَوْلَةِ عَظِيمَ الصَّوْلَةِ. وَاللَّهِ
لَيَسْـَـرِّدَنَّكُمْ فِي أَطْرَافِ الْأَرْضِ
حَتَّى لَا يَبْقَى مِنْكُمْ إِلَّا قَلِيلٌ،
كَالْكُحْلِ فِي الْعَيْنِ، فَلَا تَرَالُونَ
كَذَلِكَ حَتَّى تُثَوِّبَ إِلَى الْعَرَبِ
عَوَازِبُ أَحْلَامِهَا، فَالْزَمُوا السُّنَنَ
الْقَائِمَةَ وَالْأَنَارَ الْيُسْنَى، وَالْعَهْدَ
الْقَرِيبَ الَّذِي عَلَيْهِ بَاقِي النُّبُوَّةِ.
وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ الشَّيْطَانَ إِنَّمَا يُسَنِّي لَكُمْ
طُرُقَهُ لِتَتَّبِعُوا عَقِبَهُ.

heads, meaning he will have an insatiable bloodlust and will kill numerous people (M). Those who say that the individual being spoken of is ‘Abd al-Malik note that during his reign, he did indeed kill thousands of people, both in his battle against Muṣ‘ab ibn al-Zubayr, as well as through his bloodthirsty, despotic governor al-Ḥajjāj. It is even reported that he killed a hundred thousand people in his court, besides those who were killed by him in battle (T). The statement regarding how his mouth will be wide open (*fagharat fāghiratuḥu*) and his footsteps will be heavy on the ground has also been mentioned in sermon no. 100. The mouth wide open likens the individual to a predator or a wild beast, whereas his heavy footsteps symbolize his overbearing control over his dominion (MB). The Imām then says that *his reach shall be far and his onslaught severe* and brutal, which

means that his vast armies will march out in the lands (I), and the distant frontiers (M). The term '*al-ṣawlah*' refers to a violent attack or onslaught carried out in battle, or leaping upon something or someone. Here, it describes the brutality of his assault (N). Having presented these depictions of the evil tyrant who will come in the future, Amīr al-Mu'minīn says that he will scatter the believers to the ends of the earth until only few remain unharmed, like specks of kohl in the eye. This means that his persecution, killing, imprisonment, and oppression will affect everyone and none will remain safe from him except a very small number (Z). The example of *kohl in the eye* ('*kal-kuḥli fī al-ʿayn*') is used since only a little of the substance is applied to the eyes. In the same way, only very few people will be saved from the tyrant's oppression (MB).

This state of affairs will continue *until the Arabs return to their senses*, meaning until they regain their wits and reason, and organize their affairs. Some commentators say that by *Arabs*, the Imām was talking about the Banū 'Abbās, and those Arabs who support them against the Umayyads (M), or it referred to the Arabs of Yemen and the Rabī'ah, since they were the ones who stood against the Banī Umayyah (T). One commentator opines that this statement is proof that the individual being referred to in this section is not the Sufyānī (N). Nevertheless, since we do not have each and every detail about the latter, and how the Arabs will behave when he rises, it is still a possibility, given the context of this sermon and the preceding sections thereof, that it could be about the Sufyānī. A more general connotation of this is that only through sensible action based on rational stances can people attain freedom from the yoke of oppression (Z). The Imām then gives four instructions that would enable the people to gain victory over the tyrants, and secure peace for their communities. The first three of these are to *adhere to the established precedents, the clear signs, and the teachings of the early period upon which rests the legacy of Prophethood*. The *established precedents* ('*al-sunan al-qā'imah*') are the necessary requirements (*ḍarūriyāt*) of the religion, which should form the basis of every action undertaken by believers in every age. The *clear signs* ('*al-āthār al-bayyinah*') refer to the traditions that have reached the people through reliable chains and contain the lofty teachings of Islam (N). The early period ('*al-ʾahd al-qarīb*') refers to the period that remains with the vestiges of the Prophet, meaning the time of Imām 'Alī himself (Z). Finally, the Imām instructs the people to be wary of Satan, since he *makes his way easy* and smoothes his path so that people may follow in his footsteps. By this the Imām was warning

the people about the temptations and promptings of Satan, who leads them astray by portraying his path as the easier one (N). He then gets them to follow him and leads them to the painful punishment and the great abasement of the Hereafter (MB).



IN THE MEETING WITH THE CONSULTATIVE COMMITTEE

- 1 No one will precede me in calling to truth, establishing ties of kinship, and showing [others] kind benevolence. So hear my words and pay heed to what I say. After this day, you might see swords drawn and pledges broken due to this affair, so much so that some of you will become leaders of the misguided ones and followers of the ignorant fools.
- ۱ لَنْ يُسْرَعَ أَحَدٌ قَبْلِي إِلَى دَعْوَةِ حَقٍّ،
وَصِلَةِ رَحِمٍ، وَعَائِدَةٍ كَرَمٍ. فَاسْمَعُوا
قَوْلِي وَعُوا مَنَظِقِي، عَسَى أَنْ تَرَوْا
هَذَا الْأَمْرَ مِنْ بَعْدِ هَذَا الْيَوْمِ تُنْضَى
فِيهِ السُّيُوفُ، وَتُخَانَ فِيهِ الْعُهُودُ،
حَتَّى يَكُونَ بَعْضُكُمْ أئِمَّةً
لِلْأَهْلِ الضَّالَّةِ، وَشِيعَةً لِلْأَهْلِ
الْجَهَّالَةِ.

CONTEXT

These words were spoken by Imām ‘Alī in the year of ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb’s death (23 AH), in Madīnah. On his death bed, ‘Umar chose six individuals as members of a committee (*shūrā*) who would be responsible for selecting one among themselves to be the next caliph. Of course, this action was purely political, even though the second caliph had sought to give it a religious hue by saying that the Messenger of Allāh had passed away while he was pleased with these six individuals (Z). The details of the conditions pertaining to who were chosen and what transpired has already been discussed in the fourth section of sermon no. 3. What al-Sayyid al-Raḍī mentions here is part of the Imām’s address to the members of that committee (I), and in the version mentioned by al-Ṭabarī in his *Tārīkh*, there are some lines that precede these words and some that come after it (T). It is also said that aphorism no. 18 was part of this same oration (N). In their commentaries on this sermon, some have mentioned lengthy reports of what transpired on that day, quoting various historical accounts and narrations (I, T), while others have presented a detailed analysis of those events (Z).

COMMENTARY

1 This speech of Amīr al-Mu'minīn contains three main themes. The first points to some of his own merits, not as a form of self-aggrandizement, but only to lay the foundation for his audience to understand his position. Secondly, he asks them to listen to his reasoning and accept his admonition, for it is in their best interests to do so. And thirdly, he mentions some of the adverse consequences they would face if they chose to ignore him, and how the whole Muslim society would end up suffering as a result (N). The phrase '*lan yusri' aḥadun qablī ilā da'wati ḥaqqin*' has also been recorded as '*lam yusri' aḥadun qablī ilā da'wati ḥaqqin*', in which case the translation would be *no one has preceded me in accepting the invitation to truth*, and by this the Imām is referring to his glorious past as the first person to accept the message brought by the Noble Prophet, as we find in numerous reports (MB). Indeed, it was this very precedence that constituted clear evidence that if the caliphate were given to Imām 'Alī, no one would outpace him in calling to the truth, maintaining the ties of kinship, and showing others kindness and benevolence (Z). Some commentators gloss the phrase '*wa'ū mantiqī*' as *commit my words to memory and act upon them* (T). Imām 'Alī then goes on to warn them that *after this day*, meaning the day of the Shūrā, they may see *swords drawn and pledges broken over this affair*, meaning the affair of the caliphate. Indeed, due to the misstep made by the Shūrā, and their choosing the wrong individual as caliph, future events came to pass just as the Imām had warned them. One example of this was the rebellion of Mu'āwiyah in Syria which led to the Battle of Šiffīn, and the latter's reneging of his pact with Imām al-Ḥasan (T). Interestingly, in one report it is narrated that Mu'āwiyah himself said that the affair of the Muslims only became divided and fractured because of the Shūrā that was appointed by 'Umar (Z).

The extent of the ill-consequences that result from the error of choosing the wrong leader, the Imām asserts, would be such that some of them will become leaders of the misguided folk, the way Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr became leaders of those who rebelled against Imām 'Alī during his caliphate, while others became followers of ignorant fools like Mu'āwiyah, the Khawārij, and the other rulers of the Banī Umayyah (M). However, according to some commentators, the Imām's warning was regarding the corruption and harm which would result if 'Uthmān became the caliph, and it was not related to later events of history such as the

uprising of the Khawārij and others. As such, they opine that the *swords drawn* referred to the assassination of ‘Uthmān, and the *pledges broken* allude to the pledges made by ‘Uthmān to the people of Egypt which he broke, or more generally his breaking the covenant of Allāh by contravening His laws and injunctions (MB). In any case, the warning to them was that their wrong choice at that moment would lead to disastrous consequences for the Muslims in the near future.



FORBIDDING GOSSIP AND BACKBITING

- 1 It behoves those who do not sin and have been gifted with soundness [of faith] that they should pity the people of sin and wrongdoing. Gratitude is what must overwhelm them and prevent them from [finding faults in] others. Then what of the faultfinder who finds fault in his brother and upbraids him for what he is afflicted by! Does he not remember the times when Allāh had hidden his sins, of which some are greater than the sin for which he censures his brother! And how can he disparage him for a sin the like of which he has himself committed?! Even if he has not committed exactly the same sin, he has disobeyed Allāh in other ways that were even graver. By Allāh, even if he did not commit a big sin and committed only a small sin, his audacity in finding the faults of people is [itself a] greater [sin].
- وَأَتَمَّا يَتَّبِعِي لِأَهْلِ الْعِصْمَةِ
وَالْمَصْنُوعِ إِلَيْهِمْ فِي السَّلَامَةِ أَنْ
يَزْحَمُوا أَهْلَ الذُّنُوبِ وَالْمَعْصِيَةِ،
وَيَكُونَ الشُّكْرُ هُوَ الْغَالِبَ عَلَيْهِمْ
وَالْحَاجِزَ لَهُمْ عَنْهُمْ، فَكَيْفَ
بِالْعَائِبِ الَّذِي عَابَ أَحَاهُ وَعَيْرَهُ
بِئَلَوَاهُ! أَمَا ذَكَرَ مَوْضِعَ سِتْرِ اللَّهِ عَلَيْهِ
مِنْ ذُنُوبِهِ مِمَّا هُوَ أَعْظَمُ مِنَ الذَّنْبِ
الَّذِي عَابَهُ بِهِ! وَكَيْفَ يَذُمَّ بِذَنْبِ
قَدْ رَكِبَ مِثْلَهُ؟! فَإِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ رَكِبَ
ذَلِكَ الذَّنْبَ بَعَيْنِهِ فَقَدْ عَصَى اللَّهَ
فِيمَا سِوَاهُ مِمَّا هُوَ أَعْظَمُ مِنْهُ، وَإِنَّمَا
اللَّهُ، لَئِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ عَصَاهُ فِي الْكَبِيرِ،
وَعَصَاهُ فِي الصَّغِيرِ، لَجُرْأَتُهُ عَلَى
عَيْبِ النَّاسِ أَكْبَرُ.
- 2 O servant of Allāh, do not be hasty in faulting anyone for his sin as he may be forgiven for it, and do not consider yourself safe even from a small sin as you may be punished for it. Therefore, let any of you who learns of the faults of others desist [from exposing them] because of what he knows about his own faults, and let his gratitude for
- يَا عَبْدَ اللَّهِ، لَا تَعْجَلْ فِي عَيْبِ أَحَدٍ
بِذَنْبِهِ، فَلَعَلَّهُ مَغْفُورٌ لَهُ، وَلَا تَأْمَنْ
عَلَى نَفْسِكَ صَغِيرَ مَعْصِيَةٍ، فَلَعَلَّكَ
مُعَذَّبٌ عَلَيْهِ؛ فَلْيَكْفُفْ مَنْ عِلْمَ
مِنْكُمْ عَيْبَ غَيْرِهِ لِمَا يَعْلَمُ مِنْ
عَيْبِ

having been saved from what others
are afflicted by occupy him [from
looking at their faults].

نَفْسِهِ، وَلَيْكُنِ الشُّكْرُ شَاغِلًا لَهُ عَلَى
مُعَافَاتِهِ مِمَّا ابْتُلِيَ بِهِ غَيْرُهُ.

CONTEXT

Amīr al-Mu'minīn warns people about the evils of backbiting and fault-finding in this oration. It is not known exactly where or when the Imām spoke these words, and the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has placed it within a longer sermon known as 'al-Dībāj', which contains many general admonitions and pieces of advice from the Imām to the people (4:126). Since part of this oration is found in al-Āmidī's *Ghurar al-Ḥikam* with significant variance in wording, it can be deduced that his source was different from the one used by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī (N). As the message contained within this sermon is general, lack of information about its specific context or background does not hinder its reader from understanding its purport and benefitting therefrom. Al-Raḍī's title for this sermon reads '*fī al-nahy 'an ghībat al-nās*' where the term *ghībah* means speaking about someone behind his back, or in his absence, that which would disturb him or sadden him if he hears it. If what is spoken is something true, it is *ghībah*, and if it is a lie, it is known as *buhtān*, meaning slander or calumny (T).

COMMENTARY

1 The phrase '*ahl al-ṣ̣mah*' is rendered as *those who do not sin*, and it refers to the Godwary, while '*al-maṣ̣nū' ilayhim fī al-salāmah*' refers to those whom Allāh has blessed with the ability to worship Him and keep aloof from sin (Z), and are thus safe from deviation from the straight path (M). Such individuals, the Imām says, should feel compassion and mercy for those who are drowning in the sea of sin and wrongdoing. In that way, they will be motivated to try and save them from their plight and guide them out of their bewilderment towards the path of righteousness and sound faith (MB). Some commentators understand this compassion to be something akin to pity that is felt for the sinners because of the painful consequences they have prepared for themselves by their actions (T). Furthermore, the Imām says that those blessed, Godwary individuals should be

overcome by gratitude, and that should prevent them from finding fault with the sinners and pointing fingers at them. Indeed, one who is pious should not feel pleased with himself or entertain a sense of superiority due to his devotion. Rather, he should remain humble and grateful for this virtue. An interesting tradition attributed to the Noble Messenger states, “All the Children of Ādam are sinners, and the best sinners are those who repent” (Z). According to some commentators, the phrase ‘*al-ḥājizī lahum ‘anhū*’ means that they are prevented by the gratitude from exposing the faults and flaws of others (MB). Imām ‘Alī then said that if it is wrong for one who is Godwary and righteous to backbite his brother, then what of one who is just as sinful as he is! (T). Of course, it would be even more blameworthy for one who is himself guilty of sin to gossip about his brother’s faults. Indeed, a tradition from the Imām states, “The greatest flaw is for one to find fault with another for the like of which he has in himself” (Z).

The Imām then continues by reminding them that their own faults and sins, some of which are far graver, have been concealed by the Almighty. The phrase *does he not remember the times when Allāh had hidden his sins* contains an implicit rebuke as well as an exhortation to make up for their negligence by recalling the fact that Allāh has many a times hidden their own faults, even those which would be deemed major sins (MB). Worse still are those who disparage others for sins that they themselves commit. About such, the Imām rhetorically asks *how can he disparage him for a sin the like of which he has himself committed?!* This kind of act is counterintuitive and goes against all reason and logic (N). And in case the person has not committed exactly the same sin, he has surely disobeyed Allāh in other things, some of which may have been even worse and more severe than that for which he disparages others. If, in the hypothetical scenario where one has never committed any major sin, and only made small transgressions and committed minor sins, the act of audaciously finding faults in others is itself a major sin; and if he exposes these sins publicly, that would be one of the gravest major sins (Z). The phrase ‘*la-jur’atuhu ‘alā ‘ayb al-nās akbar*’ could alternatively mean that the audacity and insolence of exposing the faults of others is considered a graver sin in the eyes of Allāh; and that is perhaps because the consequence of this action and the corruption that results from it is greater (M). By mentioning these different scenarios, the Imām voids all justifications for fault-finding and backbiting, while at the same time highlighting the seriousness of this evil deed (N).

2 This section starts with the Imām using a vocative, which some consider a conciliatory vocative (MB), with the general address, *O servant of Allāh*. He then proceeds to tell his listeners not to be hasty in faulting anyone for his sin, as he may already have been forgiven by Allāh (N), or will be granted forgiveness in the future. It may be that due to this sin of his, Allāh will grant him a remedy from a spiritual malady (Z). At the same time, it is possible that because of one's delusion regarding the smallness or triviality of his own sin, a person fails to gain forgiveness for it and ends up facing divine wrath and punishment. So nobody should feel safe enough with his own actions to freely find fault with others for their deeds (N). If one knows that he has faults, he must strive to remove them from himself, and that would occupy him from worrying about the faults of others. And if he is free of particular faults, he should thank Allāh for the blessing and be so overwhelmed by gratitude that it keeps him away from looking at the misdeeds of others (Z).

Some commentators have offered interesting discussions regarding backbiting in their commentaries. Herewith is a summary of the points that pertain to the subject of *ghībah* (MB):

- (i) All scholars agree that just as backbiting is prohibited, so too is listening to it. Indeed, the listener is considered one of the two perpetrators of the crime of *ghībah* (*aḥad al-muḡhtābayn*).
- (ii) There are some exceptions to the prohibition of backbiting, such as: speaking out against the oppression of an oppressor, giving sincere advice to someone on an important matter (such as marriage), asking for a religious ruling about the action of someone, warning a believer of what would bring him harm in this world or the next, using it as the only effective means of stopping one from evil actions, exposing the hidden sicknesses of a person to a doctor, rejecting the false attribution of a person to a lineage or family that is not his, or backbiting someone who openly commits indecencies and wrongdoing (*al-mutaajāhir bil-fisq*).
- (iii) The expiation for backbiting, as we learn from the traditions of the Infallibles, is that one must feel remorse for his action and seek forgiveness for it. Then he should ask the one whom he spoke about to forgive him. Furthermore, we are told that whenever one remembers that person (whom he had backbited), he should seek forgiveness from Allāh on his behalf. And if his words caused any loss

to the individual, he should endeavour to make up for that loss, be it in his honour or his wealth.



ON THE EVILS OF SLANDER

1 O people! If a person knows his brother to be steadfast in faith and a follower of the right way, then he should never listen to what people say about him. See how an archer may shoot a target but his arrow misses; similarly what is spoken can wound, yet its falsehood soon comes to naught, and Allāh is All-hearing and All-witnessing. Know that nothing lies between truth and falsehood but four fingers.

2 [He (‘a) was asked the meaning of this statement, so he closed his fingers together and placed them between his ear and his eye, then said:] Falsehood is when you say, “I have heard it,” while truth is when you say, “I have seen it!”

١ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، مَنْ عَرَفَ مِنْ أَخِيهِ وَثِيقَةَ دِينٍ وَسَدَادَ طَرِيقٍ، فَلَا يَسْمَعَنَّ فِيهِ أَقَاوِيلَ الرِّجَالِ. أَمَّا إِنَّهُ قَدْ يَزِمِي الرَّامِي، وَتُحْطِئُ السَّهَامُ، وَيُحِيكُ الْكَلَامُ، وَبَاطِلُ ذَلِكَ يَبُورُ، وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ وَشَهِيدٌ. أَمَّا إِنَّهُ لَيْسَ بَيْنَ الْحَقِّ وَالْبَاطِلِ إِلَّا أَرْبَعُ أَصَابِعَ.

٢ [فَسُئِلَ عَلَيْهِ عَنْ مَعْنَى قَوْلِهِ هَذَا، فَجَمَعَ أَصَابِعَهُ وَوَضَعَهَا بَيْنَ أُذُنِهِ وَعَيْنِهِ ثُمَّ قَالَ:] الْبَاطِلُ أَنْ تَقُولَ سَمِعْتُ، وَالْحَقُّ أَنْ تَقُولَ رَأَيْتُ!

CONTEXT

The title given to this sermon differs among commentators, with some calling it a sermon against thinking negatively of others (*sū' al-zann*) (I), and others saying it is an oration forbidding listening to gossip and delineating the difference between truth and falsehood (N). Yet others say that it is a speech warning people from hastily accepting the words of anyone who accuses an ostensibly righteous person who is generally known for his piety (M). Given the contents of this oration, it has been suggested that it could have been part of the previous sermon, or something spoken soon after it (N). From a report in al-Thaqafī's *al-Ghārāt*, we find that the Byzantine Emperor had once sent ten questions to Mu'āwiyah, and since he could not answer them, he sent a messenger to Imām 'Alī asking him to provide the answers, and one of the questions was, “What is the distance between

truth and falsehood (*kam bayn al-ḥaqq wal-bāṭil*)?" The Imām's answer was similar to what is mentioned in this oration. Some have thus surmised that these words could have been spoken by Amīr al-Mu'minīn towards the end of his life, around 40 AH, possibly in Kūfah. However, the author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* says that Imām 'Alī mentioned this on a number of different occasions, and he notes the various sources that quote a similar statement from the Imām (2:312). This oration is found in some other early sources, with variance in wording. These include: *Dustūr Ma'ālim al-Hikam* by al-Qāḍī al-Quḍā'ī, *'Ayn al-Adab wal-Siyāsah* by 'Alī ibn Hudhayl, and part thereof is also found in *al-Khiṣāl* by al-Ṣadūq, and *al-'Iqd al-Farīd* by Ibn 'Abd Rabbih (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām begins by warning people not to give ear to any rumours or gossip that is spoken about a brother in faith who is known to be a devout believer and a righteous individual. The goal behind this instruction was generally to preserve the dignity of believers while at the same time fostering a sense of closeness and trust among them by eschewing the fallout of slander (N). The phrase '*wathīqata dīnin*' means firmness in following the religion, and '*sadāda ṭarīqin*' means steadfastness in action and conduct (T). It is also possible that the former phrase pertains to one's correct beliefs (*'aqīdah*), whereas the latter refers to one's proper practice (*'amal*), as found in the definition present in some narrations (MB). A beautiful tradition from the Imām tells us that one should think positively of his brother in faith to such an extent that when he says something, as long as there is a way to interpret it positively, one should not assume it was meant negatively (T). Imām 'Alī then proceeds to give an example showing that even if the person who is speaking about others is a truthful individual, he is not infallible and can err in his judgment, just like the archer who shoots and misses his target (N). In the same way, one who censures another or lays blame may be wrong in his assertions (I). Many times, what is spoken by the people is based on mere conjecture and assumption, or on what they have overheard. In such cases, most of what is conveyed is false. A variant version of the phrase '*yuḥīku al-kalām*' is '*yuḥīlu al-kalām*', which means what is spoken can be far from the truth, however the former version is more likely correct (T). The phrase '*bāṭilu dhālika yabūr*' means that the goal behind the negative statements against the individual, which are the result of

malice and jealousy, or for other such reasons, will fail and come to naught (MB). However, its repercussions will remain and one will be held to account for it, since *Allāh is All-hearing and All-witnessing*. Hence it behoves the people to speak only that which is true, and do only that which is good (T). Finally, the Imām notes that the gap separating truth from falsehood is but the span of four fingers. Due to the apparently abstruse nature of this statement, someone asked the Imām what he meant by it. Indeed, there were a number of instances when Imām ‘Alī was questioned about the meaning of what he had spoken and the analogies he had presented. Some commentators have even compiled these kinds of orations containing questions put to the Imām and the answers given by him in a separate section in their commentaries (T).

2 In response to the questioner who had asked what the Imām meant by the statement *nothing lies between truth and falsehood but four fingers*, Amīr al-Mu’minīn lined up his fingers, and closing them together, placed them between his ear and his eye. Then he explained that *falsehood is when you say, “I have heard it,” while truth is when you say, “I have seen it!”* That is because most of what is heard from the people is not factual, whereas what is witnessed and seen first-hand is true (T). If one were to ask: how can it be said that falsehood is what is heard whereas truth is what is seen, when most of the knowledge that has reached us is through what we have heard, including about the prophethood of the Noble Messenger, his miracles, etc.? The answer would be: the Imām was not talking about established, successively transmitted reports. Rather, he was referring to solitary statements and claims which contain censure for one whose righteousness is generally accepted (I). Indeed, there is no doubt that information which is heard can either be true or false, so this statement of the Imām must be understood within the specific context in which he was speaking, namely about the words of calumny against an individual known to be virtuous, albeit apparently, unless one witnesses otherwise (Z). One commentator points out that the Imām’s statement is not literal, because whether one says that he has heard something or he says that he saw it, it is still a report which is heard by another (MB). It is undeniable that not everything one hears is false, and not everything one sees is real and true. Sometimes the eye may err, and sometimes even an unreliable person may speak the truth. Nevertheless, when compared, one finds that more falsehood is found in what is heard than in what is seen, and perhaps that is what the Imām is referring to (N). Interestingly, in another source we find a similar statement

attributed to Imām al-Ḥasan, who said when asked by his father Imām ‘Alī, “What is the distance between faith and certitude (*kam bayn al-īmān wal-yaqīn*)?” “Four fingers!” When asked to explain what he meant, he said, “Faith is that which your ears hear and your heart believes, whereas certitude is what your eyes see and your heart is certain of. And the distance between the eye and the ear is but four fingers” (T).



ON MISPLACED BENEVOLENCE

DOING GOOD TO THE UNWORTHY

- 1 The doer of good among the unworthy, and to those who do not deserve it, will gain nothing by what he does except the praise of the ignoble, appreciation of the wicked, and the statement of the ignorant – as long he continues giving them – “How generous is his hand!” Even if in the way of Allāh he is a miser!

المعروف في غير أهله

١ وَلَيْسَ لِوَاضِعِ الْمَعْرُوفِ فِي غَيْرِ حَقِّهِ، وَعِنْدَ غَيْرِ أَهْلِهِ، مِنَ الْحِطِّ فِيمَا أَتَى إِلَّا مَحَمْدَةُ اللَّئَامِ، وَتَنَاءُ الْأَشْرَارِ، وَمَقَالَةُ الْجُهَّالِ مَا دَامَ مُنْعِمًا عَلَيْهِمْ: مَا أَجْوَدَ يَدَهُ! وَهُوَ عَنْ ذَاتِ اللَّهِ بِخَيْلٍ!

CIRCUMSTANCES FOR BENEVOLENCE

- 2 Whoever has been granted wealth by Allāh should use it to strengthen ties with his close relatives, to be a good host to his guests, and to free the prisoner and the captive. Let him give from it to the poor and the indebted; and he should patiently fulfil the rights and bear the hardships in expectation of divine reward. Verily, successfully achieving these qualities is the height of nobility in this world and the attainment of great merits in the Hereafter, if Allāh so wills.

مواضع المعروف

٢ فَمَنْ آتَاهُ اللَّهُ مَالًا فَلْيَصِلْ بِهِ الْقَرَابَةَ، وَلْيُحْسِنْ مِنْهُ الضِّيَافَةَ، وَلْيُفْكِكَ بِهِ الْأَسِيرَ وَالْعَانِي، وَلْيُعْطِ مِنْهُ الْفَقِيرَ وَالْعَارِمَ، وَلْيُضْبِرْ نَفْسَهُ عَلَى الْحُقُوقِ وَالنَّوَائِبِ، ابْتِغَاءَ الثَّوَابِ؛ فَإِنَّ فَوْزًا بِهَذِهِ الْخِصَالِ شَرَفٌ مَكَارِمِ الدُّنْيَا، وَدَرْكٌ فَضَائِلِ الْآخِرَةِ، إِنْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ.

CONTEXT

This is an excerpt of a longer oration, which, according to some commentators, also includes sermon no. 126. From what is found in other sources, such as al-

Ḥarrānī's *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, we learn that Imām 'Alī spoke these words at Ṣiffīn (in 37 AH), when his followers saw how Mu'āwiyah had lavished rewards upon his supporters and urged him to do the same. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah*, however, places this oration within a much longer sermon delivered by the Imām after the Battles of Jamal and Nahrawān (5:629), and it is possible that he said something similar on more than one occasion. This oration has been recorded in many earlier sources, wholly or in part, with some variance in wording. Al-Kulaynī reports it in *al-Kāfī*, al-Mufīd in *al-Majālis*, al-Ṭūsī in his *al-Amālī*, and Ibn Qutaybah in *al-Imāmah wal-Siyāsah* (N). The message of this oration is general and hence the advice contained in it is applicable at all times. It is basically meant to discourage spending wealth on poets, cronies, lackeys, and so on in order to reward them for their flattery and sycophancy. Instead, believers are urged to spend their wealth in virtuous causes in order to earn divine reward (I).

COMMENTARY

1 At the outset, Amīr al-Mu'minīn explains the futility of doing good to the unworthy, and bestowing gifts to those who do not deserve it, saying that such an action will bring no gain *except the praise of the ignoble, appreciation of the wicked, and the statement of flattery by the ignorant*, and that too will only last as long as one continues giving them what they desire. The phrase '*wāḍī' al-ma'rūf*' means one who places goodness, through being benevolent and kind (MB). The ignorant folk praise one who extravagantly spends wealth in this manner saying, "*how generous is his hand!*" But were he to stop giving them these undeserved grants, the same people would revile him with the worst epithets or even take action against him (Z). A tradition attributed to the Noble Prophet states, "Whoever seeks the praise of people by disobeying Allāh, his praiser will [soon] turn into his reviler" (N). The phrase '*huwa 'an dhātillāh bakhīl*' has been narrated in *al-Kāfī* as '*huwa 'indallāhi bakhīl*', meaning that in the eyes of Allāh, he is a miser. Based on al-Raḍī's version here, it means that even though this person is praised as a bounteous individual by the ignorant, he is counted among the niggardly because of his miserliness when it comes to spending in the way of Allāh. Put differently, since wealth can either be spent appropriately or inappropriately, if it is withheld when it ought to be spent, in accordance with the commandments and prescriptions of the Almighty, then the one who withholds it is a miser. Conversely, if it is spent

where one ought to withhold it, in accordance with the ordinances of Allāh, then it is extravagance and wastefulness. The correct course between these two extremes, where one spends generously on what Allāh has prescribed, is true beneficence. Indeed, it is this middle path that is highlighted in the verse of the Qur'ān which states: *And those who, when they spend, are neither extravagant nor stingy...* (Q25:67) (MB).

2 The Imām subsequently gives examples of how one ought to spend generously in the way of Allāh, and outlines the circumstances in which benevolence is appropriate and even mandatory. The first responsibility of one who has been granted wealth by Allāh, is to *use it to strengthen ties with his close relatives*. This means giving financial aid to one's needy kin, because they are more worthy of one's kindness and assistance (Z). The importance of this is so great that traditions tell us no other charity is accepted from one who has a needy relative (MB). It has also been reported that when the Noble Messenger was asked about the most praiseworthy charity, he replied that it was giving to the needy relative who is estranged (N). This was practically shown by Imām al-Ṣādiq who, on his death bed, instructed that al-Ḥasan ibn 'Alī ibn al-Ḥusayn (al-Aḥḡas) should be given seventy dīnārs from his wealth. When someone objected to his giving this amount to one who sought to harm him, he replied that the latter had a right of kinship with him (T). The second thing one ought to do with his wealth is *to be a good host to his guests*. Indeed, hosting one's brothers in faith is highly encouraged as it increases affection among friends and strengthens the bonds of brotherhood. According to one narration, Imām al-Ṣādiq told one of his followers that when guests enter his house, they bring with them forgiveness for him and his family, and when they leave, they take away his sins and those of his family (N). The third way one should use his wealth is *to free the prisoner and the captive*. The term '*al-ʿanī*' is understood by some commentators to be a synonym of '*al-asīr*', meaning prisoner or captive (I), and has been included here only as explication (Z). Others interpret it as one who is distressed by his captivity (*'anāhu ḡabsuhu*), because of the abasement it entails (T).

Yet another duty of the wealthy believer is to help the poor and those who are burdened by debts. Though these two groups are among the eight categories of people who may receive the mandatory *zakāt*, it is evident that the Imām is talking about a more general type of charity here, and there are many narrations wherein it has been recommended to help believers pay off their debts (T). While giving all

these charities, one should *patiently fulfil the rights and bear the hardships* since it is normal for a person to dislike parting with his wealth when there is no immediate profit to be gained by doing so (Z). The phrase '*wal-yaṣbir nafsahu*' means he should keep himself patient (I), and endure any hardship he faces in fulfilling what has been prescribed for him by the Almighty (M). The *hardships* ('*al-nawāib*') generally refer to the losses or catastrophes that befall an individual in his wealth (Z).

One has to bear all this patiently *in expectation of divine reward*, and indeed traditions tell us that the best charity is that which is given by one who has little to give (T). By mentioning the desire to acquire divine recompense, the Imām is highlighting the requisite intention for giving charity, which is seeking the pleasure of Allāh, and not for other reasons like showing off or gaining praise (MB). Finally, the Imām notes that if one is successful in attaining these virtues, he will gain *the height of nobility in this world* ('*sharafu makārim al-dunyā*') along with *great merits* ('*faḍā'il*') in the Hereafter. That is because generous bestowal is a virtue which is praiseworthy in the sight of Allāh, and is considered a trait of the noble ones by the people of this world (Z). It leads to gaining a good reputation among the people, and an honourable position in the society. Some commentators suggest that by using the term '*fawzan*' without the article '*al*', and not saying '*al-fawz*', the Imām meant even attaining a little of this results in honour in both worlds (MB). In another pithy aphorism from Amīr al-Mu'minīn, he sums up this outcome of generosity and says, "Whoever bestows generously attains eminence (*man jāda sāda*)" (N).



PRAYER FOR RAIN

1 Verily, the earth that bears you and the sky that shades you are both obedient to your Lord. They did not start bestowing their generous blessings upon you out of compassion for you, nor in order to attain closeness to you, nor for any good which they hope from you; rather, they were ordered to benefit you so they obeyed, and they were instructed to maintain your welfare so they did accordingly. Verily Allāh tries His servants at the moment of [their] evil actions by diminishing the yields, withholding blessings, and closing the treasure-chests of bounty, so that the repentant may repent, the detacher may detach [from sin], the admonished may take admonishment, and the deterred may refrain [from evil].

١ أَلَا وَإِنَّ الْأَرْضَ الَّتِي تَحْمِلُكُمْ،
وَالسَّمَاءَ الَّتِي تَظِلُّكُمْ، مُطِيعَتَانِ
لِرَبِّكُمْ، وَمَا أَصْبَحْتَ تَجُودَانِ
لَكُمْ بِبَرَكَتِهِمَا تَوْجُعاً لَكُمْ، وَلَا
زُلْفَةً إِلَيْكُمْ، وَلَا لَخَيْرٍ تَرْجُوَانِهِ
مِنْكُمْ، وَلَكِنْ أَمْرًا بِمَنَافِعِكُمْ
فَأَطَاعَتَا، وَأُفِيمَتَا عَلَى حُدُودِ
مَصَالِحِكُمْ فَقَامَتَا. إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَبْتَلِي
عِبَادَهُ عِنْدَ الْأَعْمَالِ السَّيِّئَةِ
بِنَقْصِ الثَّمَرَاتِ، وَحَبْسِ
الْبَرَكَاتِ، وَإِغْلَاقِ خَزَائِنِ
الْخَيْرَاتِ، لِيُثَوِّبَ تَائِبٌ، وَيُقْلِعَ
مُقْلِعٌ، وَيَتَذَكَّرَ مُتَذَكِّرٌ، وَيَرْدَجِرَ
مُرْدَجِرٌ.

2 Allāh, the Glorified, has made seeking forgiveness a means for overflowing sustenance and mercy on the creation, as He, the Glorified, has said: *Plead to your Lord for forgiveness, indeed He is Most-forgiving. He will send for you abundant rains from the sky, and aid you with wealth and sons, and provide you with gardens and provide you with streams* (Q71:10-12). So may Allāh have mercy on the one who turns to repent-

٢ وَقَدْ جَعَلَ اللَّهُ سُبْحَانَهُ الْإِسْتِغْفَارَ
سَبِيلًا لِدُرُورِ الرِّزْقِ وَرَحْمَةً الْخَلْقِ،
فَقَالَ سُبْحَانَهُ: «اسْتَغْفِرُوا رَبَّكُمْ إِنَّهُ
كَانَ غَفَّارًا يُزِيلُ السَّمَاءَ عَلَيْكُمْ
مِدْرَارًا وَيُمْدِدْكُمْ بِأَمْوَالٍ وَبَنِينَ
وَيَجْعَلْ لَكُمْ جَنَّاتٍ وَيَجْعَلْ لَكُمْ
أَنْهَارًا»، فَارْحَمِ اللَّهُ أَمْرًا اسْتَقْبَلَ

ance, seeks pardon for his sins, and hastens [to good deeds] before his death.

تَوْبَتُهُ، وَاسْتَقَالَ حَاطِيَّتَهُ، وَبَادَرَ مَمِيَّتَهُ.

CONTEXT

This is the second sermon in *Nahj al-Balāghah* that pertains to praying for rain (*istisqāʿ*), the first one being sermon no. 114. There is no information available about the context of this oration, though the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes it as part of a longer sermon in which the Imām talks about the causes of cessation of provision (*qaṭʿ al-rizq*) from Allāh, before praying for rain (4:279). It has been suggested that the Imām most likely spoke these words in Kūfah, after calling the people to gather for Ṣalāt al-Istisqāʿ, in one of the years wherein they were experiencing drought (N). Some commentators say that since the acceptance of supplication is contingent upon certain conditions, the Imām mentioned some important matters before beginning the prayer for rain, so that his listeners and those who were present in the congregation could thereby be prepared and not end up returning disappointed (MB). This oration has been mentioned in al-Daylamī's *Iʿlām al-Nubuwwah*, narrated from Imām al-Ṣādiq, and part of it is also discussed by Ibn Athīr in his *al-Nihāyah* (N).

COMMENTARY

1 In this prefatory section, Imām ʿAlī lays the groundwork and prepares the people by reminding them of the spirit of servitude to the Almighty, and of His great blessings (N). The statement *the earth that bears you and the sky that shades you* is interpreted by some commentators as representative of compassion, for the earth bears the people like a mother carries her child, and the sky protects them like a father protects his children (M). It has been suggested that the term sky (*ʿal-samāʾ*) here could figuratively be referring to clouds, since it is the clouds that carry rain to the people (MB). Both the earth and sky do this in obedience to Allāh, as noted in the verse: ...*He said to it (the sky) and to the earth, "Come, willingly or unwillingly!" They both said, "We come willingly."* (Q41:11) (T). The Imām then notes that the rainfall from the sky and the vegetation that grows on the earth are not

the result of their compassion for humankind (*'tawajju'an lakum'*), nor in order to become closer to them (*'zulfatan ilaykum'*), nor for the purpose of attaining some goodness from them, as is common when people show generosity to others (MB). Rather, they were commanded to provide people with benefit, and thus they obeyed, and they were ordered to ensure the welfare of the people, so they complied. As such, it behoves the people not to place their hope in the sky or the earth, but rather in the Creator, and it is to Him that they should supplicate and ask for rain (I). The Imām subsequently informs the people that their own evil actions lead them to be tried by hardships such as diminishing yields, withholding of blessings, and the locking away of bountiful treasures. That is because trials like these are a means of disciplining wrongdoers, and this is a form of grace (*lutf*) from Allāh (MB). It is done *so that the repentant may repent, the detacher may detach himself from sin, the admonished may take admonishment, and the deterred may refrain*. Some have understood the phrase *'yuqli'a muqli'un'* to mean returning to the right path (R), while others say it connotes desisting from sin and misdeeds (T). The admonishment pertains to the reminder of the rewards prepared for those who avoid sins, and the deterrent refers to the warnings about a painful punishment that awaits sinners in the Hereafter (MB).

2 Like an expert physician, after diagnosing the ailment, Imām 'Alī offers the remedy for it, which in this case is seeking forgiveness (*'al-istighfār'*). The term *'durūr'* comes from *darra*, which literally means the flowing of milk from the teat of a camel or a cloven-footed animal, and it later came to signify abundance, bounty, and rainfall (N). After stating that Allāh has made *seeking forgiveness a means for overflowing sustenance and mercy on the creation*, Amīr al-Mu'minīn offers proof for this from the Glorious Qur'ān (I). He quotes the verses in which Prophet Nūḥ had instructed his people to seek forgiveness and repent for their sins (Q71:10-12). Prophet Nūḥ was telling his people to repent to Allāh for their disbelief and their sins, as Allāh forgives those who turn to Him penitently. He further promised that if they do this, the Almighty will bless them with abundant provisions and blessings in the form of rainfall, wealth, and children. Undoubtedly, repentance is one of the means of attaining the pleasure of Allāh, and His pardon. As for it being a cause of increase in provision, that is contingent upon striving, sowing, and expending effort (Z). The Imām then prays to Allāh to shower His mercy on those who repent and do good deeds before death comes to them. The phrase *'bādara maniyyatahu'* literally means he races against his death, and it

3 O Allāh! We have come out to You from under the tents and shelters, after [hearing] the cries of the livestock and the children, yearning for Your mercy, hoping for the bounty of Your blessing and fearing Your chastisement and wrath. O Allāh! Quench us with Your rain and do not place us among those who have lost hope, nor annihilate us with drought, nor punish us for what the foolish among us have done, O Most Merciful of those who show mercy. O Allāh! We have come out to You to complain to You about what is not hidden from You, having been compelled by desperate straits and driven by devastating drought, and we have been rendered helpless in the face of unattainable needs and are overcome by the incessant befalling of difficult tribulations.

4 O Allāh! We beseech You not to turn us away disappointed, nor send us back dejected, nor deal harshly with us due to our sins, nor treat us according to our deeds. O Allāh! Pour on us Your rain and Your blessings, and [grant us] Your sustenance and Your mercy, and give us a drink which is beneficial, quenching, and irrigating, by which all that had dried up [of the vegetation] starts growing [again], and all that had withered comes to life. Let it be a beneficial downpour that results in abundant harvests, and by which the

٣ اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّا خَرَجْنَا إِلَيْكَ مِنْ تَحْتِ
الْأَشْتَارِ وَالْأَكْنَانِ، وَبَعْدَ عَجِيجِ
الْبَهَائِمِ وَالْوِلْدَانِ، رَاغِبِينَ فِي
رَحْمَتِكَ، وَرَاجِينَ فَضْلَ نِعْمَتِكَ،
وَحَائِفِينَ مِنْ عَذَابِكَ وَنِقْمَتِكَ.
اللَّهُمَّ فَاسْقِنَا غَيْثَكَ، وَلَا تَجْعَلْنَا مِنْ
الْقَانِطِينَ، وَلَا تُهْلِكْنَا بِالسَّنِينِ، وَلَا
تُؤَاخِذْنَا بِمَا فَعَلَ السُّفَهَاءُ مِنَّا يَا
أَرْحَمَ الرَّاحِمِينَ. اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّا خَرَجْنَا
إِلَيْكَ نَشْكُو إِلَيْكَ مَا لَا يَخْفَى
عَلَيْكَ، حِينَ أَلْجَأْتَنَا الْمَضَائِقُ
الْوَعْرَةَ، وَأَجَاءْتَنَا الْمَقَاحِطُ
الْمُجْدِبَةَ، وَأَعْيَيْتَنَا الْمُطَالِبُ
الْمُتَعَسِّرَةَ، وَتَلَاخَمَتْ عَلَيْنَا الْفِتَنُ
الْمُسْتَضِعَّةُ.

٤ اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّا نَسْأَلُكَ أَلَّا تَرُدَّنَا
خَائِبِينَ، وَلَا تُقْلِبْنَا وَاجِمِينَ، وَلَا
تُخَاطِبَنَا بِذُنُوبِنَا، وَلَا تُقَايِسَنَا
بِأَعْمَالِنَا. اللَّهُمَّ انْشُرْ عَلَيْنَا غَيْثَكَ
وَبَرِّكَتَكَ، وَرَزْقَكَ وَرَحْمَتَكَ،
وَاسْقِنَا سُقْيَا نَافِعَةً مُزَوِّجَةً مُعْشِبَةً،
تُنْبِتُ بِهَا مَا قَدْ فَاتَ، وَتُحْيِي
بِهَا مَا قَدْ مَاتَ، نَاقِعَةً الْحَيَا،
كَثِيرَةً الْمُجْتَنَى، تُزَوِّي بِهَا

plains may be watered, dried rivers
may begin to flow, trees may become
leafy, and prices may come down.
Verily, You have the power to do as
You will.

الْقَيْعَانَ، وَتُسِيلُ الْبُطْنَانَ،
وَتُسَوِّرُقُ الْأَشْجَارَ، وَتُرْخِصُ
الْأَسْعَارَ، إِنَّكَ عَلَى مَا تَشَاءُ
قَدِيرٌ.

alludes to the fact that repentance is not only for attaining worldly comforts; rather, its more important purpose is to acquire salvation in the Hereafter. Thus, if one makes haste and quickly seeks forgiveness for his wrongdoings before departing this world, he will have secured his place in the permanent abode of the Afterlife (N).

3 After preparing the hearts of the people and inviting them to turn penitently to Allāh, Imām ‘Alī begins to supplicate to Allāh for rain. The words and phrases he uses evoke a sense of need, desperation, humbleness, and submission before Allāh. He pleads for divine grace and favour using five statements, each beginning with the phrase ‘O Allāh’ (N). He commences with descriptions of their desperate state, and how they have come out to pray after hearing the heartrending cries of their children and even their livestock. The purpose of mentioning this is to heighten the yearning for divine mercy among the people, and to increase their hope in blessings from their Lord (M). Their coming out *from under the tents and shelters* signifies that the prayer of Istisqā’ was led by the Imām in an open plain; and jurists tell us it is recommended that the prayer for rain be offered in the open desert; except, that is, for the people of Makkah, who should offer *ṣalāt al-istisqā’* in al-Masjid al-Ḥarām (Z). The term “*ajj*” refers to raised voices and loud cries and moans (MB). Interestingly, some narrations encourage believers to take their infants and thirsty livestock with them when they go to attend *ṣalāt al-istisqā’*, and it has also been said that babies should be separated from their mothers so that their cries may shake the hearts of the people and make them turn ever more yearningly to Allāh (N). Amīr al-Mu’minīn subsequently prays to Allāh to quench them with His rain, and not to place them *among those who have lost hope*. The term ‘*al-qāniṭīn*’ refers to the despondent, despairing, disheartened individuals, who have lost all hope. Losing hope in Allāh is itself considered a sin, and the Glorious Qur’ān tells us: *Who despairs of the mercy of his Lord except those who are astray?* (Q15:56) (Z). The term ‘*al-sinīn*’ is plural of *sanah*, which means intense drought, as

mentioned in the verse: *And We indeed seized the House of Fir‘awn with droughts and shortage of produce so that they might take heed* (Q7:130) (I). The Imām further asks Allāh not to punish them for what the foolish among them have done. By *the foolish*, he means the ignorant people who frequently sin and perpetrate those evils that cause the withholding of divine mercy. The same thing is reflected in what Prophet Mūsā said to Allāh regarding those ignorant followers of his who turned to worshipping the golden calf (Q7:155) (MB). According to some traditions, the good are punished due to the deeds of the evil ones among them, and the learned due to the actions of the ignorant, because they did nothing to stop them from what they were doing (T).

Amīr al-Mu‘minīn then says that they have come out *to complain* to Allāh about that *which is not hidden* from Him, meaning the hardships they are facing due to the drought (MB). Complaining *to* Allāh is not something unlikely or detested; rather, it is when one complains *against* Allāh that he does something repugnant (T). So when servants enumerate their problems before their Lord, it is not because He is unaware of them, but because He likes it when His servants mention their difficulties to Him and express their neediness and desperation, seeking His assistance (N). The four things that the Imām then complains about are: *desperate straits* (*‘al-maḍāyiq al-wa‘rah’*) which make life difficult and hard, *devastating drought* (*‘al-maqāḥiṭu al-mujdibah’*) resulting from the parched earth and lack of rainfall, *unattainable needs* (*‘al-maṭālib al-muta‘assirah’*) that have led to extreme indigence, and *difficult tribulations* (*‘al-fitan al-mustaṣibah’*) that have befallen the people. The verb *‘talāḥamat’* means it came upon (R), and attached itself (I). Here, it signifies the various hardships such as hunger, indigence, and all the other trials that afflict one during times of famine (MB).

4 Continuing the supplication, Imām ‘Alī beseeches Allāh not to turn them away disappointed. The term *‘khāibīn’* applies to those who fail to acquire what they seek (T). He further pleads to Allāh not to send them back dejected. The term *‘wājimīn’* refers to those who are so overcome by grief that they are unable to speak (R). Such is their state here because of losing hope in getting what they have sought from the Almighty (MB). *‘Lā tukhāṭibanā bi dhunūbinā’* means do not address us with a response that befits our sins, in a harsh and unyielding manner, when we supplicate to You (I). Similarly, *‘lā tuqāyisana bi ‘mālinā’* means do not make Your response commensurate with our deeds. Or, put differently, do not give us a response that corresponds with the measure of our evil actions, and do not treat

us according to our misdeeds (MB). Finally, the Imām turns to his request for rain, asking Allāh to pour on them His rain and His blessings. The term '*ghayth*' usually refers to rain that falls after a dry spell, when it is missed and needed (T). He further asks that they be granted sustenance and mercy, as well as *a drink which is beneficial, quenching, and irrigating, by which all that had dried up starts growing, and all that had withered comes to life*. Rain is beneficial when it does not cause destruction through flooding, it is quenching when it relieves the thirst of animals and people, and it is irrigating ('*mu'shibah*') when it refreshes and revives, causing vegetation to thrive (MB). In some manuscripts '*nāqī'at al-ḥayā*', which means a quenching rain, has been recorded as '*nāfi'at al-ḥayā*' which means a beneficial rain, and since both signify benefit, we have opted to select the second, more general translation here. Some further qualities of this rainfall are mentioned by the Imām, as he says that it should be one which yields abundant fruit ('*kathīrat al-mujtanā*'), waters the vast plains ('*turwī bihā al-qī'ān*'), causes dried-up rivers and deep valleys to flow ('*tusīlu al-buṭnān*', where *buṭnān* refers to any low or depressed land), makes trees bear plenty of leaves ('*tastawriq al-ashjār*'), and also thereby results in the lowering of costs ('*turkhiṣu al-as'ār*'). Indeed, the outcome of copious rainfall and bumper harvests is that the price of food goes down, since the supply increases and there is more than enough food for everyone. That is, of course, if greedy merchants do not take wrong advantage of the situation to hoard produce, or sell it to outsiders on the black market, and so on. Indeed, we note that in the world today, some of the richest countries in terms of their yields and natural resources are unfortunately also the poorest, because of the avarice of a few individuals and the unsatiable gluttony of other, stronger nations (Z).



THE GUIDES AND THE MISGUIDED

SENDING PROPHETS

- 1 He sent His Messengers with what He designated for them of His revelation, and made them His proof over His creation, so that it would not be necessary to prove to them why they are left with no acceptable excuse [for their disbelief]. So He called them to the right path through the truthful speech [of His Prophets]. Verily, Allāh has fully unmasked the creation, not because He was unaware of what they concealed of their guarded secrets and hidden thoughts, but in order to test which of them is best in deeds, so that divine reward may be a recompense [for their virtues] and divine punishment a chastisement [for their vices].

MERITS OF THE AHL AL-BAYT

- 2 Where are those who claimed that they are the ones who are firmly grounded in knowledge instead of us, [thereby] lying and transgressing against us, for Allāh has elevated us and abased them, bestowed [it] upon us and deprived them, and granted us entry but expelled them. Through us guidance is sought and the blind [heart] seeks clear sight. Verily the Imams are from Quraysh, with their

مبعث الرسل

١ بَعَثَ رُسُلَهُ بِمَا خَصَّهُمْ بِهِ مِنْ وَحْيِهِ،
وَجَعَلَهُمْ حُجَّةً لَهُ عَلَى خَلْقِهِ، لِئَلَّا
تَجِبَ الْحُجَّةُ لَهُمْ بِتَرْكِ الْإِعْذَارِ
إِلَيْهِمْ، فَدَعَاهُمْ بِلِسَانِ الصِّدْقِ إِلَى
سَبِيلِ الْحَقِّ. أَلَا إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَعَالَى قَدْ
كَشَفَ الْخَلْقَ كَشْفَهُ، لَا أَنَّهُ جَهْلَ
مَا أَخْفَوهُ مِنْ مَصُونٍ أَسْرَارِهِمْ
وَمَكْنُونٍ صَمَائِرِهِمْ، وَلَكِنْ لِيَبْلُوَهُمْ
أَيُّهُمْ أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا، فَيَكُونَ الثَّوَابُ
جَزَاءً وَالْعِقَابُ بَوَاءً.

فضل أهل البيت

٢ أَيْنَ الَّذِينَ زَعَمُوا أَنَّهُمُ الرَّاكِبُونَ
فِي الْعِلْمِ دُونَنَا، كَذِبًا وَبَغْيًا عَلَيْنَا،
أَنْ رَفَعَنَا اللَّهُ وَوَضَعَهُمْ، وَأَعْطَانَا
وَحَرَمَهُمْ، وَأَدْخَلَنَا وَأَخْرَجَهُمْ. بِنَا
يُسْتَعْتَبَى الْهُدَى وَيُسْتَجْلَى الْعَمَى.
إِنَّ الْأَيْمَةَ مِنْ قُرَيْشٍ غُرِسُوا فِي
هَذَا الْبَطْنِ مِنْ هَاشِمٍ، لَا تَصْلُحُ

genealogy going back to Hāshim. It does not befit anyone else, nor are other leaders suitable [for the task].

عَلَى سِوَاهُمْ، وَلَا تَصْلُحُ الْوَلَاةُ مِنْ غَيْرِهِمْ.

CONTEXT

Though the details regarding when and where this oration was given have not reached us, commentators note that it was spoken in response to some of the Companions who differed regarding his merit and superiority over them [and indeed over all the Companions] (M). In this sermon, the Imām speaks about the sending of Prophets by Allāh, the merits of the Ahl al-Bayt, and the people of misguidance. Part of this oration has been mentioned by al-Āmidī in *Ghurar al-Hikam wa Durar al-Kalim*, with some additions that are not present in *Nahj al-Balāghah*, thereby showing that he had another source for the sermon (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* mentions sections of this sermon as parts of different, longer orations by the Imām, and it is possible that this oration is comprised of parts from separate speeches by Amīr al-Mu'minīn.

COMMENTARY

1 Though some versions read '*ba'athallāhu rusulahu*' instead of '*ba'atha rusulahu*', the latter form is correct (T), and the pronouns of the first statement clearly refer to the Almighty (MB). Allāh singled out the Messengers and Prophets as recipients of His revelation by which they were to guide the people towards a life of felicity (Z). In this way, they acted as His proofs (*hujaj*) over His creation, so that there may not remain any excuse for them to disbelieve. This is reflected in the verse that states: [They were] Messengers bearing glad tidings and warnings so that humankind would have no excuse before Allāh after [the sending of] the Messengers (Q4:65) (I). The two terms '*lisān al-ṣidq*' and '*sabīl al-ḥaqq*' respectively refer to the words of guidance which are illuminated with truth, and the path that takes humanity towards the Creator (M). When he says that Allāh has fully unmasked the creation, the Imām means that He has made their state known and manifested their condition through the laws He ordained for them, since it is by the extent of their submission to His commands that the level of their felicity or wretchedness

becomes evident (MB). Indeed, Allāh knows His creation better than they know themselves, but He does not punish them for what only lies in their hearts; rather, it is for what they say or do that they will be requited (Z). Hence Imām ‘Alī clarifies that the unmasking of the servants is *not because He was unaware of what they concealed of their guarded secrets and hidden thoughts, but in order to test which of them is best in deeds*. The term ‘*bawā’an*’ means that which is commensurate with the action (T), and it refers to the fair punishment that will be meted out against those who commit misdeeds, in accordance with the justice of Allāh (MB).

2 The Imām then turns to the subject of the merits of the Prophet’s family. He begins by categorically stating that *the ones who are firmly grounded in knowledge* (‘*al-rāsikhūna fī al-‘ilm*’) are none other than the Ahl al-Bayt. All those who claim this position, or a share therein, for themselves or others, have lied and transgressed. Indeed, there is both intellectual and scriptural evidence for this, and traditions to this effect are found in both Shī‘ī and Sunnī sources (MB). The rhetorical question *where are those who claimed that they are the ones who are firmly grounded in knowledge instead of us* alludes to a group of Companions who debated with him regarding merits. Among them were those who claimed that another was more worthy, or better-versed in the Qur’ān, or more learned about the lawful and the forbidden (I). In reality, however, even the enemies of Imām ‘Alī were aware that he was the most firmly grounded in knowledge. That is why some commentators interpret this question by the Imām as a challenge to any claimant who alleges a station in knowledge equal to that of the Ahl al-Bayt (Z). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then states: *Allāh has elevated us and abased them, bestowed [it] upon us and deprived them, and granted us entry but expelled them*, and there are numerous established historical reports and traditions that reflect the truth of this (N). The status of the Ahl al-Bayt was raised, and they were granted the lofty station of Imāmah, which was deprived to others. Likewise, they were the ones admitted into the circle of special divine grace whereas others were expelled therefrom (MB). The Imām further says that it is through the Ahl al-Bayt that guidance is sought and the blind heart *seeks clear sight*. The verb ‘*yustajlā*’ means seeking illumination and unobscured vision (I), and here it refers to dispelling the blindness of falsehood (T). Indeed, the Ahl al-Bayt are like lamp-posts of guidance, by which people find their way in the darkness. They show people the right way through the light of their knowledge, as explained earlier in sermon no. 4. As for his statement regarding the Imāms being from Quraysh, this is something found in a number of

ON THE MISGUIDED FOLK

3 They have preferred this world and deferred the next; they have left the clean water and taken drink from the turbid. It is as though I see their wicked one having associated himself with evil and become intimate with it, having befriended it and conformed to it, until his hair turned grey with it and his nature was indelibly coloured by it. Then he advances, emitting foam like a torrential stream, not caring what it drowns, or like fire kindled in straw, paying no heed to what it burns!

4 Where are the minds that seek enlightenment from the lamps of guidance, and the eyes that gaze at the minarets of piety?! Where are the hearts that were dedicated to Allāh, and committed to the obedience of Allāh?! These people have thronged around worldly vanities and jostled over the unlawful. The banners of Paradise and Hell were raised for them, but they turned their faces away from Paradise and advanced towards Hell by dint of their actions. Their Lord called them but they recoiled and turned away. Yet when Satan called them, they responded and went [towards him].

منها: في أهل الضلال

٣ آتَرَوْا عَاجِلًا، وَأَخَّرُوا آجِلًا،
وَتَرَكُوا صَافِيًا، وَشَرِبُوا آجِنًا،
كَأَنِّي أَنْظُرُ إِلَى فَاسِقِهِمْ وَقَدْ
صَحِبَ الْمُنْكَرَ فَأَلْفَهُ، وَبَسَى بِهِ
وَوَافَقَهُ، حَتَّى شَابَتْ عَلَيْهِ مَفَارِقُهُ،
وَصُبِغَتْ بِهِ خَلَانِقُهُ، ثُمَّ أَقْبَلَ مُزِيدًا
كَالتَّيَّارِ لَا يَبَالِي مَا غَرَّقَ، أَوْ كَوَقْعِ
النَّارِ فِي الْهَشِيمِ لَا يَحْفِلُ مَا حَرَّقَ!

٤ أَيْنَ الْعُقُولُ الْمُسْتَضِيحَةُ بِمَصَابِيحِ
الْهُدَى، وَالْأَبْصَارُ اللَّامِحَةُ إِلَى مَنَارِ
التَّقْوَى؟! أَيْنَ الْقُلُوبُ الَّتِي وَهَبَتْ
لِلَّهِ، وَعُوقِدَتْ عَلَى طَاعَةِ اللَّهِ؟!
ارْذَحَمُوا عَلَى الْخَطَامِ، وَتَشَاخَوْا
عَلَى الْحَرَامِ، وَرَفَعَ لَهُمْ عِلْمُ الْجَنَّةِ
وَالنَّارِ، فَصَرَفُوا عَنِ الْجَنَّةِ
وُجُوهَهُمْ، وَأَقْبَلُوا إِلَى النَّارِ
بِأَعْمَالِهِمْ، وَدَعَاهُمْ رَبُّهُمْ فَتَفَرُّوا
وَوَلَّوْا، وَدَعَاهُمُ الشَّيْطَانُ فَاسْتَجَابُوا
وَأَقْبَلُوا.

traditions from the Noble Messenger himself (MB). The mention of their genealogy *going back to Hāshim* does not mean that it includes all the progeny of Hāshim. Rather, it refers to the Ṭālibiyyīn (from the progeny of Abū Ṭālib) specifically, and not the other branches of Hāshim's descendants, like the Banū

‘Abbās and others (T). In fact, a number of commentators note that it does not even refer to all the Ṭālibiyyīn, but only the chosen members of the Ahl al-Bayt, namely the twelve infallible Imāms (N, MB). Finally, Imām ‘Alī says that the position of Imāmah *does not befit anyone else nor are other leaders suitable* for it. That is because Allāh has purified the Ahl al-Bayt and protected them from error, as clearly mentioned in the Glorious Qur’ān (Q33:33) (Z).

3 Now the Imām begins describing the misguided people. He commences by noting how they prioritize their present life over the Hereafter, which they treat as less important. Some say that the Imām was describing those whom he spoke of in the previous section, namely the Companions who claimed greater merit than the Ahl al-Bayt. Others opine that the Imām was talking about the Banū Umayyah (MB), or a group that would come later in the future (I). In any case, these were individuals who gave preference to this world over the next, turning towards worldly desires and away from that which would improve their state in the Hereafter. They took religion lightly and were iniquitous and unrighteous in their behaviour (Z). Examples of such individuals included al-Mughīrah ibn Shu‘bah, ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ, Marwān ibn al-Ḥakam, and Mu‘āwiyah (M). They chose this world over the next because its pleasures are immediately accessible, whereas the Hereafter is unseen and will come later (MB). In so doing, however, they left the clean water (‘*ṣāfiyan*’) and drank from what was turbid and foul (‘*ājīnan*’). These two terms metaphorically represent the wholesome, unpolluted pleasures and rewards of the Hereafter compared to the fleeting, unwholesome pleasures of this world (M). Indeed, worldly pleasures are often accompanied by maladies and pain, whereas that is not the case with the delights of Paradise (MB). Imām ‘Alī then says that it is as though he could *see their wicked one having associated himself with evil and become intimate with it, having befriended it and conformed to it, until his hair turned grey with it and his nature was indelibly coloured by it*. This could be referring to ‘Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān (T), who was one of the worst and most tyrannical rulers of the Banī Umayyah (N). However, it could also be a general reference to the despotic rulers who would rise from this group (Z), and not any particular individual (M).

The Imām mentions the qualities of this wicked individual, such as his enjoyment of evil as though it was something intimate to him, or a close, familiar friend. Furthermore, the fact that he conforms to such a wicked nature until his hair turns grey figuratively depicts his continual perpetration of evil throughout

his reign, until the end of his life. Thus evil is deeply ingrained in him and is part of his character, just as something indelibly dyed with a colour that can never be separated from it (MB). The verb '*basi'a bihi*' means he became familiar and comfortable with it, and this verb is also used to refer to a she-camel that becomes familiar with a person thereby allowing him to milk it (R). The phrase '*shābat 'alayhi mafāriquhu*' literally means the middle of his head turned grey, and it signifies a lengthy companionship (T). Imām 'Alī provides a further description of this wicked *fāsiq*, comparing him to a torrent ('*al-tayyār*') that drowns anything in its path without concern, or like fire that falls upon straw ('*al-hashīm*'), raging and burning everything without care. These analogies depict an individual who does not care about the consequences of his corruption; one whose reformation cannot even be hoped for, just as a raging fire cannot be controlled (MB). Some commentators have given examples of such behaviour by 'Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān during his rule (T).

4 In the last section of this oration, Imām 'Alī talks about two groups. The first comprises those intelligent and wise people who are Godwary and obedient to Allāh, while the second group are those who hanker after the world and its pleasures, vying for it with each other (N). He poses a rhetorical question to express sorrow, and asks *where are the minds that seek enlightenment from the lamps of guidance, and the eyes that gaze at the minarets of piety?* Thus, he likens the Imāms to the luminous lamps of guidance, and seeking illumination (*al-istiṣbāḥ*) from them could metaphorically mean learning religious tenets and laws from them. He similarly compares the Imāms to beacons or minarets of piety, since through them people are guided out of the darkness of error (MB). He further asks *where are the hearts that were dedicated to Allāh, and committed to the obedience of Allāh?* And these questions have been interpreted by some to signify the absence of Godwariness in his community. It was as though they had no faith to prevent them from the unlawful, out of fear of Allāh, nor did they have any intelligence by which they could at least preserve their honour in front of the people, since their minds and hearts had been overrun by worldly desires (Z). Instead, the people had *thronged around worldly vanities and jostled over the unlawful*. The term '*al-ḥuṭām*' literally means dry, broken fragments (T), and it is also used to refer to the perishing goods and possessions of this world. Here, it has been used to highlight how quickly the worldly wealth they seek perishes and decays (MB).

The verb '*tashāḥḥū*' means they crowded and pushed one another, since they did not want to miss out on the thing they sought (R). Hence they vied and jostled over what was unlawful of this world, not wanting to lose it to anyone else, but they ended up losing their religion and the Hereafter (T). As for the raising of *banners of Paradise and Hell*, some understand it to metaphorically refer to the laws of the *sharīah* that lead one to Paradise, and the temptations of this fleeting world, respectively (M). Others say that the banner of Paradise alludes to all that guides a person to the right path and a felicitous life (Z). However, people are so attached to this world that they turn away, averting their faces from Paradise, and advance instead towards Hell *by dint of their actions*, meaning their evil deeds which earn punishment in hellfire (MB). In response to the call of their Lord, they recoiled and turned away, or they ran away (which is another meaning of '*naḥḥū*'). But when Satan called out to them, they went towards him. This behaviour has been alluded to in a number of verses of the Qur'ān, such as: *...nor can you make the deaf hear the call when they turn their backs [and leave]* (Q30:52) (T). In the end, they will face eternal perdition because they failed to live a 'life based on reason' (*ḥayātun ma'qūlun*) in this world (J).



ABOUT THE WORLD

EVANESCENCE OF THIS WORLD

- 1 O people, in this world you are but a target for the arrows of death. With every gulp there is constriction and with every morsel there is choking! You do not obtain any blessing in it except by foregoing another, and none among you advances in age by a day but through the diminution of another [day] from his life. Nothing new is added to his nourishment but by the consumption of what was there before it of his [allotted] sustenance. No effect is actualized for him except that another ceases to exist for him. Nothing novel is renewed for him except after another new thing becomes old for him. No crop is raised for him unless another has been reaped. Gone are the roots whose offshoots we are, and how long can an offshoot remain after its root has gone?!

CENSURING INNOVATION IN RELIGION

- 2 No innovation is introduced [in the religion] but that a *sunnah* is thereby forsaken. So beware of innovations and stick to the clear road. Verily the old, established ways are the best while the newly invented ones are the worst.

فناء الدنيا

١ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، إِنَّمَا أَنْتُمْ فِي هَذِهِ الدُّنْيَا غَرَضٌ تَنْتَضِلُ فِيهِ الْمَنَابِ، مَعَ كُلِّ جُرْعَةٍ شَرَقٌ، وَفِي كُلِّ أَكْلَةٍ غَصَصٌ! لَا تَتَأَلَوْنَ مِنْهَا نِعْمَةً إِلَّا بِفِرَاقٍ أُخْرَى، وَلَا يُعَمَّرُ مُعَمَّرٌ مِنْكُمْ يَوْمًا مِنْ عُمْرِهِ إِلَّا بِهَدْمِ آخَرٍ مِنْ أَجْلِهِ، وَلَا تُجَدِّدُ لَهُ زِيَادَةٌ فِي أَكْلِهِ إِلَّا بِنَفَادِ مَا قَبْلَهَا مِنْ رِزْقِهِ، وَلَا يَحْيَا لَهُ أَثَرٌ إِلَّا مَاتَ لَهُ أَثَرٌ، وَلَا يَتَجَدَّدُ لَهُ جَدِيدٌ إِلَّا بَعْدَ أَنْ يَخْلُقَ لَهُ جَدِيدٌ، وَلَا تَقُومُ لَهُ نَابِتَةٌ إِلَّا وَتَسْقُطُ مِنْهُ مَحْصُودَةٌ، وَقَدْ مَضَتْ أَصُولُ نَحْنُ فُرُوعُهَا، فَمَا بَقَاءُ فَرْعٍ بَعْدَ ذَهَابِ أَصْلِهِ؟!

منها: في ذم البدعة

٢ وَمَا أُحْدِثَتْ بِدْعَةٌ إِلَّا تُرِكَ بِهَا سُنَّةٌ، فَاتَّقُوا الْبِدْعَ وَالزَّمُوا الْمَهْيَعَ، إِنَّ عَوَازِمَ الْأُمُورِ أَفْضَلُهَا، وَإِنَّ مُحَدَّثَاتِهَا شَرَّارُهَا.

CONTEXT

Since this oration has a general purport, and the Imām aims to make his listeners aware of the flaws and shortcomings of this world in order to lessen their inclination towards it (MB), lack of details regarding its exact context does not pose a problem. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places it within a longer sermon that Imām ‘Alī gave in one of the Friday prayers, which would mean that it was not addressed to any specific group (4:226). Aphorism no. 180 contains a similar message, and some consider it a repetition of this sermon (T). Part of this oration has been mentioned by Ibn Shu‘bah al-Ḥarrānī in *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, and al-Shaykh al-Mufid has also mentioned it, with slight variance, in *al-Irshād*. In his *al-Amālī*, al-Ṭūsī has also mentioned this speech. The two general messages of this sermon pertain to the evanescence of this world, and the evil of innovation in religion (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Amīr al-Mu‘minīn begins by telling the people that in this world, they are *but a target for the arrows of death*. The term ‘*gharaḍ*’ refers to that which is set up as a target for archers to aim and shoot at (I). The similitude he uses here for death is like archers shooting at their target, and the arrows metaphorically represent accidents and maladies. Employing the plural ‘*al-manāyā*’ either signifies the different causes of death, such as drowning, falling off a cliff, etc., or the many people who die, with each individual facing a unique experience upon death (MB). The Imām then points out an important reality of this world, namely that everything around us has a positive aspect and a negative one. Even its food and drink, which we use for nourishment and survival, can become a cause of death for us. Indeed, *with every gulp there is constriction and with every morsel there is choking*, and no one can ever tell whether or not the sip they take will end their life, or the bite of food will choke them to death (Z). Furthermore, even the blessings of this life are such that in order to attain one, another must be foregone or given up. For instance, one who is poor and has no wealth to worry about starts losing sleep over how he should protect his wealth once he is blessed with affluence. Hence, he has to forego peace of mind in order to be rich. And this is true for most worldly bounties (N). The Imām emphasizes this by saying that *nobody advances in age by a day but through the diminution of another from his life*,

and by living for a day, one is essentially deducting it from his lifespan. Indeed, every breath we take brings us a step closer to our graves (T). Moreover, nothing new is added to a person's nourishment but by the consumption and depletion of his allotted sustenance, meaning that one can only eat what has been decreed as part of his provision in this world, and space in the stomach for a new meal is only made available after the previous meal has been digested (Z). Additionally, a new morsel of food can only be eaten after the previous morsel has been masticated and swallowed (I).

The phrase '*lā yaḥyā lahu atharun illā māta lahu atharun*' has been interpreted differently by commentators. Some say '*atharun*' here refers to one's reputation, such that if a person is known at a particular time for a praiseworthy or evil action, that which he was known for prior to this will have been effaced and forgotten (M). Others say since in most cases a person does not gain renown for his work except in old age, it is only when one has lost his youth and vigour that he attains repute and prominence (I). Yet others posit that this phrase means if one leaves behind some heritage, like a book he has written, or an edifice he has built, from which people derive continuous benefit, it is only because he expended and used up those faculties of his mind and body that he possessed (N). Hence, in the most general sense, we could say that *no effect is actualized for him except that another ceases to exist for him*. Likewise, nothing novel is renewed for a person *except after another new thing becomes old for him*. Some read the statement *no crop is raised for him unless another has been reaped* literally, meaning one can only plant new crops after the previously planted ones are harvested (T). Yet others interpret it metaphorically to refer to the cycle of life, where the crops ('*nābitah*') represent one's offspring and what is harvested ('*maḥṣūdah*') represents the old parents and grandparents who die (M). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then poses a rhetorical question and says *gone are the roots whose offshoots we are, and how long can an offshoot remain after its root has gone?* By this, he points to the fact that since all our predecessors passed away, we should not have any false expectations that we will remain forever (N). Imām al-Ṣādiq is reported to have said, "It is amazing to see a people whose predecessors have died, yet when called to depart they are in a state of play and sport!" (T).

2 This section is from another part of the oration in which the Imām warns the people against innovation in religion ('*bid'ah*'). The negative consequences of this has also been discussed in sermon no. 17. One commentator defines *bid'ah* as

anything that was introduced after the time of the Noble Prophet, some of which was good while some was evil (I). However, this definition clearly does not align with what the Imām says here, as he unequivocally states *no innovation is introduced in the religion but that a sunnah is thereby forsaken*. The *sunnah* itself instructs us to eschew innovation and heresy, since the Messenger of Allāh is reported to have said, “Every heresy is a misguidance, and every misguidance leads to the Fire” (MB). Hence Imām ‘Alī warns his listeners to *beware of heresies and stick to the clear road*, which is the path towards which the Book of Allāh and the Noble Prophet guides the people (Z). He emphasizes the matter further by saying that *the old, established ways are the best while the newly invented ones are the worst*. Some suggest that this is because novel ideas and practices give rise to doubt and uncertainty, being outside the prescribed laws and teachings, and thus result in confusion and other negative consequences (M). One commentator says it is likely that the term “*awāzim*”, which means ancient or established (I), is a scribal error and the original term was ‘*qawādim*’, since the opposite of *al-‘azm* is *al-rukḥṣah*, not *al-muḥḍath* (T). Nevertheless, most commentators understand “*awāzim al-umūr*” to refer to those old practices that were established during the time of the Noble Prophet, and about which there can be no doubt (MB, Z). It bears mentioning here that Islam is not against invention in the general sense. It is only innovation in religion that is forbidden, for the reasons mentioned above. Positive innovation in other fields such as science, architecture, medicine, etc. are all lauded and considered steps towards the advancement and progress of humanity as a whole (J).



WHEN CONSULTED BY ‘UMAR IBN AL-KHATTĀB

1 Verily in this matter, victory or defeat is not dependent on how many or few [we are]. It is Allāh's religion which He has made prevail, and His army which He has mobilized and aided, until it reached where it now stands and ascended to its present position. We have a promise from Allāh, and Allāh fulfils His promises and supports His army. The position of the head of state is like that of the thread to the beads: it unites them and connects them. If the thread is broken, the beads will scatter and get lost, then they will never all come together as one again. The Arabs today, even though they are small in number, are great because of Islam and mighty because of their unity!

١ إِنَّ هَذَا الْأَمْرَ لَمْ يَكُنْ نَصْرُهُ وَلَا خِذْلَانُهُ بِكَثْرَةٍ وَلَا بَقَلَّةٍ، وَهُوَ دِينُ اللَّهِ الَّذِي أَظْهَرَهُ، وَجُنْدُهُ الَّذِي أَعَدَّهُ وَأَمَدَّهُ، حَتَّى بَلَغَ مَا بَلَغَ وَطَلَعَ حَيْثُ طَلَعَ، وَنَحْنُ عَلَى مَوْعُودٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ، وَاللَّهُ مُنَجِّزٌ وَعْدَهُ، وَنَاصِرٌ جُنْدَهُ. وَمَكَانُ الْقَيْمِ بِالْأَمْرِ مَكَانُ النَّظَامِ مِنَ الْحَرَرِ: يَجْمَعُهُ وَيُضْمُّهُ؛ فَإِنْ انْقَطَعَ النَّظَامُ تَفَرَّقَ الْحَرَرُ وَذَهَبَ، ثُمَّ لَمْ يَجْتَمِعْ بِحَذَافِيرِهِ أَبَدًا. وَالْعَرَبُ الْيَوْمَ وَإِنْ كَانُوا قَلِيلًا، فَهُمْ كَثِيرُونَ بِالْإِسْلَامِ، عَزِيزُونَ بِالْاجْتِمَاعِ!

CONTEXT

A difference of opinion exists among scholars regarding when the Imām spoke these words to ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb. Some, like al-Madā’inī in his *Kitāb al-Futūḥ*, consider it to have been during the Battle of Qādisiyyah. Others, like al-Ṭabarī, say that it was during the Battle of Nahāwand. Before the Battle of Qādisiyyah, which was fought in 14 AH (or 16 AH), ‘Umar sought advice from the Muslims regarding his personal participation in the battle, and at that time Imām ‘Alī advised him against it, as has been recorded. So ‘Umar agreed and sent Sa’d ibn Abī Waqqāṣ instead as the leader of the Muslim army. In the case of the Battle of Nahāwand, ‘Uthmān advised ‘Umar to gather forces from all the major Muslim cities and then

march out himself to fight the Persians. However, Imām ‘Alī again advised him against going out himself, and he accepted that advice and sent al-Nu‘mān ibn Muqarrin instead (M). Some commentators say the words of this oration were undoubtedly spoken regarding the second encounter of Nahāwand (21 AH), since that has also been corroborated by al-Shaykh al-Mufid in his *al-Irshād*, al-Dīnawarī in his *al-Akhbār al-Ṭiwāl*, and Ibn A‘tham al-Kūfī in his *al-Futūḥ* (T). In any case, according to the title given to this sermon by the compiler, it was the result of the advice ‘Umar sought regarding his own participation in battle against the Persians. Something similar is found in sermon no. 134 where Amīr al-Mu‘minīn advised ‘Umar against marching out to face the Byzantines. After quoting this speech, al-Mufid comments on how the Imām had played such an important role at this sensitive juncture in order to save the Muslims (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Since the companions of ‘Umar assumed that victory would be attained by huge numbers, just like the assumption held by some during the Battle of Ḥunayn (Q9:25) (T), Imām ‘Alī dispelled their incorrect supposition by stating that victory or defeat does not hinge on how large or small their army is. Rather, Allāh causes His religion to prevail, and He has aided the army of believers, *until it reached where it now stands and ascended to its present position*. Some understand the Imām’s words to be in reference to the many battles which Muslims had won despite being outnumbered, especially during the time of the Noble Prophet, such as the Battles of Badr and Aḥzāb (N). The verb ‘*a‘addahu*’ refers to how the Almighty prepared, equipped, mobilized the army of believers, while ‘*amaddahu*’ connotes His support and assistance to the Muslim army as they faced the disbelieving enemy. Allāh’s making His religion prevail refers to causing it to triumph over all the other religions, as that was something Allāh has promised the believers (‘*naḥnu ‘alā mawūdin min Allāh*’) and *Allāh fulfils His promises*. The Imām subsequently turns to the subject of the role of a leader, and he likens the position of the head of state to that of a string of beads. Just as the string unites the beads and holds them together, so too does the ruler gather the people and keep them united (MB). To emphasize the point further, Imām ‘Alī says that *if the thread is broken, the beads will scatter and get lost, then they will never all come together as one again*. That is because once the thread breaks, what was connected and

2 So be like an axle [for them], and rotate the mill with the Arabs. Send them into the flames of war without you, for if you leave this land, the Arabs will [renege on their pledge] and rebel against you from all sides and directions, until the borders you leave behind ungarded will turn into a greater concern than what is in front of you. Verily, if the outsiders see you tomorrow they will say, “He is the root of the Arabs, so if you cut him down, you will [finally] be at peace.” In this way, their vehemence against you will be heightened, as will their eagerness to fight you.

٢ فَكُنْ قُطْبًا، وَاسْتَدِرِ الرَّحَى بِالْعَرَبِ، وَأَصْلِهِمْ دُونَكَ نَارَ الْحَرْبِ، فَإِنَّكَ إِذَا شَخَصْتَ مِنْ هَذِهِ الْأَرْضِ انْتَفَضَتْ عَلَيْكَ الْعَرَبُ مِنْ أَطْرَافِهَا وَأَقْطَارِهَا، حَتَّى يَكُونَ مَا تَدْعُ وَرَاءَكَ مِنَ الْعُورَاتِ أَهَمَّ إِلَيْكَ مِمَّا بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ. إِنَّ الْأَعَاجِمَ إِنْ يَنْظُرُوا إِلَيْكَ غَدًا يَقُولُوا: هَذَا أَصْلُ الْعَرَبِ، فَإِذَا افْتَعَثْنَاهُ اشْتَرَحْتُمْ، فَيَكُونُ ذَلِكَ أَشَدَّ لِكَلْبِهِمْ عَلَيْكَ وَطَمَعِهِمْ فِيكَ.

3 As for what you have mentioned about their having set out to fight against the Muslims, verily Allāh, the Glorified, detests their setting out [against the Muslims] more than you do, and He is more capable of changing what He detests. As for your statement about their [large] numbers, we never fought based on the strength of numbers in the past; rather, we fought with trust in divine support and assistance.

٣ فَأَمَّا مَا ذَكَرْتَ مِنْ مَسِيرِ الْقَوْمِ إِلَى قِتَالِ الْمُسْلِمِينَ، فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سُبْحَانَهُ هُوَ أَكْرَهُ لِمَسِيرِهِمْ مِنْكَ، وَهُوَ أَفْدَرُ عَلَى تَغْيِيرِ مَا يَكْرَهُ. وَأَمَّا مَا ذَكَرْتَ مِنْ عَدَدِهِمْ، فَإِنَّا لَمْ نَكُنْ نُقَاتِلُ فِيَمَا مَضَى بِالْكَثَرَةِ، وَإِنَّمَا كُنَّا نُقَاتِلُ بِالنُّصْرِ وَالْمَعُونَةِ.

organized also breaks up and gets scattered all over. So too would the people be scattered if their ruler is killed by the enemy, and they will be left disoriented and demoralized (M). Their never coming together or becoming whole again is meant as a hyperbole to describe the gravity of the matter (MB). Finally in this section, the Imām notes, possibly as a means of heightening their spirits (N), that even though the Arabs are few in number, they are great by virtue of Islam, and are mighty because of their unity under a single banner (T). The phrase *‘hum kathīrūna*

bil-Islām' literally means they are many by virtue of Islam, and according to some commentators, this multitude (*kathrah*) is actually a metaphor for strength (M).

2 Amīr al-Mu'minīn continues his advice to 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb by telling him that he should be an axle for the people. By this he means that just like the axle remains in its place with the wheel rotating around it, he too should remain in his place in the capital as he sends the army forth to engage the enemy in battle (MB). The phrase '*aṣlihim dūnaka nār al-ḥarb*' literally means cast them into the fire of battle while staying away therefrom. Here, it is meant metaphorically to refer to how he should allow the Muslim army to face the enemy while keeping aloof himself, lest the enemy should harm him (N). The Imām then explains that if he leaves the capital, the Arabs will renege on their pledge and rebel against him from all sides, until the areas left behind by him will turn into a greater concern for him than what lies before him. This threat was real given that the Arabs, especially the nomads among them, were still inclined to some of their corrupt ancient practices. So seeing the opportunity in the absence of the ruler, they would rebel and thereby end up causing a greater headache for 'Umar than what he sought to address by marching out in the first place (M). The term '*al-ʿawrāt*' in the present context refers to the vulnerable locations within Muslim lands (N). Imām 'Alī then gives another reason why 'Umar should remain behind, noting that if the enemy were to see him in the battlefield, they would say to each other, "*He is the root of the Arabs, so if you cut him down, you will finally be at peace.*" In other words, they would desire to kill him, and expend all their efforts to achieve that goal. They refer to him as the cornerstone or root of the Arabs ('*aṣl al-ʿarab*') because through his presence they remain united and steadfast, as a single, organized body (MB). To sum up, two important lessons can be taken from this advice of the Imām. The first pertains to the importance of preserving the life of the ruler, as a social responsibility, since that is what ensures the functioning of an organized society. Enemies are, for this very reason, wont to attack the leaders of any country or faction first and foremost. The second lesson is that as they consider external threats, rulers should simultaneously be wary of internal threats at the hands of hypocrites, rebels, and the like. Sometimes the second type of threat can even pose greater danger than the first (N).

3 In this final section of the sermon, Imām 'Alī responds to two statements made by 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb, as reasons for his having to lead the Muslim army against the Persians. From the response, we can deduce that the statements 'Umar

made were firstly, that an army of Persians was marching against the Muslims, and they were a formidable force that had to be countered. However, Amīr al-Mu'minīn gives a counter-argument saying that Allāh detests their expedition against the Muslims more, *and He is more capable of changing what He detests*. Indeed, the Muslims were shown special grace by Allāh and He would support them against their enemies time and again, as seen in numerous previous battles (N). The second thing that 'Umar had said pertained to the large numbers and vast hoards of the enemy troops. In his response, Imām 'Alī reminded him that Muslims *never fought based on the strength of numbers in the past*; rather, they fought *with trust in divine support and assistance*. In other words, the Imām was telling 'Umar not to fear the large number of enemy forces and the relatively fewer number of Muslim troops, since Allāh was on their side (Z). From historical records we find that 'Umar accepted these arguments presented by Imām 'Alī and stayed behind, keeping away from the fighting himself. In the end, the Muslim army was victorious in the battle against the enemy in this encounter (N).



ON WHAT IS TO COME

THE PURPOSE OF SENDING PROPHETS

- 1 Allāh sent Muḥammad (ṣ) with the truth, so that he would remove His servants from the worship of idols towards His worship, and from obedience to Satan towards His obedience. [He sent him] with the Qurʾān, which He made clear and firm, so that the servants may know their Lord as they were ignorant of Him, and may acknowledge Him after they had denied Him, and may affirm Him after having repudiated Him. So He, the Glorified, revealed Himself to them in His Book, without their having seen Him, by means of what He showed them of His power and frightened them of His wrath, and how He annihilated those whom He did by His chastisement and mowed down those whom He did by His retribution!

الغاية من البعثة

١ فَبَعَثَ اللَّهُ مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ بِالْحَقِّ لِيُخْرِجَ عِبَادَهُ مِنْ عِبَادَةِ الْأَوْثَانِ إِلَى عِبَادَتِهِ، وَمِنْ طَاعَةِ الشَّيْطَانِ إِلَى طَاعَتِهِ، بِقُرْآنٍ قَدْ بَيَّنَّهُ وَ أَحْكَمَهُ، لِيَعْلَمَ الْعِبَادُ رَبَّهُمْ إِذْ جَهِلُوهُ، وَلِيَقْرُؤُوا بِهِ بَعْدَ إِذْ جَحَدُوهُ، وَلِيُثْبِتُوهُ بَعْدَ إِذْ أَنْكَرُوهُ. فَتَجَلَّى لَهُمْ سُبْحَانَهُ فِي كِتَابِهِ مِنْ غَيْرِ أَنْ يَكُونُوا رَأَوْهُ، بِمَا أَرَاهُمْ مِنْ قُدْرَتِهِ، وَخَوْفِهِمْ مِنْ سَطْوَتِهِ، وَكَيْفَ مَحَقَّ مَنْ مَحَقَّ بِالْمَثَلَاتِ، وَاحْتَصَدَ مِنَ احْتَصَدَ بِالنَّقِمَاتِ!

CONTEXT

The main theme of this sermon is the purpose of sending guidance to the people in the form of Prophets (M). Its secondary theme pertains to the future trials and calamities that will befall the people. This is then followed by some beneficial advice by which the believers may remain safe from the clutches of corruption (N). Al-Kulaynī has mentioned his oration in the last volume of *al-Kāfī*, and according to his version, this speech was given by Imām ‘Alī at Dhū Qār, just

before the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH). The author of *Maṣādir Nahj al-Balāghah* opines that sermon no. 237 is part of this oration, and so is aphorism no. 91. Furthermore, he notes that some sayings from Imām al-Ḥasan found in works like *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl* also incorporate a number of points from this sermon (2:327). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this within a longer oration by the Imām which was known by the title ‘al-Makhzūn’ (4:11).

COMMENTARY

1 Amīr al-Mu’minīn first discusses the purpose behind sending the Noble Messenger, and by extension all the Prophet and Messengers, to guide the people. He notes that it was *so that he would remove His servants from the worship of idols towards His worship, and from obedience to Satan towards His obedience*. The Prophet’s mission was to purify the hearts of the people and remove love and attachment of the world from them, as well as inclination towards base desires and the following of whims and caprice. He was to instead encourage them to pursue a path of virtue and righteousness (MB). The term ‘*al-awthān*’ is plural of *al-wathan*, which is defined as anything that has a body fashioned from the minerals of earth, or from stone or wood, and has a form similar to that of a human being, that is then erected and placed somewhere so as to be worshipped. Some say that it is synonymous with *al-ṣanam*, while others say the latter refers to an image but without a sculpted form (T). In the version of this sermon mentioned by al-Kulaynī, the Imām states that the goal of sending the Messenger was *to remove His servants from the worship of His [other] servants towards His worship... and from obedience to His servants towards His obedience* (N). Allāh also sent with the Noble Prophet *the Qur’ān, which He made clear and firm*, so that people may know their Lord, acknowledge Him, and accept Him. Through the clear teachings of the Qur’ān and the evidence presented therein, the false beliefs and practices of the idolators were repudiated (N). Through its clarity, and the unambiguous nature of its teachings, which lacked any discrepancy or contradiction, the people who turned to it were guided aright. Furthermore, the beauty and eloquence of the Qur’ān penetrated deep into their hearts and transformed them into strong believers – those who were no longer ignorant of their Lord (MB). Imām ‘Alī then adds that Allāh, the Exalted, *revealed Himself to them in His Book, without their having seen Him*, by showing them His power and frightening them of His wrath.

Indeed, the stories of earlier nations mentioned in the Qurʾān, and their fate, serve as both admonition for people as well as a means of making the might of Allāh known to them (I). The verb *'tajallā'* is understood by some commentators to refer to how the Almighty introduces Himself in the verses that speak about His Oneness, or His attributes (N). Others have alternatively suggested that the term *'kitāb'* in this context is meant metaphorically and refers to all that He has created, for indeed by observing the beautiful creation of Allāh, we become aware of the greatness and wisdom of the Creator (MB).

If *'kitāb'* is taken to mean the Qurʾān, as it more likely does, then the phrase *frightened them of His wrath* (*'khawwafahum min saʿwatihī'*) refers to the verses of warning and those containing frightening accounts of previous nations that were destroyed with terrible punishments (N). The manifestation of the divine in these verses may be intellectual, or even something deeper. Consider the account of al-Walīd ibn al-Mughīrah, who was an elderly, respected leader of the Arabs during the Age of Ignorance, known for his eloquence. Once, the elders of Quraysh went to al-Walīd and spoke to him against the Noble Prophet, asking him to investigate what he was reciting: was it poetry or words of soothsayers? Al-Walīd responded that he would listen to it and inform them, and then he approached the Prophet and asked him, "Recite your poetry to me." The Messenger of Allāh replied, "It is not poetry; rather, these are the worlds of Allāh..." Then he recited Sūrah Fuṣṣilat, and when he came to the verse: *But if they turn away, then say, "I have warned you of a [mighty] thunderbolt, like the thunderbolt of ʿĀd and Thamūd"* (Q41:13), al-Walīd began to tremble, and all the hair on his body stood up. He rushed to his house and did not go back to the Quraysh. When Abū Jahl later went to him, al-Walīd denied having accepted the religion of Islam, but expressed his amazement at the Qurʾān and how it had affected him. Not being able to describe the Qurʾān as poetry or soothsaying, al-Walīd told the Quraysh that they should consider it sorcery (T).

2 The Imām now turns to informing people about what would happen in the future. He tells them that after him, a time would come *when there will be nothing more obscured than the truth, nothing more apparent than falsehood, and nothing more prevalent than lies against Allāh and His Prophet*. Some commentators say this refers to the period of the Banū Umayyah, for scholars have noted how it was during their reign that ḥadīth fabrication became common (I). It will be an age where, the Imām says, *no commodity will be deemed more unprofitable than the Qurʾān when it is recited as it ought to be recited*, meaning that nothing will be

THE FUTURE

2 Verily, after me, a time will come upon you when there will be nothing more obscured than the truth, nothing more apparent than falsehood, and nothing more prevalent than lies against Allāh and His Prophet. For the people of that time, there will be no commodity more unprofitable than the Qurʾān when it is recited as it ought to be recited, nor anything in greater demand than it when its meanings are distorted. And in the towns, there will be nothing more unrecognizable than virtue, nor anything more familiar than vice!

3 The bearers of the Book will cast it away and its memorizers will act as those who have forgotten it. In those days, the Book and its people will be expelled and exiled – two companions keeping each other's company on one path, with no one offering them shelter. Thus, at that time the Book [of Allāh] and its followers will be amongst the people yet not among them, and alongside them but not with them, because misguidance cannot be in harmony with guidance, even if they come together. So the people will unite upon division and will break away from community, as though they are the leaders of the Book instead of the Book being their leader. Thus, nothing of it will remain with them save its name,

الزمان المقبل

٢ وَإِنَّهُ سَيَأْتِي عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِي زَمَانٌ لَيْسَ فِيهِ شَيْءٌ أَخْفَى مِنَ الْحَقِّ، وَلَا أَظْهَرَ مِنَ الْبَاطِلِ، وَلَا أَكْثَرَ مِنَ الْكُذِبِ عَلَى اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ، وَلَيْسَ عِنْدَ أَهْلِ ذَلِكَ الزَّمَانِ سِلْعَةٌ أَبْوَرُ مِنَ الْكِتَابِ إِذَا تَلَّيَ حَقَّ تِلَاوَتِهِ، وَلَا أَتْفَقَ مِنْهُ إِذَا حُرِّفَ عَنْ مَوَاضِعِهِ، وَلَا فِي الْبِلَادِ شَيْءٌ أَنْكَرَ مِنَ الْمَعْرُوفِ وَلَا أَغْرَفَ مِنَ الْمُنْكَرِ!

٣ فَقَدْ نَبَذَ الْكِتَابَ حَمَلَتُهُ وَتَنَاسَاهُ حَفَظَتُهُ؛ فَالْكِتَابُ يَوْمَئِذٍ وَأَهْلُهُ مَنفِيَّانِ طَرِيدَانِ، وَصَاحِبَانِ مُضْطَجِبَانِ فِي طَرِيقٍ وَاحِدٍ، لَا يُؤْوِيهِمَا مُرُوءٌ؛ فَالْكِتَابُ وَأَهْلُهُ فِي ذَلِكَ الزَّمَانِ فِي النَّاسِ وَلَيْسَا فِيهِمْ، وَمَعَهُمْ وَلَيْسَا مَعَهُمْ، لِأَنَّ الضَّلَالَةَ لَا تُوَافِقُ الْهُدَى وَإِنْ اجْتَمَعَا، فَاجْتَمَعَ الْقَوْمُ عَلَى الْفُرْقَةِ، وَافْتَرَقُوا عَنِ الْجَمَاعَةِ، كَأَنَّهُمْ أُنْمَةُ الْكِتَابِ وَلَيْسَ الْكِتَابُ إِمَامَهُمْ، فَلَمْ يَبْقَ عِنْدَهُمْ مِنْهُ إِلَّا اسْمُهُ، وَلَا يَعْرِفُونُ

and they will know nothing but its script and its writing. Before that, they will have inflicted all forms of torment on the virtuous, called their truth about Allāh false allegations, and imposed for virtues the punishment of vices.

- 4 Those before you were only destroyed by their lengthy aspirations and their turning a blind eye to death, until the promise, in which excuses are rejected, repentance cannot be sought, and chastisement and retribution befalls, came to pass for them.

إِلَّا خَطَّهٖ وَزَيَّرَهُ، وَمِنْ قَبْلُ مَا
مَثَّلُوا بِالصَّالِحِينَ كُلَّ مَثَلَةٍ، وَسَمَّوْا
صِدْقَهُمْ عَلَى اللَّهِ فِرْيَةً، وَجَعَلُوا فِي
الْحَسَنَةِ عُقُوبَةَ السَّيِّئَةِ.

۴ وَإِنَّمَا هَلَكَ مَنْ كَانَ قَبْلَكُمْ بِطُولِ
أَمَالِهِمْ وَنَعْيَبِ آجَالِهِمْ، حَتَّى نَزَلَ
بِهِمُ الْمُؤْعُودُ الَّذِي تُرَدُّ عَنْهُ
الْمُعْذِرَةُ، وَتُزْفَعُ عَنْهُ التَّوْبَةُ،
وَتَحُلُّ مَعَهُ الْقَارِعَةُ وَالنَّقْمَةُ.

considered as having less worth than the proper recitation of the Book of Allāh. This connotes the disinterest of people when it comes to reading the Qurʾān in the right way, and interpreting its message correctly. That is because the teachings of the Glorious Book will go against the whims and desires of most of the people of that time, since they will be followers of caprice and falsehood (MB). The terms ‘*sil’ah*’ and ‘*abwar*’ respectively mean an article of merchandise or a commodity, and something that is corrupted, ruined, or unsaleable (I), and here they figuratively represent how little worth the true teachings of the Qurʾān will have to the people of that era. Conversely, nothing will be *in greater demand than it when its meanings are distorted*, because the corrupted meanings will be in line with what people desire (MB). An example of this is seen when Muʿāwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān once sent written instructions to all towns forbidding the people from mentioning the merits of ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib and his progeny. Ibn ‘Abbās asked Muʿāwiyah, “Do you prevent us from reciting the Qurʾān?” He said, “No.” That was when Ibn ‘Abbās told him that the Qurʾān was revealed upon the household of the Noble Messenger, so one could not know the meaning of its verses except by referring to the Ahl al-Bayt, and in so doing, they would automatically become aware of the merits of ‘Alī ibn Abī Ṭālib. Muʿāwiyah said, “You may recite any of it as long as it does not concern what was revealed about you (the Ahl al-Bayt)!” (T).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn subsequently says that this will be a time when *there will be nothing more unrecognizable than virtue, nor anything more familiar than vice!* Since people will have become slaves to their base desires, they will hate anything virtuous. On the other hand, they will espouse different vices, clinging on to them in order to attain whatever they yearn for. This situation will become so prevalent that evil will start being considered praiseworthy, whereas good will be deemed something ugly and detested (MB). This reversal is reflected clearly in a tradition attributed to the Noble Messenger, who is reported to have said to his companions, "How will you be when your womenfolk and youth become corrupt, yet you abstain from enjoining good and forbidding evil?" They said, "Will that truly happen?" He said, "Yes; and something even worse. How will you be when you enjoin evil and forbid good?" They asked, "Will that truly happen?" He said, "Yes; and something worse still. How will you be when you consider evil to be good, and good to be evil!?" (T).

3 The Imām then describes how people of this future time will behave towards the Book of Allāh. He says that those who had upheld the Qur'ān, and were its bearers (*'ḥamalatuḥu'*), will cast it away and those who have memorized it *will act as those who have forgotten it*. The phrase *'tanāsāḥu ḥafāẓatuhu'* literally means that the memorizers will pretend to have forgotten it, and here it refers to how those who have committed the Qur'ān to memory will turn a blind eye to it and purposely ignore its commandments and proscriptions (M). It will be a time when those who act on the Qur'ān will be banished and driven out. The two adjectives *'manfiyyān ṭarīdān'* have been transposed in some manuscripts (I), and mean to be exiled and driven away respectively (N). The Qur'ān and those who adhere to it will be like *two companions keeping each other's company on one path, with no one offering them shelter*. As the people of that time will be averse to right guidance, they will dislike the Book of Allāh and those who follow it. Hence, not only will they repudiate them, but they will also seek to cause them distress and harm (MB). Since *misguidance cannot be in harmony with guidance*, the Qur'ān and its followers will be amongst the people yet not among them, they will be alongside them but not with them. This means while they will physically be together in one community, they will remain detached from each other in spirit (T). The Imām further states that the people of that time will *unite upon division and will break away from community*, meaning they will agree upon dissent and disagree upon accord (N). Alternatively, it could mean that they will agree with each other in

their separation from the truth, and will sever ties with its followers (T). They will act as *though they are the leaders of the Book instead of the Book being their leader*, distorting its meanings and changing its teachings to fit their own ideas and corrupt goals instead of submissively following its injunctions as one would obey his leader (MB). As a result, nothing of the Qurʾān will remain with them save its name, and *they will know nothing but its script and its writing*.

The term ‘*zabr*’ means that which is written (R), and here it refers to the text of the Qurʾān (T). In another tradition reported from the Noble Messenger and Imām ‘Alī, they said, “A time will come upon the people when nothing will remain among them of the Qurʾān save its script, and of Islam save its name. Their mosques on that day will be well built edifices, but desolate in terms of guidance...” (Z). Indeed, people did write the Qurʾān with the best forms of calligraphy, and even included gilded decorations on the margins thereof, and made fanciful covers from different materials, expending much effort and time, and spending huge sums. They would pass on those treasured *maṣāḥif* from generation to generation, and even use them on occasion to recite the Qurʾān. However, they neglected to act upon the teachings of the Holy Book. Such an action is akin to placing a life-saving remedy in a decorated bottle but never opening it to use the medicine in order to heal the sick (N). A question that could be asked here pertains to what the righteous people would do at such a time – would they remain silent and take no action? The last sentence of this section may be seen as a reply to this very question. The phrase ‘*before that*’ refers to the time just prior to the state described by the Imām, *they will have inflicted all forms of torment on the virtuous, called their truth about Allāh false allegations, and imposed for virtues the punishment of vices*. This is the reason why the virtuous would not openly speak out against what they witnessed later. Commentators have discussed the exact period this was referring to. Some say it was a reference to the early days of Umayyad rule, and scholars have given examples of how Muʿāwiyah killed many of the Muhājirīn and Anṣār, numbering in their thousands. The same continued with the subsequent rulers from the Banū Umayyah, like the accursed Yazīd, ‘Abd al-Malik ibn Marwān, and his henchman al-Ḥajjāj (N). Others posit that the conditions mentioned came about later during the rule of the Banū ‘Abbās (MB).

4 Amīr al-Muʾminīn now warns the people by recounting to them the causes that led to the annihilation of previous nations. He notes that it was primarily because of *their lengthy aspirations and their turning a blind eye to death*. They

harboured long, worldly hopes and ambitions, while at the same time neglecting their diminishing lifespans. The phrase *'taghayyubi ājālihīm'* connotes forgetting or becoming negligent regarding their eventual death, such that it becomes absent from their thoughts (MB). Some commentators have suggested that the annihilation being referred to here is a spiritual kind of perishing, and it connotes being misguided from the right path. However, it is more likely that it includes both material as well as spiritual annihilation, examples of which can be seen in the case of the evildoers at the time of Prophets Nūḥ and Lūṭ (N). The term *promise* (*'al-mawūd'*) means death, and when it comes, all excuses and apologies will be rejected, and the door of repentance will be closed, just as the Qur'ān states: *But repentance is not for those who continue doing evil deeds until, when death approaches any of them, he says, "Indeed now I repent," nor for those who die while they are disbelievers* (Q4:18) (M). What awaits them is only *chastisement and retribution*. The term *'al-qārī'ah'* refers to a catastrophe or great adversity which befalls someone suddenly (R) and *'al-niqmah'* here refers to retribution (*intiqām*) for their misdeeds (T).

5 Having warned the people about the consequences of long aspirations, the Imām now speaks about what would guide them to felicity and success. He tells them that whoever *seeks welfare from Allāh is successful*. The phrase *'man istanṣaḥallāha'* means one who takes Allāh as his *nāsiḥ*, meaning well-wisher or adviser, and listens attentively to His words and follows His instructions (MB). Others understand the phrase to simply connote being obedient to Allāh, knowing that He will only guide one towards what is best for him, and forbid him from that which is harmful (I). Furthermore, the Imām says that whoever *takes His word as a guide is led towards what is most upright*, without any doubt; unlike all other guides, for whom the possibility of misguidance always exists, intentional or otherwise (Z). Subsequently, Imām 'Alī notes that the success attained by seeking Allāh's counsel (*istinṣāḥ*), and the guidance achieved by following His word, leads one to attain His proximity and become *Allāh's neighbour* (*'jārullāh'*). And Allāh's neighbour is always safe and secure, while His enemy is always worried and scared. That is because the latter has, by his disobedience, been abandoned to his own devices and has thus gone astray, distancing himself from the Almighty and placing himself in grave danger thereby (MB). Alternatively, it could mean that one who is close to Allāh is safe from His chastisement, while one who challenges Him is never safe from His wrath (Z).

ADVISING THE PEOPLE

- 5 O people, verily he who seeks welfare from Allāh is successful, and he who takes His word as a guide is led towards what is most upright, for indeed Allāh's neighbour is secure while His enemy is afraid. It does not behove one who recognizes His greatness to consider himself great, for verily the eminence of those who know of His greatness is in their humility before Him, and the safety of those who know of His power is in their submission to Him. So do not flee from the truth as the healthy person flees from the scabbed, or the sound one from the sick.

عظة الناس

٥ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، إِنَّهُ مَنِ اسْتَشْصَحَ اللَّهَ وَفَقَّ، وَمَنِ اتَّخَذَ قَوْلَهُ دَلِيلًا هُدِيَ لِلَّتِي هِيَ أَقْوَمُ؛ فَإِنَّ جَارَ اللَّهِ آمِنٌ وَعَدُوُّهُ خَائِفٌ، وَإِنَّهُ لَا يَنْبَغِي لِمَنْ عَرَفَ عَظَمَةَ اللَّهِ أَنْ يَتَعَظَّمْ، فَإِنَّ رِفْعَةَ الَّذِينَ يَعْلَمُونَ مَا عَظَمَتُهُ أَنْ يَتَوَاضَعُوا لَهُ، وَسَلَامَةَ الَّذِينَ يَعْلَمُونَ مَا قُدْرَتُهُ أَنْ يَسْتَسْلِمُوا لَهُ، فَلَا تَنْفِرُوا مِنَ الْحَقِّ نِفَارَ الصَّحِيحِ مِنَ الْأَجْرَبِ وَالْبَارِي مِنْ ذِي السَّقَمِ.

- 6 Know that you will never recognize right guidance unless you recognize the one who has abandoned it, and you will never abide by the covenant of the Book unless you recognize the one who has violated it, and you will never hold on to it unless you recognize the one who has cast it aside. So seek this from those who possess it, for indeed they are the life of knowledge and death of ignorance. They are the ones whose judgment apprises you of their knowledge, their silence of their speech, and their exterior of their interior. They neither go against the religion nor do they differ about it, for it is among them as a truthful witness and a silent speaker.

٦ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّكُمْ لَنْ تَعْرِفُوا الرُّشْدَ حَتَّى تَعْرِفُوا الَّذِي تَرَكَّهُ، وَلَنْ تَأْخُذُوا بِمِيثَاقِ الْكِتَابِ حَتَّى تَعْرِفُوا الَّذِي نَقَضَهُ، وَلَنْ تَمَسَّكُوا بِهِ حَتَّى تَعْرِفُوا الَّذِي نَبَذَهُ؛ فَالْتَمِسُوا ذَلِكَ مِنْ عِنْدِ أَهْلِهِ، فَإِنَّهُمْ عَيْنُ الْعِلْمِ وَمَوْتُ الْجَهْلِ، هُمْ الَّذِينَ يُخْبِرُكُمْ حُكْمُهُمْ عَنْ عِلْمِهِمْ، وَصَمْتُهُمْ عَنْ مَنْطِقِهِمْ، وَظَاهِرُهُمْ عَنْ بَاطِنِهِمْ، لَا يَخَالِفُونَ الدِّينَ وَلَا يَخْتَلِفُونَ فِيهِ، فَهُوَ بَيْنَهُمْ شَاهِدٌ صَادِقٌ وَصَامِتٌ نَاطِقٌ.

The Imām subsequently tells the people that it is not proper for one who recognizes the greatness of Allāh to aggrandize himself. The verb '*yataʿazzam*' means self-glorification or considering oneself great. Indeed, a creature like the human being, who is totally dependent on his Sustainer for everything, has no cause for arrogance and conceit (T). Moreover, the Imām explains that true eminence for those who know of the greatness of Allāh lies *in their humility before Him*. It is this humility which causes an individual's status to become elevated, until he arrives at a position of eminence and greatness among all of creation in this world and in the Hereafter (MB). The Imām then continues in the same vein and declares that *the safety of those who know of His power is in their submission to Him*, meaning that the security of those who know of the unlimited power of Allāh lies in their submission to Him (Z). The verb '*yastaslimū*' comes from *al-istislām*, which connotes obedience and submission. It is one of the traits of a true believer, and its opposite is *al-istikbār*, which is manifest arrogance (MB). Imām 'Alī then tells the people not to flee from the truth *as the healthy person flees from the scabbed, or the sound one from the sick*. People usually keep a distance from anyone suffering from scabies, because it is a skin disease that is contagious (T). It is an infection of the skin caused by mites, and is characterized by intense itching and the formation of vesicles and pustules. By giving these examples, the Imām is depicting the most intense form of aversion and repulsion (MB). Indeed, people usually turn away from the truth because it is often heavy to bear, and requires patience and forbearance (Z).

6 The Imām then explains how right guidance can be recognized. He states that the only way to know guidance is to recognize those who have abandoned it, and the only way to abide by *the covenant of the Book* ('*mīthāq al-kitāb*') is to recognize those who have violated it, and the only way to hold fast to the Qur'ān is to know those who have cast it aside. Indeed, a well-known dictum states that things are known by their opposites (*turāf al-ashyā bi-ḍdādhā*), so the true meaning of health is only known in sickness, and the true meaning of light is only appreciated in darkness, and so on (N). The meaning of abiding by the covenant of the Book of Allāh means acting upon its teachings and injunctions (Z). The difference between the three groups of errant individuals mentioned here is clear. One group abandoned the truth, but without necessarily denigrating it, another has broken the pledge of the Book of Allāh, and the third has cast aside the Qur'ān, thereby considering the truth unimportant (N). The imperative *seek this from those*

who possess it means seek knowledge of the Qurʾān from the people of the Qurʾān, namely the Ahl al-Bayt (Z). Alternatively, it could mean seek all that has been mentioned, including the truth, right guidance, and adherence to the pledge of the Book, from those who possess these traits, and by that the Imām was referring to himself and the pure ones from his progeny (MB). That is because they are *the life of knowledge and death of ignorance*, since the knowledge of the Noble Prophet has been passed down to them, and wherever they are, they spread its light and tear off the veils of ignorance (N). Describing the people of the Qurʾān, Imām ‘Alī says that they are those whose judgments reveal their knowledge and apprise the people of how learned they are. The term ‘*ḥukmuhum*’ can refer to either their rulings pertaining to religious laws as ordained by the Almighty, or their judgments in legal cases that are brought before them, such as personal disputes and the like. In any case, the judgements that issue forth from them show how deeply learned and profoundly knowledgeable they are (MB).

As for their silence informing the people *of their speech*, it means that even their silence conveys meaning, since they never remain quiet out of ignorance or speechlessness. Rather, they know when to speak and when it is more effective to remain silent (Z). Some have suggested that ‘*manṭiqihim*’ here refers to their reasoning or intention (N), but most commentators understand it to mean their speech, since silence is itself a ‘language’ in the sight of those possessed of wisdom. Indeed, it conveys both prudence and discernment, such that when one then speaks, his words are valued and taken seriously and with reverence (MB). The Imām further says that their exterior informs the people of their interior, or, put differently, their outward aspect apprises people of their inner being (‘*bāṭinihim*’). This means that they are not people who pretend, or who act contrary to what they believe or feel, like hypocrites. Rather, what is in their hearts is congruent with what is outwardly seen from them (T). Alternatively, it means that the virtuous actions they perform outwardly reveal their inward merits (MB). Finally, the Imām notes that *they neither go against the religion nor do they differ about it*, meaning they always follow the commandments of Allāh and adhere to His laws. Their not differing about religion is further evidence that they have knowledge about Islam and the *sharīʿah*, and since the path is only one, they follow it to the letter and do not differ regarding it (M). The pronoun ‘it’ in the phrase *it is among them as a truthful witness and a silent speaker* may refer to the Qurʾān (M), or the religion (MB), but since both outwardly represent the same thing, it does not change the

meaning in either case (T). It is a *truthful witness* (*‘shāhidun ṣādiq’*) in that they consider it unimpugnable and rely upon it completely, just as one would trust a veracious witness (I). Alternatively, it is a truthful witness that testifies to their complete harmony with religion and how they never differ regarding it (MB), or their lofty station in the eyes of Allāh (Z). And it is a silent speaker (*‘ṣāmitun nāṭiq’*) because religion does not speak for itself and needs one to speak on its behalf (I).



ON THE PEOPLE OF BAṢRAH

- 1 Each of the two wishes the matter was his, drawing it towards himself to the exclusion of his comrade. They neither connect to Allāh through a [firm] rope, nor move closer to Him through any means. Each of them bears malice against his comrade, and shortly the veil will be lifted from it! By Allāh, if they achieve what they desire, one of them will rip the other apart, and this one will pounce on that one.
- 2 The rebellious party has arisen, so where are those who reckon upon divine reward?! The precedents have already been set for them and they have been given the news beforehand. For every misguidance there is a cause and every traitor has a pretext. By Allāh, I shall not be like one who listens to the sound of mourners striking their chests, hears the caller who brings news of death, and visits the bereaved.

١ كُلُّ وَاحِدٍ مِنْهُمَا يَرْجُو الْأَمْرَ لَهُ، وَيَعْطِفُهُ عَلَيْهِ دُونَ صَاحِبِهِ، لَا يَمْتَنَانِ إِلَى اللَّهِ بِحَبْلِ، وَلَا يُمَدِّدَانِ إِلَيْهِ سَبَبٍ. كُلُّ وَاحِدٍ مِنْهُمَا حَامِلٌ ضَبًّا لِصَاحِبِهِ، وَعَمَّا قَلِيلٍ يُكْشَفُ قَنَاعُهُ بِهِ! وَاللَّهِ لَئِنْ أَصَابُوا الَّذِي يُرِيدُونَ لَيَنْتَزِعَنَّ هَذَا نَفْسَ هَذَا، وَلَيَأْتِيَنَّ هَذَا عَلَى هَذَا.

٢ قَدْ قَامَتِ الْفِتْنَةُ الْبَاغِيَّةُ، فَأَيْنَ الْمُحْتَسِبُونَ؟! فَقَدْ سُنَّتْ لَهُمُ السُّنَنُ، وَقُدِّمَ لَهُمُ الْخَبَرُ، وَلِكُلِّ ضَلَّةٍ عَلَّةٌ، وَلِكُلِّ نَاكِثٍ شُبْهَةٌ. وَاللَّهِ لَا أَكُونُ كَمُسْتَمِعِ الدَّمِ، يَسْمَعُ النَّاعِي وَيَحْضُرُ الْبَاكِ.

CONTEXT

The title of this oration refers to those who rose against Amīr al-Mu'minīn in the Battle of Jamal, which was fought outside Baṣrah in 36 AH. This sermon was given before the battle took place, and in it the Imām reveals the true motives behind the rebellion against him by Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr, though he does not mention the third instigator, who was 'Ā'ishah bint Abī Bakr. However, in other

versions of this narration, he does mention her as well (T). He notes that even though they seemed united in their stance, if any of them had the opportunity to gain power at the expense of the other, he would do so. In the second half of the sermon, Imām ‘Alī warns the people against rebellion and its negative consequences which would beset them if they rose up wrongfully. Before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, this sermon was narrated by Abū Mikhnaḥ in his book on the Battle of Jamal, which was apparently accessible to Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd. Al-Shaykh al-Mufīd has also related it in his *Kitāb al-Irshād*, with noticeable differences in wording (N). Since the title mentions the people of Baṣrah in general, one commentator takes exception and says that it should have been titled, ‘On Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr when they marched to Baṣrah,’ since the oration is not about Baṣrans as such (T).

COMMENTARY

1 The dual pronouns used in this section refer to Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr, and the Imām exposes their true intent behind breaking their oaths of allegiance to him and rebelling. It was for nothing other than gaining political power, and even the caliphate, for themselves. Since each of the two considered himself more worthy than the other, if they had achieved victory in battle, they would have eventually fought each other for it (MB). The word ‘*al-amr*’ is translated as *the matter*, and here it refers to sovereignty and rulership, and each of these two individuals saw himself as more deserving than the other for this position (Z). Interestingly, it has been reported that they differed openly before the battle had begun, and even disagreed on who among them would lead the prayer. It was ‘Ā’ishah who then stepped in and appointed their sons, Muḥammad ibn Ṭalḥah and ‘Abdullāh ibn Zubayr, to take turns in leading the people in prayer. Many such instances of falling-out between the two have been reported, and in most of the cases it was ‘Ā’ishah who patched things up between them (I). The Imām then mentions the reason for this behaviour, saying that it was because *they neither connect to Allāh through a firm rope, nor move closer to Him through any means*. The verb ‘*yamuttānī*’, from the root *matta*, literally means to pull, and was used to describe the act of drawing water from a well with a bucket and rope. Later, it came to connote bringing oneself closer to something, and here this meaning is intended (N). Though *any means* translates ‘*sababīn*’, the term also means cord or rope, and the phrase could thus also be translated as *a cord by which they are*

attached to, or reach, Him. Both these expressions signify the same thing, namely that Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr did not come out for the sake of Allāh, but only for worldly gain (Z). Alternatively, it means that neither of them have any excuse before Allāh for breaking their oaths and rebelling against the Imām (MB).

Yet despite their agreement in rebellion, Imām ‘Alī notes that *each of them bears malice against his comrade*, meaning they harbour rancour against each other. The phrase ‘*ḥāmīlu ḍabb*’ means he carries feelings of latent spite in his heart (R). To the Arabs the term *ḍabb* had many meanings, including a certain species of lizard with a spiny tail that is said to devour its young, and would hence be used as a metaphor for the ultimate betrayal (M). The Imām goes on to say that this malice between them would become evident *and shortly the veil will be lifted from it*. Some commentators note that all the worldly people are this way, and their outward cooperation and agreement is only because they all love the world, so they stand opposed to those who deem it insignificant. However, in their hearts they are bitter rivals and have hatred and envy for each other (T). The term *veil* (‘*qinā’*’) has been employed here because it hides their internal feelings like a curtain (MB). And indeed, this is exactly what happened. Al-Zubayr left the battle remorseful, as Ṭalḥah continued calling out to him to remain steadfast and censuring him for leaving the fight. As such, each of them disparaged the other: one for continuing the illegitimate fight, and the other for cowardly abandoning it (Z). Subsequently, the Imām notes that even in the hypothetical situation of their attaining what they sought, namely political authority (T), *one of them will rip the other apart, and this one will pounce on that one*. It was unavoidable, since rulership cannot be shared by two individuals, so if they had achieved what they desired, and taken authority away from the Imām, they would surely have fought among themselves until one had killed the other. As the Arabs say, “*al-mulku ‘aqīm*,” meaning dominion knows no friend or kin (I).

2 The Imām then turns to the people and urges them to rise up to face the oath-breaking rebels. To motivate them, he rhetorically asks, *the rebellious party has arisen, so where are those who reckon upon divine reward?! The term ‘al-muḥtasibūn’* refers to those who patiently strive in the way of Allāh, seeking only His pleasure and reward. He refers to the enemy as *the rebellious party* because that is how the Noble Prophet had spoken about them when foretelling these events (T). Some commentators interpret this rhetorical question as an expression of sadness by the Imām as he missed the early Muslims who had been strong and

steadfast (MB). It has also been pointed out that though the title '*al-fi'atu al-bāghiyah*' was more commonly applied to Mu'āwiyah and his followers, since the Noble Messenger is reported to have told 'Ammār ibn Yāsir, "You will be killed by a rebellious faction (*taqtuluka al-fi'at al-bāghiyah*)," it also applies to the rebels in the Battle of Jamal, since they had risen in rebellion against a legitimate ruler (N). As for the precedents having been set for them and their receiving the news beforehand, it means that the believers had already been shown how rebels must be dealt with. And the news being referred to is the statement of the Messenger of Allāh to Imām 'Alī informing him of the three groups who would come out against him (Z).

Then, to answer the question that some might ask, 'If the Prophet had forewarned the people about this group, how is it that they still rose up and joined forces in rebellion against the Imām?' Amīr al-Mu'minīn states that *for every misguidance there is a cause ('illah') and every traitor has a pretext*. The cause of their misguidance in this case was worldly desires for power and authority, as noted earlier (N). Some have interpreted '*illah*' to mean justification, in which case the first phrase means that every misguidance has a justification in the eyes of the one who is misguided, to which the latter resorts in order to absolve himself from error and wrongdoing. According to this reading, the justification presented by the rebels was avenging the blood of 'Uthmān (Z). However, Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr had no justification or excuse for rebellion, since they were the ones who participated in killing 'Uthmān, and they had no pretext since there was nothing wrong done by the Imām that would give them a reason for rising up against him (T). In fact the matter was very clear, and it was undoubtedly a case of insurgency against a lawful ruler by a deviant and misguided lot (MB). Finally, Imām 'Alī says that he would not be like the one who sits idly, listening to the sound of mourners striking their chests, hearing the caller who brings news of death, and visiting the bereaved, but still does not take lesson from all of this. The term '*al-ladm*' means to strike and it is commonly used to describe how women lament the dead by striking their chests (T). However, according to the simile used in sermon no. 6, it also refers to the sound of striking pebbles thrown near a hyena, which nevertheless continues to remain asleep and unmoved by the sound (MB). It means that the Imām would not remain silent after learning of their uprising, and continue to observe passively until they attack him suddenly (M).

The *news of death* which was brought to him refers to information regarding how ‘Ā’ishah, Ṭalḥah, al-Zubayr, and their followers had fought his governor in Baṣrah, ‘Uthmān ibn Ḥunayf, and killed many of his companions, among whom was Ḥakīm ibn Jabalah al-‘Abdī. At first ‘Ā’ishah had ordered them to kill ‘Uthmān ibn Ḥunayf but when one of the women present adjured her and reminded her that he was the Prophet’s Companion, she changed her mind and ordered him to be imprisoned instead. They tortured him and singed his beard, eyebrows, and eyelashes. They whipped him forty lashes and kept him locked up as a prisoner. It was when word of this reached the Imām that he expressed his unwillingness to silently stand by in the face of such oppression (Z). In some manuscripts, the phrase ‘*thumma lā ya’tabir*’, which is translated as *yet still does not take lesson*, is found at the end of this section. Some commentators opine that it must have been in the marginal notes which later got mistaken for part of the text of the sermon (T).



BEFORE HIS DEATH

1 O people, every individual will meet what he flees from during his flight. Death is the destination to which the soul is driven, and running away from it is the same as going towards it. How many days I have spent searching for the secret of this matter, but Allāh willed it to remain hidden. Far be it! It is concealed knowledge!

2 As for my last will: For Allāh – never associate anything with Him, and for Muḥammad (ṣ) – do not disregard his Sunnah. Establish these two pillars and light these two lamps. You shall be free of blame as long as you do not break away [from the truth]. Each one of you has been made responsible to the extent of his ability, and the burden has been lightened for the ignorant, for you have a merciful Lord, an upright faith, and a learned leader. Yesterday I was your companion, today I am a lesson for you, and tomorrow I shall separate from you. May Allāh forgive me and you! If the step remains steady in this slippery place, then so be it. But if the foot slips, then it is because we were in the shade of branches, the path of blowing winds, and under the canopy of clouds whose layers fade

١ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ، كُلُّ امْرِئٍ لَاقٍ مَا يَفِرُّ مِنْهُ فِي فِرَارِهِ، الْأَجَلُ مَسَاقُ النَّفْسِ، وَالْهَرَبُ مِنْهُ مُوَافَاتُهُ. كَمْ أَطَرَدْتُ الْأَيَّامَ أَبْحَثُهَا عَنْ مَكْنُونِ هَذَا الْأَمْرِ، فَأَبَى اللَّهُ إِلَّا إِخْفَاءَهُ، هَيْهَاتَ! عِلْمٌ مَخْزُونٌ!

٢ أَمَّا وَصِيَّتِي: فَاللَّهُ لَا تُشْرِكُوا بِهِ شَيْئًا، وَمُحَمَّدًا ﷺ فَلَا تُضَيِّعُوا سُنَّتَهُ، أَفِيْمُوا هَذَيْنِ الْعُمُودَيْنِ، وَأَوْقِدُوا هَذَيْنِ الْمِصْبَاحَيْنِ، وَخَلَاكُمْ ذَمٌّ مَا لَمْ تَشْرُدُوا، حُمِّلْ كُلُّ امْرِئٍ مِنْكُمْ مَجْهُودَةً، وَخُفِّفَ عَنِ الْجَهْلَةِ، رَبُّ رَحِيمٌ، وَدِينٌ قَوِيمٌ، وَإِمَامٌ عَلِيمٌ. أَنَا بِالْأَمْسِ صَاحِبُكُمْ، وَأَنَا الْيَوْمَ غَبْرَةٌ لَكُمْ، وَغَدًا مُفَارِقُكُمْ، غَفَرَ اللَّهُ لِي وَلَكُمْ! إِنْ تَثَبَّتِ الْوُطْأَةُ فِي هَذِهِ الْمَرَلَةِ فَذَاكَ، وَإِنْ تَدَخَضَ الْقَدَمُ فَإِنَّا كُنَّا فِي أَفْيَاءِ أَغْصَانٍ، وَمَهَابِّ رِيَّاحٍ، وَتَحْتَ ظِلِّ غَمَامٍ، أَضْمَحَلَّ فِي الْجَوِّ مُتَلَفِّفُهَا، وَعَفَا فِي الْأَرْضِ مَحْطُهَا.

away in the sky, and whose traces disappear in the earth.

- 3 I was only a neighbour, with my body remaining in your company for a few days, and you will shortly be left with my lifeless corpse: still after movement and silent after speech. So let my quiet stillness, the closing of my eyes, and the motionlessness of my limbs be a lesson for you, for indeed it is more of an admonition for those who take lesson than eloquent speech and a clear word. My farewell to you is the valediction of one who is prepared to meet [his Lord]. Tomorrow you will look [back] at my days, and my intentions will be revealed to you, and you will then understand me, after my place is vacant and my station is occupied by someone else.

۳ وَإِنَّمَا كُنْتُ جَاراً جَاوَرَكُم بِدَنِي
أَيَّاماً، وَسَتُعَقَّبُونَ مِنِّي جُثَّةً خَلَاءَ:
سَاكِنَةً بَعْدَ حَرَكَ، وَصَامِتَةً بَعْدَ
نُطْقٍ، لِيُعْظَكُم هُدُوءِي، وَخُفُوءُ
إِطْرَاقِي، وَسُكُونُ أَطْرَافِي، فَإِنَّهُ
أَوْعَظُ لِلْمُعْتَبِرِينَ مِنَ الْمُنْطِقِ
الْبَلِيغِ وَالْقَوْلِ الْمُسْمُوعِ. وَدَاعِي
لَكُمْ وَدَاعُ امْرِئٍ مُرْصِدٍ لِلتَّلَاقِي،
عَدَا تَرَوْنَ أَيَّامِي، وَيَكْشِفُ لَكُمْ
عَنْ سَرَائِرِي، وَتَعْرِفُونَنِي بَعْدَ خُلُوءِ
مَكَانِي، وَقِيَامِ غَيْرِي مَقَامِي.

CONTEXT

These words were spoken by Amīr al-Mu'minīn in Kūfah, in the year 40 AH, while he was on his deathbed. According to what has been reported by al-Kulaynī in *al-Kāfi*, it contains part of his testament to Imām al-Ḥasan after he had been fatally struck and those around him asked him to make his final testament. So he requested a pillow to be folded up and then, leaning on it, he gave this address (T). There are three sections in this oration; the first is about the inevitability of death, the second comprises some short yet profound advice, and the last section has lessons that people can learn from the Imām's martyrdom, and how they would only realize his true value once he was no longer amongst them. This sermon has been reported in a number of other early sources such as *al-Kāfi*, *Murūj al-Dhahab* by al-Mas'ūdī, and *Maqtal Amīr al-Mu'minīn* by Ibn 'Asākir. Another part of this oration is found in letter no. 23 of *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). In the version recorded

by the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah*, Imām al-Bāqir reported that after being struck, Imām ‘Alī leaned on the pillar of the masjid, and as blood was flowing down from his head, he gave a short sermon, part of which has been adduced here. As he did so, the people began to weep loudly, just the way they had done when the Noble Messenger passed away from this world (4:695).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening statement of this oration is a reminder of the inescapability of death. The statement *every individual will meet what he flees from during his flight* means that even as a person seeks to flee death during his lifetime, his death will nonetheless meet him, just as he is fleeing it. Indeed, as long as one is alive, he is in a state of fleeing his death, for his lifetime can be considered a period of flight from death (MB). Yet nobody can outrun death, and the Qur’ān tells us: *Say, “Verily the death from which you flee will surely meet you...”* (Q62:8) (T). The Imām then describes death as *the destination to which the soul is driven* (*‘al-ajal masāq al-naḥs’*). If the term *‘al-ajal’* is taken to mean the end of one’s life, then *‘masāq al-naḥs’* means the destination or goal towards which one is driven. However, if *‘al-ajal’* is understood as the remaining lifespan of an individual, then *‘masāq al-naḥs’* refers to the time taken to drive the soul to its end, for the time that remains of one’s life in this world is equal to the time it takes to drive him to his death (MB). Furthermore, *running away from it is the same as going towards it*, meaning there is no way to outrun death, as it will come upon us regardless if we run eastwards or westwards, and it makes no difference whether we are moving or stationary (Z). No matter what we do to evade death, all our efforts use up the time allotted to us and waste away the moments and days of our prescribed lifespan, which in turn brings us closer to our death (M). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then comments that he had spent many days *searching for the secret of this matter* but to no avail. The verb *‘aṭradtu’* is considered a more intense form of *ṭaradtū* (R), from the root *ṭarada* which means to cast away (N) or drive off (MB). It is as if the Imām is speaking about the days as though they were individuals whom he banished and expelled (I). Thus did he spend many days of his life seeking to find the answer to the mystery, *but Allāh willed it to remain hidden*.

The secret matter being referred to by the Imām is his martyrdom and the details thereof, specifically when exactly it would take place (M). Indeed, the

Noble Prophet had informed Imām ‘Alī that he would be martyred, but he did not tell him when that would happen. So the Imām waited anxiously for the day to come (Z). This fact does not contradict the narrations regarding his interpreting the various signs that pointed to his last night in this world, such that he even informed his daughter Umm Kulthūm of it before leaving her house to lead the prayer on the fateful day. That is because Allāh had only hidden the details of the matter from him, so that things would take their course as ordained. An example that illustrates this reality is how Prophet Ya‘qūb was able to smell the scent of Yūsuf from a great distance when Allāh wanted to join him with his son, but he could not see him in the well when Allāh desired to separate him from his son (T). Others have opined that the mystery being referred to by the Imām here was the secret behind the overpowering of truth by falsehood and the reason behind the usurping of the rights of the Ahl al-Bayt, which was something hidden from the people (MB). Given that the Imām calls this *concealed knowledge* (*‘ilmun makhzūn*), some commentators posit that he was referring to the general inaccessibility of knowledge of one’s time and place of death. However, general rules have exceptions, and it is quite possible for the Almighty to grant this knowledge to some of His chosen friends (N).

2 Imām ‘Alī then turns to his final testament, stating first and foremost that no partners should ever be ascribed to Allāh, and the *sunnah* of the Noble Messenger should never be abandoned. By this he meant that all actions should be performed sincerely for Allāh, and His commandments and prohibitions should be obeyed (MB). Given that the Prophet’s *sunnah* encompasses all the teachings of Islam, including ritual praxis, moral ethics, and social contracts and conventions, his instruction generally requires complete adherence to the teachings of the religion (N). These are the two pillars that he tells the people to establish, and the two lamps he asks them to kindle. The analogy used here is apt because just as pillars keep the tents and buildings erect, and lamps illuminate the darkness for one to find his way, so too do the belief in *tawhīd* and acting upon the *sunnah* of the Prophet keep one’s faith upright and keep him guided aright (M). The phrase *you shall be free of blame as long as you do not break away* has been linked by most commentators to the previous statement, meaning as long as you do not break away from *tawhīd* and the *sunnah* in your actions (I). Alternatively, it means that as long as they do not differ with each other and continue holding on to the rope of the Ahl al-Bayt, there will be no blame upon them (MB). The verb

‘*tashrudū*’ comes from *sharada*, and is used to describe a refractory camel or horse that breaks loose and runs away at random (T).

The Imām then tells them that each of them *has been made responsible to the extent of his ability, and the burden has been lightened for the ignorant*, meaning that Allāh has only assigned each individual what he can bear, and has made the load lighter for those who are ignorant and weak (R). Thus the level of responsibility is in proportion to the knowledge and cognizance of an individual, and the ignorant are not tasked with carrying the same burden as the learned (MB). A tradition that reflects this states that an ignorant person will be forgiven seventy mistakes before a learned person is forgiven a single mistake (T). Indeed, the Qur’ān also tells us: *Allāh does not task any soul but to the extent of its ability* (Q2:286) (N). The Imām then tells the people that they have *a merciful Lord, an upright faith, and a learned leader*. When the Messenger of Allāh once saw a mother coddling her infant, he told his companions, “Do you see how this mother loves her child?... Allāh is more compassionate with His servants than she is towards her baby!” (Z). The religion is described as *upright* (‘*qawīm*’) because there is no crookedness in it, and by *learned leader* the Imām was referring to the divinely appointed leader during every period, including the Noble Prophet himself. Or he was talking specifically about the Prophet only (MB).

Imām ‘Alī then turns to those present and says that yesterday he was their companion, today he is a lesson for them, and tomorrow he shall leave them. Here the Imām contrasts his past, present, and future, reminding them of how he had earlier fought alongside them, and managed their affairs with sincerity and goodwill. They now saw him lying on his deathbed, unable to move, and that was a lesson for them to heed (Z). He also foretold his death and that he would soon leave them behind, since the term ‘*ghadan*’ can be used for the next day or sometime in the future (N). The general prayer for divine pardon *may Allāh forgive me and you* appears here in some manuscripts, but in others, it comes before the phrase *yesterday I was your companion* (T). The Imām subsequently says *if the step remains steady in this slippery place, then so be it*, meaning if I regain my health and recover from this injury, then that is what you seek (Z). He describes this world as a *slippery place* because there is no steadiness in it, and at any moment one can fall into its calamities and hardships. The word ‘*al-murād*’ is appended to ‘*fa dhāka*’ in one of the early manuscripts, in which case instead of *so be it*, the translation would be *that is what is sought [by you]* (T). *But if the foot slips*, meaning if he passes

away (MB), *then it is because we were in the shade of branches*, and one's life flies past as quickly as the waning of a shadow as the sun declines (Z), and *the path of blowing winds*, for just as a flickering flame is put out by a gust of wind, so too does the life of a person come to an end due to the winds of calamity that befall him (T). The Imām further gives the analogy of being *under the canopy of clouds whose layers fade away in the sky, and whose traces disappear in the earth*, by which he means that it is not surprising if he dies, for they are in a world that quickly perishes and whose traces disappear, just like the phenomena he mentions. In a way, he is expressing his lack of concern, as he was never expecting to remain in this world and hence had not attached himself to it (MB). At the same time, he was also advising those whom he addressed that they too should keep themselves detached from it and eschew love for worldly gains and pleasures (T).

3 Imām 'Ali now begins reminding those who are present about certain important realities that they should always be aware of, and tells them that he was *only a neighbour* to them, remaining physically in their company for a while. The implication here is that his spirit was linked to higher realms, even while he was physically in the world (MB). It could also be a reference to his disinclination towards this world and remaining in it (M). He subsequently tells the people that they will soon be left with his lifeless corpse: *still after movement and silent after speech*. Even though dead bodies no longer move or speak, their presence conveys the most important lesson for people. It is reported that one of the soldiers of the Macedonian king Alexander commented when he saw his lifeless corpse, "He has moved us with his stillness!" Indeed, whoever derives no lesson from such a scene is truly an ignorant individual (Z). The Imām himself alludes to this when he tells them *so let my quiet stillness, the closing of my eyes, and the motionlessness of my limbs be a lesson for you, for indeed it is more of an admonition for those who take lesson than eloquent speech and a clear word*. The phrase '*khufūtu iṭrāqī*' connotes lack of movement of eyes that are downcast, due to weakness of the eyelids. Another version reads '*khufūtu aṭrāfi*' which signifies the immobility of the limbs (T). The Imām describes this as a more efficacious admonition that what is conveyed through speech because people are generally influenced more by what they witness with their own eyes than what they hear about, even if it is spoken very eloquently (M). Subsequently, he bids them farewell, and notes that his valediction is that *of one who is prepared* for the meeting, meaning the meeting with Allāh, his Lord (I). He was indeed prepared for the judgment and recompense

of the Hereafter (Z). Finally, Imām ‘Alī tells the people that on the morrow, once he is no longer in their midst, they will look back on his life (*‘tarawna ayyāmī*) and come to realize his greatness, which many had taken for granted. The phrase *‘yukshafu lakum ‘an sarā’irī* means my innermost thoughts and intentions will be unveiled for you, and by this he meant they will realise that he only fought those battles during his caliphate for the sake of Allāh, and to prevent the spread of corruption in the land, even though during his lifetime some had wrongly surmised that he sought to hold on to political authority (I).

Indeed, it was only after Amīr al-Mu’minīn had left this world, and his place was occupied by others who were evil and corrupt, that people realized his true merits and station (Z). There are numerous historical accounts that testify to this late realization. For instance, the report about the noble lady Dārimah al-Ḥajūniyyah being summoned by Mu‘āwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān is quite telling. The latter said to her, “I have summoned you to ask why you love ‘Alī and hate me?” After insisting that she respond, Dārimah said that it was due to Imām ‘Alī’s justice and his equal distribution of public funds among the people that she loved him, and she hated Mu‘āwiyah for having rebelled and fought one who was the rightful ruler, seeking what was not his to take. Then she began to list the merits of Imām ‘Alī. In the end, Mu‘āwiyah asked if she wanted anything, so she said, “A hundred red camels, saddled, and with their cameleer.” After he had granted her request, Mu‘āwiyah quipped, “Had ‘Alī been alive, he would never have granted your request.” She replied, “No indeed! [His justice was such that] he would not bestow even a hair from the wealth of the Muslims!” (T).



ON FUTURE EVENTS AND THE MISGUIDED

- 1 They took to the right and the left as they strayed into erroneous ways and abandoned the paths of right guidance. So do not seek to hasten that which shall be and is awaited, and do not deem delayed what the morrow brings. For how many a person has been hasty for that which if he were to attain, he would wish that he never got it; and how close today is to the dawning of tomorrow!
- 2 O people, this is the time when every promised event shall come to pass, and that which you know not will soon become visible. Verily, whoever among us is present during it will move through it with a bright lamp and tread on the footsteps of the virtuous, so as to unfasten the noose, free the slaves, divide the united, and unite the divided. He will be in occultation from the people; the tracker will not see his trail even if he searches with his keen gaze. Then a group of people will be sharpened in it like the sharpening of blades by a blacksmith. Their sight will be brightened by the revelation, and its interpretation will reverberate in their ears, and they will drink from the cup of wisdom in the evening [again] after the morning!
- ١ وَأَخَذُوا يَمِينًا وَشِمَالًا ظَنَنَّا فِي مَسَالِكِ الْغَيِّ، وَتَزَكَّى لِمَذَاهِبِ الرُّشْدِ؛ فَلَا تَسْتَعْجِلُوا مَا هُوَ كَائِنٌ مُرْصَدٌ، وَلَا تَسْتَبْطِنُوا مَا يَجِيءُ بِهِ الْغَدُ، فَكَمْ مِنْ مُسْتَعْجِلٍ بِمَا إِنَّ أَدْرَكَهُ وَدَّ أَنَّهُ لَمْ يُدْرِكْهُ، وَمَا أَقْرَبَ الْيَوْمَ مِنْ تَبَاشِيرِ غَدٍ!
- ٢ يَا قَوْمُ، هَذَا إِبَّانٌ وَرُودٌ كُلِّ مَوْعُودٍ، وَدُنُوءٌ مِنْ طَلْعَةٍ مَا لَا تَعْرِفُونَ، أَلَا وَإِنَّ مَنْ أَدْرَكَهَا مِمَّا يَسْرِي فِيهَا بِسَرَّاجٍ مُنِيرٍ، وَيَحْدُو فِيهَا عَلَى مِثَالِ الصَّالِحِينَ، لِيُحْلِلَ فِيهَا رِقْقًا، وَيُعْتِقَ فِيهَا رِقْقًا، وَيَصْدَعَ شُعْبًا، وَيَشْعَبَ صَدْعًا، فِي سُتْرَةٍ عَنِ النَّاسِ لَا يُبْصِرُ الْقَائِفُ أَثَرَهُ وَلَوْ تَابَعَ نَظْرَهُ. ثُمَّ لَيُشْحَذَنَّ فِيهَا قَوْمٌ شَحَذَ الْفَنِّ النَّضْلَ، تُجْلَى بِالتَّنْزِيلِ أَبْصَارُهُمْ، وَيُزَمَّى بِالتَّفْسِيرِ فِي مَسَامِعِهِمْ، وَيُغَبِّقُونَ كَأْسَ الْحِكْمَةِ بَعْدَ الصَّبُوحِ!

CONTEXT

According to the title of this oration, it is one in which Imām ‘Alī mentions certain epic future events and describes some of the misguided factions. Out of the three sections of the sermon, the first speaks of those who have diverged from the straight path. The second mentions a difficult future time when only those who follow the Ahl al-Bayt will be able to proceed in guidance. In the third and final section, the Imām speaks of yet another misguided group who separated from the path of the close friends of Allāh. The only other early source that mentions part of this sermon is *al-Mustarshid fī Imāmat Amīr al-Mu’minīn* by al-Ṭabarī. The latter notes that the actual sermon was quite lengthy and this is only an excerpt thereof (N). Though details about the context of this sermon are not available, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places it within a much longer oration given by Amīr al-Mu’minīn only a few days before his martyrdom, in Kūfah, in the year 40 AH (4:625).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening statement alludes to a group of people who had abandoned the main pathway of truth and opted to follow divergent paths on the right or left (R). A tradition from Imām al-Šādiq names some of the deviant sects that “went astray, right and left, from the straight path,” including the Murji’ah, the Khawārij, and the Qadariyyah (T). Some have understood his saying that *they strayed into erroneous ways and abandoned the paths of right guidance* to refer to their taking up extremist positions and abandoning the teachings of the Qur’ān and Sunnah (M). Amīr al-Mu’minīn then advises the people not to seek the hastening of *that which shall be and is awaited*, and not to consider *what the morrow brings* as delayed or slow to arrive. By this he is either referring to the divine chastisement that would befall the deviant groups (R), or the rise of the awaited Mahdī (T), or generally the trials and tribulations that the Noble Messenger had foretold for the End Times (M). The Imām then explains why they should not seek the hastening of this, though it is something that is undoubtedly bound to come to pass. He says that *many a person has been hasty for that which if he were to attain, he would wish that he never got it*, since everything has its appropriate time, and specific conditions need to be met before something can transpire. It is like a fruit which, if picked before it ripens, would only lead to regret and loss (N). One commentator

suggests that this statement was specifically addressing those companions of the Imām who sought to march out quickly against the Syrians, their goal being the acquisition of spoils and material wealth (R). Those who say that the Imām is referring to the rise of the Qā'im quote the tradition attributed to Imām al-Bāqir which states that if people knew what the awaited Imām would do when he came, many of them would wish they were not present there... And then he describes how the Mahdī would put many hypocrites to the sword (T). However, it is more likely that the Imām was making a general point, for it is commonly found that people seek to hasten things without understanding the harm that it would bring in its wake (MB). Then, perhaps as a means of assuring his listeners, the Imām says *how close today is to the dawning of tomorrow*, meaning what was sought by them would indeed come soon (M). The term '*tabāshūr*' is often used to describe the first streaks of light at daybreak (I).

2 Imām 'Alī then tells the people the time when all that has been promised will indeed come. The word '*ibbān*' means time, and it is commonly used to express how near the time of a particular event is (R). Some commentators interpret this as a reference to the Day of Judgment and the tribulations that will occur prior to it (I), while others say it refers to the trials that would occur after the Imām's demise, such as the tyranny of Banū Umayyah and Banū 'Abbās, since the statement *this is the time when...* evidently points to something that would transpire shortly (T). There are also differences regarding what he was alluding to by the statement *that which you know not will soon become visible*. Some say that this refers to the just rule of the Mahdī which will uproot all injustice from the world (N), while others suggest that it is about the unknown and hence unrecognized terrors that would occur just before the Day of Judgment, such as the rise of the Dajjāl, and so on (I). It has been suggested that this lack of clarity is due to how al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has taken only excerpts of the Imām's words, which has made it difficult to understand the context of his speech here (MB). In any case, since a variety of different tribulations were foretold for the future, occurring during each era, some of them would take place while one of the Imāms of the Ahl al-Bayt was present among the people (Z). Hence Amīr al-Mu'minīn describes how the Infallible Imām who is present during that time *will move through it with a bright lamp and tread on the footsteps of the virtuous*. Some have interpreted this *bright lamp* ('*sirājin munūr*') as a metaphor for the merits of the soul and the perfect qualities possessed by the Infallibles, including their knowledge and lofty morals

(M). Alternatively, it is a euphemism for the light of *wilāyah* which can never go dark or lead one astray from the path of guidance (MB). The *virtuous* (*‘al-ṣāliḥīn’*) refers to the Prophets and their legatees (*awṣiyā’*) (Z), and their practice was to *unfasten the noose, free the slaves, divide the united, and unite the divided*. Unfastening the noose, or loosening that which is bound, is considered by some to mean that they remove the doubts that constrict the souls (M). The term *‘ribq’* refers to a rope that is tied with loops to place around the necks of animals in order to tether them (T). The slaves and those in bondage whom they free figuratively refers to the oppressed people whom they save from their oppressors (MB), or the ignorant and misguided whom they free from their state through the light of guidance (Z). The act of dividing the united, and uniting the divided pertains to the enemies and the friends of the Ahl al-Bayt respectively, and though some commentators state that it is the Mahdī who will do all this (R, N), others say that all the Imāms of the Ahl al-Bayt did this (T).

The following description seemingly supports the former opinion, since the Imām says that *he will be in occultation from the people; the tracker will not see his trail even if he searches with his keen gaze*, and we know that the awaited Imām is indeed in occultation. However, it is still possible to interpret this more generally to mean that whenever any Imām does these things, it is mostly carried out secretly without people knowing who has done it. That is because his intention is to attain the pleasure of Allāh and not to gain notoriety among the people (Z). The term *‘al-qā’if* refers to a tracker who can read the signs and traces, as well as footprints (T). If the awaited Imām is intended here, the fact that no tracker will see his trail emphasizes how hidden he will be, such that it would be impossible to reach him, even if a search is carried out with all the means available (MB). On the other hand, if it refers to all the Imāms of the Ahl al-Bayt, then this highlights how they are unknown among the people, except to those whom they introduce themselves as divinely appointed guides. To the rest, they are seemingly ordinary individuals (M). Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī notes that a group among the people will *be sharpened in it like the sharpening of blades by a blacksmith*. The term *‘al-qayn’* means blacksmith, and *‘al-naṣl’* refers to the iron blade of a sword or dagger (T). Some commentators suggest that this analogy depicts the great resolve that will be granted to a group to fight against the forces of misguidance during these future times (I). Others say it refers to ‘sharpening of the wits’ such that the minds of one group will be made more capable of discernment and understanding the various

kinds of knowledge and wisdom (M). Based on the first interpretation, the *group* ('*qawm*') refers to the helpers and companions of the Mahdī, and if the second interpretation is taken, then the *group* refers to the scholars of the Muslim nation who have developed themselves and trained their souls (MB).

The Imām then mentions some other qualities of this group, saying *their sight will be brightened by the revelation and its interpretation will reverberate in their ears, and they will drink from the cup of wisdom in the evening after the morning*. One commentator suggests that these traits were present in those who were trained by the Imāms, and he gives the example of the students of Imām Ja'far al-Ṣādiq, many of whom attained a mastery of various sciences after being taught by him (Z). According to the description, these would be individuals for whom the darkness of doubt and uncertainty would be dispelled through the illumination of the Qur'ān, as they get to hear the correct exegesis of the Qur'ān from those who have knowledge of it (*ahl al-dhikr*) (MB). As a result, the realities are unveiled for them and penetrate their hearts, thereby giving them access to difficult matters and mysteries (I).

3 This last part of the sermon contains statements that are apparently unclear, and the commentators have understood them differently. That is because of the qualities described as well as the pronouns used in it. Some attribute the apparent discrepancies to the way al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has excerpted parts of the sermon. In any case, this section contains information about people, from the period of Jāhiliyyah up to the time of the Noble Messenger, whom the Imām divides into three groups: the misguided, those of weak faith, and the strong, courageous believers (N). Regarding the first of these, he states that *their term was prolonged so that their disgrace would be complete* and they became deserving of *the calamitous changes* that befell them. The term '*al-ghiyar*' refers to those blessings that are altered thereby leading to hardship (I), or any difficult thing that befalls people, changing their state for the worse (N). If one were to ask how giving them respite and lengthening their lives could result in completion of their disgrace, the answer is that the prolonged term they were granted was used by them to fall even deeper into error and heedlessness, and to commit more sins. And since carrying out misdeeds results in disgrace and the removal of blessings, that is why the time they were given led to their ignominious end (MB). This was until the appointed end of that term came, and a group *sought comfort through strife and raised their weapons from fighting them*. The phrase '*ikhlawlaqa al-ajal*' denotes the approach

ALSO: ON MISGUIDANCE

- 3 Their term was prolonged so that their disgrace would be complete and they deserved the calamitous changes [that would befall them]; until the appointed end was reached, and a group of people sought comfort through strife and raised their weapons from fighting them. [As for the righteous believers,] they did not consider their patience to be a favour to Allāh and did not regard sacrificing their lives in the way of truth as great. Until such a time when it was decreed that the period of trial should come to an end, they lifted their wisdom upon their swords and sought nearness to their Lord through the command of their admonisher. Until when Allāh took [the soul of] His Prophet (ﷺ), a group turned back on their heels. They were ruined by the ways [of misguidance] and placed their trust in [deceitful] confidants, kept ties with other than the kin, abandoned the link [to the Prophet] whom they had been ordered to love, and shifted the edifice [of leadership] from its firm foundation and built it in an improper place. They are the mines of every misdeed and the doors of all who strike forth in ignorance. They moved to and fro in bewilderment, staggering in intoxication, as was the way of the people of the Pharaoh: either cut off to

منها: في الضلال

٣ وَطَالَ الْأَمْدُ بِهِمْ لِيَسْتَكْمِلُوا
الْخِزْيَ، وَيَسْتَوْجِبُوا الْغَيْرَ؛ حَتَّى
إِذَا اخْلُوتَ الْأَجَلُ، وَاسْتَرَاحَ
قَوْمٌ إِلَى الْفِتَنِ، وَاشْتَالُوا عَنْ
لِقَاحِ حَرْبِهِمْ، لَمْ يَمْنُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ
بِالصَّبْرِ، وَلَمْ يَسْتَغْظِمُوا بِذَلِكَ
أَنْفُسَهُمْ فِي الْحَقِّ؛ حَتَّى إِذَا
وَأَفَقَ وَارِدُ الْقَضَاءِ انْقِطَاعَ مُدَّةِ
الْبَلَاءِ، حَمَلُوا بِصَائِرِهِمْ عَلَى
أَسْيَافِهِمْ، وَذَانُوا لِرَبِّهِمْ بِأَمْرِ
وَاعِظِهِمْ؛ حَتَّى إِذَا قَبَضَ اللَّهُ
رَسُولَهُ ﷺ، رَجَعَ قَوْمٌ عَلَى
الْأَعْقَابِ، وَغَالَتْهُمْ السُّبُلُ،
وَأَكَلُوا عَلَى الْوَلَانِجِ، وَوَصَلُوا
غَيْرَ الرَّحِمِ، وَهَجَرُوا السَّبَبَ
الَّذِي أُمِرُوا بِمَوَدَّتِهِ، وَنَقَلُوا
الْبِنَاءَ عَنْ رِصِّ أَسَاسِهِ فَبَنَوْهُ فِي
غَيْرِ مَوْضِعِهِ. مَعَادِنُ كُلِّ حَاطِيَّةٍ،
وَأَبْوَابُ كُلِّ ضَارِبٍ فِي غَمْرَةٍ،
قَدْ مَارُوا فِي الْحَيْرَةِ، وَذَهَلُوا
فِي السَّكْرَةِ، عَلَى سُنَّةٍ مِنْ آلِ
فِرْعَوْنَ: مَنْ مُنْقَطِعٍ إِلَى الدُّنْيَا

lean only on this world, or separated from the faith and opposed to it.

رَاكِبِينَ، أَوْ مُفَارِقِينَ لِلدِّينِ
مُبَايِنِينَ.

of an appointed time, and here it means that the period of those misguided people who deserved abasement came to a close (MB).

One commentator suggests that the phrase '*istarāḥa qawmun ilā al-ḥitan*' was actually a scribal error, and it should have been '*fī al-ḥitan*' (T). Regarding the identity of those who sought comfort through strife, some say that they were righteous believers who were forced, during a particular period, to remain silent in the face of sedition and strife, and had to practice dissimulation (*taqiyyah*) in order to remain undisturbed by the events taking place around them. These could have been individuals who lived during the Age of Ignorance, where they were surrounded by corruption but remained aloof therefrom, and it was only later when the Noble Prophet came that they supported him and raised their swords to fight alongside him (N). Others say that these were actually people who capitulated in the face of the evil tyrants, seeking comfort and security by avoiding confrontation with them or speaking up against them (Z). Yet others specify that it was a group of the Shī'ah and the people of Baṣrah who inclined towards the misguided group which arose there, in order to remain safe from their intrigues (MB). The phrase '*ishtālū 'an laqāḥi ḥarbihim*' has been interpreted in two opposite ways, with some saying that it means they raised their swords away from fighting them, meaning that they did not fight against those who were corrupt and oppressive (I, MB). Others suggest it could mean that they were on the brink of commencing hostilities, just as a camel that is about to give birth, since '*laqāḥ*' literally refers to an impregnated camel (T). Yet others say that it refers to another group who raised their weapons in order to fight those corrupt oppressors (N). However, it seems the first interpretation is more correct, and this phrase continues from the previous one, describing how those who sought safety sat back and avoided confrontation or conflict with the corrupt powers (Z).

The Imām then describes a third group, and those were the righteous ones who rose up to fight against the evildoers without considering their patience to be a favour to Allāh or regarding sacrificing their lives in the way of truth as something too great. Some commentators link this to the previous statement and interpret the patience mentioned here as the dissimulation that the believers are

forced to practice to remain safe (R), or read the phrase to mean that they did not exhibit patience or show readiness to lay down their lives for the truth (T). However, others opine that there is a disjoint between this and what was mentioned previously, and something has been elided. That is why they consider this to be in reference to a completely different group of individuals – those who are righteous and ready to lay down their lives for the sake of Allāh (Z, M). Then, *when it was decreed that the period of trial should come to an end*, with the rise of the Mahdī (T), or the end of the rule of misguided oppressors (MB), *they lifted their wisdom upon their swords*, meaning they will announce their creed and defend it with their blood and their lives (Z). The reason why swords are mentioned here is perhaps because just as one can clearly see the shimmer of a shining sword, so too will they clearly proclaim their beliefs (I). On the other hand, the phrase could also mean that they struck with their swords while being cognizant and aware of what was required of them by their religion, not out of heedlessness or delusion (R). In any case, it is evident that there is a lot of disagreement regarding the exact interpretation of this section, and hence many varying opinions have been put forward by commentators (MB).

In what then follows, Imām ‘Alī speaks about the events pertaining to the time right after the Noble Messenger had left this world, which was when *a group turned back on their heels*. This refers to what is found in a number of traditions which speak of the ‘spiritual apostasy’ (*irtidād ma’nawī*) of the people after the Noble Prophet passed away, except those sincere followers who were protected by Allāh (T). It refers to their acting against the instructions of the Messenger of Allāh, and according to some commentators, the group being referred to was made up of those who usurped the caliphate and others who followed them (MB). In reference to this, the Qur’ān states: *Muḥammad is but a Messenger; [other] Messengers have passed before him. If he dies or is slain, will you turn back on your heels? And whoever turns back on his heels will not harm Allāh in the least, and soon Allāh will reward the grateful* (Q3:144) (Z). The Imām then describes some qualities of these people, saying that they were ruined by the ways of misguidance, which translates ‘*ghālathum al-subul*’, where the verb ‘*ghālahu*’ means it takes him from whence he knows not (T). Some suggest that the phrase ‘*ghālathum al-subul*’ means that they were destroyed by their differences of opinion and variant inclinations (I), which led them to misinterpret many of the prophetic injunctions based on their whims (N). Their second negative quality was that they placed their trust in deceitful

confidants from among the hypocrites and outsiders (N). The phrase ‘*ittakalū ‘alā al-walā’ij*’ has, according to some commentators, some elision since the term *walījah* means one who is close to a person and keeps his secrets. Hence, the phrase might have been ‘*ittakalū ‘alā ghayr al-walā’ij*’ meaning they relied on those who were not close confidants, or ‘*ittakalū ‘alā al-walā’ij min dūnillāh*’ meaning they placed their trust in others besides Allāh (T). Alternatively, it has been suggested that the phrase means in their false beliefs and corrupt actions, they relied upon those who were akin to themselves and confided in those who espoused similar views (MB). As for their keeping *ties with other than the kin*, it refers to the kin of the Noble Prophet, and his close family (M), whom they were told to keep ties with and adore (I), but they chose to sever ties with them and inclined to others who would bring them worldly benefit (MB). In doing so, they *abandoned the link* to the Prophet whom they had been ordered to love, and *shifted the edifice* of leadership *from its firm foundation and built it in an improper place*. Because they abandoned the Ahl al-Bayt, and did not love them as commanded in the verse: *Say, ‘I do not ask of you any reward for it but love for [my] near relatives.’* (Q42:23), they forsook their link to the Noble Messenger (Z).

The edifice (‘*al-binā’*’) being referred to here is the caliphate (N, M), or the edifice of religion and faith (MB), and their uprooting it and erecting it in a wrong location refers to their opposing the Prophet regarding the right of the Ahl al-Bayt, which they usurped (Z). As a consequence of this, they became *the mines of every misdeed and the doors of all who strike forth in ignorance*, since that they became the source of all the evils committed by this *ummah* by taking away the caliphate from its rightful owners, meaning the pure Ahl al-Bayt (MB). The phrase ‘*dāribin fī ghamrah*’ refers to one who enters into error knowingly (I), and these individuals are figuratively described as *doors* (‘*abwāb*’) because they facilitate the entry of anyone who wishes to embark on sedition or evil action (M). Subsequently, the Imām says that these people move *to and fro in bewilderment and staggering in intoxication*, which metaphorically describes their hesitation and uncertainty, such that they remained perplexed and baffled, not knowing the right course to follow. This was their state because they had abandoned the path of the Infallible Imāms (MB). The Imām then compares their state to that of the followers of Fir‘awn, and he uses the indefinite form of the noun ‘*sunnah*’ to signify their emulation of part of the practice of Pharaoh’s people (M). Indeed, they followed the path of oppression and error just as Fir‘awn and his people had done (MB). To elaborate this further,

he says that some of them were cut off from everything but this world, to which they devoted themselves fully, while others were *separated from the faith and opposed to it*. The first group consisted of those who had been sincere believers during the time of the Prophet, but later began to incline towards worldliness and supported those who had no right to the caliphate, out of desire for worldly gain (T). These were people whose only aim was attaining that which they sought of material pleasures (MB). The second group, however, consisted of those who discarded their faith and deserted the religion, even if they did not possess or gain any worldly benefit in doing so (M). Some commentators mention a list of individuals who fall into the second category, most of whom only accepted Islam unwillingly after the Conquest of Makkah, or just before it (T).



HIS WARNING AGAINST STRIFE

ALLĀH AND HIS MESSENGER

- 1 I seek His help in repelling Satan and deterring him, and protection from his snares and wiles. I bear witness that there is no god but Allāh, and I bear witness that Muḥammad is His servant and His Messenger, and His specially chosen and selected one. Neither can his distinction be matched nor can his loss be recovered. Through him, the towns were illuminated after the darkness of misguidance, pervasive ignorance, and barbaric practices, with people regarding the unlawful as lawful, humiliating the men of wisdom, living in an age without Prophets, and dying as unbelievers!

WARNING AGAINST STRIFE

- 2 Then you, O Arabs, are targets of tribulations that have drawn near. So beware of the intoxication of blessings, and be careful of the calamities of chastisement. Keep steadfast in the darkness of dubiety and crookedness of sedition, when its foetus is born, its secret become manifest, its axle is installed, and its millstone rotates. It begins in hidden alleys and turns into something evidently hideous. Its intensity is like the fervour of a youth

الله ورسوله

١ وَأَسْتَعِينُهُ عَلَى مَدَاحِرِ الشَّيْطَانِ
وَمَزَاجِرِهِ، وَالْإِغْتِصَامِ مِنْ حَبَائِلِهِ
وَمَخَائِلِهِ. وَأَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ،
وَأَشْهَدُ أَنَّ مُحَمَّدًا عَبْدُهُ وَرَسُولُهُ،
وَنَجِيُّهُ وَصَفْوَتُهُ؛ لَا يُؤَاوِزِي فَضْلُهُ،
وَلَا يُجْبِرُ فَقْدُهُ، أَصَاءَتْ بِهِ الْبِلَادُ
بَعْدَ الضَّلَالَةِ الْمُظْلِمَةِ، وَالْجَهَالَةِ
الْغَالِبَةِ، وَالْجَفْوَةِ الْجَافِيَةِ، وَالنَّاسُ
يَسْتَحِلُّونَ الْحَرِيمَ وَيَسْتَذِلُّونَ
الْحَكِيمَ، يَحْيَوْنَ عَلَى فَرَةٍ
وَيَمُوتُونَ عَلَى كُفْرَةٍ!

التحذير من الفتنة

٢ ثُمَّ إِنَّكُمْ مَعَشَرَ الْعَرَبِ أَغْرَاضُ بَلَايَا
قَدْ افْتَرَبَتْ، فَاتَّقُوا سَكْرَاتِ النُّعْمَةِ
وَاحْذَرُوا بَوَائِقَ النُّقْمَةِ، وَتَبَتَّبُوا فِي
قَتَامِ الْعُسْوَةِ، وَاعْوِجَاجِ الْفِتْنَةِ عِنْدَ
طُلُوعِ جَنِينِهَا، وَظُهُورِ كَيْمِهَا،
وَانْتِصَابِ قُطْبِهَا، وَمَدَارِ رَحَاهَا.
تَبْدَأُ فِي مَدَارِجِ خَفِيَّةٍ، وَتُثَوِّلُ إِلَى
فَظَاعَةٍ جَلِيَّةٍ، شَبَابُهَا كَشِبَابِ الْعُلَامِ،

and its impact is like that of large rocks. Tyrants inherit it from each other by [mutual] agreement! The first of them serves as a leader for the last, and the last of them follows the first. They vie with each other for this lowly world and fight like dogs over a stinking carcass. Soon the follower will renounce the leader, and the leader [will renounce] the follower. They will part ways with mutual hatred and curse each other when they meet.

وَأَثَارُهَا كَأَثَارِ السَّلَامِ، يَتَوَارَثُهَا
الظَّالِمَةُ بِالْعُهُودِ! أَوَّلُهُمْ قَائِدٌ
لَا خَيْرَ لَهُمْ، وَآخِرُهُمْ مُقْتَدٍ بِأَوَّلِهِمْ،
يَتَنَافَسُونَ فِي دُنْيَا دَنِيَّةٍ، وَيَتَكَالَبُونَ
عَلَى حَيْفَةٍ مُرِيحَةٍ، وَعَنْ قَلِيلٍ يَتَبَرَّأُ
الَتَّابِعُ مِنَ الْمَتَّبِعِ، وَالْقَائِدُ مِنَ
الْمُقْتَدِ، فَيَتَرَايَلُونَ بِالْبُغْضَاءِ،
وَيَتَلَاغُونَ عِنْدَ اللِّقَاءِ.

CONTEXT

This oration is about events that will transpire in the future, and the calamities that will befall the people in later times. It commences with seeking assistance from the Almighty, as a believer ought to do when faced with tribulations and, indeed, at all times (MB). No information is available about when or where this sermon was delivered by the Imām, and it is also not recorded in any other known early source. Al-Sayyid Yaḥyā ibn Ḥamzah al-Yamānī mentions a couple of lines of this oration in his *al-Ṭirāz*, and due to the slight variance in wording, it may be surmised that he referred to a source other than *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* includes it as part of the sermon known as ‘al-Bayān’, which Amīr al-Mu’minīn gave after the Battle of Nahrawān (3:11).

COMMENTARY

1 The phrase *I praise Allāh* (*aḥmadullāh*) is included in the beginning of some versions of this sermon, but it may have been added later as the earliest extant manuscripts do not contain it. Perhaps that is because the start of the sermon seems abrupt and there may have been something mentioned before the opening lines which has not been included by al-Sayyid al-Raḍī. Amīr al-Mu’minīn starts his oration by seeking Allāh’s help to repel and deter Shayṭān. The phrase ‘*asta’īnuhu ‘alā madāḥir al-shayṭān wa mazājirihī*’ connotes his seeking assistance

in that which leads to the repulsion of Satan and deterrence against him. This includes acts of worship and righteous actions that serve to drive away the Devil (M). In a tradition reported from the Noble Messenger it is said that he once asked his companions, "Should I not inform you of something which, if practiced by you, will expel Satan and drive him as far away from you as the East is from the West?" They all replied in the affirmative, so he said, "Fasting blackens his face, giving charity breaks his back, loving [each other] for the sake of Allāh and assisting each other in doing good deeds cuts off his tail, and repentance severs his aorta..." (T). Likewise, the Imām also seeks *protection from his snares and wiles*, meaning the sins and temptations that lead one away from righteousness, and indeed without the help of Allāh neither can one worship Him, nor can he eschew sin (N). Imām 'Alī then mentions the testimony of faith, and we have discussed why he would repeat this in his orations in our commentary of the second section of sermon no. 2. He refers to the Messenger of Allāh as *His specially chosen and selected one*, and the details regarding this is mentioned in the third section of sermon no. 93.

Though most commentators consider the terms '*najīb*' and '*ṣafwāh*' to be synonyms, some say that since '*najīb*' means most excellent and valuable, there is a subtle difference between the two terms and the first one lays the foundation for the second, as it is due to his excellence that he was chosen (N). Then, to show the extent of the Prophet's excellence, Imām 'Alī says that *neither can his distinction be matched* by anyone, *nor can his loss be recovered*, meaning no one could ever replace him. That is because his perfection cannot be encompassed by any among the creation, and thus his loss could never be recovered (M). The Imām then reminds the people of how the Noble Messenger had illuminated the towns with his guidance after they had been steeped in the *darkness of misguidance*. Section twenty of sermon no. 1 describes the state of the people before the Messenger of Allāh came to them, and here the Imām presents a further description noting that they had fallen into *pervasive ignorance* ('*al-jahālah al-ghālibah*') and had *barbaric practices* ('*al-jafwāh al-jāfiyah*'), which refers to their rough nature and hard hearts, due to which they would spill blood without a second thought (MB), and even bury their infant daughters alive (T). They were people who regarded the unlawful as lawful, humiliated men of wisdom and learning instead of respecting them, and died as unbelievers. Indeed, the Arabs at that time had nothing but ignorance, disgrace, and ignominy, until the Noble Prophet came to them with Islam, and

saved them from their plight (Z). The term '*kafrāh*' is singular of *kafarāt* (I), and means darkness that covers one due to disbelief and error (Z).

2 Some commentators say the tribulations mentioned in this section pertain to what would transpire during the reign of Banū Umayyah, and the Banū 'Abbās after them (T). Others interpret it as a reference to End Times tribulations (I). However, since the Imām tells them that they are targets of *tribulations that have drawn near* ('*balāyā qad iqtarabat*'), the first interpretation seems more likely. He then mentions two factors that give rise to strife, the first being *intoxication of blessings* ('*sakarāt al-ni'mah*'), which figuratively refers to the state of heedlessness that overcomes a person who is granted blessings, such that he becomes like one who is inebriated and unaware of his surroundings (MB). When people become so engrossed in the blessings that they no longer think about their purpose in this world, it is as though they are intoxicated (M). The second factor is *the calamities of chastisement* ('*bawā'iq al-niqmah*') which some have interpreted as the sedition and strife (*fitnah*) which results from their own misdeeds (N). The Imām tells the people to be careful of these calamitous punishments just as one who has sound health is careful of ailments, or one who is strong is careful of growing weak, and so on (Z). Imām 'Alī then advises the people how to mitigate the effects of strife, telling them to remain firm and steadfast *in the darkness of dubiety and crookedness of sedition*. By this he means that when matters become unclear and confusing, they should stop and not plunge into them without consideration and discernment (MB). The term '*qatām*', which literally means dust (T), is used here as a euphemism for something dubious that gives rise to sedition, like the killing of 'Uthmān which was used as a pretext for the rebellion that led to the Battles of Jamal and Şifḥīn. Indeed, just as one cannot find his way in a dust storm, so too does one get confused by such dubious matters (M). The Imām then tells them when to take action against potential strife, saying that it should be *when its foetus is born, its secret become manifest, its axle is installed, and its millstone rotates*. Some commentators understand these similes as a reference to two stages in any sedition, the first of which is its manifestation after being hidden, like a foetus being born, and the second is when it gains momentum and strength, like a rotating millstone (MB). This development and 'evolution' of *fitnah* in the community is further depicted by the Imām as something that *begins in hidden alleys and turns into something evidently hideous*. It does not, therefore, show its true nature in the beginning; rather, it presents itself in the admirable garb of

reformation and a call to what is right. Only with the passage of time does its true, ugly nature rear its head and bear its teeth (Z).

Amīr al-Mu'minīn then presents a further description of sedition, stating that *its intensity is like the fervour of a youth* ('*shibābuhā kashibāb al-ghulām*') and *its impact is like that of large rocks* ('*āthāruhā ka'āthār al-silām*'). The term '*shibāb*' is used to describe the playful frolic of a horse (T), and here it describes a state of excitement. It is as though in the beginning, those who plot sedition and act as agents of strife behave in a playful manner, lacking seriousness, but later it turns into a grave matter that leaves deep wounds, like those caused by large rocks striking the body (I). Alternatively, this alludes to how a *fitnah* begins as something benign and calm, but it soon transforms into something much more. Its effects are very negative on the society, just like a body being pelted with rocks (Z). *Tyrants inherit it from each other by mutual agreement*, meaning that the fruits of sedition are left by tyrants to their heirs and successors, or that they took as inheritance among themselves that which Allāh had bestowed to the Ahl al-Bayt as their right (MB). This could be an allusion to how Mu'āwiyah ibn Abī Sufyān had bequeathed power to Yazīd, for he was the first to pass on power to his son as his heir in this manner, and he took pledges of allegiance to this effect from the people in his own lifetime (T).

As for the first of them being a *leader for the last*, it is like the cameleer who leads a train of camels, walking ahead of them as they follow his lead. And *the last of them follows the first* means that those who come later follow in the footsteps of their tyrant predecessors and act as they had acted (I). Here, the type of *fitnah* being specifically referred to is that wherein leadership is usurped from those who have a right to it, and then passed on to others among the progeny or kin of the usurpers (Z). The reality, however, is that they only *vie with each other for this lowly world and fight like dogs over a stinking carcass*. Indeed, one tradition describes this world to be like a carcass, and those who avidly seek it to be like dogs (T). Yet in the end, *the follower will renounce the leader, and the leader the follower*, on the Day of Judgment, as mentioned in several verses of the Qur'ān (MB). They will separate from each other *with mutual hatred and curse each other when they meet* in the Hereafter, as reflected in the verse which states: *Then on the Day of Resurrection you will reject one another and curse one another, and your abode will be the Fire, and you will have no helpers* (Q29:25) (I). Some suggest that this renouncing refers to the time of the Banū 'Abbās, for it was a common practice at that time to have

3 Then, there will subsequently appear a tumultuous strife, devastating in its advance. Thus, the hearts will swerve after being steadfast and men will go astray after being sound [in faith]. During its onslaught, caprices will vary and when it rises, opinions will become confused. Whoever stands to face it will be ruined by it and whoever tries to quell it will be destroyed by it. In it, they will bite each other the way wild donkeys bite one another in the herd! The fastening of the rope [of faith] shall slacken and the true face of matters will be obscured. During it, wisdom will diminish and the oppressors will do all the talking. It will hew the Bedouins with its chisel and crush them with its chest. In its [clouds of] dust, the lone traveller will be lost, and in its path, the riders will be annihilated. It will arrive with the bitterness of fate and will lactate fresh blood [instead of milk]. It will breach the beacons of faith and break the ties of certitude. The saga-cious will flee from it while the filthy will foster it. [It shall be] full of thunder and lightning, and will overwhelm with catastrophe! In it ties of kinship will be severed and Islam will be for-saken! He who disavows it is afflicted [by it], and he who departs from it remains [within it]!

ثُمَّ يَأْتِي بَعْدَ ذَلِكَ طَالِعُ الْفِتْنَةِ
الرَّجُوفُ وَالْقَاصِمَةُ الرَّحُوفُ،
فَتَرِيغُ قُلُوبٌ بَعْدَ اسْتِقَامَةٍ،
وَتَضِلُّ رَجَالٌ بَعْدَ سَلَامَةٍ،
وَتُخْلِفُ الْأَهْوَاءُ عِنْدَ هُجُومِهَا،
وَتُلْتَبِسُ الْأَرْأَاءُ عِنْدَ نُجُومِهَا،
مَنْ أَشْرَفَ لَهَا قَصَمَتْهُ، وَمَنْ
سَعَى فِيهَا حَطَمَتْهُ؛ يَتَكَادِمُونَ
فِيهَا تَكَادِمَ الْحُمُرِ فِي الْعَانَةِ! قَدْ
اضْطَرَبَ مَعْقُودُ الْحَبْلِ وَعَمِيَ
وَجْهُ الْأَمْرِ، تَغِيضُ فِيهَا
الْحِكْمَةُ، وَتَنْطِقُ فِيهَا الظُّلْمَةُ،
وَتَذُقُ أَهْلُ الْبَدْوِ بِمَسْحَلِهَا،
وَتَرُضُّهُمْ بِكُلْكُلِهَا؛ يَضِيغُ فِي
غُبَارِهَا الْوُحْدَانُ، وَيَهْلِكُ فِي
طَرِيقِهَا الرُّكْبَانُ؛ تَرْدُ بِمُرِّ
الْقَصَاءِ، وَتَحْلُبُ عَبِيطَ الدِّمَاءِ،
وَتَتْلُمُ مَنَارَ الدِّينِ، وَتَنْقُضُ عَقْدَ
الْيَقِينِ؛ يَهْرُبُ مِنْهَا الْأَكْيَاسُ،
وَيُدْبِرُهَا الْأَرْجَاسُ، مِزْعَادُ
مِيزَاقٍ، كَاشِفَةٌ عَنْ سَاقٍ! تُقَطِّعُ
فِيهَا الْأَرْحَامَ، وَيَفَارِقُ عَلَيْهَا
الْإِسْلَامُ! بَرِيئُهَا سَقِيمٌ وَظَاعِنُهَا
مَقِيمٌ!

FROM THE SAME SERMON

منها

- 4 Among them will be some who are killed without retaliation and others who are frightened and seek protection. They will be deceived by oaths and the pretence of faith. So do not become monuments of strife and signposts of innovations. Adhere to that which the rope of the community has been tied to and upon which the pillars of obedience have been founded. Proceed towards Allāh as oppressed people and do not go to Him as oppressors. Beware of the ways of Satan and the places that nurture aggression. Do not put morsels of unlawful [food] in your stomachs, for verily you are being watched by the One who has made sin unlawful for you, and has made the pathways of obedience easy for you.

٤ بَيْنَ قَتِيلٍ مَظْلُومٍ، وَخَائِفٍ مُسْتَجِيرٍ، يُحْتَلُونَ بِعَقْدِ الْإِيمَانِ وَبِغُرُورِ الْإِيمَانِ؛ فَلَا تَكُونُوا أَنْصَابَ الْفِتَنِ وَأَعْلَامَ الْبِدْعِ، وَالزُّمُومَا مَا عَقِدَ عَلَيْهِ حَبْلُ الْجَمَاعَةِ، وَبَيَّتَ عَلَيْهِ أَرْكَانُ الطَّاعَةِ، وَأَقْدَمُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ مَظْلُومِينَ، وَلَا تَقْدَمُوا عَلَيْهِ ظَالِمِينَ، وَاتَّقُوا مَدَارِجَ الشَّيْطَانِ وَمَهَابِطَ الْعُدْوَانِ، وَلَا تُدْخِلُوا بُطُونَكُمْ لَعَقَ الْحَرَامِ، فَإِنَّكُمْ بَعَيْنِ مَنْ حَرَّمَ عَلَيْكُمُ الْمَعْصِيَةَ، وَسَهَّلَ لَكُمْ سُبُلَ الطَّاعَةِ.

people declare their dissociation from deposed leaders from the Banū ‘Abbās when a new leader came to power. Hence, their pledges of allegiance were accompanied with declarations of hatred for former rulers (M).

- 3 In this section Imām ‘Alī describes another *fitnah* of seismic proportions that would beset the people. He says *there will subsequently appear a tumultuous strife, devastating in its advance*, and a number of commentators have suggested that he was referring to the invasion of the Tartars (M), while others opine that it was about one of the difficult End Times tribulations like the *fitnah* of al-Dajjāl (MB). It has been pointed out, however, that the first opinion is highly unlikely, since the Tartars only sought to conquer Muslim lands, loot their wealth, and destroy their cities, whereas what the Imām has described here is a strife wherein the faith of the people is targeted, and doubts and misguidance spreads among

them (N). As such, this may have been a reference to the *fitnah* of the Banū ‘Abbās (T). The strife is described as *tumultuous* (*‘al-rajūf*) because of the great discord and agitation it will bring in its wake, and it is said to be *devastating in its advance* (*‘al-qāṣimat al-zahūf*) because of the widespread destruction it will cause as it moves forward, step by step (MB). Some have interpreted this to be a depiction of how the Banū ‘Abbās attained power, slowly and gradually, until they overthrew the Banū Umayyah and took the caliphate (T).

During that sedition, the Imām says, *the hearts will swerve after being steadfast and men will go astray after being sound* in faith, meaning those who were staunch believers will begin to waver in their belief, and they will stray from the right path (M). Alternatively, it means those who had followed the path of the Ahl al-Bayt will turn away therefrom and end up following divergent paths after having been of sound faith previously (T). During the onslaught of this future sedition, *caprices will vary* with everyone acting on their own whims, and *opinions will become confused* due to the numerous different views that exist, such that the sound will become mixed with the unsound (Z). At that time, whoever stands up to face the *fitnah* will be ruined by it, and *whoever tries to quell it will be destroyed by it* as it shatters all those who try to withstand its assault. The verb *‘ḥaṭamathu* means it will break him into pieces (T). As such, nobody will successfully oppose this sedition, which will be encompassing and overwhelming. Imām ‘Alī then uses an analogy to describe the behaviour of people at that time, saying that they *will bite each other the way wild donkeys bite one another in the herd*, which portrays how it will affect them all to such a degree that they begin harming each other. Another effect of this strife will be the undoing of knots in the rope of faith, which metaphorically represents the laws of religion and its legal rulings (MB), or the belief in Imāmah (T). Alternatively, it could be a reference to the overall state of disorder and discord that will be prevalent, leading to the obscuring of *the true face of matters* (*‘wajh al-amr*), such that what is right and proper will be covered up by the numerous false views and opinions (Z).

During this *fitnah*, *wisdom will diminish and the oppressors will do all the talking*, such that wise people will not get a chance to speak while the tyrants will voice their ideas openly, since they will have all the power at that time (MB). Wise people will remain silent either due to despair and fear, or because people will turn a deaf ear to them (Z). The phrase *‘taduqqu ahl al-badwi bimishḥalihā* has been rendered *it will hew the bedouins with its chisel*, but since the word *‘mishḥal*’ also has

other meanings, such as iron bridle, file, or any implement used for hewing wood, commentators say that here it metaphorically refers to that which will cause harm and distress to the Arabs during this strife (M). The *fitnah* will also *crush them with its chest* (*'taruḍḍuhum bikalkalihā'*), which figuratively describes how they would be crushed the way something which is under a camel is squashed by its weight when it sits upon it (MB). Furthermore, the lone travellers will be lost in its clouds of dust, and the riders will perish in its paths. Some commentators suggest that *the lone traveller* (*'al-wuḥdān'*) here refers to the eminent and scholarly personalities who will be lost in the confusion of the strife, while *the riders* (*'al-rukbān'*) metaphorically refers to strong groups of people who will also be unable to counter the *fitnah* and will thus perish. The sedition will be so grave and overwhelming that neither individuals and small groups, nor large factions will be able to withstand it (N). When it comes, the strife will *arrive with the bitterness of fate*, meaning its arrival will be accompanied with great devastation, and the term *fate* (*'al-qadā'*) has been used by the Imām here to connote destruction (Z). It *will lactate fresh blood* instead of milk, which is an allusion to the rampant bloodshed and war that will result therefrom (I). *It will breach the beacons of faith*, which figuratively refers to religious scholars or laws, and the breaching thereof either means obliteration or lack of adherence (MB). And it will *break the ties of certitude* since those responsible for the sedition will act against the ordinances that lead one closer to the Almighty (M). *The sagacious will flee from it while the filthy will foster it*, meaning the wise individuals will flee from that sedition, while the lowly, wretched, and corrupt individuals will take to it. The term *'al-arjās'* refers to wicked individuals who have engulfed themselves in evil and have become, in essence, something filthy and corrupt (I).

Continuing the description of this future strife, Amīr al-Mu'minīn states that it shall be *full of thunder and lightning*, which represents its severity and intensity (N), and it will *overwhelm with catastrophe*. The phrase *'kāshifātun 'an sāq'* literally means bears its shanks, but is used to connote severe hardship and calamity. The Qur'ān employs it to describe the condition on the Day of Resurrection when it states: *On the day when the shank is laid bare and they are called to prostrate, but are unable [to do so]* (Q68:42) (T). The Imām then says that during this *fitnah*, *ties of kinship will be severed and Islam will be forsaken*, since sin will become ubiquitous and people will stop following the teachings of Islam (Z). At that time, whoever disavows it will be afflicted, and whoever seeks to depart from it will

remain within it, unable to escape! This means that the evil will be so pervasive that even those who think they have escaped it continue to be within its bounds. This highlights how encompassing the *fitnah* will be, such that no one will be safe from it (T), and those who assume that they have detached themselves from it are still, in reality, in its grasp (I).

4 There is a difference of opinion among commentators regarding whether this section of the sermon is directly linked to what precedes it or not (N). During the age of strife, some of those who adhere to the religion will be *killed without retaliation* (*'qatīlin maṭlūl'*), meaning their blood will go unavenged, having been wrongfully and unjustly slain, while others will be frightened and will seek asylum, with none to be found (Z). The verb *'yukhtalūna'* can also be read in the active form as *'yakhtilūna'*, in which case the translation would be *they deceive by oaths and the pretence of faith*, meaning the agents of strife will deceive people by making false oaths and pretending to be religious and faithful (N). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then cautions the people that they should never be supporters of any sedition they encounter (M), warning them not to become *monuments of strife and signposts of innovations* and heresies. This means they should neither be leaders in it, nor should they point others towards it (MB). He then advises them to *adhere to that which the rope of the community has been tied to and upon which the pillars of obedience have been founded*, referring to that which unites them and sets them aright, namely the Book of Allāh and the Sunnah of the Noble Prophet (Z), or more specifically the religious laws that bring about social order and gather people to what is right (MB). The Imām then tells them it would be better if they came to Allāh as oppressed people, rather than as oppressors. Of course, this does not mean that he was calling on them to passively accept injustice, as it would be considered a means of aiding the oppressors or facilitating tyranny. Instead, this instruction means that if one is given a choice between being an oppressor or being oppressed, with no third option, then it is preferable to be among the oppressed than among the perpetrators of oppression. This is like the case of choosing the bad over the worse (N).

Subsequently, Imām 'Alī warns them of *the ways of Satan* (*'madārij al-shayṭān'*) and *the places that nurture aggression* and enmity. The literal meaning of *'mahābiṭ'* is declivities or low-lying areas (R), and it can also be used to refer to places wherein people descend from their mounts (MB). Here it alludes to locations of destructive animosity and oppression, and according to one commentator,

there is a subtle point in this warning, especially if we understand ‘*madārij*’ to mean an ascending pathway, like a staircase. It means that Satan takes the human being up the steps of disobedience, gradually, and when he reaches the peak, he pushes him down into the abyss of his doom (N). The final advice given to the people by the Imām is not to put *morsels of unlawful food* in their stomachs. The term ‘*lu’aq*’ is plural of *lu’qah* which literally means a spoonful (I), and here it connotes a small amount of food. Alternatively, the term signifies the little value of what is earned of this evanescent world in comparison to the abundance of the Hereafter (MB). Undoubtedly, when tyranny becomes rampant and oppression is prevalent, that which is unlawful is more easily accessed by people and becomes increasingly available. However, consuming the illicit has harmful effects such as darkening the heart and distancing one from the Creator. That is why the Imām was warning the people against partaking of what is *ḥarām* (N). In the end, he reminds them that they *are being watched by the One who has made sin unlawful* for them, *and has made the pathways of obedience easy* to follow. By this he means that Allāh is aware of all their actions, and that should itself suffice as a reason to eschew the forbidden (M), for a servant who knows that his master is watching is more careful of his deeds than one whose master is absent or heedless of his actions (MB).



ON THE ATTRIBUTES OF ALLĀH AND RELIGIOUS LEADERS

- 1 Praise be to Allāh who demonstrates His existence through His creation, His eternality through the origination of His creation, and that nothing is like Him through their shared similarities. Senses cannot perceive Him and curtains cannot veil Him, due to the difference between the Maker and the made, the Limiter and the limited, and the Nurturer and the nurtured. He is One but not by counting, the Creator but not through activity or toil, the All-hearing but not by means of any organ, the All-seeing but not by opening any eyes, the All-witnessing but not by contact, the Distinct but not through distance, the Manifest but not by visibility, and the Hidden but not by subtlety.
- 2 He is Distinct from all things by His subdual of them and power over them, and all things are distinct from Him because of their subjugation before Him and their returning to Him. Whoever describes Him has limited Him, whoever limits Him has counted Him, and whoever counts Him has negated His eternality. Whoever asks, "How [is He]?" has sought a description for Him and whoever asks, "Where [is He]?" has confined him. He was the Knower even when there was nothing to be

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الدَّالُّ عَلَى وُجُودِهِ
بِحَلْقِهِ، وَبِمُحَدِّثِ خَلْقِهِ عَلَى أَرْزَلِيَّتِهِ،
وَبِأَشْيَاءِهِمْ عَلَى أَنْ لَا شِبْهَ لَهُ. لَا
تَسْتَلِمُهُ الْمَشَاعِرُ، وَلَا تَحْجُبُهُ
السَّوَاتِرُ، لَا فِتْرَاقِ الصَّانِعِ
وَالْمُصْنُوعِ، وَالْحَادِّ وَالْمَحْدُودِ،
وَالرَّبِّ وَالْمَرْثُوبِ. الْأَحَدُ لَا يَتَأَوَّلُ
عَدَدٍ، وَالْحَالِقِ لَا يَمْغَى حَرَكَةٍ
وَنَصَبٍ، وَالسَّمِيعِ لَا بِأَذَاةٍ، وَالْبَصِيرِ
لَا بِتَفْرِيقِ آلَةٍ، وَالشَّاهِدِ لَا بِمُمَاسَّةٍ،
وَالْبَاطِنِ لَا بِتَرَاحِي مَسَافَةٍ، وَالظَّاهِرِ
لَا بِزُؤِيَّةٍ، وَالْبَاطِنِ لَا بِلَطَافَةٍ.

٢ بَانَ مِنَ الْأَشْيَاءِ بِالْقَهْرِ لَهَا
وَالْقُدْرَةَ عَلَيْهَا، وَبَانَتِ الْأَشْيَاءُ
مِنْهُ بِالْخُضُوعِ لَهُ وَالرُّجُوعِ إِلَيْهِ.
مَنْ وَصَفَهُ فَقَدْ حَدَّهُ، وَمَنْ حَدَّهُ
فَقَدْ عَدَّهُ، وَمَنْ عَدَّهُ فَقَدْ أَبْطَلَ
أَرْزَلَهُ، وَمَنْ قَالَ: كَيْفَ؟ فَقَدْ
اسْتَوْصَفَهُ، وَمَنْ قَالَ: أَيْنَ؟ فَقَدْ
حَيَّرَهُ. عَالِمٌ إِذْ لَا مَعْلُومٌ، وَرَبٌّ

known, the Nurturer even when there
 was nothing to be nurtured, and the
 All-powerful even when there was
 nothing to be overpowered.

إِذْ لَا مَرْبٍّ مَرْبٍ، وَقَادِرٍ إِذْ لَا
 مَقْدُورٍ.

CONTEXT

This is one of the lofty sermons of Amīr al-Mu'minīn that contain deeply insightful teachings about the Almighty and His attributes, as well as profound wisdom and intellectual discourse the like of which is not seen in any previous works, nor has it been propounded by any erstwhile or late sages (MB). The Imām gave this oration at the beginning of his caliphate in Madīnah (in 35 AH), according to Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd, and since this information is not mentioned anywhere else, it leads us to believe that the latter had access to another source of this sermon besides *Nahj al-Balāghah*. Parts of this speech have been mentioned by al-Kulaynī in the first volume of his *al-Kāfī*, as well as al-Āmidī in *Ghurar al-Ḥikam wa Durar al-Kalīm* (N). Al-Ṣadūq has also related part of it in his *al-Tawḥīd* through Imām al-Riḍā (T). Interestingly, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* records this oration as part of a longer sermon that the Imām delivered after his return from the Battle of Ṣiffīn (1:310).

COMMENTARY

1 After praising Him, three things are mentioned by the Imām about Allāh in the opening statement. Firstly, the demonstration of *His existence through His creation*, for by observing how everything in creation functions in an organized manner, moving towards a specific goal, we understand that there is surely an intent behind its existence, and intent signifies design, and no design can exist without a designer (Z). Hence, by simply looking and pondering over what exists around us in nature, we become aware of the existence of the Creator. This is known as the teleological argument for God's existence, and it is based on a firm rational foundation. A further discussion on this may be found in the second section of sermon no. 49 (MB). The next thing he mentions pertains to the *eternality (azaliyyah)* of Allāh, which is shown *through the origination of His*

creation. That is because anything which is originated has to have an originator that precedes it, and if that originator is also created, it also has an originator that precedes it, and the same continues to apply going forward, leading to infinite regress (*tasalsul*), which is rationally impossible. Hence, there must be a starting point of origination that was pre-eternal (*qadīm*), and that is proof that Allāh has always existed (I). The phrase '*muḥdathi khalqihī*' can also be rendered *the temporality of His creation*, which gives the same meaning of their having been originated and brought into existence from non-existence. Thirdly, the Imām emphasizes that *nothing is like Him* ('*lā shibha lahu*'), and this is established by the shared similarities of the creatures, either in terms of their neediness and dependence upon Him (M), or through their likeness in qualities such as material composition, species, type, shape, volume, colour, and so on (MB). Some understand this as a reference to the composite nature of that which is created, which is why they consist of some parts that are similar and others that are different (N). On the other hand, the Almighty is a non-composite Being, and hence nothing else can ever be like Him. The Imām further states that although *senses cannot perceive Him* because He is beyond being perceived by the five senses (T), and even intellection and rational thought cannot comprehend His Essence (Z), *curtains cannot veil Him* since proof of His existence is evident and clear through His creation which is present everywhere (N). This can be further understood when pondering upon *the difference between the Maker and the made, the Limiter and the limited, and the Nurturer and the nurtured*, for each has unique qualities that cannot be shared with the other (M). Indeed the qualities of the Necessarily Existent (*wājib al-wujūd*) cannot be the same as those whose existence is only possible and contingent (*mumkin al-wujūd*) (MB).

Imām 'Alī then explains the true meaning of *tawḥīd*, saying that Allāh is *One but not by counting* ('*al-aḥadu lā bi-ta'wīli 'adad*'), clarifying that it is not numerical oneness that is intended thereby. In one report, we find that during the Battle of Jamal, a bedouin came to Amīr al-Mu'minīn and asked about the oneness of Allāh, so the Imām explained to him, "Saying that Allāh is One can mean four things, two of which are invalid while the other two are valid. The two which do not apply to Him are saying He is one meaning the number 'one', and this is incorrect since that which can never have a second cannot have any number applied to Him..." (T). When it is said He is not one *by counting*, it means that no second can even be imagined for Him, since there can be no second infinite Being, as that would

render both limited and finite. It would be like saying “infinity plus one” which is entirely illogical. Rather, He is One in that none is like Him, whether imagined or real (N). If understood as a first number, the oneness would be a starting point for the multiplicity that follows it, and that can never apply to the Almighty. Some further details of this have been explained in the commentary of sermon no. 64 (MB). The Imām then says that Allāh is the Creator, *but not through activity or toil*, meaning His act of creation does not involve movement or effort on His part, the way it does for human beings who make things. Rather, it is as the Qur’ān states: *His command, when He intends anything, is only to say to it, ‘Be,’ and it is* (Q36:82) (T). He further explains that Allāh is All-hearing, *but not by means of any organ* such as ears, and He is All-seeing, *but not by opening any eyes*. The phrase *‘lā bitafrīqi ālah’* literally means not by parting any implement or organ, but some commentators understand it to imply that he does not need to open any eyelids to see, as the creatures do (Z). Others take it as a reference to the way the pupils focus, through the process of dilation (T), or the rays by which one is able to see (I). In any case, the meaning is clear – Allāh does not need any appendage or external means in order to hear or see, just as He witnesses everything *not by contact* (*‘lā bi-mumāssah’*), but by His all-encompassing knowledge (T). This means that unlike human witnesses who have to be physically present, Allāh has no such limitation and is hence All-witnessing (I). Just as physical presence and contact do not apply to Him, so too is His being separate and distinct from everything not based on spatial or temporal distance. Rather, it is because He is the most perfect Being, while all others are imperfect (N). Manifest is He, *but not by visibility* like all other apparent things that can be seen with the eyes, and He is Hidden, *but not by subtlety* like those subtle unseen things, such as air or tiny particles. This has been discussed in the commentary of sermons no. 49 and 64 (MB).

2 Having noted that Allāh is distinct and separate from His creation, the Imām explains this further by stating that *He is Distinct from all things by His subdual of them and power over them, and all things are distinct from Him because of their subjugation before Him and their returning to Him*. It is obvious that if Allāh is separate from all things, then all things are separate from Him, but both these aspects differ from the way material things are distinct and separate from each other (T). His separation denotes His power and subjugation of all things, and the distinction of creation connotes their utter subordination before Him (N). And their *returning to Him* signifies their dependence on Him for their existence and all

their perfections (*kamālāt*) as is expected for every contingent being (MB). Imām ‘Alī then says that whoever describes Allāh *has limited Him*, meaning that whoever attributes any of the qualities of creation to Him has circumscribed Him with a set limit (R). Indeed His Essence cannot be described, and no external attribute can be ascribed to it (I). Whoever makes such an ascription and thereby limits Him *has counted Him*, meaning he has reckoned Him and sought to encompass Him with his understanding, yet it is Allāh who encompasses everything and nothing can encompass Him (Z). The outcome of counting Him in such a way is that one ends up negating His eternity (*‘abṭala azalahu’*). By limiting Allāh, one takes Him to be like a contingent being, and such a being can never be eternal (MB). Similarly, counting Him entails deeming the presence of a starting point for Him, which likewise means that He is not pre-eternal (M). The questions “How?” and “Where?” do not apply to Allāh, and asking that about Him is tantamount to seeking a description of Him and confining Him. That is because ‘howness’ relates to the creatures and refers to their state in terms of qualities such as height, weight, position, and so on, none of which applies to the Almighty. And ‘whereness’ describes the position, direction, and location of a thing – if Allāh had a direction or a place, He would need it to exist, but He is free of all need and completely independent (Z).

The Imām then says *He was the Knower even when there was nothing to be known*, since knowledge is an attribute of His Essence, which is timeless (T). That which is known is contingent and comes later, yet His knowledge thereof is not dependent on its existence (MB). He knows things before they exist, and when they come into existence, and His knowledge of them does not change (Z). Likewise, He was *the Nurturer even when there was nothing to be nurtured, and the All-powerful even when there was nothing to be overpowered*, since the qualities of nurturing (*rubūbiyyah*) and power (*qudrah*) are also attributes of His Essence (M). Some commentators say that the meaning of ‘*al-rabb*’ here is owner (*mālik*), and since Allāh is the owner of all time and space, and it is He who brings it into existence from non-existence, and vice versa, as He wills, He was thus even before what is nurtured by Him came into being (MB). In the same way, His power existed pre-eternally, since it is by His power that all things come into existence, and continue to exist, as and when He pleases (Z).

ALSO: ON RELIGIOUS LEADERS

- 3 The riser has risen, the refulgent has gleamed, the emergent has emerged, and the bent has been straightened. Allāh has replaced one people with another and one day with another. We awaited these changes as the famine-stricken await the rain. Certainly, the Imāms are Allāh's custodians over His creatures and His supervisors over His servants. None shall enter Paradise except he who knows them and is known by them, and none shall enter the Fire except one who denies them and is denied by them.

- 4 Verily Allāh, the Exalted, has distinguished you through Islam and has chosen you for it. That is because it is the epithet of peace and the assemblage of honour. Allāh, the Exalted, chose its course and clarified its proofs through manifest knowledge and hidden wisdom. Its wonders never cease and its marvels never end. In it are blooms of bounties and lamps for the darkness. [The doors of] virtues are not opened save with its keys, and [the veils of] darkness cannot be dispelled save by its lamps. He has protected its domain and opened up its pastures. In it is a cure for the one who seeks a cure and sufficiency for the one who seeks sufficiency.

منها: في أئمة الدين

٣ قَدْ طَلَعَ طَالِعٌ، وَلَمَعَ لَامِعٌ،
وَلَا حَ لَائِحٌ، وَاعْتَدَلَ مَائِلٌ،
وَاسْتَبَدَلَ اللَّهُ بِقَوْمٍ قَوْمًا، وَبِیَوْمٍ
یَوْمًا، وَانْتَظَرْنَا الْغَیْرَ انْتَظَارَ
الْمُجْدِبِ الْمَطَرِ. وَإِنَّمَا الْأَئِمَّةُ
قُوَامُ اللَّهِ عَلَى خَلْقِهِ، وَغُرَفَاؤُهُ
عَلَى عِبَادِهِ، وَلَا يَدْخُلُ الْجَنَّةَ
إِلَّا مَنْ عَرَفَهُمْ وَعَرَفُوهُ، وَلَا
يَدْخُلُ النَّارَ إِلَّا مَنْ أَنْكَرَهُمْ
وَأَنْكَرُوهُ.

٤ إِنَّ اللَّهَ تَعَالَى خَصَّكُمْ بِالْإِسْلَامِ
وَاسْتَخْلَصَكُمْ لَهُ، وَذَلِكَ لِأَنَّهُ اسْمُ
سَلَامَةٍ، وَجَمَاعُ كَرَامَةٍ، اضْطَفَى اللَّهُ
تَعَالَى مِنْهُجَةً وَبَيَّنَّ حُجَجَهُ، مِنْ
ظَاهِرِ عِلْمٍ وَبَاطِنِ حُكْمٍ، لَا تَقْنَى
غَرَائِبُهُ وَلَا تَنْقُضِي عَجَائِبُهُ، فِيهِ
مَرَايِغُ النِّعَمِ وَمَصَابِيحُ الظُّلُمِ، لَا
تُفْتَحُ الْخَيْرَاتُ إِلَّا بِمِفْتَاحِهِ، وَلَا
تُكْشَفُ الظُّلُمَاتُ إِلَّا بِمَصَابِيحِهِ، قَدْ
أَحْمَى حِمَاهُ وَأَرَعَى مَرْعَاهُ، فِيهِ
شِفَاءُ الْمُسْتَفِي وَكَفَايَةُ الْمُكْتَفِي.

3 Those who take this sermon, and particularly this passage, to have been spoken after Amīr al-Mu'minīn became the caliph, claim that the Imām is speaking about himself here (I), and this interpretation seems to fit in well with the content of this section of the oration (Z). Rising of *the riser* refers to the arrival of the period of his rule, and the transference of the caliphate to him (M). It is possible that the first three phrases refer to this same event (I), or the second phrase *the refulgent has gleamed* connotes the return of his right to him, and the shining forth of justice thereby. And the third phrase, *the emergent has emerged*, alludes to the emergence of wars and strife that would come about after authority was passed on to him (MB). Indeed, by the leadership of the *ummah* passing to its rightful owner, *the bent and crooked state of the days of 'Uthmān had been straightened* and set aright (T). In this way, Allāh *replaced one people with another and one day with another*, as He replaced 'Uthmān and his followers with 'Alī and his followers, and the former's reign with the latter's (I), or more generally, Allāh replaced darkness with light, oppression with justice, and falsehood with truth (T). Some have interpreted the Imām's statement *we awaited these changes as the famine-stricken await the rain* as proof that the Imām knew what would transpire, or his acceptance of what had been divinely decreed in this regard (MB). Others take it to mean that the Muslims were eagerly waiting for a change in the status quo, as the nepotism and injustice had become unbearable for them. Indeed, the Imām had himself warned the third caliph of the negative outcome of his actions, but he turned a deaf ear to the Imām's advice (Z). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then proceeds to describe the role and function of Imāms, saying that they are *Allāh's custodians over His creatures and His supervisors over His servants*, meaning they are caretakers who have been appointed by Him to lead the people (N). It is clear that by *Imāms* here, it is the infallible Imāms from the Ahl al-Bayt being referred to, and no one else (T). Their custodianship over the people refers to acting in their best interests and administering their affairs, or establishing the commands and prohibitions of Allāh and His laws among the people, as His representatives on earth (MB). The term "*urafā'u*" is plural of *'arīf*, which means overseer or supervisor, and it shows that they have been tasked with managing the affairs of the people, and thus obedience to them has been made mandatory on all (Z).

So important is their position that *none shall enter Paradise except he who knows them and is known by them, and none shall enter the Fire except one who denies them and is denied by them*. This means that people of every generation will

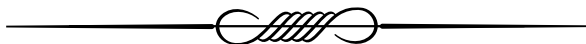
not gain entry into Paradise unless they know the Imām of their time, and he too knows them. Knowing them here means recognizing their status as divinely appointed guides. This condition for entry into Paradise may be understood in two ways. Firstly, we know that no believer will enter Paradise unless he follows the laws of the *sharī'ah* as ordained by the Almighty, and that is not something easily attained unless one has knowledge about it. To gain this knowledge, one has to refer to those who possess it and are aware of all aspects thereof. That is none other than the divinely chosen guides – the Imāms. Secondly, belief in *wilāyah* and *imāmah* is itself part of the foundations of faith, and one cannot enter Paradise without belief (M). As for the Imāms knowing him, it refers to their guidance of the individual, or testimony on his behalf before Allāh that he believed and followed them (Z). If one were to ask: how can it be said that only those who deny them will enter Hell while we know that even sinners who do not deny them will be cast into hellfire? A number of possible answers to this may be offered. First, it is possible that what is being spoken of here is abiding in Hell for eternity, meaning those sinners who believe in them may go to Hell for a period of time, but not forever. Second, perhaps this denial may allude to a person's denial and rejection of the religion as a whole, and that would cause him to be deserving of eternal damnation. Third, it may mean that whoever disobeys Allāh is as one who has denied the Imāms, and they too reject him, as noted in their statement, "Our *wilāyah* is not actualized except by action." As for the notion that even the wicked among the Shī'ah will be saved from hellfire, that goes against the established principles of the Qur'ān and Sunnah, and is hence invalid (T).

4 In this last section, the Imām mentions one of the greatest blessings granted to the believers, namely the religion of Islam. He says that Allāh *has distinguished you through Islam and has chosen you for it*. Though he was addressing his companions, this is something that applies to every Muslim, since it is meant as a reminder of the bounty of Islam and an encouragement to adhere to it (Z). The Imām calls Islam *the epithet of peace* ('*ism al-salāmah*') because it is derived from the term *al-salāmah* which denotes safety and security (I). Alternatively, this has nothing to do with its lexical derivation, but rather with its function and purpose. Indeed, Islam is the means by which one gains security from the wrath of the Omnipotent Lord, and salvation from the Fire (MB). Others have understood it as having a broader meaning, since a peaceful life is one with harmony, empathy, and mutual cooperation, which is what one attains when he follows the teachings of

Islam (Z). The Imām also calls it *the assemblage of honour* ('*jimā'u karāmah*'), meaning that it comprises all that would elevate the human being and ennoble him, raising him to a respected position and an honourable status through guidance towards virtue and righteousness, ultimately leading him to felicity and Paradise (M). Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn says that the course of Islam has been chosen by Allāh, and its proofs have been clarified by Him *through manifest knowledge and hidden wisdom*. Some commentators suggest that this could be a reference to the Qur'ān, which contains both manifest knowledge and secret wisdom (I). Others posit that *manifest knowledge* refers to that which is found in the Qur'ān and Sunnah, whereas *hidden wisdom* connotes intellectual proofs (MB). Yet others take the former to refer to rational evidence and the latter to mean the secret wisdom behind Divine injunctions and laws (N). The pronoun 'its' in *its wonders never cease and its marvels never end* refers to the Glorious Qur'ān (Z), or to Islam in general (MB). The former interpretation means that the Qur'ān is ever-fresh and keeps giving guidance and wisdom every time one reads it, never growing old or irrelevant over time (T), and the latter interpretation refers to how amazingly Islam overpowered all the pagan powers in such a short time with Allāh's help (MB). Most commentators, however, prefer the first meaning since it matches the current context (N).

The Imām further states that *in it are blooms of bounties and lamps for the darkness*. The phrase '*marābī' al-ni'am*' describes the verdant blooms which result from the abundant rains of spring, and here it is used metaphorically to allude to the copious blessings one attains by reading the Qur'ān and acting upon its teachings (M). The *lamps* contained within it reflect the function of the Holy Book as described in the verse: [*This is*] *a Book We have sent down to you so that you may lead people out from darkness into light, by the permission of their Lord, to the path of the Mighty, the Praised* (Q14:1) (T). He further says that it is only *with its keys* that the doors to virtue can be opened, and only by using its lamps can one dispel the veils of darkness. This could generally signify that only the Qur'ān has the prescription for a successful life, and it is only the Qur'ān that contains the solutions to all the problems one faces in life (Z). Hence, if one seeks these prescriptions and solutions elsewhere, he will fall into error (N). The Imām subsequently states *He has protected its domain and opened up its pastures*, where the pronoun 'He' refers to the Almighty (I), or if read differently, it could refer to the Qur'ān itself, in which case the translation would read *it has protected its domain and opened up its pastures*

(N). This means that Allāh has outlined His prohibitions through the Qurʾān (R), and has likewise granted permission to His servants to enjoy that which He has made lawful for them (T). Finally, the Imām says that the Qurʾān contains within it *a cure for the one who seeks a cure, and sufficiency for the one who seeks sufficiency*. It heals the maladies of ignorance and misguidance, and offers that which suffices one who seeks the truth and is pleased with justice (Z). Those who interpreted the earlier pronoun as referring to Islam rather than the Qurʾān say that these descriptions also pertain to the religion, for Islam contains the keys to virtue, illumination from darkness, prescriptions that lead to felicity, a cure for spiritual maladies within its ethical teachings, as well as that which is enough to render believers independent and free of need through the truth it conveys (MB).



CHARACTERISTICS OF CERTAIN GROUPS

DESCRIPTION OF THE MISGUIDED ONE

- 1 In the respite he has [been given] from Allāh, he falls [into error] with the heedless and spends his days with the sinners, with neither a straight path nor a guiding leader.

صفة الضال

١ وَهُوَ فِي مُهْلَةٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ يَهْوِي مَعَ
الْغَافِلِينَ، وَيَعْدُو مَعَ الْمُذْنِبِينَ،
بِلا سَبِيلٍ قَاصِدٍ، وَلَا إِمَامٍ
قَائِدٍ.

ON THE QUALITIES OF THE HEEDLESS

- 2 Until when He unveils for them the requital of their sins and brings them out from [under] their cloaks of heedlessness, they will approach [it] having turned back and turn back having approached. Then they will neither benefit from attaining what they sought [in the world], nor from achieving what they desired.
- 3 I warn you and myself of this situation. Every individual must derive benefit for himself, as the wise one is only he who hears and reflects, sees and observes, and benefits from lessons [of past events]. Then he proceeds on a clear pathway, in which he avoids falling into pits and straying into errors, and he does not assist the misguided ones against himself by twisting the truth, distorting speech, or fearing honesty.

منها: في صفات الغافلين

٢ حَتَّى إِذَا كُشِفَ لَهُمْ عَنْ جَزَاءِ
مَعْصِيَتِهِمْ، وَاسْتَخْرَجَهُمْ مِنْ
جَلَابِيبِ غَفْلَتِهِمْ، اسْتَقْبَلُوا
مُذْبِرًا وَاسْتَدْبَرُوا مُقْبِلًا، فَلَمْ
يَنْتَفِعُوا بِمَا أَدْرَكُوا مِنْ طَلِبَتِهِمْ،
وَلَا بِمَا قَضَوْا مِنْ وَطَرِهِمْ.

٣ إِنِّي أَحْذَرُكُمْ، وَنَفْسِي، هَذِهِ الْمَنْزِلَةَ،
فَلْيَنْتَفِعْ امْرُؤٌ بِنَفْسِهِ، فَإِنَّمَا الْبَصِيرُ مَنْ
سَمِعَ فَتَفَكَّرَ، وَنَظَرَ فَأَبْصَرَ، وَانْتَفَعَ بِالْعِبَرِ،
ثُمَّ سَلَكَ جَدًّا وَاضِحًا يَتَجَنَّبُ فِيهِ
الصَّرْعَةَ فِي الْمَهَاوِي، وَالضَّلَالَ فِي
الْمَغَاوِي، وَلَا يَعِينُ عَلَى نَفْسِهِ الْغَوَاةَ
بِتَعْصُفٍ فِي حَقٍّ، أَوْ تَحْرِيفٍ فِي نُطْقٍ،
أَوْ تَخَوُّفٍ مِنْ صِدْقٍ.

CONTEXT

In some manuscripts of *Nahj al-Balāghah*, this oration is recorded as part of the previous sermon. Perhaps one reason for this is the abrupt manner in which this sermon starts, which shows that it must have been preceded by something which al-Sayyid al-Raḍī has not quoted here. According to Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd, the Imām spoke these words while proceeding to Baṣrah to fight the rebels in what came to be known as the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH). This leads us to conclude that Ibn Abī al-Ḥadīd must have read this sermon in another source which mentioned the details about its context. Other early sources that quote parts of this oration are *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl* and *al-Kāfi* (N). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this speech in a longer oration delivered by the Imām on the first Friday after his arrival in Kūfah, within a sermon named ‘al-Minbariyyah’ (4:186). In any case, it contains some advice that is generally applicable and beneficial for all people.

COMMENTARY

1 The opening section begins with a pronoun which shows that something before it was elided, and varying opinions exist regarding whom the Imām spoke of. Some say the pronouns ‘he’ and ‘his’ refer to individuals who refused to support Imām ‘Alī in the Battle of Jamal (R), or more generally any person who has fallen into misguidance and has lost his way (I). Others opine that it is not possible to definitively say whom the Imām was referring to because of the omission of what precedes it (MB). In any case, we know from the Qur’ān that those who disbelieve or go astray are indeed given some respite in this world in order to mend their ways (e.g. Q73:11) (T). The term ‘*muhlah*’ has been translated as *respite*, and here it refers to the lifespan of an individual (M). Instead of using this time to reform and improve himself, the misguided one who has strayed from the path of virtue and righteousness falls further into error, as he joins the company of the heedless ones and *spends his days with the sinners*. This, then, renders him among those who are doomed and face annihilation (M), for indeed they neither follow a straight path, nor have a *guiding leader*. It is possible that the phrase ‘*imāmin qā'id*’ refers to the infallible Imāms of the Ahl al-Bayt, or to any Godworthy leader who adheres to the teachings of the Prophet and his pure progeny. Either way, its inclusion here points to the important role of good, pious leadership in the guidance of people, just as the bad company of heedless and sinful individuals leads to error (N).

2 Though this section is clearly separate from what precedes it, and seems to be from another part of the sermon, some commentators have tried to draw a link between the two by pointing out that in the first section the Imām alluded to the heedlessness of the misguided people and in this section, he points to how short-lived this state of heedlessness is before the veils are lifted and death makes the reality apparent to all people (N). He then describes what will happen when Allāh unveils for the people *the requital of their sins*, revealing thereby the punishment that awaits them in the Hereafter, having brought them out from under *their cloaks of heedlessness* that covered them in this world. These were the people who whiled away their time in the world, wasting it in play and entertainment, completely negligent of death until the moment of its arrival (Z). It has been suggested that the *cloaks of heedlessness* refer to the physical aspect of human existence, which can act as a veil that causes one to forget the more important spiritual aspect thereof. Focussing on one's physical needs and desires automatically leads one to become heedless of his spiritual development. Indeed traditions tell us that this world and the Hereafter are on opposite ends such that the nearer one gets towards one, the farther he becomes from the other (M). It is only when one departs from this world that the veils of negligence are rent apart, as the Qur'ān states: "*You had indeed been heedless of this, so We lifted from you your veil and today your sight is piercing*" (Q50:22). The phrase *they will approach having turned back and turn back having approached* ('istaqbalū mudbiran wa istadbarū muqbilan') means that they will face the horrors they had turned away from in negligence, and separate from their wealth and children (Z). Or they will encounter what they thought would never befall them of punishment and wretchedness, and part ways with what they had relied upon of this world (T). The first was unseen to them in this world, but now becomes apparent, while the second was present with them in the world, but is now left behind (MB). In short, they come to recognize the truth of what they denied, and realize the futility of what they considered important (I). Thus, *they will neither benefit from attaining what they sought* of the wealth they amassed in this world, or the power they strove to achieve (R). Alternatively, this means that the worldly desires they hankered after will be of no use to them as they will have left it all behind (MB). They will likewise gain nothing from the desires they fulfilled and the passions they slaked (Z). The phrase '*qaḍaw min waṭarīhim*' means satisfying their needs and wants to the fullest – and despite

their doing so, and taking full advantage of what they had access to in this world, none of it was of any use to them in the end (N).

3 The reason for saying that he warns himself as well was only to make the people more pliable and likely to follow his advice (T). The phrase '*hādhihi al-manzilah*' means this station or situation, and refers to the state of heedlessness and ignorance he had earlier described. In some manuscripts instead of '*al-manzilah*', we find the term '*al-mazallah*', which means a slippery place where one can fall into error, and refers to this world (MB). The Imām then says that every individual should *derive benefit for himself* ('*falyantafi'imru'un binafsihi*'), meaning he should take advantage of the blessings he has been granted (N), or he should use the intellect he has been given, for it is through the intellect that he can reflect, observe, and derive lessons, after which he is able to choose the most beneficial course of action (Z). Amīr al-Mu'minīn then equates the one who does this to a wise individual, for it is only a person who possesses wisdom and discernment that will do what is truly in his best interest (M). He says only he *who hears and reflects, sees and observes, and benefits from lessons* of past events and experiences can be considered wise. Here the word '*al-baṣīr*' is rendered as *wise*, since it connotes a person with the ability to see the correct course of action through reflection and observation. He is one who recognizes what would bring him benefit and what would cause harm (MB). Having done so, such an individual then *proceeds on a clear pathway in which he avoids falling into pits and straying into errors*. The term '*jadaḍ*' refers to firm, solid ground whereupon one who walks is safe from slipping or tripping (R). '*Al-mahāwī*' and '*al-maghāwī*' refer, respectively, to a place where one can fall into, such as canyons or pits (T), and dubious pathways that lead one to error (I). Thus, the Imām is saying that whoever understands the reality of things, and benefits from experience and admonition, is guided to the path of salvation and can traverse it with confidence of attaining success and felicity in the end (Z). And because such a person has discernment and wisdom, *he does not assist the misguided ones against himself*, thereby giving them ammunition against him, and a means of causing him harm, *by twisting the truth, distorting speech, or fearing honesty*.

The term '*al-ghuwāt*' refers to those who are not cautious of error and misguidance (Z), or those who are steeped in ignorance (MB). The phrase '*ta'assufin fi haqq*' means using vagueness in language to twist the truth, as is practiced by those who try to portray a thing that is forbidden as something lawful using clever

ADVISING THE PEOPLE

4 So sober up from your intoxication, O listener, and awaken from your heedlessness; reduce your hastiness and ponder carefully upon what has come to you through the unlettered Prophet (ﷺ), which is inevitable and inescapable. Oppose the one who opposes this in favour of something else, and leave him and whatever he has accepted for himself. Set aside your pride, let go of your haughtiness and recall your grave, for verily your passage is through it. As you will deal with others, so shall you be dealt with, and you will reap what you sow. What you send forth today, you will meet tomorrow. So pave the way for your arrival [in the Hereafter] and send forth [good deeds] for your day [of reckoning]. Be cautious, be cautious, O listener! And strive, strive, O heedless one! *And none can inform you like the One who is All-aware.*

5 Verily one of the verdicts of Allāh in the Wise Reminder, based upon which He bestows reward or metes out punishment, and through which He is pleased or angered, is that it will not benefit a man, even if he exerts himself and acts sincerely, if he leaves this world to meet his Lord with one of these traits without repenting for it: that he ascribes a partner to Allāh in

عظة الناس

٤ فَأَفِقْ أَتُهَا السَّامِعُ مِنْ سَكْرَتِكَ،
وَاسْتَيْقِظْ مِنْ غَفْلَتِكَ، وَاحْتَصِرْ
مِنْ عَجَلَتِكَ، وَأَنْعِمِ الْفِكْرَ فِيمَا
جَاءَكَ عَلَى لِسَانِ النَّبِيِّ
الْأُمِّيِّ ﷺ مِمَّا لَا بُدَّ مِنْهُ
وَلَا مَحِيصَ عَنْهُ، وَخَالَفَ مَنْ
خَالَفَ ذَلِكَ إِلَى غَيْرِهِ، وَدَعَا
وَمَا رَضِيَ لِنَفْسِهِ، وَضَعَ فُحْرَكَ،
وَاحْطُطْ كِبْرَكَ، وَادْكُرْ قَبْرَكَ،
فَإِنَّ عَلَيْهِ مَمَرَّكَ، وَكَمَا تَدِينُ
تُدَانُ، وَكَمَا تَزْرَعُ تَحْصُدُ، وَمَا
قَدَّمْتَ الْيَوْمَ تَقْدَمُ عَلَيْهِ غَدًا،
فَأَمْهَدِ لِقَدَمِكَ، وَقَدِّمِ لِيَوْمِكَ.
فَالْحَذَرَ الْحَذَرَ أَتُهَا الْمُسْتَمِعُ!
وَالْجِدَّ الْجِدَّ أَتُهَا الْغَافِلُ! «وَلَا
يُنَبِّئُكَ مِثْلُ خَبِيرٍ».

٥ إِنَّ مِنْ عَزَائِمِ اللَّهِ فِي الذِّكْرِ
الْحَكِيمِ، الَّتِي عَلَيْهَا يُثِيبُ وَيُعَاقِبُ،
وَلَهَا يَرْضَى وَيَسْخَطُ، أَنَّهُ لَا يَنْفَعُ
عَبْدًا - وَإِنْ أَجْهَدَ نَفْسَهُ وَأَخْلَصَ
فِعْلَهُ - أَنْ يَخْرُجَ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا لَا قِيَاءَ رَبَّهُ
بِخَصْلَةٍ مِنْ هَذِهِ الْخِصَالِ لَمْ يُتَبَّ
مِنْهَا: أَنْ يُشْرِكَ بِاللَّهِ فِيمَا افْتَرَضَ

what He has made obligatory upon him of His worship, or appeases his own anger by taking a life, or faults a person for an act committed by another, or seeks fulfilment of a need from people by introducing an innovation in His religion, or meets people while double-faced, or walks among them with a forked-tongue.

- 6 Understand this, for indeed an illustration is a guide for its like. Verily cattle are only concerned with their stomachs and predators are only concerned with preying on others. Verily women [who lack faith] are concerned only with the adornments of this world and creating mischief in it. Verily the believers are humble, verily the believers are apprehensive [of divine punishment], and verily the believers are afraid [of the Almighty].

عَلَيْهِ مِنْ عِبَادَتِهِ، أَوْ يَشْفِي عَيْظَهُ
بِهَلَاكِ نَفْسٍ، أَوْ يُعَرِّ بِأَمْرِ فَعَلَهُ غَيْرُهُ،
أَوْ يَسْتَنْجِحَ حَاجَةً إِلَى النَّاسِ
بِإِظْهَارِ بَدْعَةٍ فِي دِينِهِ، أَوْ يَلْقَى
النَّاسَ بِوَجْهَيْنِ، أَوْ يَمْشِي فِيهِمْ
بِلِسَانَيْنِ.

٦ اغْقِلْ ذَلِكَ فَإِنَّ الْمَثَلَ دَلِيلٌ
عَلَى شَبِيهِهِ. إِنَّ الْبَهَائِمَ هُمُّهَا
بُطُونُهَا، وَإِنَّ السَّابَاعَ هُمُّهَا
الْعُدَوَانُ عَلَى غَيْرِهَا، وَإِنَّ النِّسَاءَ
هُمُّهُنَّ زِينَةُ الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا
وَالْفَسَادُ فِيهَا؛ إِنَّ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ
مُسْتَكِينُونَ، إِنَّ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ
مُشْفِقُونَ، إِنَّ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ خَائِفُونَ.

trickery and semantics (Z). Some commentators understand it to mean that one should not show the misguided people anything which they might use to harm him, and he should hide such kinds of facts from them using means such as twisting the truth and concealing it from them (MB). Yet others take it to connote assisting the misguided folk by joining them in doing things that go against righteousness, such as distorting the truth and misrepresenting words that are spoken, as that would encourage them while bringing harm to his soul (M). Feigning fear of honesty (*'takhawwufin fi šidq'*) even when one is not truly afraid thereof, just to remain on good terms with the misguided people, is also harmful. A believer should thus not allow fear of others to push him towards any of these things (MB). Another interpretation of *fearing honesty* is remaining silent in the face of injustice and suppression of truth out of fear of the anger of wrongdoers (Z), and that too is blameworthy.

4 Having warned his listeners, the Imām instructs them to *sober up* (*‘afiq*) from their intoxication, and awaken from their heedlessness. In another version, the word *‘al-mustamti*’ is mentioned in place of *‘al-sāmi*’, and some say that is more correct, since it is one who is intoxicated by the pleasures of this world that is being told to sober up (T). The terms intoxication (*al-sakrah*) and heedlessness (*al-ghaflah*) have been paired because both these states lead one to abandon work, and just like a sleeping person is unaware of what goes on around him until he is woken up, so too is a heedless person oblivious until he is ‘woken up’ from his negligence (MB). The phrase *‘ikhtaṣir min ‘ajalatik*’ is rendered *reduce your hastiness*, and means do not be hasty in your affair until you are aware of its consequences (Z), or temper your haste for worldly gain and reduce your inclination for the same (MB). The Imām then tells them to *ponder carefully upon what has come to them through the unlettered Prophet (ṣ), which is inevitable and inescapable*. The phrase *‘an’im al-fikr*’ means contemplate and reflect upon with seriousness (R), and the *inevitable and inescapable* refers to death and the Day of Judgment (M), or what the Noble Messenger had prophesied about the oath-breakers at the Battle of Jamal (T). The meaning of the adjective *‘al-ummi*’ for the Messenger of Allāh has been the subject of much debate among scholars throughout the ages. Essentially, it has three possible meanings: one who is unlettered, meaning he has not undergone any formal education or tutelage; one who rose up among the masses (*ummah*); or one who is from Umm al-Qurā, which was a name given to the city of Makkah. There are arguments that can be made for each of these meanings, and some commentators have opted for the first meaning, while others insist on the last meaning (MB), yet perhaps all the possible meanings are correct (N).

Amīr al-Mu’minīn then tells the people to *oppose anyone who opposes this in favour of something else, and leave him and whatever he has accepted for himself*, meaning that whoever goes against what the Prophet said should be opposed, resisted, and rejected (T). Alternatively, it means those who turn away from thinking of death and resurrection, and focus instead on this world and its pleasures, should be opposed (MB). The Imām then addresses one of the worst flaws in character, namely arrogance. He tells the people to discard their pride, abandon their haughtiness, and recall the grave, *for verily your passage is through it* (*‘inna ‘alayhi mamarrak*). Indeed, just as one who has to walk through a dark passageway needs to prepare some form of illumination, so too does the person who knows that he will have to go through the grave to get to the Hereafter (M). The grave is likened

to a passageway because it is not the final abode, but only a path which must be traversed to arrive at the Hereafter (I). Remembering death and the darkness of the grave helps to remove arrogance from one's heart, which in turn saves one from the ignorance and small-mindedness that comes with it. In some narrations we are told the haughty will be resurrected as tiny creatures that will be trodden upon by the people as a requital for their pride (Z).

The imperatives '*ḍa*' and '*uḥṭuṭ*' literally mean laying down and descending, respectively, so it is as though the Imām is likening their removal of pride to descending from a mount or placing it down on the ground, which is apt considering arrogance makes one think he is higher than others (N). A fundamental and universal rule is then mentioned by the Imām when he says *as you will deal with others, so shall you be dealt with, and you will reap what you sow*, meaning as you treat others, so shall you be treated (I), or more specifically, if you nurture evil, like one who plants a seed and nurtures it, then you will reap the destruction it brings just as you will conversely benefit from nurturing virtue (MB). To emphasize this further, the Imām states *what you send forth today, you will meet tomorrow*, which is a reflection of the verse: *...and whatever good you send ahead for yourselves, you shall find it with Allāh...* (Q2:110) and other, similar verses (T). The Imām then tells each listener to exercise caution regarding all his deeds, past and future, and to strive hard, both openly and in secret (R). Some commentators interpret the term '*al-jidd*' here as seriousness, as opposed to jest (T), in which case he is telling the heedless people to become serious in their endeavours. However, most understand the term to connote striving and working hard, and here it refers to striving to be Godwary and virtuous (MB). Finally, this section ends with the Imām quoting a line from the Qurʾān: *...and none can inform you like the One who is Aware* (Q35:14). By this he means that no one can inform the people about the reality of things like one who has knowledge about those realities (I), and here he is referring to himself. This type of quote is known as *iqtibās* (T) and is commonly used to convey meanings using the words of the Qurʾān. Indeed, whoever reads the descriptions of this world given by Imām 'Alī in *Nahj al-Balāghah* and other sources will see that nobody has spoken about the realities of this *dunyā* the way he has, and he has presented a comprehensive and complete image of it, from various angles and perspectives, in a unique manner (Z).

5 The Imām then mentions *one of the verdicts of Allāh in the Wise Reminder*, which pertains to certain traits that lead to eternal punishment if forgiveness is

not sought. The term '*al-ʿazāʾim*' is translated as *verdicts*, and refers to obligatory statutes, as opposed to '*al-rukḥāṣ*' which means that which is flexible and permitted; and *the Wise Reminder* ('*al-dhikr al-ḥakīm*') is the Glorious Qurʾān (T). Some commentators understand '*al-ʿazāʾim*' to mean those matters that are decisive, clear, and unequivocal (Z, N). In any case, the Imām says it is on the basis of this verdict or resolution that Allāh *bestows reward or metes out punishment, and through which He is pleased or angered*, thereby highlighting its great significance. It is through acting upon it that one attains divine rewards and neglecting or rejecting it brings down punishment (MB). Then he states that even if one exerts himself and acts sincerely, as long as he leaves this world without repenting for any one of the following traits, his efforts will be in vain. The phrase *without repenting* is only mentioned for emphasis and clarity, as even without it the meaning would be conveyed (I). The implication is there are certain sins that invalidate and nullify any good deed a person performs, no matter how sincere his intention may be; and here the Imām mentions five such sins (Z). The first is ascribing partners to Allāh *in what He has made obligatory upon him of His worship*. This connotes performing acts of worship to show off to the people rather than out of sincere devotion to the Almighty (MB). Or, more generally, taking other gods besides Allāh and worshipping them (I). Indeed, worshipping with the intention of showing off (*al-riyāʾ*) is also a form of polytheism, and has been termed 'the hidden *shirk*' by the Messenger of Allāh (Z). The second sin is appeasing one's anger by taking a life without right, which is what the phrase '*bi ḥalāki nafsīn*' means (I). In some manuscripts the phrase reads '*bi ḥalāki nafsīhī*', which would be rendered *by destroying himself*, referring to allowing oneself to be consumed by rage until he ends up fatally harming himself (MB). However, the first reading is more commonly accepted (M), and that is why we chose it here. The third sin is censuring someone for an action committed by another person, thereby assassinating his character and impugning his reputation. According to what we find in the narrations, the value of a person's respect and esteem is similar to that of his life and blood, and must therefore be preserved (N). Regarding this, the Qurʾān states: *And whoever commits an offence or a sin, then casts blame for it on an innocent person, has indeed taken on a burden of calumny and manifest sin* (Q4:112) (T).

The fourth sin is trying to fulfil one's needs or attain what one wants from the people by innovating a heresy in religion ('*bi iẓḥāri bidʿatin fī dīnihī*'), by which he

declares lawful what Allāh has forbidden, or forbids what Allāh has made lawful, all for worldly gain (Z). So grave is this sin that a tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq states, “Whoever walks towards a heretic (*ṣāḥib bid‘ah*) and shows him respect, has actually walked in the [pathway to the] destruction of Islam” (T). A narration from Abū ‘Abdillāh suffices to highlight the gravity of this sin. It is reported, he said, that there was once a man who tried to earn wealth through lawful means but failed. So he tried through unlawful means, and still failed. Then Satan came to him and said, “O so-and-so! You have tried to seek this world through lawful means but were unsuccessful, and you tried through unlawful means, but were still unable to acquire it. Should I show you a way by which your wealth will increase and so will your followers?” He replied affirmatively, so Satan said, “Innovate a religion and call people to it.” The man did so, and slowly people began responding to him and obeying him. In this way, he became very wealthy. Then he thought to himself, “What have I done? I have invented a religion and invited people to it. I see no means of repentance from this except if I openly declare to them that it is false.” So he began approaching his followers and telling them, “What I had invited you towards was false. I had only invented it!” But they responded, “You lie! This is the truth. It is only that you have begun to doubt it and have thus recanted it.” When he saw this, he placed a chain around his neck and tethered it saying, “I will not undo this until Allāh forgives me!” So Allāh revealed to one of His Prophets, “Tell so-and-so, ‘By My Might, even if you supplicate to Me until your limbs fall off, I will not answer You unless you return those who died upon your false religion and make them recant it!’” (MB).

The fifth sin is being a hypocrite, or what the Imām refers to as being *double-faced*, or having a *forked-tongue*. Having two faces or two tongues means pretending to be what one is not, or saying something different from what is in one’s heart (N). Some commentators say that gossipers and backbiters also fall into this category, since they speak ill of others behind their backs while pretending to be their admirers and friends in their presence (MB). Others say these are individuals who bring about divisions among the people, breaking up friendships and increasing hostility among enemies (M). In any case, the evil of hypocrisy is evident, and its punishment is severe. In one tradition, Imām al-Ṣādiq reportedly said, “Whoever meets a believer with a double-face and a forked tongue, he will come on the Day of Judgment with two tongues of fire” (T).

6 This last section has been narrated by al-Kulaynī in *al-Kāfī*, and al-Ḥarrānī in *Tuḥaf al-Uqūl*, and according to some commentators it implicitly refers to the leaders of the rebellion in the Battle of Jamal (T). Amīr al-Muʾminīn starts by telling the people to focus their attention in order to understand what he is saying, *for indeed an illustration is a guide for its like*, meaning the example he gives should be reflected upon, as it sheds light on all other cases that are similar and clarifies them (M). Some take this first statement to be a reference to what precedes it, namely the five vices that the Imām mentioned, which were all present among the enemy at the Battle of Jamal (N), while others take it as referring to what follows (T). The first similitude mentioned by the Imām is that *cattle are only concerned with their stomachs*, meaning that anyone whose primary concern is the fulfilment of his base urges can be likened to cattle, since they are not bothered by the deeper realities and are hence like grazing animals (M). In the famous narration of al-Mufaḍḍal, Imām al-Ṣādiq is reported to have said that one of the reasons why daytime has been limited is in order to stop the cattle from eating, otherwise they would eat themselves to death! If we accept the contention that the Imām was implicitly referring to Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr here, it could mean that he was likening them to cattle because their only focus was attainment of worldly wealth, and that is why they rose up to their own detriment (T). Secondly, he says that *predators are only concerned with preying on others*, meaning they are only concerned about attacking and overcoming their prey, which is an allusion to giving in to one's violent tendencies (*al-quwwah al-ghaḍabiyyah*) (M). This can likewise apply to Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr, for history shows how they remained obstinate in their wanting to fight the Imām, despite all attempts on his part to try and seek a peaceful solution (T).

The third statement pertains to women who, the Imām says, *are concerned only with the adornments of this world and creating mischief in it*, which again refers to their being consumed by base desires (MB). Some commentators link this to the general nature of women (I). However, given that the first two examples fit in well with the nature of Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr, it is more plausible that Imām ʿAlī was alluding here to the third instigator of the Battle of Jamal, ʿĀʾishah bint Abī Bakr (T). In any case, these three analogies do not apply to true believers, since their qualities are different, as the Imām subsequently clarifies when describing the believing men and women (Z). He says that the believers are *humble* (*ʿmustakīnūn*), *apprehensive* of divine punishment (*ʿmushfiqūn*), and *afraid* of the Almighty

(‘*khāʿifūn*’). The term ‘*mushfiqūn*’ has been rendered as *apprehensive* to match what is mentioned in the Qurʾān (Q42:18, Q21:28, etc.) (MB), but it is also possible that here it means ‘compassionate’, especially if these three qualities are contrasted with the three negative qualities that were mentioned earlier. So they are unlike predators who constantly want to harm their prey, because they are kind and compassionate towards others (T).



ON THE MERITS OF THE AHL AL-BAYT

1 The eye of [one with] an intelligent heart is that by which he sees his end and recognizes its lowlands and its elevations. The caller made his call and the leader led [his flock], so respond to the caller and follow the leader. They dived into the seas of strife and took hold of innovations instead of established practices. The believers shrunk back while the misguided liars became vocal. We are the intimates and the companions [of the Prophet], the keepers and doors [to the Sunnah]. And houses are not entered save through their doors. So whoever enters them from other than their doors is called a thief.

وَنَاطِظُ قَلْبِ اللَّيِّبِ بِهِ يُبْصِرُ أَمَدَهُ،
وَيَعْرِفُ غَوْرَةَ وَنَجْدَهُ. دَاعٍ دَعَا
وَرَاعٍ رَعَى، فَاسْتَجَبُوا لِلدَّاعِي
وَاتَّبَعُوا الرَّاعِي. قَدْ خَاضُوا بِحَارَ
الْفِتَنِ، وَأَخَذُوا بِالْبِدَعِ دُونَ السُّنَنِ،
وَأَرَزَّ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ، وَنَطَقَ الضَّالُّونَ
الْمُكَذِّبُونَ. نَحْنُ الشُّعَارُ
وَالْأَصْحَابُ، وَالْخَزَنَةُ وَالْأَبْوَابُ،
وَلَا تُؤْتَى الْبُيُوتُ إِلَّا مِنْ أَبْوَابِهَا،
فَمَنْ أَتَاهَا مِنْ غَيْرِ أَبْوَابِهَا سُمِّيَ
سَارِقًا.

CONTEXT

No information is available regarding the context of this oration. However, the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places its first section within a longer sermon known as ‘al-Minbariyyah’, which Imām ‘Alī gave on the first Friday after his arrival in Kūfah (4:186), and the other parts thereof are then quoted within a number of various sermons and letters. Three subjects are addressed in this sermon. The first pertains to the merits of the Ahl al-Bayt, their vast knowledge, and the importance of following them. Second is about the relationship between the apparent and hidden aspects of one’s character. The third relates to how it is necessary to reform a thing by returning to its source. The foremost of these three subjects is discussed at length in the initial two sections while the remaining two topics are briefly touched upon in the third section of the sermon. Other early sources that mention

this sermon include *Ghurar al-Ḥikam* and *Kitāb al-Ṭirāz*, both of which quote some parts of this oration, and because of the variation in wording, it is clear that the authors of these works referred to sources other than *Nahj al-Balāghah* (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām begins by describing individuals who possess insight and wisdom. He says that *the eye of one with an intelligent heart is that by which he sees his distant end and recognizes its lowlands and its elevations*. The term ‘*nāẓir*’ literally refers to the pupil, or the black part of the eye with which one sees, and ‘*al-labīb*’ refers to one who possesses intelligence and wisdom (T). The statement means that an intelligent person possesses a keen heart with which he perceives his goal, and recognizes those conditions that he encounters, distinguishing what elevates him from that which lowers his status and causes him to fall (I). The terms ‘*ghawrahu*’ and ‘*najdahu*’ are rendered as *lowlands* and *elevations*, but can also refer to the hidden reality and the outward appearance, respectively (Z). Since the perceptive one strives to progress and ascend higher, attaining greater merit and virtue and eschewing lowly traits like ignorance and ignobility, he finds that such elevation requires following the infallible Prophet and Imām, as it is they who have called the people and lead them aright. *So respond to the caller and follow the leader*, as that is the only way to be guided to the straight path and attain felicity (MB). Some commentators state that the term ‘*dā’in*’ refers to the Noble Prophet, while ‘*rā’in*’ refers to Imām ‘Alī (T, I). Other say the former refers to the Noble Qur’ān and the Sunnah, while the latter refers to one who protects the religion (Z), but the first meaning seems more correct in this context. Then the Imām turns to a second group – those who oppose the truth and lack the intelligence and wisdom to recognize it. They are the ones who *dived into the seas of strife and took hold of innovations instead of established practices*, and thus they abandoned the Ahl al-Bayt and turned to the usurpers of the caliphate. They were also the ones who rebelled and revolted during the Imām’s rule, leading to the battles of Jamal, Ṣiffin, and Nahrawān (N). The phrase ‘*araza al-mu’minūn*’ has been rendered *the believers shrunk back*, meaning they cowered and remained silent in order to stay safe during the reign of falsehood (MB), and indeed the likes of Salmān, ‘Ammār, al-Miqdād, and others can be seen to have acted thus during the caliphate of the first three rulers, for example (T). In contrast, *the misguided liars became vocal* and did

whatever they pleased during the rule of error and treachery (Z), since the truth had been concealed and evil had taken over (MB).

Imām ‘Alī then turns to the merits of the Ahl al-Bayt, stating *we are the intimates and the companions* of the Prophet, *the keepers and doors* to the Sunnah. It has been suggested that he was referring to himself, even though he used the plural pronoun (I). However, it is more likely that he was referring to both himself and the righteous ones among his progeny (MB). The term ‘*al-shi‘ār*’ literally refers to the undergarments that make direct contact with the skin, thereby being closest to the body (I), and here it is used metaphorically to refer to those who were closest to the Messenger of Allāh (Z). They are also called *the companions* (‘*al-aṣḥāb*’) because they were in his company from the earliest moments, and remained true to him, and had faith in everything he said and taught. The article ‘al’ before these two terms is used to convey exclusivity (*ḥaṣr*), meaning it was only the Ahl al-Bayt who were his true intimates and closest companions, no one else (MB). As for their being *the keepers and doors* (‘*al-khazanah wal-abwāb*’), it means they were the store-keepers and gateways to knowledge, as the Noble Messenger had said, “I am the city of knowledge and ‘Alī is its gate.” Or it could mean that they are the keepers and gateways of Paradise, since no one can enter Paradise without their *wilāyah* (I). Since they inherited the knowledge of the Noble Messenger, these two terms may also refer to their being the keepers and protectors of the Sunnah, and the teachings of religion (Z). One commentator gives twenty-four examples of how Imām ‘Alī and the Ahl al-Bayt are exclusively the closest to the Messenger of Allāh, to the exception of all others (T). Having called them doorways to knowledge, the Imām states that *houses are not entered save through their doors*, and *whoever enters them from other than their doors is called a thief*. This figuratively means that those who take knowledge from other than the Ahl al-Bayt are trying to seize something the way a thief does – seeking to steal something unjustly (MB). Therefore, those who quote from the Prophet, attributing teachings to him that have been acquired through other channels, are like thieves who have entered a house from other than its door (T).

2 The Imām continues to mention the merits of the Ahl al-Bayt, partly to counter the false propaganda of the Banū Umayyah against the family of the Prophet (N). He says that the Ahl al-Bayt are *the gems of faith*, and *the treasures of the Most Merciful*. This alludes to their beautiful qualities and character, which is a corollary of deep faith and certitude (M). Another version of the first statement

PART OF THE SAME SERMON

منها

- 2 Among them are the gems of faith, and they are the treasures of the Most Merciful. If they speak they are truthful and if they remain silent they are not surpassed [by anyone]. So let the scout report honestly to his people, and let him retain his wits and be one of the children of the Hereafter, for indeed he has come from it and will return to it. Thus the one who sees with the heart and acts with insight must begin his action by knowing: is the action detrimental to him or is it beneficial? If it is beneficial for him, he undertakes it, but if it is detrimental, he desists from it. For verily, he who acts without knowledge is like one who treads on the wrong path; his distance from the clear path increases him in nothing but distance from his goal. And he who acts with knowledge is like one who treads on the clear path. So let the seer observe: is he proceeding [forward] or returning [backward]?
- 3 Know that for every exterior there is an interior that is similar to it. So that which has a good exterior also has a good interior, and that which has a corrupt exterior also has a corrupt interior. The truthful Messenger (ﷺ) has said, "Verily Allāh may love a servant but hate his action, and He may love an action but hate its doer." And know that every action has a [growth like that

۲ فِيهِمْ كَرَاهِمُ الْإِيمَانِ، وَهُمْ كُتُورُ الرَّحْمَنِ، إِنْ نَطَقُوا صَدَقُوا، وَإِنْ صَمَتُوا لَمْ يُسَبِّحُوا. فَلْيَصْدُقْ رَأْيَهُ أَهْلُهُ، وَلْيَحْضِرْ عَقْلَهُ، وَلْيَكُنْ مِنْ أَتْبَاءِ الْآخِرَةِ، فَإِنَّهُ مِنْهَا قَدِمَ، وَإِلَيْهَا يَنْقَلِبُ. فَالْناظِرُ بِالْقَلْبِ الْعَامِلُ بِالْبَصَرِ، يَكُونُ مُبْتَدَأُ عَمَلِهِ أَنْ يَعْلَمَ: أَعْمَلُهُ عَلَيْهِ أَمْ لَهُ؟ فَإِنْ كَانَ لَهُ مَضَى فِيهِ، وَإِنْ كَانَ عَلَيْهِ وَقَفَ عَنْهُ. فَإِنَّ الْعَامِلَ بِغَيْرِ عِلْمٍ كَالسَّائِرِ عَلَى غَيْرِ طَرِيقٍ، فَلَا يَزِيدُهُ بُعْدُهُ عَنِ الطَّرِيقِ الْوَاضِحِ إِلَّا بُعْدًا مِنْ حَاجَتِهِ، وَالْعَامِلُ بِالْعِلْمِ كَالسَّائِرِ عَلَى الطَّرِيقِ الْوَاضِحِ، فَلْيَنْظُرْ نَاطِرًا أَسَائِرًا هُوَ أَمْ رَاجِعٌ؟

۳ وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ لِكُلِّ ظَاهِرٍ بَاطِنًا عَلَى مِثَالِهِ، فَمَا طَابَ ظَاهِرُهُ طَابَ بَاطِنُهُ، وَمَا خَبَثَ ظَاهِرُهُ خَبَثَ بَاطِنُهُ، وَقَدْ قَالَ الرَّسُولُ الصَّادِقُ ﷺ: إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْعَبْدَ وَيُبْغِضُ عَمَلَهُ، وَيُحِبُّ الْعَمَلَ وَيُبْغِضُ بَدَنَهُ. وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ لِكُلِّ عَمَلٍ نَبَاتًا، وَكُلُّ نَبَاتٍ لَا غَنَى بِهِ

of a] plant, and every plant cannot do without water, while waters are of different types. So that which is irrigated with fresh water grows well and its fruit is sweet, whereas that which is irrigated with dirty water grows poorly and its fruit is bitter.

عَنِ الْمَاءِ، وَالْمِيَاهُ مُخْتَلِفَةٌ، فَمَا
طَابَ سَقْيُهُ طَابَ غَرْسُهُ وَحَلَّتْ
ثَمَرَتُهُ، وَمَا خَبِثَ سَقْيُهُ خَبِثَ غَرْسُهُ
وَأَمَرَتْ ثَمَرَتُهُ.

contains the word *Qur'ān* instead of *īmān*, in which case the translation would be: *the extolments of the Qur'ān are about them*. As for their being treasures of the Omnibenevolent ('*kunūz al-Raḥmān*'), it is because only the most valuable things are treasured, and since Allāh placed the best of all virtues and merits within them, such as knowledge, forbearance, generosity, courage, etc., they are deemed His treasures (MB). Highlighting one of these great merits, the Imām says that *if they speak they are truthful and if they remain silent they are not surpassed* by anyone. That is because their speech is only based on knowledge and wisdom, and their silence brings about a sense of awe in the people, so nobody in their presence would dare to speak of that about which they remain silent (Z). Of course, their silence was not indicative of inability to respond; rather, it was the most prudent course of action at that moment (N). After speaking of some virtues of the Ahl al-Bayt, the Imām quotes a well-known proverb *let the scout report honestly to his people*, which means whoever comes to the Imāms to learn from them and take from their light should report back truthfully to his people about what he saw and heard from them (MB). He then advises them to retain their wits and stay alert, for indeed one who actively employs his intellect immediately recognizes the virtue of the Ahl al-Bayt (R). It may also mean that he wanted them to be attentive to his words and recognize the truth thereof (MB). By telling them to be *children of the Hereafter*, Imām 'Alī meant that they should keep the Hereafter as their goal and desire, since it is from Allāh that we all came and to Him we shall all return (MB). Alternatively, it means they should work for the Hereafter and strive for it, since that is what they were created for (Z).

A fundamental principle of wisdom is then broached by Amīr al-Mu'minīn, and that is the importance of thinking about the consequences of any action before undertaking it. He says that the *one who sees with the heart and acts with insight*

should first determine if the action he wants to perform will be detrimental to him or beneficial (Z). *If it is beneficial for him, he undertakes it, but if it is detrimental, he desists from it*, for indeed one who is wise enough to think about consequences would not then put himself in harm's way knowingly. The Imām then contrasts this with the state of a person who acts without knowledge, saying that such an individual *is like one who treads on the wrong path*. This is reflected in a statement attributed to the Messenger of Allāh wherein he said, "Whoever acts without knowledge, that which he corrupts is far more than what he reforms" (T). For such a person, *his distance from the clear path increases him in nothing but distance from his goal*, meaning the farther he is from the correct path, the further he gets from his goal, since the remoteness of the objective he seeks is proportional to his distance from the path that leads him to it (MB). Conversely, whoever acts with knowledge *is like one who treads on the clear path* and will thus arrive at his intended destination. The Imām then tells his listeners to observe whether they are proceeding forward or returning backward. By this he means that they should note whether they are following the right course or not. For if they are not, all their efforts will only lead them further away from what they seek (N).

3 In this section, Amīr al-Mu'minīn mentions some key points when distinguishing the virtuous from the wicked. Indeed, identifying the true nature of people is an important ability when living in a society, because many times people seek to conceal their true nature and intentions (N). He says that *for every exterior there is an interior that is similar to it*, meaning that for every outward appearance of action, there is an inward state or intention, and in most instances, one reflects the other. So if a person's actions are righteous, then his inner state is inclined towards piety and virtue, whereas if his deeds are evil, then his inner state is corrupt and ugly (I). Virtues like generosity, honesty, and courage are indicative of a noble character, whereas vices like miserliness, dishonesty, and cowardice show that one has an ignoble soul (MB). *So that which has a good exterior also has a good interior, and that which has a corrupt exterior also has a corrupt interior*. That is why the only way to learn about the true character of a person is by scrutinizing his actions and behaviour (Z). Subsequently, the Imām quotes the Messenger of Allāh as having said, "Verily Allāh may love a servant but hate his action, and He may love an action but hate its doer." This means that Allāh loves the believer for his faith but dislikes some of his evil actions, and He hates the disbeliever for his defiant disbelief, but He may like some of his virtuous deeds (MB). Even one who is

generally good may at times commit an evil deed; otherwise he would be infallible. Likewise, even one who is evil may do something that is good (Z). Also, it bears reminding here that when 'love' and 'hate' are attributed to the Almighty, it means that which He likes and dislikes, or approves of and disapproves of, respectively (M).

The phrase '*li kulli 'amalin nabātan*' has been rendered *every action has a plant*, but some commentators say that this was a scribal error and should have read '*li kulli gharasin nabātan*' which means *for every plant there is growth* (T). In any case, it metaphorically refers to the growth and development of one's deeds, and the consequences thereof (M). To clarify this analogy further, the Imām says that *every plant cannot do without water, while waters are of different types*. Indeed, the similitude of deeds to plants and the way they are watered and grow is clear. If watered with fresh, sweet water, they can grow into fructive trees that bear pleasant fruits, whereas if irrigated with polluted or salty water, any fruit they bear will be bitter and corrupt. In the same way, the intention and sincerity behind actions determine how virtuous they will be (Z). Just as fresh water gives rise to sweet fruits, so too do sincere actions result in the sweet, everlasting fruits of Paradise. Conversely, the bitter fruit of dirty irrigation is like the nasty fruit of Hell that results from disbelief, and actions performed only to show off or win praise (MB). As such, it is important to ensure that one's actions are based on sincerity and devotion to Allāh.



ON THE UNIQUENESS OF THE BAT

PRAISING AND EXALTING ALLĀH

- 1 Praise be to Allāh whose essence cannot be known through descriptions and whose greatness restrains the intellects, so they can find no way of reaching the farthest limit of His dominion! He is Allāh, the Manifest Truth; Truer and more Manifest than what the eyes can see. Intellects cannot specify any limit for Him, for He would then be likened [to another], and thoughts cannot imagine any dimensions for Him, for then He would have a likeness. He created the creation without any prototype, and without the counsel of any advisor, or the assistance of any helper. His creation was completed by His command and submitted to Him in obedience. It responded without defiance, and it yielded without resistance.

حمد الله وتزيمه

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي أَنْحَسَرَتْ
الْأَوْصَافُ عَنْ كُنْهِ مَعْرِفَتِهِ،
وَرَدَعَتْ عَظَمَتُهُ الْعُقُولَ، فَلَمْ
تَجِدْ مَسَاجِدًا إِلَى بُلُوغِ غَايَةِ
مَلَكُوتِهِ! هُوَ اللَّهُ الْحَقُّ الْمُبِينُ،
أَحَقُّ وَأَبِينُ مِمَّا تَرَى الْعَيُونُ، لَمْ
تَبْلُغْهُ الْعُقُولُ بِتَحْدِيدٍ فَيَكُونَ
مُشَبَّهًا، وَلَمْ تَقْعْ عَلَيْهِ الْأَوْهَامُ
بِتَقْدِيرٍ فَيَكُونَ مُمَثَّلًا. خَلَقَ
الْخَلْقَ عَلَى غَيْرِ تَمَثِيلٍ، وَلَا
مُسْوَرَةٍ مُشِيرٍ، وَلَا مَعُونَةٍ مُعِينٍ،
فَتَمَّ خَلْقُهُ بِأَمْرِهِ، وَأَذْعَنَ
لِطَاعَتِهِ، فَأَجَابَ وَلَمْ يُدَافِعْ،
وَأَنقَادَ وَلَمْ يُتَارَعَ.

CONTEXT

This is an oration in which Imām ‘Alī mentions the wondrous creation of the bat. It is considered one of the sermons on monotheism in *Nahj al-Balāghah*, and since his aim in describing this unique creature was to remind the people about the greatness of the Creator, and His amazing creation, which is evidence of His power and dominion, the Imām begins by praising Allāh and mentioning His attributes (MB). There seems to be no other early source that mentions this sermon

before al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, and though it lacks a chain of transmission, its lofty contents are considered enough by scholars to establish its attribution to the Imām. Nothing is known about the context of this sermon, and one commentator remarks that the way in which Imām ‘Alī describes the bat is so detailed that one could [mistakenly] think that he spent many years studying this mysterious creature until he was able to find out about its hitherto unknown qualities (N).

COMMENTARY

1 As was his wont, Amīr al-Mu’minīn began his sermon by extolling the Almighty. He praises Allāh, saying that His Essence *cannot be known through descriptions and His greatness restrains the intellects, so they can find no way of reaching the farthest limit of His dominion*. That is because nothing is like Allāh or His attributes, so the mind cannot grasp or understand His reality (Z). Yet He is *the Manifest Truth* (*‘al-ḥaqq al-mubīn’*, which can also be translated as *the True, the Manifest*), as stated in the verse: *On that Day Allāh will pay them in full their just due, and they will know that Allāh is the Manifest Truth* (Q24:25) (T). Indeed, the Imām says that He is *Truer and more Manifest than what the eyes can see*, since the intellectual realm is more firmly established and dependable than the realm of the physical senses, as the senses often err, making one perceive something big as small, or a moving thing as stationary, and other such mistakes in perception. However, intellectual judgments that are based on rational reasoning are far more reliable, since they are based on stronger foundations (I). And since Allāh’s existence is proven by the intellect, it is something incontrovertible (T). The Imām then says that the intellects cannot delineate any limit for Him, as that would be tantamount to likening Him to another. Indeed, Allāh is beyond any limits or boundaries, which are qualities of material entities, and He is free of any compositeness, so His existence has no parts or parameters (MB). Furthermore, *thoughts cannot imagine any dimensions for Him, for then He would have a likeness*, because the mind can only envision that which can be likened to another in its qualities and dimensions (M).

The Imām then says that Allāh creates everything *without any prototype, and without the counsel of any advisor, or the assistance of any helper*, unlike that which human beings make, which is always based on something similar which existed before, and is never entirely new and unique (N). On the other hand, all of Allāh’s

CREATION OF THE BAT

خلقة الخفاش

2 Among the marvels of His making and the wonders of His creation is what He has shown us of the mysterious wisdom in these bats, which are held back by daylight that spreads out [its illumination] for everything, and are let out by the dark night that holds back every living creature. How weak are their eyes that they cannot make use of the radiant sunlight so as to be guided in their movements and reach their known places through the manifest direction of the sun.

٢ وَمِنْ لَطَائِفِ صَنْعِهِ وَعَجَائِبِ خَلْقَتِهِ، مَا أَرَانَا مِنْ غَوَامِضِ الْحِكْمَةِ فِي هَذِهِ الْخَفَافِشِ الَّتِي يَفْضُضُهَا الضِّيَاءُ الْبَاسِطُ لِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ، وَيَبْسُطُهَا الظَّلَامُ الْقَابِضُ لِكُلِّ حَيٍّ، وَكَيْفَ عَشِيَّتْ أَعْيُنُهَا عَنْ أَنْ تَسْتَمِدَّ مِنَ الشَّمْسِ الْمُضِيئَةِ نُورًا تَهْتَدِي بِهِ فِي مَذَاهِبِهَا، وَتَتَّصِلَ بِعَالِيَةِ بَرْهَانِ الشَّمْسِ إِلَى مَعَارِفِهَا.

3 He has deterred them by its shining light from moving amidst its glowing rays, and confined them in their hiding places from going into its glimmering brightness. Hence, their eyelids are closed over their eyes by day and they consider the night a lamp by which they go in search of their sustenance. So neither does the dark of night obstruct their sight, nor is their movement in it hindered because of its intense darkness. As soon as the sun casts off its veil and its morning glow becomes visible, with the rays of its light entering [even] upon lizards in their holes, they shut their eyelids over the sides of their eyes and content themselves with what they have acquired in the darkness of the night.

٣ وَرَدَّعَهَا بِتَلَوُّ ضِيَائِهَا عَنِ الْمُضِيِّ فِي سُبُحَاتِ إِشْرَاقِهَا، وَأَكْنَهَا فِي مَكَامِنِهَا عَنِ الدَّهَابِ فِي بُلَجِ اثْتِلَاقِهَا، فَهِيَ مُسَدَّلَةُ الْجُفُونِ بِالنَّهَارِ عَلَى حِدَاقِهَا، وَجَاعِلَةُ اللَّيْلِ سِرَاجًا تَسْتَدِلُّ بِهِ فِي التَّمَاسِ أَرْزَاقِهَا؛ فَلَا يَرُدُّ أَبْصَارَهَا إِسْدَافُ ظُلْمَتِهِ، وَلَا تَمْتَنِعُ مِنَ الْمُضِيِّ فِيهِ لِعَسَقِ دُجْنَتِهِ. فَإِذَا أَلْقَتِ الشَّمْسُ قِنَاعَهَا، وَبَدَتْ أَوْضَاحُ نَهَارِهَا، وَدَخَلَ مِنْ إِشْرَاقِ نُورِهَا عَلَى الضُّبَابِ فِي وَجَارِهَا، أَطْبَقَتِ الْأَجْفَانُ عَلَى مَا قَبِهَا، وَتَبَلَّغَتْ بِمَا اكْتَسَبَتْهُ مِنَ الْمَعَاشِ فِي ظُلْمِ لَيَالِيهَا.

creations are innovations that have never existed before, and are not based on any previous template. And Allāh did not have to use any blueprint before creating anything, the way architects do before they build any structure (MB). This is something quite evident, since nothing existed prior to its creation by Allāh, and there was no existent being with Him who could act as an advisor or helper (T). He is All-wise, so He never requires counsel, and He is All-powerful, so He never needs help (Z). The phrase *'tamma khalquhu bi amrihi'* has been rendered *His creation was completed by His command*, which means that every created thing reached its perfect and complete state, or all that He willed into creation came out of nothingness into existence, by His command (MB). Then, everything in creation *submitted to Him in obedience*, responding *without defiance*, and yielding *without resistance*. Indeed, there is nothing in the heavens or on earth but that it is subservient to the will and power of Allāh (Z).

2 Having alluded to the wonderful creation of Allāh, the Imām now mentions a single creature that is both mysterious and amazing, namely the bat. Part of its uniqueness lies in how its vision is different from that of all other animals, and its wings are different from all other birds, as is the way in which it gives birth. For this reason, some scholars opined that the bat was not a bird at all, because of the way it is formed, with ears and teeth, and how it urinates and lactates (T). The term *'khaḥāfish'* means bats, and its singular is *khuffāsh*, derived from *al-khaḥash*, which connotes weakness of vision and sight. A person suffering from day blindness (hemeralopia), such that he can see at night but not in the daytime, is called *al-akhḥash* (I). The Imām notes how *bats are held back by daylight*, and how they are drawn out *by the dark night that holds back every living creature*, which is partly due to the fact that the eyes of a bat work only after sunset. If we ponder over the wisdom behind this, we will not be able to understand why it was created thus, and it is indeed one of the unsolvable mysteries (Z). Some commentators understand the phrase *'yaqbiḥuhā al-ḍiyā'* to mean that daylight constricts its sight (I), and the terms *'al-ḍiyā'* and *'al-ḡalām'* refer to sunlight and night time respectively (T). The Imām then emphasizes this unique feature of bats, saying that it is amazing how they cannot use the radiant sunlight to take guidance in their movements and to reach their known places *through the manifest direction of the sun*. Contrary to most other creatures who see better by the light of the sun, the bat sees better when there is no sunlight! (T). One commentator suggests that here, the term *'ma'ārifihā'* refers to what is intrinsically known by this creature (R).

Hence, the point to consider here, and which behoves pondering upon, is how for the bat, something like sunlight, which most other creatures find helpful and of benefit, is actually harmful (N). It is also worthwhile noting that the Imām does not say bats are blind, as some people believed until recently, and hence they invented phrases like “as blind as a bat!” Rather, he accurately describes the property of their eyesight, which has now been scientifically verified.

3 Continuing with his description of how sunlight affects bats, the Imām says they are deterred by the shining light of the sun from *moving amidst its glowing rays* and majestic gleams (*‘subuḥāti ishrāqihā’*). Some consider the pronoun to refer back to the dazzling light, in which case the translation would be *its shining light has deterred them...* (T). This radiance also causes them to remain confined in their caverns to keep away from the brightness. The term *‘makāminihā’* means their hiding places in which they remain to avoid the sun’s glare, and particularly the first rays of sunlight (*‘bulaj i’tilāqihā’*) (N). During the daytime *their eyelids are closed over their eyes*, having drooped over their pupils to prevent any penetration of light. This is a result of their sensitivity to sunlight, but it is also interpreted by some to refer to sleep, or a kind of slumber (M). Then, at night, bats use the darkness *as a lamp by which they go in search of their sustenance*. One scholar marvels at how mosquitoes go out at night seeking their sustenance, which comprises blood of animals, while bats also go out after dark in search of sustenance, so they come upon the mosquitoes, which they then consume – so one seeker of sustenance in the night ends up as sustenance for another! (T). As for their taking night time *as a lamp*, this is an apt allusion to the way in which bats see at night. Since their eyes are filled with photoreceptor cells, called rods, their ability to see in what may be considered pitch darkness is enhanced. Additionally, bats use ultrasonic sound waves, which they send out and then listen for echoes (in a process known as echolocation) to manoeuvre and find prey. *So neither does the dark of night obstruct their sight nor is their movement in it hindered because of its intense darkness.*

The term *‘isdāf’* depicts a specific type of darkness that is mingled with very slight illumination (R), or one that is extreme in its gloom. And *‘ghasaqi dujunnatihī’* also connotes intense, enveloping darkness (I). However, once *the sun casts off its veil and its morning glow becomes visible*, the rays of the sun begin to shine upon everything on earth, even entering *upon lizards in their holes*. Perhaps the reason for mentioning the lizard in particular is because of the way lizards generally come out of their holes at sunrise, to bask in the first rays of the sun (N). Some say that

4 So glorified is He who has made for them the night as day, and a time to seek sustenance, and [has made] the day a time for rest and repose! He made for them from their flesh wings by which they can ascend when they need to fly, looking like the auricles of ears, without any feathers or quills. Yet you can see the position of the veins quite distinctly. They have two wings which are neither so thin that they would get torn [while flying], nor so thick that they prove to be too heavy [for flight].

5 They fly while their young are attached to them, clinging to them for protection, landing when they land and soaring when they soar. It does not part from it[’s mother] until its limbs become strong and its wings can support it for flight, and [after] it has learnt its ways of life and what benefits it. So glory be to the Originator of everything without any example set by another.

٤ فَسُبْحَانَ مَنْ جَعَلَ اللَّيْلَ لَهَا نَهَارًا
وَمَعَاشًا، وَالنَّهَارَ سَكْنًا وَقَرَارًا!
وَجَعَلَ لَهَا أَجْنِحَةً مِنْ لَحْمِهَا تَعْرُجُ
بِهَا عِنْدَ الْحَاجَةِ إِلَى الطَّيْرَانِ، كَأَنَّهَا
شَطَايَا الْأَذَانِ، غَيْرَ ذَوَاتِ رِيشٍ وَلَا
قَصَبٍ، إِلَّا أَنَّكَ تَرَى مَوَاضِعَ
الْعُرُوقِ بَيِّنَةً أَعْلَامًا، لَهَا جَنَاحَانِ لَمَّا
يَرِقَا فَيَنْشَقَّا، وَلَمْ يَغْلُظَا فَيَنْقَلَا.

٥ تَطِيرُ وَوَلَدُهَا لَاصِقٌ بِهَا لَا جِيءَ إِلَيْهَا،
يَقَعُ إِذَا وَقَعَتْ وَيَزْتَفِعُ إِذَا ارْتَفَعَتْ،
لَا يُفَارِقُهَا حَتَّى تَشْتَدَّ أَرْكَائُهُ،
وَيَحْمِلُهُ لِلتُّهُوْضِ جَنَاحُهُ، وَيَعْرِفُ
مَذَاهِبَ عَيْشِهِ وَمَصَالِحَ نَفْسِهِ،
فَسُبْحَانَ الْبَارِي لِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلَى
غَيْرِ مِثَالٍ خَلَا مِنْ غَيْرِهِ.

they do this because it helps to make their sight clear, and that is why they remain in their holes during the winter (T). Conversely, at the first sign of sunrise, bats *shut their eyelids over the sides of their eyes and content themselves with what they have acquired in the darkness of the night*. The term ‘*ma‘āqihā*’ refers to the sides of the eyes that are close to the nose, and some say that it refers to the tear ducts that are on the sides of the eyes. The term is used here to show how their eyelids cover the entirety of their eyes, including the sides thereof (N). Interestingly, the way in which a bat hunts and forages at night has also been mentioned by Imām al-Ṣādiq in the well-known tradition of al-Mufaḍḍal (T).

4 The Imām glorifies Allāh for making the night for the bats as day, *and a time to seek sustenance*, and for making the day a time for their rest and repose. This is contrary to most of the other creatures that strive for their sustenance during the day and rest at night. Indeed, this is another sign of His power and might (T). Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn mentions another astounding feature of the bat, specifically the structure of its wings. He notes that the wings of bats are made from flesh, in the form of *the auricles of ears, without any feathers or quills*. All birds have wings made of feathers, but the bat's wings are composed of a fleshy membrane (Z). The bow-shaped, ear-like structure of the wings also impresses and bewilders, especially since the bat is known to fly very fast. Their wings are entirely unique both in form and construction. Instead of feathers with hollow quills, they have meaty membranes with thin and light bones. Furthermore, despite its lightness, this membrane is very resilient. If a light is placed behind them, one can even see the tiny veins and capillaries that run through these wing membranes (N). Hence the Imām says *you can see the position of the veins quite distinctly*. And it is also surprising how the bat flies with complete agility using this type of wings. The blood vessels in bats' wings function to ensure the required blood flow, and research has shown how their wings have what is termed 'rhythmic contractility' where the onward flow of blood is accelerated by each contraction.

Today, scientists tell us that the structure of bat wings resemble the human arm and hand. Hence they call the thin bones that hold up the wing "fingers," like the fingers of the human hand. Interestingly, bats also have five fingers, which get folded when the bat is not in flight. The fingers, along with the membrane that stretches between them, allows for flexible and precise control during flight, something that is indeed a marvel to behold. Since the term '*al-urūq*' also means roots that branch out, it is possible that the Imām was referring to the fingers of the bat, especially since he says they are quite distinctly visible. He then spoke about the density and weight of the wings, saying that *they are neither so thin that they would get torn while flying, nor so thick that they prove to be too heavy for flight*. As an example, some species of bats have wings that weigh only 4-6 grams. Any tear that happens in the wing is the result of attacks by predators and not due to flight. Though many of these details were not known to earlier generations, they were aware of the uniqueness of this creature. Hence we find in one report that people had asked Prophet ʿĪsā to make a bat for them by the permission of Allāh, because they considered it the most amazing of all flying creatures (T).

5 Finally, in this last section, Imām ‘Alī speaks about yet another impressive quality of the bat. He says that *they fly while their young are attached to them, clinging to them for protection, landing when they land and soaring when they soar*. When bats fly, their pups cling tightly to them for shelter and safety, using both their feet and their mouths. They grip the mother’s side with their tiny claws and sometimes even bite onto her nipples to stay attached during flight. This is crucial for their survival as a fall would be fatal. The bat is classified as a mammal since it delivers its young instead of laying eggs like birds. The female bat typically bears between three to seven pups in her lifetime, and it is one of the few animals that actually carry its young, like humans, apes, and kangaroos. At times, the mother bat even nurses its young while flying (T). It is interesting to note that even during take-off and landing, the pup remains attached to its mother, and this remains so *until its limbs become strong and its wings can support it for flight* (I). For this reason, the mother bat does not part from its pup until *it has learnt its ways of life and what benefits it* (‘*madhāhiba ‘ayshihi wa maṣāliḥa nafsihi*’). The clinging of a pup begins right from birth, and continues until it grows strong enough to fly on its own. Intriguingly, the presence of a clinging pup does not hamper the mother’s agility, and the ability of nursing females to get about and find food is unaffected by their babies, which typically adhere to their mothers continuously for a week after birth. Having mentioned this amazing creature and its astounding features, the Imām concludes his speech by glorifying Allāh, just as he had commenced it by praising Him (MB). He reiterates once more that Allāh is *the Originator of everything without any example set by another*, and while all of His creation is wonderful, the bat was specifically chosen for mention here because of its unique attributes that place it between the categories of animal and bird (T).



ADDRESSING THE PEOPLE OF BAṢRAH

WHAT HE TOLD THE PEOPLE OF BAṢRAH
ABOUT FUTURE HARDSHIPS

- 1 During this period, whoever can keep himself holding on to Allāh, the Mighty and Majestic, should do so. If you obey me I shall indeed take you, if Allāh so wills, on the path to Paradise, even if it is fraught with severe hardships and is full of bitterness. As for that woman, she is in the grip of womanly views and malice is boiling in her bosom like the cauldron of a blacksmith. If she were called upon to deal with another as she has with me, she would not have done it. Yet she still has her original respect, and the reckoning [of her misdeeds] is upon Allāh, the Exalted.

ON THE DESCRIPTION OF FAITH

- 2 It is a path with the clearest road and the most radiant lamp, for it is through faith that one is directed towards virtuous actions, and virtuous deeds are regarded as an indication of faith. Knowledge thrives through faith and it is due to knowledge that death is feared. Through death this world comes to an end, and through [good deeds in] this world the next world is acquired. (Through the resurrection Paradise is brought near [for the

خاطب به أهل البصرة على جهة

اقتصاص الملاحم

١ فَمَنْ اسْتَطَاعَ عِنْدَ ذَلِكَ أَنْ يَعْتَمِلَ
نَفْسَهُ عَلَى اللَّهِ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ فَلْيَفْعَلْ، فَإِنْ
أَطَعْتُمُونِي فَإِنِّي حَامِلُكُمْ إِنْ شَاءَ
اللَّهُ عَلَى سَبِيلِ الْجَنَّةِ، وَإِنْ كَانَ ذَا
مَشَقَّةٍ شَدِيدَةٍ وَمَذَاقَةٍ مَرِيرَةٍ. وَأَمَّا
فُلَانَةٌ، فَأَذَرَكَهَا رَأْيَ النِّسَاءِ، وَضَعَتْ
غَلَا فِي صَدْرِهَا كَمِزْجِلِ الْقَيْنِ،
وَلَوْ دُعِيَتْ لَتَنَالَ مِنْ غَيْرِي مَا أَتَتْ
إِلَيَّ لَمْ تَفْعَلْ، وَلَهَا بَعْدُ حُزْمَتُهَا
الْأُولَى، وَالْحِسَابُ عَلَى اللَّهِ تَعَالَى.

منه: في وصف الإيمان

٢ سَبِيلٌ أَبْلَجُ الْمُنْهَاجِ، أَنْوَرُ السَّرَاجِ،
فَبِالْإِيمَانِ يُسْتَدَلُّ عَلَى الصَّالِحَاتِ،
وَبِالصَّالِحَاتِ يُسْتَدَلُّ عَلَى الْإِيمَانِ،
وَبِالْإِيمَانِ يُعْمَرُ الْعِلْمُ، وَبِالْعِلْمِ
يُزْهَبُ الْمَوْتُ، وَبِالْمَوْتِ تُحْتَمُ
الدُّنْيَا، وَبِالدُّنْيَا تُحَرَّرُ الْآخِرَةُ،
[وَبِالْقِيَامَةِ تُزْلَفُ الْجَنَّةُ وَتُبَرَّرُ
الْجَحِيمُ لِلْغَاوِينَ،] وَإِنَّ الْخَلْقَ لَا

Godwary] and Hell is brought into view for the errant.) Verily, there is no refuge for the creatures from the resurrection; they are moving swiftly in its arena towards the final end.

مَقْصَرٌ لَهُمْ عَنِ الْقِيَامَةِ، مُزْقَلِينَ فِي
مُضْمَارِهَا إِلَى الْعَايَةِ الْقُصْوَى.

CONTEXT

This oration was addressing the inhabitants of Baṣrah, after the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH). In it, Amīr al-Mu'minīn gave answers to the various questions that different groups had posed, and explained how the battle against the rebels was necessary and what the correct procedure of dividing the spoils from this battle was. He told the people it was not permissible to take the wealth of the rebels or to enslave their women and children, as war booty. He also mentioned some details about faith and disbelief, enjoining good and forbidding evil, innovation in religion, and strife. Scholars have noted how some of the aphorisms in *Nahj al-Balāghah* are linked to this sermon and are a part thereof, namely aphorisms no. 27, 28, 257, and 363. The author of *Mukhtaṣar Baṣā'ir al-Darajāt* states that he came across a book titled *Khuṭab li-Mawlānā Amīr al-Mu'minīn* and in it Sayyid Ibn Ṭāwūs had put a marginal note stating that the original author of the work had said it was transmitted from Imām al-Ṣādiq, with only two intermediary transmitters linking him to the Imām. As such, it is likely that the book was written somewhere around 200 AH. And this is the earliest source for parts of this sermon (N).

COMMENTARY

1 Since this oration starts rather abruptly, with the phrase *during this period...*, it has been suggested that the Imām must have mentioned something before this regarding the strife and war which would take place between the believers (M). Because the sermon is about future calamities, the opening statement of the Imām pertains to how believers should behave when that fateful time comes. He says *whoever can keep himself holding on to Allāh, the Mighty and Majestic, should do so*, meaning they should cling to the worship of Allāh and adhere to it (MB). Some have understood this to mean they should hold back and ensure not to commit

any wrongdoing or sin, as much as possible (Z). The verb '*yaṭaqil*' means to bind, confine, and restrain, so by saying one should bind himself to Allāh, the Imām means that he should confine himself to the worship and obedience of Allāh (N). Subsequently, the Imām promises the people that if they obey him, he would lead them on *the path to Paradise, even if it is fraught with severe hardships and is full of bitterness*. This is the path of truth (T), or the upright religion and the straight way; and his condition that they must obey him if they seek this guidance was because only one who is obeyed can lead the people as he wills (MB). Typically, the path of truth and right guidance is difficult to follow, and that is why he describes it as being filled with hardships and bitter trials (I). The remaining part of this first section of the sermon is about 'Ā'ishah bint Abī Bakr, one of the wives of the Noble Messenger, who rose up to rebel against the Imām in the Battle of Jamal. The Imām refers to her as *that woman* ('*fulānah*'), just as he had referred to her father as *that individual* ('*fulān*') in the Sermon of Shiqshiqiyah (T). One commentator suggests that it is possible al-Sayyid al-Raḍī replaced their names with these titles out of dissimulation (*taqiyyah*) (MB).

Imām 'Alī proceeds to then explain why 'Ā'ishah did what she did, and the motivation that drove her. This was important, as many people were questioning how it was possible for the 'mother of the believers' to participate in an illegitimate uprising against the Imām. He thus explained that firstly, she was *in the grip of womanly views*, meaning that the weak suppositions and discernment of women caused her to easily be swayed by the likes of Ṭalḥah and al-Zubayr. That is why we learn from historical reports that after all was said and done, 'Ā'ishah expressed regret for having participated in the uprising and sought forgiveness for it. Secondly, she harboured deep rancour and malice against Imām 'Alī which simmered and then boiled up to the point of her coming out to fight in battle against the Imām (N). '*Mirjal al-qayn*' either means a dying cauldron which was used to boil dye and colour clothes therewith (R), or a blacksmith's cauldron made of iron or brass (T). This hatred and aversion was specifically aimed at Imām 'Alī, and hence he says that if 'Ā'ishah was called upon to deal with anyone else as she treated with him, she would not have done so. Indeed, her dislike for Amīr al-Mu'minīn is well documented and known. Its causes were many, but the primary reason for her rancour was that the lineage of the Noble Messenger continued from Imām 'Alī and al-Sayyidah Fāṭimah, not from herself (Z). The Imām then concludes this section of the sermon by stating that despite what she had done,

‘Ā’ishah *still has her original respect*, and the reckoning of her misdeeds is upon Allāh, the Exalted. This explains why he did not punish her for the grave betrayal, despite her being deserving of punishment: because she had the respect which comes with being one of the wives of the Messenger of Allāh (M). Some interpret his saying that *the reckoning is upon Allāh* to mean that Allāh is oft-forgiving and His mercy all-encompassing, so He will likely forgive her (I). Others note that the very fact that she repented is acknowledgement that she committed a sin in the first place (Z), and it is only Allāh who can choose to accept repentance or reject it.

2 The Imām then speaks about faith, its corollaries, and its outcomes (N). He begins by describing *īmān* as *a path with the clearest road and the most radiant lamp*. The phrase *‘ablaj al-mīnhāj’* means a clear, straight path (R), and it is referred to thus because it leads all those who follow it to the proximity of Allāh and to Paradise. And it is the path with *the most radiant lamp* (*‘anwar al-sirāj’*) because it is illuminated and clear, such that anyone who treads upon it never loses his way (MB). This is explained by the Imām when he says that *it is through faith that one is directed towards virtuous actions, and virtuous deeds are regarded as an indication of faith*. By this, he means that whoever attests to belief in the Almighty and His Messenger, he will gain guidance through them towards virtuous actions. That is because Islam, through its tenets, directs one towards righteousness and good (I). In the same way, one can identify who has faith by the virtuousness of his deeds, the way effects are evidence of their cause (MB). The Imām then says that *knowledge thrives through faith*, meaning that through faith, one can derive true benefit from knowledge, that can last and persist. Put differently, with faith, knowledge can bring positive change that benefits the people, generation after generation, and it does not get used for corruption, mischief, or destruction (Z). Alternatively, the phrase could mean that faith brings with it a sense of humility and justice, which in turn remove the stumbling blocks to knowledge such as arrogance and bias (N). As for his statement *due to knowledge death is feared*, it is because knowledge about the Creator, the purpose of creation, the link between this world and the Hereafter, and the resurrection, all cause one to think about death. And it is this constant remembrance that leads one to be afraid of death and what will come after it, thereby pushing one to work for the Hereafter (M). For this reason, the Qur’ān clearly states: *Only those of His servants who are knowledgeable fear Allāh* (Q35:28) (R). The phrase *‘bil-mawt tukhtam al-dunyā’* has

been rendered *through death this world comes to an end*, and this could either mean that with the death of each individual, his world is brought to an end, or that with the death of all the people the world ends (T). The general purport of this is that death is the final station of this world, just as it is the first station of the Hereafter (MB). And since it is the abode of trial and duty (*taklīf*), only through belief and virtuous actions in the life of this world can *the next world* be acquired (M).

Then, *through the resurrection Paradise is brought near the Godwary and Hell is brought into view for the errant*, as mentioned in Q26:90-91. Those righteous people who see the approach of Paradise will be gladdened by it, as they realize this is where they will end up. Conversely, those who see Hell in front of them realize their wretched fate and are filled with grief as they are pushed towards it (MB). This statement is not found in some manuscripts of *Nahj al-Balāghah*, and has thus been placed in parentheses (T). To emphasize further, the Imām says there is no place of refuge from the resurrection for any creature; and they are all *moving swiftly in its arena towards the final end*. The term '*maqṣar*', or '*maqṣir*' (T), is derived from *qaṣr*, which refers to something that holds back, hinders, or stops, and since a station is a stopping place for people, and marks the end of their journey, it became the meaning of this term (N). Some commentators understand the phrase *its arena* ('*miḍmāriḥā*') to metaphorically refer to the duration of one's life in this world, since this life is indeed a place of preparation of the souls for their race towards the Almighty, just as a sports arena is a place where horses race one another (M).

3 In this section, a description of the resurrection is presented by the Imām. The phrase '*shakhaṣū min mustaqarr al-ajdāth*' means the people emerge from their graves (R), or rise up from their resting places, namely their tombs (MB), and *set off for the final destinations*, with some ending up in Paradise, while others in hellfire (T). The Imām then says that *each abode has its people, they can neither be exchanged nor are they transferred therefrom*, meaning the inhabitants of each abode cannot exchange their abode with the other, nor can they be shifted from one abode to the other. This means the inhabitants of Hell being alluded to here are the disbelievers and hypocrites, since traditions tell us that sinful believers will indeed be transferred to Paradise after being punished for their sins (M). And of course, those who are granted entry into Paradise will remain therein for eternity (Z). The Imām then turns to the matter of enjoining good and forbidding evil, and

THE STATE OF THE PEOPLE OF THE
GRAVES UPON RESURRECTION

3 They have risen from the resting places of their graves and have set off for the final destinations. Each abode has its people. They can neither be exchanged nor are they transferred therefrom. Verily enjoining good and forbidding evil are both among the traits of Allāh, the Glorified, and verily they neither bring death closer nor do they reduce sustenance.

4 Take care that you adhere to the Book of Allāh, for it is a strong rope and a clear light, a beneficial cure and a quencher of thirst, a protection for the one who holds fast and a deliverance for the one who clings to it. It does not bend so as to need straightening, and does not deviate so as to be corrected. Frequent repetition and continuous listening do not make it old. Whoever speaks according to it is truthful and whoever acts by it surpasses [others].

منه: حال أهل القبور في القيامة

٣ قَدْ شَخَّصُوا مِنْ مُسْتَقَرِّ الْأَجْدَاثِ،
وَصَارُوا إِلَى مَصَايِرِ الْغَايَاتِ؛ لِكُلِّ
دَارٍ أَهْلُهَا، لَا يَسْتَبَدِّلُونَ بِهَا وَلَا
يُنْقَلُونَ عَنْهَا. وَإِنَّ الْأَمْرَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ،
وَالنَّهْيَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ، لَخُلُقَانِ مِنْ
خُلُقِ اللَّهِ سُبْحَانَهُ، وَإِنَّهُمَا لَا يَقْرَبَانِ
مِنْ أَجَلٍ، وَلَا يَنْقُصَانِ مِنْ رِزْقٍ.

٤ وَعَلَيْكُمْ بِكِتَابِ اللَّهِ، فَإِنَّهُ الْحَبْلُ
الْمَتِينُ وَالنُّورُ الْمُبِينُ، وَالشِّفَاءُ
النَّافِعُ وَالرِّيُّ النَّاقِعُ، وَالْعِصْمَةُ
لِلْمُتَمَسِّكِ وَالنَّجَاةُ لِلْمُتَعَلِّقِ، لَا
يَغْوُجُ فَيَقَامَ وَلَا يَزِيغُ فَيُسْتَعْتَبَ،
وَلَا تُخْلِفُهُ كَثْرَةُ الرَّدِّ وَوُلُوجُ
السَّمْعِ، مَنْ قَالَ بِهِ صَدَقَ وَمَنْ
عَمِلَ بِهِ سَبَقَ.

since the Battle of Jamal was a manifest example of the necessity of *amr bil-ma'rūf* and *nahy'ān al-munkar*, he tells the people *verily enjoining good and forbidding evil are both among the characteristics of Allāh, the Glorified* (N). The attribution of *characteristics* to Allāh is metaphorical, since traits and qualities like this are what generally define human action, and are based on the nature of a person and his intrinsic inclinations and habits. And all this does not apply to the Almighty, so this cannot be understood literally (M). Of course, if the phrase itself is understood differently to refer to godly attributes, or actions that are pleasing to Allāh and loved by him, then such a literal interpretation would be correct (MB).

The Imām then clarifies that enjoining good and forbidding evil *neither bring death closer nor do they reduce sustenance*. Indeed, most people are hesitant to bid others to do what is right and stop them from what is wrong because they imagine it would lead to a loss in income or even a shortening of their lives. However, here the Imām declares that one's death is not hastened by *amr bil-ma'rūf* and *nahy 'an al-munkar*, and neither is one's livelihood curtailed thereby (N). A beautiful tradition from the Noble Messenger states that whoever seeks to please people through that which displeases Allāh, those who praise him will start censuring him. But whoever prefers obedience to Allāh through that which angers people, Allāh will suffice him against the enmity of all his enemies and the treachery of every betrayer; and Allāh will be his Helper and Supporter (T).

4 Since the cure of social evils and personal problems is found in the guidance of the Glorious Qur'ān, the Imām reminds his listeners of the value of this Holy Book, and advises them to adhere to it, and to hold fast to its teachings (N). He tells them that the Qur'ān is *a strong rope* ('*al-ḥabl al-matīn*'), and this figurative description is apt since it is by clutching it that one is saved, just as one who holds on to a firm rope is saved from falling into an abyss (MB). The Noble Messenger himself also compared the Qur'ān to a rope, when he said in his famous tradition of the two weighty things (*al-thaqalayn*), "...The Book of Allāh is a rope that extends between the heavens and the earth" (T). The Imām further emphasizes this similitude when he says that the Qur'ān is *a protection for the one who holds fast, and a deliverance for the one who clings to it* ('*al-iṣmatu lil-mutamassik wal-najātu lil-muta'alliq*') (Z). He also calls the Qur'ān *a clear light, a beneficial cure, and a quencher of thirst*. Indeed, it is a bright light, as through its illumination people are brought out of the darkness of ignorance and misguidance towards the straight path, as stated in Q14:1 (T). It is also a beneficial cure for the believers, as the verse states: *...For those who believe it is a guidance and a cure* (Q41:44). The Qur'ān is especially useful as a remedy for spiritual maladies and internal flaws (MB). As for it being *a quencher of thirst* ('*al-rayy al-nāqī'*'), that is because just like water is the most important element for sustaining life, so too is the Qur'ān the most important means for sustaining the spiritual life of human beings (N). The Imām further states that the Qur'ān *does not bend so as to need straightening, and does not deviate so as to be corrected*, meaning that it never becomes crooked, just as the stated in the verse: *All praise is for Allāh, who sent down the Book to His servant and did not put therein any [possibility of] crookedness* (Q18:1) (Z). There is no crookedness or

deviation in it because it contains only the truth, and the truth only confirms itself and does not contradict itself so as to require correction or straightening (MB).

Another quality of the Qurʾān which the Imām then mentions is that *frequent repetition and continuous listening do not make it old*. Some commentators have understood the term ‘*al-radd*’ to mean refutation (instead of repetition), and have thus interpret this statement to mean that despite the numerous attempts to present refutations against the Qurʾān by those who are misguided, right from the time it was first revealed, none of the refutations have had any impact due to the obviousness of their falsehood (T). However, the more correct interpretation of this statement is that it is not like all other speech, in whatever form it may be, which renders its reciter and listener weary if repeated too many times. Allāh has honoured the Glorious Qurʾān and made it such that no matter how many times it is repeated or heard, it is ever fresh and interesting (I). This is a unique feature of the Qurʾān, and no other speech shares this quality (Z).

Finally, the last quality of the Holy Book mentioned by the Imām is that *whoever speaks according to it is truthful and whoever acts by it surpasses others*. That is because its speech is in concordance with reality, so whoever speaks according to the Qurʾān will be truthful in what he says (MB). A tradition attributed to the Messenger of Allāh compares the believer who reads and acts upon the Qurʾān to the one who does not do so. The former is like a fragrant citron fruit that also has a sweet taste, whereas the latter is like the date – its taste is sweet but it has no fragrance (T). Indeed, the Qurʾān has such an attractiveness that anyone who listens to it is enthralled by its beauty. It has been reported that Abū Jahl, Abū Sufyān, and al-Akhnas ibn Shurayq, who were the most bitter enemies of the Messenger of Allāh, used to come secretly in the night and stand beside the wall of the Prophet’s house in order to hear him reciting the Qurʾān. Each of them thought he was doing this alone, but one night, they suddenly bumped into each other, coming face to face. Not wanting to admit what they were doing, they began accusing each other and quarrelling. Then they came to an agreement that they would keep it a secret and promised each other never to come there again (Z). Thus we see how the Qurʾān attracts people towards itself.

5 At this point, the narrator of the sermon notes that a man stood up and said, “O Amīr al-Muʾminīn, tell us about the strife; and had you asked the Holy Prophet (ṣ) about it?” The fact that the definite article ‘*al*’ has been used shows that the questioner was referring to a particular strife, namely the *fitnah* that the Noble

5 [A man stood up and said, “O Amīr al-Muʾminīn, tell us about the strife; and had you asked the Holy Prophet (ﷺ) about it?” So he (‘a) said:] When Allāh, the Glorified, revealed the verses: *Alif lām mīm. What! Do people think that they will be left alone once they say, “We believe,” without being tested?* (Q29:1-2), I knew that the strife would not befall us as long as the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ) is among us. So I said, “O Messenger of Allāh, what is this strife about which Allāh, the Exalted, has informed you?” He replied, “O ‘Alī, my *ummah* will be tested after me.” I said, “O Messenger of Allāh, did you not say to me on the day of Uhūd, when a group among the Muslims fell as martyrs while martyrdom eluded me, and that was very difficult for me to bear, so you said to me, ‘Rejoice, for verily martyrdom is in your future?’” He replied, “Yes, indeed it is so, and how will your patience be then?” I said, “O Messenger of Allāh, it is not an occasion for patience [in my eyes]; rather, it is an occasion for glad tidings and gratitude!”

6 And he said, “O ‘Alī, verily the people will be tested through their wealth, and will consider their devotion as a favour to their Lord. They will expect His mercy and feel safe from His punishment. They will regard as lawful what He has made unlawful through spurious doubts and distracting desires. They will thus claim the lawfulness of

٥ [وَقَامَ إِلَيْهِ رَجُلٌ فَقَالَ: يَا أَمِيرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ، أَحْبَرْنَا عَنِ الْفِتْنَةِ، وَهَلْ سَأَلْتَ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ ﷺ عَنْهَا؟ فَقَالَ ﷺ: إِنَّهُ لَمَّا أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ سُبْحَانَهُ قَوْلَهُ: «الَمْ أَحْسِبَ النَّاسَ أَنْ يَتْرَكُوا أَنْ يَقُولُوا آمَنَّا وَهُمْ لَا يُفْتَنُونَ»، عَلِمْتُ أَنَّ الْفِتْنَةَ لَا تَنْزِلُ بِنَا وَرَسُولُ اللَّهِ ﷺ بَيْنَ أَظْهُرِنَا. فَقُلْتُ: يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ، مَا هَذِهِ الْفِتْنَةُ الَّتِي أَحْبَرَكَ اللَّهُ تَعَالَى بِهَا؟ فَقَالَ: يَا عَلِيُّ، إِنَّ أُمَّتِي سَيُفْتَنُونَ بَعْدِي. فَقُلْتُ: يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ، أَوْ لَيْسَ قَدْ قُلْتَ لِي يَوْمَ أُحُدٍ حَيْثُ اسْتُشْهِدَ مَنْ اسْتُشْهِدَ مِنَ الْمُسْلِمِينَ، وَحِزَّتْ عَنِّي الشَّهَادَةُ فَشَقَّ ذَلِكَ عَلَيَّ، فَقُلْتَ لِي: أُنَبِّئُكَ فَإِنَّ الشَّهَادَةَ مِنْ وَرَائِكَ؟ فَقَالَ لِي: إِنَّ ذَلِكَ لَكَذَلِكَ، فَكَيْفَ صَبْرُكَ إِذَا؟ فَقُلْتُ: يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ، لَيْسَ هَذَا مِنْ مَوَاطِنِ الصَّبْرِ، وَلَكِنْ مِنْ مَوَاطِنِ الْبُشْرَى وَالشُّكْرِ!

٦ وَقَالَ: يَا عَلِيُّ، إِنَّ الْقَوْمَ سَيُفْتَنُونَ بِأَمْوَالِهِمْ، وَيَمْنُونُ بِدِينِهِمْ عَلَى رَبِّهِمْ، وَيَتَمَنُّونَ رَحْمَتَهُ، وَيَأْمَنُونَ سَطَوَتَهُ، وَيَسْتَحِلُّونَ حَرَامَهُ بِالشُّبُهَاتِ الْكَاذِبَةِ، وَالْأَهْوَاءِ السَّاهِيَةِ، فَيَسْتَحِلُّونَ الْخَمْرَ بِالنِّبَذِ،

wine by calling it date juice, of a bribe by calling it a gift, and of usury by calling it trade.” I said, “O Messenger of Allāh, how should I place them at that time? As being guilty of apostasy or guilty of dissension?” He said, “[As] guilty of dissension.”

وَالسُّحْتِ بِالْهَدِيَّةِ، وَالرِّبَا بِالْبَيْعِ.
قُلْتُ: يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ، فَبِأَيِّ الْمَنَازِلِ
أُنْزِلُهُمْ عِنْدَ ذَلِكَ؟ أِبِمَنْزِلَةِ رِدَّةٍ أَمْ
بِمَنْزِلَةِ فَتْنَةٍ؟ فَقَالَ: بِمَنْزِلَةِ فَتْنَةٍ.

Messenger had foretold and warned about (I). And since this address was delivered by the Imām in Baṣrah, it is likely that the questioner sought to know whether or not the dissent of the Baṣrans was part of the strife that had been prophesied by the Messenger of Allāh. By enquiring whether he had asked the Prophet about it or not, the questioner may have wanted to know if the Imām asked him about the details of the *fitnah* or about the status of those involved in it (MB). In his response, the Imām said that when the first verses of Sūrah al-‘Ankabūt were revealed, he realized that the strife would come about after the Messenger of Allāh had left this world. He knew this because the Prophet had informed him about what would happen among his nation after his demise (Z), or because the causes of *fitnah* and the factors that lead to it are prevented by the Messenger’s presence (T). Some commentators refer to the verse: *But Allāh would not punish them while you are among them...* (Q8:33) saying that it is because of this verse that the Imām knew the *fitnah* would only come after the death of the Noble Messenger (I). However, this would entail interpreting *fitnah* as divine punishment, whereas we know that here it refers to strife (MB). Hence, it is more plausible that the Noble Prophet had himself informed Imām ‘Alī that this *fitnah* would transpire after he has left this world. And indeed, this is reflected in what the Imām subsequently reports. He says that when he asked the Prophet about it, the Noble Messenger replied that his *ummah* will be tested after him. According to some commentators, this refers to how they will be granted abundant wealth and power as a test, and many would end up becoming so engrossed in these things that they would forget Allāh and would turn away from obedience to Him (Z). Others say that this was the *fitnah* pertaining to the successorship and *wilāyah* of Amīr al-Mu’minīn (MB).

Imām ‘Alī then asked the Noble Prophet about what was promised to him after the Battle of Uḥud, regarding his attaining martyrdom. On that day, when the

Imām did not attain martyrdom, he was sad that it had eluded him, thereby leaving him deprived of its honour. This was difficult for him to bear, so to console him, the Prophet gave him glad tidings that he would indeed attain martyrdom in the future (*'inna al-shahādata min warā'ik'*). Now the Imām asks the Prophet about that promise, as a long time had passed since he had been given those glad tidings (Z), so the Messenger of Allāh confirmed this again, saying *yes, indeed it is so* (*'inna dhālika lakadhālik'*). By this he meant that the Imām would indeed be martyred, even if it was at a much later time; and some commentators say that the Imām did not ask the Prophet this as a question, but as an expression of yearning for something that had been delayed (MB). It has been suggested that the Noble Messenger asked *how will your patience be then?* because the apparent aspect of facing death by the sword is a difficult trial that requires patience to bear, and the Imām's reply that he considers it *an occasion for glad tidings and gratitude* came from his unwavering conviction of the honour that accompanies death in the way of Allāh (T). Indeed, his remark that *this is not an occasion for patience* highlights the great certitude and profound cognizance of the Imām, just like his statement when he was struck by the sword, "I have succeeded, by the Lord of the Ka'bah!" (I). Martyrdom was something the Imām yearned for and looked forward to, that is why in his eyes it was not difficult to bear (MB).

6 In this final section of the sermon, the Imām continues quoting the Noble Messenger. Though some manuscripts contain the word *ba'dī* in the phrase '*sayuṭtanūna ba'dī bi amwālihim*', it is absent from the earlier manuscripts and is hence considered a mistaken addition (T). Describing the trials that people will face in the future, the Prophet says that *verily the people will be tested through their wealth*. By this he meant that they would become so preoccupied with amassing wealth and preserving it that they will forget Allāh, and will only focus on profit and gain (Z). Alternatively, he meant that they would be tested through riches and poverty, and by opportunities for lawful and unlawful earning, as well as on how they spend their wealth and whether they give what is due from it of alms or not (MB). The second trait mentioned by the Messenger of Allāh is that they *will consider their devotion as a favour to their Lord*. This was something done even by some of those who lived during the time of the Prophet. In this regard, the Qur'ān states: *They think that they have done you a favour by submitting [and becoming Muslims]. Say, "Do not consider your submission a favour to me. Rather it is Allāh who confers a favour upon you in that He has guided you to belief, should you be*

truthful." (Q49:17) (I). Ironically, these same people then feel entitled to Allāh's compassion as they *expect His mercy and feel safe from His punishment*. It should be noted that just as despairing of Allāh's mercy is a grave sin, so too is feeling entitled to it to such a degree that one does not care about following the injunctions of religion. A tradition says that whoever does this is the most foolish of fools (*aḥmaq al-ḥamqā*) (MB). The Noble Prophet subsequently mentions yet another trait saying that *they will regard as lawful what He has made unlawful through spurious doubts and distracting desires*. This means they will follow their passions, and then to justify their deeds, they will look for spurious arguments and deceptive doubts to excuse themselves (N).

The Prophet then gives three examples of how they would employ deception to present the forbidden as lawful. The first is that they will *claim the lawfulness of wine by calling it date juice*, meaning they will drink wine and when it is said to them that wine is forbidden, their response will be that it is only *date juice* ('*nabīdh*'). However, the date juice which was considered permissible caused no intoxication whereas wine is intoxicating (N). In fact, in legal parlance, the term *wine* ('*khamr*') refers to any intoxicating drink. It is reported that Imām al-Ṣādiq said, "Allāh did not forbid wine due to its name; He forbade it due to its [intoxicating] effect. So whatever has the same effect as wine is [also] forbidden" (Z). The second example of their deceit is that they will call bribes 'gifts'. The term '*al-suḥt*' refers to all unlawful earning, such as taking bribes to pass judgment, trading in intoxicants, and so on. In this instance, given the context, the connotation of the term is specifically bribery, and it means that they take bribes claiming that it is only a gift (MB). The third example is that they will justify consuming usury *by calling it trade*. Indeed, even the Qur'ān mentions this false justification when it says: *That is because they say, "Trade is just like usury." Yet Allāh has allowed trade and forbidden usury* (Q2:275) (R). The legal rulings pertaining to what is considered lawful trade and what falls in the domain of forbidden usury are quite detailed. Small wonder it is, then, that Imām 'Alī would address the traders and merchants telling them to learn the rulings before embarking on trade. He would say to them, "Understand the rulings and then trade, for by Allāh usury in this community is more concealed than a tiny ant crawling on a smooth rock" (T). These were the qualities mentioned by the Noble Messenger of those who would come after him. Having heard these words of the Prophet, Amīr al-Mu'minīn asked him how such people should be categorized – *as being guilty of apostasy or guilty of dissension?* In response, the

Noble Prophet said they should be considered as dissenters, and those guilty of sedition and strife (*'bi manzilati fitnah'*). That was because they still apparently professed faith, even though they sinned; so they could not be considered apostates, despite having hearts filled with the ugliest disbelief (MB). They were thus to be considered among the iniquitous (*fāsiqīn*), but not the disbelievers (*kuffār*) (Z).



URGING PEOPLE TO BE GODWARY

1 Praise be to Allāh who made praise a key to His remembrance, a means of increase in His grace and a sign of His bounties and grandeur. Servants of Allāh, time flows with those who remain just as it did with those who have gone. That which has passed of it shall not return and what is there of it shall not remain forever. Its last act is the same as its first, its affairs outpace everything, and its signposts reinforce each other.

١ الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي جَعَلَ الْحَمْدَ مِفْتَاحاً
لِذِكْرِهِ، وَسَبَباً لِلْمَزِيدِ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ،
وَدَلِيلًا عَلَى آلَانِهِ وَعَظَمَتِهِ. عِبَادَ
اللَّهِ، إِنَّ الدَّهْرَ يَجْرِي بِالْبَاقِينَ
كَجَرِّهِ بِالْمَاضِينَ، لَا يُعُودُ مَا قَدْ
وَلَّى مِنْهُ، وَلَا يَبْقَى سَرْمَداً مَا فِيهِ.
آخِرُ فَعَالِهِ كَأَوَّلِهِ، مُتَسَابِقَةٌ أُمُورُهُ،
مُتَظَاهِرَةٌ أَعْلَامُهُ.

2 It is as though the Hour is upon you, driving you on as a cameleer drives his camels. So he who occupies himself with other than [what is good for] his soul gets perplexed in darkness and mired in ruination. His devils lead him in his rebellion and make his evil deeds seem decorous to him. Paradise is the end for the foremost [in virtue] and Hell is the end for those who fall short [in their deeds].

٢ فَكَأَنَّكُمْ بِالسَّاعَةِ تَحْدُوكُمْ حَدَوُ
الرَّاجِرِ بِسَّوْلِهِ، فَمَنْ شَغَلَ نَفْسَهُ بِغَيْرِ
نَفْسِهِ تَحَيَّرَ فِي الظُّلُمَاتِ، وَارْتَبَكَ
فِي الْهَلَكَاتِ، وَمَدَّتْ بِهِ شَيَاطِينُهُ
فِي طُغْيَانِهِ، وَرَبَّتْ لَهُ سَيِّئُ أَعْمَالِهِ،
فَالْجَنَّةُ غَايَةُ السَّابِقِينَ وَالنَّارُ غَايَةُ
الْمُفَرِّطِينَ.

CONTEXT

There is no clear information about the context of this sermon in the available commentaries. However, according to what has been mentioned by the fourth-century scholar ‘Alī ibn Mahdī al-Ṭabarī al-Māmaṭīrī (d. 360 AH) in his *Nuzhat al-Abṣār wa Maḥāsīn al-Āthār* (pp. 233-5), Imām ‘Alī spoke these words in Baṣrah, a short while after the Battle of Jamal (in 36 AH). Ibn Athīr has mentioned and

explained some of the difficult terms of this oration in his *al-Nihāyah*, and some statements from it are also found in *Ghurar al-Ḥikam wa Durar al-Kalim*, albeit with slight variance in wording (N). From its contents, it is evident that the goal of this sermon was to advise the people and warn them against heedlessness and ignorance (MB). The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* places this oration within a longer sermon which the Imām gave on the subject of preparation for death (2:316).

COMMENTARY

1 Imām ‘Alī begins, as always, by praising Allāh, the Exalted. His stating that Allāh has *made praise a key to His remembrance* echoes what has been stated in a number of verses of the Glorious Qur’ān (M). In fact, some commentators say that the term ‘*dhikrihi*’ here refers to the Qur’ān itself (R). It is also possible that the Imām is referring to the general remembrance of Allāh, in any form it takes. An interesting tradition from the Noble Messenger states, “Any speech that does not begin with the praise of Allāh is incomplete.” Indeed, we find that all the Infallibles would start their speeches by praising the Almighty, and this was their established practice (N). The Imām further states that praising Allāh is *a means of increase in His grace and a sign of His bounties and grandeur*. Since the term ‘*ḥamd*’ means praise mixed with gratitude, many commentators have quoted the verse: *If you are grateful, I will surely enhance you with more [blessing]...* (Q14:7) to show that Allāh has Himself promised those who are thankful an increase in blessings (MB, I). His praise is *a sign of His bounties and grandeur* since it shows that He has bestowed some bounty on His servants, and because of His unrivalled greatness and grandeur, all praise belongs only to Him (T).

After praising the Almighty, Imām ‘Alī addresses the people and begins advising them. He tells them that *time flows with those who remain just as it did with those who have gone*, meaning just as the march of time did not stop for the earlier generations, it will not stop for them either (MB). Some take this as an allusion to the well-known dictum ‘history repeats itself’. The events of today are like those of the past, albeit with some small differences (N). Perhaps the Imām addressed them as *servants of Allāh* in order to make them realize that they have no control over many things in their lives, one such thing being the passage of time (T). To emphasize the quick passage of time and its value, he states that what *has passed*

of it shall not return and what is there of it shall not remain forever. Indeed, time and tide wait for no man, and with its passage evils like tyranny, wickedness, and wretchedness come to an end, just as joys and pleasures also abate (R). Some commentators suggest that when the Imām speaks of the actions of time, as in the phrase *its last act is the same as its first* (*‘ākhīru fa‘ālihi ka awwalihi*), he is actually referring to the Lord of time, not time itself (Z). In any case, the Imām means to remind them that just as time never distinguished between the rich and the poor, the healthy and the sick, the lowly and the lofty, in the past, it will not distinguish between these groups and others in the future (MB).

The phrase *‘mutasābiqatun umūruhu’* is rendered *its affairs outpace everything*, and means that time precedes all other things, racing before it the way racehorses compete with each other (I). And *‘mutazāhiratun a‘lāmuhu’* means that its banners prop each other up and support its signs from being lost (R). This figurative statement depicts how its ways of the past continue on even in the present, thereby acting as support for its characteristics and nature, which encompasses all the people (M). Since some manuscripts contain the phrase *‘mutashābihatun a‘lāmuhu’* instead, some commentators understand the meaning to be *its affairs are [all] similar*, and the second phrase is then understood by them to mean *its signs are clearly apparent*. At any rate, the overall connotation here is that by examining past events in history, one can derive lessons by which he may understand what is happening in the present, and perhaps deduce what would soon happen in the future as well (N).

2 After this brief introduction, the Imām now admonishes his listeners, telling them that *it is as though the Hour is upon you, driving you on as a cameleer drives his camels*. The term *‘al-zājir’* refers to a herdsman who is rough and heavy-handed with his camels, and *‘shaul’* refers to camels with lighter burdens, or those with less milk in their udders, such that they are more agile and swift in movement (N). Thus, the analogy aims to convey the meaning that the time of the Hour is quickly approaching (M). In sermon no. 21, which contains a similar statement, we have noted one of the possible meanings for the term Hour; but here it may be referring to the Day of Resurrection. This would then mean that the Last Day is close, and they are all going to quickly end up there (MB). So whoever occupies himself with other than what is good for his soul ends up *perplexed in darkness and mired in ruination*. Every individual has some flaws and shortcomings, and the only way to gain salvation is by striving to reform and get rid of one’s faults, thereby attaining

a level of perfection and coming closer to the All-perfect Lord. However, those who are too engrossed in other things and other people, end up bewildered and perplexed, and are ruined thereby (N).

The Imām then describes how devils lead such a person in his rebellion, inciting him and making *his evil deeds seem decorous to him*. As the Qurʾān states: *Satan has made their deeds seem decorous to them and has hindered them from the [right] way...* (Q27:24) (T). The devils attached to him (*ʿshayāṭīnuhu*) urge him to give in to his base desires, and to find faults in others while completely overlooking his own flaws and considering all his actions to be good. If he cannot find a fault in someone, he invents one! (Z). Sometimes these devils come in the form of human beings as well, encouraging one to commit sins and acts of disobedience (MB). Finally, the Imām mentions the ultimate end, saying that *Paradise is the end for the foremost* in virtue (*ʿal-sābiqīn*) and *Hell is the end for those who fall short* in their deeds (*ʿal-mufarriṭīn*). The *foremost* has been interpreted by some to mean those who waste no time in fulfilling what is made obligatory upon them, whereas *those who fall short* do not care about the rights of Allāh and of the people (Z). Others say that the *foremost* are those who advance ahead of all others in obedience and worship, whereas *those who fall short* are people who fail to take the opportunity to do good deeds in this world and do not acquire the virtues that would take them to Paradise, so they end up in hellfire (N).

3 Having spoken about advancing to Paradise and being saved from hellfire, the Imām turns to the mention of Godwariness (*ʿal-taqwā*) since it is by being mindful of Allāh that one can do what is required to attain salvation and eternal felicity (MB). He likens Godwariness to *an impenetrable fortress* whereas *impiety is a decrepit citadel* which is easily breached and neither protects its residents from harm, nor affords any security to one who takes refuge therein. The phrase *ʿdāru ḥiṣnīn ʿazīz* means an abode that is a mighty fortress (I), offering security to all who take refuge therein. This alludes to the power of Godwariness as a spiritual force which hinders sin and wrongdoing, thereby protecting one from the ill consequences thereof in this world and the next (N). On the other hand, *ʿal-fujūr* refers to impiety and immorality, and it leads one to censure and ruin in this world, and perdition in the Hereafter (MB). The Imām subsequently states that *through Godwariness the sting of misdeeds is cut out*, meaning that it is only by following the path of guidance that one can remain safe from danger and a disastrous end (Z). The term *ʿḥumah* refers to a venomous sting, usually from a scorpion or

3 Know, O servants of Allāh, that Godwariness is indeed an impenetrable fortress while impiety is a decrepit citadel that does not protect its residents from harm and affords no security to one who takes refuge therein. Indeed, through Godwariness the sting of misdeeds is cut off and through certitude the final goal is achieved. O servants of Allāh, fear Allāh! Fear Allāh in the matter of the dearest of all souls and the most beloved of them to you, for verily Allāh has made the way of truth clear for you and has lighted its paths. Hence there is either a besetting wretchedness or eternal felicity! So gather provisions in the days of perishing for the days of eternity. You have been shown the provision and have been ordered to depart and urged to make haste. You are thus just like halted riders who do not know when they will be ordered to march on. Look, what does one who has been created for the Hereafter have to do with this world! And what does one have to do with wealth which will shortly be taken from him, while only its consequences and reckoning remain for him!

۳ اَعْلَمُوا عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، أَنَّ التَّقْوَى دَارُ حِصْنٍ عَزِيزٍ، وَالْفُجُورَ دَارُ حِصْنٍ ذَلِيلٍ، لَا يَمْنَعُ أَهْلَهُ وَلَا يُحَرِّزُ مَنْ لَجَأَ إِلَيْهِ. أَلَا وَبِالتَّقْوَى تُقَطَّعُ حُمَةُ الْخَطَايَا، وَبِالْيَقِينِ تُدْرَكُ الْغَايَةُ الْقُصْوَى. عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، اللَّهُ اللَّهُ فِي أَعَزِّ الْأَنْفُسِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأَحَبِّهَا إِلَيْكُمْ؛ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ أَوْضَحَ لَكُمْ سَبِيلَ الْحَقِّ وَأَنَارَ طُرُقَهُ، فَشِقْوَةٌ لَازِمَةٌ، أَوْ سَعَادَةٌ دَائِمَةٌ! فَتَرَوُذُوا فِي أَيَّامِ الْفَنَاءِ لِأَيَّامِ الْبَقَاءِ. قَدْ دَلَّلْتُمْ عَلَى الرَّادِّ، وَأَمَرْتُمْ بِالظَّنِّ، وَحَثَّيْتُمْ عَلَى الْمَسِيرِ، فَأَنْتُمْ أَنْتُمْ كَرَكَبٍ وَقُوفٍ، لَا يَذْرُونَ مَتَى يُؤْمَرُونَ بِالسَّيْرِ، أَلَا فَمَا يَصْنَعُ بِالدُّنْيَا مَنْ خُلِقَ لِلْآخِرَةِ! وَمَا يَصْنَعُ بِالْمَالِ مَنْ عَمَّا قَلِيلٍ يُسَلَّبُهُ، وَتَبْقَى عَلَيْهِ نَبْعَتُهُ وَحِسَابُهُ!

serpent, but also from a hornet. Here, it is metaphorically used to describe sin and wrongdoing, because just as the sting causes much pain and suffering, sins and misdeeds result in suffering in this world as well as chastisement in the next life (M). The *cutting off* of the sting refers to stopping its flow into the body using the

tools required to prevent its spread; and here sin is likened to the poison that spreads throughout the body, and it is only *taqwā* that can halt its spread (I).

The Imām then says that it is only *through certitude* that *the final goal is achieved*, meaning that by riding the mount of certitude, one can arrive at his final destination (N). The adjective '*al-quṣwā*' also means most distant, and therefore some opine that the distant goal it refers to is eternal felicity in Paradise (R). Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn advises the people to fear Allāh regarding *the dearest of all souls and the most beloved of them to you*. The dearest and most beloved of souls to a human being is his own soul, and indeed most commentators say that the Imām is warning people to be careful about their own souls (MB). Since Allāh has *made the way of truth clear for you and has lighted its paths*, through His revelations and Messengers (M), there is no excuse left for anyone (MB). Hence, the only possible outcomes are *a besetting wretchedness or eternal felicity* ('*shiqwatun lāzimah aw sa'ādatur dā'imah*'), because the guidance has already come, and the path has been made clear. So whoever follows the path attains felicity and whoever strays therefrom ends up wretched (T).

Imām 'Alī then tells the people to gather provisions in *the days of perishing for the days of eternity*, meaning they should use the transient life of this world, with its limited time and expiring days, to gather provisions for the Hereafter which will be eternal and everlasting. The provision being referred to here is Godwariness, as stated in the verse: *And take the necessary provisions – verily the best of provisions is Godwariness...* (Q2:197) (M). He then reminds the people that they *have been shown the provision and have been ordered to depart and urged to make haste*, which may either be meant metaphorically, referring to detaching oneself from this world and yearning instead for the Hereafter, towards which one should advance with heart and soul. Or, it may be literal, in which case it means preparing for death and the actual departure from this world (MB). The phrase '*ḥuthithtum 'alā al-masīr*' means being urged on, and pushed forward upon the path, so some commentators opine that it alludes to the day and night, which march ahead, driving all the creatures with them, by force (I). To further emphasize the need for quick preparation and complete readiness for departure from this fleeting world, Imām 'Alī tells the people that their likeness is *like halted riders who do not know when they will be ordered to march on*, which figuratively refers to the unknown moment of death (I). Some say the riders represent human souls, their mounts represent their physical bodies, and their marching on refers to departure from

4 O servants of Allāh! The good that Allāh has promised is not something to be abandoned and the evil that He has forbidden is not something to be coveted. O servants of Allāh! Fear the day when deeds will be examined, when tremors will increase, and when children will turn grey. Know, O servants of Allāh, that you surely have observers over you from yourselves, and watchers in the form of your limbs, and honest recorders who record your deeds and the number of your breaths. Neither does the darkness of a pitch-dark night conceal you from them, nor can large, bolted doors hide you from them. Verily tomorrow is close to today; today will depart with all that it has and tomorrow will follow in its wake. It is as though each one of you has reached his abode of loneliness in the earth, and the location of his grave. And what a house of loneliness, abode of solitude, and desolate isolation it is!

5 It is as though the Cry has reached you, the Hour has come upon you, and you are presented [before Allāh] for the decisive judgement. All falsities have been withdrawn from you and the excuses you give have been rendered futile. The truth has been established before you and all matters related to you have been put in their rightful places. So take admonition from [your]

٤ عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، إِنَّهُ لَيْسَ لِمَا وَعَدَ اللَّهُ مِنَ الْخَيْرِ مَشْرُكٌ، وَلَا فِيمَا نَهَى عَنْهُ مِنَ الشَّرِّ مَرْغَبٌ. عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، احْذَرُوا يَوْمًا تُنَحَّصُ فِيهِ الْأَعْمَالُ، وَيَكْثُرُ فِيهِ الزَّلْزَالُ، وَتَشِيبُ فِيهِ الْأَطْفَالُ. اْعْلَمُوا عِبَادَ اللَّهِ، أَنَّ عَلَيْكُمْ رَصَدًا مِنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ، وَعُيُونًا مِنْ جَوَارِحِكُمْ، وَحُفَظًا صِدْقٍ يَحْفَظُونَ أَعْمَالَكُمْ وَعَدَدَ أَنْفَاسِكُمْ، لَا تَسْتُرُكُمْ مِنْهُمْ ظُلْمَةٌ لَيْلٍ دَاجٍ، وَلَا يُكْنِيكُمْ مِنْهُمْ بَابُ دُورِ رَجَاجٍ. وَإِنَّ عَدَاً مِنَ الْيَوْمِ قَرِيبٌ، يَذْهَبُ الْيَوْمُ بِمَا فِيهِ، وَيَجِيءُ الْعَدُوُّ لَا حِقَابَ لَهُ، فَكَأَنَّ كُلَّ امْرِئٍ مِنْكُمْ قَدْ بَلَغَ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ مَنْزِلَ وَحْدَتِهِ، وَمَخْطَ حُفْرَتِهِ، فَيَا لَهُ مِنْ بَيْتٍ وَحْدَةٍ، وَمَنْزِلٍ وَحْشَةٍ، وَمُفْرَدٍ غُرْبَةٍ.

٥ وَكَأَنَّ الصَّيْحَةَ قَدْ أَتَتْكُمْ، وَالسَّاعَةَ قَدْ غَشِيَتْكُمْ، وَبَرَزْتُمْ لِفَضْلِ الْقَضَاءِ، قَدْ زَاَحَتْ عَنْكُمْ الْأَبَاطِيلُ، وَاضْمَحَلَّتْ عَنْكُمْ الْعِلَلُ، وَاشْتَحَقَّتْ بِكُمْ الْحَقَائِقُ، وَصَدَرَتْ بِكُمْ الْأُمُورُ

experiences, learn from vicissitudes of life, and benefit from warnings.

مَصَادِرَهَا، فَاتَّعِظُوا بِالْغَيْرِ،
وَاعْتَبِرُوا بِالْغَيْرِ، وَانْتَفِعُوا بِالذُّدْرِ.

this world towards the Hereafter (M). If one were to ask: the Imām had said that they *have been ordered to depart* (*‘umirtum bil-ẓa’n*) but now he says that they are halting and awaiting orders *to march on*, so is that not a contradiction? The answer is that the first phrase is in reference to movement in this world towards perfection and swift preparation for the next world, whereas the second phrase is talking about movement from this world towards the Hereafter, so there is no contradiction here (N). By asking the rhetorical question *what does one who has been created for the Hereafter have to do with this world!* the Imām is censuring those who engross themselves with worldly pursuits. It is only logical that if people were created for the Hereafter, that is what they should strive to work for (MB). To stress the point further, he poses a second rhetorical question along the same lines and asks *what does one have to do with wealth which will shortly be taken from him, while only its consequences and reckoning remains for him!* Indeed, the only way to avoid punishment in this regard is by earning a lawful income and spending one's wealth in what is lawful and permissible (Z).

4 By telling the people *the good that Allāh has promised is not something to be abandoned and the evil that He has forbidden is not something to be coveted*, the Imām is indirectly reminding them of the great reward promised to those who believe and do good, as well as the tremendous harm that results from what is forbidden. Traditions about the bounties of Paradise highlight this clearly, as they state that even the lowest level of al-Jannah is so vast and abundant, all of humanity can be accommodated and provided for therein. Likewise the torments of Hell are so unbearable that no rational person would ever covet anything that could lead him to it (T). The Imām then warns them, telling them to *fear the day when the deeds will be examined, when tremors will increase, and when children will turn grey*. Of course, he is talking about the Day of Resurrection, and the examination of deeds on that day refers to their being exposed (I), such that whoever did an atom's weight of good will see it and whoever did an atom's weight of evil will see it, as the Qur'ān clearly states (T). The earthquakes and tremors of that day are also mentioned in the Glorious Qur'ān, and it has likewise been described as the day *that will turn children's hair grey* (Q73:17) (M). These descriptions all serve to depict

the severity and intensity of distress that human beings will face on the Day of Judgement (MB). Subsequently, the people are reminded that their own selves act as observers over them (*'raṣadan min anfusikum'*), and their own limbs watch them and their actions (*"uyūnan min jawāriḥikum"*). The term *'uyūnan'* is plural of *'ayn*, which has many meanings, including spy, and that is what is intended here (T). The limbs and organs witness the individual's actions and will then testify to that on the Day of Reckoning. The Qur'ān portrays this beautifully when it states: *Until, when they reach it, their ears, their eyes, and their skins will bear witness against them for what they used to do* (Q41:20) (MB). Additionally, there are *honest recorders who record* the deeds of the people and even the number of their breaths. *'Ḥuffāza ṣidq'* refer to the noble angels appointed with the task of recording the actions of human beings (I). The fact that even the number of one's breaths is recorded shows that every minute detail about a person and what he does is watched and noted.

A question that may arise here is: if Allāh already knows everything, what is the need for such recording by angels and witnesses? It has been suggested that this is because the human being is a corporeal creature and lives in the material world, so when he is told that his own skin and limbs will testify to his deeds, or that they have been written down by angels, he is better able to fathom the reality and would thus be more careful about what he does (N). Imām 'Alī then explains how no one can hide from these angels who record the deeds, for neither can *the darkness of a pitch-dark night* conceal the people from them, nor can *large, bolted doors* provide a means of hiding from them. The phrase *'laylin dāj'* means a night that covers everything, and *'bābun dhū ritāj'* refers to a large door, which has a lock, and both have been employed here to express the impossibility of concealing oneself from the angels (T). After warning them of their deeds, the Imām speaks about the grave and describes it as the *abode of loneliness in the earth*. He reminds them of the swift passage of time, with the morrow quickly following on the heels of the present day. By saying that *tomorrow is close to today*, the Imām meant that the time of one's death is near, and his life in this world will soon come to an end. The term *'makhaṭṭ'* literally refers to a place marked with lines, and here it means the location of one's grave (N). For emphasis, the Imām again describes the grave as a *house of loneliness*, and an *abode of solitude and desolate isolation*, thereby reminding his audience of its horrors (MB).

5 After reminding the people of their dark, lonely, graves, the Imām turns their attention to the Day of Resurrection, when they will be made to stand before their Lord and give an account of their deeds. He warns them that the Cry will soon reach them, the Hour will come upon them, and they shall be presented before Allāh for the decisive judgement. *The Cry* ('*al-ṣayḥah*') is the sound that marks the beginning of the resurrection, and the rising of humankind from their graves. This loud sound has also been called the 'blowing of a horn' and it will be repeated twice – once to bring an end to this world and death to all that remain in it, and the second time to resurrect the dead (N). The *decisive judgment* ('*faṣl al-qaḍā'*') will result in every soul being given exactly what it deserves of reward or punishment, based on Divine judgment (M). By the phrase '*zāḥat 'ankum al-abāṭil*', which has been rendered *all falsities have been withdrawn from you*, the Imām means that all forms of falsehood will have been distanced and removed from them, and '*iḍmaḥallat 'ankum al-īlal*' means that excuses will have been rendered moot (T). Some commentators have understood the term '*al-īlal*' here to mean spiritual ailments, and they say the phrase means that all such ailments will be done away with (MB). However, this meaning does not match the context and the first meaning is more plausible given the numerous corroborating verses of the Qur'ān (T). Indeed, that will be the Day when truth is established and comes to the fore, and all matters are *put in their rightful places*. The phrase '*ṣadarat bikum al-umūru maṣādirahā*' implies that every individual will find the outcome of his actions and all things shall be placed in their appropriate positions (N). The same verb (*ṣadara*) has also been used in the verse: *On that Day, humankind will proceed in separate groups to be shown their deeds* (Q99:6) (T), hence some understand the phrase as a reference to how human beings will proceed from one stage to another, from this world to death, and then to resurrection (I). If this second meaning is taken, the translation would be *and your affairs will have taken their course*.

In closing, Amīr al-Mu'minīn tells his listeners to *take admonition from experiences, learn from vicissitudes of life, and benefit from warnings*. This means they ought to learn from what they see and experience around them, and from past events, all of which contain exemplary lessons that serve to remind human beings of their true purpose. What they see happening to others also contain lessons for them to learn from, so they should be heedful of this (MB). *Vicissitudes of life* translates '*al-ghiyar*' and refers to the changing circumstances and states that one experiences in his life, including the coming and going of blessings and trials

(N). As for '*al-nudhur*', it means warners or warnings, and comprises all that cautions and frightens one about the Hereafter and the torments that await one if he is not careful about his deeds in this world (MB).



ON THE PROPHET & THE QUR'ĀN, AND THE RULE OF BANŪ Umayyah

THE PROPHET AND THE QUR'ĀN

- 1 He sent him during the period after an interval in the sequence of Messengers, a lengthy slumber among the nations, and the unravelling of what had been firmly established. He brought them an affirmation of that which was before him and a light by which they may be guided. That is the Qur'ān; so try to get it to speak [to you], yet it will never speak, but I will inform you about it. Be aware that it contains knowledge of what is to come, narratives of the past, a cure for your ailments, and a system for your social interactions.

النبي والقرآن

١ أَرْسَلَهُ عَلَى حِينٍ فَتْرَةٍ مِنْ
الرُّسُلِ، وَطَوِيلِ هَجْعَةٍ مِنَ الْأُمَمِ،
وَأَنْتِقَاضِ مِنَ الْمُبْرَمِ، فَجَاءَهُمْ
بِتَصْديقِ الَّذِي بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ، وَالنُّورِ
الْمُقْتَدَى بِهِ. ذَلِكَ الْقُرْآنُ
فَاسْتَنْطِقُوهُ وَلَنْ يَنْطِقَ، وَلَكِنْ
أُخْبِرْكُمْ عَنْهُ: أَلَا إِنَّ فِيهِ عِلْمَ مَا
يَأْتِي، وَالْحَدِيثَ عَنِ الْمَاضِي،
وَدَوَاءَ دَائِكُمْ وَنَظْمَ مَا بَيْنَكُمْ.

CONTEXT

Some commentators say that this oration is the same as sermon no. 88, with slight variance, as both are seemingly from the lengthy speech of the Imām narrated in al-Kulaynī's *al-Kāfi* (MB). However, it has been pointed out that only two sentences from these sermons are alike, and the rest of the contents thereof differ substantially. Small sections of this sermon have been related by Ibn Athīr in his *al-Nihāyah*, with variation in wording, and in other works like *Tafsīr al-Qummī* (N). It has also been pointed out that sections of this sermon are very similar to the sermon given by al-Sayyidah Fāṭimah, as reported in *Balāghāt al-Nisā'* (T). Two different topics are addressed in this oration, the first being about the Noble Prophet and his merits (M), including how the Qur'ān was revealed to him as a comprehensive guide for all peoples. The second topic pertains to the Umayyads and their tyranny, and how it would not last (N).

COMMENTARY

1 The opening statement notes how Allāh sent the Noble Messenger during *the period after an interval in the sequence of Messengers, a lengthy slumber among the nations, and the unravelling of what had been firmly established*. As noted in the commentary of sermon no. 88, the term '*fatrah*' refers to the interval between two divinely appointed Prophets, wherein revelation had stopped (T). Likewise, as discussed in that sermon, the phrase *a lengthy slumber among the nations* alludes to the ignorance that had become pervasive during that time. The phrase '*intiqāḍin min al-mubram*' refers to the unravelling of the religious legislation and teachings that had been established by the previous Prophets (MB). It was at such a time that the Noble Messenger came to the people, bringing with him what affirmed *that which was before him*, meaning the Tawrāt and Injīl (I), and guidance which acted as illumination, dispelling the darkness of ignorance and errancy (N). *That was the Glorious Qur'ān* for indeed it describes itself both as a confirmer of what came before it and a light (Q5:48, Q5:15) (MB). The imperative '*fastanṭiqūhu*' is translated *so try to get it to speak* and connotes trying to get it to convey its meanings and messages (T). It is been suggested that this is a call to reflect on the Qur'ān in order to understand its deeper meanings and mysteries, though it is not possible to arrive at its reality and hidden secrets except through one who has been granted knowledge of the Book, namely the Imām himself (Z). Hence he says *yet it will never speak but I will inform you about it*. Of course, this does not mean that the Qur'ān speaks to no one other than the Infallibles, since it was revealed as a guidance for all people. Rather, it means that the esoteric and inward aspects of the Qur'ān are only accessible by the Prophet and his pure progeny (N).

Imām 'Alī then proceeds to summarize what the Qur'ān contains, telling the people that the Book of Allāh contains *knowledge of what is to come, narratives of the past, a cure for your ailments, and a system for your social interactions*. This means that the Qur'ān discusses what will transpire in the future in terms of death and what comes after it, as well as the history of bygone peoples and what can be learned from their fate (MB). The ailments that the Imām was talking about here were the vile traits and contemptible qualities prevalent among the people, for which the Qur'ān offered the best remedy through its guidance (M). The phrase '*naẓma mā baynakum*' is rendered *a system for your social interactions* and refers to an organizational structure for the regulation of people's affairs in society. It means that the Qur'ān contains all the rules and laws required to make a human

ON THE REIGN OF BANŪ Umayyah

ومنها: في دولة بني أمية

2 At that time, there will remain no brick house or woollen tent but that the oppressors would make sorrow enter it and insert wretchedness into it. On that day, there will remain none in the sky to give excuses for them and none on the earth to come to their aid. You chose to vest authority in one who was unfit for it, and you led him to that which was not meant for him. Allāh will soon take vengeance on the oppressor, morsel for morsel and sip for sip, with bitter colocynth for food, myrrh and aloes for drink, fear for inner clothing, and the sword for an outer covering. They are only [like] beasts of burden laden with sins, and camels carrying evil deeds.

٢ فَعِنْدَ ذَلِكَ لَا يَبْقَى بَيْتٌ مَدْرٍ وَلَا
وَبَرٍ إِلَّا وَأَدْخَلَهُ الظُّلْمَةُ تَرْحَةً،
وَأَوْجَلُوا فِيهِ نِقْمَةً، فَيَوْمَئِذٍ لَا يَبْقَى
لَهُمْ فِي السَّمَاءِ عَاذِرٌ، وَلَا فِي
الْأَرْضِ نَاصِرٌ. أَصْفَيْتُمْ بِالْأَمْرِ غَيْرَ
أَهْلِهِ، وَأَوْرَدْتُمُوهُ غَيْرَ وَرْدِهِ،
وَسَيَنْتَقِمُ اللَّهُ مِمَّنْ ظَلَمَ، مَا كَلَا
بِمَا كَلِ، وَمَشْرَبًا بِمَشْرَبٍ، مِنْ
مَطَاعِمِ الْعَلَقَمِ، وَمَشَارِبِ الصَّبْرِ
وَالْمَقْرِ، وَلِبَاسِ شِعَارِ الْخَوْفِ وَدِثَارِ
السَّيْفِ، وَإِنَّمَا هُمْ مَطَايَا الْخَطِيئَاتِ
وَزَوَامِلُ الْأَثَامِ.

3 I swear, and again I swear, that the Umayyads will surely spit it out after me the way phlegm is spat, then they will neither taste it nor relish its flavour ever again, as long as there is day and night!

٣ فَأَقْسِمُ، ثُمَّ أَقْسِمُ، لَتَنْخَمَنَّهَا أُمِّيَّةٌ
مِنْ بَعْدِي كَمَا تُلْفِظُ النَّخَامَةَ،
ثُمَّ لَا تَذُوقُهَا وَلَا تَتَطَعَّمُ بِطَعْمِهَا
أَبَدًا مَا كَرَّ الْجَدِيدَانِ!

society function harmoniously, with peace and security, through a just social order (N).

2 The second subject broached by the Imām pertains to the tribulation of the tyranny of Banū Umayyah, which would cause suffering to all the Muslims, as a consequence of their own misdeeds (N). The oppression that would be carried out by the Umayyads has already been discussed in sermon no. 97, and he states that during their reign, *there will remain no brick house or woollen tent but that the oppressors would make sorrow enter it and insert wretchedness into it*. The mention of *house or tent* alludes to both urban and rural dwellings, since this tribulation

would encompass both the city dwellers as well as nomadic tribes (MB). The term '*tarḥah*' refers to sorrow and grief (T), and the phrase '*awlajū fihī niqmah*' connotes forcefully introducing and inserting misery and suffering, which they would do with their cruelty and wickedness. The Imām then states that this would be the period when *there will remain none in the sky to give excuses for them and none on the earth to come to their aid*. Some commentators say he means that the oppressed people would not have any support or refuge, either due to their compliance with the oppressors or their silence in the face of oppression (N). Others say that it is the Banū Umayyah themselves who will not have anyone to make excuses for them, because of their open tyranny and excessive oppression, which can have no justification. And they will have no helper because their cruelty will affect both the virtuous and the wicked (T). It is also possible that this statement means that when their tyranny becomes pervasive, Allāh will remove His mercy from them such that they will then have no one in the heavens or earth who would support them, and their rule would collapse and come to an end (I).

Subsequently, Amīr al-Mu'minīn says *you chose to vest authority in one who was unfit for it, and you led him to that which was not meant for him*. There is a discussion among commentators regarding who is being addressed here. Some say the Imām is speaking to those who accepted Umayyad rule (Z), and this supports the earlier interpretation that the people were told they would have no refuge or help because their actions led to the ascension of this despotic dynasty (N). Others opine that this is addressed to the supporters of the Banū Umayyah, and those who wanted to see them in power (I). The phrase '*awradtumūhu ghayra wirdihī*' literally means to lead one to a waterhole which is not his, and here it connotes giving the caliphate to those who had no right to it, whether the first three caliphs or those who followed in their footsteps, like Mu'āwiyah and the rest of the Banū Umayyah (MB).

Imām 'Alī then promises that Allāh will exact vengeance and retribution on those who oppress ('*mimman ḡalam*'), and he mentions what this reprisal will entail. It will be *morsel for morsel and sip for sip, with bitter colocynth for food, myrrh and aloes for drink, fear for inner clothing, and the sword for an outer covering*. The phrase '*ma'kalan bi ma'kalin wa mashraban bi mashrabin*' is understood to mean that Allāh will replace their sweet, tasty food and drink with what is bitter and unsavoury (I). The Imām then mentions examples of the horrible vittles they will be forced to devour: *bitter colocynth for food, myrrh and aloes for drink*. The term

'*al-alqam*' refers to colocynth, which is an intensely bitter gourd-like fruit, or to anything bitter (T). '*Al-ṣabir*' and '*al-maqir*' refer to bitter drinks, usually taken as medicine. It has been suggested that these foods and drinks are meant as metaphors that refer to the bitter circumstances in store of them, such as the rise of their enemies and being slaughtered at their hands with the collapse of their rule (M). Fear has been described as their *inner clothing* and the sword as their outer garment because fear is something felt in the heart and mind, while the sword is something that harms the outer body (MB). The Imām then likens those tyrants to *beasts of burden laden with sins and camels carrying evil deeds*. The term '*zawāmil*' is plural of *zāmilah*, which is the camel that is used to carry baggage and provisions (T). Just as animals lack the intelligence to comprehend what they carry on their backs, so too do these despots lack the wisdom to understand how their oppression is only increasing their burden of sin, for which they will have to bear a painful torment in the Hereafter (N).

3 In the final section of this sermon, Amīr al-Mu'minīn informs the people about the fall of the Umayyads, and he begins by repeating the phrase *I swear* ('*uqsim*'), to emphasize that what he says is true and will surely come to pass (MB). He then declares that *the Umayyads will surely spit it out after me the way phlegm is spat*, meaning they will expectorate the caliphate and their authority the way mucus is expelled. This analogy is astounding, and some say it means that they will have polluted the government to such a degree by their tyranny and injustice that they will themselves be unable to bear it, and will be forced to spit it out like the phlegm that has gathered in one's upper chest and throat (N). Subsequently, once they are removed from power, *they will neither taste it nor relish its flavour ever again, as long as there is day and night*, meaning that no remnants of its authority or benefit will remain with any of them. The phrase '*mā karr al-jadīdān*' means as long as night and day alternates (T). In this way, the Imām informed the people of the complete collapse of the Umayyad empire (Z). Indeed, from some reports we learn that the Noble Messenger had himself also foretold the rise and fall of the Umayyads, and had even cursed them (I).



ON HIS KIND TREATMENT OF HIS SUBJECTS

1 I have been amicable with you and have spared no effort in protecting you. I freed you from the nooses of humiliation and the fetters of oppression out of my gratitude for the little goodness [you showed], and by turning a blind eye to the numerous misdeeds that the eyes had observed and the body had witnessed.

١ وَلَقَدْ أَحْسَنْتُ جِوَارَكُمْ، وَأَحْطْتُ
بِجُهِدِي مِنْ وَرَائِكُمْ، وَأَعْتَقْتُكُمْ
مِنْ رَبِي الدُّلَّ وَحَلَقِي الضَّيْمِ، شُكْرًا
مُنِّي لِلْبِرِّ الْقَلِيلِ، وَإِطْرَاقًا عَمَّا
أَذْرَكَهُ الْبَصَرُ وَشَهِدَهُ الْبَدَنُ مِنَ
الْمُنْكَرِ الْكَثِيرِ.

CONTEXT

Nothing is found in the extant sources regarding the context of this sermon, but some commentators have surmised that it was addressed to the people of Kūfah (MB). From the content of the oration, we may deduce that the Imām spoke these words towards the end of his life, since he mentions how he turned a blind eye to the way people had behaved, and despite their poor attitude and disobedience, he had been amicable with them and protected them from both internal and external enemies (N). However, it is also possible that the Imām said this much earlier, and he may have been talking about how he protected the people during the days of ʿUthmān (T). There is no other extant early source that has recorded this sermon, though many later sources have quoted it from *Nahj al-Balāghah*. The author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has placed this oration within a much longer sermon which the Imām gave on the subject of his closeness to the Messenger of Allāh, and the merits of the Prophet's household (2:414).

COMMENTARY

1 The Imām reminds the people that he has been amicable with them, and has spared no effort in protecting them. The phrase '*laqad aḥsantu jiwārukum*'

literally means I have been a good neighbour to you, and have fulfilled the duties of righteous companionship. A similar statement is seen in sermon no. 149, where the Imām said *I was only a neighbour, with my body remaining in your company for a few days*, so we note that by this he was generally referring to his presence among the people, and his associating with them (MB). Being amicable with one's neighbours entails not exposing their faults or causing them disturbance, and remaining patient with them as much as possible (Z). It means being respectful and kind towards one's neighbours, such that they feel a sense of ease with one's presence among them. History attests to how the Imām would treat the people as a kind father-figure, especially the orphans and less fortunate among them, whom he would regularly visit and give food (N). As for the phrase '*aḥaṭṭu bi juhdī min warā'ikum*', it is understood by some to mean that he strove to keep the people safe and protect them, since oftentimes the enemy attacks from the rear (*warā'*), especially while one is trying to flee. However, it may also mean that the people gained strength and power through his presence and support (MB). The Imām then says that he freed them *from the nooses of humiliation and the fetters of oppression*, which is seen as a reference to their state during the days of 'Uthmān ibn 'Affān, when they were under the yoke of oppression (T). The Imām had saved them from that unjust system, where nepotism and cronyism was the order of the day (N). The term '*ribaḳ*' is plural of *ribḳah*, meaning a snare or noose (R), usually made out of rope, and '*al-ḍaym*' refers to injustice, tyranny, or the abasement that results therefrom (T). Imām 'Alī then explains why he did all this for them, stating that it was *out of gratitude* for the little good they did, and *by turning a blind eye to the numerous misdeeds that the eyes had observed and the body had witnessed*.

His gratitude was for their little obedience to him (M), or their few virtuous actions in general (MB), or their turning to him and agreeing by consensus to pledge allegiance to him as caliph (T). By mentioning that their good was paltry, the Imām actually meant that they had not done anything to deserve such gratitude, but it was only out of his own graciousness that he had assisted them the way he did (N). And the fact that he did so while staying silent about their numerous faults shows that they were unworthy of his support and kindness. The term '*iṭrāqan*' means having lowered his head, and connotes silence along with lowering of the gaze (T). Here, it means that he turned a blind eye and ignored the wrongs he saw from them. And what *the body had witnessed* refers to what he experienced and perceived; together, these two statements mean that he overlooked

much of what they had done to cause him suffering and difficulty (Z). Some opine that what *the body had witnessed* was their abandonment of the Imām, despite his special status and his having been appointed by the Noble Messenger as the rightful successor (T). Those who misconstrued this statement tried to answer the question, ‘How could the Imām turn a blind eye to something wrong and evil?’ by saying that he did this because he knew that no one would listen to him or follow him (I). Since he could not force them to abandon their misdeeds, or attempting that may have led them to embark on something even worse, the Imām had no choice but to remain silent about it (MB). However, what he meant by ‘*al-munkar al-kathīr*’ here was the numerous wrongs they had done against him personally, not generally any evil action or sin they undertook. And this meaning is supported by his statement in sermon no. 73: *As long as the affairs of the Muslims are secured and there is no oppression in it save upon myself only, I shall submit* (Z).



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ON HOPE IN ALLĀH AND ABOUT THE PROPHETS

THE GREATNESS OF ALLĀH

عظمة الله

- 1 His command is decisive and full of wisdom. His pleasure is a security and a mercy. He judges with knowledge and forgives with clemency.

١ أَمْرُهُ قَضَاءٌ وَحِكْمَةٌ، وَرِضَاؤُهُ أَمَانٌ
وَرَحْمَةٌ، يَقْضِي بِعِلْمٍ وَيَعْفُو بِحِلْمٍ.

PRAISING ALLĀH

حمد الله

- 2 O Allāh! Praise be to You for what You take and You give, and for what You cure and You afflict; a praise which is most pleasing to You, a praise most liked by You, and the best praise in Your sight; a praise which fills all that You have created and extends up to where You wish; a praise which is not veiled from You and does not fail to reach You; a praise whose count never stops and whose continuity never ceases.

٢ اللَّهُمَّ لَكَ الْحَمْدُ عَلَى مَا تَأْخُذُ
وَتُعْطِي، وَعَلَى مَا تُعَافِي وَتَبْتَلِي؛
حَمْدًا يَكُونُ أَرْضَى الْحَمْدِ لَكَ،
وَأَحَبَّ الْحَمْدِ إِلَيْكَ، وَأَفْضَلَ
الْحَمْدِ عِنْدَكَ؛ حَمْدًا يَمْلَأُ مَا
خَلَقْتَ، وَيَبْلُغُ مَا أَرَدْتَ؛ حَمْدًا لَا
يُحْجَبُ عَنْكَ، وَلَا يَقْصُرُ دُونَكَ؛
حَمْدًا لَا يَنْقَطِعُ عَدْدُهُ، وَلَا يَفْنَى
مَدَدُهُ.

CONTEXT

We have no available information regarding the context of this sermon, but the author of *Tamām Nahj al-Balāghah* has mentioned it as part of a longer oration known as ‘al-Zahrā’ (the Luminous Sermon, 1:392), as have others like al-Iskāfī in *al-Mi’yār wal-Muwāzanah*, and Ibn ‘Abd Rabbih in *al-Iqd al-Farīd*. Al-Zamakhsharī, who lived about a century after al-Sayyid al-Raḍī, has mentioned part of this sermon in his *Rabīʿ al-Abrār*, with some variance in wording, which shows that he had a different source for the sermon. This is one of the lengthier sermons of *Nahj al-Balāghah*, and comprises a number of different topics. The five basic themes

addressed in this oration are: the greatness of Allāh, the importance of hope, qualities of the Noble Messenger, prophetic practices worthy of emulation, and simple living (N). The beautiful and lesson-giving descriptions of the Messenger of Allāh in this oration are particularly interesting and of benefit to all believers to wish to follow his example.

COMMENTARY

1 The opening statement of this sermon describes the command of Allāh as *decisive and full of wisdom*, which means His judgment is final and cannot be averted (T), while at the same time being wise, unlike the commands of tyrants and despots who give strict orders that lack reason (N). The wisdom in His command is manifested in the benefit it has for those being commanded (R). *His command* (*‘amruhu’*) may refer to His ontological or generative (*takwīnī*) command, meaning what pertains to His creation, all of which are under His control and He only says to anything ‘Be!’ and it is. Or, it may refer to His legislative (*tashrī‘ī*) command, which includes all that He prescribes and proscribes, the obedience of which is obligatory on the creatures (Z). Some have suggested that *His command* may also refer to His decree regarding each of His servants (R). The Imām then says that Allāh’s *pleasure is a security and a mercy*, since whoever attains the station of divine pleasure (*al-riḍā*), having done what pleases his Lord, will be safe and mercy will be showered upon him (I). The *security* (*‘amān’*) being referred to here is safety from His wrath and punishment (Z). Subsequently, Imām ‘Alī says that Allāh *judges with knowledge and forgives with clemency*. Since He is omniscient and knows everything, including what is hidden from others, His judgment is based purely on the truth and is always perfectly correct (T). Furthermore, it is the best judgment and decree possible, with nothing that could ever be better (Z). The fact that He forgives out of clemency means that He is not obliged to forgive, due to weakness or inability, the way some people ‘forgive’ those who are stronger than themselves. Rather, despite being able to punish, He forgives (I).

2 Now the Imām begins praising Allāh, *for what You take and You give*, because both His giving and taking are based on wisdom and what is best for the creatures (T). And the same goes for what He cures and what He afflicts of maladies and pains – it is all for the good of the creatures, though they may not understand. This

has also been discussed in the commentary of the opening lines of sermon no. 132. Since we know that Allāh needs nothing, He would not gain anything by inflicting hardship on any creature. Hence, any difficulty that befalls an individual can only be for reasons that benefit him or the creation as a whole. That is why He ought to be praised and shown gratitude for it (MB). One narration states that the Almighty revealed to Mūsā (‘a), “I have not created any creature more beloved to me than My believing servant. I only afflict him with what is good for him, and cure him with what is good for him. I turn away from him what is harmful for him and replace it with what is better for him. I know best what is in the interests of My servant. So let him be patient in My trials, grateful for My blessings, and pleased with My decree. I then will record him among the veracious ones near Me” (T). Subsequently, the Imām mentions six qualities of praise, in order to describe the type of praise he means. Firstly, it is a praise that is most pleasing to Allāh, meaning it is offered the way He wishes to be praised, and is thus more perfect than any other form of praise (MB). The next qualities further emphasize the first, since it is the praise *most pleasing* (‘arḍā’) to the Almighty which is *most liked* (‘aḥabba’) by Him, and the *best praise* (‘afḍala’) in His sight. To highlight the extensiveness of this praise, Imām ‘Alī notes the three other characteristics thereof, namely that it is *a praise which fills all that You have created and extends up to where You wish; a praise which is not veiled from You and does not fail to reach You; and a praise whose count never stops and whose continuity never ceases*. It is thus a most comprehensive praise, without limitation in terms of time, place, or number (N). It is not pretentious praise, because in order for praise to reach the Almighty and not be veiled from Him, it must be sincere (I). Furthermore, since spoken praise comes to an end once the sound gets silenced, or the breath of the speaker ends, the praise *whose count never stops and whose continuity never ceases* can only mean praise through virtuous actions, because it is only the consequence of such righteous deeds that remain perpetual (Z).

3 The Imām then speaks about the attributes of Allāh, beginning with the recognition of the inability of servants to know the reality of His greatness. This is echoed by the beautiful statement of Imām al-Sajjād in *al-Ṣaḥīfah al-Sajjādiyyah*, that were the inhabitants of the heavens and the earth to come together in order to describe the greatness of Allāh, they would still not be able to do so (T). This is clear, because the Almighty is infinite in greatness, and as finite beings we do not have the capacity to understand the Infinite (N). What we do know, the Imām says,

3 We do not know the essence of Your greatness, except that we know You are Ever-living, All-sustaining, and neither drowsiness befalls You nor sleep. Vision does not extend to You and sight does not apprehend You. You apprehend the sights, reckon the deeds, and seize by the forelocks and the feet. What [little] is that which we see of Your creation, wonder about of Your might, and describe of Your great authority, yet what is hidden from us of it – and what our sight cannot perceive and our intelligence is unable to fathom, with the veils of the unseen having come between us and it – is far greater!

4 So he who empties his heart and engages his mind in order to know how You established Your Throne, how You created Your creation, how You suspended Your skies in the air, and how You spread Your earth upon the waves of water, his gaze comes back weary, his intelligence is baffled, his ears are confused and his mind is bewildered.

٣ فَلَسْنَا نَعْلَمُ كُنْهَ عَظَمَتِكَ إِلَّا أَنَّا نَعْلَمُ
أَنَّكَ حَيٌّ قَيُّومٌ، لَا تَأْخُذُكَ سِنَّةٌ وَلَا
نَوْمٌ، لَمْ يَنْتَهِ إِلَيْكَ نَظَرٌ وَلَمْ يُدْرِكْكَ
بَصَرٌ، أَدْرَكَتِ الْأَبْصَارُ، وَأَخْصَيْتِ
الْأَعْمَالُ، وَأَخَذْتَ بِالتَّوَاصِي
وَالْأَقْدَامِ؛ وَمَا الَّذِي نَرَى مِنْ
خَلْقِكَ، وَنَعْجِبُ لَهُ مِنْ قُدْرَتِكَ،
وَنَتَّصِفُهُ مِنْ عَظِيمِ سُلْطَانِكَ، وَمَا
تَعَيَّبَ عَنَّا مِنْهُ - وَقَصَّرَتْ أَبْصَارُنَا
عَنْهُ، وَانْتَهَتْ عُقُولُنَا دُونَهُ، وَحَالَتِ
سُورُ الْغُيُوبِ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَهُ - أَعْظَمُ!

٤ فَمَنْ فَرَّغَ قَلْبَهُ وَأَعْمَلَ فِكْرَهُ، لِيَعْلَمَ
كَيْفَ أَقَمْتَ عَرْشَكَ، وَكَيْفَ
ذَرَأْتَ خَلْقَكَ، وَكَيْفَ عَلَّقْتَ فِي
الْهَوَاءِ سَمَآوَاتِكَ، وَكَيْفَ مَدَدْتَ
عَلَى مَوْرِ الْمَاءِ أَرْضَكَ، رَجَعَ طَرْفُهُ
حَسِيرًا، وَعَقْلُهُ مَبْهُورًا، وَسَمْعُهُ
وَالِهًا، وَفِكْرُهُ حَائِرًا.

is that He is Ever-living, All-sustaining, and neither drowsiness befalls Him nor sleep. This is evident since He is the source of all life, so He must be Ever-living ('*al-Hayy*'), and He sustains all of existence, as the only Necessarily Existent being, therefore He must be All-sustaining ('*al-Qayyūm*'). And since everything is entirely dependent on Him, and He needs nothing, He neither becomes drowsy nor does He sleep (Z). The Qur'an also states this explicitly: *Allāh, there is no god but Him, the Ever-living, the All-sustaining. Neither drowsiness befalls Him nor sleep...*

(Q2:255) (T). By saying *vision does not extend to You and sight does not apprehend You*, Imām ‘Alī meant that Allāh cannot be seen by human beings, since seeing Him would mean facing Him, and Allāh is beyond being in any single direction (I). Further details about this have been discussed in sermon no. 49. Though creatures cannot see Him, He apprehends all sights, reckons all deeds, and seizes *by the forelocks and the feet*. In some manuscripts, the phrase ‘*aḥṣayta al-ālmāl*’ reads ‘*aḥṣayta al-ālmār*’, in which case the translation would be *You reckon the lifespans* (T). The connotation of His seizing the creatures *by the forelocks and the feet* is complete control and power over His creation. Everything is subservient to Him, and He subdues all by His limitless power. Based on what is stated in the Glorious Qur’ān, some say that this may be specifically with respect to the wrongdoers and sinners on the Day of Judgment: *The guilty shall be recognized by their mark, and they shall be seized by the forelocks and the feet* (Q55:41) (MB). However, others opine that the verse that best reflects the meaning of what the Imām is saying here is: *There is no moving creature but that He holds it by its forelock* (Q11:56) (T).

Subsequently, he expresses the reality regarding the greatness of creation, noting how what we see of His creation is very little, as is our wonder of His might, and our description of His great power and authority. He poses a rhetorical question to highlight the fact that our perception and knowledge of the greatness of our Creator and His creation is paltry at best. Despite the advancements in science and technology, which have opened the doors to different worlds that were previously unknown, like outer space or tiny microscopic habitats, what we do not know about creation still outweighs what we do know. Hence, our knowledge is very limited, and so is what we marvel at or describe of the Almighty’s greatness (N). Indeed, what is hidden from us of this creation, *and what our sight cannot perceive and our intelligence is unable to fathom, with the veils of the unseen having come between us and it*, is far greater than can be imagined.

4 Amīr al-Mu’minīn then notes how any attempt at encompassing certain realities would be futile for human beings. He says that anyone who *empties his heart and engages his mind* in order to comprehend how Allāh established His Throne, created His creation, suspended the skies in the air, and spread the earth upon the water, will be unable to do so. Instead, his gaze will return weary, his intelligence baffled, his ears confused, and his mind bewildered. Indeed, to ponder these realities, and any such important questions regarding the nature of existence, the purpose of life, and the grandeur of creation, one’s heart must not

be preoccupied by mundane things. Likewise, the mind must be free to engage in contemplation without distraction. Yet even when a person applies his mind with full focus, there are some things that remain out of reach. And if this is the case with some aspects of His creation, then how can one ever hope to attain a complete, encompassing understanding of the Creator? (MB). While the mind is capable of deduction and inference, there are certain things which it cannot fathom. One such thing is the primary cause of all events, not just the perceivable secondary causes. Scholars and thinkers have discussed this at length, yet most of what they posit are merely assumptions and hypotheses (Z). Some commentators suggest that the Divine Throne (*‘arsh*) mentioned here is an allusion to the whole metaphysical realm (N). Only by turning to what the Qur’ān tells us and what the Infallibles have taught can we get a glimpse of those realities that our minds and hearts cannot directly reach.

5 In this section, the Imām begins explaining the meaning of hope in Allāh. His statement: *He claims, based on this own assertion, that he has hope in Allāh. By the Great Lord, he has lied!* shows that simply making the claim that one has hope in the Almighty does not make it so. The pronoun ‘*he*’ here generally refers to anyone who makes such an assertion without fulfilling its conditions as mentioned later (R). The reason for his swearing by *the Great Lord* (*‘al-‘Aẓīm*) is because in this instance, since the discussion is about hope in the Almighty, the mention of Allāh’s greatness is apt (M). In one manuscript, however, the phrase *by Allāh* appears instead of *by the Great Lord*. The term *‘za‘mihi*’ refers to a verbal claim made by someone (I). The reason why this claim is deemed false by the Imām is explained when he says *how is it that his hope does not clearly manifest itself in his actions? The hope of anyone who is hopeful is evident in his actions.* Therefore, when one’s deeds do not match what he claims to hope for, then those hopes are not true. It is narrated that Imām al-Ṣādiq was once told, “There is a group of your partisans who engage in sins saying: we hope [for forgiveness].” So he said, “They lie. They are not out partisans. Rather, they are a group who have been deceived by false hopes. One who [truly] hopes for something works for it, and one who fears something flees from it” (T). Hence, one who only asserts that the hopes for divine reward and forgiveness yet does not demonstrate this by his actions is only lying (I).

HOW HOPE WORKS

5 He claims, based on this own assertion, that he has hope in Allāh. By the Great Lord, he has lied! How is it that his hope does not clearly manifest itself in his actions? The hope of anyone who is hopeful is evident in his actions. Every hope, other than hope in Allāh, is indeed pretentious, and every fear that is felt, other than the fear of Allāh, is unreal. He hopes for big things from Allāh and for small things, he puts his hope in the servants [of Allāh]; yet what he gives to the servant, he does not give to the Lord! How is it that Allāh, exalted be His praise, is accorded less consideration than what is done for His servants?

6 Are you afraid of being dishonest about your hope in Him? Or do you not regard Him as one upon whom hope may be placed? Also, if he fears one among His servants, he gives him [such consideration] out of his fear that he does not give his Lord. Hence, he has made his fear of the servants ready currency while his fear of his Creator is mere deferment or promise. And this is also the case with one in whose eyes this world is great and in whose heart it holds a big position. He prefers it over Allāh, so he devotes himself to it and becomes its slave.

منها: كيف يكون الرجاء

٥ يَدَّعِي بِرْغَمِهِ أَنَّهُ يَرْجُو اللَّهَ، كَذَبَ وَالْعَظِيم! مَا بَالُهُ لَا يَتَّبِعُ رَجَاؤُهُ فِي عَمَلِهِ؟ فَكُلُّ مَنْ رَجَا عُرِفَ رَجَاؤُهُ فِي عَمَلِهِ، وَكُلُّ رَجَاءٍ - إِلَّا رَجَاءَ اللَّهِ - فَإِنَّهُ مَذْحُولٌ، وَكُلُّ خَوْفٍ مُحَقَّقٌ، إِلَّا خَوْفَ اللَّهِ فَإِنَّهُ مَعْلُولٌ، يَرْجُو اللَّهَ فِي الْكَبِيرِ، وَيَرْجُو الْعِبَادَ فِي الصَّغِيرِ، فَيُعْطِي الْعَبْدَ مَا لَا يُعْطِي الرَّبَّ! فَمَا بَالُ اللَّهِ جَلَّ ثَنَاؤُهُ يُقْصَرُ بِهِ عَمَّا يُصْنَعُ بِهِ لِعِبَادِهِ؟

٦ أَتَخَافُ أَنْ تَكُونَ فِي رَجَائِكَ لَهُ كَاذِبًا؟ أَوْ تَكُونَ لَا تَرَاهُ لِلرَّجَاءِ مَوْضِعًا؟ وَكَذَلِكَ إِنْ هُوَ خَافَ عَبْدًا مِنْ عَيْدِهِ، أَعْطَاهُ مِنْ خَوْفِهِ مَا لَا يُعْطِي رَبَّهُ، فَجَعَلَ خَوْفَهُ مِنَ الْعِبَادِ نَقْدًا، وَخَوْفَهُ مِنْ خَالِقِهِ ضَمَارًا وَوَعْدًا، وَكَذَلِكَ مَنْ عَظُمَتِ الدُّنْيَا فِي عَيْنِهِ، وَكَبُرَ مَوْقِعُهَا مِنْ قَلْبِهِ، آثَرَهَا عَلَى اللَّهِ، فَانْقَطَعَ إِلَيْهَا وَصَارَ عَبْدًا لَهَا.

Every hope, other than hope in Allāh, is indeed pretentious and flawed. The term ‘*madkhūl*’ connotes fault and corruption (N), so such a hope cannot be deemed sincere or true. *And every fear that is felt, other than the fear of Allāh, is unreal* since whatever else one fears is something evanescent and will perish and pass, and any harm it may do would only be possible by the permission of Allāh. On the other hand, fearing Allāh is the only real fear, since it entails being afraid of the Omnipotent, All-encompassing Lord, whose decree is final and cannot be escaped, and His punishment is painful and perpetual (MB). Turning back to the one who falsely claims that he hopes in Allāh, the Imām says that such an individual *hopes for big things from Allāh and for small things, he puts his hope in the servants*. He hopes that Allāh will grant him Paradise, whereas from the people, he hopes for mundane things like assistance in some worldly matters, or material help. Despite this, *what he gives to the servant, he does not give to the Lord*, meaning that the effort he makes in acquiring what he hopes for from the people, and the work he puts into it, is much more than what he does for that which he hopes from Allāh (Z). The mention of ‘giving’ to his Lord is only meant figuratively, and it connotes lack of seriousness in terms of worship and obedience, which would make him deserving of what he hopes for from his Lord (MB). The Imām then asks rhetorically *how is it that Allāh, exalted be His praise, is accorded less consideration than what is done for His servants?* By this, he was asking how they could be so careless about the right of Allāh, and fall short in showing gratitude for His blessings and favours (Z).

6 Continuing his discussion on hope, the Imām poses some more rhetorical questions. *Are you afraid of being dishonest about your hope in Him? Or do you not regard Him as one upon whom hope may be placed?* This means that by falling short in carrying out what is required as a condition for hope, one shows that he is afraid of one of two things, both of which are wrong (MB). The first fear, about being dishonest in one’s hope, signifies thinking that a person like oneself cannot have hope in Allāh, due to his lowly, sinful nature. Of course, this is a grave error, because Allāh’s mercy encompasses all things, and one should never lose hope in His mercy (Z). The second fear is also entirely baseless, for it is only in Allāh that one can truly place his hope. It is reported that Allāh once told Prophet Mūsā, “As long as you do not see My kingdom diminish, do not place your hope in anyone other than Me” (T). Given the different meanings of the verb *kadhaba*, the phrase ‘*atakhāfu an takūna fī rajā’ika lahu kādhibā*’ may also be translated *are you afraid*

of being disappointed by your hope in Him? yet this does not change the overall meaning as discussed above. The Imām then says that as with his hope, an individual may give greater consideration to his fear of other people than he does to his fear of Allāh. As a result of this, he makes *his fear of the servants ready currency while his fear of his Creator is mere deferment or promise*. When applied to loans, the terms ‘*ḍimāran*’ and ‘*wa’dan*’ refer to that whose repayment one has no hope for, and that which one is not sure will be repaid, respectively (T). The second term was used by a bedouin who had asked Ibn al-Zubayr for money in order that he participate in battle against the Syrians, to which the latter said, “Fight; then if I get the victor’s booty, I will give you some of it.” To this, the nomad quipped, “I see you want my soul as ready cash, but wish to pay for it with unsure credit (*wa’dan*)!” (T).

The Imām’s statement here means that such a person acts upon his fear of the people, taking the necessary precautions and safeguards with due diligence, but when it comes to fearing Allāh, he is lax in doing so (MB). It is quite evident that most people fear what is present more than what will come in the future, even if they are sure about it (Z), and this attitude is actually due to their weak understanding and short-sightedness (N). In the end of this section, Imām ‘Alī explains another reason why such people give priority to the present life and more consideration to material causes. He says it is because in their eyes this world is great, and in their heart it holds great value. They thus devote themselves to it and become its slave. Regarding such people, the Qur’ān states: *Then as for the one who rebelled, and preferred the life of this world, then verily hellfire is the abode [for him]* (Q79:37-39) (T). That is the consequence of loving this world and considering it as something of great significance. Whoever thinks in this way will indubitably choose the world over obedience to his Lord, but whoever considers obedience to his Creator to be more important will prefer that over this world. These two approaches and attitudes are contraries and cannot co-exist (Z).

7 The Imām then speaks about the Prophets of Allāh. He begins by mentioning the greatest of all Messengers, the Noble Prophet Muḥammad (ṣ), saying that in him they have a *sufficient exemplar*. Some have sought to draw a link between this section and the previous one by saying that the Prophet was a great example for the believers, since he turned away from this temporary, material world and its pleasures, and preferred the Hereafter (MB). Indeed, the Noble Messenger has taught the people about the *reprehensible nature of this world and*

THE MESSENGER OF ALLĀH

- 7 In the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ) there is certainly a sufficient exemplar for you and a guidance for you about the reprehensible nature of this world and its flaws, its numerous ignominies and evils, since its sides were constrained for him, while its peripheries were easily accessible to others. He was thus weaned off its suckling and turned away from its adornments.

MŪSĀ

- 8 If you want, I will give you a second example of Mūsā, the Interlocutor of Allāh (ع), when he said: *My Lord, I am indeed in need of whatever good You may send down to me.* By Allāh, he did not ask Him for anything but bread to eat, because he had been eating only the herbs of the earth, and the green colour of the herbs could be seen from the delicate skin of his belly due to his emaciation and the attenuation of his flesh.

رَسُولُ اللَّهِ

وَلَقَدْ كَانَ فِي رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ كَافٍ لَكَ فِي الْأُسْوَةِ، وَدَلِيلٌ لَكَ عَلَى ذَمِّ الدُّنْيَا وَعَيْبِهَا، وَكَثْرَةِ مَحَازِيهَا وَمَسَاوِيهَا، إِذْ قُبِضَتْ عَنْهُ أَطْرَافُهَا، وَوُطِّئَتْ لِعَيْبِهِ أَكْنَافُهَا، وَقُطِّمَ عَنْ رَضَاعِهَا، وَزُوِيَ عَنْ رَحَافَتِهَا.

مُوسَى

وَإِنْ شِئْتَ تَنَبَّئْتُ بِمُوسَى كَلِيمِ اللَّهِ ﷺ، حَيْثُ يَقُولُ: «رَبِّ إِنِّي لِمَا أَنْزَلْتَ إِلَيَّ مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَقِيرٌ»، وَاللَّهُ مَا سَأَلَهُ إِلَّا جُزْأً يَأْكُلُهُ، لِأَنَّهُ كَانَ يَأْكُلُ بِقَلَّةٍ الْأَرْضِ، وَلَقَدْ كَانَتْ خُضْرَةُ الْبَقْلِ تُرَى مِنْ شَفِيفِ صِفَاقِ بَطْنِهِ، لِهَزَالِهِ وَتَسَدُّبِ لَحْمِهِ.

its flaws, as well as its numerous ignominies and evils. The Imām refers to the Noble Messenger as both an exemplar ('*uswah*') and a guide ('*dalīl*') since the first term means we should emulate him and the second signifies that he actively calls us to follow him (N). The term '*dalīl*' also means proof, and some commentators thus understand the statement to mean that the way in which this world was *constrained for him, while its peripheries were easily accessible to others* is proof of its baseness and ignominy. If this world was truly something worthy and good, the Almighty would bestow it first and foremost to his most noble Prophet, and the

one most beloved to Him (MB). The adjective ‘*makhzāt*’ is plural of *makhzāt* (I), or *mukhziyah*, and means evil and ugly traits (T). The world withheld its wealth from him because he was unwilling to accept it (M); rather, it was the Prophet who held his hand back from this world and refused to take from it, as he knew its true nature (Z). The Messenger *was thus weaned off its suckling and turned away from its adornments*, which is a metaphoric representation of how he turned aside from this world and rejected its material wealth and allure (M). This was despite the fact that he had control over much of the wealth that was acquired as war booty. Yet he still chose to live a simple life and famously declared, “My poverty [and simplicity] is my pride” (N).

8 To give a second example of the simple lives led by the Prophets of Allāh, Imām ‘Alī mentions Mūsā (‘a), *the Interlocutor of Allāh* (‘*kalīmullāh*’). This world also held off from him and he was a man of modest means, despite being one who conversed with the Almighty. According to one report, Allāh communicated with Prophet Mūsā, with [a total of] fourteen thousand words, the sweetness of which was so great that he did not eat or drink for three days (T). The Imām then quotes the verse of the Qur’ān which recounts what Mūsā (‘a) had said upon reaching Madyan, after traversing the harsh desert: “*My Lord, I am indeed in need of whatever good You may send down to me*” (Q28:24). By this supplication, Mūsā was asking Allāh for nothing more than a piece of bread to eat, says the Imām, because he had been eating only the herbs and wild plants of the earth. As a result, he was so thin, and his flesh so pared, that the green colour of the herbs could be seen through the delicate skin of his belly *due to his emaciation and the attenuation of his flesh*. According to the traditions, bread is considered a blessed food (T). The term ‘*shafīf*’ is from *shaffa*, meaning thin and delicate to the extent that what is behind it is visible. ‘*Ṣifāq*’ refers to the inner layer of the belly’s skin beneath the outer layer upon which hair grows, and the phrase ‘*tashadhdhubi laḥmihi*’ means that his flesh was in a dispersed or shrunken state, which connotes emaciation and loss of body weight due to excessive hunger. A number of traditions also explain that his intention behind the supplication was seeking food to eat. That is because when he left the Egyptian capital, Mūsā (‘a) did so out of fear and had thus made no preparation of provisions for the journey. He travelled a distance of three days, and some say eight days. He was reportedly barefooted, and his feet were full of blisters by the time he arrived in Madyan (MB). The lesson to be learned here is that this world is to be sought only to the extent that fulfils one’s need. Whether it be food,

DĀWŪD

- 9 If you want, I will give you a third example of Dāwūd (‘a), the possessor of the Psalms and the reciter among the people of Paradise. He used to make baskets out of date-palm leaves with his own hands and would say to his companions, “Which of you will help me to sell this?” And he would then eat barley bread [with what he earned] from its price.

‘ĪSĀ

- 10 If you want, I will tell you about ‘Īsā son of Maryam (‘a). He would use a stone for his pillow and wear coarse clothes. His condiment was hunger, his lamp in the night was the moon, and his shelter during the winter was the east of the earth, and the west. His fruits and flowers consisted of what grows on the earth for livestock. He had neither a wife to allure him, nor a son to give him grief, nor wealth to distract him, nor greed to disgrace him. His two feet were his conveyance and his two hands his servant!

داود

٩ وَإِنْ شِئْتَ ثَلَاثُ بَدَاوُدَ عَلَيْهِ
صَاحِبِ الْمَزَامِيرِ، وَقَارِيِ أَهْلِ
الْجَنَّةِ، فَلَقَدْ كَانَ يَعْمَلُ سَفَائِفَ
الْخُوصِ بِيَدِهِ، وَيَقُولُ لِجَلَسَائِهِ:
أَيُّكُمْ يَكْفِينِي بَيْعَهَا؟ وَيَأْكُلُ قُرْصَ
الشَّعِيرِ مِنْ ثَمَنِهَا.

عيسى

١٠ وَإِنْ شِئْتَ قُلْتُ فِي عِيسَى ابْنِ مَرْيَمَ
عَلَيْهِ، فَلَقَدْ كَانَ يَتَوَسَّدُ الْحَجَرَ،
وَيَلْبَسُ الْحَشِينَ، وَكَانَ إِدَامُهُ
الْجُوعُ، وَسِرَاجُهُ بِاللَّيْلِ الْقَمَرُ،
وِظِلَالُهُ فِي الشِّتَاءِ مَشَارِقُ الْأَرْضِ
وَمَغَارِبُهَا، وَفَاكِهَتُهُ وَرَيْحَانَتُهُ مَا
تُنْبِتُ الْأَرْضُ لِلْبَهَائِمِ، وَلَمْ تَكُنْ لَهُ
زَوْجَةٌ تَفْتِنُهُ، وَلَا وَلَدٌ يَحْزِنُهُ، وَلَا
مَالٌ يُلْفِتُهُ، وَلَا طَمَعٌ يُذِلُّهُ؛ دَابَّتُهُ
رِجْلَاهُ، وَخَادِمُهُ يَدَاهُ!

clothing, shelter, or anything else. It is not meant to be sought in order to amass more wealth, or to boast therewith, or to gain influence over others (Z). Though he was in a dire condition at that moment, Mūsā (‘a) only asked Allāh for what would suffice to alleviate his hunger and need, and that is a sign of his abstemiousness and detachment from this world (N).

9 The Imām then offers a third example as proof of the deficiency of this material world. This time, he mentions the practice of Prophet Dāwūd, whom he calls *possessor of the Psalms and the reciter among the people of Paradise*. The literal meaning of ‘*al-mazāmīr*’, which is the plural of *al-mizmār*, is reed pipes or flutes, and it is said that he was referred to as ‘*ṣāhib al-mazāmīr*’ because his voice was so beautiful that it was as though he had flutes in his throat (T). His recitation was so melodious and captivating that even the birds would be attracted thereby, and upon hearing it wild animals would come towards him calmly such that people would be unafraid of them (I). In one tradition from Imām al-Ṣādiq, he says that whenever Prophet Dāwūd recited the Zabūr, all the mountains, rocks, birds, and wild beast were attracted towards him due to his enchantingly beautiful voice. Perhaps it is due to his euphonious voice that he will be the reciter for the people of Paradise (MB). Then, to highlight his detachment from this world and renunciation of its wealth and pleasures, the Imām says that he used to *make baskets out of date palm leaves* by his own two hands, and would then ask his companions, “Who among you will sell these for me?” Furthermore, his meals consisted of barley bread which he purchased with what he earned from selling his baskets. Such was the simple, abstemious life of Dāwūd (‘a). There is some discussion among commentators regarding whether this was his condition before he received the kingdom or after it. Indeed, he was bestowed with a great kingdom (Q38:20). Because he was also reported to have earned by making coats of mail, as Allāh had made iron soft for him (Q34:10), some have surmised that his basket weaving was during an earlier period in his life (MB). If, however, it has been during his reign, his having asked his companions to help sell his baskets may perhaps be an indication that it is improper for one who occupies the seat of judge over the people to engage in trade with them directly, since they may recognize him and try to pay more in order to curry favour with him. Whatever the case, this passage shows Dāwūd’s austerity; and traditions also tell us that even during his rule, he never used any wealth from the public treasury for himself (N).

10 As yet another example, Imām ‘Alī tells the people about Prophet ʿĪsā. He says that ʿĪsā son of Maryam (‘a) was such an ascetic that he *would use a stone for his pillow and wear coarse clothes*. In some manuscripts, the phrase ‘*wa yaʿkul al-jashib*’, meaning *and [he would] eat insipid food*, is also found (T). The Imām further says that *his condiment was hunger, his lamp in the night was the moon, and his shelter during the winter was the east of the earth, and the west*. Generally,

condiments make food more palatable, especially if one is eating something dry or bland. In the case of Prophet ʿĪsā, his condiment was hunger since when one is extremely hungry, he enjoys eating even the most dry and tasteless of foods, as long as it satiates his hunger. In that way, it takes the place of condiments. Alternatively, the Imām meant that ʿĪsā (ʿa) used to take pleasure in hunger just as condiments make food more tasty and pleasurable to eat (MB). As for his shelter in the winter being the east and west, it means that in the mornings he would benefit from the rays of the sun in the west, and in the evenings, he would benefit from the rays in the east, to keep him warm from the cold (N). This was the level of his asceticism, despite the fact that during his era people were steeped in materialism and love for this world. In this way he acted as a role model for the people of his time and all times (Z). Amīr al-Muʾminīn then says that *his fruits and flowers consisted of what grows on the earth for livestock*. Fruits and flowers here represent all that is pleasurable to eat or smell from what grows on the earth, yet for him, what the livestock fed on, like grass and shrubs, sufficed for these pleasures (MB). Moreover, *he had neither a wife to allure him, nor a son to give him grief, nor wealth to distract him, nor greed to disgrace him*. He had no spouse to attract his attention, and had no offspring who could cause him grief by falling ill or getting distressed (T). He likewise had no wealth to occupy him thereby distracting him from the remembrance of Allāh, and his lack of greed saved him from abasement and disgrace (MB). Finally, the Imām says that Prophet ʿĪsā's form of transport were his two feet, and his only servants were his two hands. Though we know from historical reports that ʿĪsā (ʿa) did indeed eat meat and ride a donkey, the Imām's description of him here means that in most instances, this was his state (I). It shows how detached Prophet ʿĪsā was from the material comforts of this world (N).

11 Amīr al-Muʾminīn now returns to the subject of his beloved, the Messenger of Allāh. On many occasions the Imām spoke about the Prophet and fondly remembered him. He reminded the people of how the Messenger had saved humanity and brought to them the divine message of guidance. Now, the Imām gives them details of the daily life of the Noble Prophet and how he would interact with the world around him (Z). The terms '*al-ʾaṭyab*' and '*al-ʾaṭhar*' are elatives, and denote his superior goodness and purity compared to all others. In some manuscripts these two terms have been transposed, with the latter coming before the former (T). The Imām then tells the people that they should adhere to his

THE GREATEST PROPHET

11 So follow the example of your Prophet, the good, the pure, may Allāh bless him and his progeny. Verily, in him is an exemplar for one to emulate and an attribution for one who wishes to be ascribed to him. The most beloved servant to Allāh is he who emulates His Prophet and treads in his footsteps. He took the least from this world and did not even glance at it [with interest]. Of all the people of the world, he was the most slender and the most empty of stomach. The world was offered to him but he refused to accept it. When he knew that Allāh hated a thing, he too hated it; that Allāh held a thing as abject, he too considered it abject; that Allāh took a thing to be trivial, he too regarded it as trivial. If there was nothing in us but love for what Allāh and His Prophet hate and esteem for what Allāh deems insignificant, that would be enough of a defiance of Allāh and a transgression against the command of Allāh.

12 He (s) used to eat on the ground and sat like a slave. He mended his shoes with his own hands and patched his clothes himself. He rode on an unsaddled donkey and allowed another to ride with him. There was a curtain on his door and when he saw the pictures on it he said to one of his wives, "O so-and-so! Take it out of my sight because

الرسول الأعظم

١١ فَتَأَسَّ بِنَبِيِّكَ الْأَطْيَبِ الْأَطْهَرِ
 ﷺ فَإِنَّ فِيهِ أُسْوَةً لِمَنْ تَأَسَّى،
 وَعَرَاءٌ لِمَنْ تَعَرَّى؛ وَأَحَبُّ
 الْعِبَادِ إِلَى اللَّهِ الْمُتَأَسِّي بِنَبِيِّهِ
 وَالْمُقْتَصُّ لِأَثَرِهِ؛ قَضَمَ الدُّنْيَا
 قَضْمًا، وَلَمْ يَعْزَهَا طَرْفًا، أَهْضَمَ
 أَهْلَ الدُّنْيَا كَشْحًا، وَأَخْمَضَهُمْ
 مِنَ الدُّنْيَا بَطْنًا، عُرِضَتْ عَلَيْهِ
 الدُّنْيَا فَأَبَى أَنْ يَقْبَلَهَا، وَعَلِمَ أَنَّ
 اللَّهَ أَبْغَضَ شَيْئًا فَأَبْغَضَهُ، وَحَقَّرَ
 شَيْئًا فَحَقَّرَهُ، وَصَغَّرَ شَيْئًا
 فَصَغَّرَهُ. وَلَوْ لَمْ يَكُنْ فِينَا إِلَّا
 حُبُّ مَا أَبْغَضَ اللَّهُ وَرَسُولُهُ،
 وَتَعْظِيمُ مَا صَغَّرَ اللَّهُ، لَكَفَى بِهِ
 شِقَاقًا لِلَّهِ، وَمُحَادَّةً عَنْ أَمْرِ اللَّهِ.

١٢ وَلَقَدْ كَانَ ﷺ يَأْكُلُ عَلَى
 الْأَرْضِ، وَيَجْلِسُ جَلْسَةَ الْعَبْدِ،
 وَيَخْصِفُ بِيَدِهِ نَعْلَهُ، وَيَرْقَعُ بِيَدِهِ
 ثَوْبَهُ، وَيَرْكَبُ الْحِمَارَ الْعَارِيَّ،
 وَيُزِدُّ خَلْفَهُ، وَيَكُونُ السُّتْرُ عَلَى
 بَابِ بَيْتِهِ فَتَكُونُ فِيهِ النَّصَاوِيرُ

when I look at it, I recall the world and its allurements.”

فَيَقُولُ: «يَا فَلَانَةُ - لِإِحْدَى أَزْوَاجِهِ
- غَيَّبَهُ عَنِّي فَإِنِّي إِذَا نَظَرْتُ إِلَيْهِ
ذَكَرْتُ الدُّنْيَا وَرَحَّارَهَا».

example and follow in his footsteps, for *in him is an exemplar for one to emulate and an attribution for one who wishes to be ascribed to him*. The phrase “*azāan li man ta’azzā*” means that the Prophet is the best person whom one can link himself to (T), by following his practices. To highlight the importance of this further, Imām ‘Alī says that whoever emulates the Noble Messenger is the *most beloved servant to Allāh*, meaning Allāh loves him more than all the other servants. The Qur’ān states in this regard: Say, “*If you love Allāh, then follow me; Allāh will love you and forgive you your sins. And Allāh is Oft-Forgiving, Merciful*” (Q3:31). The Imām then speaks of the abstemiousness of the Messenger of Allāh, saying that *he took the least from this world and did not even glance at it* with interest. The phrase ‘*qaḍama al-dunyā qaḍman*’ means that he only took of this world that which was enough to sustain him, and what was necessary for a simple life (I). The phrase ‘*lam yūrihā*’ literally means that he did not give it a loan, and this makes the meaning more subtle: he did not even loan it a glance (T), let alone looking at it with interest! Next, he describes the Messenger of Allāh as having been *the most slender and the most empty of stomach*. His slender stature was the result of emaciation, and his empty stomach was due to his frequent hunger. Indeed it has been reported that at times he would tie a stone to his stomach to assuage his hunger (MB). It has also been narrated that when the Prophet had lunch, he never ate dinner, and when he ate dinner, he never had lunch. He would also never eat to his fill (T). The fact that *the world was offered to him but he refused to accept it* has been mentioned in many traditions. Indeed the treasures of this world were placed at his disposal, but the Messenger of Allāh chose to keep away from it (MB).

Imām ‘Alī then sums up the approach of the Noble Prophet, saying that whenever *he knew that Allāh hated a thing, he too hated it; that Allāh held a thing as abject, he too considered it abject; that Allāh took a thing to be trivial, he too regarded it as trivial*. This means all value in his eyes was based on how something was held in the sight of Allāh. His love was only reserved for what Allāh loved, and his hatred was for that which Allāh hated. The world was insignificant in his eyes

because he knew of its insignificance in the eyes of the Almighty (N). Emulating this approach is so important that the Imām says if our only fault was to love what Allāh hates and esteem what He considers insignificant, that would be sufficient as opposition to Allāh and a challenge to His command! In some manuscripts the words '*wa rasūluhu*' come after '*mā ṣaghghara Allāh*', in which case the translation would read *what Allāh and His Prophet deem insignificant* (T).

12 Imām 'Alī then continues recounting the simplicity and humility of the Noble Prophet. He says that the Messenger of Allāh *used to eat on the ground and sat like a slave*. This means that he never sat on any carpet or table while he ate his meals (N). Some have understood the sitting of a slave to mean placing the middle of one's shanks on the ground, and then resting the thighs upon them, when one sits down (I). It is reported that a lowly woman once passed by the Prophet and saw him sitting in this manner, so she remarked, "O Muḥammad, do you sit like slaves sit?" He (ṣ) replied, "And who is more of a slave to his Lord than me?" (T). The Imām then says that the Noble Messenger used to mend *his shoes with his own hands and patched his clothes himself*. Wearing mended sandals was itself a sign of humbleness, especially when the mender was himself the wearer of the sandals. Amīr al-Mu'minīn emulated the Messenger of Allāh in this practice and would also mend his own sandals, as we have noted from what is mentioned in sermon no. 33. Likewise the patching of one's own clothes, and riding *an unsaddled donkey* are signs of great humility (MB). And allowing another person *to ride with him* only emphasizes his own humbleness further (I). The Imām then mentions how a curtain with images was once hung on the door of his home, so he asked one of his wives to remove it from his sight, as it reminded him of the world and its ornaments. This may be in reference to what has been reported in the narrations, where we are told that at one time 'Ā'ishah hung a cloth with pictures of living creatures in her room, and when he saw it, the Prophet was displeased. He said to her that it reminds him of the world and its allurements, and instructed that it be taken down immediately (N). It has been suggested that the pictures mentioned here are those of plants and trees, not of animals or other such living creatures, since the house of the Prophet was where revelation descended and angels frequented, and no angel would ever enter a house where there was an image of a living animal (MB).

13 Thus, he turned his heart away from this world and purged its recollection from his mind. He liked its allurements to remain hidden from his sight so that he would not take adornments from it, nor regard it a place of stay, nor hope to settle in it. Consequently, he removed it from his mind, distanced it from his heart and kept it hidden from his sight. Indeed, this is how one who detests a thing hates to look at it or to hear it mentioned in his presence.

١٣ فَأَعْرَضَ عَنِ الدُّنْيَا بِقَلْبِهِ، وَأَمَاتَ ذِكْرَهَا مِنْ نَفْسِهِ، وَأَحَبَّ أَنْ تَغِيبَ زِينَتُهَا عَنْ عَيْنِهِ، لِكَيْلَا يَتَّخِذَ مِنْهَا رِيَاشًا، وَلَا يَعْتَقِدَهَا قَرَارًا، وَلَا يَزُجُو فِيهَا مَقَامًا، فَأَخْرَجَهَا مِنَ النَّفْسِ، وَأَشْخَصَهَا عَنِ الْقَلْبِ، وَغَيَّبَهَا عَنِ الْبَصَرِ. وَكَذَلِكَ مَنْ أَبْغَضَ شَيْئًا أَبْغَضَ أَنْ يَنْظُرَ إِلَيْهِ، وَأَنْ يُذَكَّرَ عِنْدَهُ.

14 Certainly there was in the Messenger of Allāh (ﷺ) that which apprised you of the evils of this world and its flaws: when he remained hungry in it along with his dearest ones, and despite his nearness [to Allāh], the allurements of the world remained away from him. So let the observer observe intently: did Allāh honour Muḥammad as a result of this or disgrace him? If he says that Allāh disgraced him, he has certainly lied – by Allāh, the All-supreme, – and uttered a grave falsehood. But if he says Allāh honoured him, he should know that Allāh disgraced the others when He extended the world to them while keeping it away from the closest of all people to Him. So let the follower emulate His Prophet, tread in his footsteps, and enter through his entrance; otherwise he will not be safe from ruin. For verily Allāh made Muḥammad

١٤ وَلَقَدْ كَانَ فِي رَسُولِ اللَّهِ ﷺ مَا يَدُلُّكَ عَلَى مَسَاوِي الدُّنْيَا وَعُيُوبِهَا: إِذْ جَاعَ فِيهَا مَعَ خَاصَّتِهِ، وَزُوِيَتْ عَنْهُ زَخَارِفُهَا مَعَ عَظِيمِ زُلْفَتِهِ. فَلْيَنْظُرْ نَاطِرٌ بِعَقْلِهِ: أَكْرَمَ اللَّهُ مُحَمَّدًا بِذَلِكَ أَمْ أَهَانَهُ؟ فَإِنْ قَالَ: أَهَانَهُ، فَقَدْ كَذَبَ - وَاللَّهُ الْعَظِيمُ - بِالْإِيفِكِ الْعَظِيمِ، وَإِنْ قَالَ: أَكْرَمَهُ، فَلْيَعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ أَهَانَ غَيْرَهُ حَيْثُ بَسَطَ الدُّنْيَا لَهُ، وَزَوَّاهَا عَنْ أَقْرَبِ النَّاسِ مِنْهُ. فَتَأَسَّى مُتَأَسِّ بِنَبِيِّهِ، وَافْتَصَّ أَنْرَهُ، وَوَلَجَ مَوْلَجَهُ، وَإِلَّا فَلَا يَأْمَنُ الْهَلَكَةَ، فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ جَعَلَ مُحَمَّدًا ﷺ عِلْمًا

(§) a sign of the Hour, a bearer of the glad tidings of Paradise, and a warner of retribution.

- 15 He left this world hungry but arrived in the Hereafter completely sound. He did not lay brick upon brick [to build a house] until he passed away and responded to his Lord's summoner. So how great was Allāh's favour upon us when He blessed us with him as a precedent for us to follow and a leader to walk behind! By Allāh, I have patched this tunic of mine so many times that I feel ashamed of its tailor. Someone said to me, "Why don't you discard it?" so I said, "Leave me, for only in the morning do people commend the night journeys."

لِلسَّاعَةِ، وَمُبَشِّرًا بِالْجَنَّةِ، وَمُنْذِرًا
بِالْعُقُوبَةِ.

١٥ خَرَجَ مِنَ الدُّنْيَا حَمِيصًا، وَوَرَدَ
الْآخِرَةَ سَلِيمًا، لَمْ يَضَعْ حَجْرًا عَلَى
حَجَرٍ، حَتَّى مَضَى لِسَبِيلِهِ، وَأَجَابَ
دَاعِيَ رَبِّهِ، فَمَا أَعْظَمَ مَنَّةَ اللَّهِ عِنْدَنَا
حِينَ أَنْعَمَ عَلَيْنَا بِهِ سَلَفًا نَتَّبِعُهُ،
وَقَائِدًا نَطَأُ عَقْبَهُ! وَاللَّهِ لَقَدْ رَفَعْتُ
مِذْرَعَتِي هَذِهِ حَتَّى اسْتَحْيَيْتُ مِنْ
رَاقِعَيْهَا، وَلَقَدْ قَالَ لِي قَائِلٌ: أَلَا
تَتْبَذُهَا عَنْكَ؟ فَقُلْتُ: اغْرُبْ
عَنِّي، فَعِنْدَ الصُّبْحِ يَحْمَدُ
الْقَوْمُ الشَّرِي.

13 After noting the outward aspects of his ascetism, the Imām now mentions the Noble Messengers' true inner *zuhd*, saying that *he turned his heart away from this world and purged its recollection from his mind* (M). This alludes to the fact that two true loves cannot coexist in one human heart; whenever one becomes infatuated with this world and begins to love it, the love of Allāh is removed from his heart to make room for love of this world (N). That is why he always preferred that its allurements should *remain hidden from his sight*, so as not to take any adornments therefrom, *nor regard it a place of stay, nor hope to settle in it*. In one tradition from the Noble Messenger, he is reported to have said, "What do I have to do with this world? My example is only like that of a riding traveller who comes upon a tree [in the desert] on a hot summer's day, and stops to take a short nap under its shade before departing and leaving it behind" (T). The term '*riyāsh*' is rendered adornments, but some suggest that it specifically refers to luxurious, decorated clothes. And indeed, the Noble Prophet only wore simple clothing his entire life (MB). He never regarded this world as an abode of lengthy stay or

settlement, and always treated it as a place of transition and brief passage (Z). It is reported that once, the Prophet wore a new pair of sandals which pleased him, but he then fell in prostration saying, "I was impressed by their beauty, so I humbled myself before my Lord, fearing His displeasure with me!" Then he gave them away to the first beggar he came across (MB). Thus did he turn away from this world both outwardly and inwardly. For some people, it is possible that they have removed love for this world from their hearts, but their state in it is one of ease and comfort. But the Noble Prophet removed it both from his heart and his sight, not wanting to partake of any of its pleasures or comforts (T). He did that because he truly detested the worldly allurements, and *this is how one who detests a thing hates to look at it or to hear it mentioned in his presence*. The answer to why he loathed this world so much has already been mentioned in the commentary of section 11 of this sermon. To explain why the Prophet did not like even the mention of this world in his presence, one commentator quotes an anecdote from the time of the famous mystic Rābī'ah al-'Adawiyyah. It is said that a group of scholars and ascetics had once gathered in Rābī'ah's presence and they began criticizing the world while Rābī'ah remained silent. Once they had finished, she said, "Whoever loves a thing likes to mention it, whether by praising it or criticizing it. If indeed this world had no worth in your eyes, then why do you even mention it?" (T).

14 By the way the Messenger of Allāh interacted with this world, people can be apprised of its evils and flaws. This is further evidence that the material world is not something to hanker after, for the close friends of Allāh and His Messengers never sought its comforts (T). Indeed, the Prophet would often remain hungry along with his dearest ones ('*khāṣṣatihi*'), and despite his nearness to Allāh and the lofty station he held in His sight, *the allurements of the world remained away from him*. The Imām then proceeds to offer a rational argument, inviting the observer to observe intently and ponder over the question: *did Allāh honour Muḥammad as a result of this or disgrace him?* Meaning, by withholding this world and its comforts from His Prophet, and granting the same to others, did Allāh honour his Messenger or disgrace him? Obviously, He honoured him and disgraced those who opposed him, to such a degree that only those who follow His Prophet are saved while the rest are doomed (R). It is reported that the Noble Prophet once asked a shepherd for some milk, but he refused to give him any. Then he asked another, so he sent him all the milk he had along with a sheep which he could milk for more if he so wished. So the Prophet supplicated that the first shepherd be granted

abundant wealth and many children, and for the second shepherd, he prayed to Allāh to grant him sufficiency (*al-kafāf*). The people were surprised by this and said, “You supplicated for the one who refused you with a prayer that the majority of us would love, and you prayed for the one who fulfilled your request with a supplication that all of us would dislike?” So the Messenger of Allāh said, “Verily that which is little yet sufficient is much better than that which is abundant and distracting. O Allāh, grant Muḥammad and the family of Muḥammad sufficiency” (T). Having explained the reality of this world, and the way the Noble Prophet regarded it, Imām ‘Alī once again exhorts the people to emulate the Prophet, *tread in his footsteps, and enter through his entrance*; for if they do not do this, they *will not be safe from ruin*. That is because love of this world and vying for it is the root cause of all evil, and leads one away from the path of Paradise towards the lower levels of Hell (MB). Subsequently, the Imām again speaks of the attributes of the Beloved Messenger, saying that Allāh made him *a sign of the Hour, a bearer of the glad tidings of Paradise, and a warner of retribution*. This means that Allāh sent the Prophet to inform the people that the Hour of Judgment is surely coming, and that Paradise will be for the Godwary just as Hell will be for the wicked (Z). Some opine that by the way in which he lived in this world, the people understood that this is not a permanent abode, and in this way he was practically showing them that the world would come to an end (MB). The term “*alaman li al-sā‘ah*” has also been read as “*ilman li al-sā‘ah*” by some, in which case it metaphorically means that it was through him that people gained knowledge of the Hour (M).

15 In the final section of the sermon, Imām ‘Alī continues to describe the Noble Prophet, saying that *he left this world hungry but arrived in the Hereafter completely sound*. The term ‘*khamīṣan*’ literally means hollow of stomach (T), and the soundness with which he entered the Hereafter refers to being free from any of the evil consequences of attachment to the world or its pleasures (MB). Alternatively, it could be a reference to his sound heart, in accordance with the verse that states: *The Day when neither wealth nor children will avail, except the one who comes to Allāh with a sound heart* (Q26:88-89) (T). The Messenger of Allāh did not *lay brick upon brick* to build a house for himself until he left this world, responding to his Lord’s summoner. This is related in many authentic narrations (I). He would also discourage people from focussing on building large, extravagant homes, and it is reported that he once said, “Whoever builds more than what he needs, he will be forced to carry it [as a burden] on the Day of Resurrection” (MB).

After having described the *zuhd* of the Noble Prophet, Imām ‘Alī remarks that it was indeed a great favour of Allāh upon the believers that He blessed them with a personality like the Blessed Prophet *as a precedent for them to follow and a leader to walk behind*. Indeed, the Messenger of Allāh is the most excellent of all leaders, and the greatest of all Prophets. And what grave ingratitude it would be for us to fumble in misguidance as a result of not taking lessons from the life of the Noble Prophet (N)! In this instance, because the context pertains to asceticism and detachment from the world, the meaning of following him is emulating the Messenger in his disinclination to the world and its pleasures (MB). In closing, Amīr al-Mu’minīn gives his own example, and how he had patched his tunic so many times that he now felt ashamed of its tailor. He recounted how someone said to him, ‘*Why don’t you discard it?*’ so he replied, ‘*Leave me, for only in the morning do people praise the night travellers.*’ At times the Imām would give his tunic to someone to patch, and sometimes he would do it himself. And the fact that it had so many patches, until he was embarrassed to give it to the tailor again, shows his asceticism (N). In this way, he emulated his beloved Prophet, whose *zuhd* he had just described to the people. ‘*Midra’ah*’ was a tunic made of wool, and the imperative ‘*a’zib ‘annī*’ means distance yourself from me, or leave my presence (MB). The proverb *only in the morning do people commend the night journeys* means that those who bear difficulties and hardships with fortitude and patience will be pleased when they arrive at their destination, and are also praised by the people who commend the result of their effort (N). It comes from the fact that travelling at night is arduous, and when the night traveller who is determined pushes forward in the darkness and arrives safely in the morning, he feels a sense of achievement and is also praised for his night journey. In the same way, when a believer dies and enters the Day of Judgment, seeing how he is safe due to the efforts he undertook in the world, he feels happy with his achievement and attains a praiseworthy end (R).

